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North-Eastern Neo-Aramaic in the context of the languages of Western Asia

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Contact and Multilingualism

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12 Introduction to verbal morphology and its inflectional categories

12.1 Introduction

The languages of the area, in particular Semitic, Iranian and Armenian, share several commonalities in verbal paradigm organisation (see Matras 2009; Haig 2014; Noorlander 2014, Noorlander & Stilo 2015, Stilo & Noorlander 2015). In this chapter, we provide general information about the core TAM-based verbal stems and TAM-modifiers used in verbal inflection, which are examined in detail in subsequent chapters. As shown in (1), one of the most common structures begins with a marker of clause-level grammatical information in which the categories of tense, aspect and mood (TAM) are fused. What comes after the TAM modification is an inflectional stem, in which voice and tense are expressed together, to which are added (suffixal) person markers. For more details regarding verbal person marking, see Chapter 13.

(1) Common template of verbal morphology
Tense-Aspect-Mood + Stem + Person marking suffixes

Several languages in the area, notably Arabic and Central Kurdish varieties, allow for person coding to intervene between the stem and the preverbal TAM modifier, as shown in (2) for *Qəltu*-Arabic and in (3) for Central Kurdish. Moreover, the preverbal TAM expression can be an auxiliary that is inflected for person, depending on the language (see further §13.5), as (4) illustrates for NENA.

(2) Siirt *Qəltu*-Arabic (Jastrow 1978: 303)
d- a- qattəl -ken
FUT- 1SG:A- kill -2PL:P
'I shall kill you (PL.).'

(3) Central Kurdish
de =t bîn -im
IND =OBL.2SG:P see.PRS -1SG:A
'I see you (SG.'

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(4) C. Qaraqosh (Khan 2002a: 332)
k-iyən *k-axl-ən*
IND-COP.1SG.M:A IND-eat-1SG.M:A
'I am eating.'

12.2 TAM modifiers and inflectional stems in NENA

12.2.1 Basic ingredients of verbal conjugation

The verb in NENA dialects is commonly broken down into the following morphological structures:

1. root consisting of radical consonants, which can be strong (i.e., preserving the three radical consonants in all forms), for example *q-ṭ-l* 'to kill', *n-š-q* 'to kiss', *g-r-š* 'to pull', *d-m-x* 'to sleep', weak (i.e., having either a vowel or semi-vowel in one of the three consonantal slots in certain forms), for example *x-z-y* 'to see', *q-y-m* 'to rise', or irregular;

2. inflectional stem, the base of a lexical verb, possibly with additional morphemes, that is inflected for voice and tense-aspect by modifying the internal structure of the stem itself (see §14.1);

3. person marking suffixes expressing the person, gender and number of the subject and/or object(s), which are attached to the stem (see §13.2);

4. preverbal modifiers that express tense, aspect and/or mood, which are placed before the inflectional stem, such as the future tense marker *b-* (see §17.1);

5. a suffix *-wa*, also known as a "past convertor" (see §12.2.2), denoting anteriority ("one step back" in time Cohen 2012: 459) or past tense;

Historically, all verbal inflection in NENA, with the exception of the imperative, goes back to originally analytic verbal constructions. The inflectional bases are thus historically nonfinite verbal forms that became finite, as summarised below. A simplified overview of the verbal system in a sample of NENA dialects is given in Table 12.2.1.

(5) Inflectional stem categories and their origins
Imperative < Imperative

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'Present' (imperfective)	<	Predicative active participle
'Past' (perfective)	<	Predicative resultative participle
Resultative participle	<	Attributive resultative participle
Active participle	<	Agent nominalisation
Infinitive/Gerund/Progressive	<	Verbal noun

This basic template can be illustrated as follows:

(6) J. Dohok (cf. Molin 2024: 129)
b- yaw -ən -wa -nu -lax
FUT- give -1SG.M:A -PST -OBL.3PL.T -OBL.2SG.F:R
'I would give them to you.'

The structure begins with a TAM-marker followed by a verbal stem associated with certain lexical-semantic content, to which, in turn, person markers of a particular set are added. The anteriority affix or so-called "past convertor" particle *-wa-* can occur between the sets of person markers. A verb in NENA can incorporate up to three arguments in its conjugation.

Table 12.1: Example paradigms of 3sg.m. verbs *šql* 'to take' or *ʾxl* 'to eat' in a sample of NENA dialects

	J. Betanure (Mutzafi 2008a)	**J. Koy Sanjak** (Mutzafi 2004a)	**C. Bohtan** (Fox 2009)	**C. Sanandaj** (Panoussi 1990)
Subjunctive	*šaqəl*	*ʾaxəl*	*oxəl*	*ʾaxəl*
Present habitual	*kšaqəl*	*kxəl*	*yoxəl*	*kaxəl*
Past habitual	*kšaqəlwa*	*kxəlwa*	*yoxəlwa*	*kaxəlwa*
Future	*bšaqəl*	*kxəl*	*boxəl*	*kaxəl*
Past perfective	*šqəlle*	*xəlle*	*xəlle*	*ixəlle*
Past anterior	*šqəlwāle*	*xəlwāle*	*xilwa*	*xəlwāle*
Present perfect	*ʾile šqila*	*xile=le*	*xil*	*gi-xəlle*
Present progressive	*ʾile bəšqala*	*xāle=le*	*yoxəl*	*kaxəl=ile*
Past progressive	*ʾile bəšqala*	*kxəlwa*	*yoxəlwa*	*kaxəlwa=yawa*
Infinitive	*šqala*	*xala*	*ixola*	*ixala*
Imperative	*šqol*	*xol*	*uxəl*	*ixol*

12.2.2 TAM modifiers

In NENA, the verbal stem is modified for tense, aspect and/or mood, which. As is typical for Semitic languages, this is performed by specific root-and-pattern

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or templatic morphology, e.g., "present" stem *patəx* 'open' vs. "past" stem *ptix*. TAM inflection can also be fused with person, so that different sets of person markers are used to distinguish between particular clauses, e.g.,

(7) C. Bohtan (Fox 2009

a. *ptəx-lox-le*
openPST.PFV-OBL.2SG.M:A-OBL.3SG.M:P
'You (sg.m.) opened it.' Past perfective

b. *ptix-ət-le*
openPST.PFV-2SG.M:A-OBL.3SG.M:P
'You (sg.m.) have opened it.' Present perfect

c. *patx-ət-le*
openPRS-2SG.M:A-OBL.3SG.M:P
'You (sg.m.) open it.' Present habitual

The stem least marked for tense and aspect is the so-called "present" stem, e.g., *qaṭəl-* 'kill'. All additional TAM modifiers precede the verbal stem, except for a few modifiers based on a copula (see below). An overview of preverbal modifiers is given in Table 12.2. Often, the use of such preverbs will also result in stem allomorphy, as illustrated in 8. In the majority of NENA dialects, however, the distinction between the present subjunctive and indicative is lost, often with a few remaining relics, the initial weak verbs in particular.

(8) J. Dohok (Molin 2024: 86)

a. *∅-ʾaxəl-∅*
SBJV-eat-3SG.M:S
'he may eat' Present subjunctive

b. *k-exəl-∅*
IND-eat-3SG.M:S
'he eats' Present indicative habitual

In several dialects, the subjunctive preverb is overt and identical to the complementiser *d-* 'that', e.g.,

(9) C. Tiyari (Talay 2009: 34.11)
waḷḷa bay-ən t-az-ən l-xa ʾumṛa
by_God IND.want-1SG.M SBJV-go-1SG.M to-a church
'By God, I want to go to a church.'

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Table 12.2: Sample of modifiers and their functions with corresponding stems in NENA dialects

Modifier	Core function	Combined with
da, *də*		Imperative
∅, *d-*, *ṯ-*	Subjunctive	Present stem
k-, *g-*, *ki-*	Indicative	Present stem
ʾi-, *y-*	Indicative	Present stem
b-, *bəd-*, *b(ə)ṯ-*	Future	Present stem
šud-, *ṭri-*	Jussive	Present stem
qam-, *kəm-*, *tam-*	Past perfective	Present stem
zi-	Proximative/prospective	Present stem
PRESENT COPULA	Present progressive	Present stem
PRESENT COPULA	Present perfect	Past stem
gi-, *lā*, *hole*	Present perfect	Past stem

(10) C. Aradhin (Krotkoff 1982 112.129, transcription and glossing modified)
ʾana k-ib-ən d-az-ən l-ʾeta
1SG IND-want-1SG.M SBJV-go-1SG.M to-church
'I want to go to church.'

Preverbal TAM-modifiers typically combine with the so-called "present" stem (see §18.1), but can also combine with 'past' stem verbal forms (see Chapter 16), e.g.,

(11) C. Jinnet (Noorlander field notes)

a. *šti-li*
drinkPST-OBL.1SG
'I drank.' Past perfective

b. *holə šti-li*
PRS.PRF drinkPST-OBL.1SG
'I have drunk.' Present perfect

An exception to the tendency for preverbal TAM-modification is the so-called "past convertor" *-wa*, which is historically derived from an auxiliary **hwā*, the 3sg.m. past tense form of the copula verb *hwy* 'to be'. This past convertor is suffixed before or after the person markers, depending on the type of conjugation, and occasionally metathesis occurs, e.g.,

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(12) C. Diyana-Zarwiwa (Napiorkowska 2015: 60)

a. *ʾi-patx-ən*
IND-open-1SG.M:A
'I open.' Present habitual

b. *ʾi-patx-ən-wa*
IND-open-1SG.M:A-PST
'I used to open.' Past habitual

c. *ptəx-xi* ~ *ptəx-li*
open.PST-OBL.1SG:A
'I opened.' Preterite

d. *ptəx-wa-li* ~ *ptəx-xa-wi*
open.PST-PSTOBL.1SG:A
'I had opened.' Plupreterite

Furthermore, the affix *-wa* can still feature in the past tense forms of the copula and existential constructions across NENA dialects, in which case it retains its original value as a copula (seeStilo & Noorlander 2015 for areal parallels), e.g.,

(13) C. Jinnet (Noorlander field notes)

a. *ḥəmme=wa*
heat.M.SG=PST.COP.3
'It was hot.' lit. 'Heat was.' Past copula (3sg. and 3pl.)

b. *one=wən*
x
'I am the one / It is I.' Present copula 1sg.m.

c. *one=wən-wa*
1SG=COP.1SG-PST
'I was the one / It was I.' Past copula 1sg.m.

d. *ʾit nira*
EXIST river
'There is a river.' Present existential

e. *ʾət-wa nira*
EXIST-PST river
'There was a river.' Past existential

(14) C. Marga (Khan and Noorlander field notes)

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a. *xawr-i=le*
friend-POSS.1SG=COP.3SG.M
'He is my friend.' Present copula

b. *xawr-i=wā-le*
friend-POSS.1SG=PST-COP.3SG.M
'He was my friend.' Past copula

Various types of copula can be used as tense-aspect marking auxiliaries (see Chapters 13, 15, 19, 16). Depending on the dialect, a copula can be combined with a verbal form that already has a preverbal TAM-modifier such as indicative imperfective *k-*, as shown in (15). When these tense-aspect marking auxiliaries are mobile, they attach to the most accented constituents on the left edge of the verb phrase, as shown in (15b). Occasionally, depending on the dialect, the auxiliary can also occur at the right edge, as shown in (15c) and (15d), with predicate focus. In several Christian dialects located in the south-eastern sector, the placement of the auxiliary is generally after the finite verb form, as shown in (12.2.2).

(15) C. Qaraqosh (Khan 2002a: 332)

a. *k-iyən* *k-axl-ən* *xabušə*
IND-COP.1SG.M:A IND-eat-1SG.M:A apple.PL
'I am eating apples.'

b. *ma=yət* *k-axl-ət*
what=COP.2SG.M:A IND-eat-2SG.M:A
'What are you eating?'

c. *k-axl-ət* *xabuš=iyət?*
IND-eat-2SG.M:A apple.PL=COP.2SG.M:A
'Are you eating apples?'

d. *k-axl-ət=iyət?*
IND-eat-2SG.M:S=COP.2SG.M:S
'Are you eating?'

(16) C. Sanandaj (Panoussi 1990: 118)
qaṭl-ən=yən
kill.IND-1SG.M:A=PRS.COP.1SG.M:A
'He is killing.' Present progressive

As a general tendency, however, auxiliaries are combined with nonfinite verbal forms such as the resultative participle and the infinitive to create compound

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tenses (see Sections 13.2.5, 16.1.1, 19.1). Generally, a fossilised third person form of the copula can undergo grammaticalisation to become a preverbal tense-aspect marker (see, for instance, §16.1.2). As a result, one can find the person inflection on the (preceding) auxiliary, on the main verb, or on both, e.g.,

(17) C. Jinnet (Noorlander field notes)

a. *how-an* *bə-štoya*
DEIC.COP-1SG.F:S LOC-drink.INF
'I am drinking.' Auxiliary inflected only

b. *hol(ə)* *šaty-an*
DEIC.COP(.3SG.M) drink-1SG.F:S
'I am drinking.' Main verb inflected only

c. *how-an* *šaty-an*
DEIC.COP-1SG.F:S drink-1SG.F:S
'I am drinking.' Both inflected

12.3 TAM modifiers and inflectional stems in Iranian

12.3.1 Basic ingredients of verbal conjugation

The verb in Kurdish is commonly broken down into the following morphological structures:

1. stem: an inflectional base of a lexical verb inherently marked for either past or present tense.
2. person marking suffixes;
3. preverbal modifiers that express tense, aspect and/or mood, which are placed before the inflectional stem, such as the imperfective/indicative marker *de-*
4. a past participle suffix, e.g., the Northern Kurdish suffix *-î* added to the past stem *kuşt* 'killed' to form the past participle *kuşt-î*;
5. various forms of the copula that combine with the past stem to form the past subjunctive, past conditional, past perfect, and past perfect conditional.

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For Central Kurdish only, the following morphological components are also relevant:

- relational preverbs that attach to simplex verbs to create derived forms;
- absolute prepositions (applicative according to Karim & Salehi 2022) which attach to the verbal stem, adding an additional indexed argument.

Historically, Kurdish verbal forms have two sources: (1) the originally analytic past participle, and (2) the synthetic present-tense stem, the former being an originally non-finite form and the latter a finite verb, as summarised below.

(18) Inflectional stem categories and their origins

Present	<	Finite present tense stem
Past	<	Predicative resultative participle
Past participle	<	Innovative resultative participle
Infinitive/Gerund	<	Verbal noun

This basic template can be illustrated as follows:

(19) CK Slêmanî

lê *=m* *wer-* *ne-* *e-* *girt* *-in* *-î*

from =1SG:A away- NEG- IPFV- hold.PST -3PL.T -2SG:R

'I wouldn't have taken them from you.'

The structure begins with an absolute preposition, followed by a clitic person marking denoting the agent, a preverb, a negator, and a TAM-marker, all of which occur before the verbal stem. Other infectional person markers follow the verbal stem. A verb in Central Kurdish can incorporate up to three arguments in its conjugation, as (19) illustrates.

12.3.2 TAM modifiers

The proto-Kurdish forms had the TAM prefixes **de-* [IPFV-], **bí-* [SBJV-/IMP], and **me-* [PROH-]. To these, we can add the negative marker *ne-*, used everywhere except the prohibitive and present indicative, where *na-* is used, likely a contraction of *ne- and *de (See Chapter 18 for more on the origin of these forms). In addition, there are copula suffixes, such as *=a*, which have been recruited for various TAM categories in combination with the prefixes. An exception is Hewramî, where the majority of verbs have no overt marking of mood distinction. Here, the difference between indicative and subjunctive verb form is carried out by stress;

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the verb stem in the subjunctive mood carries stress: *kéro* 'that he/she does' vs. *kero* 'he/she does'. Phonological factors are the main trigger for the appearance of indicative and subjunctive prefixes, e.g., consonant-only stems take the mood prefixes: *mi-l-û* 'I go'; *bi-l-û* 'that I go' (Mohammadirad & Karim 2025).

Table 12.3: A sample paradigm showing Northern and Central Kurdish TAM categories

	NK	CK	
PRS.IND	***di***-*kevim*	***de***-*kewim*	'I fall'
PRS.SBJV	***bí***-*kevim*	***bí***-*kewim*	'that I fall'
IMP	***bí***-*keve*	***bí***-*kewe*	'fall'
PST	*ketim*	*kewtim*	'I fell'
PST	*min nivîsî*	*nûsî=m*	'I wrote it'
PST.HAB	***di***-*ketim*	***de***-*kewtim*	'I used to fall'
PST.HAB	*min* ***di***-*nivîsî*	***de***=*m*-*nûsî*	'I used to write it'
PRS.PRF	*ket*-***î***-*me*	*kewt*-***û***-*m*	'I have fallen'
PRS.PRF	*min nivîsî*-*ye*	*nûsî*-***w***=*im*=***e***	'I have written it'
PST.PRF	*ket*-***ibû***-*m*	*kewt*-***ibû***-*m*	'I had fallen'
PST.PRF	*min nivîsî*-***bû***	*nûsî*-***bû***=*m*	'I had written it'
PST.SBJV	*ket*-***ib***-*im*	*kewt*-***ib***-*im*	'that I have fallen'
PST.SBJV	*min nivîsî*-***b***-*e*	*nûsî*-***b***=*im*	'that I have written it'
PST.COND	***bi***-*ket*-***a***-*m*=***a***	***bi***-*kewtim*=***a***=***ye***	'had I fallen'
PST.COND	*min* ***bi***-*nivîsî*-***a***	***bi***=*m*-*nûsî*=***a***=***ye***	'had I written it'
PST.PRF.COND	***bi***-*ket*-***iba***-*m*	***bi***-*kewt*-***ibw***=***a***-*m*	'I had fallen'
PST.PRF.COND	*min* ***bi***-*nivîsî*-***ba***	***bi***=*m*-*nûsî*-***bw***=***a***	'I had written it'

12.4 TAM modifiers and inflectional stems in Armenian

12.4.1 Basic ingredients of verbal conjugation

Armenian verb forms can be divided into two basic categories: synthetic and complex (periphrastic). Synthetic verb forms can be divided into two main categories: perfective (aorist) verb forms, which are based on the Classical Armenian aorist, and imperfective verb forms, which are based on the Classical Armenian present and imperfect. The basic complex tense forms in Armenian are formed of various invariant participles expressing the lexical verb, plus the enclitic copula (auxiliary), which expresses the person and number of the subject, and, in

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most dialects (see §12.4.4 for exceptions), tense (past vs. non-past) (see Chapter 15 for the syntactic behaviour of this element). Key verb forms in SWA, SEA, and Urmia Armenian are shown in Table 12.4.1.

Table 12.4: Infinitive and 1SG forms of the regular verb 'to write' in SWA, SEA, and Urmia Armenian (present forms in brackets are habitual/narrative)

	SWA	SEA	Urmia
INFINITIVE	*gr-el*	*gr-el*	*kʲɪr-el*
AORIST	*gr-ecʿi*	*gr-ecʿi*	*kʲɪr-im*
PRESENT SUBJUNCTIVE	*gr-em*	*gr-em*	*kʲɪr-em*
PAST SUBJUNCTIVE	*gr-ēi*	*gr-ei*	*kʲɪr-em=eɾ*
PRESENT	*kə gr-em*	*gr-um=em*	*kʲɪr-es/-el=em* (*kə-kʲɪr-em*)
IMPERFECT	*kə gr-ēi*	*gr-um=ei*	*kʲɪr-es/el=em=eɾ* (*kə-kʲɪr-em eɾ*)
FUTURE	*piti gr-em*	*gr-elu=em*	*kʲɪr-ely=em / ti kʲɪr-em*
PAST FUTURE	*piti gr-ēi*	*gr-elu=ei*	*kʲɪr-ely=em eɾ / ti kʲɪr-em=eɾ*
PERFECT	*gr-er/-ac=em*	*gr-el=em*	*kʲɪr-ɪr=em*
PLUPERFECT	*gr-er/-ac=ēi*	*gr-el=ei*	*kʲɪr-ɪr=em=eɾ*

12.4.2 TAM modifiers in synthetic verb forms

12.4.2.1 Perfective synthetic forms without TAM-modifiers: the aorist

The aorist is a perfective verb form that usually, but not necessarily, has past time reference (see §16). It is inherited from Classical Armenian, and has survived in most modern dialects, including those in contact with NENA. It has been lost in the dialects of the Agulis-Meghri group, and in Suceava. The aorist is formed with the perfective stem in verbs with stem alternation, and distinctive endings expressing the person and number of the subject which differ from those of the other tenses (see Chapter 13), as seen in (20). It does not take any prefixes, nor can it be associated with the past particle (see §12.4.4).

(20) SEA
ker-a
eat.pfv-AOR.1SG
'I ate.' Aorist

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12.4.2.2 Imperfective synthetic forms with TAM-modifiers

The imperfective synthetic verb forms are based on the Classical Armenian present and imperfect indicative, which are formed of the imperfective stem in verbs with stem alternation, and endings which express the person and number of the subject, as well as expressing tense (there are different sets of endings for the present and the imperfect). The forms of the Classical Armenian present and imperfect indicative are used for the modern Armenian present (21) and imperfect subjunctive (22).

(21) SEA
ut-em
eat.ipfv-PRS.1SG
'I eat.' Present subjunctive

(22) SEA
ut-ei
eat.ipfv-IPF.1SG
'I ate.' Imperfect subjunctive

In Western Armenian, the preverbal particle *kə* (or phonetic variant) is attached to form the present (23) and imperfect (24) indicative, and the preverbal particle *piti* (or phonetic variant) is used to form the future (25) and future in the past (26).

(23) Van Armenian (based on Acharyan 1952)
k-ut-em
PTCL-eat-PRS.1SG
'I eat/am eating.'

(24) Van Armenian (based on Acharyan 1952)
k-ut-i
PTCL-eat-IPF.1SG
'I ate/was eating.'

(25) Van Armenian (based on Acharyan 1952)
(pi)ti ut-em
PTCL eat-PRS.1SG
'I will eat/be eating.'

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(26) Van Armenian (based on Acharyan 1952)
(pi)ti ut-i
PTCL eat-IPF.1SG
'I would eat/be eating.'

The particle *kə* is derived from a periphrasis *kay u* 'stand/exist and' > *ku* > *kə*. It serves as a marker of actualisation, distinguishing the (actual) present from the (irrealis) subjunctive (Vaux 1995, Donabédian 2018: 22). It did not exist in Classical Armenian, but is attested in Middle Armenian texts (12th -18th century AD). The use of progressive-indicative aspectual prefixes of this type has been suggested to be an Eastern Anatolian areal feature (Matras 2010: 75). Given these parallels, it is likely that this construction originated as a progressive, but by the time it is attested in Middle Armenian texts, it is already well established as a general present tense. Since written Classical Armenian continued to be modelled on the language of the 5th century AD, changes that took place in the spoken language were not expressed in writing until the appearance of Middle Armenian in the 12th century, so the initial appearance and the original pattern of usage of *ku* is not recorded.

Further evidence that this construction may have begun as a progressive form is the fact that in many dialects *kə* is not used with certain stative verbs, which could be considered incompatible with progressive meaning. These verbs form the corresponding tenses without the particle, as in Classical Armenian, as shown in the following examples of present tense from Karin (Erzurum) dialect given by Acharyan (1961: 83): *g^{h}id-em* 'I know', *un-im* 'I have', *ka-m* 'I exist', E-M 'I am'.

The particle *kə* is not used with negative forms. The corresponding negative uses a different periphrasis, which is used for both negative and affirmative present and imperfect in Middle Armenian texts, where it originally had progressive meaning. This was formed with the locative of the infinitive, which in Classical Armenian was formed with the preposition *i* + accusative (zero) ending, and the copula/auxiliary, as seen in examples 27, 28, 29:

(27) Middle Armenian (Abajyan et al. 2017: 243)
i xos-el ē
PRP speak-INF be.PRS.3SG
'S/he speaks/is speaking.'

(28) Middle Armenian (Abajyan et al. 2017: 243)

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en *i* *kŕu-il*
be.PRS.3PL PRP fight-INF
'They fight/are fighting.'

(29) Middle Armenian (Abajyan et al. 2017: 243)
i *gn-al* *ēr*
PRP go-INF be.PST.3SG
'S/he was going.'

The preposition *i* was already optional in Middle Armenian, and has been lost in most modern dialects. In addition, the infinitive in this periphrasis, which is now restricted to negative contexts, has undergone phonetic changes in both Eastern and Western Armenian, so that there is now a separate "negative participle" distinct from the true infinitive (SEA *xosel*, SWA *xōsil*), as seen in examples 31:

(30) SWA
čʿ-em *xōs-ir.*
NEG-be.PRS.1SG speak-N.PTCP
'I don't speak.'

(31) SEA
čʿ-em *xos-i.*
NEG-be.PRS.1SG speak-N.PTCP
'I won't/don't speak.'

The particle *piti* was originally an impersonal verb meaning 'there is need to', which had imperfect (*piter*) and aorist (*pitecʿav*) forms that were still in use in some areas in the 17th century (Acharyan 1961: 132). It was used with the infinitive in Classical Armenian, which it could either follow (32) or precede (33).

(32) Classical Armenian (Acharyan 1961: 132)
baycʿ i *teł̄i* *aysr* *inj* *darjeal g-al* *pit-i*
but PTCL place DEM1.GEN 1SG.DAT again come-INF be.need-PRS.3SG
'But there is need for me to come to this place again.'

(33) Classical Armenian (Acharyan 1961: 132)
pit-i *patu-el* *z-nosa*
be.need-PRS.3SG honour-INF ACC-DEM3.PL
'One should (lit. there is need to) honour these (people).'

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The combination of *piti* and the infinitive meaning 'there is need to' is still found in literary SEA (34), although, in SEA, *piti* is invariant and can be considered a particle rather than a verb.

(34) SEA (Acharyan 1961: 132)
piti gn-al
PTCL go-INF
'One must go.'

However, in colloquial Eastern Armenian, as in Western Armenian, *piti* is generally used with the subjunctive of the lexical verb (35).

(35) Colloquial EA
piti gən-am
PTCL go-PRS.SBJV.1SG
'I must go.'

In many Eastern dialects, including the old dialect of Yerevan, *piti* could be described as a modal auxiliary verb, expressing deontic modality. It is declined for person and tense (present and imperfect), and is used with the infinitive or a form derived from the infinitive of the lexical verb, as seen in (35). This is consistent with the general preference in Eastern Armenian for complex verb forms composed of an inflected auxiliary and an invariant participial form of the lexical verb.

Table 12.5: The modal auxiliary *piti* with the verb *siril* 'to love' in Old Yerevan Armenian (Acharyan 1961: 134)

Person	Present	Imperfect
1SG	*siril ptim*	*siril pti*
2SG	*siril ptis*	*siril ptir*
3SG	*siril pti*	*siril pter*
1PL	*siril ptinkʿ*	*siril ptinkʿ*
2PL	*siril ptikʿ*	*siril ptikʿ*
3PL	*siril ptin*	*siril ptin*

In contrast, in Western Armenian dialects, *piti* has become an invariant particle expressing future meaning, which is used with the subjunctive of the lexical verb, parallel to the particle *kə*, as we have seen seen in (25).

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However, unlike *kə*, *piti* is compatible with the negative: the lexical verb appears in the negative of the subjunctive (i.e., the subjunctive with the negative prefix *čʿ-*), as seen in (36).

(36) SWA (Sakayan 2012: 137)
piti čʿ-gr-em
FUT NEG-write-PRS.SBJV.1SG
'I won't write.'

These particles show different degrees of bondedness with the verb stem in different dialects. For example, in Mush dialect, initial voiced stops are aspirated, but in example (37) from the Mush subdialect of Tuskulu[1], we observe that, following *kə*, the root-initial /d/ is not aspirated, implying that it is not interpreted as word-initial, thus *kə-* can be classified as a prefix. In contrast, in example (38), from Erzurum dialect (Shirakamut village in Lori province, settled from Pasen in 1827), which also has aspiration of initial voiced stops, the root-initial /d/ is aspirated following *kə* (pronounced [gə] in this dialect). In addition, in Erzurum dialect this element is mobile (see Bezrukov & Dolatian 2020 for data from the Erzurum subdialects of Gyumri and Akhalkalaki). Thus it can be seen to show a lesser degree of bonding to the stem than we find in Tuskulu.

(37) Mush Armenian (Tuskulu) (Yeranosyan n.d.)
me tsɛr-ən kə-dən-ɛr b^hɛran
one end-DEF ptcl-put-IPF.3SG mouth
'He used to put one end (of it) in (his) mouth.'

(38) Erzurum Armenian (Shirakamut) (Mesropyan 1990)
me tsɛr-ə b^hɛran-ə gə d^hən-ɛr
one end-DEF mouth-DEF ptcl-put-IPF.3SG
'He used to put one end (of it) in (his) mouth.'

It is also the case that *kə* generally shows a higher degree of bondedness with the verb than *piti*. As seen in example (37), in Tuskulu, *kə-* shows a high degree of bondedness with the verb stem, to the extent that the verb stem-initial consonant loses its aspiration, as, following *kə-*, it is not interpreted as being in word-initial position. However, in the same text, we see that not only does *piti* (pronounced [pəti] in this dialect) not suppress aspiration on a stem-initial voiced consonant, but it can be separated from the verb stem by an adverb, as seen in (39).

[1]Tuskulu is a village in Gegharkunik province of Armenia which was settled mainly from Archesh in the region of Mush in 1827-8.

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(39) Erzurum Armenian (Shirakamut) (Mesropyan 1990)
yes pəti ʃut g^{h}-i
1sg.nom PTCL early come-IPF.1SG
'I would have come early.'

In addition, Acharyan (1961: 140) notes that in many Western Armenian dialects, *piti* need not be repeated with a string of verbs with the same subject and tense, as seen in (40).

(40) Western Armenian (Istanbul) (Acharyan 1961: 140)
piti ert‘-am ber-em
ptcl go-PRS.1SG bring-PRS.1SG
'I will go and bring (it).'

In general, this is not the case with *kə*, which is usually repeated with each verb. However, there are some examples in texts where a verb with *kə* is followed by a verb that lacks the particle (i.e., has the form of the present subjunctive), as seen in (41), (42), (43). This could be interpreted as parallel to the cases where a single *piti* is associated with a number of verbs, as in (40). As discussed in §20, there are parallels with the use of the subjunctive in narrative in NENA.

(41) Salmast Armenian (Atayan 1906: 198)
me marɾ^{h} k^{h}uʧ^{h}a-jen k-ənsn-i, iʃk-a, et jer-en
one person street-ABL PTCL-pass-PRS.3SG see-$^{\text{prs.sbjv.3sg}}$ DEM2 place-ABL
me dhol-i tsen=i ik^{j}-æli
one dhol-GEN voice=be.PRS.3SG come-I.PTCP
'A person passes by in the street, [and] sees [that] the sound of a dhol (type of drum) is coming from that place.'

(42) Van Armenian (Ghaziyan 2009: 12)
kə t^{h}oɣn-en, p^{h}axn-en
PTCL leave-PRS.3PL flee-PRS.3PL
'They leave [and] run away.'

(43) Van Armenian (Ghaziyan 2009: 14)
k-ejln-i avel k-arn-i dzer, paʃla-ji avel an-el
PTCL-lget.up-PRS.1PL broom PTCL-take-PRS.3SG hand, start-3SG.PRS broom do-INF
'She gets up, takes the broom in her hand, [and] starts to sweep.'

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In Eastern Armenian dialects, the forms with *kə* and *piti* have various modal uses (see Chapter 17), while innovative complex forms have developed for present and future tenses (see Chapters 18, 19, 17). However, in some Eastern dialects, including the Salmast texts recorded in Atayan (1906), the *kə-* forms are still regularly used for (non-progressive) present, and in Urmia/Khoy dialect as described by Asatryan (1962), *piti* undergoes phonetic reduction, sometimes as far as *ti*, as in rural forms of Van dialect, where, as in most Western dialects, it functions as the regular future tense marker. A native speaker of Urmia dialect from Karaglukh village in Vayots Dzor province, Armenia (settled from Urmia area in 1828), when asked to provide examples of how these forms (*kətə* in this subdialect) are used, described her plans for the summer (44), implying that they may be used as simple future tense forms, as in Western Armenian, rather than necessarily expressing obligation modality, as in most Eastern dialects (see Chapter 17).

(44) Urmia Armenian (Hodgson field notes)
amar-ə kətə et^{h}-am Tsaxkadzoɾ
summer-DEF PTCL go-PRS.1SG Tsaghkadzor
'In the summer I will go to Tsaghkadzor (well-known tourist resort)'

12.4.3 TAM modifiers in complex verb forms

12.4.3.1 Complex present

The defining characteristic that separates Western from Eastern Armenian is that Eastern Armenian dialects have complex present and imperfect tense forms. Both of these are formed of an imperfective participle with the present and past copula, respectively.

The imperfective participle used in Eastern Armenian dialects has three main types, all of which can be analysed as containing a locative element. It may be based on a) the imperfective stem with the modern Eastern Armenian locative ending *-um*, as seen in (46). This probably originates with the Classical Armenian locative of verbal nouns, some of which took the ending *-um*, as in (45), where we see the locative of the noun *kṙiv* 'fight(ing)', which corresponds to the verb stem *kṙv-* 'fight' (see Acharyan 1961: 175, Abajyan et al. 2017: 241). The preposition *i* was subsequently lost, and *-um*, which was generalised as the locative case ending in most Eastern Armenian dialects, began to be added to the stem of (almost) any verb to form the imperfective participle. In SEA, exceptions are the monosyllabic verbs *gal* 'to come', *tal* 'to give', *lal* 'to cry', which have the b)

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type of imperfective participle, with the ending *-is*.[2]. The majority of verbs in SEA and most Eastern Armenian dialects form the imperfective participle in this way. According to Gevorgyan (1987: 40), an example of the present tense with this type of participle is found in the work of the 13th century author Vardan Arevelcʻi, who was born in Gandzak (Ganja) in what is now Azerbaijan.

(45) Classical Armenian (Acharyan 1961: 175)
i kŕv-um-n en
LOC fight-LOC-DEF be.PRS.3PL
'They are in the fight(ing).'

(46) SEA
kŕv-um=en
fight-I.PTCP=be.PRS.3PL
'They are fighting.'

Another type of imperfective participle b) is proposed to be derived from the Classical Armenian locative (preposition *i* + accusative plural suffix *-is*) of verbal nouns in *-ikʻ* such as *lal-ikʻ* '(act of) crying', as seen in (47), with subsequent loss of *i* (see Acharyan 1961: 176, Abajyan et al. 2017: 243). This is used for three monosyllabic verbs (*gal* 'to come', *tal* 'to give', *lal* 'to cry') in SEA, as seen in (48), and more widely in some other dialects. Synchronically, it is identical to the infinitive + ending *-is*. In Urmia dialect, which lacks locative case, the *-um* participle is absent, and this type of form is used for all verbs (although the c) type is used in some subdialects, as discussed below). In this dialect, the participle has undergone different phonetic developments, so that when the copula is cliticised on it, the ending *-Vlis* > *-Vs* (where V is the thematic vowel) (49), while when the copula is not cliticised on it, *-Vlis* > *-Vli* (50). As well as in Urmia, this type of participle is dominant in some dialects of the Agulis-Meghri and Karabagh groups, and also in the dialect of Artvin, spoken in the Black Sea area and considered to be related to the dialect of Tbilisi of the wider Ararat group (Jahukyan 1972: 135), thus both geographically and linguistically distant from Urmia. This distribution, and the fact that it is not synchronically analysable as a locative form, imply that it may be an older form that was displaced by the a) type of participle in most areas where the *-um* locative is used.

[2]In some Eastern Armenian dialects, such as Bayazet (see Katvalyan 2009), these verbs too take the ending *-um*, which is added to the infinitive, rather than the verb stem, which consists of only a single consonant: *gal-um* 'come-I.PTCP'. In other Eastern Armenian dialects, such as Agulis, the *-is* forms are used for a larger number of verbs than in SEA, including all verbs with the thematic vowel -a-.

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(47) Classical Armenian (Acharyan 1961: 176)
i lali-s em
LOC cry(ing)-LOC be.PRS.1SG
'I am in (the act of) crying.'

(48) SEA
l-alis=em
cry-I.PTCP=be.1SG.PRS
'I am crying.'

(49) Urmia Armenian (Asatryan 1962: 99)
kʲiɾ-es=em
write-I.PTCP=be.PRS.1SG
'I am writing/write.'

(50) Urmia Armenian (Asatryan 1962: 99)
jes=em kʲiɾ-eli
1SG.NOM=be.PRS.1SG write-I.PTCP
'I am writing/write.'

Some forms c) may be directly derived from the Classical Armenian locative singular of the infinitive (preposition *i* + accusative (zero) ending). It is possible that this construction was already used to express progressive meaning in Classical Armenian, even without the preposition *i*, as seen in (51), and it is thought to predate the *k-*, *-um*, and *-lis* present tenses (Gevorgyan 1987: 40). It is common in Middle Armenian (with optional *i*), as seen in (52), and is in fact the source of the negative of the *kə*-forms in the standard Armenian languages, as discussed in §12.4.2. The preposition *i* is generally lost in the modern language, resulting in forms where the imperfective participle appears identical to the infinitive, as seen in (53)[3].

(51) Classical Armenian (5th century) (Gevorgyan 1987: 40)
t-al ēr
give-INF be.IPF.3SG
'(S)he was giving.'

(52) Middle Armenian (13th century) (Acharyan 1961: 174)

[3]When used for the negative of the *kə*-forms, this participle has undergone phonetic changes in both SEA and SWA, so that it is no longer identical to the infinitive.

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ē *i* *g-al*
be.PRS.3AG LOC come-INF
'(S)he is coming/comes.'

(53) Urmia Armenian (Asatryan 1962: 99)
kʲiɾ-el=em
write-I.PTCP/INF=be.PRS.1SG
'I am writing/write.'

Such forms are found in some environments in New Jugha dialect, as discussed by Acharyan (1961: 178), and also appear in some Urmia subdialects and in Maragha (Acharyan 1961: 186 refers to "the -el form [of the imperfective participle] of Persian-Armenian dialects", see also Gevorgyan 1987: 44). In some Urmia subdialects, such as that spoken in Karaglukh and Aghnjadzor villages in Vayots Dzor region in Armenia, this form is used in all environments, as seen in 55, 56. Gevorgyan (1987: 44) considers that the Urmia and Maragha forms represent the continuation of the Middle Armenian construction. However, in some Urmia subdialects, the *-s* forms, as seen in (49), alternate with the *-l* forms which are identical to the infinitive, as seen in 57. Asatryan (1962: 99) proposes that the *-l* forms actually result from the loss of the final vowel of the *-li* ending seen in (50) (which has the variant *-lə* in some subdialects), which is considered to derive from the loss of the final *-s* of the *-lis* participle, rather than being directly derived from the locative of the infinitive.

(54) Urmia Armenian (Aygezard, Ararat province) (Asatryan 1962: 180)
əl-eli *ʧʰi* *əl-eli* *mi* *marʧʰ* *me* *kənəikʲ=i*
be-PTCP.IMPF NEG.be.3SG be-PTCP.IMPF one man one woman=be.3SG
əl-eli
be-PTCP.IMPF
'Once upon a time there was a man and wife (lit. [There] is, [there] isn't, [there] is one man one woman).'

(55) Urmia Armenian (Aghnjadzor, Vayots Dzor) (Hodgson field notes)
aɾden *etʰ-al=ekʰʲ*
already go-PTCP.IMPF=be.2PL
'You are going already.'

(56) Urmia Armenian (Karaglukh, Vayots Dzor) (Hodgson field notes)
etʰ-al=es *tsar-er-en* *pæn=es* *kʰaG-el*
go-PTCP.IMPF=be.2SG tree-PL-ABL thing=be.2SG pick-PTCP.IMPF
'You go and pick thing(s) from the trees.'

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(57) Urmia Armenian (Gandzak, Vayots Dzor) (Asatryan 1962: 178)
kʲerakuɾ-n ut-es=em, ʧʰ-em maɾs-el
food-DEF eat-PTCP.IMPF=be.1SG NEG-be.1SG digest-PTCP.IMPF
'I eat the food, I don't digest (it).'

12.4.3.2 Complex perfect

In Classical Armenian, the only major complex tense form was the perfect. This was formed of a participle based on the perfective stem with the ending *-eal* (here referred to as the past participle based on its function in modern Armenian, where the ending has various phonetic variants, including *-el*, *-al*, and *-er*), and, optionally, the enclitic copula (see Chapter 22 for a discussion of the Classical Armenian perfect). (58) shows its form in SEA, where the copula is generally obligatory (although it may occur only once in chains of verbs with the same tense and subject, as seen in (60)). In some dialects, including those of the Urmia-Salmast-Khoy area, the 3SG copula is often omitted, as seen in (61) and (62). To the best of our knowledge, this tense form has survived in all modern Armenian dialects, although in some, its function has changed. In many Western Armenian dialects, it has acquired evidential meaning, while in the dialects of Agulis-Meghri and Suceava, it replaces the synthetic aorist. There is a corresponding pluperfect tense with the same participle and the past form of the copula (59).

(58) SEA
ker-el=em
eat.PFV-PST.PTCP=be.PRS.1SG
'I have eaten.'

(59) SEA
ker-el=ēi
eat.PFV-PST.PTCP=be.PST.1SG
'I had eaten.'

(60) SEA (EANC)
hastat ēt mard-ə eli ira jaxord xelkʿ-ic
surely DEM2 person-DEF PTCL 3SG.GEN unsuccessful mind-ABL
gnacʿ-el xortakv-el nahatak=a eɫ-el
go-PST.PTCP sink-PST.PTCP martyr=be.PRS.3SG be-PST.PTCP
'Surely that man has gone out of his wretched mind again, sunk [in the lake], [and] become a martyr.'

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(61) Urmia Armenian (Aghnjadzor) (Hodgson field notes)
intʃʰ el-e?
what be-PST.PTCP
'What has happened?'

(62) Salmast Armenian (Atayan 1906: 202)
dædæ-n mer-e
father-DEF die-PST.PTCP
'Father has died.'

In those dialects where the original perfect tense has changed its function (including SWA and Agulis-Meghri), the meaning of the perfect tense is expressed by a different periphrasis, using the resultative participle, an innovation of Middle Armenian formed of the perfective stem with the ending *-ac* (and phonetic variants), as seen in (63).

(63) Istanbul Armenian (Acharyan 1961: 224)
ays ban-ə sovorutʿyun=e darj-ac Pols-i meǰ
DEM1 thing-DEF custom=be.PRS.3SG become-RES.PTCP Istanbul-GEN in
'This thing has become a custom in Istanbul.'

12.4.3.3 Complex future

In Classical Armenian, one way of expressing future meaning involved the copula and a participle in *-locʿ*, which appears to be the genitive plural of the infinitive (which is formed on the imperfective stem), as seen in (64).

(64) Classical Armenian (Acharyan 1961: 229)
sir-elocʿ em
love-F.PTCP be.PRS.1SG
'I will love.'

According to (Acharyan 1961: 232), this type of form has survived in two dialects: Agulis, where the participle has the ending *-latsʰ*, and Nor Jugha, where it has the ending *-letsʰ*, although he considers it more likely that these are actually derived from the ending *-leacʿ* of the genitive plural of the *-likʿ* participle (the locative of which gives the imperfective participle in *-lis* and phonetic variants).

More widespread in modern dialects is the future participle in *-lu*, which represents the genitive singular of the infinitive (see Acharyan 1961: 231). In Classical Armenian, this was only used as an adjective, but it is found in future tense

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forms in Middle Armenian (Acharyan 1961: 232). In Eastern Armenian dialects, in which the present tense is also complex, and which generally show a greater preference for complex tense forms, this is a regular future tense form (65), with a corresponding future-in-the past with the past copula (66). In Western Armenian dialects, where the future tense is formed with the particle *piti*, this form, where present, has acquired a meaning of obligation modality, possibly through influence of the Turkish obligative forms based on the short infinitive + ending *-lI* (in some Armenian dialects spoken in Turkey, the participle actually has the ending *-li*) (Acharyan 1961: 235-6).

(65) SEA
ut-elu=em
eat.IPFV-F.PTCP=be.PRS.1SG
'I will eat.'

(66) SEA
ut-elu=ēi
eat.IPFV-F.PTCP=be.PST.1SG
'I would eat.'

12.4.3.3.18 Secondary complex tenses

In addition to the basic complex tenses (perfect, future, present) described in the previous section, Armenian also makes use of secondary complex tenses formed of perfective, imperfective, and future participles and conjugated forms of the auxiliary verb *linel* 'to be/become'. As described by Asatryan (2004: 281), the action is conceived of as being simultaneous with (imperfective participle), completed by (perfective participle) or in the future at (future participle) the reference point of the relevant form of the auxiliary. It is interesting that the perfective participle used in these forms is the resultative participle, even in SEA and other Eastern dialects, including Urmia, where this form is not used for the regular perfect tense. The imperfective participle used in SEA is the *-lis* participle, not the *-um* participle used for the regular present tense. [4]

The complex verbs forms with the *-lis* participle are characteristic of formal literary SEA rather than colloquial/dialect speech.

[4]This participle, as well as being used to form the present tense of a few monosyllabic verbs, is also used in literary SEA, but not in the colloquial language, in adverbial clauses expressing simultaneity, as seen in (i).

(i) SEA (Dum-Tragut 2009: 205)

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Some dialects, such as Paraka of the Agulis-Meghri group, do have complex tenses with an imperfective participle, but these use the same participle that forms the present tense (>*-um* or >*-lis*, depending on the verb). These forms may express both progressive (as in 67) and habitual (as in 68) meaning, like other forms based on the imperfective participle in this dialect. Both these examples have the auxiliary verb in the perfect tense, and seem to express an event with imperfective aspect in the non-witnessed past (in both cases, the speaker is telling stories from the life of their parents/grandparents that happened before they were born, a context where perfect tense is usual, see §20).

(67) Paraka Armenian (Hodgson 2022a)
eʃalon-ə *k-øys=a* *el-ats* *hajɾenik^h*
military.train-DEF come-I.PTCP=be.3SG be-RES.PTCP fatherland
Germanja-jits^h
Germany-ABL
'The military train was coming to the fatherland from Germany [when the accident happened].'

(68) Paraka Armenian (Hodgson 2022a)
bəʒəʃk-neɾ-i-n *ɣaɾk-əm=ən* *el-ats* *taɾber* *teɣ-aɾ*
doctor-PL-DAT-DEF send-I.PTCP=be.3PL be.RES.PTCP different place-PL
'They used to send doctors to different places.'

The main dialects in contact with NENA (Urmia, Van, Mush) seem to lack complex verb forms with an imperfective participle, possessing only those built on future and resultative participles. In Urmia (Asatryan 1962: 135) and Van (Acharyan 1952: 179), there are no forms given with the perfect of the auxiliary. Baghdasaryan-Tapaltsyan (1958: 167) states that in Mush dialect, all conjugated forms of the auxiliary are possible in complex tenses with the future or resultative participle of the lexical verb, although she gives examples only of the present subjunctive and *piti*-future. In Urmia (Asatryan 1962: 135) and Van (Acharyan 1952: 179), complex forms are given with the present (in Urmia, both complex present and *kə*-present), imperfect, aorist, piti-future, and subjunctive of the auxiliary, as seen in 12.6.

antaŕ-um *sunk* *havakʿ-elis Madlen-ə* *korcʿr-ecʿ* *tan* *banali-n*
forest-LOC mushroom collect-IPT Madlen-DEF lose-AOR.3SG house.GEN key-DEF
'(While she was) collecting mushrooms in the forest, Madeleine lost her front door key.'

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Table 12.6: Secondary complex tenses of verb *kʰjənel* 'to sleep' (1sg) (Urmia) (Asatryan 1962: 135)

Auxiliary form	Future participle	Resultative participle
Present (complex)	*kʰjənely=jem əleli*	*kʰjənats=em əleli*
Imperfect	*kʰjənely=jem eɾ əleli*	*kʰjənats=em eɾ əleli*
Aorist	*kʰjənely əlam*	*kʰjənats əlam*
Present (*kə*)	*kʰjənely k-əlem*	*kʰjənats k-əlem*
Future (*piti*)	*kʰjənely ti əlem*	*kʰjənats ti əlem*
Subjunctive	*kʰjənely əlem*	*kʰjənats əlem*

Note that for Van, Acharyan (1952: 179) also gives past equivalents for the forms based on the subjunctive (i.e., *kə*-imperfect, *piti*-future-in-the-past, past subjunctive). In Van dialect, these are based on the imperfect subjunctive, which does not exist in Urmia. In Urmia, the equivalent forms would be based on the present subjunctive plus past particle (see §12.4.4), but are not actually given by Asatryan (1962: 135), perhaps because he considered it unnecessary given that their structure can be deduced from the rest of the paradigm.

12.4.4 TAM modification by means of the past particle

In the dialects of the Urmia group (which also includes Salmast, Khoy, and Maragha) the past copula and the imperfect subjunctive have been lost, so that past forms of the copula (12.7) and the subjunctive (12.8), as well as synthetic (prefix + subjunctive) and complex (participle + copula) tenses based on them, are formed by adding the particle *eɾ*, which is identical to the 3sg past copula in dialects that possess it, to the relevant present tense form. To the best of our knowledge, this system is not found in any other Armenian dialects.[5] For forms with the 3sg copula, *eɾ* replaces, rather than accompanies, the present copula (note that the 3sg copula is often omitted in this dialect, as seen in (61) and (62). For the 3sg past subjunctive, the original synthetic form (with the ending *-eɾ*) has been preserved, in contrast to the other persons, where *eɾ* is added to the present form.

The past particle immediately follows the copula (whether enclitic on the lexical verb, as in (69), or on another element, as in (70)) or other inflected verb, i.e., it

[5]The dialects of the Agulis-Meghri group and those of Hadrut and related dialects spoken in northern Iran (Karadagh) and southern Karabagh also have past particles, but these are derived from participial forms of the verb 'to be', not from the past copula.

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Table 12.7: The paradigm of the copula/auxiliary in Urmia Armenian (Asatryan 1962: 103)

Person	Present	Past
1SG	*em*	*em=eɾ*
2SG	*es*	*es=eɾ*
3SG	*i*	*eɾ*
1PL	*enk^{hj}*	*enk^{hj}=eɾ*
2PL	*ek^{hj}*	*ek^{hj}=eɾ*
3PL	*en*	*en=eɾ*

Table 12.8: The paradigm of the subjunctive (verb *k^{j}irel 'to write')* in Urmia Armenian (Asatryan 1962: 107)

Person	Present	Past
1SG	*k^{j}iɾem*	*k^{j}iɾem=eɾ*
2SG	*k^{j}iɾes*	*k^{j}iɾes=eɾ*
3SG	*k^{j}iɾi*	*k^{j}iɾeɾ*
1PL	*k^{j}iɾenk^{hj}*	*k^{j}iɾenk^{hj}=eɾ*
2PL	*k^{j}iɾek^{hj}*	*k^{j}iɾek^{hj}=eɾ*
3PL	*k^{j}iɾen*	*k^{j}iɾen=eɾ*

follows the subject agreement, but precedes the object clitic when this is present, as in (71) (see §13.4.4.3).

(69) Urmia Armenian (Stilo & Noorlander 2015: 478)
kaɾt^{h}-es=em=eɾ
read-I.PTCP=be.1SG=PST
'I was reading.'

(70) Urmia Armenian (Stilo & Noorlander 2015: 478)
me xat^{h} giɾk^{h}=em=eɾ kaɾt^{h}-ali
one piece book=be.1SG=PST read-I.PTCP
'I was reading a book.'

(71) Urmia Armenian (Asatryan 1962: 136)
oɾ-ə xæjiɾ xet oxn-es=eɾ=ət
day-DEF hundred time bless-I.PTCP=PST=ART2
'S/he used to bless you a hundred times a day.'

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12.5 Discussion

Overall, the greatest level of structural similarity in Tense-Aspect-Mood (TAM) encoding between NENA and its neighbouring languages can be found in the construction of the indicative habitual and its subjunctive counterpart (Matras 2010: 57; Noorlander 2014; Stilo & Noorlander 2015, see also Pennacchietti 1988, 1994; Chyet 1995; Matras 2009: 259–260, 2010: 75; Matras & Sakel 2007: 845), as well as in copula-based tense formations, i.e., complex verb forms. There are some commonalities in verbal stem organisation in terms of tense-aspect formation, but there are also noteworthy differences in how verbal stems are marked for tense or mood or a combination of both tense and aspect besides mood, which are discussed in the chapters concerning the relevant areas of verbal syntax.

In principle, all the languages of the region, with the exception of Turkic, have at least some dialects that typically distinguish the realis present from the irrealis by means of a preverbal modifier (see also Noorlander & Stilo 2015). The irrealis is a distinct finite verbal form known as the subjunctive, typically used in modal complements expressing desire, ability and obligation, illustrated by the example *'I want to go home'* in Table 12.9. The parallels in the expression of the indicative habitual are further discussed in §18. Another parallel in this respect is the development of preverbal modifiers to express the future, for which see §17. The respective morphemes themselves have largely language-internal sources. Only few of the preverbal TAM-modifiers in NENA are the result of direct importation from neighbouring Iranian languages, such as the borrowing of Kurdish *de-* into NENA illustrated in (72), cf. (73).

(72) J. Koy Sanjak ((Mutzafi 2004a)
da-rxiš-le
IPFV-walk.PST-OBL.3SG:S
'He was walking.'

(73) Common Central Kurdish
de-řoyşt
IPFV-go.PST.3SG:S
'He was walking.'

In the inflection that follows the verbal stem, there are numerous past tense particles that parallel the so-called 'past tense convertor' *-wa* in NENA, namely the past marker *(=)er* in Urmia Armenian and the augment *-ên* in Gorani. These also correspond to the past tense copula *bû* and dialectal variants thereof in

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Northern Kurdish. This also shows a convergence in paradigm organisation, as shown in the examples below. In both Neo-Aramaic and Armenian, this particle originated as a fossilised invariant 3SG form of the past tense copula (Stilo & Noorlander 2015. In the past equivalent to the present indicative and subjunctive, the subject coding precedes the past tense particle, while the object coding, if present, follows it in both Neo-Aramaic and Armenian.

(74) C. Urmi, NENA

a. *šaḵl-a -wa -lux*
take-3SG.F:A -PST -OBL.2SG.M:P
'She used to take you.' Past habitual

b. *bəšḵal-u =n -va*
take.PROG-POSS.3SG.M:P =COP.1SG:A -PST
'I was taking him.' Past progressive

c. *le-vən -va +bda*
NEG-COP.1SG.M:A -PST know.PROG
'I did not know.' Negative past progressive

d. *mər-t =ən -va*
say.RES.PTCP-F.SG:A =COP.1SG:A -PST
'I had said.' Past perfect

e. *ʾət -va*
EXIST -PST
'There was.' Past exisential

(75) Urmia Armenian

a. *oxn-es =eɾ =ət*
bless-I.PTCP =PST =ART2
'S/he used to bless you.' (Asatryan 1962: 136)

b. *oṭ-es =em =er*
eat-I.PTCP =COP.1SG =PST
'I used to eat.' (Stilo & Noorlander 2015: 459)

c. *as-ir =em =er*
say-PST.PTCP =COP.1SG =PST
'I had said.' (Stilo & Noorlander 2015: 469)

d. *čʿ-em =er gin-ali*
NEG-COP.1SG =PST know-PST.PTCP
'I did not know.' (Stilo & Noorlander 2015: 477)

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(76) Hewramî

a. *ber -ên -mê =it*
take.PRS -PST -1PL:A =OBL.2SG:P
'We used to take you.'

b. *am -ên -mê*
come.PST -PST -1PL:A
'If I had come.'

c. *b -ên -ê*
be.PRS -PST -3PL
'There were.'

(77) Common Northern Kurdish

a. *me ew kuşt-i -bû-∅*
1PL.OBL 3SG.DIR kill.PST-PTCP -be.PST-3SG
'We had killed him.'

b. *he -bû-∅*
EXIST -be.PST-3SG
'There was.'

Furthermore, the syntax of the copula as a TAM auxiliary in NENA has parallels in the neighbouring languages in the formation of various periphrastic verb forms, here referred to as 'complex verbal constructions', which are further discussed in Chapters 13, 19, 16 and 15. In such complex verb forms across the languages of the area, the copula itself can serve as preverbal TAM modifier and become a fossilised invariant particle (see also the past tense particle mentioned above). This occurs alongside its function as an auxiliary in the development of BE-perfects as well as in the development of progressives. In such complex verb forms, the auxiliary itself can become fully integrated into the verbal inflection, as discussed in Chapters 13, 19 and 16. Finally, with respect to the verbal stem itself and the verbal endings expressing the person, number and gender of the subject and/or object, the strongest parallels are found between NENA and Iranian. These are further discussed in Sections 13.5 and 21.6. The most noteworthy parallel is the 'oblique' encoding of the agent in past perfective clauses in contrast to present imperfective clauses, as the examples below illustrate. Here, a tense-aspectual distinction is made not only on the level of verbal stem or preverbal modification, but also on the level of argument encoding, such as case marking or verbal person marking. The additional 'oblique' coding of the agent

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may thus be considered part of a tense-aspect formation; see Chapters 13, 21 and 22 for further discussion. This is distinct from the oblique marking of experiencers and possessors in other contexts, which do not depend on the verbal stem they combine with and therefore cannot be considered tense-aspect formatives, see Chapter 24.

(78) C. Nerwa, NENA (Noorlander field notes)

a. *(ʾaxni) i-ʾaxl-ax*
NOM.1PL IND-eat.PRS-1PL:A
'We eat.' Present habitual

b. *(ʾaxni) xəl(-∅)-lan*
NOM.1PL eat.PST.PFV-3SG.M:P-OBL.1PL:A
'We ate (it).' Past perfective

(79) Common Central Kurdish (Mohammadirad field notes)

a. *(ême) de-xo-yn*
1PL IND-eat.PRS-1PL:A
'We eat.' Present habitual

b. *(ême) de=man-xward(-∅)*
1PL PROG=OBL.1PL:A-eat.PST(-3SG:P)
'We were eating (it).' Past progressive

(80) Hewramî (Mohammadirad field notes)

a. *(ême) wer-mê*
1PL eat.PRS-1PL:A
'We eat.' Present habitual

b. *(ême) warđ=ma*
1PL eat.OBL.1PL:A
'We ate.' Past perfective

(81) C. Marga, NENA (Noorlander field notes)

a. *ʾaxni yaxl-ax*
NOM.1PL eat.PRS-1PL:A
'We eat.' Present habitual

b. *ʾəll-an xil-∅*
OBL-1PL eat.PST.PFV-3SG.M:P
'*We* ate (it).' Past perfective (with agent focus)

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(82) Behdînî Northern Kurdish (Mohammadirad field notes)

a. *Em* *di-xw-in*
DIR.1PL IND-eat.PRS-PL:A
'We eat.' Present habitual

b. *Me* *xwar(-∅)*
OBL.1PL eat.PAST(-3SG:P)
'We ate (it).' Past

Table 12.9: Indicative and subjunctive forms in same subject 'want' complements, conveying the sentence 'I want to go home'

Language	**'I'**	**IND**	**BASE**	**PAM**	**SBJV**	**BASE**	**PAM**	**'home'**
		Prefix		**Suffix**	**Prefix**		**Suffix**	
J. Dohok NENA	*ʾana*	*g-*	*əb*	*-ən*	*∅-*	*ʾaz*	*-ən*	*beθa*
J. Urmi NENA	*ana*	*g-*	*bé*	*-n*	*∅-*	*ez*	*-én*	*belá*
Ṭuroyo Neo-Aramaic	*ono*	*k-*	*əbʿ*	*-ono*	*∅-*	*əzz*	*-í(no)*	*l-ú=bayθo*
Northern Kurdish	*ez*	*di-*	*xwaz*	*-im*	*∅-*	*her*	*-im*	*malê*
Salmast Armenian	*yes*	*k-*	*uz*	*-em*	*∅-*	*etʿ*	*-am*	*tun*

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13 The morphology of verbal person marking

13.1 Introduction

Verbal person marking refers to the use of bound morphemes (affixes or clitics) attached to verbs to indicate the person as well as number and/or gender of the arguments in a clause. These person markers can encode the subject (S, A), object (P, T, R), or other syntactic roles, and their distribution is often sensitive to tense, aspect, mood (TAM), and transitivity. This chapter therefore deals with the verbal inflection of person as well as their associated syntactic roles (S, A, P, T, R). The sets of bound person markers are attached to verbal stems that comprise a verbal paradigm. Syntactic roles are distinguished here according to the semantic and syntactic principles discussed in Comrie 1978, 1989 and (Andrews 2007) (see also Chapter 21), and are defined as follows:

- S as the single argument of an intransitive clause.
- A as the agent-like argument of a transitive clause.
- P as the patient-like argument of a primary monotransitive clause.
- T as the theme-like argument of a ditransitive clause.
- R as the recipient-like argument of a ditransitive clause.

Whether a clause is transitive or intransitive is primarily grounded in lexical verb classes. Following (Haig 2008), a transitive clause is determined by the lexical class of transitive verbs and their morphosyntactic properties. For example, in Central Kurdish, a light verb construction containing a transitive light verb *kirdîn* 'to do' is classified as transitive even though it may be semantically intransitive, e.g., *fewt kirdîn* 'to die', *pyase kirdîn* 'to walk'. Conversely, the semantically transitive verb *serkewtin* 'to climb' is built on *kewtin* 'to fall', which is intransitive. Similarly, when the P argument is omitted with a transitive verb

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such as 'to eat', as in *Where did you eat this morning?*, this does not result in detransitivisation. This generally holds true for most languages in the area. As we will see, however, the situation is more complex in NENA dialects, since transitive clauses based on verbal froms that inflect for two core arguments, i.e., A and P, can comprise a subsystem of their. By and large, however, the transitivity is similarly determined lexically in NENA.

In terms of verbal inflection morphology, there is significant diversity in verbal person marking across the region, with both cross-language convergence and internal microvariation. The systems in NENA and Kurdic languages are particularly complex, often marking both subjects and objects on the verb, and showing sensitivity to TAM and transitivity. Armenian and other languages in the area, by contrast, tend to have more uniform, subject(S/A)-oriented person marking.

In Iranian as well as in NENA, verbal person marking morphology not only expresses subjects (S/A), but can also express objects (P, T, R). In Northern Kurdish, person marking is mostly independent of the verb (see also Chapters 9 and 21). This also applies to object marking in most Armenian dialects (see §13.4). Across Neo-Aramaic and Neo-Iranian varieties, the person markers that are selected to encode subjects, i.e., S and A, and/or objects vary within verbal paradigms and can be sensitive to tense-aspect-mood besides lexical transitivity, which, in turn, shows considerable language- and dialect-dependent variation.

In both Aramaic and Iranian, the oblique expression of A in the past is the result of the grammaticalisation of a former transitive resultative construction in which the verb was a patient-oriented resultative participle and the agent was expressed separately from it in an oblique case. We lack here the space to discuss the details of this development, but this does concern an ancient trait of the languages in question, since the earliest attestations of this phenomenon occur in ancient epigraphic traditions that go back to the period of the Achaemenid empire, in so-called Imperial Aramaic, as shown in (1), and in Old Persian, as shown in (2). A parallel construction, though attested centuries after this, also occurs with the genitive case in Classical Armenian, as shown in (4)

(1) Imperial Aramaic
katab-tī *ʾeger-tā* *dā* *ka=dī* *ken* *šamīʿ-∅*
write.PST.PFV-1SG:A letter.F.SG DEM.F.SG when thus heard.RES.PTCP-M.SG
l-anā *lēʾmar*
DAT-1PL saying
'I wrote this letter when it was heard by/unto us thus, saying...' (TAD A3.3:13)

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(2) Old Persian (Kent 1953: 142, DSf 19–20)
taya *=maiy* *framāt-am*
NOM.REL.N.SG =GEN-DAT.1SG order.RES.PTCP-NOM.N.SG
'What has been commanded by me.'

(3) Parthian (Durkin-Meisterernst 2014: 394)
u=t *az* *hišt* *hēm* *sēwag*
and=2SG:A 1SG.DIR leave.PTCP COP.1SG:P orphan
'And you left me behind as an orphan.'

(4) Classical Armenian (Hewson & Bubenik 1997: 76)
gorc *gorceal* *ē* *nora*
work make.PTCP be.PRS.3SG 3SG.GEN
'He has accomplished a work.'

It is widely assumed that the early development of a dative agent in premodern Aramaic and a genitive agent in Classical Armenian was ultimately a contact-induced innovation resulting from contact with Iranian (Meyer 2023). However, it would be misleading to disregard the internal developments within Aramaic and Armenian. With respect to Aramaic, see, among others, Kutscher (1969) and Noorlander (2026b) for arguments as to why this assumption is not unproblematic. One important factor is that the distribution of the constructions in Imperial Aramaic (1) and in (4) is not equivalent to that of Old Persian (2) nor that of Parthian (3. The Old Persian construction already reflects a system-wide syntactic and morphological phenomenon, while the effects of lexical-semantic restrictions remain evident in Aramaic from the Imperial period well into the Late Antique period. This notwithstanding, it is clear that the striking parallelisms cannot be completely disentangled from periods of Aramaic-Iranian bilingualism reinforcing the grammaticalisation that resulted in the verbal system found in North-Eastern and Central Neo-Aramaic dialects, as the microvariation will reveal. In both Aramaic and Iranian, the oblique person markers were integrated into the verbal inflection of the modern dialects, see §13.5. The Classical Armenian genitive agent, however, did not continue into modern dialects.

Because of the historical background of the verbal system, factors pertaining to tense-aspect-mood (TAM) and lexical transitivity directly impact the verbal person marking found in NENA dialects. The common pattern within Neo-Aramaic and Neo-Iranian languages is for transitive agents to be expressed differently according to the TAM constructions they are used in. Oblique person markers, historically related to the oblique agents in the participle-based constructions

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mentioned above, are used in TAM constructions based on the past stem of the verb. On the other hand, within Iranian, intransitive subjects are marked by the same set of person markers in both present tense and past tense constructions. Within NENA, however, intransitive subjects in past stem verb forms are expressed by the same set of person markers that are used for the agent in such verbal forms. This type of inflection occurs only sporadically in Iranian, notably in Gorani dialects outside the Hawraman region.

In what follows, we focus on the expression of person and role in verbal inflection in the languages under investigation. For the functions of the verbal forms in terms of tense, aspect, and mood, see Chapters 17, 18, 19, 16 and 20. How the verbal inflection interacts with the syntax of full NPs is dealt with in Chapter 21. While transitivity plays a key role in our discussion, we describe the verbal conjugations here independently of the more abstract relationship between intransitive and transitive clauses and how this relationship can be characterised in terms of alignment. A separate discussion dedicated to alignment typology can be found in Chapter 22. From the perspective of NENA dialectology, verbal person marking varies independently of how the alignment in the respective dialect is characterised. Moreover, the sets of person markers vary so drastically depending on dialect and construction type that it is often impossible to speak of dedicated 'ergative' or 'accusative' sets of person markers. It is better to characterise these sets of person markers by their associated syntactic role within the context of the respective verbal paradigm.

Neo-Aramaic manifests a diversity greater than that which has been documented for the various Iranian languages spoken in the area. Most forms of Armenian show far greater uniformity across their verbal systems, as do the more peripheral languages such as Azeri and local Arabic varieties. However, a noticeable tendency within this vast landscape of variability is that of cross-system harmonisation (e.g., Haig 2008, Noorlander 2021b), where the person marking of the present tense verbal forms is extended to that of other tense formations. This is certainly a core factor that accounts for some of the microvariation in NENA and Kurdic dialects. Cross-system harmonisation is also found, to some extent, in Armenian. The typology of verbal inflection in Armenian, however, has remained considerably more consistent with cognate Indo-European languages than that found in Iranian.

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13.2 Verbal person marking in NENA

13.2.1 Core verbal inflectional stems: present and past stem

In grammatical descriptions of NENA dialects, two primary verbal bases are distinguished, which have distinct origins, namely:

(5)

	Stem	Origins
"Present (Imperfective)"	*qaṭel*	Active participle
"Past (Perfective)"	*qṭil*	Resultative participle

The above terminology is used loosely here for abstract morphological categories to aid us in the discussion of verbal inflection. The *qaṭəl*-stem and *qṭil*-stem in NENA go back to what were originally verbal adjectives, and are now the basis of core verbal conjugations. Both these stems can be inflected by means of the same sets of person-marking affixes, which can express either the same roles or the opposite roles (i.e., the same affix can be used for different roles depending on the construction). Generally, the inflection of the *qṭil-stem* is more likely to be restricted in distribution within the verbal system compared to the *qaṭəl*-stem, which is generally unrestricted and can be considered the main verbal construction. The *qṭil*-stem serves as the basis for the expression of past perfective constructions (see §13.2.4). It may also serve as the basis for the expression of resultative-stative situations and the perfect tense (here, equivalent to "anterior"), for which see §12.2.2. Various Tense-Aspect-Mood-modifying affixes can be combined with the *qaṭəl*-stem, see Chapters 18 and 17. For further details on the respective verbal derivations in relation to valence-adjusting morphology and constructions such as causatives and passives, see Chapter 14.

13.2.2 Core verbal person markers

Verbal person marking is highly variable in NENA. The same set of person markers can be used to express different functions across paradigms as well as across individual dialects. The syntactic function of the person markers is ultimately determined by their combination with the immediately preceding verbal stem. All NENA dialects have several sets of verbal person markers at their disposal, which can have a variety of syntactic functions depending on the preceding verbal stem:

(6) Core sets of verbal person markers

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Set I "D(irect) suffixes"	<	Bound person markers historically based on enclitic pronouns and/or participial agreement
Set II "Oblique L-suffixes"	<	Oblique bound person markers historically based on the dative preposition *l-* inflected for person, number and gender, e.g., **l-an* 'to us' > *-lan* 'us'

The D-suffixes always express the syntactic functions S and A when they are attached to the present stem, for which we also use the abstract label *qaṭəl*. The L-suffixes always express the function of A when they are attached to the past stem, for which the label *qṭil* shall be used.

Other sets of verbal person markers are typically used with complex verbal constructions in which the verbal stems ultimately have a nominal basis, such as the resultative participle or the infinitive:

(7) Other sets of verbal person markers

Enclitic Copula	<	Bound person markers historically derived from free pronouns and the verb *hwy* 'to be'
"LL-series"	<	Bound allomorphs of free prepositional person markers based on the dative-accusative preposition *ʾəll-*, cf. *ʾəllew* 'him' and *-llew* 'him'
"Possessive" suffixes	<	Bound person markers attached to originally nominal forms of the verb; these are otherwise attached to nouns and prepositions

Considerable neutralisation, analogical extension, and cross-system harmonisation occurs across verbal paradigms in NENA. Depending on the dialect and the type of verbal construction, phonetic reduction of the enclitic copula can result in allomorphs that are near-identical or completely identical to the D-suffixes (Set I). The same holds true for the so-called LL-series, which can end up identical to the L-suffixes. At the same time, the third person forms of the enclitic copula also have an /l/-element in the majority of NENA dialects, e.g., 3SG.M *=ile* and 3SG.F *=ila*. For the use of these person markers in complex verb phrases, see §13.2.5. For further details about the relationship between perfect and past perfective constructions, see Chapter 16.

13.2.2.1 D(irect)-suffixes

The first and second person forms of the D-suffixes are historically derived from enclitic personal pronouns that became attached to an immediately preceding

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Table 13.1: Main sets of person markers in NENA dialects. Examples taken from J. Koy Sanjak (Mutzafi 2004a, 96)

	Set I D-suffixes	Enclitic Copula	Set II L-suffixes	Set III LL-series	Possessive Suffixes
1SG.M	*-en*	*=wen*	*-li*	*-(ə)lli*	*-i*
1SG.F	*-an*	*=wan*	*-li*	*-(ə)lli*	*-i*
1PL	*-ex*	*=wex*	*-lan*	*-(ə)llan*	*-an*
2SG.M	*-et*	*=wet*	*-lox*	*-(ə)llux*	*-ux*
2SG.F	*-at*	*=wat*	*-lax*	*-(ə)llax*	*-ax*
2PL	*-etun*	*=wetun*	*-lxun*	*-(ə)llәxun*	*-xun*
3SG.M	*-∅*	*=ile*	*-le*	*-(ə)llew*	*-ew*
3SG.F	*-a*	*=ila*	*-la*	*-(ə)llaw*	*-aw*
3PL	*-i*	*=ilu*	*-lu*	*-(ə)llu*	*-u*

Table 13.2: Core verbal endings in NENA. Illustrated with the verb *nšq* 'to kiss' in J. Koy Sanjak (Mutzafi 2004a)

	Present Imperfective S/A *qaṭәl*	Past Perfective A *qṭil*	Imperative S/A
1SG.M	*našq-en*	*nšiq-li*	
1SG.F	*našq-an*	*nšiq-li*	
1PL	*našq-ex*	*nšiq-lan*	
2SG.M	*našq-et*	*nšiq-lox*	*nšoq*
2SG.F	*našq-at*	*nšiq-lax*	*nšoq*
2PL	*našq-etun*	*nšiq-lxun*	*nšoq-un*
3SG.M	*našәq-∅*	*nšiq-le*	
3SG.F	*našq-a*	*nšiq-la*	
3PL	*našq-i*	*nšiq-lu*	

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verbal adjective. The third-person forms represent the bare inflection of the original verbal adjective. The D-suffixes serve as the core verbal endings of the present stem verbal forms. Thus, the former verbal adjective **qaṭ(ə)l-* always combines with D-suffixes that express both the single argument of intransitive verbs and the agent of transitive verbs. The original enclitic and adjectival endings are illustrated below..

(8)

	Premodern Aramaic	NENA (C. Qaraqosh)		
3SG.M	**qāṭel-∅*	*qaṭəl-∅*		'he kills'
3SG.F	**qāṭl-ā*	*qaṭl-a*		'she kills'
3(M)PL	**qāṭl-īn*	*qaṭl-i*		'they kill'
1SG.M	**qāṭel-∅=nā*	*qaṭəl-na*	*qaṭl-ən*	'I (M) kill'
1SG.F	**qāṭl-ā=nā*	*qaṭl-ana*	*qaṭl-an*	'I (F) kill'
2(M)PL	**qāṭl-īt=tun*	*qaṭl-itu*		'you (pl.) kill'
	etc.			

Thus, the third person D-suffixes reflect the original nominal endings **-∅*, **-ā* and **-īn* for predicative adjectives. The first and second person D-suffixes reflect a combination of these with the original enclitic equivalents of independent pronouns, e.g., 1SG **=nā* and 2PL **=tun*, which correspond to the independent pronouns**ʾānā* and **ʾattun*. For overviews and detailed discussion, see Khan (2011); Coghill (2016) and Noorlander (2021a).

In their expression of the object of the *qṭil*-stem, the D-suffixes are restricted; for examples, see §13.2.4.2. This restriction applies to geographic distribution and demographic distribution as well as grammatical distribution.

Sporadically, D-suffixes can also be used to express:

- the single argument of an intransitive past stem verb form, immediately attached to the *qṭil*-stem, as (9) illustrates, although this is not the norm across NENA dialects;
- the agent of a transitive verb, immediately attached to the *qṭil*-stem, as (9) illustrates, which occurs only in C. Bohtan.

(9) C. Bohtan (Noorlander field notes)
kpin-i *xuda xatika xil-i*
become_hungryPST-3PL:S only piece eat.PST-3PL:A
'They have become hungry and have eaten only a little bit.'

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The D-suffixes of the third person masculine singular and plural do not have near-identical morphemes elsewhere in the system, i.e., 3SG.M *-∅* and 3PL *-i*. (Strictly speaking, the 3SG.F feminine ending *-a* can be considered to be identical to the 3SG.F possessive series *-a* 'her', which occurs in several NENA dialects, cf. *našq-a* 'she kisses' and *nšaq-a* 'her kissing'.) The3PL morpheme *-i* can also occur in the inflection of the past tense enclitic copula (see §13.2.5.2), *C. Marga w-i-wa* 'they were'.

With respect to the first and second person D-suffixes, there can be considerable overlap with the forms of the copula, especially the enclitic forms. Indeed, the first and second person forms of the enclitic copula are inflected with the same endings in most dialects, typically attached to a base consisting of *ʾiw* or *ʾiy* (see §13.2.5.2 and Chapter 15 for more details). In several dialects, the D-suffixes and the enclitic copula can be morphologically identical. Thus, the dialects with the 2PL D-suffix *-itu* often have an identical equivalent form of the enclitic copula, e.g.,

(10) C. Nerwa (Noorlander field notes)

a. *le maṣ -itun ∅-paxl -itun*
NEG be_able -2PL:S SBJV-work -2PL:S
'You (PL) cannot work.'

b. *dax =itun*
HOW =COP.2PL:S
'How are you?'

13.2.2.2 "Oblique" L-suffixes

The "oblique" L-suffixes are historically derived from enclitic dative-accusative pronouns based on the preposition *l-*. Across all NENA dialects, the L-suffixes express the following syntactic functions:

- the agent of transitive verbs, attached to the past stem / *qṭil*-stem (see §13.2.4.1);
- the direct object of transitive verbs, attached to the present stem (*qaṭəl*-stem) and the imperative immediately after the inflectional endings that denote the agent (see §13.2.3).

The "oblique" L-suffixes serve as the primary endings in the inflection of the past stem verb, which ultimately goes back to an impersonal construction with enclitic dative agent indices, e.g.,

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(11)

	Premodern Aramaic	NENA (C. Qaraqosh)	
3SG.M	**qṭīl-∅=l-eh*	*qṭəl-lə*	'he killed'
3SG.F	**qṭīl-∅=l-āh*	*qṭəl-la*	'she killed'
3(M)PL	**qṭīl-∅=l-hen*	*qṭəl-hən*	'they killed'
1SG.M	**qṭīl-∅=l-ī*	*qṭəl-li*	'I killed'
1PL	**qṭīl-∅=l-an*	*qṭəl-lan*	'we (f.) killed'
	etc.		

The original M.SG of a former resultative participle, e.g., *qṭil-∅* 'he/it has been killed', has become the invariant base of a new verbal inflection. The core inflectional endings derive from enclitic person markers that ultimately have a prepositional base, e.g., *l-ī* 'to/for/by/of me', which expressed the agent of a transitive verb or the single argument of an intransitive verb. In some NENA dialects, the original reflexes of the inflection of the former resultative participle, i.e., the D-suffixes (see previous subsection), are used as object marking affixes (see §13.2.4.2) in this construction. See Khan (2004a, 2017a), Coghill (2016) and Noorlander (2021c)) with further references on the historical development of this construction.

Furthermore, depending on the dialect, the L-suffixes can express:

- the single argument of intransitive verbs, attached to a *qṭil*-stem (see §13.2.4.1);
- the direct object of transitive verbs, attached to a *qṭil*-stem verbal form immediately after the L-suffixes that denote the agent (see §13.2.4.4);
- the recipient, addressee, goal, experiencer, or external possessor for both *qaṭəl* and *qṭil* (see Chapter 24);
- the predicative possessor of a locative-exisential possessive construction, attached to an existential particle or to the copula verb *hwy* (see Chapter 24).

Moreover, in the vast majority of NENA dialects, the "oblique" L-suffixes also express third person arguments in the inflection of the enclitic and deictic present affirmative copulas. These oblique endings are directly attached to the dialect-specific copula base. (They are generally not indicated as "oblique" in the glossing, however.) Third person subjects of a present tense copula clause are thus treated identically to the direct object of a transitive present tense clause (Molin 2024: 171), e.g.,

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(12) C. Marga (Noorlander field notes)

a. *nabl-i -le l-baysa*
take-3PL:A -OBL.3SG.M:P to-house.M.SG
'They take him home.'

b. *ho -le gu baysa*
PRS.DEIC.COP -OBL.3SG.M:S house.M.SG
'He is at home.'

c. *ʾayka =y-leʔ*
where ==PRS.COP-OBL.3SG.M
'Where is he?'

In a few of these dialects, this third person *l*-copula can be identical to the aforementioned "oblique" L-series, in which case it can be enclitic, as (13) shows, or, more rarely, proclitic, as (14) illustrates.

(13) J. Dohok (Molin fieldnotes)
gurgā =le
wolf.M.SG =COP.3SG.M:S
'He is a wolf.'

(14) C. Hawdiyan (Khan, Molin and Noorlander fieldnotes)
le= pθixa
COP.3SG.M:S= open.
'It is open.'

By extension, the "oblique" L-suffixes can also be used throughout the entire inflectional paradigm of the present deictic copula, a phenomenon with a wide distribution in NENA. This is a characteristic feature of the deictic copula based on *ho-* found in the Christian NENA dialects of south-eastern Turkey and western Iraqi Kurdistan bordering on Turkey, as shown in (15) and (16). In the dialects of Txuma, this can also apply to the enclitic copula, as shown in (17).

(15) C. Nerwa (Noorlander field notes)
ho -lan gu beða
DEIC.COP -1PL in house.M.SG
'We are at home.'

(16) C. Halmun (Talay 2009: 80.64)

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dăhən ho -li go Ḥălab
now DEIC.COP -OBL.1SG:S in Aleppo
'Now I am in Aleppo.'

(17) C. Txuma Gəssa (Talay 2009: 256.68)
dus =i-lax
correct =PRS.COP-OBL.2SG.F:S
'You (F.SG) are right.'

Historically, the L-suffixes are based on the preposition *l-* that used to be inflected for person by means of the so-called pronominal suffixes. (These suffixes are referred to as the "possessive" suffixes, as they are typically used to express adnominal possession, but they also serve as pronominal complements of prepositions.) In most NENA dialects, the L-suffixes can thus be decomposed into the building blocks of an *l*-base and an additional person marking element, cf. *xmar-i* 'my donkey' and 1SG. L-suffix *-l-i*. However, in several NENA dialects, the oblique L-suffixes can correspond to and alternate with prepositional phrases based on the preposition *l-* (as well as historically distinct prepositions that merged with it, see Chapter 9), e.g.,

(18) C. Hertevin (Noorlander field notes)

a. *qare-∅ l-kalw-ew*
call-3SG:A OBL-dog.M.SG-POSS.3SG.M
'He calls for his dog.'

b. *qare-∅ -le*
call-3SG:A -OBL.3SG.M
'He calls for him.'

The preposition *l-* can also have its own set of free and bound pronouns, here referred to as the LL-series. This is an otherwise independent series that preserves the preposition *l-*, typically with gemination, e.g., 1SG *ʾəll-i*. This LL-series can, in turn, be bound and attached to a verbal host, which can make it difficult to distinguish between the L-suffixes and the LL-series in certain contexts, e.g.,

(19) J. Nerwa (Literary)

a. *ma ʾwəð-le ʾilaha ʾəll-əd ʾIyyov?*
what do.PST-OBL.3SG.M:A god.M.SG OBL-CSTR Job.M.SG
'...what God did to Job...' (Sabar 1976: 56.1)

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b. *d-ʾwəð-le -lu ʾilaha*
REL-do.PST-OBL.3SG.M:A -OBL.3PL:R god.SG.M
'...which God did to them...' (Sabar 1976: 70.8)

c. *ma ʾwəð-le ʾilaha ʾəll-ehun?*
what do.PST-OBL.3SG.M:A god.M.SG. OBL-3PL
'What did God do to them?' (Sabar 1976: 73.5)

As can be seen, for example, in the three rightmost columns and the three bottom rows in Table 13.1, the distinction between the two series tends to be more apparent in the 3SG.M and 3SG.F forms.

13.2.2.3 Mixture of "oblique" and "direct" person markers

In a few dialects, the D-suffixes have "infiltrated" the L-suffixes. In the dialect of Hertevin, this concerns both the inflection of the past stem verbal forms in specific contexts, as shown in (20a), and the deictic copula as opposed to the enclitic copula; contrast (20b) with (20c). Among Christian varieties of Txuma in south-eastern Turkey (Talay 2008b: 198, 202), this is confined to the first person plural and the second person singular copulas, cf. deictic 2SG.M *ho-l-əθ* and enclitic *(e)=l-əθ*.

(20) C. Hertevin (Noorlander field notes; see also Jastrow 1988)

a. *wəd -l-ən -ni ḥa beta*
do.PST -OBL-1SG.M:A -OBL.1SG:R a house.M.SG.
'I built a house for myself.'

b. *ho -l-aḥ b-bet-an*
COP -OBL-1PL:S in-house.M.SG-POSS.1PL
'We are at home.'

c. *ʾawa mani =le*
3SG.M who =COP.3SG.M:S
'Who is he?'

In the Jewish dialects of Iranian Azerbaijan (see Khan 2020b), the *l*-element has spread to the entire paradigm of the present affirmative copula; in this situation, the first and second person inflection takes the D-suffixes as endings, e.g.,

(21) J. Urmi (Garbell 1965b: 147)
at i -l -et ganawa!
2SG PRS.COP -OBL -2SG.M:S thief.M.SG
'You (M.SG) are the thief!'

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(22) J. Shino (Garbell 1965b: 238)
at *xalunt-i* *=l-* *at!*
2SG sister.F.SG.-POSS.1SG =PRS.COP.OBL -2SG.M:S
'You (F.SG) are my sister!'

13.2.2.4 Tense-aspect-sensitive inversion of role referencing

The inflection of the past stem, i.e., the *qṭil*-stem, is often more restricted than that of the present stem, i.e., the *qaṭəl-stem.* Throughout NENA dialects, the *qṭil*-stem is inflected for the agent by means of the "oblique" L-suffixes to denote, among other things, the past perfective tense (see Chapter 20.). In the majority of dialects, the L-suffixes also express the subject of intransitive verbs in identical fashion. In general, the role-referencing functions of the D-suffixes and L-suffixes are reversed depending on the preceding verbal stem. Thus, when attached to the present stem, the D-suffixes denote the agent and the L-suffixes the object, but with the past stem the opposite is the case, as Table 13.3 illustrates. In reality, however, the transitive inflection of *qṭil* that is the inverse of that of *qaṭəl* is restricted or impossible depending on the generation and/or location of the speakers of the NENA dialect in question (see further below).

Table 13.3: Role inversion and person marking in conservative NENA dialects

	D(irect)-suffix	Oblique L-suffix
Inflection based on present stem (*qaṭəl-*)	A, S	P, T, R
Inflection based on past stem (*qṭil-*)	P, T (S)	S, A, R,

Instead, NENA speakers, especially those belonging to the younger generations, prefer an alternative construction to express the past stem with two arguments. The pressure of competing transitive past perfective constructions has thus restricted the paradigm or resulted in its entire loss at the expense of these alternatives, at least with respect to transitive verbal coding. Two tendencies can be observed:

- the analogical extension of the transitive morphosyntax of the present stem verb forms, i.e., that of *qaṭəl*, to the transitive paradigm of the past stem verb, i.e., *qṭil*;
- the use of free direct object pronouns originating in independent dative pronouns, which, through analogy with the present stem, can develop further into enclitic pronominal objects attached to the past stem.

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As the subsections below will illustrate, innovative object markers can be used predominantly to express pronominal objects in the past perfective; this applies to the so-called LL-series and independent dative-accusative pronouns discussed in §13.2.4.5 and §13.2.5.4. Elsewhere, the transitive inflection of *qṭil* has been adapted by analogy with *qaṭəl*, in which case the object is expressed by means of L-suffixes, and, as a result of near-complete adaptation, innovative agent markers that fuse both L-suffixes and D-suffixes may be used, which only occur when there is an object L-suffix (see §13.2.2.3). This analogical extension is complete in the *qam*-perfective construction, which is found in the majority of NENA dialects. This verbal form is based on the *qaṭəl*-stem, but used for the transitive past perfective, and has to combine with a pronominal object suffix. It is used to express two verbal arguments on the verb, and is incompatible with intransitive verbs, see §13.2.4.3 below.

13.2.3 Present stem verbal inflection and the imperative: expression of pronominal object suffixes

In verb forms based on *qaṭəl*-, pronominal objects are expressed with Set II, i.e., the L-suffixes, attached to the subject inflection expressed with Set I, i.e., the D-suffixes. The initial /l/ of the L-suffix generally assimilates fully to the immediately preceding nasal /n/ of subject suffixes from Set I such as the 1SG *-an*. Depending on the dialect, the initial /l/ can also assimilate to any immediately preceding consonant of the preceding verbal suffix. The same set, i.e., the L-suffixes, are generally used to express the pronominal object of the imperative, e.g.,

(23) C. Marga

	Without object suffix	With object suffix
a.	*pasx-a*	*pasx-a-le*
	open-3SG.F:A	open-3SG.F:A-OBL.3SG.M:P
	'She opens (sth.).'	'She opens it.'
b.	*xazy-an*	*xazy-an-nax* (< **xazy-an-lax*)
	see1SG.F:A	see1SG.F:A-OBL.2SG.F:P
	'I see (sb.).'	'I see you.'
c.	*xazy-an-wa*	*xazy-an-wa-lax*
	see1SG.F:A-PST	see1SG.F:A-PST-OBL.2SG.F:P
	'I used to see (sb.).'	'I used to see you.'
d.	*psuxun*	*psuxun-ne*
	open.IMP.PL	open.IMP.PL-OBL.3SG.M:P
	'Open (pl.)!'	'Open (pl.) it!'

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In some dialects, the third person object suffixes that are attached to 1SG subject suffixes are distinct from the L-suffixes. In southeasern Trans-Zab Jewish dialects, the third person object suffixes have become identical to the possessive suffixes attached to nouns and prepositions in this context. The L-suffixes, however, may be used as usual when the tense marker *wa* intervenes between subject and object coding, e.g.,

(24) J. Saqiz (Yisraeli 1998: 116, 118)

	Without object suffix	With object suffix
a.	*našəq-∅*	*našəq-∅-la*
	kiss-3SG.M:A	kiss-3SG.M:A-OBL.3SG.F:P
	'He kisses (sb.).'	'He kisses her.'
b.	*našəq-na*	*našəq-n-av*
	kiss1SG.M:A	kiss1SG.M:A-POSS.3SG.F:P
	'I kiss (sb.).'	'I kiss her.'
c.	*našəq-na*	*našəq-na-wa-la*
	kiss1SG.M:A	kiss1SG.M:A-PST-OBL.3SG.F:P
	'I used to kiss (sb.).'	'I used to kiss her.'

When inflected for a first person singular subject, the corresponding object suffixes are based on /ay/ instead of the usual /l/ in C. Qaraqosh. The L-suffixes, however, are used instead when the past tense marker intervenes, e.g.,

(25) C. Qaraqosh (Khan 2002a: 137-138)

	Without object suffix	With object suffix
a.	*naqəš-∅*	*naqəš-∅-lə*
	'He strikes (sb.).'	'He strikes him.'
b.	*naqš-ana*	*naqš-an-ayə*
	'I strike (sb.).'	'I strike him.'
c.	*naqš-an-wa*	*naqš-an-wa-lə*
	'I would strike (sb.).'	'I would strike him.'

In the Christian dialect of Shaqlawa, the set called "enclitic copula" is used after verbal forms ending in *-un*, which includes both 2PL present and plural imperative forms. The L-suffix is employed as usual when the tense marker intervenes between the subject and object coding, e.g.,

(26) C. Shaqlawa (Khan 2021: 137-138)

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	Without object suffix	With object suffix
a.	*garəš-Ø*	*garəš-Ø-lu*
	pull-3SG.M:A	pull-3SG.M:A-OBL.3PL:P
	'He pulls.'	'He pulls them.'
b.	*garš-itun*	*garš-itun=ina*
	pull-2M.PL:A	pull-2M.PL:A=COP.3PL:P
	'You (pl.) pull.'	'You (pl.) pull them.'
c.	*garš-itun-wa*	*garš-itun-wa-lu*
	pull-3SG.M:A-PST	pull-3SG.M:A-PST-OBL.3PL:P
	'You (pl.) used to pull.'	'You (pl.) used to pull them.'

13.2.4 Past stem verbal inflection: constructions based on *qṭil*

Table 13.4: Main patterns in transitive verbal person marking across NENA

	A	P	Example
qaṭəl-stem	D-suffix	L-suffix	C. Marga *qaṭl-ux-le* 'We kill him.'
qamqaṭəl-stem	D-suffix	L-suffix	C. Nerwa *qəmqaṭl-əx-le* 'We killed him.'
qṭil-stem	D-suffix	L-suffix	C. Bohtan *qṭil-ax-le* 'We killed him.'
qṭil-stem	LD-suffix	L-suffix	C. Hertevin *qṭəl-laḥ-le* 'We have killed him.'
qṭil-stem	L-suffix	L-suffix	J. Urmi *qṭəl-le-lan* 'He killed us.'
qṭil-stem	L-suffix	LL-series	C. Ashitha *qṭəl-le=llan* 'He killed us.'
qṭil-stem	L-suffix	Indep. Dat-Acc.	C. Urmi *kat-an qṭəl-lə* 'He killed us.'
qṭil-stem	L-suffix	D-suffix	C. Marga *qṭil-ux-le* 'He killed us.'

13.2.4.1 Transitivity and past stem inflectional endings

Depending on the dialect, the set of verbal person markers used to express the subject and/or agent can vary depending on grammatical and semantic factors such as tense-aspectual properties, semantic or lexical transitivity, and morphosyntactic transitivity.

In a few NENA dialects, Set I, i.e., the D-suffixes, can serve as subject endings to inflect the *qṭil-stem*. This is confined to resultative and/or perfect forms of single argument verbs. Subject orientation is maintained for intransitive verbs, but a shift to patient orientation is regularly observed for transitive verbs. Agent orientation is thus generally incompatible with D-suffixes attached to the *qṭil*-stem, e.g.,

(27) J. Koy Sanjak (Mutzafi 2004a)

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Table 13.5: Dedicated marking of S and/or A

	D-suffix	L-suffix
Tense-Aspect Properties:	Resultative-Stative Perfect	Dynamic Past Perfective
Lexical Transitivity:	Intransitive	Transitive
Morphosyntactic Transitivity:	Agent with pronominal object	Agent without pronominal object

	Dynamic Intransitive	Stative Intransitive
	Past Perfective	Present Perfect/Resultative
	L-suffix	D-suffix
a.	*dmix-lu*	*dmix-i*
	sleep.PST-OBL.3PL:S	sleep.3PL:S
	'They fell asleep.'	'They have fallen/are asleep.'
b.	*pliṭ-la*	*pliṭ-a*
	go_out-OBL.3SG.F:S	go_out-3SG.F:S
	'She went out.'	'She has gone/is out.'
c.	*ṛxiš-li*	*ṛxiš-an*
	walk.PST-OBL.1SG:S	walk.PST-1SG.F:S
	'I walked.'	'I have walked.'
d.	*xil-le*	*xil-∅*
	eat.PST-OBL.3SG.M:S	eat.PST-3SG.M:S
	'He ate (sth.).'	'It has been eaten (by sb.).'

In the dialects of Bohtan (Fox 2009), by contrast, transitive verbs always maintain agent orientation, e.g.,

(28) C. Bohtan (Fox 2009)

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	"Dynamic" Transitive	"Stative" Transitive
	Past Perfective	Present Perfect/Resultative
	L-suffix	D-suffix
a.	*qṭəl-lā*	*qṭil-i*
	kill.PST-OBL.3PL:A	kill.PST-3PL:A
	'They killed (sb.).'	'They have killed (sb.).'
b.	*mupləṭ-le*	*mupləṭ-∅*
	take_out.PST-OBL.3SG.M:A	take_out.PST-3SG.M:A
	'He took out (sth.).'	'He has taken out (sth.).'
c.	*xəl-le*	*xil-∅*
	eat.PST-OBL.3SG.M:A	eat.3SG.M:A
	'He ate (sth.).'	'He has eaten (sth.).'

In the south-eastern Trans-Zab subgroup of J. NENA dialects, the L-suffixes are incompatible with verbs that take an intransitive past stem, and the D-suffixes must be used instead (see Hopkins 2002, Khan 2007b). The L-suffixes combine with dedicated transitive past stems, and the D-suffixes with dedicated intransitive past stems, e.g.,

(29) J. Saqiz (Yisraeli 1998)

	Transitive A	Intransitive S
	L-suffix	D-suffix
a.	*mədməx-lu*	*dmix-i*
	sleep.CAUS.PST-OBL.3PL:A	sleep.INTR.PST-3PL:S
	'They put (sb.) to sleep.'	'They fell asleep.'
b.	*pləṭ-la*	*pliṭ-a*
	move_out.TRZR.PST-OBL.3SG.F	move_out.INTR.PST-3SG.F:S
	'She let (sb.) go out.'	'She went out.'

Lexically transitive verbs thus have to be detransitivised by means of the intransitive past stem in order to be compatible with the D-suffixes, in which case they most often have patient orientation, rarely agent orientation (see Khan 2007b, Coghill 2016 and Noorlander 2021a), e.g.,

(30) J. Saqiz (Yisraeli 1998)

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	Transitive A	Intransitive S
	L-suffix	D-suffix
a.	*nšəq-lu*	*nšiq-i*
	kiss.PST-OBL.3PL:A	kiss.DTRZR.PST-3PL:S
	'They kissed.'	'They were kissed (by sb.).'
b.	*xəl-le*	*xil-∅*
	eat.PST-OBL.3SG.M:A	eat.DTRZR.PST-3SG.M:S
	'He ate (sth.).'	'It was eaten (by sth.).'

In the western periphery, the inflectional morphemes used to express the agent are modified when a pronominal object suffix is added. At times, this is merely allomorphic and the result of morphophonology, as in the case of the alternation between /a/ and /o/ reflecting historical vowel lengthening upon adding the object suffix, e.g., C. Jinnet *ʾaḥl-a* 'She eats' : *ʾaḥl-o-le* (< **ʾaḥl-ā-le*) 'She eats them' and *ḥəl-la* 'She ate' : *ḥəl-lo-le* ((< **ḥəl-ā-le*)) 'She ate them'. However, partial adaptation of the transitive morphosyntax of *qṭil* to that of *qaṭəl* has resulted in a major morphological distinction between the coding of the agent in the absence of a pronominal object suffix and the coding of the agent in the presence of a pronominal object suffix. A special set of person markers for second person agents and sometimes also first person agents is used to inflect *qṭil* only in combination with a pronominal object. This special ergative set is based on an /l/-element like an L-suffix, but takes person marking morphemes from the D-suffixes as in the inflection of *qaṭəl*, for example, *-l-* plus *-at* for the 2SG.F agent, which is distinct from the oblique L-suffix *-laḥ*, e.g.,

(31) C. Jinnet (Noorlander fieldnotes)

	Without object suffix	With object suffix
Present:	D-suffix	D-suffix
a.	*ʾaḥl-at*	*ʾaḥl-at-te*
	eat-2SG.F:A	eat-2SG.F:A-OBL.3PL:P
	'You (F.SG) eat (sth.).'	'You (F.SG) eat them.'
Past:	L-suffix	L + D-suffix
b.	*ḥəl-laḥ*	*ḥəl-lat-te*
	eat.PST-OBL.2SG.F:A	eat.PST-ERG.2SG.F:A-OBL.3PL:P
	'You (F.SG) ate (sth.).'	'You (F.SG) ate them.'

The *qam*-perfective construction mentioned in §13.2.4.3 also properly belongs here. In a considerable number of dialects, the inflection of *qṭil* is entirely confined to transitive clauses without a pronominal object. When the pronominal object is attached, the entire verbal form is modified to that of *qaṭəl* with an additional preverbal TAM marker, e.g.,

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(32) C. Nerwa (Noorlander field notes, see also Talay 2001)

	Without object suffix	With object suffix
Present:	D-suffix	D-suffix
a.	*y-axl-at*	*y-axl-at-tey*
	IND-eat-2SG.F:A	IND-eat-2SG.F:A-OBL.3PL:P
	'You (F.SG) eat (sth.).'	'You (F.SG) eat them.'
Past:	L-suffix	qam + D-suffix
b.	*xəl-lax*	*qəm-axl-at-tey*
	eat.PST-OBL.2SG.F:A	PST.TRZR-eat-2SG.F:A-OBL.3PL:P
	'You (F.SG) ate (sth.).'	'You (F.SG) ate them.'

13.2.4.2 Pronominal object expressed by D-suffixes

Across NENA dialects, the object may be expressed by Set I, i.e., the D-suffixes. This set always precedes Set II, i.e., the L-suffixes, which denote the agent, e.g.,

(33) C. Marga (Khan and Noorlander fieldnotes)

a. Past stem verb without object suffix
qṭəl -le
kill.PST -OBL.3SG.M:A
'He killed (sb.).'

b. Past stem verb with object suffix
qṭil -a -le
kill.PST -3SG.F:P -OBL.3SG.M:A
'He killed her.'

c. Past stem verb without object suffix
mpuləṭ -lax
move_out.TRZR.PST -OBL.2SG.F:A
'You let (sb.) go out.'

d. Past stem verb with object suffix
mpulṭ -an -nax
move_out.TRZR.PST -1SG.F:P -OBL.2SG.F:A
'You let me go out.'

In the majority of NENA dialects, however, object inflection with D-suffixes is restricted to third person objects, while first and second person objects are expressed through alternative means. In a few dialects in the western sector, the L-suffixes denoting the agent can be omitted. When the agent argument is co-referentially deleted, only the pronominal object coding remains. This is strictly

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confined to constructions where the pronominal object is expressed by D-suffixes. For the syntactic conditions under which this occurs, see §21.2.2.4 and 21.2.3.4. Examples:

(34) C. Marga (Noorlander fieldnotes)

a. Past stem verb with agent suffix
qṭil -a -le
kill.PST -3SG.F:P -OBL.3SG.M:A
'He killed her.'

b. Past stem verb without agent suffix
qṭil -a
kill.PST -3SG.F:P
'(He/she/it/they) killed her.'

c. Past stem verb with agent suffix
mpulṭ -an -nay
move_out.TRZR.PST -1SG.F:P -OBL.3PL:A
'They let me go out.'

d. Past stem verb without agent suffix
mpulṭ -an
move_out.TRZR.PFV -1SG.F:P
'(He/she/it/they) let me go out.'

In most of the Trans-Zab Jewish dialects of NENA, the transitive verb undergoes stem modification from *nšiq-* or *nšəq* to *nəšq-* when the D-suffixes are added to express the object. In such cases, the L-suffixes expressing the agent can never be omitted, e.g.,

(35) J. Saqiz (Yisraeli 1998)

a. *nšəq -lu* → *nəšq* ***-a*** *-lu*
kiss.PST -OBL.3PL:A kiss.PST -3SG.F:P -OBL.3PL:A
'They kissed (sb.).' → 'They kissed **her**.'

b. *pləṭ -la* → *pəlṭ* ***-i*** *-la*
move_out.PST -OBL.3SG.F:A move_out.PST -3PL:P -OBL.3SG.F:A
'She let (sb.) go out.' → 'She let **them** go out.'

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13.2.4.3 Pronominal object impossible: transitive *qam*-perfective construction based on *qaṭəl-*

Across the entire NENA-speaking area, with the exception of the western periphery, the vast majority of Christian dialects use a dedicated transitive past perfective construction based entirely upon *qaṭəl* in order to express the object by means of L-suffixes. This also holds true for the Jewish NENA dialects (known also as *Lišana Deni*) located north-west of the Great Zab river. In this transitive construction, the preverbal modifier *qam* or a dialect-dependent variant thereof is prefixed to the verbal stem *qaṭəl-* and the agent is expressed through D-suffixes, e.g., *qəm-garəš-∅-la* 'He pulled her'. The morphosyntax is thus identical to that of the transitive coding for the present. This *qam*-construction is only compatible with lexically transitive verbs, and nearly always occurs *with* an object suffix. It is in complementary distribution with *qṭəlle*, which occurs *without* an object suffix. In many of these dialects, the *qam*-construction is the only means available to form a past perfective construction with both an agent and object index, e.g.,

(36) C. Nerwa (Noorlander field notes)

a. Past perfective clause without pronominal object suffix
qṭəl -le
kill.PST -OBL.3SG.M:A
'He killed (sb.).' (Lit. 'Him killed.')

b. Past perfective clause with pronominal object suffix
qəm-qaṭəl -∅ -lax
PST.TRZR-kill -3SG.M:A -OBL.2SG.F:P
'He killed you.'

c. Past perfective clause without pronominal object suffix
mpuləṭ -lax
move_out.PST.TRZR -OBL.2SG.F:A
'You let (sb.) go out.'

d. Past perfective clause with pronominal object suffix
qəm-palṭ -at -te
PST.TRZR-move_out -2SG.F:A -OBL.3SG.M:P
'You let him go out.'

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13.2.4.4 Pronominal object expressed by L-suffixes

In several dialects, especially in the western periphery in SE Turkey, the pronominal object indices are expressed by the same set as that of the agent, i.e., the L-suffixes. The second L-suffix, which denotes the object, is attached to the first L-suffix, which denotes the agent, e.g.,

(37) C. Bohtan (Fox 2009)

a. *ġzi -li* → *ġzi -li -le*
see.PST -OBL.1SG:A see.PST -OBL.1SG:A -OBL.3SG.M:P
'I saw (sb.).' → 'I saw him.' (Lit. 'Me saw him.')

b. *ġze -le* → *ġze -le -li*
see.PST -OBL.3SG.M:A see.PST -OBL.3SG.M:A -OBL.1SG:P
'He saw (sb.).' → 'He saw me.' (Lit. 'Him saw me.')

This parallels the verbal inflection in Central Neo-Aramaic dialects further west. In Ṭuroyo, this is the typical construction for first and second person objects, e.g.,

(38) Ṭuroyo

a. *ḥze -li* → *ḥze -li -lax*
seePST -OBL.1SG:A seePST -OBL.1SG:A -OBL.2SG.F:P
'I saw (sb.).' → 'I saw you.' (Lit. 'Me saw you.')

b. *ḥze -lax* → *ḥze -lax -li*
seePST -OBL.2SG.F:A seePST -OBL.2SG.F:A -OBL.1SG:P
'You saw (sb.).' → 'You saw me.' (Lit. 'You saw me.')

In some NENA dialects of the western periphery, the addition of the object marking L-suffix requires a special verbal form, on which see §13.2.4.1.

13.2.4.5 Pronominal object expressed by bound LL-series

In most of the Trans-Zab Jewish dialects, pronominal objects are typically expressed by Set III, i.e., the LL-series, which cliticises to the immediately preceding agent marker, e.g.,

(39) J. Koy Sanjak (Mutzafi 2004a: 100)

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a. Past stem verb without object suffix
   nšəq -le
   kiss.PST -OBL.3SG.M:A
   'He kissed (sb.).' (Lit. 'Him kissed.')
b. Past stem verb with object suffix
   nšəq -le =ll-i
   kiss.PST -OBL.3SG.M:A =OBJ-1SG
   'He kissed me.' (Lit. 'Him kissed to-me.')
c. Past stem verb without object suffix
   nšəq -li
   kiss.PST -OBL.1SG:A
   'I kissed (sb.).' (Lit. 'Me kissed.')
d. Past stem verb with object suffix
   nšəq -li =ll-ew
   kiss.PST -OBL.1SG:A =OBJ-3M.SG
   'I kissed him.' (Lit. 'Me kissed to-him.')

This is also common in the Christian dialects of the Hakkari region (SE Turkey). The LL-series are ultimately derived from free prepositional pronouns that cliticised to the immediately preceding verbal form (see §13.2.2.2 and Chapter 9), e.g.,

(40) C. Ashitha (Borghero 2005: 193)

a. Past stem verb without object suffix
   xze -le
   see.PST -OBL.3SG.M:A
   'He saw (sb.).' (Lit. 'Him saw.')
b. Past stem verb with object suffix
   xze -le =ll-ən
   see.PST -OBL.3SG.M:A =OBJ-1PL
   'He saw us.' (Lit. 'Him saw to-us.')
c. Past stem verb without object suffix
   xze -le
   see.PST -OBL.3SG.M:A
   'He saw (sb.).' (Lit. 'Him saw.')
d. Past stem verb with free pronominal object (slow speech)

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xze *-le* *ʾəll-ən*
see.PST -OBL.3SG.M:A OBJ-1PL
'He saw us.' (Lit. 'Him saw to-us.')

In numerous dialects, the LL-series may become identical to the L-suffixes as a result of the loss of gemination, i.e., *=lli* > *=li*. A core difference between the two may be observed in the third person only, e.g., 3SG.M LL-series *=llew* > *=llew* vs. 3SG.M L-suffix *-le*. Thus, the third person masculine singular object can still be morphologically distinct from the third person masculine singular agent, e.g.,

(41) Hakkari (Talay 2011: 56-57)

	Verbal Stem	Agent L-suffixes	Object LL-series	
Upper Barwar	*xze*	*-le*	*=l-u*	'He saw him.'
Ṭal	*xze*	*-le*	*=l-ew*	'Idem.'
Baz	*xze*	*-le*	*=l-əv*	'Idem.'

13.2.4.6 Pronominal object expressed by innovated object markers (free pronominal objects)

The LL-series are ultimately derived from free prepositional pronouns and can still occur as such, especially when the pronoun is accentuated, e.g.,

(42) C. Upper Ṭyari (Walṭo, SE Turkey; Talay 2009: 34.12)
prəm *-le* *ʾəll-e* *did-e*
slaughter.PST -OBL.3SG.M:A OBJ-3M.SG GEN-3M.SG
'He killed *him*.'

(43) J. Koy Sanjak (Mutzafi 2004a: 191.21)
ʾəll-əd *did-ew* *məxḷəṣ* *-ḷe.*
OBJ-CSTR GEN-3M.SG save.PST -OBL.3SG.M:A
'*Him* he spared.'

Christian dialects in the northern sector typically express the pronominal object of past stem verb forms by using free pronouns based on a differential object marker that syncretises dative and accusative case (see §9.2 and 21.2.3.4). In some of these dialects, this is the only means of expressing a pronominal object in clauses based on past stem verbs, in which case these pronouns need not be prosodically or pragmatically prominent, e.g.,

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(44) C. Sardarid (NW Iran; Younansardaroud 2001: 205, 232.4, transcription modified)
may xzi -lə qa- diy-+ux
who see.PST -OBL.3SG.M:A OBJ- GEN-2M.SG
'Who saw you?'

(45) C. Van (Hawshesur, SE Turkey; Noorlander field notes)
ġzi- l ṭal- ox
see.PST -OBL.3SG.M:A OBJ -2.SG.M
'He saw you.'

13.2.4.7 Distribution of pronominal object expressions in past stem verb forms

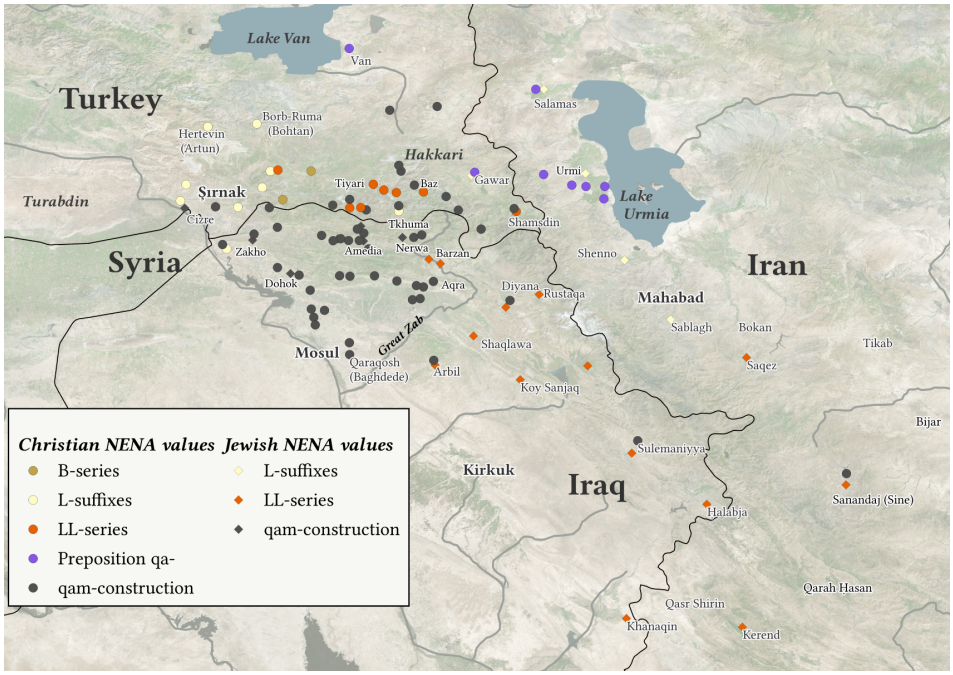

Figure 13.1: Distribution of bound object person marking sets in past stem verb forms in NENA (excluding D-suffixes)

Figures 13.1 and 13.2 show the areal distribution of pronominal objects of past perfective clauses:

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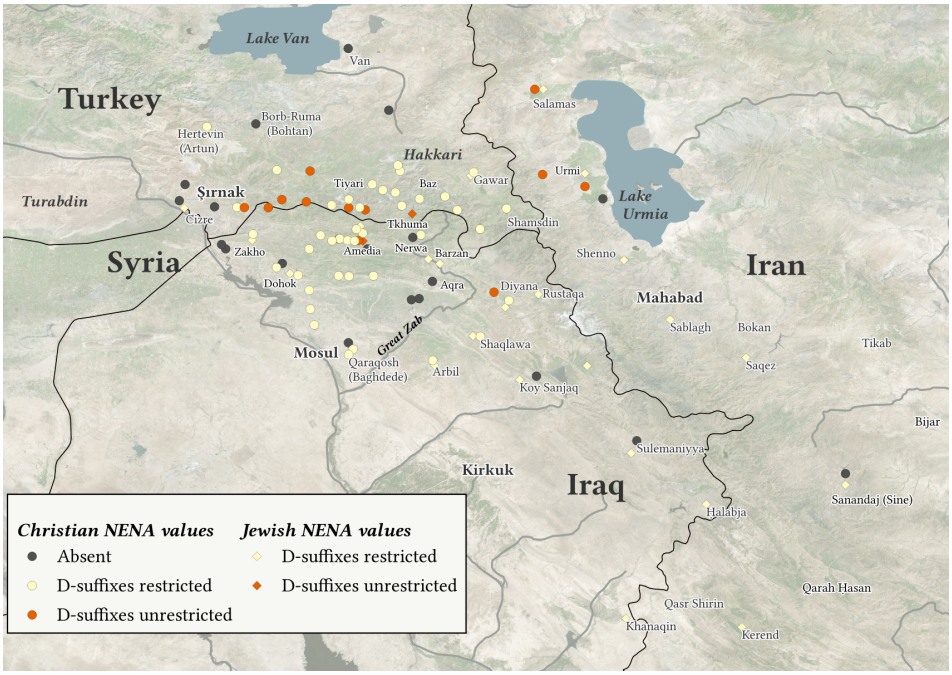

Figure 13.2: Distribution of D-suffixes as object markers in past stem verb forms in NENA

- D-suffixes (Sub§13.2.4.2): this set is found across the entire region, but mostly restricted to the third person; an unrestricted paradigm is typical of a few conservative dialects in the north-western sector;
- L-suffixes (Sub§13.2.4.4): primarily among Christian dialects of south-eastern Anatolia and Jewish dialects of Iranian Azerbaijan;
- *qam*-construction (Sub§13.2.4.3): this occurs throughout the NENA-speaking area, but is notably absent among Trans-Zab Jewish NENA dialects;
- LL-series (Sub§13.2.4.5): this is typical of Trans-Zab Jewish NENA, but also occurs among Christian dialects in the Hakkari Province of Turkey;
- free person markers (Sub§13.2.4.6): the use of free pronominal objects, in particular those based on the preposition *qa-*, is more common in Christian dialects of the northern periphery.

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13.2.5 Complex perfect and progressive

Complex verb phrases are innovations within the verbal system that serve as originally periphrastic perfect and/or progressive constructions. In NENA, complex verb phrases consist of

- a main verb: an originally nominal, i.e., nonfinite, form of the verb, such as a participle, infinitive, or agent noun;
- a BE-auxiliary: a form that was originally a copula that functions as an auxiliary and serves to inflect the verb for person;
- an object coding strategy: if available, a relevant strategy for pronominal object coding attached to the main verb or to the auxiliary.

13.2.5.1 Core verbal forms in complex perfects and progressives

The strategy for expressing the perfect discussed here involves the combination of a resultative participle with a copula. The expression of the perfect, however, varies significantly across NENA dialects, on which see further Chapter 16. The same variability holds true for the progressive, on which see further Chapter 19. The progressive discussed in this section is that based on the infinitive. The forms of the resultative participle and the infinitive in the majority of NENA dialects are illustrated in Table 13.6. In the Trans-Zab Jewish dialects of NENA located in the south-east, there are two derivations that show a transitivity distinction in their stem morphology, which is illustrated in Table 13.7.

Table 13.6: Typical inflection of nominal forms of the verb in NENA

		Stem I	Stem II	Stem III
Resultative	M.SG	*qṭil-a*	*mquṭl-a*	*muqṭl-a*
Participle	FS	*qṭil-ta*	*mquṭal-ta*	*muqṭal-ta*
	PL	*qṭil-e*	*mquṭl-e*	*muqṭl-e*
Infinitive		*qṭala*	*qaṭola*	*maqṭole*

13.2.5.2 The copula/auxiliary as person marker

The copula serves as an auxiliary in complex perfects and progressives, and is highly variable within and across NENA dialects. Further details concerning the

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Table 13.7: Nominal forms of *smx* 'to wait', *šql* 'to buy', *skr* 'to get lost', and *rdx* 'to boil' in J. Sulemaniyya (Khan 2004b: 99-101

		Stem I		Stem III	
		Intransitive	Transitive	Intransitive	Transitive
		smx 'wait'	*šql* 'buy'	*skr* 'get lost'	*rdx* 'boil (sth.)'
Resultative	M.SG	*smixa*	*šəqla*	*məskira*	*mrədxa*
Participle	F.SG	*smixta*	*šqəlta*	*məskirta*	*mərdəxta*
	PL	*smixe*	*šəqle*	*məskire*	*mrədxe*
Infinitive		*samoxa*	*šaqola*	*maskora*	*mardoxa*

syntax and moprhology of the copula in NENA dialects can be found in Chapter 15. Table 13.9 offers an example paradigm of the copula in a NENA dialect. Table 13.10 illustrates the forms of a realis complex perfect in the Christian dialect of Nerwa.

Generally, dialects have an enclitic copula for affirmative past and present tense clauses, alongside independent counterparts used in other contexts, namely deictic copulas, negated copulas, and the copula verb *hwy ʾvy* 'to be', which is typically used in modal complements, as well as future tense, habitual and imperative clause types. All of these forms can serve as auxiliaries in complex verb forms.

Depending on the dialect, the inflection of the copula partly overlaps with the D-suffixes and L-suffixes. In the majority of NENA dialects, the third person copula tends to have endings that are identical to the L-suffixes, e.g., *=(i)le* 'he is'. Among the Christian dialects, the L-suffixes rarely encroach on the subject inflection of complex verbal forms. In the Gəssa variety of Txuma, however, the subject inflection of complex verb forms has become identical with that of the past stem verb forms. The L-suffixes have been generalised across all verb forms, as illustrated in Table 13.11.

More generally, however, we observe a tendency to extend the inflection of the present stem verb forms to that of complex verb forms by changing the shape of the copula to adapt them to the match the D-suffixes in the first and second person forms. Across NENA dialects, the resultative participle can be combined with either a shortened or a full form of the copula. The shortened form of the copula can be very similar to the D-suffixes, and can even become identical to them, cf. C. Nerwa 2SG.M present subjunctive *šaql-at* 'that you may take' and 2SG.M progressive *šqal=ət* alongside *šqale=wət* 'you are taking'.

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In the Jewish dialects of the northern sector of the NENA-speaking region, the full copula has an *l*-element that is generalised for all persons, e.g., J. Urmi 3pl *=ilu* 'they are' and 1PL *=ilex* 'we are', which is restricted to the third person in other NENA dialects, e.g., J. Dohok 3pl *'ilu, =lu* 'they are' vs. 1PL *=wax* (see §13.2.2.2). The phonetic reduction of the copula is strongest in the Jewish dialects of Urmi and Salamas in Iranian Azerbaijan, whereas in the Jewish dialects of Bashqala and Gawar in south-eastern Turkey, the full form can be preserved in all contexts (Garbell 1965b: 69; Khan 2008b), as shown in Table 13.8. Through this phonetic reduction, the forms of the first and second person become identical to the D-suffixes, cf. 1SG.M D-suffix *-en* in *garš-en* 'I (m.) pull', and that of the third person overlaps with the possessive suffixes, cf. *-u* 'their' in *bel-u* 'their house'.

Table 13.8: Gradual phonetic reduction of the copula person markers in the Jewish NENA dialects of Iranian Azerbaijan (Garbell 1965b: 69)

	J. Urmi/Salamas	J. Shino/Solduz	J. Bashqala/Gawar
1SG.M	*griš-en* 'I (M.SG) have pulled (sth.)'	*griš-len*	*griš-e=len*
3PL	*griš-u* 'They have pulled (sth.).'	*griš-lu*	*griš-e=lu*

Table 13.9: The paradigm of the copula person markers in NENA illustrated with the forms in J. Koy Sanjak (Mutzafi 2004a: 83, 115)

Person	Present	Past	Subjunctive	Negative (present)
1SG.M	*=wen*	*weli*	*hawen*	*lewen*
1SG.F	*=wan*	*weli*	*hawyan*	*lewan*
1PL	*=wex*	*welan*	*hawex*	*lewex*
2SG.M	*=wet*	*welox*	*hawet*	*lewet*
2SG.F	*=wat*	*welax*	*hawyat*	*lewat*
2PL	*=wetūn*	*welxūn*	*hawetūn*	*lewetūn*
3SG.M	*=ile*	*wele*	*hawe*	*lewe*
3SG.F	*=ila*	*wela*	*hawya*	*lewa*
3PL	*=ilu, =en*	*welu*	*haweni*	*lewu*

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Table 13.10: Complex perfects illustrated with the verb *šql* 'to take' in C. Nerwa

	Participle + Enclitic Copula	Deictic Copula + Participle
3SG.M	*šqile=le,*	*hole šqila*
3SG.F	*šqəlte=la*	*hola šqəlta*
3PL	*šqile=ley*	*holey šqile*
2SG.F	*šqəlte=wat, šqəlt=at*	*holax šqəlta*
1PL	*šqile=wəx, šqil=əx*	*holan šqile*

Table 13.11: Complex verbal forms illustrated with the verb *dry* 'to put' in C. Txuma-Gəssa (Talay 2008a)

	Past	Perfect	Progressive
3SG.M	*dre-le*	*dərye=le*	*bdare=le*
1SG.M	*dre-li*	*dərye=li*	*bdare=li*
1PL	*dre-lan*	*dərye=lan*	*bdare=lan*

Table 13.12: Complex progressives across J. NENA illustrated with the verb *grš* 'to pull'

	J. Dohok	J. Koy Sanjak	J. Urmi	J. Sulemaniyya
3SG.M	*wele bəgraša*	*graša=le*	*garöš-e*	*garoša=y*
3SG.F	*wela bəgraša*	*graša=la*	*garöš-a*	*garoša=ya*
3PL	*welu bəgraša*	*graša=lu*	*garöš-u*	*garoše=n*

Table 13.13: Complex progressives across C. NENA dialects illustrated with the verb *grš* 'to pull'

	C. Hawdiyan	C. Urmi	C. Nerwa
3SG.M	*le bəgraša*	*bəgrašə=lə*	*hole graša*
3SG.F	*la bəgraša*	*bəgrašə=la*	*hola graša*
3PL	*na bəgraše*	*bəgrašə=na*	*holay graša*

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Table 13.14: Person marking in complex transitive perfects across NENA dialects (where 'Agreement' stands for participial agreement)

A	P	Example
Agreement + Copula	L-suffix	J. Urmi *ʿqtil-ta hawya-lan* 'She would have killed us.'
L-suffix	Agreement + Copula	C. Kerend *qṭəl-t=awya-lan* 'We would have killed her.'
Agreement + Copula	Possessive	C. Qaraqosh *qṭil-aḥ=iyyax* 'Have we killed her?'
Copula	Agreement + Possessive	J. Sulemaniyya *qṭəl-t-aw=iyex* 'We have killed her.'
Agreement + Copula	LL-series	C. Marga *hola qṭəl-t=əllan* 'She has killed us.'
Agreement + Copula	B-series	C. Harbole *hola qṭəl-ta biyan* 'She has killed us.'
∅	Agreement + Copula	C. Kerend *qṭəlta=ya* '(He/she/they) have killed her.'

13.2.5.3 Pronominal object expressed by possessive suffixes

Across NENA dialects, the object can be expressed by means of possessive suffixes, which are always attached to an originally nominal form of the verb, and never to the copula, e.g.,

(46) C. Diyana (Napiorkowska 2015: 211-212)

a. Complex progressive without object suffix
hole *ptaxa*
DEIC.COP.3SG.M:A open.PROG
'He is opening (sth.).'

b. Complex progressive with object suffix
hole *ptax* *-o*
DEIC.COP.3SG.M:A open.PROG -POSS.3SG.F:P
'He is opening it (f.).' (Lit. 'He is its opening.')

c. Complex perfect without object suffix
ptix *-te* *=la*
open.RES.PTCP -F.SG:A =PRS.COP.3.F.SG:A
'She has opened (sth.).'

d. Complex perfect with object suffix
ptix *-t* *-u* *=la*
open.RES.PTCP -F.SG:A -POSS.3PL:P =COP.3SG.F:A
'She has opened them (F).' (Lit. 'She is their opened.')

(47) J. Sulemaniyya (Khan 2004b: 138, 139)

a. Complex progressive without object suffix
garoša *=y*
pull.PROG =COP.3SG.M:A
'He is pulling.'

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b. Complex progressive with object suffix
garoš -aw =ye
pull.PROG -POSS.3SG.F:P =COP.3SG.M:A
'He is pulling her.' (Lit. 'He is her pulling.')

c. Complex perfect without object suffix
qṭil -ta =ya
kill.RES.PTCP -F.SG:A =PRS.COP.3SG.F:A
'She has killed (sb.).'

d. Complex perfect with object suffix
qṭil -t -u =ya
kill.RES.PTCP -F.SG:A -POSS.3PL:P =COP.3SG.F:A
'She has killed them (F).' (Lit. 'She is their killed.')

In J. Sulemaniyya and Ḥalabja, this strategy is confined to third person objects (Khan 2004b: 138, 139), and in J. Koy Sanjak, it is confined to third person agents (Mutzafi 2004a, Noorlander 2021a), see Sub§13.2.6.

13.2.5.4 Pronominal object expressed by LL-series or B-series

If the LL-series expresses the pronominal object, it is generally attached to the main verb, e.g.,

(48) C. Marga (Noorlander field notes)

a. Complex progressive without object suffix
hole ptaxa
DEIC.COP.3SG.M:A open.PROG
'He is opening (sth.).'

b. Complex progressive with object suffix
*hole ptax **=əll-a***
DEIC.COP.3SG.M:A open.PROG =OBJ-3SG.F
'He is opening it (f.).'

When the agent person marker, i.e., the enclitic auxiliary, is not preverbal, but attaches to the verbal host, the LL-series denoting the P argument can attach to either the auxiliary or the main verb, depending on the dialect, e.g,

(49) C. Nerwa (Noorlander field notes)
qṭil =ən =əll-ax
kill.RES.PTCP.M.SG:A =COP.1SG:A =OBJ-2SG.F
'I have killed you.'

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(50) C. Ashitha (Borghero 2005)
qṭil *=əll-ax* *=iwən*
kill.RES.PTCP.M.SG:A =OBJ-2F.SG =COP.1SG.M:A
'I have killed you.'

The same holds true for the pronominal object clitics based on the preposition *b-*, which can be referred to as the B-series. Here, the object coding typically follows the enclitic copula of the first and second persons, but may precede that of the third person singular (Talay 2008a: 321) (see §13.2.6), e.g.,

(51) C. Mazṛa (Talay 2008a: 321)

a. *xəzy-e* *=wəx* *=əbb-e*
see.RES.PTCP-PL:A =COP.1PL:A =OBJ-3SG.M:P
'We have seen it (m.).'

b. *griš* *=əbb-e* *=le*
pull.RES.PTCP.M.SG:A =OBJ-3SG.M:P =COP.3SG.M:A
'He has pulled it.'

For both of these, it is possible for the third person copulas to be elided in fast speech or simply dropped altogether, so that the only remaining coding of the agent is the participle, e.g.,

(52) C. Mazṛa (Talay 2008a: 321)
prim-e *=le* → *prim*
slaughter.RES.PTCP-M.SG:A =COP.3SG.M:A slaughter.RES.PTCP.M.SG:A
=əbbe
=3sg.m:P
'He has slaughtered (sb.).' → 'He has slaughtered him.'

13.2.5.5 Pronominal object expressed by L-suffixes

L-suffixes can be attached to the auxiliary to express the pronominal object, e.g.,

(53) J. Koy Sanjak (Mutzafi 2004a)

a. *nšiq* *-a* *=wen* → *nšiqa* *=wen*
kiss.RES.PTCP -F.SG:A =COP.1SG.M kiss.RES.PTCP =COP.1SG.M
-nax
-2SG.F:P
'I have kissed (sb.).' → 'I have kissed you.'

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b. *plaxa =wex* → *plaxa =wex -xa*
open.PROG =COP.1PL:A open.PROG =COP.1PL:A -3SG.F:P
'We are opening.' → 'We are opening it (F).'

(54) J. Urmi (Khan 2008b: 140-143)

a. Complex verb without object suffix
qaṭol =en
kill.PROG =COP.1SG.M:A
'I am killing (sb.).'

b. Complex verb with object suffix
qaṭol =en -nax
kill.PROG =COP.1SG.M:A -2SG.F:P
'I am killing you.'

c. Complex verb without object suffix
qaṭola =weli
kill.PROG =be.PST.1SG:A
'I was killing (sb.).'

d. Complex verb with object suffix
qaṭol =en -wa -le ~ *qaṭola =weli*
kill.PROG =COP.1SG:A -PST -OBL.3SG.M:P kill.PROG =be.PST.1SG:A
-le
-OBL.3SG.M:P
'I was killing him.'

e. Complex verb without object suffix
griš -ta =hawy-a
pull.RES.PTCP -F.SG:A =be.PRS.SBJV-3SG.F:A
'She would have pulled (sb.).'

f. Complex verb with object suffix
griš -ta =hawy-a -li
pull.RES.PTCP -F.SG:A =be.PRS.SBJV-3SG.F:A -OBL.1SG:P
'She would have pulled me.'

L-suffixes can also be immediately attached to the main verbal component of the complex perfect. This is the case in the J. Barzani negative present perfect, e.g.,

(55) J. Barzani (Mutzafi 2002a: 65)

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a. *lewe* *šdir-a* *-le*
NEG.COP.3SG.M:A send.RES.PTCP-M.SG:A -3SG.M:P
'He has not sent him.'

b. *lewe* *gzir* *-a* *-le*
NEG.COP.3SG.M:A circumcise.RES.PTCP-M.SG:A -3SG.M:P
'He has not circumcised him.'

13.2.5.6 Pronominal object expressed by innovated object markers (free pronominal objects)

The LL-series or B-series can occur independently as object pronouns, e.g.,

(56) C. Harbole (Khan field notes)
holi *griš-a* *biy-aw*
DEIC.COP.1SG:A pull.RES.PTCP-M.SG:A OBJ-3SG.F
'I have pulled her.' (Lit. 'I am sent at her.')

In J. Zakho, the independent genitive can be used to express the pronominal object of a complex verb form, e.g.,

(57) J. Zakho
ʾile *mšudr-a* *did-i*
COP.3SG.M:A send.TRZR.RES.PTCP-M.SG:A GEN-1SG
'He has sent me.' (Lit. 'He is sent mine.')

13.2.5.7 Pronominal object expressed by copula and/or participial agreement

In the south-eastern Trans-Zab subgroup of J. NENA, the object of a complex perfect is expressed by the copula and participial agreement, e.g.,

(58) J. Kerend (Hopkins 2002: 292)

a. Complex verb without object suffix
gərša *=y*
pull.RES.PTCP.M.SG =COP.3SG.M:A
'They pulled (sb.).'

b. Complex verb with object suffix
grəš *-ta* *=ya*
pull.RES.PTCP -F.SG:P =COP.3SG.F:P
'They pulled her.'

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c. Complex verb without object suffix
gərš =awe -li
pull.RES.PTCP =be.PRS.SBJV -OBL.1SG:A
'I would have pulled (sb.).'

d. Complex verb with object suffix
grəš -t =awya -li
pull.RES.PTCP -F.SG:P =be.PRS.SBJV -3SG.F:P -OBL.1SG:A
'I would have pulled her.'

In J. Sulemaniyya and Ḥalabja (Khan 2004b), feminine gender agreement always overrides agreement in gender with any other participant. Thus, if the pronominal P argument is feminine, the participle will agree with P instead of A, e.g.,

(59) J. Sulemaniyya (Khan 2004b)
gərš -e =t → grəš -t -aw =yet
pull.PTCP -M.SG =2SG:A pull.PTCP -F.SG:P -3SG.F:A =2SG.M:A
'You (M.SG) have pulled (sb.).' → 'You (M.SG) have pulled her.'

13.2.5.8 Pronominal object impossible

In the western sector, the complex perfect and/or progressive does occur, but cannot take object affixes. Instead, when the verbal form takes object affixes, it has to occur in a past or present stem verbal form. The TAM-marking shifts from the auxiliary in combination with a non-finite verbal form to that of a preverb and a finite verbal form, e.g.,

(60) C. Jinnet (Noorlander field notes)

a. Present perfect clause without object suffix
howən šəty -a
DEIC.COP.1SG.M:A drink.RES.PTCP -1SG.M:A
'I (M) have drunk (sth.).'

b. Present perfect clause with object suffix
hol šti -li -ya
DEIC.COP drink.PST -1SG:A -3SG.F:P
'I have drunk it (F).'

c. Present progressive clause verb without object suffix

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hola *bəštoya*
DEIC.COP.3SG.F drink.PROG
'She is drinking (sth.).'

d. Present progressive clause with object suffix
hol *šaty* *-o* *-lə*
DEIC.COP drink -3SG.F:A -3SG.M:P
'She is drinking it (m.).'

13.2.5.9 Distribution of pronominal object expressions in complex verb forms

Figure 13.3 displays the areal distribution of pronominal object expressions in complex verb forms.

- From north to south, by far the most common expression of the pronominal object is through the addition of possessive suffixes.
- The use of the LL-series and/or B-series is more common in the western sector.
- The use of L-suffixes is primarily found among Jewish dialects.
- In Iranian Kurdistan, and to some extent also in Sulemaniyya and Ḥalabja, the copula agrees with the object.

13.2.5.10 Transitivity and person marking in complex verbal forms

In the majority of NENA dialects that developed a complex progressive on the basis of the infinitive, there are no relevant restrictions in terms of verbalisation or transitivity coding (though see §13.2.6 for constraints on person-role associations). In a few dialects in the western sector, complex verb constructions are incompatible with pronominal objects (see §13.2.5.8 above). The complex perfect based on the resultative participle, however, shows considerable microvariation in terms of verbalisation and transitivity coding.

Broadly speaking, the copula and resultative participle agree with the subject of the clause, whether this is an agent of a transitive verb or the single argument of an intransitive verb. In several NENA dialects, however, transitive verbs are ambivalent in their argument orientation, and the resultative participle can thus be agent-, subject-, or patient-oriented, depending on the context, as illustrated in Table 13.15.

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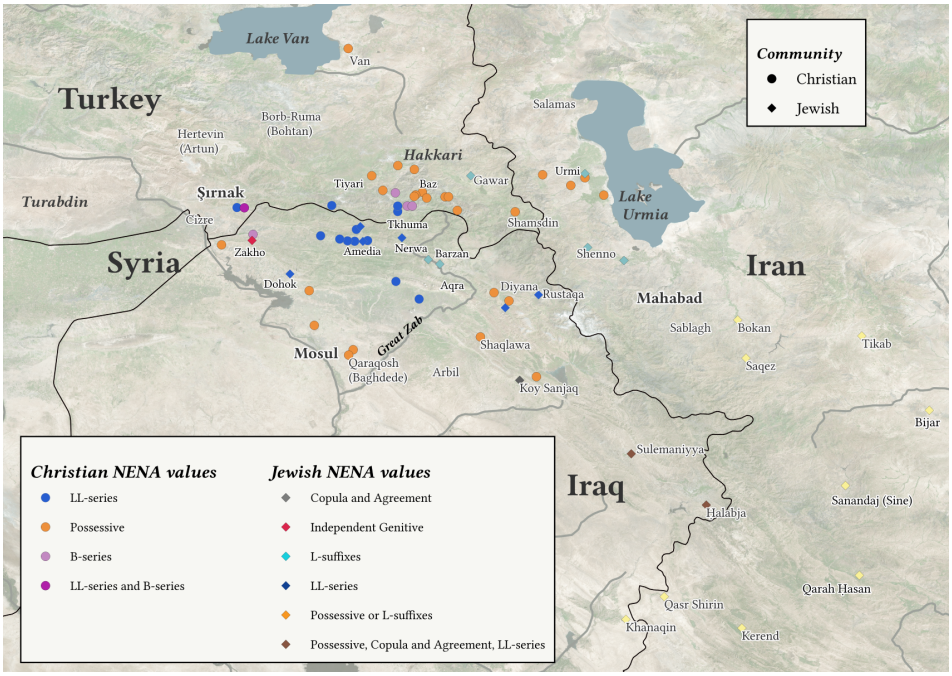

Figure 13.3: Distribution of object markers in compelx verb forms in NENA

Table 13.15: Illustrations of argument orientation in the complex perfect in C. Ashitha (Borghero 2005)

pθixtɛ=la		
Agent-oriented 'She has opened (sth.).'	Subject-oriented 'It (f.) is open.'	Patient-oriented 'It (f.) has been opened (by sb.).'
xiltɛ=la		
Agent-oriented 'She has eaten (sth.).'	Patient-oriented 'She/it (f.) has been eaten (by sb.).'	

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In such a system, there is little distinction between a copula clause with a verbal adjective that conveys an intransitive result state, e.g., *pθix-tɛ=la* 'It (f.) is open', and a complex perfect that comprises a verbal clause denoting a dynamic-transitive action, e.g., *pθix-tɛ=la* 'She has opened (sth.)'. There is significant microvariation among NENA dialects in how such clauses are differentiated through verbal morphology, which may involve the following factors, further discussed below: the position and type of copula, the adaptation of the transitivity coding to that of the present, the morphology of the resultative participle, and restrictions on what syntactic role can control participial agreement.

In the majority of Christian NENA dialects, the position of the enclitic copula is not entirely fixed. The enclitic copula is a mobile person marker that can move to the most accented constituent at the left edge of the verb phrase. In these dialects, the position of independent copulas, such as the negative copula, is, however, generally preverbal. The mobility of the enclitic copula and its sensitivity to prosodic prominence and discourse configuration, i.e., narrow focus, does not apply to the object marking strategy, which remains fixed and attaches to the main verb, as is the case with the bound person markers of the LL-series, e.g.,

(61) C. Nerwa (Noorlander field notes)

a. *qa-mo =(wə)t xəl-t =əll-e?*
for-what =COP.2SG.M:A eat.RES.PTCP-F.SG:A =OBJ-3SG.M
'Why have you eaten it (M)?'

b. *ʾat =(iw)ət xəl-t =əlle xabuš-i?*
2SG =COP.2SG.M:A eat.RES.PTCP-F.SG:A =OBJ-3SG.M appleM.SG-POSS.1SG
'Are you (the one who has) eaten my apple?'

c. *ʾədyo =(wə)x muθy =əll-e xoɻ-an*
today =1PL:A take.RES.PTCP.PL:A =OBJ-3SG.M friend.M.SG-POSS.1PL
l-maða
to-village.F.SG
'*Today* we have taken our friend to the village (not yesterday).'

d. *ʾana le =(wa)n xəl-t =əll-e*
1SG NEG =COP.1SG.F:A eat.RES.PTCP-F.SG:A =OBJ-3SG.M
'I have not eaten it.'

In Christian NENA dialects in the northern and eastern sectors, agent orientation is maintained throughout the complex perfect of transitive verbs, while patient orientation is impossible. Subject orientation still persists in single-argument clauses that denote a result-state (see also Khan 2016b: 398 – 399), as shown in Table 13.16.

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Table 13.16: Illustrations of argument orientation in the complex perfect in C. Shaqlawa

ptəxte=la		
Agent-oriented	Subject-oriented	**Patient-oriented
'She has opened (sth.).'	'It (F) is open.'	**'It (F) has been opened (by sb.).'
xəlte=la		
Agent-oriented	**Patient-oriented	
'She has eaten (sth.).'	**'She/it (F) has been eaten (by sb.).'	

In these NENA varieties, there is also an increasing level of adhesion between the resultative participle and the copula, so that the copula no longer tends to move to a constituent with prosodic prominence in the clause (see also Khan 2016b: 295 – 301), cf. (62) with (61). Once again, independent copulas are an exception, typically occurring preverbally in these dialects, as shown in (62d).

(62) C. Shaqlawa (Noorlander field notes)

a. *qa-ma xəl-t -u =wat?*
for-what eat.RES.PTCP-F.SG:A -POSS.3SG.M:P =COP.2SG.M:A
'Why have you eaten it (M)?'

b. *ʾāt xəl-t -u =wat*
2SG eat.RES.PTCP-F.SG:A -POSS.3SG.M:P =COP.2SG.M:A
xabuš-i?
appleM.SG-POSS.1SG
'Are you (the one who has) eaten my apple?'

c. *xawṛ-an ʾədyu muty -u =wəx*
friend.M.SG-POSS.1PL today take.RES.PTCP.PL:A -POSS.3SG.M:P =3PL:A
l-mata
to-village.F.SG
'*Today* we have taken our friend to the village.'

d. *ʾana le =wan xəl-t -u*
1SG NEG =COP.1SG.F:A eat.RES.PTCP-F.SG:A -POSS.3SG.M:P
'I have not eaten it.'

A few dialects in western Iraqi Kurdistan can distinguish a dynamic-transitive perfect from an intransitive resultative construction by the position of the basic copula relative to the verb. The transitive perfect is only compatible with a

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preverbal copula, while a postverbal copula must be interpreted as intransitive resultative (Noorlander 2021a). The postverbal position of the copula is, therefore, incompatible with agent orientation, as Table 13.17 shows for the Jewish dialect of Betanure. In J. Koy Sanjak, this concerns the syntax of the negative copula. When the negative copula is postverbal, agent orientation is impossible, as Table 13.17 illustrates.

Table 13.17: Agent orientation and placement of person marker

	Copula preverbal	Copula postverbal
J. Betanure	*ʾile pθixa*	*pθixa =yle*
(Mutzafi 2008a)	A-orientation possible	A-orientation impossible
	'He has opened (sth.)'	'It (m.) has (been) opened.'
	Copula preverbal	Copula postverbal
J. Koy Sanjak	*lewe bšila*	*bšila lewe*
(Mutzafi 2004a)	A-orientation obligatory	A-orientation impossible
	'He has not cooked (sth.)'	'It has not (been) cooked.'

In J. Barzani, in turn, also located in western Iraqi Kurdistan, the placement of the negative auxiliary is always before the predicate, irrespective of the argument orientation, e.g.,

(63) J. Barzani (Mutzafi 2002a)

	Negative copula preverbal	Affirmative copula postverbal
a.	***lewe*** *pina*	*pinā* ***=le***
	'He is not hungry.'	'He is hungry.'
b.	Negative present perfect	
	lewan *xzitā =le*	
	'I (f.) have not seen him.'	

In J. Barzani, only the negative present perfect is based on a complex verb form, while the affirmative present perfect is a synthetic verb consisting of a past stem verbal form with a preverbal TAM marker. In both cases, the pronominal object can be expressed by means of a reduced form of the LL-series, which has become identical to the L-suffixes.

When the enclitic copula attaches to the verb, there is an increasing tendency for univerbation and inflectionalisation, where analogy with the present stem verbal forms plays a key role. In this process of inflectionalisation, the transitive inflection of the complex verbal forms has become partly or completely identical

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to that of the present stem verbal forms in several NENA dialects due to cross-system harmonisation. The first and second person endings can become identical to the D-suffixes through the phonetic reduction of the enclitic copula, e.g., present copula 2SG.F *=iwat* > *=at* > *=ət* > *-t*, and past copula *=iwat-wa* > *=at-wa* > *=ət-wa*. This also results in an increasing level of adhesion to the preceding resultative participle, which still inflects for gender agreement, that can be observed only for the feminine singular, which takes the typical ending *-t-*. By the same token, the object clitics of the LL-series can become identical to the L-suffixes used in present-stem verbal forms, e.g., 1sg *ʾəlli* > *=lli* > *=li*. Thus, in many dialects, when a pronominal object suffix is added to the verb, the inflection of the complex verbal forms is identical to that of the present (see REF). This contrast is shown by a comparison of the negative perfect and affirmative perfect forms, e.g.,

(64) C. Barwar (Khan 2008c: 196, 284)

	Negative present perfect	Affirmative present perfect
a.	***lɛwən*** *ptixt =əlle*	*ptixt=**ən** -ne*
	‘I (F) have not opened it (M).’	‘I (F) have opened it.’
b.	***lɛla*** *ptix-t =əlle*	*ptixt=**əl** -le*
	‘She has not opened it (M).’	‘She has opened it.’

In past complex verbal forms, the similarity with the present stem inflection is even more striking, in that we do not find the past copula, but rather the so-called “past convertor” *-wa-*, e.g.,

(65) C. Barwar (Khan 2008c: 196, 284)

	Negative past perfect	Affirmative past perfect
a.	***lɛn-wa*** *ptixt =əlle*	*ptixt=**ən** -wa -le*
	‘I (F) had not opened it (M).’	‘I (F) had opened it.’
b.	***lɛ-wa*** *ptixt =əlle*	*ptixt=**əl** -wa -le*
	‘She had not opened it (M).’	‘She had opened it.’

In several Trans-Zab Jewish dialects of NENA, the affirmative present copula has become near-identical to the inflection of the present tense. When the copula is enclitic, the L-suffixes immediately attach to the copula, as they attach to D-suffixes in the “present”. In the Jewish dialects located in the south of Iranian Azerbaijan, what makes the copula distinct is a generalised *l*-element, as shown in (66), while in the Jewish dialect of Koy Sanjak located in eastern Iraqi Kurdistan, the inflection of the affirmative present perfect is identical to the present stem forms apart from the *w*-element. In both cases, the strong parallel with

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the "present" only obtains where first and second person agents are concerned. Furthermore, in the negative present perfect, the copula becomes preverbal and independent, and in J. Koy Sanjak, as shown in (66), it is even the case that a different object marking strategy is used, namely the attachment of possessive suffixes to the main verb.

(66) J. Shino and Solduz (Garbell 1965b)

Negative present perfect	Affirmative present perfect
*l-**an** xzita =lle*	*xzite =**lan** -ne*
'I have not seen him.'	'I have seen him.'

(67) J. Koy Sanjak (Mutzafi 2004a: 107)

Negative present perfect	Affirmative present perfect
*l-**ewan** ġzit =ew*	*ġzita =**wan** -ne*
'I have not seen him.'	'I have seen him.'

In J. Solduz, there are three possible strategies: either the negation and person marking of the agent are fused together in the preverbal auxiliary, or the person marking is expressed on both the main verb and the negative auxiliary, or the negator *la* is used and the person marking occurs only on the main verbal component, e.g.,

(68) Location of person marking in the negative perfect in J. Solduz (Garbell 1965b)

a. *l-en* *wid-a*
NEG-1SG.M:A do.RES.PTCP-M.SG:A
'I (M) have not done.' Negative auxiliary only

b. *l-en* *wid-en*
NEG-1SG.M:A do.RES.PTCP-1SG.M:A
'I (M) have not done.' Negative auxiliary and main verb

c. *la* *wid-en*
NEG do.RES.PTCP-1SG.M:A
'I (M) have not done.' Main verb only

In J. Urmi, the verbalisation of the complex verbal forms and their adaptation to the person marking system of the present stem verbal forms is virtually complete. The full form and the reduced form of the copula have a complementary distribution, as illustrated below. The full form is generally only compatible with an intransitive stative interpretation similar to a non-verbal clause, while the

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shortened form is always agent-oriented and expresses the transitive dynamic perfect similar to a verbal clause. The position of the negative auxiliary, in turn, like all copula forms, has been generalised to the right edge. However, what was originally a person-marking auxiliary has been fully integrated into the verbal inflection as verbal person endings, and the only means to negate the perfect is with the preposed negator *la* as found in verbal clauses. The past copula can still surface as an auxiliary in the past perfect, in which case agent or patient orientation is possible, whereas agent orientation is obligatory when the inflection of the "present" verbal forms is adopted. Moreover, when pronominal objects are added, the transitive coding becomes fully assimilated to the present stem verbal inflection in clauses where the agent is first/second person. This is the result of the reduction of the copula to D-suffixes and the simplification of the original LL-clitics to L-suffixes.

(69) J. Urmi (Garbell 1965b: 69; Khan 2008b: 5, 79, 83)

	Verbal clause	Nonverbal clause
a.	*plix -u* < *plixe =lu*	*plix-e =lu*
	Agent-oriented	Patient-oriented
	'They have opened (sth.).'	'They are open.'
b.	*xilt-an* < *xilte =lan*	*xilte=lan*
	Agent-oriented	Patient-oriented
	'I (F) have eaten (sth.).'	'I (F) have been eaten.'

(70) J. Urmi (Garbell 1965b: 69; Khan 2008b: 5, 79, 83)

	Negative present perfect clause	Negative present copula clause
a.	*la plixt-a*	*plixta lew-a*
	'She has not opened (sth.).'	'It (F) is not open.'
	Affirmative past perfect with D-suffix	Affirmative past perfect with copula
b.	*bšilt-a -wa*	*bšilta =wela*
	Agent-orientation only	Agent/patient-orientation
	'She had cooked (sth.).'	'She had cooked (sth.).'
		'It (F) has been cooked.'

In south-eastern Trans-Zab Jewish NENA dialects, there is a transitivity-based morphological split. The so-called sound verbs of the transitive complex perfect show a stem distinct from that of their intransitive counterparts. For this stem to occur, the clause has to be semantically transitive. The stem alternation is consistent across dialects, but the verbal person marking strategies vary considerably. For most weak verbs, this stem distinction is not observed, and the same

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morphology can be transitive or intransitive. In the Sulemaniyya region, the participle and copula regularly agree with the subject and agent (but see Sub§13.2.6 below for variation when object suffixes are attached), e.g.,

(71) J. Sulemaniyya (Khan 2004b: 98, 106, 108, 301)

	Transitive	Intransitive
a.	*pəlx-a=y*	*kwiš-a=y*
	Agent-oriented	Subject-oriented
	'He has opened (sth.).'	'He has gone down.'
b.	*qəṭl-e=n*	*qṭil-e=n*
	Agent-oriented	Patient-oriented
	'They have killed (sb.).'	'They have been killed.'
But:		
c.	*xil-e=n*	
	Agent-oriented	Patient-oriented
	'They have eaten (sth.).'	'They have been eaten.'

Table 13.18: Complex verbal forms with the verbs *smx* 'to wait' and *šql* 'to buy' in J. Sulemaniyya (Khan 2004b: 98,

	Perfect Intransitive	Perfect Transitive
3SG.M	*smixa=y*	*šəqla=y*
3SG.F	*smixta=ya*	*šqəlta=ya*
3PL	*smixe=n*	*šəqle=n*
2SG.F	*smixta=yat*	*šqəlta=yat*
2PL	*smixe=tun*	*šəqle=tun*

In the Trans-Zab Jewish dialects located in Iranian Kurdistan, subject orientation is readily maintained and encoded on the resultative participle and the copula without any restrictions. When the verb is transitive, however, there is no overt person marking of the agent. This "impersonal" transitive form of the realis perfect is only compatible with third person arguments (see §13.2.6).

(72) J. Sanandaj (Khan 2009: 91, 310)

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	Transitive	Intransitive
a.	*šəqla=y*	*kwiš-a=y*
	buy.PTCP.M.SG=SG.M	descend.PTCP-M.SG:S=COP.3SG.M:S
	Agent-oriented	Subject-oriented
	'(He) has bought (sth.).'	'He has gone down.'
b.	*qəṭl-a=y*	*qṭil-e=n*
	kill.PTCP.M.SG=SG.M	kill.PTCP-PL:S=COP.3PL:S
	Agent-oriented	Patient-oriented
	'(They) have killed (sb.).'	'They have been killed.'
c.	*xil-a=y*	*xil-e=n*
	eat.PTCP.M.SG=SG.M	eat.PTCP-PL:S=COP.3PL:S
	Agent-oriented	Patient-oriented
	'They) have eaten (sth.).'	'They have been eaten.'

For the irrealis perfect in these dialects, the subjunctive of the auxiliary verb *hwy* 'be' is used. Here, transitive verbs take Set II, the L-suffixes, as agent coding, but intransitive verbs use the bare inflection of the verb *hwy*, which takes Set I, the D-suffixes, e.g.,

(73) J. Sanandaj (Khan 2009: 92-93)

	Transitive	Intransitive
a.	*šəql=ăwe-le*	*kwiš=ăwe-∅*
	'He would have bought (sth.).'	'He would have gone down.'
b.	*qəṭl=ăwe-lu*	*qṭil=ăwe-n*
	'They would have killed (sb.).'	'They have been killed.'
c.	*xil=ăwe-li*	*xil=ăwe-na*
	'I would have eaten (sth.).'	'I would have been eaten.'

13.2.6 Person role constraints on binding and affix order

Several transitive constructions in NENA are incompatible with certain person-role configurations. This primarily concerns constraints on the combination of two or more bound person marking sets as well as the simple attachment of a bound person marker to the verbal stem. In these morphosyntactic constraints, at least one set of person markers and the syntactic role they express is person-restricted. This means that some person-role associations may undergo a gradual paradigm loss, so that they may be restricted even when one of the arguments is absent or expressed independently. It can even occur that the construction as a whole is constrained by person-role configurations, in which case multiple arguments are confined to a specific grammatical person. Often, the linear order of

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bound person markers can be a contributing factor, in which case the linear order of Stem-Patient-Agent (V-P-A) is more constrained than Stem-Agent-Patient. When the same syntactic role is not expressed through a bound person marker, or the syntactic roles are expressed in a different linear order, the person-role constraints are lifted.

Table 13.19: Patient and/or agent-related person role constraints in monotransitive clauses in south-eastern Trans-Zab Jewish NENA

	Person	**3 only**	**1, 2, 3**
	Role	**P**	**A**
All Trans-Zab J.:	Past	D-suffix	L-suffix
J. Sulemaniyya:	Infinitive	Possessive suffix	Copula
J. Sulemaniyya:	Resultative participle	Possessive suffix	Copula
	Person	**3 only**	**3 only**
	Role	**P**	**A**
All in W Iran:	Resultative participle	Copula	Zero

Table 13.20: Agent-related person role constraints in monotransitive clauses

	Person	**1, 2, 3**	**3 only**
	Role	**P**	**A**
J. Koy Sanjak	Infinitive	Possessive suffix	Enclitic copula
	Resultative participle	Possessive suffix	Enclitic copula
C. Barwar	Infinitive	LL-series	Enclitic copula
	Resultative participle	LL-series	Enclitic copula
	Person	**1, 2 only**	**1, 2, 3**
	Role	**A**	**P**
C. Hertevin	Past	L-D-suffix	L-suffix

In the vast majority of NENA dialects, first/second person direct objects cannot be expressed by the D-suffixes in past stem verbal forms (see §13.2.4.2). The D-suffixes that express the object are directly attached to the verbal stem and precede the "oblique" L-suffixes that encode the agent. When such a person-role restriction applies to the D-suffixes, an alternative strategy is necessary to express clauses with first/second person P arguments. Prima facie, this would

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Table 13.21: Recipient-related person role constraints in ditransitive clauses in NENA

	Person	1, 2, 3	3 only
	Role	R	T
V-R=T	Present / Past / Imperative	L-suffix	Enclitic copula
V-T-R	Present	L-suffix	L-suffix

seem to result from the restriction on the binding of person markers. In the Trans-Zab Jewish varieties of NENA, for example, no such constraint applies when the first/second person is expressed independently, e.g.,

(74) J. Sanandaj (Khan 2009)

a. P-coding bound
grəš -i -lan
pull.PST -3PL:P -3PL:P
'We pulled them.'

b. P-coding unbound
ʾəll-an grəš -lu
OBJ-1PL pull.PST -3PL:A
'They pulled us.'

Furthermore, in some dialects, such as J. Betanure (Mutzafi 2008a), the constraint is lifted when the agent coding is absent. Thus, when the "oblique" agent marker is attached to the preceding D-suffix, first/second person P arguments cannot be expressed. By contrast, when the "oblique" agent marker is dropped, first/second person P arguments can be freely expressed by D-suffixes, e.g.,

(75) J. Betanure (Mutzafi 2008a)

a. A-coding bound
griš -a -lu
pull.PST -3SG.F:P -3PL:A
'They pulled her.'

b. A-coding absent/unbound
griš -ax
pull.PST -1PL:P
'(People) pulled us.' / 'We were pulled (by sb.).'

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More generally, we observe that V-P-A ordering of the bound person markers is disfavoured, in which case the binding of the patient marker directly to the verbal stem is avoided. In the alternative strategy, for instance, the A and P arguments can still be bound without any person restriction. The ordering of bound person markers reflects the same V-A-P order (where 'V' stands for the verbal stem) as that of the present stem verbal forms, e.g.,

(76) J. Koy Sanjak (Mutzafi 2004a)

a. V-P-A (P:1,2 impossible)
nəšq -a -li
kiss.PST -3SG.F:P -1SG:P
'I kissed her.'

b. V-A-P (P:1,2 possible)
nšeq -la =lli ~ ʾəll -i nšəq -la
kiss.PST -OBL.3SG.F:A =1SG:P OBJ -1SG kiss.PST -OBL.3SG.F:A
'She kissed me.'

(77) J. Betanure (Mutzafi 2008a)

a. V-P-A (P:1,2 impossible)
nšiq -i -lan
kiss.PST -3PL:P -OBL.1PL:A
'We kissed them.'

b. V-A-P (P:1,2 possible)
qam- našq -i -lan
PST.TRZR- kiss -3PL:A -OBL.1PL:P
'They kissed us.'

Moreover, in some dialects, such as C. Barwar (Khan 2008c, the person-role constraint also affects the attachment of the D-suffixes alone to the "past" verbal stem. Thus, even when the "oblique" L-suffix is dropped, the person-role constraint remains in force, e.g.,

(78) C. Barwar (Khan 2008c)

a. A-coding bound; P:1,2 impossible
griš -a -lu
pull.PST -F.SG:P -3PL:A
'They pulled her.'

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b. A-coding absent/unbound; P:1,2 impossible
griš -a
pull.PST -F.SG:P
'(People) pulled her.' / 'She was pulled (by something).'

Nevertheless, there is no inherent morphosyntax-specific explanation for such person restrictions. In many dialects, the above strategies are compatible with all persons, e.g.,

(79) J. Barzani (Mutzafi 2002a)

a. V–P–A (P:1,2 possible)
*nəšq -ən -a (< *nəšq-ən-na)*
kiss.PST -1SG.M:P -OBL.3SG.F:A
'She kissed me (M.).'

b. V–A–P (P:1,2 possible)
nšəq -la =li ~ nšəq -la ʾəl-i
kiss.PST -OBL.3SG.F:A =OBL.1SG:P kiss.PST -OBL.3SG.F:A OBJ-1SG
'She kissed me.'

(80) J. Amidya (Greenblatt 2011)

a. V–P–A (P:1,2 possible)
nšiq -ax -lu
kiss.PST -1PL:P -OBL.3PL:A
'They kissed us.'

b. V–A–P (P:1,2 possible)
qam -našq -i -lan
PST.TRZR -kiss -3PL:A -1PL:P
'They kissed us.'

(81) C. Marga (Noorlander and Khan field notes)

a. A-coding bound (P:1,2 possible)
griš -ux -lay
pull.PST -1PL:P -OBL.3PL:A
'They pulled us.'

b. A-coding absent/unbound (P:1,2 possible)
griš -ux
pull.PST -1PL:P
'(People) pulled us.' / 'We were pulled (by something).'

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In general, therefore, we observe that one construction is simply favoured over another, presumably due to a paradigm loss that is in progress. In practice, however, speakers more readily accept clauses with the D-suffixes where either the A argument or the P argument is a speech act participant, or neither of them is one. When both arguments are speech act participants, the alternative strategy is preferred (see Khan 2016b II: 248-249; Noorlander 2021a; see also below), e.g.,

(82) C. Bne Matha (Noorlander field notes)

a. A:1,2 impossible
xəzy -an -na
see.PST -1PL:P -OBL.3SG.F:A
'She saw me (F).'

b. A:1,2 possible
qəm -xazy -at -ti
PST.TRZR -see.PST -2SG.F:A -OBL.1SG:P
'You (F.SG) saw me.'

In a few Christian dialects in the western sector, the D-suffixes fuse with the "oblique" L-suffix for speech act participants when a P marker is attached to them. Here, the D-suffix is available as an alternative to mark third person P arguments, but the first/second person affixes are absorbed as A-markers (see Sections 13.2.4.1), e.g.,

(83) C. Hertevin (Jastrow 1988)

a. V-P-A (P:1,2 impossible)
ḥəzy -a -li
see.PST -3SG.F:P -OBL.1SG:A
'I saw her.'

b. A:3 impossible
ḥze -lat -ti
see.PST -ERG.2SG.F:A -OBL.1SG:P
'You (F.SG) saw me.'

Complex verb constructions may also sporadically be constrained by person in a way similar to the above. When the pronominal object is expressed by affixes bound to the verbal stem before the enclitic copula that denotes the A argument, this is incompatible with first/second person P arguments. In the alternative strategy, first/second person objects are expressed independently. This is, for instance, the case in J. Sulemaniyya and Ḥalabja (Khan 2004b), e.g.,

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(84) J. Sulemaniyya (Khan 2004b)

a. V-P =A (P:1,2 impossible)
garoš -aw =yen
pull.PROG -3SG.F:P =COP.1SG.M:A
'I am pulling her.'

b. V =A P (P:1,2 possible)
garoša =ya ʾəll-i
pull.PROG =COP.3SG.F:A OBJ-1SG:P
'She is pulling me.'

In the Jewish dialects of Iranian Kurdistan, the transitive complex perfect is only compatible with third person A arguments, in which case the agent coding is null. The resultative participle and enclitic copula, in turn, can express the P argument, but are incompatible with first/second person. This restriction does not apply when the pronominal object is attached directly to the enclitic copula. In such clauses, the participle and copula are invariant and do not encode any argument. Thus, even in the absence of agent coding, the person-role constraint applies, similarly to what we observed for the agentless past stem verbal forms above.

(85) J. Saqiz (Yisraeli 1998)

a. A-coding absent (A:1,2 and P:1,2 impossible)
nšəq -te =ya ∅
kiss.RES.PTCP -F.SG:P =COP.3SG.F:P 3:A
'(They/he/she/it) has/have kissed her.'

b. A-coding absent (A:3 and P:1,2 possible)
nəšqa =y -li ∅
kiss.RES.PTCP =COP.3SG.M:P -OBL.1SG:P 3:A
'(They/he/she/it) has/have kissed me.'

In some dialects, attachment of the pronominal object to the verbal stem before the agent coding is only dispreferred when the A argument is a speech act participant. In most dialects of NENA, it is the enclitic copula that denotes the agent. When cliticised to a verb form with an object suffix, it may be incompatible with first/second person A arguments. When the pronominal object attaches to the copula instead of to the verbal base, the A argument can be a speech act participant.

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(86) J. Koy Sanjak (Mutzafi 2004a: 107)

a. V-P =A order possible (A:1,2 impossible)
graš -aw =ile
pull.PROG -POSS.3SG.F:P =COP.3SG.M:A
'He is pulling her.'

b. V-P =A order impossible (A:1,2 possible)
graša =wən -na
pull.PROG =COP.1SG:A -OBL.3SG.F:P
'I (M) am pulling her.'

(87) C. Barwar (Khan 2008c)

a. V =P =A order possible (A:1,2 impossible)
qṭil -t =əllox =ila
kill.RES.PTCP -F.SG:A =OBJ.2SG.M =COP.3SG.F:A
'She has killed you (M.SG).'

b. V =P =A possible (A:1,2 possible)
qṭile =wət =əlla
kill.RES.PTCP.M.SG:A =2SG.M:A =OBJ.3SG.F
'You (M.SG) have killed her.'

(88) C. Mazṛa (Talay 2009: 196.37, 200.7)

a. V =P =A possible (A:1,2 impossible)
xəzy =əbbe =le
see.RES.PTCP =OBJ.3SG.M =COP.3SG.M:A
'He has seen him.'

b. V =P =A impossible (A:1,2 possible)
xəzy -e =wəx =əbbe
see.RES.PTCP -PL:A =COP.1PL:A =OBJ.3SG.M
'We have seen him.'

Again, at face value, it would seem that binding of P-coding to the verbal stem is disfavored when the copula is first/second person. Thus, when the A argument is a speech act participant and the A-coding occurs independently of the verb, the P-markers freely attach to the verbal stem, e.g.,

(89) J. Koy Sanjak (Mutzafi 2004a: 107)

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a. A-coding unbound (P-coding on stem possible)
le=wan ġzi -t -ew
NEG=COP.1SG.F:A see.RES.PTCP -F.SG:A -POSS.3SG.M:P
'I have not seen him.'

b. A-coding bound (P-coding on stem impossible)
ġzi -ta =wan -ne
see.RES.PTCP -F.SG:A =COP.1SG.F:A -OBL.3SG.M:P
'I have seen him.'

(90) C. Mazṛa (Talay 2009: 200.7-8)

a. A-coding unbound (P-coding on stem possible)
l=en-wa xəzy =əbbe
NEG=COP.1SG.M:A-PST see.RES.PTCP.M.SG:A =OBJ.3SG.M
'I have not seen him.'

b. A-coding bound (P-coding on stem impossible)
xəxzy -e =wəx =əbbe
see.RES.PTCP -PL:A =COP.1PL:A =OBJ.3SG.M
'We have seen him.'

Finally, person-role constraints also occur in ditransitive constructions. Here, the situation is different in that a bound theme marker is systematically restricted to the third person when it is combined with a bound recipient, e.g.,

(91) J. Dohok (Molin 2024)

a. R bound; T:1/2 impossible
b- yawəl -∅ -lu -lan
FUT- give -3SG.M:A -OBL.3PL.T -OBL.1PL:R
'He will give them to us.'

b. R unbound; T:1/2 possible
b- yawəl -∅ -lan tal-u
FUT- give -3SG.M:A -OBL.1PL.T DAT-3PL
'He will give us to them.'

Typically, in the dialects of the Mosul Plain and the Arbel Plain in Iraq, the enclitic copula is used to express bound third person theme markers when the recipient is a bound person marker.

(92) J. Koy Sanjak

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a. R bound; T:1/2 impossible
k- *me* *-∅* *-lan* *=ilu*
IND- bring -3SG.M:A -OBL.1PL:R =COP.3PL.T
'He brings them to us.'

b. R unbound; T:1/2 possible
k- *me* *-∅* *-lu* *baq-əd* *did-an*
IND- bring -3SG.M:A -OBL.3PL.T DAT-CSTR GEN-1PL
'He brings them to us.'

(93) C. Shaqlawa

a. R bound; T:1/2 impossible
k- *ew* *-ən* *-ox* *=ina*
IND- give -1SG.M:A -2SG.M:R =COP.3PL.T
'I will give them to you.'

b. R unbound; T:1/2 possible
k- *ew* *-ən* *-nox* *qa-t-u*
IND- give -1SG.M:A -OBL.2SG.M.T DAT-GEN-3PL
'I will give you to them.'

13.2.7 Pronominal objects in light verb constructions

In light verb constructions, the pronominal object can either be attached to the verb, as shown in (94), or attached to the nominal element, as shown in (95).

(94) J. Solduz (Garbell 1965b: 177)
qamči dhəl *-le* *-le*
whip hit.PST -OBL.3SG.M:A -OBL.3SG:P
'They whipped him.'

(95) J. Saqiz (Yisraeli 1998: 170)
ʿayb *-ev* *k-ol-i*
shame -POSS.3SG.M IND-do-3PL:A
'They shame him.'

13.3 Verbal person marking in Iranian

13.3.1 Core verbal inflectional stems: present and past stem

Within Iranian, inflectional stems are generally subdivided into the following categories:

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(96) Core inflectional stems in Kurdic
'to take'

	Gorani Hewramî	NK Behdînî	CK Erbil
Present	*ber-*	*be-*	*be-*
Past	*berđ-*	*bir-*	*bird-*
Res. participle	*berđe* (M.SG) *berđê* (F.SG, PL)	*birî-*	*birdû-*
Imperative	*ber-*	*be-*	*be-*
Infinitive	*berđey*	*birin*	*birdin*

13.3.2 Core verbal person markers

13.3.2.1 Affixal person markers vs. oblique clitics

There are four sets of person markers that express the core arguments of the clause across Kurdic, namely:

- present-tense suffixes representing inherited verbal person endings, referred to as 'affixal person markers';
- past-tense suffixes, historically forms of the copula, with the notable exception that the third-person singular form is always omitted, also subsumed under 'affixal person markers';
- oblique clitic person markers that attach to the first element of the verb phrase; they may attach to VP-internal morphemes as well as VP-internal syntactically separate elements. This set does not break morpheme boundaries in Southern Kurdish, however, and is absent from Northern Kurdish.
- a set of copula person markers (which in the realis present enclitic form are identical to the past-tense suffixes mentioned above);
- independent person markers that may inflect for case, depending on the dialect.

Broadly speaking, the two subsets of affixal person markers together comprise 'Set 1', which corresponds to Set 1, the D-suffixes, in NENA dialects. The affixal person markers that belong to Set 1 are always attached directly to the stem in Northern Kurdish, while their position in the verbal structure can vary in Central Kurdish. With respect to Set 2, the oblique L-suffixes in NENA, these correspond

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to either a second set serving as bound oblique person markers (Central and Southern Kurdish, Gorani) or a series of free oblique person markers (Northern Kurdish, Zazaki). The independent person markers generally do not inflect for case in Central and Southern Kurdish and Gorani, while they do in Northern Kurdish and Zazaki.

The sets of person markers in Hewrami and Central Kurdish are illustrated in Table 13.23 and Table 13.22, respectively. The inflection of past intransitive verbs is historically the result of the univerbation of historically copular forms (based on *h-*). The person markers interact in the tense-aspect-sensitive argument indexing system. Notably, one set of person markers may express the A argument in one tense and the P argument in the other (see next subsection). In Kurdish, the copula paradigm reflects the same inflection as the past tense paradigm via affixal person markers and is not further discussed here.

Table 13.22: Bound person markers in Central Kurdish

	Affixal person markers		Oblique clitics
	S/A-present	S/P-past	A-past/P-present
1SG	*-im*	*-im*	*=m*
2SG	*-î*	*-î*	*=t*, *=o*
3SG	*-ê*	*-Ø*	*=î*
1PL	*-în*	*-în*	*=man*, *=in*
2PL	*-in*	*-in*	*=tan*, *=û*
3PL	*-in*	*-in*	*=yan*

Table 13.23: Bound person markers in Hewramî (Mohammadirad 2026)

	Affixal person markers		Oblique clitics
	S/A-present	S/P-past	A-past/P-present
1SG	*-û*	*-ane*	*=im*
2SG	*-î*	*-î*	*=it*
3SG	*-o*	-Ø (M); -e (F)	*=iş*
1PL	*-mê*	*-îmê*	*=ma*
2PL	*-dê*	*-îdê*	*=ta*
3PL	*-a*	*-ê*	*=şa*

Northern Kurdish and Zazaki lack a bound set of oblique person markers (though see below). The syntactic functions expressed by bound oblique person

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markers in other Iranian languages are expressed by free oblique pronouns. Table 13.24 illustrates the paradigm of person markers in NK.

Table 13.24: Sets of person markers in NK

	Affixal person markers		Free oblique person markers
	S/A-present	S/P-past	A-past/P-pres
1SG	*-im*	*-im*	*min*
2SG	*-î*	*-î*	*te*
3SG	*-e/-ît*	*-Ø*	wî (M); wê (F)
1PL	*-în/-in*	*-în/-in*	*me*
2PL	*-in*	*-in*	*we*
3PL	*-in*	*-in*	*wan*

13.3.2.2 Tense-sensitive inversion of role referencing

Within conservative dialects of Kurdish and Gorani, the tense-sensitive person marking shows an inversion in role referencing, which is summarised in Table 13.25. The set of oblique clitics express P in the present tense, but A in the past tense, and vice versa (see §13.3.6.1 for microvariation). Compare the following examples from Hewramî.

(97) Hewramî

a. *ber-î=şa*
take.PRS.IND-2SG:A=OBL.3PL:P
'You take them.'

b. *berd-î=şa*
take.PST-2SG.P=OBL.3PL:A
'They took you.'

In conservative dialects of Northern Kurdish, this role reference inversion is associated with the direct and oblique case-marking of free person markers, as summarised in Table 13.26. Thus, the affixal person markers cross-reference the argument in the direct case, whose role depends on whether the verb is based on the past or present stem e.g.,

(98) Behdînî NK

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Table 13.25: Role inversion and person marking in conservative dialects of Central Kurdish and Gorani

	Set 1 Affixal person markers	Set 2 Oblique clitics
Constructions based on present stem verb forms	S, A	P, R
Constructions based on past stem verb forms	S, P, R	A, R

a. *tu* *min* *di-b-î*
DIR.2SG OBL.1SG IND-take.PRS-2SG:A
'You are taking me.'

b. *min* *tu* *di-bir-î*
OBL.1SG DIR.2SG IND-take.PRT-2SG:P
'They were taking you.'

Table 13.26: Role inversion and case and person marking in conservative dialects of Northern Kurdish

	Affixal person markers	Direct pronoun	Oblique pronoun
Constructions based on present stem verb forms	S, A	S, A	P, R
Constructions based on past stem verb forms	S, P	S, P	A, R

13.3.2.3 VP-internal mobility of oblique clitics

Oblique clitics are mobile person markers across Central Kurdish and Gorani. Their placement follows a a so-called 'VP-second' positioning rule. This means that they are placed in second position immediately after the first element within the VP. Constituents considered to be VP-external, such as subject NPs and clausal adverbs, are not available for clitic hosting, e.g.,

(99) CK
min řeng=yan *de-ke-m*
1SG colour=OBL.3PL:P IND-do.PRS-1SG:A
'I shall colour them.' Present stem verb form

(100) CK
min řeng=im *de-kird-in*
1SG colour=OBL.1SG:A IND-do.PST-3PL:P
'I was colouring them.' Past stem verb form

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Typically, the placement of oblique clitics strictly conforms to the VP-second positioning rule and is not sensitive to prosodic and/or discourse prominence. For example, in (101), the sentential stress is on the *wh*-constituent *kê* 'who', but the clitic appears on the topical direct object NP, following the VP-second positioning rule.

(101) CK
kitêb-eke=t *be kê* *da*
book-DEF=OBL.2SG:A to who give.PST
'To whom did you give the book?'

There is some minor evidence that sentential stress can lead to the mobility of clitic pronouns. In this case, the mobility occurs if the accentuated and focalised element is VP-initial. In (102), the clitic appears on the clausal adverb *qet*, which bears the main sentential stress.

(102) CK Mukri (Öpengin 2013b: 331)
qet=im *dił* *ne-êşand-û=n*
never=OBL.1SG:A heart NEG-hurt.PST-PTCP=COP.3PL
'I have never broken their heart.'

Furthermore, oblique clitic placement can be sensitive to the internal morphological structure of verb forms. This holds true for Central Kurdish, but not for Gorani, where the mobility of the clitics is reduced. In the negation of past stem verbs, for instance, the oblique clitic expressing the agent lands on the stressed negation formative in CK (103), but lands on the verbal stem in Gorani (104). Still, in both Iranian languages, the mobile clitic will land on the first element within the VP, even when the verb is negated, as 102 illustrates.

(103) Common Central Kurdish
ne=man-xward
NEG=OBL.1PL:A-eat.PST
'We did not eat (it).'

(104) Hewramî
ne-ward=ma
NEG-eat.PST=OBL.1PL:A
'We did not eat (it).'

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13.3.3 Present stem verbal inflection

The following examples from Hewramî illustrate the verbal person marking in Iranian present stem verbal forms:

(105) *min mi-l-û*
1SG IND-go.PRS-1SG:S
'I go/ am going.' Present stem S

(106) *m-aç-û*
IND-say.PRS-1SG:A
'I say.' Present stem A

(107) *wîn-û=ş*
see.PRS-1SG:A=OBL.3SG:P
'I see her/him.' Present stem P

Across all Kurdic, P is expressed by an oblique set in present stem verbal forms, either by oblique clitics, as in Central and Southern Kurdish as well as in Gorani, or by independent oblique pronouns, as in Zazaki and Northern Kurdish.

13.3.3.1 Pronominal object expressed by oblique clitics

The following examples illustrate the present stem inflection of A and P in Central and Southern Kurdish and Gorani. Note that in Central Kurdish, the oblique clitic is mobile and lands on the indicative prefix. In Southern Kurdish and Gorani, the oblique clitic follows the set of affixal person markers expressing the A argument.

(108) Common Central Kurdish
de=y-xo-m
IND=OBL.3SG:P-take.PRS-1SG:A
'I eat it.'

(109) SK Qurwe
e-xwe-m=ey
IND-eat.PRS-1SG:A=OBL.3SG:P
'I take it.'

(110) Gorani Zerde
me-wer-î=ş
IND-eat.PRS-1SG:A=OBL.3SG:P
'I eat it.'

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13.3.3.2 Pronominal object expressed by free oblique pronouns

In Northern Kurdish and Zazaki, pronominal objects are expressed by oblique pronouns that appear pre-verbally, e.g.,

(111) NK
wê *di-xo-m*
3SG.F.OBL IND-eat.PRS-1SG:A
'I eat it.'

13.3.4 Past stem verbal inflection

Table 13.27 and Table 13.28 represent the inflection of core arguments of the clause in the past perfective across varieties of Kurdish.

13.3.4.1 Pronominal object expressed by affixal person markers

In varieties which have retained the tense-sensitive inversion, the pronominal object is expressed by the affixal person markers. This is the case with conservative varieties of Gorani, and those Central Kurdish varies influenced by them. In conservative dialects of Northern Kurdish, the affixal person marker is expressed on the verb, but obligatorily combines with a free pronoun in the direct case, e.g.,

(112) Behdînî NK
min *ew* *xwar-in*
OBL.1SG DIR.3 eat.PST-3PL:P
'I ate them.'

The following examples from Hewramî illustrate the verbal person marking in conservative Gorani past stem verbal forms:

(113) *min wit-a*
1SG sleep.PST-1SG:S
'I slept.' Past stem S

(114) *wat=im*
say.PST=OBL.1SG:A
'I said.' Past stem A

(115) *to* *min=it* *qul* *kerd-a*
2SG 1SG=OBL.2SG:A hole do.PST-1SG:P
'You disabled me.' Past stem P

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Table 13.27: The expression of A and S in Past imperfective/preterite

	S-past		A-past	
NK	*ket-im* [fall.PST-1SG:S]	'I fell.'	*min bir* [1SG.OBL took]	'I took (it).'
Zaz.	*kewt-a* [fall.PST-1SG:S]	'I fell.'	*mi berd* [1SG.OBL took]	'I took (it).'
CK	*kewt-im* [fall.PST-1SG:S]	'I fell.'	*bird=im* [took=OBL.1SG:A]	'I took (it).'
Hewr.	*kewt-a* [fall.PST-1SG:S]	'I fell.'	*berd=im* [took=OBL.1SG:A]	'I took (it).'
SK	*keft-im* [fall.PST-1SG:S]	'I fell.'	*bird-im* [took-1SG:A]	'I took (it).'

Table 13.28: The expression of A and P in past perfective/preterite

NK	*min tu bir-î*	[1SG.OBL 2SG.DIR take.PST-2SG:P]	'I took you.'
Zaz.	*min ti berd-î*	[1SG.OBL 2SG.DIR take.PST-2SG:P]	'I took you.'
NCK	*bird=m-î*	[take.PST=OBL.1SG:A-2SG:P]	'I took you.'
Hewr.	*berd-î=m*	[take.PST-2SG.P=OBL.1SG:A]	'I took you.'
SCK	*bird=t=im*	[take.PST=OBL.2SG.P=OBL.1SG:A]	'I took you.'
SK	*bird-im=ad*	[take.PST-1SG:A=OBL.2SG:P]	'I took you.'

13.3.4.2 Pronominal object expressed by oblique clitics

In the central Kurdish of the Sanandaj region and neighbouring Gorani varieties, the pronominal object in past stem verb forms is expressed by the oblique clitic set, similarly to that in present stem verb forms. However, the agent is expressed by the same set of oblique clitics, e.g.,

(116) Gorani Qela

a. *berd=man=şan*
take.PST=OBL.1PL.P=OBL.3PL:A
'They took us.'

b. *berd=şan=man*
take.PST=OBL.3PL.P=OBL.1PL:A
'We took them.'

(117) CK Sanandaj
bird=man=yan
take.PST=OBL.1PL.P=OBL.3PL:A
'They took us.'

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In Southern Kurdish dialects, the inflection of transitive verbs has been harmonised throughout, so that only the pronominal object is expressed by the oblique clitics, e.g.,

(118) Southern Kurdish

a. *we-n=ed*
take.PRS-3PL:A=OBL.2SG:P
'They take you.'

b. *bird-in=ed*
take.PST-3PL:A=OBL.2SG:P
'They took you.'

13.3.4.3 Pronominal object expressed by free oblique pronouns

In Northern Kurdish, the pronominal object of past stem verb forms is expressed by free oblique pronouns, e.g.,

(119) Common Northern Kurdish
Te *min* *dît*
OBL.2SG OBL.1SG see.PST
'You saw me.'

13.3.4.4 Intransitive subjects expressed by oblique clitics

In Gorani dialects outside the Hawraman region, such as Bajalani of the Mosul region and Bajalani of the Qasr-e Shirin region, the inflection of past transitive verbs has been extended to the inflection of past intransitive verbs, e.g.,

(120) Gorani, Bajalani of Mosul area (MacKenzie 1956: 423)
çi *arpaçî ama=yman*
from PN come.PST=OBL.1PL:S
'We came from Ārpačī.'

It is notable that oblique clitics inflecting past intransitive subjects have been subject to grammaticalisation, in the sense that they have become fixed in their attachment to the verb and lost their mobility. The oblique clitics expressing the A argument of past stem verb forms, however, remain mobile as usual.

The Bajalani dialects of the Qasr-e Shirin region in Iran the oblique clitic inflection is only found with the past tense form of the copula verb 'to be'. The inflection of intransitive past stem verbs remains the expected affix person markers (see Mohammadirad In press for discussion).

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Table 13.29: Bound person markers in Gorani Bajalani (Mosul) (MacKenzie 1956)

	A/S prs	A-past	S-past and cop.pst	cop.prs
1SG	-î	=m	=m	=nî
2SG	-î	=t	=t	=nî
3SG	-o	=ş	-Ø	=(a)n
1PL	-mê	=ma	=ma	=nmê
2PL	-ê	=ta	=ta	=ndê
3PL	-an	=ma	=şa	=nê

(121) Gorani, Bajalani of of Qasr-e Shirin (Biskan, Mann & Hadank 1930: 400)

a. *çe yane wî=man sakin bî=man*
in house REFL=OBL.1PL stationary COP.PST=OBL.1PL:S
'We settled (lit. became stationary) in our own houses.'

b. *lua-ym*
go.PST-1SG:S
'We went.'

This Gorani pattern of using the oblique clitics with past stem intransitive verbs has been partly replicated in the CK dialects of Iraqi Kurdistan, notably in the CK dialects of Rojbayani and Kelekçî in the Erbil region and the CK dialects of the Kirkuk region. In the latter, the oblique clitics have been extended to past stem intransitive verbs in 1PL and 2PL person configurations (122), e.g.,

(122) CK Kirkuk (Daqoq region)
we pa-we e-roy=man bo mekteb
by foot-POST IPFV-go.PST=1PL:S to school
'We would walk to school.'

The past tense copula forms as found in the Bajalani dialects of Qasr-e Shirin, as seen above, are replicated in the CK dialect of the Kalar region (south of Sulemaniyya), e.g.,

(123) *bû=man*
be.PST=OBL.1PL:S
'We were.'

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Table 13.30: Oblique inflection in the verbal inflectional paradigms of CK dialects in Erbil region

	CK Rojbeyani		CK Kelekçî	
	PRS	PST	PRS	PST
1SG	-im	-im	-im	-im
2SG	-i	-Ø	-ît	-î
3SG	-e	-Ø	-ê	-Ø
1PL	-in	**-man**	-în	**-man**
2PL	-in	**-tan**	-in	**-tan**
3PL	-in	-in	-in	-in

13.3.5 Complex perfect: the copula auxiliary BE as person marker

Broadly speaking, the same distribution in the expression of pronominal objects found in the past perfective and imperfective is also found in the expression of such objects in the perfect, as shown in Tables 13.31 and 13.32. All these verb forms, including the perfect, are derived from the same past stem across the Iranian languages in the region. The key difference in the perfect is the (additional) use of the copula. The pronominal object is expressed by copulas only in conservative dialects of Central Kurdish and Gorani, as well as those of Northern Kurdish. Thus, in these conservative varieties, the pronominal object is treated as equivalent to the subject of a copula clause. As in the past perfective, however, most varieties will express the pronominal object in the same way as the present stem verbal forms due to cross-system harmony.

Table 13.31: Intransitive inflection of the perfect

Bah. NK	*em yêt ket-î*	[1PL.DIR EZ.PL fall.PST-PTCP]	'We have fallen.'
Common NK	*ket-in=e*	[fall.PST-1PL.S=COP]	'We have fallen.'
Zaz.	*kewt-a*	[fall.PST-1SG:S]	'I have fallen'.
CK	*kewt-û=yn*	[fall.PST-PTCP=COP.1PL:S]	'We have fallen.'
Hewr.	*kewt-ê=nmê*	[fall.PST-PTCP=OBL.1PL:S]	'We have fallen.'
SK	*keft-îm=e*	[fall.PST-1PL.S=COP]	'We have fallen.'

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Table 13.32: Transitive inflection of the perfect

Bêhdînî NK	*min ew yêt birî=n*	[1SG.OBL 3PL.DIR EZ.PL take.PST.PTCP=COP.3PL:P]	'I took them.'
Common NK	*min wan bir-î=ye*	[1SG.OBL 3PL.OBL take.PST-PTCP=COP.3SG]	'I have taken them.'
Northern CK	*bird-û=m=in*	[take.PST-PTCP=OBL.1SG:A=COP.3PL:P]	'I have taken them.'
Hewramî	*berd-ê=nê=m*	[take.PST-PTCP=COP.3PL.P=OBL.1SG:A]	'I have taken them.'
Southern CK	*bird-ig=yan=m=e*	[take.PST-PTCP=OBL.3PL.P=OBL.1SG:A]	'I have taken them.'
Southern Kurdish	*bird-m=es=eyan*	[take.PST-1SG:A=COP.3SG=OBL.3PL:P]	'I have taken them.'

13.3.6 Complex combinations of person markers

13.3.6.1 Person role constraints on affix binding and order

In Northern Kurdish, there are no oblique clitics for pronominal arguments in any syntactic role except for the recipient (R) argument of ditransitive verbs. If the R argument of a ditransitive verb is pronominal and 3SG, it can be expressed by the enclitic form *=ê*, which is a shortened form of the 3SG oblique pronoun *wê*. The enclitic form *=ê* can express a 3SG referent regardless of gender, e.g.,

(124) NK
min *got=**ê***
1SG.OBL say.PST=OBL.3SG:R
'I told him/her.'

(125) NK
min *da=**ê***
1SG.OBL give.PST=OBL.3SG:R
'I give (it) to him/her.'

(126) NK
em *her-n=**ê***
1PL.DIR go.IMP-1PL=OBL.3SG:R
'Let us go there.'

When different clausal arguments are expressed on the verb through bound person marking, different patterns emerge across Kurdish. In present-tense constructions, there are generally two patterns. In Gorani and Southern Kurdish, the object index, expressed by clitic pronouns, follows the subject index. In Central Kurdish, the object clitic lands on the preverbal TAM prefix.

(127) Gorani

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wîn-û=ş
see.PRS-1SG:A=OBL.3SG:P
'I see her/him.'

(128) Southern Kurdish
be-m=ey
take.PRS-1SG:A=OBL.3SG:P
'I take her/him.'

(129) Central Kurdish
de=y-be-m
IND=OBL.3SG.P-TAKE.PRS-1SG:A
'I take her/him.'

In past tense constructions, bound person marking exhibits a significant degree of variation within Kurdish. In all variaties of Central Kurdish, a 3SG agent would always follow the object of the verb.

(130) CK Mukri
bird-în=î
take.PST=OBL.1PL.P=OBL.3SG:A
'They took us.'

(131) CK Sanandaj
bird=man=î
take.=OBL.1PL.P=OBL.3SG:A
'He took us.'

In Upper Central Kurdish, the ordering for all other persons is systematically V=A-P:

(132) CK Mukri/Erbil
a. *bird=yan-î*
take.PST=OBL.3PL:A-2SG:P
'They took you.'
b. *dî=tan-în*
see.PST=OBL.1PL:A-1PL:P
'You (PL) saw us.'

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In central varieties of CK, e.g., the Sulemaniyya region of Iraqi Kurdistan, the ordering is the same as in upper CK, except that when the A is 3PL, both V=A-P and V-P=A are possible (MacKenzie 1961a: 113), e.g.,

(133) a. *bird=yan-î*
take.PST=OBL.3PL:A-2SG:P
'They took you.'

b. *bird-î=yan*
take.PST-2SG.P=3PL:A
'They took you.'

In the southern sector of Central Kurdish varieties, the ordering is consistently V-P-A, regardless of how the object is expressed, e.g.,

(134) CK Jaffi
bird-în=yan
take.PST=OBL.1PL.P=OBL.3PL:A
'They took us.'

(135) CK Sanandaj
bird=man=yan
take.=OBL.1PL.P=OBL.3PL:A
'They took us.'

The exact same ordering occurs in Gorani varieties, as seen in the examples below. It has been suggested in (Mohammadirad In press) that the organisation of bound person marking in southern dialects of CK reflects a Gorani substrate (see also Leezenberg 1992, Mohammadirad 2025d).

(136) Hewramî
berd-îmê=şa
take.PST-1PL.P=OBL.3PL:A
'They took us.'

(137) Gorani Qela
berd=man=şan
take.PST=OBL.1PL.P=OBL.3PL:A
'They took us.'

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13.3.6.2 Multiple oblique clitics

Past stem verb forms can take more than one oblique clitic, one expressing the A argument and the other expressing the P argument. In southern varieties of Central Kurdish, both the A and P arguments are mobile and land on the negation formative, e.g.,

(138) CK Sanandaj
ne=yan=im-bird-ig=e
NEG=OBL.3PL.P=OBL.1SG:A-take.PST-PTCP=COP.3SG
'I have not taken them.'

In Gorani, however, the oblique clitic expressing the A argument does not land on the negator, but is placed after any set of person markers that express the P argument, e.g.,

(139) Hewramî
ne-berdê=nê=m
NEG-take.PST.PTCP.PL=COP.3PL.P=OBL.1SG:A
'I did not take them.'

13.3.6.3 Affix co-optation

In some Central Kurdish and Gorani dialect groups, the expression of P through affixal person markers is extended to the expression of other nonsubject arguments, including recipients, addressees, beneficiaries, possessors, comitatives, etc. This has been termed 'affix co-optation' in the literature (Haig 2018a).

The expression of non-core arguments on past transitive verbs comes at the cost of object agreement on the verb, meaning that the P index is absent if its slot has been taken by a non-core argument (Mohammadirad 2025a). In (140), the verb does not agree with the plural direct object, expressing instead the recipient argument.

(140) Hewramî (Mohammadirad 2025a)
*sênze danê heser(e)-ê=şa da-**ø** **pene***
thirteen CLF.PL mule.F-PL.DIR=OBL.3PL:A give.PST-3SG:R to
'They gave him thirteen mules.'

(141) Hewramî (Mohammadirad 2026: 349)
*xeber-ê=m ne-zanê=**nê***
news.M-PL.DIR=OBL.1SG:A NEG-know.PST.PTCP.PL=COP.3PL:PSR
'I didn't know their news.' [JM.30]

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(142) Central Kurdish (Mohammadirad 2020b: 329)
hemîşe dayk=im ew şit=î=e bo
always mother=OBL.1SG. DEM thing=OBL.3SG:A=DEM to
*e-kut=**în***
IPFV-tell.PST-1PL:R
'My mom would always tell us this thing.'

This means that there is role referencing inversion for expressing non-core arguments across upper and central varieties of CK and conservative Gorani varieties. The bound complements of *pê* in (143) and *pene* in (144) are expressed by different sets of bound person markers, triggered by tense.

(143) CK

a. *pê=t de-de-m*
to=OBL.2SG:R IND-give.PRS-1SG:A
'I give (it) to you.'

b. *pê=m da-y*
to=OBL.2SG:R give.PST-2SG:R
'I gave (it) to you.'

(144) Hewramî

a. *pene=t waç-û*
to=OBL.2SG:R tell.PRS.IND-1SG:A
'I tell you.'

b. *pene=m wat-î*
to=OBL.2SG:R tell.PST-2SG:R
'I told you.'

This system has been harmonised in Southern CK varieties and peripheral Gorani. Here, the non-core argument is expressed on its governing adposition by a clitic pronoun (Öpengin & Mohammadirad 2022).

(145) CK Sanandaj (Mohammadirad 2020b: 359)
*dayk=im hîlkewřon=î **bo=m** durus e-kird*
mom=OBL.1SG:PSR fried_eggs=3SG:A for=OBL.1SG:R right IPFV-do.PST
'My mother would make me fried eggs.'

(146) Gorani Zarda (Mahmoudveysi & Bailey 2013: 153)

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qeyrê qise=m ***pene=şan*** *kerd*
a_bit saying=OBL.1SG:A to=3PL:R do.PST
'I scolded them a bit'.

These oblique clitics expressing adposition complements are mobile in CK and some Gorani varieties.

(147) CK Bane (Mohammadirad 2026: 352, glossing and transcription modified)
ba defr-ekan=m=î pê bi-şo-m
HORT dish-DEF.PL=OBL.1SG:PSR=3SG:R with SBJV-wash.PRS.1SG:A
'That I wash my dishes with it.'

(148) Gorani Zarda (Mahmoudveysi & Bailey 2013: 146)
min=ic hüc=im pey ne-kir-ya
1SG:ADD nothing=OBL.1SG:R by NEG-do.PRS.PASS.3SG:S
'I too, there was nothing to be done by me.'

13.3.7 Pronominal objects in light verb constructions

In light verb constructions, the pronominal object can appear as a direct object of the verb, as shown in (149a) and (150a), or as an adnominal possessor of the nominal element, as given in (149b) and (150b).

(149) Common Northern Kurdish

a. *wî ew qamçî kir*
OBL.3SG.M DIR.3SG whip do.PST
'He whipped him.'

b. *min serdan-a te kir*
OBL.3SG.M visit-EZ.F.SG OBL.2SG do.PST
'I visited you.'

(150) Common Central Kurdish

a. *banghêşt=im kird-ît*
invitation=OBL.1SG:A do.PST-2SG:P
'I invited you.'

b. *serdan-î to=m kird*
visit-EZ 2SG=OBL.1SG:A do.PST
'I visited you.'

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13.4 Verbal person marking in Armenian

13.4.1 Core finite verbal forms: present and aorist inflectional endings

Modern Armenian has replaced many of the finite verb forms of Classical Armenian inherited from common Indo-European with periphrastic constructions using auxiliary verbs to indicate tense and mood. This tendency is more pronounced in Eastern than in Western Armenian. Finite verbs in Armenian inflect only for person and number indices of the grammatical subject relation, expressing A and S arguments, including subjects of passive verb forms (151) (see §14. In Classical Armenian, the perfect tense had default 3SG agreement for transitive verbs (see §21), but, to the best of our knowledge, this pattern has not survived in any modern dialect.

(151) SEA https://t.me/s/mediamagam?before=8439
sir-ecʿi u sir-v-ecʿi
love-AOR.1SG and love-PASS-AOR.1SG
'I loved and was loved.'

Number agreement is sometimes omitted for 3PL, i.e., 3SG agreement is used for 3PL referents, especially if inanimate (152).

(152) SEA (Hodgson 2019a: 36)
ačʿkʿ-er-s cʿav-um=a
eye-PL-ART1 hurt-I.PTCP=be.PRS.3SG
'My eyes hurt.'

13.4.1.1 Present (subjunctive) inflectional endings

The forms used as subjunctive (present and imperfect) in modern Armenian are those of the Classical Armenian present and imperfect indicative, which are the reflexes of the Indo-European present stem verb forms. These subjunctive forms, shown in Table 13.33, are the base for the KƏ-FORMS, which are used for present and imperfect indicative in Western dialects, and mainly as future/conditional forms in Eastern dialects (see sections 18, 17), and for the future/obligatory forms with *piti* + subjunctive (see §17).

13.4.1.2 Transitivity and aorist inflectional endings

The aorist (past perfective) in Armenian has two sets of endings, the so-called "active-type" and "passive-type". In Classical Armenian, the so-called "passive-type" endings were used with *-i-* stem verbs. These *-i-*stem verbs were mainly

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Table 13.33: SEA present and imperfect subjunctive of *sirel* 'to love'

Person	Present	Imperfect
1SG	*sir-em*	*sir-ei*
2SG	*sir-es*	*sir-eir*
3SG	*sir-i*	*sir-er*
1PL	*sir-enkᶜ*	*sir-einkᶜ*
2PL	*sir-ekᶜ*	*sir-eikᶜ*
3PL	*sir-en*	*sir-ein*

intransitive verbs with passive or anticausative/inchoative meaning (change-of-state verbs). [1] The Classical Armenian aorist endings are shown in Table 13.34.

Table 13.34: Classical Armenian "active-type" and "passive-type" aorist endings

Person	"Active-type" (Active/Causative)	"Passive-type" (Passive/Inchoative)
1SG	*-i*	*-ay*
2SG	*-er*	*-ar*
3SG	-	*-aw*
1PL	*-akᶜ*	*-akᶜ*
2PL	*-ekᶜ*/*-ikᶜ*	*-aykᶜ*/*-arukᶜ*
3PL	*-in*	*-an*

In SEA, where *-i*-stem verbs no longer form a separate category, but have become indistinguishable from *-e*-stem verbs, the "passive-type" endings are only used for verbs with certain affixes, including inchoative verbs derived from adjectives or nouns by means of the affix *-an-*. The "passive-type" endings are not used with the passive derivation, which takes the same endings as simple transitive active *-e-* stem verbs. The SEA aorist endings are shown in Table 159.

The form of colloquial Eastern Armenian spoken in Iran, where, as in SEA, the *-i*-stem verbs have merged with the class of *-e*-stem verbs, has generalised the "passive-type" endings to the whole class (see Dolatian et al. 2023: 118, 143).

[1] According to Luraghi et al. 2021: 376, 380, the origin of the suffix *-i-* was probably PIE **-(i)ię /o-*, which has been connected to the stative or intransitivising suffix **-eh1-/-h1-ye/o-* , which would link Armenian *-i-* with the Indo-Iranian suffix of *-ya-* stems and the Ancient Greek passive aorists with *-ē-*.

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Table 13.35: SEA "active-type" (active, causative and passive) and "passive-type" (inchoative) aorist endings

Person	"Active-type"		"Passive-type"
Person	Active	Passive	Inchoative
	bŕn-el	*bŕn-v-el*	*mec-an-al*
	'to catch'	'to be caught'	'to become big'
1SG	*bŕn-ecʿ -i*	*bŕn-v-ecʿ-i*	*mec-acʿ-a*
2SG	*bŕn-ecʿ-ir*	*bŕn-v-ecʿ-ir*	*mec-acʿ-ar*
3SG	*bŕn-ecʿ-Ø*	*bŕn-v-ecʿ-Ø*	*mec-acʿ-av*
1PL	*bŕn-ecʿ-inkʿ*	*bŕn-v-ecʿ-inkʿ*	*mec-acʿ-ankʿ*
2PL	*bŕn-ecʿ-ikʿ*	*bŕn-v-ecʿ-ikʿ*	*mec-acʿ-ankʿ*
3PL	*bŕn-ecʿ-in*	*bŕn-v-ecʿ-in*	*mec-acʿ-an*

In Urmia and Van dialects, we find the typically Eastern merger of *-i-* and *-e-* stem verbs in forms based on the CA present, but, unlike in SEA, the distinction is preserved to some extent in the aorist. In Urmia, according to Asatryan (1962: 106), the choice of aorist ending depends directly on transitivity, with transitive active verbs taking the "active-type'' endings, and intransitives and passives taking the "passive-type" endings. In Van, the old *-e*-stem verbs (mainly transitive) take "active-type'' aorists, and the old *-i*--stem verbs (mainly intransitive and passive) take "passive-type'' aorists (Acharyan 1952: 157).

Many Western dialects, including SWA, have preserved the distinction between *-i-* and *-e-* stem verbs. The *-i-* stem verbs, which include all passives, take "passive-type" aorist endings, as shown in Table 13.36.

13.4.1.3 Extension of present inflection to past verb forms

In some forms of Armenian, past tense endings have been remodelled by analogy with the present tense.

In dialects of the Urmia group, including Maragha, some Van subdialects (Acharyan 1952: 160), as well as Ararat dialects spoken in Iran (Tehran, Tabriz), Nakhijevan (Astapat), and Vayots Dzor (Vardanyan 2004), and apparently in the speech of an increasing number of colloquial EA speakers in Armenia (V. Katvalyan p.c. described this feature as "invasive"), the 1SG of past tense forms (aorist, and imperfect in those dialects that possess it) takes the ending *-m*, which is the final consonant of the 1SG present tense ending. Table 13.37 compares the 1SG endings of present, imperfect, and aorist in SEA and colloquial Iranian EA.

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Table 13.36: SWA "active-type" (e-stem) and "passive-type" (i-stem) aorist

Person	e-stem *koč^{c}-el* 'to call'	i-stem (passive) *koč^{c}-v-il* 'to be called'	i-stem (active) *xōs-il* 'to speak'
1SG	*koč^{c}-ec^{c}-i*	*koč^{c}-v-ec^{c}-a*	*xōs-ec^{c}-a*
2SG	*koč^{c}-ec^{c}-ir*	*koč^{c}-v-ec^{c}-ar*	*xōs-ec^{c}-ar*
3SG	*koč^{c}-ec^{c}-Ø*	*koč^{c}-v-ec^{c}-av*	*xōs-ec^{c}-av*
1PL	*koč^{c}-ec^{c}-ink^{c}*	*koč^{c}-v-ec^{c}-ank^{c}*	*xōs-ec^{c}-ank^{c}*
2PL	*koč^{c}-ec^{c}-ik^{c}*	*koč^{c}-v-ec^{c}-ak^{c}*	*xōs-ec^{c}-ank^{c}*
3PL	*koč^{c}-ec^{c}-in*	*koč^{c}-v-ec^{c}-an*	*xōs-ec^{c}-an*

Table 13.37: 1sg present subjunctive, imperfect subjunctive, and aorist of the verb *ergel* 'to sing' in SEA and colloquial Iranian Armenian (Dolatian et al. 2023)

Dialect	Present	Imperfect	Aorist
SEA	*erg-em*	*erg-ei*	*erg-ec^{c}-i*
Colloquial Iranian EA	*yeɹk^{h}-em*	*yeɹk^{h}-im*	*yeɹk^{h}-am*

Similarly, in Suceava dialect, spoken in Romania, the 2SG imperfect ending, originally *-eir*, has been remodelled to *-eis* through analogy with the 2SG present *-s* (Acharyan 1911).

13.4.2 Complex verb forms: the copula/auxiliary BE as person marker

The enclitic copula/auxiliary serves as a subject person marker in clauses with non-verbal predicates or complex tense forms composed of a participle plus the auxiliary. In most Western dialects, it is enclitic on the participle in complex tense forms. In Eastern Armenian dialects, including SEA, and some Western dialects spoken in Eastern Anatolia (Van, Mush, Diyarbakir, Dersim), the copula/auxiliary is mobile, being sensitive to prosodic prominence and information structure (see §15 for details). In most dialects, the negated copula/auxiliary is not mobile (see §15 for exceptions). It is stressed, and fixed in immediately preverbal position in complex verb forms (154). This contrasts with its behaviour with non-verbal predicates, which it follows (153).

(153) SEA https://iravunk.com/?p=160941&l=am

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im *čakat-i-n* *«patgamavor»* *gr-ac* *čʿi*
1SG.GEN forehead-DAT-DEF write-RES.PTCP NEG.be.PRS.3SG
"'Deputy" is not written on my forehead.'

(154) SEA
im *čakat-i-n* *«patgamavor»* *čʿi* *gr-el*
1SG.GEN forehead-DAT-DEF NEG.be.PRS.3SG write-PST.PTCP
'S/he didn't write "Deputy" on my forehead.'

In most dialects, the copula/auxiliary also expresses tense (present vs. past), except in the dialects with a past particle (see §12.4.4), where past tense is expressed by this particle. In these dialects, the present form of the copula could be considered to be unmarked for tense, expressing only a person index. The endings of the present and past copula/auxiliary, as seen in Table 13.38, are parallel to those of the present and imperfect subjunctive, i.e., the CA present and imperfect of lexical verbs, as seen in Table 13.33.

Table 13.38: The paradigm of the enclitic copula/auxiliary in Standard Eastern Armenian

Person	Present	Past
1SG	*em*	*ēi*
2SG	*es*	*ēir*
3SG	*ē*	*ēr*
1PL	*enkʿ*	*ēinkʿ*
2PL	*ekʿ*	*ēikʿ*
3PL	*en*	*ēin*

13.4.3 Person syncretism

In some Armenian dialects, we find syncretism of certain person endings parallel to that found in other languages of the area. In particular, Vaux (2016: 33) compares the patterns of person syncretism in the imperfect endings of the Sasun dialect group with person syncretism in Kurdish. As seen in Table 13.33, the 2SG and 3SG imperfect suffixes (originally *-eir* and *-eɾ*) are merged to *-eɾ*, while *-ek^h* is used for 1SG (originally *-ei*), 1PL (originally *-eink^h*), and 2PL (originally *-eik^h*).

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13.4.4 Pronominal objects throughout the verbal system

13.4.4.1 Pronominal object expressed by free dative person marker

Stressed pronominal objects can be expressed by independent object pronouns in dative case, whose position is variable, as seen in (155) and (156),

(155) SEA
kʻez *sir-um=em*
2SG.DAT love-I.PTCP=be.PRS.1SG
'I love you.'

(156) SEA
sir-um=em *kʻez*
love-I.PTCP=be.PRS.1SG 2SG.DAT
'I love you.'

13.4.4.2 Pronominal object optionally omitted

The overt expression of pronominal objects is optional. Cognitively accessible objects can be expressed with zero anaphora, as seen in (157).

(157) SEA
sir-um=em
love-I.PTCP=be.PRS.1SG
'I love (me/you/him/her/it/us/them).'

13.4.4.3 Pronominal object expressed by "possessive articles"

In most Armenian dialects, there are no bound pronominal object indices. In some dialects spoken in Iran, however, the so-called "possessive articles" (see §11.4.2) may attach to verbs to express nonsubject arguments, parallel to the "Set 2" clitics found in other languages of the area (see §13.5). In colloquial Iranian Armenian, only the second person form can be used (Dolatian et al. 2023), but in Urmia, first person objects can also be expressed in this way, as seen in (159).

(158) Colloquial Iranian Armenian (Dolatian et al. 2023: 169)
kə-zang-em=ət
PTCL-call-1SG=ART2
'I will call you.'

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(159) Urmia Armenian (Asatryan 1962: 136)
oɾoxkets^{h}=əs yres tun-ə
send-AOR.3SG=ART1 3PL.GEN house-DEF
'S/he sent me to their house.'

These "possessive articles" can also be used for certain types of recipient arguments, such as addressee (160), and benefactive (161).

(160) Colloquial Iranian Armenian (Dolatian et al. 2023: 176)
me ban as-em=ət
one thing tell-PRS.SBJV.1SG=art2
'Let me tell you something.'

(161) Urmia Armenian (Acharyan 1911: 284)
me tsi pərn-enk^{h}=t
one horse catch-PRS.SBJV.1PL=ART2
'Let's catch a horse for you.'

In contrast to the NENA possessive suffixes, when used in complex tense forms, they attach to the copula/auxiliary, which agrees with the subject, rather than to the lexical verb (162).

(162) Colloquial Iranian Armenian (Dolatian et al. 2023: 171)
naj-um=em=ət
look-I.PTCP=be.1SG.PRS=ART2
'I am looking at you.'

13.5 Discussion

In terms of verbal person marking, striking parallels are found between Neo-Aramaic and Neo-Iranian languages. The most striking parallelism is the tense-aspect-determined inversion of role marking in transitive clauses, which has been noted by many scholars in the field (see Khan 2004a, 2007c, Coghill 2016 and Noorlander 2021c,a for recent discussions and further references therein). This similarity is strongest between conservative NENA and conservative Gorani dialects, e.g.,

(163) C. Marga, NENA

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a. *šaql-ux* *-lax*
take.PRS-1PL:A -OBL.2SG.F:P
'We take you.' Present habitual

b. *šqil-ux* *-lax*
take.PST-1PL:P -OBL.2SG.F:A
'You took us.' Past perfective

(164) Hewramî

a. *ber-mê* *=ta*
take.PRS-1PL:A =OBL.2PL:P
'We take you.' Present habitual

b. *berđ-îmê* *=ta*
take.PST-1PL:P =OBL.2PL:A
'You took us.' Past perfective

Here, two sets of bound person markers are attached to the verbal stem, and their morphological arrangement remains the same, but the syntactic role they cross-reference is inverted depending on the TAM value of the verb. The NENA oblique (L-)suffixes correspond to the oblique pronominal clitics in Iranian, while the direct (D-)suffixes correspond to the other direct person agreement affixes in Iranian.

In northern and central varieties of Central Kurdish (e.g., Erbil, Suleimaniya), a similar type of role referencing inversion is attested in verbal person marking. Here, however, the oblique set expressing both P-present and A-past generally attaches to a preverbal host, as shown in (165), which never happens in NENA (but see the parallels with mobile person markers in NENA further below). The direct suffixes remain bound directly to the verbal stem, similarly to the direct suffixes in NENA.

(165) Common Central Kurdish

a. *de=tan* *-be-yn*
IND=OBL.2PL:P -take.PRS-1PL:A
'We take you.' Present

b. *de=tan* *bird-în*
IND=OBL.2PL:A take.PST-1PL:P
'You were taking us.' Past progressive

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If oblique person markers that express A-past land on a past stem verb form rather than a preverbal element in Central Kurdish, the ordering of the sets is generally different from that of NENA. In upper Central Kurdish dialects, such as Mukri, the A-P order of person markers in past stem verbal constructions reflects that which is found for the independent person markers in Northern Kurdish (see below). Here, the oblique set can precede the direct suffixes. Such ordering of oblique before direct person markers never occurs in NENA.

(166) CK Mukri
dî =tan -în
see.PST -OBL.2PL:A -1PL:P
'You (pl.) saw us.'

In some southern varieties of Central Kurdish, however, the past tense reflects the exact same pattern as in NENA and in Gorani, e.g.,

(167) CK Jaffi (Mohammadirad In press)

a. *de=yan-be=yn*
IND=OBL.2PL:P-take.PRS-1PL:A
'We take them.' Present

b. *bird-în=yan*
take.PST-1PL.P=OBL.3PL:A
'They took us.' Past

In present stem verbal forms, however, the oblique clitic would land on the preverbal modifier, which does not happen in NENA.

In Behdînî Northern Kurdish, this inversion is manifested in verbal person marking only with respect to either A in the present or P in the past, but not both. Otherwise, the inversion is expressed by case on the independent pronoun, where the oblique case is assigned to both P-present and A-past. Note that the respective order of the A and P arguments remains the same and is not inverted depending on tense, e.g.,

(168) Behdînî Northern Kurdish

a. *Ez te t-be-m*
DIR.1SG OBL.2SG IND-take.PRS-1SG:A
'I take you.' Present

b. *Te ez bir-im*
OBL.2SG DIR.1SG take.PST-1SG:P
'You took me.' Past

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This type of inversion is also attested in the case system of the north-western outlier Zazaki. In Zazaki, however, the verbal object affix in the past generally consists of distinct verbal endings vis-à-vis the present, so that the inversion is not necessarily also morphologically evident on the verb, e.g.,

(169) Zazaki

a. *ez* *to* *ben-a*
DIR.1SG OBL.2SG take.PRS.AUG-1SG:A
'I take you.' Present

b. *to* *ez* *berd-a*
OBL.2SG DIR.1SG take.PST-1SG:P
'You took me.' Past

Nevertheless, there is great internal variation in NENA, and some measure of variation also in Kurdish. If there are restrictions, the past stem verbal forms are more restricted than the present stem verbal forms. The minimal parallelism that is found in this respect between the NENA dialects and the neighbouring Iranian languages is the observable pattern of matching the encoding of the A argument in the past to that of the P argument of the present. Thus, both Neo-Aramaic and its Neo-Iranian neighbours employ a so-called "oblique" set to express the A argument in the past as well as the P argument in the present. This principle applies to a varying extent in all North-eastern and Central Neo-Aramaic dialects and in Northern and Central Kurdish, Gorani, and several other north-western Iranian languages located outside of the Neo-Aramaic speaking region (see also Haig 2008). Here, it is also relevant to consider that in conservative dialects of both Neo-Iranian and Neo-Aramaic, the person marking of P-past can be zero for the third person (masculine) singular, cf. Gorani Gawraju *košt-∅=im* 'I killed him' (Mahmoudveysi et al. 2012: 38), NENA C. Marga *qṭəl-∅-li* 'I killed him'. The recent documentation data on NENA dialects does seem to reflect an areal distribution of the aforementioned role reference inversion that may point to contact with south-eastern varieties of Northern Kurdish, called Behdînî in north-western Iraqi Kurdistan and the Turkish province of Hakkari. Throughout Northern Kurdish, there is a tendency to drop the verbal affixes that express P in the past, but this tendency is largely not observed in Behdînî NK. In the majority of NENA dialects, too, the inversion is completely obsolete or restricted to third-person P arguments in the past, except in the north-west, which would coincide with the region of Behdînî NK. In the same region as Behdînî NK, NENA dialects are found that allow for the "oblique" L-suffixes to be omitted on past

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stem verbal forms. This is only possible when the construction is transitive, and the verb has a P-index (see further §21.2.2.4 and §21.2.3.4).

In constructions based on the past stem or the resultative participle, a noticeable tendency shared between Neo-Iranian and Neo-Aramaic is person-based preferences, especially in the ordering of person markers. In the NENA dialects, this change in ordering of A and P in their attachment to the verbal stem tends to go hand in hand with a change in sets of person markers, as the position of each set of suffixes in the verbal form is fixed. In Iranian, however, the sets of person markers dedicated to A and P remain generally independent of the order they occur in. A striking parallel, however, is the preference for P-A order when the A argument is third person. In all variaties of Central Kurdish, P-A order is preferred when the A argument is third person singular. This corresponds to a tendency among NENA dialects to prefer P-A order of person markers when the A argument is third person, e.g.,

(170) C. Bne Matha, NENA

a. *šqil-ax -le*
take.PST-1PL:P -OBL.3SG:A
'He took us.' Past perfective

b. *šqil-əllan =ile*
take.RES.PTCP-1PL:P -COP.3SG:A
'He has taken us.' Present perfect

(171) Common Central Kurdish

a. *bird-în =î*
take.PST-1PL:P =OBL.3SG:A
'He took us.' Past

b. *bird-û-yn =î*
take.PST-PTCP-1PL:P =OBL.3SG:A
'He has taken us.' Present perfect

In copula-based transitive verbal constructions, there is a direct correspondence between the copular syntax of south-eastern Trans-Zab Jewish dialects of NENA and that of Gorani, which parallels the past stem verbal inflection ((Khan & Mohammadirad 2024b: 194–202). In both language groups, the perfect is formed on the basis of the copula and a participle, which jointly express S and P. The convergence, however, remains partial in terms of person constraints and agent marking. In the irrealis perfect, there is a direct correspondence between

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the copulas as bound object markers and the obliques as bound agent markers, while in the realis perfect, the oblique agent markers are not available in NENA, and can only entail a third person agent. Moreover, all constructions based on the past stem and resultative participle are restricted to third person objects in these Trans-Zab Jewish NENA dialects.

(172) J. Saqiz (Yisraeli 1998

a. *xəzy-a -lu*
see.PST-3SG.F -OBL.PL:A
'They saw her.' Past

b. *xzite=ya -∅*
see.RES.PTCP.F.SG:P=COP.3SG.F:P -3:A
'They(/he/she/it) have seen her.' Realis present perfect

c. *xzit=awy-a -lu*
see.RES.PTCP.F.SG:P -be.PRS.-3SG.F:P -OBL.3PL:A
'They might have seen her.' Irrealis present perfect

(173) Hewramî

a. *dî-e =şa*
see.PST-3SG.F =OBL.3PL:A
'They saw her.' Past

b. *dî-ê=ne =şa*
see.PST-PTCP.F.SG:P=COP.3SG.F:P =OBL.3PL:A
'They have seen her.' Realis present perfect

c. *dî-ê=b-o =şa*
see.PST-PTCP.F.SG:P=be.PRS.-3SG:P =OBL.3PL:A
'They might have seen her.' Irrealis present perfect

The use of the enclitic copulas as (mobile) verbal person markers in complex verb constructions more closely converges with Armenian. They combine with the resultative participle, for instance, to express a complex perfect. In many NENA dialects, such complex perfects can still be patient-oriented with transitive verbs, with only an implicit agent. In several Christian dialects of NENA, however, notably C. Urmi and Shaqlawa, the complex perfect construction must be agent-oriented when the verb is transitive (cf. Khan 2016b, I: 404), which parallels the dominant syntax of such constructons in modern Armenian.

Moreover, across NENA dialects and Armenian, the enclitic copula can be mobile and moves to the most accented constituent on the left edge of the verb

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phrase. Its syntax is sensitive to prosodic prominence, information structure, and discourse configuration. In Armenian, this mobility is characteristic of Eastern Armenian, and some dialects from the eastern part of the Western Armenian-speaking area (Van, Mush, Diyarbakir, Dersim). As an auxiliary, the position of the negated copula in most Armenian dialects is preverbal. This closely parallels the syntax of copulas in the majority of NENA dialects. With respect to mobility and attachment to negation, their function as agent markers in transitive perfects has more in common with the mobile oblique clitics in Central Kurdish than the copula in Iranian more generally. In Iranian languages, the copula is typically fixed in clause-final position. In the Neo-Iranian languages of the NENA-speaking region, the syntactic roles that the copula expresses are typically fixed, namely S and P. The syntactic role expressed by the copula in NENA and Armenian is generally only S or A, with the exception of south-eastern Trans-Zab Jewish NENA. In placement, however, the oblique clitic in Neo-Iranian tends to come in second position within the verb phrase, irrespective of prominence or discourse configuration, but does not usually attach to NPs with S or A roles. This notwithstanding, there are circumstances where these mobile person markers do overlap, which is presumably not incidental. Thus, in Central Kurdish, the oblique clitic can also move to a nonsubject *wh*-constituent in the clause, as well as to the negator, as its hosts before the verbal stem. This syntatic convergence, though not driven by the same mechanisms, does parallel both NENA and Eastern Armenian.

(174) C. Nerwa (Noorlander field notes)

a. *ʾāt* *ma=t* *xil-a?*
NOM.2SG what=COP.2SG.M:A eat.RES.PTCP-M.SG:A
'You, what have you eaten?' Host is *wh*-object

b. *le-le* *xil-əlle*
NEG-COP.3SG.M:A eat.RES.PTCP.M.SG:A-3SG.M:P
'He has not eaten it.' Host is negator

c. *ʾayya* *məni=le* *xil-əlla*
DEM.F.SG who=COP.3SG.M:A eat.RES.PTCP.M.SG:A-3SG.F:P
'Who has eaten this?' Host is *wh*-agent

d. *ma* *le-t* *xil-a*
WHAT NEG-COP.2SG.M:A eat.RES.PTCP-M.SG:A
'What have you not eaten?' Host is negator

(175) SEA

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a. *du* *inčʿ=es* *ker-el?*
2SG.NOM what=be.PRS.2SG eat-PST.PTCP
'You, what have you eaten?' Host is *wh*-object

b. *čʿ-i* *ker-el*
NEG-be.PRS.3SG eat-PST.PTCP
'S/he has not eaten (it).' Host is negator

c. *sa* *ov=ē* *ker-el?*
DEM1 who=bePRS.3SG eat-PST.PTCP
'Who has eaten this?' Host is *wh*-agent

d. *inčʿ* *čʿ-es* *ker-el?*
what NEG-be.PRS.2SG eat-PST.PTCP
'What haven't you eaten?' Host is negator

(176) Central Kurdish

a. *to* *çî=t* *xward-û=e*
DIR.2SG what=OBL.2SG:A eat.PST-PTCP=COP.3SG
'You, what have you eaten?' Host is *wh*-object

b. *ne=î-* *xward-û-n=e*
NEG=OBL.3SG:A- eat.PST-PTCP-3PL:P=COP.3SG
'He has not eaten them.' Host is negator

c. *kê* *eme=î* *xward-û=e*
who DEM=OBL.3SG:A eat.PST-PTCP=COP.3SG
'Who has eaten this?' Host is **not** *wh*-agent

d. *çî=t* *ne-* *xward-û=e*
what=OBL.2SG:A NEG- eat.PST-PTCP=COP.3SG
'What have you not eaten?' Host is *not* negator

This parallelism is even more striking in the negation of the complex perfect as opposed to the negation of non-verbal predicates. In such copula-based constructions, the person marker typically attaches to the negator in NENA. In NENA and Armenian, the negative copula is used in both types of clauses, while in Kurdish and Gorani, the negative copula is not used in the perfect. In several Jewish varieties of NENA, preverbal vs. postverbal placement relative to the predicate signals a distinction between a transitive complex verb construction and an intransitive state. This again closely parallels the syntax of person marking in both SEA and Central Kurdish. In comparison to Central Kurdish, however, NENA copula

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placement parallels the mobile oblique clitics that denote the agent. More generally, the preverbal placement of the negative copula as opposed to its postverbal placement is associated with a verbal as opposed to a nonverbal predicate in most Armenian dialects and several NENA dialects. In negative forms of complex verb constructions, the person marking can also be expressed on both the main verb and the negative auxiliary in some Armenian dialects, notably Mush, Diyarbakir, Dersim, some Van subdialects, and Bayazet. These occasional mixed forms are also recorded among Jewish NENA dialects of Iranian Azerbaijan and parallel these Armenian dialect forms.

(177) J. Koy Sanjak (Mutzafi 2004a: 107)

a. *lewe plix-u*
NEG.COP.3SG.M:A open.RES.PTCP.M.SG:A-3SG.M:P
'He has not opened them.' Negator and subject index preposed

b. *plix-a lewe*
open.RES.PTCP-M.SG:S NEG.COP.3SG.M:S
'It is not open.' Negator and subject index postposed

(178) SEA

a. *Čʿi bacʿ-el.*
NEG.be.PRS.3SG open-PST.PTCP
'S/he has not opened (sth.).' Negator and subject index preposed

b. *Bacʿ čʿe.*
open NEG.be.PRS.3SG
'It is not open.' Negator and subject index postposed

(179) Central Kurdish

a. *ne=y kirdû=n-ewe*
NEG=OBL.3SG:A do.PST.PTCP=COP.3PL:P=DRCT
'He has not opened them.' Negator and subject index preposed

b. *krawe nîye*
open NEG.COP.3SG:S
'It is not open.' Negator and subject index postposed

Using the preverbal TAM modifier as landing site for the oblique clitic in Central Kurdish would further parallel the use of a preverbal deictic copula in NENA dialects, while the object coding remains attached to the verb, e.g.,

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(180) C. Nerwa
ho-le *pðax-əlley*
DEIC-COP.3SG.M:A open.PROG-3PL:P
'He is opening them.' Present progressive

(181) Central Kurdish
de=y *-kird-in-ewe*
IND=OBL.3SG:A -do.PST-3PL:P=DRCT
'He was opening them.' Past progressive

In the majority of Trans-Zab Jewish dialects of NENA, however, the copula has lost its mobility, takes a fixed position after the verbal stem, and can ultimately end up fused with it as an inflectional ending in the northern varieties. This fixed position parallels the syntax of the copula in Iranian more generally, but in the complex perfect it also parallels the placement of the oblique clitic in Gorani, where the negator precedes the verbal stem as in these NENA varieties, but no person marker moves to it. The use of "possessive suffixes" as object indices in complex verbal forms in NENA reflects a parallelism with the P-A order in past stem verbal forms, and as such is more comparable to the perfect in conservative Gorani dialects and southern dialects of Central Kurdish.

(182) J. Koy Sanjak Mutzafi 2004a
xzi-t-an *=ila*
see.PST-PTCP.F.SG:A-POSS.1PL:P =COP.3SG.FA
'She has seen us.' Realis present perfect

(183) Hewramî
dî-ê=nmê *=şa*
see.PST-PTCP.PL:P-COP.1PL:P =OBL.3PL:A
'They have seen us.' Realis present perfect

(184) CK Sanandaj
bird-êg=man=yan=e
take.PST-PTCP=1PL:P =OBL.3PL:A=COP.3SG
'They have taken us.' Realis present perfect

With the exception of Zazaki and Northern Kurdish, pronominal objects are typically bound to the verb, and their independent expression is associated with discourse prominence. In the majority of Central Kurdish, case distinctions among personal pronouns have been lost, similarly to NENA. The development

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of dedicated independent pronominal objects in NENA dialects of Iran, however, converges with those in Armenian, Persian and Azeri, e.g.,

(185) C. Urmi

a. *ḵa-díyyax* ⁺*byay=ən.*
DAT-2SG.F want.PROG=COP.1SG.M
'I love *you*.'

b. ⁺*byay=ən* *ḵa-díyyax.*
want.PROG=COP.1SG.M DAT-2SG.F
'I love *you*.'

(186) SEA

a. *kʿez* *sir-um=em.*
2SG.DAT love-I.PTCP=be.PRS.1SG
'I love you.'

b. *sir-um=em* *kʿez.*
love-I.PTCP=be.PRS.1SG 2SG.DAT
'I love you.'

In Armenian, object pronouns are often dropped altogether when they are cognitively accessible. This typically does not occur in Neo-Aramaic or in the neighbouring Iranian langauges, but is a general phenomonenon among Mlaḥso Neo-Aramaic speakers (Jastrow 1985: 56). The speakers of Mlaḥso Neo-Aramaic report that they used to live alongside Armenians (Jastrow 1985). Unlike most of Neo-Aramaic, such cognitively accessible object indices can be dropped entirely in Mlaḥso Neo-Aramaic, e.g.,

(187) Mlaḥso Neo-Aramaic
li *ṣid-len* ... ∅ *ṣid-len*
OBJ.1SG seize.PST-OBL.3PL OBJ.1SG take.PST-OBL.3PL upon
∅ *mobə-len, ʿal* *ə-goro li qṭir-len*
DEF.SG-roof.M.SG DAT.1SG bind.PST-OBL.3PL
'They seized me ... They seized me, took me to the roof (and) tied me up.'

(188) Agulis Armenian (Tsghna) Hodgson (2022a)
Tan-um=a *nel* *hit-ə* *kʿäšvän.*
take-I.PTCP=be.PRS.3SG PST with-ART3 field
'He used to take me to the fields with him.'

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Finally, the processes of extension and cross-system harmonisation within the respective languages can be observed across NENA, Iranian and Armenian, in which present tense clauses function as an analogical model. In general, there is a close correspondence between these languages in the tendency for the enclitic copula forms to be(come) identical or near-identical to the subject affixes of the present tense. There is also a tendency for the person marking of present tense verbal forms to be extended to other verbal forms. This extension can be complete, as in the case of Southern Kurdish as well as Persian; in Armenian, too, there are some examples of present tense subject indexes that have been extended to the past. In NENA, however, this extension remains only partial, and it is primarily transitive verbal constructions that are analogically adapted to present stem verbal forms, which can even result in mixed forms.

In NENA and some dialects of Kurdish, for instance, it is only the oblique coding of the pronominal object in present tense clauses that has been extended to the pronominal object in the past. Consequently, in both Neo-Aramaic and Kurdish, this can result in the so-called "double oblique" expression of A and P arguments, e.g.,

(189) C. Haṣṣan
xze -lux -li
see.PST -OBL.2SG.M:A -OBL.1SG:P
'You saw me.'

(190) Ṭuroyo Neo-Aramaic
ḥze -lux -li
see.PST -OBL.2SG.M:A -OBL.1SG:P
'You saw me.'

(191) Mlaḥso Neo-Aramaic (Jastrow 1994a)
ṭʿin -len -le
carry.PST -OBL.1PL:A -OBL.3SG.M:P
'They carried him.'

(192) Common Northern Kurdish
Te min dît
OBL.2SG OBL.1SG see.PST
'You saw me.'

In terms of geographic distribution, this is found particularly among Christian dialects of NENA in the western sector, including Central Neo-Aramaic. This

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western distribution in NENA would correspond with the western and northern distribution of the "double oblique" past transitive construction in Northern Kurdish.

In several conservative NENA dialects in south-eastern Anatolia and western Iraqi Kurdistan, the "double oblique" construction is confined to two-argument clauses consisting of an agent and a recipient pronominal argument. This parallels the use of the oblique pronouns in Northern Kurdish, where the oblique recipient is placed after the verb across the tense-based split, e.g.,

(193) C. Marga

a. *yaw -ət -ti*
give -2SG.M:A -OBL.1SG:R
'You give me (sth.).'

b. *ywəl -lux -li*
give.PST -OBL.2SG.M:A -OBL.1SG:R
'You gave me (sth.).'

(194) Common Northern Kurdish

a. *Tu di-d-î min*
DIR.2SG IND-give.PRS-2SG:A OBL.1SG
'You give (it) to me.'

b. *Te da min*
OBL.2SG give.PSTOBL.1SG
'You gave (it) to me.'

In the eastern sector, the "double oblique" clitics found in Central Kurdish dialects of Iranian Kurdistan and peripheral Gorani dialects correspond to the "oblique" L-suffixes combined with the phonetically reduced LL-series in the past stem verbal forms in the local Trans-Zab Jewish NENA varieties.

(195) J. Sanandaj
xze -lox -li
see.PST -OBL.2SG.M:A -OBL.1SG:P
'You saw me.'

In NENA, however, the relative order of bound person markers reflects A-P ordering, as in present stem verbal forms, whereas the relative order is P-A in the local Central Kurdish dialects, as it is more generally in Gorani. This ordering in

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southern CK varieties reflects a substrate feature from Gorani (Mohammadirad 2025d, In press). Interestingly, in the peripheral so-called Bajalani varieties of Gorani in Iraq, the order appears to be A-P, similarly to NENA.

(196) CK Sanandaj
dî *=man* *=tan*
see.PST =OBL.1PL:P =OBL.2PL:A
'You saw us.'

(197) Gorani Qala
dî *=man* *=şan*
see.PST =OBL.1PL:P =OBL.3PL:A
'They saw us.'

(198) Gorani Bajalani Mosul (MacKenzie 1956: 423)
arnā *=m* *=iš*
put.PST =OBL.1SG:A =OBL.3SG:P
'I put it down.'

In Persian and Southern Kurdish varieties, cross-system harmonisation is complete. The "direct" subject indices and "oblique" object indices have been made consistent across all tenses, e.g.,

(199) Southern Kurdish
a. *we-n=ed*
take.PRS-3PL:A=OBL.2SG:P
'They take you.'
b. *bird-in=ed*
take.PST-3PL:A=OBL.2SG:P
'They took you.'

In NENA, however, the situation has remained more mixed and is less consistent, converging with the neighbouring Iranian-speaking communities. The majority of NENA dialects, however, have generalised the transitive inflection of the present stem verbal forms, e.g.,

(200) C. Nerwa
a. *ʾi-šaql-i-lax*
IND-take-3PL.A-OBL.2SG.F:P
'They take you.'

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b. *qəm-šaql-i-lax*
PST.PFV-take-3PL:A=OBL.2SG.F:P
'They took you.'

Such an extension does not seem to occur in Central Kurdish, Zazaki, or Gorani, nor does it typically occur among Northern Kurdish speakers in the region we are concerned with here. However, the extension of the "direct" case to also mark the A-past was sporadically recorded in Dorleijn (1996)'s elicitication responses among Turkish-Northern Kurdish bilinguals in Diyarbakir, e.g.,

(201) NK Diyarbakir (Dorleijn 1996: 117)
a. *Ez* *wan* *di-bîn-im*
DIR.1SG OBL.3PL IND-see.PRS-1SG:A
'I see them.' Present
b. *Ez* *wan* *dît-im*
DIR.1SG OBL.3PL see.PST-1SG:A
'I saw them.' Past

Northern Kurdish dialects of the enclave in Gilan, located north-west of Tehran in Iran, have fully generalised the transitive morphosyntax of present tense clauses (Shojai 2005, Haig 2008: 253-255).

In some Armenian dialects of Iran, first or second person object indices can be expressed as "possessive articles" attached to the verb (see §13.4.4.3), similarly to Persian and Southern Kurdish. Their form and function parallels the use of the "possessive suffixes" in NENA complex verbal forms as well as the oblique clitics in Central Kurdish and Gorani present stem verbal forms more generally. Their functions also coincide with the "oblique" L-suffixes in NENA. Unlike the object indices in NENA and Iranian, these "possessive articles" attach to the copula in complex verbal forms in Armenian, and not to the lexical verb. Binding of "possessive suffixes" to a copula would be impossible in NENA, but L-suffixes and the LL-series can be bound to a copula as object indices.

Analogy in the reverse direction, i.e., the extension of "oblique" agent markers from past stem verbal forms to present stem verbal forms, does not occur. Extension of "oblique" person markers to wider contexts of usage, however, does occur. In a few NENA dialects in Hakkari, for example, the L-suffixes have been extended across the paradigm of the present affirmative enclitic copula, similarly to the S-past and A-past person markers, e.g., *qime=li* 'I have risen' : *qəm-li* 'I got up'(see §13.2.2.2 and Table 13.11. The extension of the oblique L-suffixes

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throughout the paradigm of the present deictic copula has a widespread distribution across NENA dialects. In Gorani dialects outside the Hawraman region, such as Bajalani of the Mosul region and Bajalani of the Qasr-e Shirin region, the oblique A-past clitics have been extended to S-past, which parallels the uniform syntax of "oblique" L-suffixes as S-past and A-past indexes across NENA dialects. Overall, the NENA dialects exhibit a staggering degree of diversity in terms of verbal person marking. Typologically, a great deal of this microvariation can be understood against the backdrop of the surrounding language communities, Iranian in particular. A general tendency towards internal uniformity in argument marking, especially with respect to the direct object, is not only evident in verbal person marking, but also in the syntax of case, to which we turn in Chapter 21.

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14 Valency changing constructions: causative and passive

This chapter offers a summary of the formation of causatives and passives in the respective languages. In NENA, causativisation is primarily handled by verbal stem derivation. Three major stem classes are distinguished: Stem I (basic, often intransitive), Stem II (a largely non-productive, mostly transitive class), and Stem III, which is the main productive causative formation across dialects. While most dialects maintain a formal distinction between Stems II and III, many peripheral varieties show partial or complete merger due to analogy and phonetic erosion, especially involving loss or reduction of the causative *m*-augment. In addition to morphological causatives, NENA employs periphrastic causatives using verbs meaning 'let' or 'make/do' plus a subjunctive complement.

Unlike causatives, passives in NENA are rarely morphological. Instead, they are typically expressed through periphrastic constructions, notably with the auxiliary 'come' plus an infinitive, a pattern clearly linked to contact with Northern Kurdish. Another widespread strategy is the impersonal passive, which reduces agent specificity (often via third-person plural coding) without full detransitivisation. Some western dialects exhibit agentless past constructions that resemble passives in meaning but remain syntactically transitive. Participles and infinitives may also be voice-ambiguous, allowing patient-oriented (passive-like) readings in appropriate contexts. Jewish Trans-Zab dialects stand out in systematically distinguishing inchoative/passive and causative forms in past and perfect constructions. For a detailed discussion of the passive in NENA and its parallel constructions, see Noorlander (2026a). The comparative sections show that Iranian languages display both synthetic and periphrastic passives and productive morphological causatives, with significant microvariation and frequent overlap between passive and inchoative morphology. Armenian, by contrast, relies heavily on a highly productive intransitivising suffix that covers passive, reflexive, reciprocal, and anticausative functions, alongside analytic causatives with 'give'. Overall, the chapter demonstrates how NENA has largely lost dedicated valency-reducing morphology, compensating through periphrastic strategies shaped by sustained contact with Iranian and Kurdish varieties.

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14.1 Causative and passive in NENA

14.1.1 Available "stems" and their historical background

The term "Stem" is used here to refer to a class of verbs within Neo-Aramaic rather than simply the stem of a verb to which suffixes are added. Generally, Central and North-Eastern Neo-Aramaic distinguish between three "Stems". "**Stem I**" comprises all basic verbs (non-derived), both transitive and intransitive. The majority of intransitive verbs belong to this class, and it is the direct historical reflex of the so-called Grundstamm ("G-Stem") in common Semitic. Stems II and III constitute the main valency-increasing derivations. "**Stem II**" is a closed class of mostly transitive verbs (non-productive) and goes back to the so-called intensive/factitive or Dopplungstamm ("D-Stem"). "**Stem III**" is the primary formation to derive causatives from Stem I and goes back to the so-called Kausativstamm ("C-Stem"). Historically, each of these stems had a detransitive counterpart which was derived by adding a *t*-prefix and modifying the templatic morphology of the verb. These verbal forms were not strictly passive, but covered a wide range of detransitivising functions typical of a middle voice marker, including anticausative, reflexive, reciprocal, and passive. The direct reflexes of the participles of these detransitive formations continue in Ṭuroyo Neo-Aramaic, to which NENA dialects are closely related. Table 14.1 summarises the main verbal stems in Ṭuroyo, their functions, and their historical background, based on the detailed analysis in (Kuzin 2026). Lexically transitive and intransitive verbs are distinguished in their inflection of the past in Ṭuroyo, e.g., the intransitive verb *d-m-x* 'to sleep' is inflected differently from the transitive verb *g-r-š* 'to pull': *daməx-∅* 'he slept' vs. *grəš-le* 'he pulled'. Ṭuroyo even has impersonal passive forms of intransitive verbs.

Table 14.1: Verbal derivations in Ṭuroyo Neo-Aramaic

	Function	Present	Reflex of	Past	Reflex of
Stem I	Transitive	*gorəš* ('to pull')	ACT.PTCP.	*grəš-le*	RES.PTCP.
	Intransitive	*doməx* ('to sleep')		*daməx*	STAT. PTCP.
	Detransitive	*məgrəš* ('to be pulled')	MED.PTCP.	*griš*	RES.PTCP.
	Impersonal	*mədməx* ('(people) sleep')		*dmix*	RES.PTCP.
Stem II	Transitive	*mʿaləq* ('to hang')	ACT.PTCP.	*mʿalaq-le*	RES.PTCP.
	Detransitive	*miʿaləq* ('to be hung')	MED.PTCP.	*mʿaləq*	RES.PTCP.
Stem III	Transitive	*maltəm* ('to gather')	ACT.PTCP.	*maltam-le*	RES.PTCP.
	Detransitive	*mitaltəm* ('to be gathered')	MED.PTCP.	*mtaltəm*	RES.PTCP.

By contrast, most NENA dialects lost the originally intransitive and detransitiving formations that were preserved in Ṭuroyo. What remains are the originally

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transitivising formations, as shown in Table 14.2. This resulting gap is filled by ambitransitivity, periphrastic constructions and impersonal constructions. However, similarly to Ṭuroyo, several NENA dialects preserved a transitivity distinction in the past stem verb forms, as illustrated in Table 14.3. In these varieties, Stem I and II merged, but, at the same time, a dedicated intransitive class of verb forms was preserved in the inflection of the past. Here, the characteristic /i/ of the basic past stem *qṭil-* was generalised for all intransitive past stem verb forms, including those of Stem III.

Table 14.2: Verbal derivations and their inflectional bases in the majority of NENA (illustrated with the dummy verb *q-ṭ-l* 'to kill')

	Present	Past	Result. Ptcpl.	Impv. Sg.	Impv. Pl.	Infinitive
Stem I	*qaṭəl-*	*qṭil-*	*qṭil-*	*qṭul*	*qṭulu(n)*	*qṭala*
Stem II	*(m)qaṭəl-*	*(m)quṭəl-*	*(m)quṭl-*	*(m)qaṭəl*	*(m)qaṭlu(n)*	*(m)qaṭole*
Stem III	*maqṭəl*	*muqṭəl-*	*muqṭl-*	*maqṭəl*	*maqṭlu(n)*	*maqṭole*

Table 14.3: Basic forms of 'to sleep', 'to take out','to get lost', and 'to put to sleep' in J. Saqiz (Yisraeli 1998)

		Stem I	Stem I/II	Stem III	
		Intransitive	Transitive	Intransitive	Transitive
		dmx 'sleep'	*plṭ* 'take out'	*skr* 'get lost'	*dmx* 'put to sleep'
Present	3M.SG	*daməx*	*paləṭ*	*maskər*	*madməx*
Past	3M.SG	*dmix*	*pləṭ-le*	*məskir*	*mədməx-le*
Infinitive		*damoxe*	*paloṭe*	*maskore*	*madmoxe*

There is further microvariation across NENA dialects in stem formation. First, the archaic feature where the *m*-augment is not found in the imperative and infinitive of Stems II and III occurs in a few dialects in the southern periphery, mostly those of the Mosul Plain (Qaraqosh, Bariṭle, Shiyuz). Second, the complete loss of the *m*-augment in Stem II due to secondary elision—for example, *zubənne* < *mzubənne* 'he sold',is primarily found in the western and northern sectors, including conservative dialects such as C. Hertevin. Finally, vowel raising in Stem II from *qaṭṭəl* to *qeṭṭəl* or *qiṭṭəl* is typical of several Christian dialects in the regions of Hakkari and Van in Turkey and that of Salamas in Iran.

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Table 14.4: Inchoative/Causative alternations in NENA

Type	Form	Intransitive Inchoative	Transitive Causative
Labile	(C. Marga)	'open' (Stem I)	'open' (Stem I)
	Present	*pasəx*	*pasəx*
	Past	*psəxle*	*psəxle*
Causative	(C. Marga)	'cook' (Stem I)	'cook' (Stem II)
	Present	*bašəl*	*mbašəl*
	Past	*bšəlle*	*mbušəlle*
Causative	(C. Marga)	'eat' (Stem I)	'feed' (Stem III)
	Present	*yaxəl*	*maxəl*
	Past	*xəlle*	*muxəlle*
Mixed	(C. Jinnet)	'cook' (Stem I)	'cook' (Stem II)
	Present	*bošəl*	*bošəl*
	Past	*bšəllə*	*bšəllə ~ bušəllə*
	Imperative Sg.	*bšül*	*bšül*
	Imperative Pl.	*bašlən*	*bašlən*
	Infinitive	*bšola*	*bšola*
Mixed	(J. Sanandaj)	'go out' (Stem I)	'bring out' (Stem II)
	Present	*păléṭ*	*paléṭ*
	Past	*pliṭ*	*pləṭle*
	Imperative Sg.	*păləṭ ~ pluṭ*	*păləṭ*
	Imperative Pl.	*păləṭmu(n)*	*păləṭmu(n)*
	Infinitive	*păloṭa*	*păloṭa*

14.1.2 Formation of causatives

14.1.2.1 Synthetic causatives

The formation of causatives is illustrated by examples from C. Marga, C. Jinnet and J. Sanandaj in Table 14.4 and comes in two primary types, namely labile/ambitransitive and causative. Labile verbs, such as 'to open' and 'to break', mostly belong to "Stem I". In most alternations, the intransitive pendant appears in Stem I, and the transitive pendant is non-basic, either from Stem II or Stem III. All dialects have Stem I and Stem III, where Stem III is the primary valency-increasing formation to derive causative verbs. The majority of dialects make use of two stems to increase valency, i.e., Stem II and III. In several dialects,

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however, Stem I and II have merged with each other and are only partly distinguished in their paradigmetic organisation and stem morphology due to analogy and phonetic changes. This tendency is mostly found in the western and eastern peripheries. Among Christian dialects, this (partial) merger is found in the dialects of Hassan, Derabün and Jinnet, the dialects in and around Aqra, and the south-eastern Christian dialects, i.e., Sulemaniyya and Sanandaj. Among Jewish dialects, this merger is found in the Trans-Zab group as well as Barzani. In the Trans-Zab Jewish dialects, however, only the past stem verb forms of the transitive pendant are inflected using the so-called oblique L-suffixes, while in the Christian varieties both the intransitive and transitive pendant are inflected as such.

14.1.2.2 Periphrastic causatives

Periphrastic causatives can be formed on the basis of the basic verb (I) *šwq* or *ṭry* 'to let' + subjunctive, as (1) shows, or on the basis of the causative (III) of the verb *ʾwð* 'to do, make' + subjunctive, as (2) illustrates.

(1) C. Nerwa

a. *b-madmx-a-lax*
FUT-CAU.sleep-3SG.F:A-2SG.F:P
'She will put you to bed.'

b. *b-šoq-a* *∅-damx-at*
FUT-let-3SG.F:S SBJV-sleep-3sg.f:S
'She will let/make you sleep.'

(2) C. Urmi
bət-mavvədd-i-lax *ḵat-∅-damx-at*
FUT-CAU.do-3PL:A-2SG.F:P CONJ-SBJV-sleep-3sg.f:S
'They will make you go to sleep.'

14.1.3 Formation of passives

14.1.3.1 Synthetic passives

The most common expression that serves as the translational equivalent of the passive is the so-called impersonal or non-promotional passive, which, strictly speaking, does not involve a valency change, but a change in referentiality. In the impersonal passive, the patient argument appears as a direct object (P

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argument). The agent is still strongly implied, but generic third person agent coding 'they, people' is used to reduce its specificity/identifiability. At times, however, a valency change occurs: the intransitive verb that otherwise conveys a spontaneous event can be used impersonally, especially in the context of generic habitual events, and in such cases, it more strongly implies an agent, as shown in (3).

(3) C. Marga
xawər-Ø-wa *ta-t-mbašl-ux-wa-le* *le*
whiten.INTR-3SG.M:S-PST so-that-cook.CAUS-1PL:A-PST-3SG.M:P NEG.HAB
bašəl-Ø-wa
cook.INTR-3SG.M.S-PST
'It needs to be whitened, so we can cook it; otherwise it cannot be cooked (lit. it cannot cook).'

Several NENA dialects in the western sector within the sphere of Behdînî Northern Kurdish have clauses based on agentless past stem verbs. In this impersonal construction, the topicalised patient appears as a direct object but the agent is left unexpressed, as (4) illustrates. This omission of the agent can fulfill a function equivalent to passivisation, i.e., a subjectless non-promotional passive. In these conservative NENA dialects, the construction as a whole remains transitive. Even though the agent is deleted, the patient retains its status as the object, and, therefore, it does not involve intransitivisation. A spontaneous reading of (4) is therefore impossible.

(4) C. Marga
tot-i *qṭil-a*
grandma.F.SG-my kill.PST-3SG.F:P
'(They/people) killed my grandma.'

In the south-eastern dialects of Trans-Zab Jewish NENA, intransitive and transitive verbs are generally distinguished by their stem and/or their inflectional endings in the past stem verbal forms and complex perfect. Virtually every transitive verb has a valency reduced formation in the past stem verbal forms and complex perfects. For most verbs, the past and complex perfect each have different stems depending on lexical transitivity, shown in Table 14.5. The intransitive betrays the characteristic stable template of CC*i*C of Stem I verbs, while the transitive reflects the original inflection of Stem II verbs, alternating between C*ə*CC

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or CCəC depending on syllable structure. This promotional passive, where the patient becomes the S argument, is distinct from the non-promotional passive in (4). Here, by contrast, the intransitive Stem I past or perfect verb form can express an event as having unfolded spontaneously, e.g., *plix-a* open.PST-3SG.F:S 'it opened (by itself)', without implication of an agent, or with a stronger agent implication, e.g., *qṭil-a* kill.PST-3SG.F:S 'she was killed (by somebody)'.

Table 14.5: Passive and inchoative in southeastern Trans-Zab Jewish past and perfect forms

Form	**Inchoative**	**Passive**	**Causative**
(J. Sulemaniyya)	'die'	'be killed (by sb.)'	'kill (sb.)'
Past	*mil-∅*	*qṭil-∅*	*qṭəl-le*
Perfect		*qṭilá=y*	*qəṭlá=y*
(J. Sanandaj)	'open (by itself)'	'be opened (by sb.)'	'open sth.'
Past	*plix-∅*	*plix-∅*	*pləx-le*
Perfect	*plix-á=y*	*plix-á=y*	*pəlx-á=y*

14.1.3.2 Periphrastic passives

The passive is generally not expressed through modification of the template of the verbal stem, but by alternative means. A dedicated passive construction that entered NENA through contact with Northern Kurdish is the combination of the auxiliary 'to come' and the infinitive, as (5) illustrates. The infinitive can be voice-neutral in several dialects of NENA, particularly in the northern sector. Patient orientation of the infinitive is most likely the result of contact with Iranian.

(5) C. Marga
čant-i *se-la* *l-gnawa.*
bag.F.SG-my came.PFV-3SG.F:S to-steal.INF
'My bag was stolen.'

The resultative participle of transitive verbs can have either agent or patient orientation, depending on the context. If this verbal adjective has patient orientation, it expresses the resulting state registered by the patient argument caused by an implicit agent, as (6) shows. The auxiliary combined with the resultative participle in such constructions is either the copula or the intransitive verb 'to become; to remain'.

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(6) C. Marga
kull-ey bat-ət *Xərbaṣale hadəx =wewa* *bəny-e*
all-3PL house.PL-CSTR Xirbasale thus =PST.COP.3PL:S built.RPP-PL
'All the houses of Xirbasale were built that way.'

14.1.4 Agent complements of passives

In general, the use of the passive is associated with more formal speech, in which case the agent is generally suppressed. The external cause of intransitive verbal constructions, however, can be expressed overtly by the following prepositions:

- *min* 'from, of' (also indirect cause marker), cf. (7);
- *(ʾə)b-* 'by, with, through' (instrumental marker);
- Complex prepositional phrases
  mən qam 'because of' (indirect cause marker), lit. 'from before' , cf. (8);
  b- 'in; with, by' + ʾiðəd 'hand of', cf. (9).

(7) C. Nerwa
ʾe-maða *pəš-la* *bn-ita* *mən huðaye*
DEM.F.SG-village.F.SG became.PFV-3SG.F:S built.RPP-F.SG from Jew.PL
'This village was built by Jews.'

(8) C. Urmi
+ʾəstican mən qam poxa *npəl-le* *ʾu* *šməṭ-le*
cup.M.SG from before wind.M.SG fell.PFV-3SG.M:S and shatter.PFV-3SG.M:S
'The cup fell and broke because of the wind.'

(9) C. Nerwa
ðe-lay *l-qəṭla* *b-ið-əd* *dəbba*
came.PFV-3PL:S to-kill.VN by-hand.F.SG-CSTR bear.M.SG
'They were killed by a bear.'

Sporadically, the preposition *l-* can also be used to express the agent, see Noorlander (2021a, 2026a) for further discussion and references.

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14.1.5 Transitivity alternations in light verb constructions

NENA displays constructions involving alternation between transitive light verbs (e.g., 'do/make', 'give', 'bring') and intransitive light verbs (e.g., 'be/become', 'come', 'remain'). These constructions are especially widespread in varieties spoken in regions with a history of contact with Iranian languages. For example, the intransitive verb *xadər* 'become' is used in Trans-Zab Jewish varieties, such as the Jewish dialect of Urmi, e.g., *⁺razi xadər* 'to become content' is the intransitive counterpart of *⁺razi od* 'to make content'. In the Christian dialect of Urmi, the intransitive verb is generally *ʾavə* 'be, become' (Khan 2016b: vol. 2, 457-458), though sometimes also *payəš* 'become; remain', e.g., *⁺razi payəš* 'to become content', which is the intransitive counterpart of *⁺razi ʾavəd* 'to make content'. Thus, similarly, the passive of transitive light verb constructions can be created on the basis of an inchoative verb that is selected as a light verb, e.g., C. Urmi *rad ʾavə* passive 'to be removed' as the intransitive counterpart of *rad ʾavəd* 'to remove' (Khan 2016b: vol. 3, 264).

14.2 Causative and passive in Iranian

14.2.1 Formation of causatives

14.2.1.1 Synthetic causative

Causative morphology is expressed primarily by suffixation in Iranian. In Hewramî, the suffixes *-n* (prs) and *-na* (pst) attach to the present stem of some intransitive verbs and derive transitive counterparts. The relevant suffixes are *-ên* (prs) and *-and* in CK, and *-în* (prs) and *-and* in NK.

(10)

Variety	Infinitive	Intransitive prs.	Intransitive pst.	Causative prs.	Causative pst.
Hewramî	*êşay*	*êş-*	*êşa-*	*êşn-*	*êşna-*
		'to hurt'		'to hurt'	
CK	*êşan*	*êş-*	*êşa-*	*êşên-*	*êşand-*
		'to hurt'		'to hurt'	
NK	*êşan*	*êş-*	*êşa-*	*êşîn-*	*êşand-*
		'to hurt'		'to hurt'	

In a few verb pairs, H. Tekht has preserved an older pattern of umlaut for the formation of causative stems, attested since the Middle Iranian period (Skjærvø 2009: 220), e.g., Middle Persian: *ahram* 'go up' vs. *ahrām* 'lead up' (TR). This pattern is attested in the verb 'to break', where the intransitive/inchoative verb

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appears with the detransitiviser suffix *-ye* (PRS); *-ya* (PST). The causative counterpart not only lacks the intransitive suffix but is distinguished by a change in the vowel of the stem (see Khan & Mohammadirad 2024b, Mohammadirad 2026).

(11)

Infinitive	Intransitive		Causative	
	prs.	pst.	prs.	pst.
meřyay	*meřye-*	*meřya-*	*mař-*	*mařa-*
	'to break'		'to break'	

In terms of causative/inchoative alternations, several types of verb pairs can be distinguished in Iranian. The examples are from Hewramî (Mohammadirad 2026) unless otherwise indicated. (i) Causative alternation: Here, the inchoative verb is the basic form, and the causative is derived from it (12).

(12)

PRS stem	
top	'die (animal)' (INTR)
top-n	'kill (animal)' (TR)

(ii) Some verb pairs exhibit "equipollent alternation", meaning that the stem is the same for both the causative and inchoative stems, but the affixes used with each verb are different (13).

(13)

pijg-ye	'scatter' (INTR)
pijg-in	'sow, to scatter' (TR)

(iii) Some verb pairs exhibit "anticausative alternation," where the causative stem is the basic form and the inchoative is derived from it (14).

(14)

fař-	'change' (TR)
fař-ye	'change' (INTR)

(iv) Finally, some verb pairs exhibit "labile alternation", in which the same stem is used for both the inchoative and the causative.

(15)

Hewramî	*xiz-*	'slip (tr., intr.)'
NK. Shemzînan	*sot-*	'burn (tr., intr.)'

The inchoative verbs in an anticausative or equipollent alternation are equivalent to what have been termed medio-passive verbs. The *-ye* suffix on these verbs is identical to the passive suffix *-ye*. Notably, the medio-passive suffix has been lost in NK and most CK varieties. Thus, for instance, the equivalent of the equipollent alternation is expressed by the causative alternation in these varieties.

(16)

	Hewramî	NK	CK
'suffocate' (INTR)	*xinîk-ye*	*xeniq-*	*xink-*
'suffocate' (TR)	*xinîk-n*	*xeniqîn-*	*xinkên-*

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14.2.1.2 Periphrastic causative

In NK dialects outside the Behdînî zone, causative constructions may be expressed periphrastically using the inflected form of the verb 'to give' plus the infinitive form of the verb. The causee is expressed by a prepositional phrase.

(17) NK
ez ê bi te bi-di-m fêrkirin
1SG.DIR FUT to 2SG.OBL SBJV-give.PRS-1SG:A teach.INF
'I will make you learn.'

The same periphrastic causative constructions occur in Zazaki.

(18) Zazaki (Paul 2024: 98)
mi sere-yê ci da ji kerdeni
1SG.OBL head-EZ.M 3SG.OBL give.PST cutting do.INF
'I had his head cut off.'

14.2.2 Formation of passives

14.2.2.1 Synthetic passive

Within Iranian, verbal morphological stems are divided into the following categories:

(19) 'to take'

	Hewramî	Beh. NK	central CK
Present stem	*ber-*	*be-*	*be-*
Past stem	*berđ-*	*bir-*	*bird-*
Resultative participle	*berđe* (M); *berđê* (F, PL)	*birî-*	*birdû-*
Imperative	*ber-*	*be-*	*be-*
Infinitive	*berđey*	*birin*	*birdin*

In Hewramî, the passive stem is generally formed by adding a passive suffix to the present stem of transitive verbs. It has the forms *-ye/-îye* (PRS.) and *-ya/-îya* (PST).

(20) *wiretey* 'sell'

Present stem	*wireş-*
Present passive	*wireşye-*
Past passive	*wireşya-*

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The passive stem exhibits morphological allomorphy in verb stems with a CV(C) pattern where the vowel is a near-open front unrounded vowel [æ], transcribed as <e>. The passive stem of such verbs contains the close-central unrounded vowel [ɨ], transcribed as <i>, which is mostly used as an epenthetic vowel. The resultant passive stem has the same morphology as inchoative stems:

(21)

Verb	Gloss	Past stem	Prs. stem	Pass. stem
kerđey	'to do'	kerđ-	ker-	kir-
berđey	'to take'	berđ-	ber-	bir-
warđey	'to eat'	warđ-	wer-	wir-
wenay	'to read'	wena-	wen-	win-
day	'to give'	da-	de-	dir-

This is similar to the stem morphology of inchoative verbs such as 'to die':

(22)

Verb	Gloss	Past stem	Prs. stem
merđey	'to die'	*merđ-*	*mir-*

Passive and inchoative verbs exhibit identical morphology with regard to the endings they take. This is exemplified by the active and passive stems of the verb *wiretey* 'to sell' and the present and past stems of the inchoative verb *qomyay* 'to happen'.

Table 14.6: Identical morphology of passive and inchoative

	Active transitive	Passive	Inchoative
Present stem	*wireş-*	*wireş-ye*	*qom-ye*
Past stem	*wiret-*	*wireş-ya*	*qom-ya*
Participle	*wirete-* (M); *wiretê-*(F, pl)		*qomya-* (M); *qomyê-*(F, PL)
Infinitive	*wiretey*		*qomyay*

The passive in much of CK is expressed synthetically by the detransitive suffix *-(r)a*.

(23) CK Shaqlawa
hîç=im *pê ne-biř-ā-∅*
nothing=1SG:R to NEG-cut.PRS-PASS.PST-3SG:S
'Nothing was given to me.'

The same suffix is used to form the anticausitive. Thus, when used with verbs like 'break' either a spontaneous reading or a strong agent implication may be inferred.

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(24) CK
dirga şik-a-∅
door break.PRS-PASS/INC-3SG:S
'The door broke/is broken.'

In Bajalani, the synthetic passive is formed by adding *-nî* to the present stem of the verb.

(25) Bajalani (MacKenzie 1956: 432)
me-kş-inî-(î)
IND-kill.PRS-PASS-1SG:S
'I shall be killed.'

14.2.2.2 Periphrastic passive

In NK, the historical synthetic passive has been lost. Instead, passive is expressed by a periphrastic construction consisting of the inflected form of the verb 'to come' plus the infinitive form of the main verb.

(26) NK Zakho
ij Cihî-ya hatî=ye sitandin
from Jew-PL.OBL come.PST-PTCP=COP.3SG:S take.PST.INF
'It has been transmitted (lit. taken) from the Jews.'

In Zazaki, by default, the synthetic passive is used, which consists of the stem and the detransitiviser suffix *-ya*.

(27) Zazaki (Paul 2024: 96)
altûnî tiri-ay-ê
gold steal.PST-PASS-COP.3SG:S
'The gold has been stolen.'

Paul (2024: 96) mentions that passive can also, though rarely, be expressed periphrastically in Zazaki, in which case it is formed using an inflected form of the verb 'to come' plus the infinitive.

(28) Zazaki
ê do bîrê kişteni
3PL FUT come.PRS.3PL:S kill.INF
'They will be killed.'

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In Gorani varieties situated in the Bahdînî contact zone, the periphrastic passive is attested alongside the historical synthetic passive. Note, however, that the periphrastic passive in Bajalani has an additional adposition preceding the infinitive, not found in NK.

(29) Bajalani (MacKenzie 1956: 433)
êd *ama* *ne* *kuştin*
DEM.3SG come.PST.3SG:S PREP kill.INF
'He was killed.'

14.2.3 Agent complements of passives

Across Kurdish, the oblique agent is expressed by a prepositional phrase headed by *be* 'by' or similar adpositions, e.g., *be dest* 'by hands', *le layen* 'from'.

(30) Hewramî (Mohammadirad 2026: 320)
sewzê xel *kir-ya=n* ***be sahêb-î=ç=iş***
crop grain do.PRS-PASS=COP.3SG.M:S by owner-OBL.M=ADD=3SG:PSR
'The crop has been piled up [lit. turned into corn] by its owner too.'

14.2.4 Transitivity alternations in light verb constructions

A prominent feature of Iranian languages is the existence of verbal elements consisting of a light verb and a non-verbal element, similar to the English verb 'give heed to'. These light verb constructions are now the most productive way of forming new verb meanings. The most common light verbs in these constructions are 'do', 'be/become', 'fall', 'come', etc. Examples:

(31)

LV	CK	NK	Gor	'Gloss'
'to do'	*saz kirdin*	*çê kirin*	*weş kerdey*	'to make'
'to fall'	nexoş kewtin	*nexweş ketin*	*neweş kewtey*	'to fall ill'
'to be'	*nizîk bûn*	nêzîk bûn	*nizîk bîyey*	'to approach'
'to come'		*tûş hatin*	*tuş hatin*	*tûş amay*
'to run into'				
'to cut'	*mare biřîn*	*mehr biřîn*	*mare biřyey*	'to marry'

As can be seen from (31), the non-verbal element in light verb constructions can be an adjective (e.g., *nexweş* 'ill') or a noun (e.g., *mare* 'marriage').

The transitivity in light verb constructions is determined by the lexical transitivity of the light verb, not the semantic transitivity of the verb as a whole. In the following examples, *fewt kerđey* 'to pass away' [lit. death to do] and *dest pê*

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kirin 'start' [lit. hand to do] are semantically intransitive, but have the syntax of transitive verbs, as the subject NP is indexed by the clitic pronoun in (32), and appears in the oblique case in (33).

(32) Hewramî
fewt=iş *kerđ*
death=3PL:A do.PST
'He/she passed away.'

(33) NK
buhar-ê *dest* *pê kir*
spring-F.SG.OBL hand to do.PST
'The spring started.'

14.3 Causative and passive in Armenian

In Armenian, the most frequent means of altering the valency or transitivity of a verb involve adding suffixes to the stem.

14.3.1 Formation of causatives

14.3.1.1 Synthetic causative

Intransitive verbs can be transitivised by causativisation, by adding the suffix which in SEA has the form *-cʿn-* to the present stem, as seen in (34), where we find the causative *vazecʿnel* 'to cause to run' of *vazel* 'to run'. This agglutinative causative is inherited from Classical Armenian.

(34) SEA (Dum-Tragut 2009: 319)
banak-um amen ōr *zinvor-ner-i-n* *vaze-cʿn-um=en*
army-LOC every day soldier-PL-DAT-DEF run-CAUS-I.PTCP=be.PRS.3PL
'In the army they make the soldiers run every day.'

Some intransitive verbs cannot be causativised morphologically, including weather verbs and some verbs of cognition, as well as *gnal* 'go' and *gal* 'come', although most other verbs of motion can form morphological causatives (see Dum-Tragut 2009: 319). Verbs that cannot be causativised morphologically can form an analytic causative with the infinitive + *tal* 'give', as seen in (35).

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(35) SEA (Dum-Tragut 2009: 319)
nra ənkeruhi-n nran karc-el=ē tal-is
DEM3.GEN girlfriend-DEF DEM3.DAT think-INF=be.PRS.3SG. give-I.PTCP
tʿe inkʿə gełecʿik ē
conj 3SG.NOM beautiful be.PRS.3SG
'His girlfriend makes him think, (that) he is beautiful.'

14.3.1.2 Periphrastic causative

Transitive verbs can only be causativised periphrastically, as seen in (36).

(36) SEA (Dum-Tragut 2009: 320)
Vardan-ə bolor-i-n tesn-el tv-ecʿ ir nor mekʿena-n
Vardan-DEF all-DAT-DEF see-INF give-AOR.3SG 3SG.GEN new car-DEF
'Vardan made everybody see his new car.'

14.3.2 Formation of passives

Transitive verbs can be intransitiviaed by adding the suffix *-v-*, which creates passives (37), reflexives (38), reciprocals (39), and anticausatives (40).

(37) SEA (Asatryan 2004: 214)
usanoł-ner-i kołm-icʿ zekucʿum=ēr patrast-v-el
student-PL-GEN side-ABL report=be.3SG.PST prepare-PASS-PST.PTCP
'A report was prepared by the students.'

(38) SEA (Asatryan 2004: 214)
patrast-v-um=ē dataran dim-el
prepare-PASS-I.PTCP=be.3SG.PRS court apply-INF
'He is preparing (himself) to go to court.'

(39) SEA (Asatryan 2004: 216)
Suren-ə ev Ašot-ə hambur-v-ecʿin
suren-DEF and ashot-DEF kiss-PASS-3PL.AOR
'Suren and Ashot kissed each other.'

(40) SEA (Asatryan 2004: 214)
saŕnamanikʿ-ner-n sks-v-ecʿin dektember-i kes-er-icʿ
frost-PL-DEF start-PASS-3PL.AOR december-GEN half-PL-ABL
'The frosts started from the middle of December.'

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It has great lexical generality (there are very few transitive verbs that cannot form passives in this way[1]), and even greater paradigmatic generality, occurring in all tenses and aspects, and on participles as well as inflected verbs.

For most verbs, it attaches to the present stem (41.a, b). For verbs whose infinitive ends in *-al* (41.c, d, e), including the category of inchoatives derived from adjectives or nouns which take the endings *-an-al* (41.d, from *urax* 'happy') or *-en-al* (41.e, from *vax* 'fear'), it attaches to the perfective stem (see Dum-Tragut 2009: 334-335):

(41)

	Active	Translation	Passive	Translation
a.	gr-el	'write'	gr-v-el	'be written'
b.	tesn-el	'see'	tesn-v-el	'be seen/see each other'
c.	kard-al	'read'	kardacʿ-v-el	'be read'
d.	uraxan-al	'be(come) happy'	uraxacʿ-v-el	'be made happy (with implied cause)'
e.	vaxen-al	'be(come) afraid'	vaxecʿ-v-el	'be frightened (with implied cause)'

This suffix did not exist in Classical Armenian. It arose in Middle Armenian, and is used in all known modern forms of Armenian.

14.3.3 Agent complements of passives

Overtly expressed agents in passive constructions have been found to be very rare in both Eastern (Asatryan 2004: 213) and Western (Haig 1982: 175) Armenian texts.

When agents are overtly expressed in passive constructions, this is generally either with the postposition *kołmicʿ*, or with ablative case. According to Dum-Tragut 2009: 340, prototypical agents, i.e., [+human] referents with agent role, are expressed with the postposition *kołmicʿ* (lit. 'side-ABL'):

(42) SEA (Dum-Tragut 2009: 340)
ayn gorcadir-i kołm-icʿ gnahat-v-el=ē
DEM3 executive-GEN side-ABL appraise-PASS-PST.PTCP=be.PRS.3SG.
bavarar
sufficient
'It has been appraised by the executive as sufficient.'

With emotion verbs, the [+human] experiencer in a passive construction is expressed with ablative case, as seen in 43.

[1]There are a few exceptions, including the verbs *unenal* 'to have', *gitenal* 'to know', *złǰal* 'to regret', which do not have passive forms (see Dum-Tragut 2009: 176).

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(43) SEA (Dum-Tragut 2009: 341)
Anna-n sir-v-um=ē ir bolor dasənker-ner-icʿ
Anna-DEF love-PASS-I.PTCP=be.PRS.3SG 3SG.GEN all classmate-PL-ABL
'Anna is loved by all her classmates.'

When the agent of a passive construction is a natural force, this is also expressed with ablative case, as seen in 44.

(44) SEA (Dum-Tragut 2009: 341)
terev-ner-ə šarž-v-um=en kʿam-ucʿ
leaf-PL-DEF move-PASS-I.PTCP=be.PRS.3PL wind-ABL
'The leaves are moved by the wind.'

14.3.4 Transitivity alternations in light verb constructions

Like other languages of the area, Armenian has constructions showing alternation between transitive light verbs such as 'to do/make, to give, to bring' and intransitive light verbs such as 'to be/become, to come, to remain'. These are especially common in areas where there is contact with Iranian languages, and some of the preverbs, such as *ŕazi* and *ŕad*, are borrowed from Iranian languages (in some cases through the mediation of Azeri, which has also borrowed these constructions). Such alternations include *ŕazi anel*, lit. 'content do/make', with transitive meaning 'to convince, to satisfy', vs. *ŕazi linel*, lit. 'content be(come)', with intransitive meaning 'to agree to something, to be satisfied', *ŕad anel* with transitive meaning 'to remove', vs. *ŕad linel* with intransitive meaning 'to be removed, to remove oneself', which has an alternative form *ŕad gal*, with the light verb 'to come' instead of 'to be(come)'. The literary Armenian equivalent of *ŕazi linel*, *goh mnal* 'to be content', uses the light verb 'to stay'. For the transitive meaning, a causative verb *gohacʿnel* 'to make satisfied' is usually used in SEA rather than a light verb construction.

Some other light verb constructions show the alternation *tal* 'give' or *acel* 'bring' (transitive) vs. *gal* 'come' (intransitive/passive), for example *šuŕ tal/acel* 'to turn (something)' vs. *šuŕ gal* 'to turn/be turned round', *man tal/acel* 'to take someone/something for a walk' vs. *man gal* 'to go for a walk/wander around', *pʿul tal/acel* 'to demolish/ruin' vs. *pʿul gal* 'to be demolished/ruined', etc.

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14.4 Discussion

One major structural level of convergence of both NENA and Northern Kurdish is the general loss of valency-reducing morphology in verbal derivation. A reduction in valency and transitivity has to be expressed by alternative means. This can be contrasted with the Neo-Aramaic and Neo-Iranian varieties that have retained detransitivising voice markers. Across Iranian, Armenian and Aramaic, the synthetic "passive" involves a verbal derivation that is better characterised as detransitive, under which also other valency and transitivity reducing semantics can be subsumed, such as anticaustives. A dedicated morphological passive therefore does appear to exist. Passive and anticausitive verb forms can exhibit identical morphology with regard to the stem and endings they take. Kurdish, especially its Northern varieties, shifted from older synthetic passives to periphrastic passives using 'come' plus the infinitive, while still retaining synthetic forms in other dialects. The auxiliary 'come' can be combined with the infinitive to express the passive across NENA dialects, which is a pattern imposed on Neo-Aramaic through Kurdish-Aramaic bilingualism. The expression of the agent can be through the idiom 'by the hand of', which is a structure that incidentally converges with Kurdish, as (45) and (46) illustrate.

(45) J. Zakho (NW Iraq; Cohen 2012: 180, fn. 15)
u=b-ase-∅ ʾəl maqoze b-əd ʾiz-∅ Mušulman-e
and=FUT-come-S.3SG.M to CAU.burn.INF by-CSTR hand-of Muslim-PL
'He will be burned (by Muslims).'

(46) Northern Kurdish (NW Iraq)
ew=ê bi dest-ê misliman-an wer-e şewit-and-i
3SG=EZ.M.SG by hand-EZ.M.SG muslim-PL SBJV.come-3SG burn-CAU-INF
'He will be burned (by Muslims).'

The expression of indirect causation in Kurdish, *ji ber*, literally 'from before', converges with Neo-Aramaic *mən qam*, as (47) and (48) show. In this case, the ultimate source of the agent complements in Kurdish may well have been Semitic (e.g., Noorlander 2026b).

(47) C. Urmi (NW Iran)
+tarra mən qam poxa ptəx -lə
door.M.SG from before wind opened.PFV -3SG.M
'The door opened because of the wind.'

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(48) Northern Kurdish (NW Iran)
jiber *ba-yê* *derî-∅* *vebû-∅*
because_of wind-EZ.M.SG door-M.SG.DIR open.PST-3SG:S
'The door opened because of the wind.'

In NENA, infinitives generally have active diathesis, but can also have passive diathesis (see Khan 2016b, II: 233–235), which presumably results from convergence with Iranian.

Intransitive verbs such as 'to become' feature as light verbs in light verb constructions or complex predicates in Iranian languages, notably Persian. Similar constructions are found in Kurdic, Armenian, Azeri, and NENA. It is conceivable that the use of the auxiliary *šodan* 'become' in the Persian passive construction may have at least influenced the use of *xadər* 'become' in the Jewish dialects of NENA in Iran. Contact with the surrounding Iranian and Turkic languages resulted in the alternation of transitive light verbs such as 'to do, to make' and intransitive light verbs such as 'to be, to become, to remain' in NENA dialects, especially in the varieties of Iran. Thus, literally 'content-make' alternates with 'content-become' in Persian *rāzi kardan* 'to make content, to please' *rāzi šodan* 'become content, be pleased', as well as in Azeri *razı etmek* (transitive) *razı olmaq* (intransitive), Northern Kurdish *razî kirin* *razî bûn*, and Armenian *razi anel* *razi linel*, and NENA, e.g., J. Urmi *+razi xadər* *+razi öd*.

Finally, these converging valency-reducing strategies contrast with the causative formations, which have largely remained untouched by contact-induced influence across the relevant languages. Here, Armenian and Kurdish betray a parallel in the usage of the verb 'to give' to form analytic causatives, a strategy that is notably absent in NENA.

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15 The copula

15.1 Copulas in NENA

15.1.1 Enclitic and Deictic Copulas

In NENA dialects, the equivalent of the English verb 'to be' in a present tense realis predication consists of a copula that is typically attached as a clitic to the predicate. The predicate may be ascriptive, locational or identificatory, e.g.,

(1) C. Qaraqosh (Khan 2002a: 125)

a. *báb-i kpìna=ilə.*
father-my hungry=COP.3SG.M
'My father is in the house.'

b. *báb-i b-bèθa=ilə.*
father-my in-house=COP.3SG.M
'My father is in the house.'

c. *ʾáwa náša bàb-an=ilə.*
that man father-our=COP.3SG.M
'That man is our father.'

The NENA copula has developed historically from the form of an enclitic pronominal copula, which existed in earlier Eastern Aramaic dialects, such as Syriac. The paradigms of the independent pronouns and their enclitic forms in Syriac are as follows (2). The relationship between the independent and enclitic forms is transparent:

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(2) Syriac (Nöldeke 1904: 44)

	Independent pronoun	Enclitic pronominal copula
3SG.M	*hū*	*=ū*
3SG.F	*hī*	*=ī*
3PL.M	*hennōn*	*=ennōn*
3PL.F	*hennēn*	*=ennēn*
2SG.M	*ʾatt*	*=att*
2SG.F	*ʾatt*	*=att*
2PL.M	*ʾattūn*	*=ttūn*
2PL.F	*ʾattēn*	*=ttēn*
1SG	*ʾenā*	*=nā*
1PL	*ḥnan*	*=nan*

Central Neo-Aramaic and Neo-Mandaic, which are the subgroups of Neo-Aramaic that are geographically adjacent to NENA, have retained paradigms of enclitic pronominal copulas that have a reasonably transparent relationship with the independent pronouns:

(3) Central Neo-Aramaic Ṭuroyo (Ritter 1990; Jastrow 1985)

	Ṭuroyo (Midyat)		Ṭuroyo (Midin)	
	Independent	Enclitic	Independent	Enclitic
3SG.M	*huwe*	*=yo*	*huwe*	*=yo*
3SG.F	*hiya*	*=yo*	*hiya*	*=yo*
3PL	*hənne*	*=ne*	*hənnek*	*=ne*
2SG.M	*hat*	*=hat*	*hat*	*=hat*
2SG.F	*hat*	*=hat*	*hat*	*=hat*
2PL	*hatu*	*=hatu*	*hatu*	*=hatu*
1SG	*ʾŭno*	*=no*	*ʾono*	*=no*
1PL	*ʾaḥna*	*=na*	*ʾaḥna*	*=na*

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(4) Central Neo-Aramaic Mlaḥso (Jastrow 1994a)

	Independent	Enclitic
3SG.M	*hiye*	*=yo*
3SG.F	*hiya*	*=yo*
3PL	*hiyen*	*=ene*
2SG.M	*hat*	*=hat*
2SG.F	*hat*	*=hat*
2PL	*hatun*	*=hatun*
1SG	*ʾono*	*=ono*
1PL	*ʾelɔna*	*=ena*

(5) Neo-Mandaic (Häberl 2009: 230)

	Independent	Enclitic
3SG.M	*huy*	*=ye*
3SG.F	*hid*	*=i*
3PL	*honni*	*=nɔn*
2sg	*ɔt*	*=ɔt*
2PL	*ʾatɔn*	*=tɔn*
1SG	*ʾan, ʾanɔ*	*=nɔn*
1PL	*ʾani*	*=ni*

The morphology of the copula exhibits considerable diversity across the numerous NENA dialects. In contrast to Ṭuroyo, Mlaḥso and Neo-Mandaic, in the majority of NENA dialects, the paradigm of the enclitic copula does not have a clear morphological relationship to paradigms of independent pronouns. The copula in NENA has converged with the morphology of verbs in various degrees across the different dialects.

The most advanced development is found in Jewish dialects on the eastern periphery in western Iran, such as J. Sanandaj, as can be seen in the following paradigms:

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(6) J. Sanandaj (Khan 2009: 85)

	Independent pronoun	Enclitic copula	Verb *h-w-y* 'to be'
3SG.M	*ʾo*	*=ye, =y*	*hăw-e*
3SG.F	*ʾo*	*=y-a*	*hawy-a*
3pl	*ʾoni*	*=yen*	*hăw-en*
2SG.M	*ʾāt*	*=y-et*	*hăw-et*
2SG.F	*ʾāt*	*=y-at*	*hawy-at*
2pl	*ʾaxtu*	*=yetun*	*hăw-etun*
1SG.M	*ʾana*	*=y-ena*	*hăw-ena*
1SG.F	*ʾana*	*=y-an*	*hawy-an*
1pl	*ʾaxni*	*=y-ex*	*hăw-ex*

The structural relationship of the enclitic copula to the independent pronouns in J. Sanandaj is not at all transparent. Rather, the inflectional endings of the enclitic copula are those of the inflection of present verbal forms (i.e., verbal forms with a stem that is derived historically from the active participle of earlier Aramaic). More specifically, the inflection of the copula resembles that of the present form of the verb *h-w-y* 'to be' (given in the right column above), which is used suppletively to express the irrealis and the future tense. In the history of NENA, the first and second person verbal inflections of the present form are, in fact, clitic first and second person pronouns in origin. The important point is, however, that they have now lost this status and have become verbal inflectional suffixes that have developed independently from the paradigm of pronouns.

The various NENA dialects exhibit different degrees of levelling between the inflection of the copula and verbal person-marker inflection. Across the NENA area, this levelling is least advanced in dialects that were spoken in the north-western periphery in south-eastern Turkey, i.e., adjacent to the area of the Central Neo-Aramaic subgroup, which, as we have seen, has retained pronominal copula enclitics. Some of the NENA dialects in this area exhibit a number of forms that are clearly light enclitic pronouns in origin and differ from the verbal inflection of the verb *h-w-y*. This can be seen in the dialects of C. Hertevin (Jastrow 1988) and C. Van, where the first and second person copula forms, and also the 3pl forms, still tend to resemble the endings of the independent pronouns rather than the verbal endings:

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(7) C. Hertevin (Jastrow 1988: 28)

	Independent pronoun	Enclitic copula	Verb *h-w-y* 'to be'
3SG.M	*ʾahu*	*=ile*	*haw-e*
3SG.F	*ʾahu*	*=ila*	*hawy-a*
3PL	*ʾaḥni*	*=ini*	*haw-e*
2SG.M	*ʾahət*	*=ihət*	*haw-ət*
2SG.F	*ʾahat*	*=ihat*	*hawy-at*
2PL	*ʾaḥniton*	*=əḥton*	*haw-etun*
1SG.M	*ʾana*	*=ina*	*haw-ən*
1SG.F	*ʾana*	*=ina*	*hawy-an*
1PL	*ʾaḥnaḥ*	*=iḥnaḥ*	*haw-aḥ*

(8) C. Van (Khan, fieldnotes)

	Independent pronoun	Enclitic copula	Verb *h-w-y* 'to be'
3SG.M	*ʾaw*	*=ilə*	*haw-ə*
3SG.F	*ʾay*	*=ila*	*hawy-a*
3PL	*ʾani*	*=in*	*haw-i*
2SG.M	*ʾāt*	*=ta*	*haw-ət*
2SG.F	*ʾāt*	*=ta*	*hawy-at*
2PL	*ʾaxtux*	*=tux*	*haw-etun*
1SG.M	*ʾana*	*=na*	*haw-ən*
1SG.F	*ʾana*	*=na*	*hawy-an*
1PL	*ʾaxnax*	*=xa*	*haw-ax*

In the paradigms of the copula in the NENA dialects of Hertevin and Van given above, the 3sg forms exhibit a suffix containing an */l/* element attached to a stem with the form *i-*, the latter being the enclitic 3sg pronoun in origin. The other forms, by contrast, do not exhibit this innovative feature and remain conservative in their form.

In the main body of NENA dialects, the inflection of the copula exhibits a partial assimilation to that of the verb *h-w-y*. The paradigms of the dialects of C. Qaraqosh and C. Barwar (northern Iraq) are given below:

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(9) C. Qaraqosh (Khan 2002a: 125-126)

	Independent pronoun	Enclitic copula	Verb *h-w-y* 'to be'
3SG.M	*ʾahu*	*=ilə*	*haw-ə*
3SG.F	*ʾahi*	*=ila*	*hawy-a*
3PL	*ʾanhən*	*=ina*	*haw-ə*
2SG.M	*ʾahət*	*=iyət*	*haw-ət*
2SG.F	*ʾahat*	*=iyat*	*hawy-at*
2PL	*ʾaxtun*	*=iyetun*	*haw-etu*
1SG.M	*ʾana*	*=iyən*	*haw-ən*
1SG.F	*ʾana*	*=iyan*	*hawy-an*
1PL	*ʾaxni*	*=iyax*	*haw-ax*

(10) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a: 180–181)

	Independent pronoun	Enclitic copula	Verb *h-w-y* 'to be'
3SG.M	*ʾaw*	*=ile*	*haw-ə*
3SG.F	*ʾay*	*=ila*	*hawy-a*
3PL	*ʾani*	*=ilɛ*	*haw-ɛ*
2SG.M	*ʾati*	*=iwət*	*haw-ət*
2SG.F	*ʾati*	*=iwat*	*hawy-at*
2PL	*ʾaxtu*	*=iwitu*	*haw-itu*
1SG.M	*ʾana*	*=iwən*	*haw-ən*
1SG.F	*ʾana*	*=iwan*	*hawy-an*
1PL	*ʾaxni*	*=iwəx*	*haw-əx*

In these two paradigms, there is a split between the third person forms, on the one hand, and the first and second person forms, on the other. It is the first and second person forms that have acquired subject verbal inflection. This is suffixed to the stem *i-*. In C. Barwar, the first and second person forms have become further assimilated to the verb *h-w-y* by acquiring its middle radical */w/*.

The inflections of the third person copula, on the other hand, have suffixes containing the element */l/*. The 3pl form in C. Qaraqosh *=ina* may have originated from an original *=i-la*, the **l* having shifted to */n/* to distinguish the form from the 3sg.f copula *=ila*.

In some dialects the */l/* element of the third person has been generalised throughout the paradigm, e.g.,

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(11) J. Urmi (Khan 2008a: 180–181)

	Independent pronoun	Enclitic copula	Verb *h-w-y* 'to be'
3SG.M	*o*	*=ile*	*haw-e*
3SG.F	*o*	*=ila*	*hawy-a*
3PL	*une*	*=ilu*	*haw-e(ni)*
2SG.M	*āt*	*=ilet*	*haw-et*
2SG.F	*āt*	*=ilat*	*hawy-at*
2PL	*atxun*	*=iletun*	*haw-etun*
1SG.M	*ana*	*=ilen*	*haw-en*
1SG.F	*ana*	*=ilan*	*hawy-an*
1PL	*axni, axnan*	*=ilex*	*haw-ex*

The *i-* stem in the copula paradigms is most easily interpreted as a vestige of an original third person pronominal enclitic copula that can be identified with the */y/* that occurs in the 3sg pronominal enclitic copula of Central Neo-Aramaic (Ṭuroyo and Mlaḥso) and Neo-Mandaic (Khan 2001, 2012, 2018a, 2022c). In Central Neo-Aramaic, the */y/* occurs in both the 3sg.m and 3sg.f of the pronominal copula, which have the common form *=yo* (see 3 above). This differs from Classical Syriac, in which the 3sg.m clitic (*=ū*) and the 3sg.f clitic (*=ī*) are distinct (see 2 above). It is possible that the */y/* of the *=yo* clitic in Central Neo-Aramaic originated in the 3sg.f clitic and was extended to the 3sg.m. A parallel process took place in the independent third person singular pronouns in the village dialects of Ṭuroyo, in which the stem of the 3sg.f has been extended to supply the stem of the 3sg.m pronoun: *hiy-a* (3sg.f), *hiy-e* (3sg.m). Contrast the more archaic dialect of Midyat, which preserves distinct stems: *hiy-a* (3sg.f), *huw-e* (3sg.m). In Mlaḥso, the stem of the 3sg.f independent pronoun has, in fact, been extended also to the 3pl pronoun: *hiy-a* (3sg.f), *hiy-e* (3sg.m), *hiy-en* (3pl). The final */o/* vowel in the 3sg.f copula clitic *=yo* in Ṭuroyo has probably been added by a process of analogical extension of the final */o/* that is found in Ṭuroyo demonstrative clitics, e.g., *=awo* ('that' 3sg.m), *=ayo* ('that' 3sg.f).

The suffixes containing */l/* can be identified with the so-called L-suffixes of NENA, which are oblique pronominal phrases containing the preposition *l-* that express pronominal objects, e.g.,

(12) C. Barwar

a. *ʾaw xaze-le*
he sees.PRS.3SG.M-OBL.3SG.M
'He sees him.'

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b. *ʾaw xaze-la*
he sees.PRS.3SG.M-OBL.3SG.F
'He sees her.'

The explanation as to why these object suffixes should appear in a copula paradigm is that they were extended by analogy from deictic constructions that drew attention to a referent. In such deictic constructions, the perceived third person referent was coded as a direct object, just as it would be in constructions containing a verb of perception ('See him!'). They are similar to deictic constructions such as French *voilà* or Italian *ecco*, which may take object complements, e.g., *le voilà*, *eccolo* 'There he is'. These are called by Fillmore (1982: 47) 'sentential demonstratives', since they can express a complete sentence.

Ṭuroyo has a sentential demonstrative that consists of the deictic element *ka-* and object L-suffixes:

(13) Ṭuroyo (Midin) (Jastrow 1985: 122)

3SG.M	*kalé*	'There he is'
3SG.F	*kalā́*	'There she is'
3PL	*kalə́n*	'There they are', etc.
2SG.M	*kalə́x*	
2SG.F	*kaláx*	
2PL	*kalóxu*	
1SG	*kalí*	

In Ṭuroyo, the copula does not have an */l/* element, so the suffixes in this paradigm are unambiguously object suffixes.

In various NENA dialects, there are sentential demonstratives that take L-suffixes as their complement. A form that is common to several dialects of northern Iraq and south-eastern Turkey is *hole* and variants of this, such as C. Alqosh *wole*, C. Tisqopa *ʾolə* (Coghill 2018: 259). This developed from the combination of the deictic element *ho-* with the object L-suffix *-le*. It is likely that the *ho-* element itself developed historically from **hā-ʾaw*, which is a combination of a deictic element *hā* and a 3sg.m demonstrative pronominal element *ʾaw* 'that one'. The construction **hā-ʾaw* could, therefore, have itself been originally a sentential demonstrative 'there he is'. In the modern dialects, however, the *ho-* element acts as the stem for the paradigm of *hole*, e.g.,

(14) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a: 186)

3SG.M	*hole*	'There he is'
3SG.F	*hola*	'There she is'
3PL	*holɛ*	'There they are', etc.

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Sentential demonstratives such as *hole* came to be reanalysed as deictic copulas. The pathway to this reanalysis is likely to have been the use of the sentential demonstrative with a locative or attributive adjunct in constructions such as (15):

(15) C. Barwar
hó-le *gu-bèθa.*
DEIC-OBL.3SG.M in-house
'There he is/see him, in the house.'

Such constructions draw attention to a referent and append more information about this referent in the adjunct. The construction then underwent a further development whereby the referent and the adjunct became more integrated, with the result that the construction drew attention to a situation involving a referent and locative expression, thus:

(16) C. Barwar
hó-le *gu-bèθa.*
DEIC-OBL.3SG.M in-house
'See him in the house.'

This is no longer a sentential demonstrative type of construction but rather a thetic sentence, i.e., a sentence that draws attention to a situation. A 'thetic sentence' presents a situation as an undivided whole. This differs from a 'categorical sentence', which consists of the bipartite act of naming an entity and making a statement about it (Sasse 1987). Such thetic sentence constructions are likely to have provided a context that was particularly conducive to the reanalysis of the *hole* form as a deictic copula.

As a result of the process of reanalysis, the form *hole* in dialects such as C. Barwar came to function both as a sentential demonstrative and as a deictic copula, which became aligned in its inflection with that of the enclitic copula. This alignment in inflection is shown clearly by comparing the full two paradigms of the deictic copula *hole* and the enclitic copula in C. Barwar:

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(17) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a: 180–187)

	Deictic copula	Enclitic copula
3SG.M	*hole*	*=ile*
3SG.F	*hole*	*=ila*
3PL	*holɛ*	*=ilɛ*
2SG.M	*howət, hot*	*=iwət, =it*
2SG.F	*howət, hot*	*=iwət, =it*
2PL	*howitu, hotu*	*=iwitu, =itu*
1SG.M	*howən, hon*	*=iwən, =in*
1SG.M	*howən, hon*	*=iwən, =in*
1PL	*howəx, hox*	*=iwəx, =ix*

In some dialects the deictic copula is only used in the third person, e.g., Umra-Dereköyü (Hobrack 2000: 42–43). In dialects that have full paradigms of the deictic copula, moreover, the third person forms occur more frequently in recorded texts than the first and second person forms.

In C. Barwar there is an alternative paradigm of *hole*, which is inflected throughout with L-suffixes, including in the first and second persons (18):

(18) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a: 187)

3SG.M	*hole*
3SG.F	*hola*
3PL	*holɛ*
2SG.M	*holux*
2SG.F	*holəx*
2PL	*holɛxu*
1SG	*holi*
1PL	*holəx*

Some dialects use exclusively a paradigm with extended L-suffixes such as (18). This applies, for example, to many dialects in the north-west of Iraq, such as Peshabur (Coghill 2008, 2013) and Qarawilla, dialects in the region of the Cudi mountain and adjacent areas in south-eastern Turkey, such as Bēṣpən (Sinha 2000), Harbole, Billin, Umra d-Shish, and some Upper and Lower Ṭyare dialects and Txuma dialects in south-eastern Turkey (Talay 2008a: 197–198).

In some dialects, the sentential demonstrative/deictic copula cognate with *hole* underwent further developments. In the dialect of Bohtan described by Fox (2002: 62–63), for example, the sentential demonstrative/deictic copula is formed by combining the spatial deictic stem *hawla* with the enclitic copula, e.g.,

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(19) C. Bohtan (Fox 2002: 62–63)

3SG.M	*hawlele* (< *hawla=ile*)
3SG.F	*hawlala* (< *hawla=ila*)
3PL	*hawlala* (< *hawla=ila*)

The spatial deictic stem *hawla-* appears to be the result of two cycles of reanalysis. In the first cycle, an original **hā-ʾaw* deictic-demonstrative was reanalysed as a spatial deictic **haw* with loss of referentiality of the demonstrative. To this spatial deictic was added the 3sg.f object L-suffix *-la* as an unspecified impersonal referential index. This combination of spatial deictic + impersonal referential index in turn underwent a cycle of reanalysis whereby the *-la* lost referentiality and the integrated form *hawla* became a spatial deictic. This was then inflected with the enclitic copula.

In dialects in the northern sector of NENA that express 'very far deixis' by glottalizing the stressed vowel of a far deixis pronoun, a deictic copula may be likewise be glottalized to express very far deixis, e.g.,

(20) C. Barwar (Khan 2008c: 187)

3SG.M	*hoʾle*
3SG.F	*hoʾla*
3PL	*hoʾlɛ*

In several dialects in the north-eastern sector of NENA, deictic copulas are formed by prefixing a *d-* deictic element. These typically are used as proximal deictic copulas, and a different form, without *d-*, is used as a distal deictic copula, e.g.,

(21) C. Zariwaw (Napiorkowska 2015: 171–176)

	Proximal	Distal
3SG.M	*dule*	*hole, wele*
3SG.F	*dula*	*hola, wela*
3PL	*duna*	*hona, wena*

The *d-* element may be an Aramaic proximal deictic element, as in, for example, the common adverbial *ʾədyo* 'today' (< **ʾaḏ-yōm*), or the proximal deictic pronouns C. Alqosh *ʾaði*, C. Ankawa *ʾadi*, C. Sat *da* (see §10.1).

The distal deictic copula *wele* may possibly be derived from a distal demonstrative pronoun *ʾawa* 'that' + enclitic copula. Distal demonstratives of this form are attested in various NENA dialects, sometimes with stress on the final syllable, e.g., C. Ashitha *ʾawá*, C. Dere *ʾawá*.

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In a number of dialects, the L-suffix of the inflection of the third person copula element is geminated, sometimes optionally. This gemination is likely to be a secondary development induced by stress, e.g.,

(22) J. Challa (Fassberg 2010: 102)

3SG.M	*wəlle, wele*
3SG.F	*wəlla, wela*
3PL	*wəllu, welu*

In J. Challa and in several other dialects, sentential demonstratives/deictic copulas of this form are used only in the third person, e.g., J. Zakho (Cohen 2012: 61–61) and C. Urmi (Khan 2016b: vol. 1, 253).

As with *hole*, in some dialects the L-suffix of the form *wəlle/wele* is generalised throughout the paradigm. This was no doubt facilitated by the invariable stem of the construction, e.g.,

(23) J. Betanure (Mutzafi 2008a: 52)

3SG.M	*wəlle*
3SG.F	*wəlla*
3PL	*wəllu*
2SG.M	*wəllox*
2SG.F	*wəllax*
2PL	*wəlloxun*
1SG	*wəlli*
1PL	*wəllan*

In the C. Jilu dialect, there are sentential demonstratives/deictic copulas formed by the prefixed augment *hay-*. A distinction is made between proximal and distal forms:

(24) C. Jilu (Fox 1997: 41)

	Proximal	Distal
3SG.M	*haydule*	*haynole*
3SG.F	*haydula*	*haynola*
3PL	*haydullɛ*	*haynollɛ*
2SG.M	*hayduwət*	*haynowət*
2SG.F	*hayduwat*	*haynowat*
2PL	*haydutu*	*haynotu*
1SG	*hayduwən*	
1PL	*hayduwan*	

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The C. Baz cluster of dialects, a sentential demonstrative/deictic copula with the stem *haydo-* is used for both proximal and distal deixis, e.g.,

(25) C. Bāz (Maha d-Xtaya) (Mutzafi 2000: 199)

3SG.M	*haydole*
3SG.F	*haydola*
3PL	*haydolay*

In some dialects, completely different constructions are used for sentential demonstratives, on the one hand, and deictic copulas, on the other. One such dialect is C. Qaraqosh. The deictic copula in C. Qaraqosh is formed by combining the deictic particle *k-* with the copula. The *k-* is likely to be derived historically from a spatial adverbial with the form **kā*; cf. Syriac *kā* 'here':

(26) C. Qaraqosh (Khan 2002a: 128)

3SG.M	*k-ilə*
3SG.F	*k-ila*
3PL	*k-ina*

The C. Qaraqosh dialect expresses a sentential demonstrative by the combination of a demonstrative pronoun and an enclitic copula. The demonstrative may have distal or proximal deixis, e.g.,

(27) C. Qaraqosh

Distal deixis	
ʾawe=lə (< *ʾawa=ilə*)	'there he is' (literally: he is that one)
ʾaye=la (< *ʾaya=ila*)	'there she is' (literally: she is that one)
ʾane=na (< *ʾane=ina*)	'there they are' (literally: they are those)
Proximal deixis	
ʾaðe=lə (< *ʾaða=ilə*)	'here he is' (literally: he is this one)
ʾaði=la (< *ʾaði=ila*)	'here she is' (literally: she is this one)
ʾani=na (< *ʾani=ina*)	'here they are' (literally: they are these)

The C. Hawdiyan dialect has a system of deictic copulas that exhibits incipient levelling in the third person:

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(28) C. Hawdiyan
3SG *le*
3PL *ne*
2SG *dut*
2PL *dutun*
1SG *dun*
1PL *dux*

As seen in the paradigm in (29), the *-e* of the original 3sg.m form of the copula **ile* has been generalised to the 3sg.f and the 3pl. There is a further set of third person deictic copulas in C. Hawdiyan that express a greater degree of distance than the basic forms:

(29) C. Hawdiyan
3SG *leha*
3PL *neha*

Inflected deictic copulas are a characteristic feature of NENA dialects in the northern sector and on the Mosul plain. In several dialects in the south-eastern sector, an invariable particle that is a fossilized form of the copula serves a similar function to that of the inflected deictic copula in the western and northern sectors. Most of these appear to be derived historically from the 3sg.f copula (*ʾila*). This has developed various phonetic shapes, e.g., *lā* (C. Bədyal, C. Koy Sanjak, J. Arbel, J. Ruwanduz, J. Rustaqa), *nā* (J. Dobe, J. Hiza), *na* (C. Aqra, C. Shaqlawa). The J. Barzan cluster of dialects has the invariable form *ʾale*, which appears to have developed from a combination of a deictic element **hā-* and the invariable third person copula form *le* (< **ʾile*). Since these particles are not inflected, they must be combined with an enclitic copula on the predicate in the first and second persons, e.g.,

(30) C. Bədyal (Khan, fieldnotes)
a. *lā́ gu-bèta.*|
COP in-house
'He/she/they is/are in the house.'
b. *lā́ gu-bète=wən.*|
COP in-house=COP.1SG.M
'I (m.) am in the house.'
c. *lā́ gu-bète=wət.*|
COP in-house=COP.2SG.M
'You (sg.m) are in the house.'

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Such invariable copulas are used in perfect and progressive constructions, e.g.,

(31) J. Arbel (Khan 1999a: 265-275)

a. *lā* *ʾəlye-le*
DEIC.COP come.PST-OBL.3SG.M
'He has come.'

b. *lā* *k-e*
DEIC.COP PTCL-come.PRS.3SG.M
'He is coming.'

Although dialects in the south-eastern sector do not have inflected deictic copulas, they do have inflected sentential demonstrative constructions, typically consisting of a demonstrative pronoun and enclitic copula, as in those in C. Qaraqosh (see 27), e.g.,

(32) C. Shaqlawa (Khan, fieldnotes)

Distal deixis	
wahe=le (< *ʾăwaha=ilə*)	'there he is' (literally: he is that one)
yahe=la (< *ʾăyaha=ila*)	'there she is' (literally: she is that one)
ʾănahe=na (< *ʾănaha=ina*)	'there they are' (literally: they are those)
Proximal deixis	
ʾăye=le (< *ʾăya=ile*)	'here he is' (literally: he is this one)
ăye=la (< *ăya=ila*)	'here she is' (literally: she is this one)
ʾăne=na (< *ʾăna=ina*)	'here they are' (literally: they are these)

The C. Sulemaniyya dialect has an invariable sentential demonstrative construction with the following forms

(33) C. Sulemaniyya (Khan, fieldnotes)

ʾul=la 'there he/she/they is/are'
ʾul=laha 'there he/she/they is/are'
ʾul=lahan 'there he/she/they is/are'

These forms appear to be derived historically from a 3sg.m demonstrative pronoun **ʾo* (< **haw*) combined with the copula *ila*, which is morphologically 3sg.f but has unspecified reference, optionally followed by further deictic elements (*-ha*, *-han*). Both the pronoun and the copula have lost specific referentiality, with the result that the construction is a spatial deictic with unspecified reference.

The J. Urmi dialect in the north-western sector of NENA, likewise, has no deictic copula but has a distal and proximal sentential demonstrative (34). This

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may reflect the origin of the speakers of the dialect from further south (Khan 2024a). The distal sentential demonstrative has the invariable stem *u* (cf. the sg.c distal demonstrative *o*) and the proximal sentential demonstrative has the invariable stem *ya* (cf. the sg.c proximal demonstrative *ya*):

(34) J. Urmi (Khan 2008b: 62)

Distal deixis	
u=le	'there he is'
u=la	'there she is'
u=lu	'there they are'
Proximal deixis	
ye=le	'here he is'
ye=la	'here she is'
ye=lu	'here they are'

15.1.2 Negative Copula

NENA dialects use a negative copula to negate copula clauses. This is in origin a combination of the negative particle *la* bonded to the enclitic copula. In many dialects, there is a transparent relationship between the paradigm of the negative copula and that of the enclitic copula, e.g.,

(35) C. Qaraqosh (Khan 2002a: 129)

	Negative copula	Enclitic copula
3SG.M	*lelə*	*=ilə*
3SG.F	*lela*	*=ila*
3PL	*lena*	*=ina*
2SG.M	*leyət*	*=iyət*
2SG.F	*leyat*	*=iyat*
2PL	*leyetu*	*=iyetu*
1SG.M	*leyən*	*=iyən*
1SG.F	*leyan*	*=iyan*
1PL	*leyax*	*=iyax*

In several dialects, however, especially in the Jewish Trans-Zab group and the Christian dialects in the south-eastern sector, there is some degree of asymmetry between the negative copula and the enclitic copula. Possible factors that have

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conditioned this include analogy with the first and second person forms of the paradigm and/or a greater degree of assimilation to the morphological shape of the suppletive verb 'to be' *h-w-y* (used in modal contexts) than is the case with the positive present copula, e.g.,

(36) J. Arbel (Khan 1999a: 115–166)

	Enclitic copula	Negative copula	*h-w-y*
3SG.M	*=ile*	*lewe*	*hăwe*
3SG.F	*=ila*	*lewa*	*hawya*
3PL	*=ilu*	*lewu*	*hăweni*
2SG.M	*=wet*	*lewet*	*hăwet*
2SG.F	*=wat*	*lewat*	*hawyat*
2PL	*=wetun*	*lewetun*	*hăwetun*
1SG.M	*=wen*	*lewen*	*hăwen*
1SG.F	*=wan*	*lewan*	*hawyan*
1PL	*=wex*	*lewex*	*hăwex*

(37) C. Shaqlawa (Khan, fieldnotes)

	Enclitic Copula	Negative Copula	*h-w-y*
3SG.M	*=ile*	*lewe*	*hawe*
3SG.F	*=ila*	*lewa*	*hawya*
3PL	*=ina*	*lewu*	*hawi*
2SG.M	*=iwət*	*lewət*	*hawət*
2SG.F	*=iwat*	*lewat*	*hawyat*
2PL	*=iwitun*	*lewitun*	*hawitun*
1SG.M	*=iwen*	*lewən*	*hawən*
1SG.F	*=iwan*	*lewan*	*hawyan*
1PL	*=iwəx*	*lewəx*	*hawəx*

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(38) C. Sulemaniyya (Khan, fieldnotes)

	Enclitic copula	Negative copula	*h-w-y*
3SG.M	*=ile*	*leye*	*haye*
3SG.F	*=ila*	*leya*	*hoya*
3PL	*=ilu*	*leyu*	*hayi*
2SG.M	*=it*	*leyit*	*hawət*
2SG.F	*=yat*	*leyat*	*hoyat*
2PL	*=itun*	*leyitun*	*hawutən*
1SG.M	*=in*	*leyin*	*hawən*
1SG.F	*=yan*	*leyan*	*hoyan*
1PL	*=yux*	*leyux*	*hawux*

15.1.3 Past Copula

In addition to the basic present enclitic copula paradigm, NENA dialects also have paradigms of past copulas. A common way to form the past copula is by attaching the verbal past tense morpheme *-wa* to forms of the present copula. This is the case, for example, in C. Urmi (in which **w* has shifted to */v/*):

(39) C. Urmi (Khan 2016b: 251–252)

	Present copula	Past copula
3SG.M	*=ilə*	*=iva*
3SG.F	*=ila*	*=iva*
3PL	*=ina*	*=iva*
2SG.M	*=ivət*	*=ītva*
2SG.F	*=ivat*	*=ītva*
2PL	*=itun*	*=itunva*
1SG.M	*=ivən*	*=īnva*
1SG.F	*=ivan*	*=īnva*
1PL	*=ivax*	*=īxva*

As can be seen in (39), in the third person, the past copula is formed by attaching the suffix *-va* to the */i/* stem of the present copula without any further inflectional L-suffixes.

In some dialects, the past copula exhibits a greater convergence with the verbal inflection of the verb *h-w-y* than in the basic present enclitic copula paradigm. This can be seen in (40) from C. Barwar:

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(40) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a: 183–184)

	Present copula	Past copula	Past *h-w-y*
3SG.M	*=ile*	*=iwewa*	*hawewa*
3SG.F	*=ila*	*=iwawa*	*hoyawa*
3PL	*=ilɛ*	*=iwɛwa*	*hawɛwa*
2SG.M	*=iwət*	*=iwətwa*	*hawətwa*
2SG.F	*=iwat*	*=iwatwa*	*hoyatwa*
2PL	*=iwɛtu*	*=iwɛtuwa*	*hawɛtuwa*
1SG.M	*=iwən*	*=iwənwa*	*hawənwa*
1SG.F	*=iwan*	*=iwanwa*	*hoyanwa*
1PL	*=iwəx*	*=iwexwa*	*hawəxwa*

In the past copula paradigm in (40), not only the first and second person forms but also the third person forms have verbal inflection, replicating that of the suppletive verb *h-w-y*. This contrasts with the paradigm of the present copula, in which only the first and second person forms have verbal inflection.

Another strategy, which is found in many Jewish Trans-Zab dialects and Christian dialects in the Baz region, is to express the past copula with the past perfective *qṭəlle* form of the verb *h-w-y*, inflected by L-suffixes, e.g.,

(41) J. Arbel (Khan 1999a: 105)

	Present copula	Past copula
3SG.M	*=ile*	*=wele*
3SG.F	*=ila*	*=wela*
3PL	*=ilu*	*=welu*
2SG.M	*=wet*	*=welox*
2SG.F	*=wat*	*=welax*
2PL	*=wetun*	*=welxun*
1SG.M	*=wen*	*=weli*
1SG.F	*=wan*	*=weli*
1PL	*=wex*	*=welan*

In the Jewish dialects of the south-eastern periphery, the stem of the past copula that is inflected by L-suffixes converges with the form of the 3sg.m present copula *=ye*, e.g.,

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(42) J. Sanandaj (Khan 2009: 87)

	Present copula	Past copula
3SG.M	*=ye*	*=yele*
3SG.F	*=ya*	*=yela*
3PL	*=yen*	*=yelu*
2SG.M	*=yet*	*=yelox*
2SG.F	*=yat*	*=yelax*
2PL	*=yetun*	*=yelxun*
1SG.M	*=yena*	*=yeli*
1SG.F	*=yan*	*=yeli*
1PL	*=yex*	*=yelan*

In Christian Baz dialects, the past copula derived from the past perfective of *h-w-y* undergoes other developments. In C. Baz Aruntus (43), for example, the stem *we* is replaced by *wa*:

(43) C. Baz Aruntus (Khan, fieldnotes)

	Present copula	Past copula
3SG.M	*=le*	*=wale*
3SG.F	*=la*	*=wala*
3PL	*=na*	*=waley*
2SG.M	*=wut*	*=walux*
2SG.F	*=wat*	*=walax*
2PL	*=utun*	*=walaxun*
1SG.M	*=wun*	*=wali*
1SG.F	*=wan*	*=wali*
1PL	*=wax*	*=walan*

In C. Baz Maha Xtaya (44) the */e/* of the past stem *we* is elided. In this dialect, the full paradigm of the present copula is inflected by L-suffixes, so the paradigms of the present and past copulas share the same inflection:

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(44) C. Baz Maha Xtaya (Mutzafi 2000: 308–309)

	Present copula	Past copula
3SG.M	*=le*	*=wle*
3SG.F	*=la*	*=wla*
3PL	*=lay*	*=wlay*
2SG.M	*=lox*	*=wlox*
2SG.F	*=lax*	*=wlax*
2PL	*=laxu*	*=wlaxu*
1sg.c	*=li*	*=wli*
1PL	*=lan*	*=wlan*

15.1.4 The Function of the copula

15.1.4.1 Enclitic copula

The enclitic copula attached to the predicate may be regarded as the functionally unmarked form of the copula. It is used irrespective of the time stability of the predicate. The predicate may express a permanent property of the subject (45a). It may identify the referent of the subject with that of the nominal of the predicate, which is typically a permanent relationship (45b). The predicate may also express a contingent situation that is not necessarily a permanent property of the subject (45c).

(45) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a: 622–623)

a. *brón-ux spày=ile.*
son-your good=COP.3SG.M
'Your son is good.'

b. *ʾăwáha gáwṛa bròn-an=ile.*
that man son-our=COP.3SG.M
'That man is our son.'

c. *brón-ux kpìnɛ=le.*
son-your hungry=COP.3SG.M
'Your son is hungry.'

In NENA dialects on the Mosul plain and in the northern sector, enclitic copulas are sensitive to focus and may be moved onto an item that is in narrow focus. This applies to contrastive focus constructions such as (46). Here, as is typically

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the case when the remainder of the clause is presuppositonal, the focus item takes the nuclear stress of the intonation group:

(46) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a: 622–623)

a. *bròn-ux=ile spáy.*|
son-your=COP.3SG.M good
'YOUR SON (and not another referent that you have in mind) is good.'

b. *bròn-ux=ile gu-béθa.*|
son-your=COP.3SG.M in-house
'YOUR SON (and not another referent that you have in mind) is in the house.'

In dialects of these groups, an enclitic copula is typically put on interrogative constituents, which are focus items. In (47b), the remainder of the clause is presuppositional, and the nuclear stress as well as the copula are placed on the interrogative item:

(47) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a: 718, 1023)

a. Speaker 1:
gu-béθ-i ʾíθ rába nàše.|
in-house-my EXIST many people
'In my house there are many people.'

b. Speaker 2:
ʾèni=le gu-béθ-ux?|
who=COP.3SG.M house-your
'Who is your house?'

If the locative constituent in such a construction is not presuppositional, the nuclear stress would typically be put on the locative constituent, but the copula would still be placed on the interrogative constituent (48). This indicates that the focus movement of the copula does not always coincide with the attraction of nuclear stress:

(48) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a: 628)
ʾéni=le gu-bèθa?|
who=COP.3SG.M in-house
'Who is in the house?'

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The dialects in the northern sector differ regarding the degree to which they move an enclitic copula in focus constructions. In the C. Urmi dialect, such focus movement is less common than in C. Barwar. In C. Urmi, the copula is moved only in cases where the speaker wishes to express a very strong contrastive stress:

(49) C. Urmi (Khan 2016b: vol. 2, 295–296)

a. *⁺mamùn-ux ɟu-bétə=lə,*| *lá bàb-ux.*|
uncle-your in-house=COP.3SG.M NEG father-your
'YOUR UNCLE is in the house, not your father.'

b. *⁺mamùn-ux=ilə ɟu-béta,*| *lá bàb-ux.*|
uncle-your=COP.3SG.M in-house NEG father-your
'YOUR UNCLE (strong expression of contrast) is in the house, not your father.'

An enclitic copula may be placed on a subject constituent when it does not have contrastive or interrogative focus, but rather is in what may be called presentational focus, e.g.,

(50) C. Qaraqosh (Khan 2018a: 259)
ʾáxni=yəx suràyə.|
we=COP.1PL Christians
'We are Christians.'

(51) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a: 628)
xúwwe=le qṭìla.|
snake=COP.3SG.M killed
'The snake is killed!'

The subject constituents in (50) and (51) here are not in contrastive focus. Rather, they are given non-contrastive presentational salience by the copula, and the following content of the clause is informative. The nuclear stress is on this informative predicate. The effect of putting presentational focus on the subject is to demote the assertiveness of the following content, thus packaging the clause as expressing a unitary situation, rather than a categorical bipartite assertion of information about a particular topic. Such constructions are, therefore, 'thetic' (Sasse 1987). They are typically used for discourse management and conversational interaction (Kaltenböck et al. 2011), in contexts such as the presentation of preliminary grounds for what follows (50), exclamatory announcements (51), or explanatory elaborations.

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A thetic copula clause of this type can be embedded in an extrapositional construction with an initial topic constituent, as in (52), in which the initial topic is in a separate intonation group:

(52) C. Qaraqosh (Khan 2002a: 413)
Baġdèdə | *ʾáhi=la* *máθa* *ʾatə́qta* *ḥèlə.* |
Baġdedə it.f=cop.3sg.f village ancient very
'Baġdedə is a very ancient town.'

This has the basic structure of a categorical sentence, since it sets up a topic and then what follows says something about this topic. The effect of the embedded thetic clause is to indicate that what is said about the topic is not simply the imparting of information, but rather it has a discourse management function, in this case, one of elaborative explanation.

This discussion of the function of the preposing of the copula in clauses is relevant for understanding the syntax of the copula in relative clauses. In NENA dialects on the Mosul plain and in the northern sector, the copula is cliticised to the relative particle at the front of a relative clause rather than on the predicate, e.g.,

(53) C. Qaraqosh (Khan 2002a: 475)
maθwáθ d=ína *xə́ðran* *Baġdèdə* |
villages rel=cop.3pl around Baġdedə
'villages that are around Baġdedə (i.e., Qaraqosh)'

We may interpret such constructions in NENA as the use of the copula to express prominence on the relative particle, co-indexed with the antecedent noun, as a strategy to demote the assertion of the clause. This would be the same strategy that we have seen in (50). The motivation to express demotion of the assertion of the clause is here not because the clause is thetic, but rather on account of the fact that restrictive relative clauses are non-assertive. Once it had developed in restrictive relative clauses, it was subsequently extended to non-restrictive relative clauses, e.g.,

(54) C. Qaraqosh (Khan 2002a: 476)
ṣálm-aḥ d=ílə *bahùra* |
face-her rel=cop.3sg.m radiant
'her face, which is radiant'

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In NENA dialects in the south-eastern sector, the enclitic copula is not sensitive to focus and does not move onto an item with focus in the types of focus constructions described above, nor in relative clauses, e.g.,

(55) J. Sulemaniyya (Khan 2004b: 349, 419)

a. *šwaw-àn tujā́r=ile.*
neighbour-our merchant=COP.3SG.M
'OUR NEIGHBOUR is a merchant.'

b. *máni ga-belà=y.*
who in-house=COP.3SG.M
'Who is in the house?'

c. *mani-t ga-bela=y*
who-REL in-house=COP.3SG.M
'whoever is in the house'

15.1.4.2 Deictic copula

Constructions with a deictic copula such as (56) and (57) are thetic clauses, in that they draw attention to a situation for the purpose of discourse management or conversational interaction rather than neutrally imparting information about the subject. The situation is typically contingent on speech time and is not a permanent situation:

(56) C. Barwar
hóle gu-bɛ̀θa.
DEIC.COP.3SG.M in-house
'He is in the house.'

(57) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a: 630)
baxtáθ-ən hóla yaqúre tərwə̀θn-a.
wives-our DEIC.COP.3PL heavy both-of.them
'Our wives are both pregnant.'

Likewise, perfect and progressive constructions that are formed with a deictic copula (see 16.1.1, 19.1.2, 19.1.3) should be regarded as thetic. They draw attention to a contingent situation and are typically used for discourse management purposes, e.g.,

(58) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a)

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a. *hóle ʾə̀θya.*|
DEIC.COP.3SG.M come.PPRT.SG.M
'He has come.'

b. *hóle θàya.*|
DEIC.COP.3SG.M come.PROG
'He is coming.'

(59) C. Qaraqosh (Khan 2002a)

a. *k-ilə ʾə̀θya.*|
DEIC-COP.3SG.M come.PPRT.SG.M
'He has come.'

b. *k-ilə k-àθə.*|
DEIC-COP.3SG.M DEIC-come.PRS.3SG.M
'He is coming.'

The thetic construction with a deictic copula can be embedded in a sentence with an initial topic, e.g.,

(60) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a)

a. Speaker 1:
ʾékɛ=le Yòsəp?.|
where=COP.3SG.M Yosəp
'Where is Yosəp?'

b. Speaker 2:
Yósəp hóle gu-bèθa.| *ʾáw maṣe*
Yosəp DEIC.COP.3SG.M in-house.PROG he be.ablePRS.3SG.M
mhayə̀r-rux.|
help.PRS.3SG.M-OBL.2SG.M
'Yosəp is in the house. He can help you.'

As remarked regarding (52), the effect of the embedded thetic clause is to indicate that what is said about the topic is not simply the imparting of information but rather the drawing of the attention of the interlocutor to a situation for the purpose of discourse management. In the case of (60b), this function is to lay the grounds for what follows, as is illustrated by the clause following it in the example. A more neutral imparting of information would be performed by a response with an enclitic copula such as (61):

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(61) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a)
Yósəp gu-bèθɛ=le.|
Yosəp in-house=COP.3SG.M
'Yosəp is in the house.'

Some dialects use an independent form of the basic copula before the predicate without a deictic element such as *ho-* or *k-*. The distribution and function of this differ across the dialects.

In C. Telkepe, this construction is the regular one in perfect and progressive constructions, e.g.,

(62) C. Telkepe (Coghill 2018: 259–260)

a. *ʾílə ʾàθyɒ.*|
COP.3SG.M come.PPRT.SG.M
'He has come.'

b. *ʾílə b-ixàlɒ.*|
COP.3SG.M in-eat.PROG
'He is eating.'

In some dialects, the independent preposed copula alternates with a deictic copula in perfect and progressive constructions, e.g.,

(63) J. Betanure (Mutzafi 2008a: 63-64)

a. *ʾíle bə-štàya.*
COP.3SG.M in-drink.INF
'He is drinking.'

b. *wə́lle bə-štàya.*
DEIC.COP.3SG.M in-drink.INF
'He is drinking.'

In the case of both (62) and (63), the constructions can be analyzed as thetic, in that they draw attention to an eventive contingent situation for discourse management purposes. The use of the deictic copula in (63b) would typically be used for drawing attention to a visible situation. Mutzafi gives examples in J. Betanure also of a preposed copula in locative clauses, which can also be analyzed as thetic clauses:

(64) J. Betanure (Mutzafi 2008a: 44, 300)

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a. *ʾile* *tama.*
COP.3SG.M there
'He is there.'

b. *paθ-oxun* *ʾila* *ʾəl-bariya.*
face-your (pl) COP.3SG.F to-desert
'Your faces are towards the desert.'

In J. Betanure, when a copula is combined with a resultative participle, it may be placed either before the participle or after it as an enclitic. According to Mutzafi, the former is a 'dynamic perfect' whereas the latter is a 'stative perfect'. This can be interpreted as corresponding to the thetic—categorical distinction. When the copula is placed before it, the construction is thetic and presents an eventive situation (65a). When it is enclitic, the construction is categorical and predicates a stative attribute of the subject (65b):

(65) J. Betanure (Mutzafi 2008a: 56-57)

a. *ʾile* *šwiqa.*
COP.3SG.M leave.PPRT.SG.M
'He has left.'

b. *šwiqa=ile.*
leave.PPRT.SG.M=COP.3SG.M
'He has left.'

In some dialects, a preposed independent copula is used in a thetic construction to express a permanent situation in contrast to the deictic copula, which is used in a thetic construction to express a contingent situation. This use of the independent copula is found in Christian dialects in the northern sector of NENA from Ṭyare to Urmi, e.g.,

(66) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a: 628)
gúða *mòdi=le?*| *ʾíle* *gə̀ldət* *xa-hèywən.*|
churn what=COP.3SG.M COP.3SG.M skin.of one-animal
'What is a churn? It is the skin of an animal.'

Here the thetic clause performs the discourse management function of explanatory elaboration.

This thetic construction with a preposed independent copula is frequently embedded in a sentence with an initial topic. As with other embedded thetic constructions such as (52) and (60b), the purpose is to indicate that what is said

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about the topic is not simply the imparting of information but rather it has a discourse management function, typically elaborative explanation.

15.2 Copulas in Iranian

All Iranian languages have enclitic copulas. The following table shows illustrative paradigms from a cross-section of Iranian languages.

Table 15.1: Present copula paradigms in selected West Iranian languages

	Gorani	CK	NK	SK	Persian
1SG	*=na*	*=im*	*=im*	*=im*	*=am*
2SG	*=nî*	*=î*	*=î(t)*	*=î(d)*	*=i*
3SG	*=n* (sg.m)/*=ne* (sg.f)	*=e*	*=e*	*=e*	*=ê*
1PL	*=nmê*	*=în/=in*	*=în*	*=îm(an)*	*=îm*
2PL	*=ndê*	*=in*	*=in*	*=în/=in*	*=îd*
3PL	*=nê*	*=in*	*=in*	*=in*	*=an*

The Gorani present copula forms are different from the rest of Iranian in that they consist of a stem *n* and inflectional suffixes. In the 3sg.m, the stem *n* has zero inflection.

Across CK and SK, the 3sg enclitic copula *=e* becomes a frozen form in the expression of the perfect. Here, two developments are attested. In SK and the northernmost varieties of CK in and around Erbil, the frozen copula appears with both intransitive and transitive verbs in the perfect.

(67) SK
hati-m=e
come.PST.PTCP-1SG:S=PERF
'I have come.'

(68) CK Erbil
hatî-m=e
come.PST.PTCP-1SG:S-PERF
'I have come.'

In the CK varieties around Sulemaniyya and Sanandaj, the frozen copula appears only with transitive verbs.

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(69) CK Sulemaniyya
hat-û=m
come.PST.PTCP=COP.1SG:S
'I have come.'

(70) CK Sulemaniyya
xward-û=m=e
eat.PST.PTCP=1SG:A=PERF
'I have eaten.'

The enclitic copula can attach to the existential base *he* and derive the existential copula in these languages, see Table 15.2 for the forms.

Table 15.2: Existential copula in Iranian

	Gorani	NCK	SCK	SK	Persian
1SG	*he=na*	*he=m*	*he=m*	*he=m*	*hast-am*
2SG	*he=nî*	*he=yt*	*he=y*	*he=y*	*hast-î*
3SG	*he=n* (m)/ *he=ne* (f)	*he=ye*	*he=s*	*he=s(e)*	*hast-Ø*
1PL	*he=nmê*	*he=yn*	*he=yn*	*he=ym*	*hast-im*
2PL	*he=ndê*	*he=n*	*he=n*	*he=n*	*hast-id*
3PL	*he=nê*	*he=n*	*he=n*	*he=n*	*hast-an*

15.2.1 Mobility of the enclitic copula

The position of the enclitic copula is generally fixed on the predicate in Iranian languages. If the subject constituent is in narrow focus, this can only be expressed by the prosody, whereby the nuclear stress of the intonation group is placed on the subject rather than on the predicate (see 71):

(71) Central Kurdish
mìn mamosta=m
1SG teacher=COP.1SG:S
'I (and not somebody else) am the teacher.'

Mobility of the enclitic copula is a feature of conservative Hewramî varieties within the Gorani group. In these, in equative copula clauses, the nuclear stress of an intonation group on the subject constituent expressing narrow focus can be associated with the movement of the enclitic copula onto the subject, e.g.,

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(72) Hewramî Takht (Mohammadirad 2026: 388)
mìn=na kuř-û mîr-î|
1SG=COP.1SG:S son-EZ.GEN prince-M.SG.OBL
'I (and not another) am the prince's son/It is I who is the prince's son.'

(73) Hewramî Takht (Mohammadirad 2026: 388)
anen pîya!
*àne=**n*** *pîya*|
DEM.DIST.M.3SG.DIR=COP.3SG.M:S man.M
'**He** is the man [not you]!' [ŞC.19]

This property of the enclitic copula is also attested to some extent in Behdînî Northern Kurdish, e.g.,

(74) NK Akre (MacKenzie 1962: 268)
tò=î kerîm?|
2SG=COP.2SG:S PN
'Are YOU Karim?'

It should be noted, however, that enclitic copulas are not mobile in Central Kurdish, peripheral Gorani varieties, and in Southern Kurdish.

15.2.2 Sentential demonstratives

Sentential demonstratives are expressed in Northern Kurdish by combining a deictic pronoun with a copula, e.g.,

(75) Behdînî
a. *ewê-he=ye.*
DEIC.3SG.M-DIST=COP.3SG
'There he is (lit. It is that one over there).'
b. *ewa-he=ye.*
DEIC.3SG.F-DIST=COP.3SG
'There she is.'
c. *ewêt-he=ne.*
DEIC.3PL-DIST=COP.3PL
'There they are.'

Such constructions are mainly used with third person copulas, though they can be used with copulas of other persons in some circumstances, e.g.,

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(76) Behdînî
tu eve=yî.
you DEIC.PROX=COP.2SG
'Here you are.'

In Hewramî, demonstrative pronouns combine with the attention-drawing paricle *=a* to express sentential demonstratives.

(77) Hewramî Tekht (Mohammadirad 2026: 182)
m-aç-o ama=n=o
IND-say.PRS-3SG:A come.PST.PTCP.M=COP.3SG.M:S=COMPL
în(e)*=*a
DEM.PROX.DIR.M.3SG=PTCL
'He (the sultan) said, 'He has returned; there [he is].''

The same structure occurs in the neighbouring CK varieties. Here the attention-drawing particle *ha* is used.

(78) CK Mariwan
eme ha
DEM.PROX.3SG PTCL
'Here it is.'

15.2.3 Deictic copula

Inflected deictic copulas occur in Behdînî NK, Gorani, Southern Kurdish, and neighbouring CK varieties. In Behdînî, they have the form of an independent *ezafe* inflected for gender and number, viz. *(y)ê* (sg.m), *(y)a* (sg.f), and *(y)êt* (pl.). In Gorani, SK, and Southern CK varieties, the deictic copula consists of a deictic particle *ha* in Kurdish, and *(î)na* in Goranî, which is inflected by inflectional suffixes from the past tense. The deictic copula in Gorani is derived from the proximal pronoun *îne*, which is combined with an attention-drawing particle *a*, resulting in the form *îna*.

15.2.4 Uses of the deictic copula in Gorani, SK, and Southern CK

The deictic particle *ha* can be used to draw attention to a situation in the immediate environment, e.g.,

(79) CK Sanandaj (Mohammadirad 2022b: H.9)

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Table 15.3: Deictic copula in Gorani, SK, and Southern CK

	Gorani	SK	Southern CK
1SG	*îna-nê*	*ha-m*	*ha-m*
2SG	*îna-y*	*ha-y*	*ha-y*
3SG	*îna*	*ha-Ø*	*ha-Ø*
1PL	*îna-ymê*	*ha-ym(in)*	*ha-yn*
2PL	*îna-ydê*	*ha-yn*	*ha-n*
3PL	*înɛ*	*ha-n*	*ha-n*

ha ka çonerî hat=ew
DEIC mr PN come.PST.3SG=COMPL
'There Mr. Chonari has come back.'

The inflected deictic copula in Gorani is the basis for the formation of locational copula clauses (See §15.2.4). This feature has spread through the influence of the Gorani substratum to neighbouring CK and SK varieties (Mohammadirad 2024b), e.g.,

(80) Hewramî Tekht (Mohammadirad 2026)
îna-ymê fiłan-e yagê
DEIC-1PL:S such_and_such-EZ.CMPD place.F
'We are at such-and-such a place.' [PM.12]

(81) CK Sanandaj
ha le mał-ê tarîk=a
DEIC.3SG:S at house-IND dark=POST
'He is in a dark house.'

In Kurdish varieties that are outside the immediate Gorani zone of influence, e.g., CK Mukri, the deictic copula is not used in the formation of locational copula constructions, e.g.,

(82) CK Mukri (Öpengin 2016: 202)
kiç-eke=m de çwarbax-êk-î da=ye
daughter-DEF=1SG:P in royal_garden-INDF-OBL POST=COP.3SG:S
'My daughter is in a (royal) garden.'

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15.2.5 Uses of the deictic copula in NK

The deictic *ezafe* copula in Behdînî NK serves various functions.

i. Locational copula clauses

As in the Kurdish varieties in 15.2.4, the deictic *ezafe* copula is used in locational copula clauses, e.g.,

(83) *ez ê li mal*
1SG.DIR EZ.M.SG at house
'I (m) am at the house.'

(84) *ez a li mal*
1SG.DIR EZ.F.SG at house
'I (f) am at the house.'

ii. Ascriptive copula clauses

(85) *ez ê baş im*
1SG.DIR EZ.M.SG well COP.1SG:S
'I (m) am well.'

(86) *ez a baş im*
1SG.DIR EZ.F.SG well COP.1SG:S
'I (f) am well.'

iii. Perfect constructions

(87) *ez ê hatî*
1SG.DIR EZ.M.SG comePST.PTCP
'I (m) have come.'

(88) NK Duhok (Khan et al. 2022b: 334)
me tu ya kuştî
1PL.OBL 2SG.DIR EZ.F kill.PST.PTCP
'(That) we have killed you.'

iv. Progressive

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(89) NK Zakho (Haig 2011)
ez yê xwarin-ê çê-di-ki-m
1SG.DIR EZ.M food-F.SG.OBL PVB-IND-do.PRS-1SG:A
'I am making food.'

In Duhok, the *ezafe* can be used in negated clauses, e.g.,

(90) *ava təšt-aḵ-ē na yē, na yē ṭabīʿī řūy*
DEM.PROX.SG thing-INDF-OBL.F NEG EZ.M NEG EZ.M normal happening
əṭ-da-t-ən.
IND-give.PRS-3SG-NA
'What is happening here is not something natural.'

15.2.6 Zazaki

Like other Kurdic varieties, Zazaki has an enclitic copula that attaches to the predicate. The copula inflects for person, number, and gender (see Table 15.4). The most variation is found in the 1SG form. Some varieties also exhibit levelling in the plural, where the original 1PL with a bilabial nasal merges with the 2PL and 3PL forms. This variation is a diagnostic feature of Zazaki dialectology. Negation of copular clauses is formed analytically by prefixing *nî-* to the copula.

Table 15.4: Zazaki copula clitics

	Affirmative	Negated
1SG	*=ane ~ =an ~ =a*	*nîyane ~ nîyan ~ nîya*
	=one ~ =on ~ =o	*nîyone ~ nîyon ~ nîyo*
	=une ~ (i)ne ~ =û ~ =u	*nîyune ~ nîne ~ nîyû ~ nîyu*
2SG.M	*=ê ~ =î*	*nîyê ~ nîy*
2SG.F	*=a ~ =ay*	*nîya*
3SG.M	*=o ~ =u ~ =we*	*nîyo*
3SG.F	*=a ~ =ay*	*nîya*
1PL	*=îme ~ =îmi ~ =îm*	*nîme ~ nîmi ~ nîm*
	=ê ~ =î	*nîyê ~ nîy*
2PL	*=ê ~ =î*	*nîyê ~ nîy*
3PL	*=ê ~ =î*	*nîyê ~ nîy*

In general, the copula occupies a fixed position, attaching directly to the predicate.

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(91) Copula sentences in Northern Zazaki (fieldwork)

a. *ez Îbrahîm=one*
1SG Ibrahim=COP.1SG
'I am Ibrahim.'

b. *Xidir tî=ya?*
Xidir 2SG=COP.2SG
'Are you Xidir?'

A striking feature is that in predicate nominal sentences, usually with equative/ascriptive clauses, the copula does not agree in gender with the subject, but rather with the predicative nominal. Thus, when the predicate is feminine, the copula surfaces in its feminine form, even if the subject is masculine.

(92) Northern Zazaki (fieldwork)

a. *nam-ê mi Mevlüd=o*
name.M-EZ.M 1SG.OBL PN.M=COP.3SG.M
'My name is Mevlüd.'

b. *nam-ê mi Nurten=a*
name.M-EZ.M 1SG.OBL PN.F=COP.3SG.F
'My name is Nurten.'

The existential copula is expressed by *est-* + copula. The negative existential employs *çin-* (and variations thereof) + copula.

15.2.6.1 Deictic particle *ha*

Zazaki has a deictic particle *ha* (see chapter on demonstratives, §10.2, Table 10.9), which can occur in locative and progressive constructions. In some varieties, the copula is absent in locative clauses, suggesting that *ha* and its regional allomorphs function as a reduced or reanalyzed deictic copula. It introduces contingent, situational predications rather than permanent states.

(93) Deictic particle *ha* and copula

a. (Central Zazaki, Baluken 2021: 62)
Ehmed h-o kîye=d.
Ahmed DEIC-COP.3SG home=at
'Ahmed is at home.'

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b. (Northern Zazaki, Selcan 1998: 585)
ana lazek=o ha!
DEM boy=COP.3SG.M DEIC
'It is that boy (there)!'

15.2.6.2 The particle *de*

An additional feature is reported for the dialects of Hezo (Batman) in Eastern Zazaki, which remain insufficiently documented. In copular sentences with adjectival predicates, a particle *de* (and variations thereof, such as *di, da, do*) precedes the adjective, e.g.,

(94) Zazaki of Hezo (fieldwork)

a. *ez de baş=ane*
1SG PTCL good=COP.1SG
'I am good.'

b. *da cuwamêr-e bî-ye*
PTCL generous-F be.PST-3SG.F
'[my grandmother] was generous'

The distribution of this particle, its origin, and its possible relation to other *d*-forms in Zazaki (for instance, the *ezafe* or future particle) is still unclear. At present, its function appears to be restricted to marking predicative adjectives. Further research is required to determine whether this represents a purely local innovation or a more widespread phenomenon.

15.2.7 Sentential demonstratives

Sentential demonstratives are expressed in Zazaki by a deictic particle combined with a demonstrative pronoun and copula, e.g.,

(95) a. *no=wo*
DEIC.PROX.SG.M=COP.3SG.M
'Here he is.'

b. *ha=wo*
DEIC.DIST.SG.M=COP.3SG.M
'There he is.'

The distal sentential demonstrative *ha-wo* sometimes contracts to *ho*.

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15.2.8 Auxiliary use in tense–aspect constructions

The copula is central not only in equative and locational clauses, but also in the formation of periphrastic tense and aspect constructions.

The perfect is built by attaching the copula forms to the past stem of the verb. Also, in the preterite the copula is used to mark person in the first and second persons. Only the third person is expressed by a simple past stem with inflections for gender and number.

Progressive forms are formed by using the copula, often in combination with a deictic particle. Finally, the pluperfect consists of the past stem in combination with the past copula.

15.3 Copulas in Arabic

Many *Qəltu* Arabic dialects, especially but not only in Anatolia, have innovated present tense copulas from personal pronouns (Jastrow 1978: 131-136), in contrast to Old Arabic and most Arabic dialects, which lack them.[1] In most *Qəltu* dialects, the copula is placed after the predicate as an enclitic. The paradigms in (96) from the Arbīl dialect show the relationship between the independent pronouns and the enclitic copula:

(96) Arbīl (Jastrow 1990a: 36-37)

	Independent pronoun	Enclitic pronominal copula
3SG.M	*hūwe*	*=ūwe*
3SG.F	*hīye*	*=īye*
3PL	*həmme*	*=əm(e)*
2SG.M	*ənta*	*=ənta*
2SG.F	*ənti*	*=ənti*
2PL	*əntəm*	*=əntəm*
1SG	*ana*	*=ana*
1PL	*nəḥne*	*=nəḥne*

In the Siirt dialects, however, the copula precedes the predicate, e.g.,

(97) Siirt (town) (Jastrow 1978: 132)

[1]Even non-*Qəltu* varieties may use pronouns as copulas under certain conditions, for instance, when the predicate is definite (Eid 1983), but they are not otherwise used systematically as such.

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a. *āva* *l-walad* *ūwe* *bōš* *malī*
DEM.SG.M DEF-boy COP.PRS.3SG.M very good.SG.M
'This boy is very good.'

b. *āvi* *l-bənt* *īye* *malīḥa*
DEM.SG.F DEF-girl COP.PRS.3SG.F good.SG.F
'This girl is good.'

In the Siirt dialects, the copula is exceptionally placed after the predicate only under certain conditions. One of the exceptions is questions, where it is enclitic, e.g.,

(98) Siirt (town) (Jastrow 1978: 132)
axū-k *awne=we?* *ūwe* *awne*
brother-2SG.M here=COP.PRS.3SG.M COP.PRS.3SG.M here
'"Is your brother here?" "He is here."'

Many dialects also possess one or more deictic copulas (called a 'demonstrative Kopula' in the German language sources). There are three types, each with a distinct meaning, according to Jastrow (Jastrow 1978: 139-141).

One is built on the enclitic copula with a *k-* prefix, which is used in the verbal system as a progressive preverbal particle before present stem verbs (see §19.3):

(99)

	Bəḥzāni	Kəndērib
3SG.M	*kū*	*kūwe*
3SG.F	*kī*	*kīye*
3PL	*kəm*	*kənne*
2SG.M	*kənta*	*kənt*
2SG.F	*kənti*	*kənti*
2PL	*kəntəm*	*kəntən*
1SG	*kana*	*kwāna*
1PL	*kənəḥna*	*kūnəḥne*

Such deictic copulas focus on the 'here and now' (Jastrow 1978: 140), e.g., Bəḥzāni *kū* 'look he is ... right now', *kənta* 'you are ... right now'.

Another type of deictic copula is formed from the first type through the addition of a suffix *-ā* (< **hā*). This only exists in the third person and expresses 'There is ...!' (German 'da ist ...'):

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(100) Kəndērib

3SG.M	*kwā*
3SG.F	*kyā*
3PL	*kənā́*

(101) Āzəx

a. *kwā* *wēḥəd*
DEIC.COP.3SG.M one
'There is one (a person)!'

b. *kyā* *pīrət* *əl-wəḥde*
DEIC.COP.3SG.F woman.CSTR DEF-ONE.F
'There is an old woman!'

The third type is formed from the second type with a further *-hā* suffix:

(102) Azəx

3SG.M *kōhā́*

This expresses far deixis, i.e., 'Over there is ...' (Jastrow 1978: 140-141).

The second type of deictic copula (100) is restricted to Anatolia, according to Jastrow (1978: 140); presumably, the third is also thus restricted. Among the dialects considered here, we find the second and third types of deictic copulas only definitely attested in Āzəx, which is Anatolian, and, as expected, not attested in the Iraqi dialects. Related in function but not in form to the aforementioned deictic copulas is the presentative found in Mosul, e.g. *hayyānu* 'there he is!' Jastrow (1979: 44) gives only third person forms for this.

On the periphery of the NENA area the Sason dialect exhibits a split in the paradigm of the enclitic copula whereby third person forms are of pronominal origin but the first and second person forms are verbal in origin (corresponding to the Old Arabic past verbal copula *kāna*). Compare the other peripheral varieties of Mardin and Daragözü, where the entire paradigm is of pronominal origin.

(103) Sason (Akkuş 2017: 460-461), Mardin (Grigore 2007), Daragözü (Jastrow 1973)

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	Sason	Mardin	Daragözü
3SG.M	*=je*	*we*	*=uu*
3SG.F	*=je*	*je*	*=ii*
3PL	*=nen*	*ənne*	*=ən*
2SG.M	*kənt*	*ənt*	*ənt*
2SG.F	*kənte*	*ənti*	*ənte*
2PL	*kənto*	*ənten*	*ənte*
1SG	*kəntu*	*ana*	*naa*
1PL	*kənna*	*nəḥne*	*naḥne*

Table 15.5: Arabic copulas inside the NENA area

	Enclitic present copula?	Deictic copulas?
Mosul (M, C, J)	no enclitic present copula (Jastrow 1979: 42)	deictic copulas not mentioned, but a presentative *hayyān-* 'there ... is!' is attested (Jastrow 1979: 44)
Bəḥzāni (C, Y, M)	enclitic present copula (Jastrow 1978: 134-135)	deictic copula with *k-* (Jastrow 1978: 139)
Mērgi (C)	apparently no present copula (Hassan 2023)	possibly deictic copula with *k-*[2]
Səndōṛ (J)	enclitic present copula (Jastrow 1991b: 782)	deictic copula with *k-* (Jastrow 1991b: 782)
Arbīl and ʿAqra (J)	enclitic present copula (Jastrow 1990a: 36-38)	no information in Jastrow (1990a), presumed absent

[2]Deictic copulas are not mentioned in Hassan's 2023 description, but in his texts there are three examples of *ku-* and *kə-*, which could be instances of the first deictic copula with a passive participle predicate *maġmi* 'thrown'. The first two are given here: *qāmu dawwaġu fattašu ġāyu ġās-u ku-məġmi makān w-ġəjl-u ku-məġmi makān* ... [get.up.SC.3PL search.SC.3PL search.SC.3PL see.SC.3PL head-3SG.M ku-throw.PASS.PTCP.3SG.M place and-leg-3SG.M ku-throw.PASS.PTCP.3SG.M place] 'They checked and looked, they saw his head [is] thrown in a place, his leg [is] thrown in a place...' Another example is with a different passive participle: *w-laḥadd əl'ān qabġ-u ku-mawjūd hawni xalf əl-bīʕa* [and-up.to now grave-SG.M ku-present.SG.M/find.PASS.PTCP.SG.M here behind DEF-church] 'and his grave is still there behind the church.' Other examples of *ku-* in the texts are likely the existential particle ('there is' < *aku).

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Table 15.6: Arabic copulas on the periphery of the NENA area

On the periphery of the NENA area	Enclitic present copula?	Deictic copulas?
Āzəx (C)	enclitic present copula (Wittrich 2001: 32–34)	all three deictic copulas (Wittrich 2001: 35–36)
Siirt town (M)	proclitic present copula, but enclitic under certain conditions (Jastrow 1978: 132; Biţună 2016b: 132-133)	no information in Jastrow (1978) or Biţună (2016b)
Tillo (M)	enclitic present copula (Lahdo 2009: 73-74)	no information in Lahdo (2009)
Kirkūk (J), Khānaqīn (J), Tūz Khurmātu (J)	occasionally an enclitic present copula (Bar-Moshe 2024)	no information in Bar-Moshe (2024)

15.4 The copula/auxiliary in Armenian

15.4.1 Enclitic copula/auxiliary

All Armenian dialects have an enclitic copula. It expresses the person of the subject. In most dialects, it also expresses tense (present and past), except in the dialects with a past particle (see §12.4.4), where past tense is expressed by this particle.

Table 15.7: The paradigm of the enclitic copula/auxiliary in Standard Eastern Armenian

Person	Present	Past
1SG	*em*	*ēi*
2SG	*es*	*ēir*
3SG	*ē*	*ēr*
1PL	*enk^c*	*ēink^c*
2PL	*ek^c*	*ēik^c*
3PL	*en*	*ēin*

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It is normally attached as a clitic to the predicate, as seen in (104):

(104) SEA (Dum-Tragut 2009: 215)
Anuš-ə gełecʿik ałǰik=ē
Anush-DEF beautiful girl=be.PRS.3SG
'Anush is a beautiful girl.'

There is no difference between its behaviour with predicates expressing permanent (104) and contingent (105) properties.

(105) SEA
Anuš-ə lav=ē
Anush-DEF well=be.PRS.3SG
'Anush is well.'

The enclitic copula also functions as an auxiliary in complex tense forms, in which case it normally attaches to the verb, as in (106).

(106) SEA (Dum-Tragut 2009: 215)
Anuš-ə gr-um=ē
Anush-DEF write-I.PTCP=be.PRS.3SG
'Anush is writing/writes'

There is no difference between its behaviour in main and subordinate clauses. It does not attach to subordinators. This includes relative pronouns, which, although they are identical to interrogative pronouns, exhibit different syntactic properties, behaving like topical elements rather than focused elements, as discussed by Hodgson (2019b: 271-2). Thus, in (107), the copula/auxiliary attaches to the lexical verb, just as in the corresponding main clause in (106), and does not attach to the relative pronoun *vor*.

(107) SEA
ayn ałǰik-ə vor gr-um=ē
DEM2 girl-DEF which write-I.PTCP=be.PRS.3SG
'the girl who is writing/writes'

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15.4.2 Movement of enclitic copula/auxiliary

In Eastern Armenian dialects, including SEA[3], the copula/auxiliary is mobile, generally attaching to the element with the nuclear sentential stress.

In cases of narrow focus, the element with the nuclear sentential stress (marked with grave accent on the stressed vowel) is the focused element, and it is this which receives the copula, both in simple copular clauses, as seen in (108), (109), (110), and clauses with complex verb forms consisting of the copula/auxiliary and a participle, as seen in (111), (112), (113).[4]

(108) SEA
Aràm-n=ē *im* *ənker-ə* *(voč‘ t‘e* *Petros-ə)|*
Aram-DEF=be.PRS.3SG 1SG.GEN friend-DEF NEG COMP Petros-DEF
‘ARAM is my friend (not Petros).’

(109) SEA
Aràm-n=ē *cuyl-ə* *(voč‘ t‘e* *Petros-ə)|*
Aram-DEF=be.PRS.3SG lazy-DEF NEG COMP Petros-DEF
‘ARAM is lazy (not Petros).’

(110) SEA
Aràm-n=ē *aysteł (voč‘ t‘e* *Petros-ə)|*
Aram-DEF=be.PRS.3SG here NEG COMP Petros-DEF
‘ARAM is here (not Petros).’

[3]Examples (111), (112), (113), (114), (115), are adapted from Kahnemuyipour & Megerdoomian (2017: 78), and (117) from Kahnemuyipour & Megerdoomian (2011: 159); the original versions are in the colloquial Eastern Armenian of Tehran, but they have here been translated into SEA, where the same generalisations apply, as they do in most other Eastern dialects.

[4]Clauses with complex verb forms including a participle and a mobile focus-sensitive copula bear a superficial resemblance to clefts, but should be distinguished from true clefts, which are also available as a focus strategy in Armenian, as discussed by Khurshudyan & Donabédian (2021). The latter are biclausal constructions with a matrix clause and a relative-like clause, as seen in (i). This contrasts with (ii), a monoclausal construction with a complex verb form including a single mobile copula and a participle.

(i) SEA (Khurshudyan & Donabédian 2021: 98)
es *Lenin-ì-n=ē,* *or* *tesn-um=em|*
1SG.NOM LeninDAT-DEF=be.PRS.3SG which see-I.PTCP=be.PRS.1SG
‘It is Lenin that I see.’

(ii) SEA
es *Lenin-ì-n=em* *tesn-um|*
1SG.NOM LeninDAT-DEF=be.PRS.1SG see-I.PTCP
‘I see LENIN.’

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(111) SEA
Aràm-n=ē *aŕ-el* *ays* *mekʿena-n|*
Aram-DEF=be.PRS.3SG buy-PST.PTCP DEM1 car-DEF
'ARAM has bought this car.'

(112) SEA
Aram-ə *ays* *mekʿenà-n=ē* *aŕ-el|*
Aram-DEF DEM1 car-DEF=be.PRS.3SG buy-PST.PTCP
'Aram bought THIS CAR.'

(113) SEA
Aram-ə *aŕ-èl=ē* *ays* *mekʿena-n|*
Aram-DEF buy-PST.PTCP=be.PRS.3SG DEM1 car-DEF
'Aram did buy this car.'/'Aram BOUGHT this car.'

This also applies to interrogatives (114, 115), which have been observed to show the same syntactic behaviour as narrow focus in Eastern Armenian (see Comrie 1984, Kahnemuyipour & Megerdoomian 2011, 2017 etc.).

(114) SEA
Aràm-n=ē *ays* *mekʿena-n* *aŕ-el|*
Aram-DEF=be.PRS.3SG DEM1 car-DEF buy-PST.PTCP
'Was it Aram who bought this car?'

(115) SEA
òv=ē *ays* *mekʿena-n* *aŕ-el|*
who.NOM=be.PRS.3SG DEM1 car-DEF buy-PST.PTCP
'Who bought this car?'

Comrie (1984) points out that when an interrogative co-occurs with a contrastive element that receives the main sentential stress, it is the interrogative that takes the copula/auxiliary, as seen in (116), implying that the distribution of the copula/auxiliary in Eastern Armenian is determined by syntax rather than directly by prosody. Both Comrie (1984) and Kahnemuyipour & Megerdoomian (2011: 159) also show that when the main sentential stress falls on the modifier of a major constituent of the clause, the copula/auxiliary is enclitic on the constituent as a whole, as seen in (117), where it is enclitic on the object noun phrase, not on the stressed adjective that modifies it, providing further evidence that copula movement in Armenian is sensitive to syntactic structure.

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(116) SEA (Comrie 1984: 18)
Context: "What is your name?" "Aram."
"isk kʿò anun-n inčʿ=ē" "Ruben"
and 2SG.GEN name-DEF what=be3SG.PRS Ruben
"And what is YOUR name?" "Ruben."

(117) SEA
yerexa-ner-ə mèc muk=en čar-el|
child-PL-DEF big mouse=be.PRS.3PL find-PST.PTCP
'The children have found a BIG mouse.'

In the absence of narrow focus, the nuclear sentential stress and the copula/auxiliary generally fall on the leftmost present element out of the following: the verb (106), a preverb (118), some types of manner or measure adverb (119), an indefinite object (120), or the subject of an intransitive thetic sentence (121).

(118) EA of Tehran (Kahnemuyipour & Megerdoomian 2017: 78)
Aɪam-ə nəkaɪ-ət indz cʰùycʰ=a təv-el|
Aram-DEF picture-ART2 1SG.DAT show.PV=be.PRS.3SG give-PST.PTCP
'Aram showed me your photo.'

(119) EA of Tehran (Kahnemuyipour & Megerdoomian 2017: 78)
Aɪa-n ʃàt=a gʊkʰ kaɪtʰ-um|
Ara-DEF much=be.PRS.3SG book read-I.PTCP
'Ara reads (books) a lot.'

(120) EA of Tehran (Kahnemuyipour & Megerdoomian 2017: 78)
Aɪa-n gùkʰ=a kaɪtʰ-um|
Ara-DEF book=be.PRS.3SG read-I.PTCP
'Ara is reading a book.'/'Ara reads books.'

(121) EA of Tehran (Kahnemuyipour & Megerdoomian 2017: 83)
me hat tùpʰ=a has-el|
one piece box=be.PRS.3SG arrive-PST.PTCP
'A box has arrived.'

In SWA and many other Western dialects, the copula/auxiliary does not show this mobility, being always enclitic on the predicate, including in interrogatives (122), (123). In complex tense forms, it is always enclitic on the verb (123), except in negative constructions, where it fuses with the negative morpheme, forming a stressed independent negative auxiliary, and appears in preverbal position (124).

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(122) SWA (Yeghiayan 2022: 210)
inčʿu apšac=es
why astonished=be.PRS.2SG
'Why are you astonished?'

(123) SWA (Yeghiayan 2022: 624)
inčʿ npatak-ov ek-ac=em
what purpose-INS come-RES.PTCP=be.PRS.1SG
'For what purpose have I come?'

(124) SWA (Yeghiayan 2022: 393)
kʿez čʿem ls-er
2SG.DAT NEG.be.PRS.1SG hear-N.PTCP
'I can't [lit. don't] hear you.'

This only applies to the auxiliary in complex tenses. In non-verbal predicates, the negative auxiliary follows the predicate (125).

(125) SWA (Yeghiayan 2022: 396)
ays verǰin jew-ə bacʿaŕvac čʿē
DEM1 last form-DEF excluded NEG.be.PRS.3SG
'This last form is not excluded.'

In SEA and many eastern dialects, the negative auxiliary shows the same behaviour as in SWA, appearing in preverbal position in complex tense forms (126) but following a non-verbal predicate (127).

(126) SEA (Dum-Tragut 2009: 215)
Anuš-ə čʿi gr-um
Anush-DEF NEG.be.PRS.3SG write-I.PTCP
'Anush is not writing / doesn't write.'

(127) SEA (Dum-Tragut 2009: 215)
Anuš-ə gełecʿik ałǰik čʿē
Anush-DEF beautiful girl NEG.be.PRS.3SG
'Anush is not a beautiful girl.'

However, in some Eastern Armenian dialects, including Agulis, Karabagh, and Lori, the negative auxiliary shows a pattern of mobility similar to its affirmative counterpart, appearing in preverbal position following an interrogative expression (128), a preverb in a complex verb construction (129), or an indefinite object

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(130), but following the verb in the absence of such elements (131). Thus, these far Eastern Armenian dialects show the greatest extent of mobility of the copula/auxiliary.

(128) Agulis Armenian (Tsghna) (Hodgson 2022a)
im *ʧʰis* *to-l*
why NEG.be.PRS.2SG give-F.PTCP
'Why won't you give [it to me]?'

(129) Agulis Armenian (Tsghna) (Hodgson 2022a)
miz *tsekʰʧʰi* *to-l*
1PL.DAT hand NEG.be.PRS.3SG give-F.PTCP
'He won't harm us [lit. give us hand].'

(130) Agulis Armenian (Tsghna) (Hodgson 2022a)
is *səɾutsʰ* *axʧʰik* *ʧʰim* *to-l*
1SG.NOM DEM1.DAT.PL girl NEG.be.PRS.1SG give-FPT
'I won't give a girl to them.'

(131) Agulis Armenian (Tsghna) (Hodgson 2022a)
hasaɾak *varʒapet-i-n* *im* *əxʧʰ ək-u-n* *to-l*
ordinary schoolmaster-DAT-DEF 1SG.GEN girl-DAT-DEF give-F.PTCP
ʧʰim
NEG.be.PRS.1SG
'I won't give my daughter to an [lit. the] ordinary schoolmaster.'

Although the mobility of the copula/auxiliary is often cited as one of the characteristics that distinguishes Eastern from Western Armenian, this feature in fact extends much further west than the border of Eastern and Western Armenian. The copula/auxiliary may attach to preverbal elements in Van (132), Mush (133), Diyarbakir (134), and Dersim (135).

(132) Van Armenian (Acharyan 1952: 215)
inoɾ *tv-ats* *katʰ, matsun, gjørømazt* *ʃat=es*
3SG.GEN give-RES.PTCP milk yoghurt ?type.of.yoghurt much=be.PRS.2SG
lk-e
drink[pejorative]-PST.PTCP
'You have slurped up a lot of the milk and yoghurt it [my cow] has given.'

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(133) Mush Armenian (Baghdasaryan-Tapaltsyan 1958: 199)
uɾ kuʃt ʧʰəval me oski=e dər-ug
3SG.GEN side sack one gold=bePRS.3SG put-RES.PTCP
'A sack of gold has been put next to him.'

(134) Diyarbakir (Tigranakert) Armenian (Haneyan 1978: 167)
æɾo-n=in dzedz-ædz
Aro-DEF=be.PRS.2SG beat-RES.PTCP
'Have they beaten Aro?'

(135) Dersim (Berri) Armenian (Baghramyan 1960: 43)
Minʧʰev inə daɾikʰ-əs Xaɾpʰertʰ-i meʧʰən=im mendztsʰ-eɾ
until nine age-ART1 Kharpert-GEN in=be.PRS.1SG grow.up-PST.PTCP
'Until the age of nine I grew up in Kharpert.'

In these areas, which form the border between dialects with a mobile copula and those where the copula is not mobile, the copula may be repeated, once on the preverbal stressed element, and once on the verb. This is most commonly reported in negative constructions, where it is attested in Mush (136), Diyarbakir (137), Dersim (138), and the Van subdialect of Diadin as spoken in Vardenis in Armenia (Jahukyan 1972: 115), as well as the neighbouring Eastern Armenian dialect of Bayazet (139). However, repetition of the copula has also been reported in affirmative clauses, as seen in (140) and (141), which, together with its geographical distribution, suggests that this represents a transitional state between dialects with a mobile copula attaching to the element with the main sentential stress, and ones where the copula is obligatorily enclitic on the verb.

(136) Mush Armenian (Baghdasaryan-Tapaltsyan 1958: 156)
jes ʧʰəm gʰəɾ-eɾ=im
1SG.NOM NEG.be.PRS.1SG write-PST.PTCP=be.PRS.1SG
'I didn't write.'

(137) Diyarbakir (Tigranakert) Armenian (Haneyan 1978: 160)
jes santsʰ æxʧʰig ʧʰim des-iɾ=im
1SG.NOM such girl NEG.be.PRS.1SG see-PST.PTCP=be.PRS.1SG
'I have not seen such a girl.'

(138) Dersim (Zarsanchag) Armenian (Baghramyan 1960: 43)
ʧʰeɾ tʰɾʤ-eɾ=eɾ
NEG.be.PST.3SG soak-PST.PTCP=be.PST.3SG
'S/he hadn't soaked [it].'

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(139) Bayazet (Gavar) Armenian (Katvalyan 2009: 11)
ʧʰem *uz-um=em*
NEG.be.PRS.1SG want-I.PTCP=be.PRS.1SG
'I don't want [it].'

(140) Mush Armenian (Baghdasaryan-Tapaltsyan 1958: 121)
jes *im* *gʰəɾ-eɾ=im*
1SG.NOM be.PRS.1SG write-PST.PTCP=be.PRS.1SG
'I wrote [it].'

(141) Bayazet (Gavar) Armenian (Katvalyan 2009: 11)
jes *em* *gʰəɾ-eɾ=em*
1SG.NOM be.PRS.1SG write-PST.PTCP=be.PRS.1SG
'I wrote [it].'

15.5 The copula in Turkic

This section focusses on Turkic identificational copulae and excludes evidential copulae.

15.5.1 The indicative copula

Azeri has two defective sets of affirmative and negative indicative identification copulae: one used in the present tense and the other in the imperfect. The expression of identification in other TAM categories requires the use of the corresponding form of the verb *ol-* 'be, become'. The forms in the tables below reflect the forms in Standard Azeri.

In the present set, the 2SG affirmative copular form is of pronominal origin. The 1SG and 1PL forms were probably originally of the same type until they were contaminated by the respective short-series agreement markers (Johanson 2021), 1PL as late as the Middle Azeri stage; and 2PL fused with the corresponding possessive suffix, most probably already in Proto-Oghuz (Dybo & Levitskaja 2002: 124).

The past set is represented by contracted forms of a presently non-existent verb 'be' (the abovementioned *ol-* being a later generalisation of a verb originally meaning 'become'), conjugated in the preterite, and is morphologically more transparent than the present set (it clearly contains the short-series agreement markers typical of the preterite).

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Negative copular forms consist of combinations of the copular morpheme *deyil* (of uncertain origin) with the affirmative forms (except in the third person, where a bare form is preferred in the present).

The third person copula *=dXr*[5] (in most Azeri dialects, the vowel is centralised and the following consonant is almost or fully inaudible) derives from the auxiliary *durur*, a third-person present tense form of the verb *dur-* 'stand'. Note that plural subjects in the third person usually receive singular marking unless they are human, topical and "distinct", i.e., belonging to the same social group as the speaker, acting now or having acted at a specific point and construed as individuated; see Schroeder's (2009: 124) analysis of the phenomenon in Turkish.

Table 15.8: Indicative affirmative present identification copula

Person	Singular	Plural
1	*=Am*	*=XQ*
2	*=sAn*	*=sXnXz*
		spoken: *=sXz*
3	*=dXr*	*=dXr(-lAr)*
	spoken: *=dX*$_{[\text{CENTRAL}]}$	spoken: *=dX*$_{[\text{CENTRAL}]}$*(lAr)*

Table 15.9: Negative present identification copula

Person	Singular	Plural
1	*deyil=əm*	*deyil=ik*
2	*deyil=sən*	*deyil=siniz*
		(*deyil-siz*)
3	*deyil=∅*	*deyil=∅(-lər)*

[5]For the notation of Turkic vowels see §7.5.

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Table 15.10: Indicative affirmative past identification copula

Person	Singular	Plural
1	*idi-m*, *=(y)dX-m*	*idi-k*, *=(y)dX-Q*
2	*idi-n*, *=(y)dX-n*	*idi-niz*, *=(y)dX-nXz* (spoken: *=(y)dX-z*)
3	*idi-∅*, *=(y)dX-∅*	*idi-∅(-lər)*, *=(y)dX-∅(-lAr)*

Table 15.11: Negative past identification copula

Person	Singular	Plural
1	*deyil=di-m*	*deyil=di-k*
2	*deyil=di-n*	*deyil=di-niz* (spoken: *deyil=siz*)
3	*deyil=di-∅*	*deyil=di-∅(-lər)*

The use of copulae for identification is mandatory in Azeri, including in the third person (with the exception of ellipsis or rare, pragmatically marked cases). The latter sets it apart from most other Turkic languages and can probably be explained by contact with Iranian languages.

(142) Standard Azeri

a. *Sən həkim=sən.*
you doctor=COP.2SG
'You are a doctor.'

b. *Sən həkim deyil=sən.*
you doctor NEG.COP=COP.2SG
'You are not a doctor.'

Non-standard varieties may show slightly differing forms (see Bulut 2014: 44-47). In some varieties (including Urmia Azeri), a suffixal dorsal consonant may not assimilate to a front-vowel nucleus and instead surface as a uvular in all contexts, hence *-ix* and *-üx* can be front-vowel variants of 1PL. The second-person forms may show a different treatment of the historical velar nasal and the adjacent vowel (cf. North-western Azeri 2SG *-sAŋ*, 2PL *-sXŋXz*): the nasal may be realised as an approximant, and the vowel may appear rounded. In addition, in

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the southernmost varieties, the second-person copula typically does not contain an initial sibilant. 2SG forms such as *=An*, *=Ayn* or *=Ay* are found in Urmia Azeri, though only sporadically (Doğan 2010: 148-149).

15.5.2 The evidential copula

Turkic evidential copular particles signal that the information conveyed in an utterance is based on a reported or inferred source. While they primarily encode source dependence rather than the speaker's stance on the proposition's veracity, their pragmatic extension may also convey a degree of detachment (cognitive or affective) from the narrated event (Johanson 2021: 565-566).

In Standard Azeri, the evidential copula set is represented by contracted forms of a now non-existent verb 'be', conjugated in what is described for Old Turkic as the resultative–mirative (Erdal 2004: 294).

Table 15.12: Evidential copula

Person	Singular	Plural
1	*imiş-əm*, *=(X)(y)mXş-Am*	*imiş-ik*, *=(X)(y)mXş-XQ*
2	*imiş-sən*, *= (X)(y)mXş-sAn*	*imiş-siniz*, *=(X)(y)mXş-sXnXz* (spoken: *= (y)mXş-sXz*)
3	*imiş-∅*, *= (X)(y)mXş-∅*	*imiş-∅(-lər)*, *=(X)(y)mXş-∅(-lAr)*

With non-finite predicates, the evidential copula occupies the morphosyntactic slot of the identification and existential copulae (which have distinct forms only in the present and past). However, since evidentiality is tense-neutral, such sentences may have either present or past reference. Note that there is no negative evidential copula set, as negation is expressed on the predicate base.

(143) Standard Azeri

a. *Hüseyn həkim=(iy)miş.*
PN doctor= EVID.COP.3SG
'Apparently, Hüseyn is/was a doctor.'

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b. *Hüseyn həkim deyil=(iy)miş.*
PN doctor NEG.COP=EVID.COP:3SG
'Apparently, Hüseyn is not/was not a doctor.'

c. *Otaq-da pişik var=(ıy)mış.*
room-LOC cat EXIST.COP=EVID.COP.3SG
'Apparently, there is/was a cat in the room.'

d. *Otaq-da pişik yox=(uy)muş.*
room-LOC cat EXIST.COP=EVID.COP.3
'Apparently, there is/was no cat in the room.'

15.6 Discussion

The existence of an enclitic copula in NENA is a feature that is shared by other languages in the region. As discussed in §15.1.1, the NENA copula is pronominal in origin, though it has acquired verbal inflection. In most dialects, this verbal inflection is restricted to the first and second persons. The clearest parallel to a pronominal copula in languages in contact is in *Qəltu* Arabic dialects, where enclitic pronouns function as copulas (§15.3). In Kurdish, the enclitic copula consists of verbal inflectional endings, though the 3SG copula *=e* is likely to be the vestige of the stem of a copula verb with zero inflection. Compare the forms of the copula in earlier Iranian:

(144)

	Proto-Iranian	Old Iranian
1SG	**as-mi*	*ah-mi*
2SG	**as-ī*	*ah-ī*
3SG	**as-ti*	*as-ti*

The element *s* of the old stem is, indeed, attested in the 3SG copula after vowels in the CK dialect of Sanandaj, e.g.,

(145) CK Sanandaj (Khan & Mohammadirad 2024b: 172)
gewre=s
big=COP.3SG
'It is big.'

The Gorani present copula forms consist of a stem *n* and inflectional suffixes. The suffixes of the Gorani copula have a less complete correspondence to present

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verbal suffixes. It is significant, however, that there is correspondence in the first and second persons. The Gorani third-person copula endings that do not correspond to the present verbal endings are likely to be clitic pronouns in origin, as is the case with third person copulas in some other Iranian languages (Korn 2011). This split in the paradigm between pronominal third-person copulas and verbal first and second-person copulas would, therefore, match the split in the paradigm in the present copula in the main body of NENA dialects. If the *n* element of the 3SG of the Gorani paradigm is indeed a pronoun in origin, this would be a direct match of the stem *i* of the NENA copula, which is also likely to be originally a third person pronoun (Khan 2022c).

There is a parallel to the split between pronominal third person copulas and verbal first and second person copulas in the Qəltu Arabic dialect of Sason on the western periphery of the NENA area (103).

The enclitic copula in Turkic , by contrast, appears to be pronominal in origin in the first and second persons but verbal in the third person (§15.5.1).

The complete levelling of inflection of the present copula with verbal inflection that is found in NENA dialects on the eastern periphery of the NENA area, such as J. Sanandaj, matches more closely the profile of the copula in Kurdish than that of Gorani.

The movement of the copula onto constituents in focus is a feature of NENA dialects in the northern sector of the NENA area. Parallels for this sensitivity of the copula to focus are found in Eastern Armenian (§15.4.2) and in Behdînî varieties of Northern Kurdish (§15.2.1), which were in contact with the northern NENA dialects. The lack of movement of the copula in NENA dialects of the southern sector, including Jewish Trans-Zab dialects, corresponds to the lack of its movement in Central Kurdish. The fact that in some Gorani varieties the copula is moved onto focused items suggests that the behaviour of the copula in NENA dialects in the southern sector matches that of Central Kurdish rather than Gorani. The lack of movement of the copula in Jewish Trans-Zab in the north-eastern sector of NENA, such as J. Urmi (Khan 2008b: 316), is evidence that the speakers of such dialects migrated from further south.

The form of the deictic copula in NENA dialects on the Mosul plain, consisting of the pre-verbal particle *k-* (originating from a presentative **kā*) + enclitic copula, e.g., C. Qaraqosh *k-ilə* (3sg.m), is closely paralleled by Arabic *Qəltu* dialects, which, likewise, form deictic copulas by combining a *k-* particle with the enclitic copula, e.g., Bəḥzāni *k-ūwe*. One should also compare the Ṭuroyo sentential demonstrative construction consisting of the deictic element *ka-* and object L-suffixes, e.g., *ka-lé* 'there he is' (13). The L-suffix inflections of the NENA copula

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(predominantly in the third person forms) is likely to have originated in deictic constructions such as Ṭuroyo *ka-lé*.

In NENA dialects of the northern sector, the common form of the deictic copula *hole* (3SG.M) has an initial deictic element *ho-* (< **hā-ʾaw* 'look (at) that') in place of a *k-* element. One may compare deictic copulas with the element *ha* in Zazaki, which in the 3SG combine with the enclitic copula *-o*, resulting in the form *ho* (93). The NENA form *hole* may have been originally deictic *ho-* + object L-suffix, but it came to be reanalysed as a merger of *ho* + enclitic copula *ile*, as shown by fuller forms such as *howile*, which are attested in some dialects, e.g., C. Barwar (Khan 2008c: 187). This is likely to have been originally a sentential demonstrative ('there he is'). A close parallel to this is Zazaki sentential demonstratives, which have the form *ha-wo*/*ho=yo* 'there he is' (95). Indeed, the Zazaki construction also resembles the phonetic shape of the NENA form.

The *d-* prefix of the deictic copula in NENA dialects in the eastern sector, e.g., C. Zariwaw *dule* 'here he is' (21), can be compared to the Azeri Turkic "ostensive" particle *dē*, which is discussed in the chapter on demonstrative pronouns (§10.5). The *d-* element in NENA is likely to be a native Aramaic demonstrative element that is matching the Turkic particle in functionally parallel constructions. It is significant that this *d-* element is restricted in NENA to the eastern sector adjacent to the Azeri speach zone.

The *i* stem of the NENA copula is likely to be in origin a third person pronoun (§15.1.1). As remarked, this matches the *n* stem of the Gorani copula, which also appears to be a third person pronoun in origin. A further factor that may have had an impact on the development of the *i* stem is the *ezafe* copula of Behdînî Kurdish (§15.2.3). This has a phonetic resemblance to the *i* stem of the NENA copula, in that it has an initial *y-* element in its independent form (*yê* 3SG.M, *ya* 3SG.F, *yêt* 3PL). This Behdînî copula, moreover, functions as a deictic copula. As discussed above, the inflection of the NENA copula with an L-suffix suggests that the form of the NENA copula that came to be used as an enclitic originated as a deictic copula.

The expression of distinctions in distance in deictic copulas in some NENA dialects, e.g., (21), (20) and (28), has parallels in *Qəltu* Arabic dialects, e.g., (102).

The invariable deictic copulas of the NENA dialects of the south-eastern sector, e.g., *lā* (C. Bədyal, C. Koy Sanjak, J. Arbel, J. Ruwanduz, J. Rustaqa), *nā* (J. Dobe, J. Hiza), *na* (C. Aqra, C. Shaqlawa), *ʾale* (J. Barzan < **hā-le*) are likely to have developed by convergence with the pattern of the deictic copulas of Central Kurdish and Gorani with the stems *ha* and *îna* respectively (§15.2.3). The aforementioned NENA invariable copulas are developments of a form of the NENA copula, in most cases the 3SG.F form *ʾila*. It is significant, however, that the */l/* has shifted

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to */n/* in many cases, which may have arisen by convergence with the phonetic shape of the stem of the Gorani deictic copula *îna*. In Central Kurdish and Gorani, these stems are uninflected in the 3SG, but inflected in other persons. This would match the pattern found in some NENA dialects, e.g. C. Bədyal (30). A further feature of Central Kurdish that may have stimulated the development of invariable copulas in south-eastern NENA dialects is the use of an invariable form of the 3SG enclitic copula *=e* on perfect verbal constructions (67, 68, 70), e.g.,

(146) CK Sulemaniyya
xward-û=m-e
eat.PST.PTCP=1SG:A-PERF
'I have eaten.'

This matches the use of invariable deictic copulas in the perfect in NENA dialects, e.g.,

(147) C. Bədyal
lā xile=wən
DEIC eat.PTCP.SG.M=COP.1SG.M
'I have eaten.'

Sentential demonstratives in NENA, consisting of a demonstrative pronoun and an enclitic copula, have direct parallels in Northern Kurdish, e.g.,

(148) a. NENA C. Qaraqosh
ʾawe=lə
DEIC=COP.3SG.M
'There he is (lit. It is that one over there).'

b. Northern Kurdish Behdînî
ewê-he=ye.
DEIC.3SG.M-DIST=COP.3SG
'There he is.'

Taken together, the comparative evidence indicates that the copular system of NENA has developed through a complex interplay of inherited Aramaic structures and long-term convergence with neighbouring languages. The enclitic copula itself is most plausibly of pronominal origin, but its paradigm has been reshaped in different ways across the NENA area under the influence of Iranian models. The geographical distribution of features such as the convergence with verbal inflection, the mobility of the copula, the formation of deictic copulas,

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and the emergence of invariable deictic forms closely mirrors patterns in the contact languages. The numerous structural parallels discussed in this chapter are too systematic to be accidental and reveal that the NENA copular system constitutes one of the clearest manifestations of the linguistic convergence that characterises the northern Mesopotamian and north-west Iranian contact zone. At the same time, the selective adoption and reinterpretation of these patterns within an inherited Aramaic framework demonstrate the remarkable capacity of NENA dialects to preserve ancient morphosyntactic structures while adapting them creatively to a multilingual environment.

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16 Perfective and perfect

16.1 NENA Past Perfective and Perfect

The perfective past is expressed across NENA dialects by the past verbal stem with person inflections. In most NENA dialects both transitive and intransitive past perfective verbs are inflected with oblique L-suffixes. In a subset of Jewish Trans-Zab dialects on the south-eastern periphery the transitive perfective is inflected with oblique L-suffixes and the intransitive perfective is inflected with direct D-suffixes.

The perfect is constructed in a variety of ways in the various dialects. These include (i) a combination of an inflected copula with a passive resultative participle, (ii) uninflected preverbal particles, (iii) the inflection of the past stem with direct D-suffixes, or (iv) a combination of these various strategies. Furthermore, in some dialects, different strategies are used according to the transitivity of the verb.

16.1.1 Perfect with resultative participle and an inflected copula

16.1.1.1

Perfective (tr. and intr.):	**Past Stem + Oblique L-suffix**
Perfect (tr. and intr.):	**Inflected Deictic Copula + resultative participle**

(1) C. Qaraqosh (Khan 2002a: 340)

Past perfective (tr. and intr.):	*qṭəl-lə* kill.PST-OBL.3SG.M 'He killed.'
Perfect (tr. and intr.):	*k-ilə qṭila* DEIC-COP.3SG.M kill.PTCP.SG.M 'He has killed.'

(2) C. Harbole (Khan, fieldnotes)

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Past perfective (tr. and intr.): *qṭəl-le*
kill.PST-OBL.3SG.M
'He killed.'

Perfect (tr. and intr.): *ho-le qṭila*
DEIC-COP.3SG.M kill.PTCP.SG.M
'He has killed.'

(3) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a: 188)

Past perfective (tr. and intr.): *qṭil-le*
kill.PST-OBL.3SG.M
'He killed.'

Perfect (tr. and intr.): *ho-le qṭila*
DEIC-COP.3SG.M kill.PTCP.SG.M
'He has killed.'

(4) C. Aruntus (Baz) (Khan, fieldnotes)

Past perfective (tr. and intr.): *⁺k̲ṭ̲əl-le*
kill.PST-OBL.3SG.M
'He killed.'

Perfect (tr. and intr.): *do-le ⁺k̲ṭ̲ila*
DEIC-COP.3SG.M kill.PTCP.SG.M
'He has killed.'

Some dialects have distinct proximal and distal deictic copulas, e.g.,

(5) C. Urmi (Khan 2016b: vol. 1, 281)

Past perfective (tr. and intr.): *⁺k̲ṭ̲əl-le*
kill.PST-OBL.3SG.M
'He killed.'

Perfect (tr. and intr.): *du-lə ⁺k̲ṭ̲ila*
DEIC.PROX-COP.3SG.M kill.PTCP.SG.M
'He (here) has killed.'

Perfect (tr. and intr.): *ve-lə ⁺k̲ṭ̲ila*
DEIC.DIST-COP.3SG.M kill.PTCP.SG.M
'He (there) has killed.'

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In most dialects, such inflected deictic copulas are used only when the subject referent is visible in the speech situation. If the subject referent is not visible or if the clause is a question, the non-deictic copula is used. In most dialects, the non-deictic copula that is used in perfects is enclitic on the participles, e.g.,

(6) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a: 660)

a. *hóle ʾəθya.*
DEIC.COP.3SG.M come.PTCP.SG.M
'Look, he has come.'

b. *ʾəθyɛ=le.*
come.PTCP.SG.M=COP.3SG.M
'He has come.'

c. *ʾəθyɛ=le?*
come.PTCP.SG.M=COP.3SG.M
'Has he come?'

In some dialects, the non-deictic copula is an independent copula placed before the participle, e.g.,

(7) J. Betanure (Mutzafi 2008a: 57–58)

a. *wə́lle ʾəθya.*
DEIC.COP.3SG.M come.PTCP.SG.M
'Look, he has come.'

b. *ʾíle ʾəθya.*
COP.3SG.M come.PTCP.SG.M=COP.3SG.M
'He has come.'

In a few dialects, the non-deictic copula is enclitic to the subject argument, e.g.,

(8) J. Amedia (Greenblatt 2011: 104)

a. *wəlle ʾəθya.*
DEIC.COP.3SG.M come.PTCP.SG.M
'Look, he has come.'

b. *báb-ux=ile ʾəθya.*
father-your=COP.3SG.M come.PTCP.SG.M
'Your father has come.'

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In some dialects, what looks like a deictic copula is combined with a perfective *qṭəlle* form. This expresses an event that has occurred in the immediate past on the margin with the present and can be witnessed by the hearer, e.g.,

(9) C. Barwar
hóle *θè-le.*
DEIC.COP.3SG.M come.PST-OBL.3SG.M
'Look he has come back.'

The *hole* in such constructions is more appropriately analysed as a sentential demonstrative ('there he is'), which is another function of the form (see §15.1.1). Indeed, in dialects that formally distinguish sentential demonstratives and deictic copulas, it is the sentential demonstrative form that is used before the perfective form, e.g.,

(10) C. Telkepe (Coghill 2018: 260)
ʾáwa=lə *θè-lə.*
that.M=COP.3SG.M come.PST-OBL.3SG.M
'There he is, he has come.'

16.1.1.2

Perfective (tr. and intr.):	**Past Stem + Oblique L-suffix**
Perfect (tr. and intr.):	**Inflected Non-deictic Copula + resultative participle**

The C. Telkepe dialect uses the independent copula rather than a deictic copula before the participle in assertions and questions, e.g.,

(11) C. Telkepe (Coghill 2018: 258–259)
a. *ʾílə* *ʾə̀θyɒ.*
COP.3SG.M come.PTCP.SG.M
'He has come.'
b. *ʾílə* *ʾə̀θyɒʔ*
COP.3SG.M come.PTCP.SG.M=COP.3SG.M
'Has he come?'

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16.1.1.3

Perfective (tr.):	**Tr. Past Stem + Oblique L-suffix**
Perfective (intr.):	**Intr. Past Stem + Direct Suffix**
Perfect (tr.):	**Tr. resultative participle + Copula**
Perfect (intr.)	**Intr. resultative participle + Copula**

In J. Sanandaj and the adjacent Jewish dialects of the south-eastern periphery of NENA, there are distinct forms of transitive and intranstive past stems and distinctive forms of transive resultative participles and intransitive resultative participles (Khan 2009: 65).

(12) J. Sanandaj (Khan 2009: 74, 90)

Past perfective (tr.):	*qṭəl-le*
	kill.PST-OBL.3SG.M
	'He killed.'
Past perfective (intr.)	*qim-∅*
	rise.PST-3SG.M
	'He rose.'
Perfect (tr.):	*qəṭla=y*
	kill.TR.PTCP=COP.3SG.M
	'He has killed.'
Perfect (intr.)	*qima=y*
	rise.INTR.PTCP=COP.3SG.M
	'He has risen.'

16.1.2 Perfect with a resultative participle and an uninflected particle

16.1.2.1

Perfective (tr. and intr.):	**Past Stem + Oblique L-suffix**
Perfect (tr. and intr.):	**(i) Particle + Resultative participle (third person)**
	(ii) Particle + Resultative participle + Enclitic Copula (first and second persons)

(13) C. Ankawa (Khan, fieldnotes)

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Past perfective (tr. and intr.): *qṭəl-le*
kill.PST-OBL.3SG.M
'He killed.'

Perfect (tr. and intr.): (i) *di-qṭila*
PTCL-kill.PTCP.SG.M
'He has killed.'
(ii) *di-qṭile=wət*
PTCL-kill.PTCP.SG.M=COP.2SG.M
'You (sg.m) have killed.'

(14) C. Bi-Sillem (Baz)/C. Shawwa/C. Ṣāṭ (Khan, fieldnotes)

Past perfective (tr. and intr.): *⁺ḵṭəl-le*
kill.PST-OBL.3SG.M
'He killed.'

Perfect (tr. and intr.): (i) *ha-⁺ḵṭila*
PTCL-kill.PTCP.SG.M
'He has killed.'
(ii) *ha-⁺ḵṭile=wət*
PTCL-kill.PTCP.SG.M=COP.2SG.M
'You (sg.m) have killed.'

(15) C. Bədyal (Khan, fieldnotes)

Past perfective (tr. and intr.): *qṭəl-le*
kill.PST-OBL.3SG.M
'He killed.'

Perfect (tr. and intr.): (i) *lā-qṭila*
PTCL-kill.PTCP.SG.M
'He has killed.'
(ii) *lā-qṭile=wət*
PTCL-kill.PTCP.SG.M=COP.2SG.M
'You (sg.m) have killed.'

(16) C. Armota (Koy Sanjak) (Khan, fieldnotes)

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Past perfective (tr. and intr.):	*qṭəl-le* kill.PST-OBL.3SG.M 'He killed.'
Perfect (tr. and intr.):	(i) *lā-qṭila* PTCL-kill.PTCP.SG.M 'He has killed.'
	(ii) *lā-qṭile=wət* PTCL-kill.PTCP.SG.M=COP.2SG.M 'You (sg.m) have killed.'

The uninflected particle *lā* (C. Bədyal, C. Armota) appears to be a fossilised forms of the 3sg.f copula (*ʾila*, see p.478). The particle *di* in C. Ankawa is likely to be related to similar sounding particles that are used in various NENA dialects to express immediacy, especially in imperatives. These may be related to the temporal adverbial 'now', which has forms such as *daha*, *hadiya*, *diya* across the dialects. The particle *ha*, which is used in various dialects of Hakkari region, is clearly a presentative particle.

In C. Shaqlawa, perfects may be formed by combining the particle *na* with the resultative participle. This particle is likely to be a phonetic variant of *lā*.

(17) C. Shaqlawa (Khan 2022b: 217)

Past perfective (tr. and intr.):	*qṭəl-le* kill.PST-OBL.3SG.M 'He killed.'
Perfect (tr. and intr.):	(i) *na-qṭila* PTCL-kill.PTCP.SG.M 'He has killed.'
	(ii) *na-qṭile=wət* PTCL-kill.PTCP.SG.M=COP.2SG.M 'You (sg.m) have killed.'

The particle *na* in the C. Shaqlawa dialect, however, has the more specific attention-drawing function of what may be termed 'epistemic contrastive focus'. It is used to correct what the speaker assumes the hearer believes or presupposes to be the case (Khan 2022b: 212–223), as seen in (18):

(18) C. Shaqlawa (Khan 2022b: 218)

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a. Speaker 1:
k-ǯb-ən *yaw-ǯn-ox* *ʾixàla.*|
DEIC-WANT.PRS-1SG.M give.PRS-1SG.M-OBL.2SG.M food
'I want to give you food.'

b. Speaker 2:
na-ʾixìle=wən.|
PART-eat.PTCP.SG.M=COP.1SG.M
'I have eaten (contrary to your belief that I have not).'

16.1.2.2

Perfective (tr. and intr.):	**Past Stem + Oblique L-suffix**
Perfect (tr. and intr.):	**Particle + Past Stem + Oblique L-Suffix**

16.1.3 Perfect with a past stem and an uninflected particle

(19) J. Arbel (Khan 1999a: 262–275)

Past perfective (tr. and intr.): *qṭəl-le*
kill.PST-OBL.3SG.M
'He killed.'

Perfect (tr. and intr.): *lā-qṭəl-le*
PTCL-kill.PST-OBL.3SG.M
'He has killed.'

(20) J. Dobe (Khan, fieldnotes)

Past perfective (tr. and intr.): *qṭəl-le*
kill.PST-OBL.3SG.M
'He killed.'

Perfect (tr. and intr.): *nā-qṭəl-le*
PTCL-kill.PST-OBL.3SG.M
'He has killed.'

(21) J. Barzan (Mutzafi 2002a: 59)

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Past perfective (tr. and intr.):	*qṭəl-le* kill.PST-OBL.3SG.M 'He killed.'
Perfect (tr. and intr.):	*ʾale-qṭəl-le* PTCL-kill.PST-OBL.3SG.M 'He has killed.'

(22) C. Sulemaniyya (Khan, fieldnotes)

Past perfective (tr. and intr.):	*qṭəl-le* kill.PST-OBL.3SG.M 'He killed.'
Perfect (tr. and intr.):	*gi-qṭəl-le* PTCL-kill.PST-OBL.3SG.M 'He has killed.'

The particle *lā* (J. Arbel), as remarked, appears to be a fossilised form of the 3sg.f copula *ʾila*. The particle *nā* in J. Dobe is a variant form of this. The particle *ʾale* in J. Barzan is likely to be in origin a presentative particle *ha* + the 3sg.m copula *ile*. The most probably origin of the particle *gi* in C. Sulemaniyya is the deictic particle **kā-*, from which the preverbal *k-* particle is derived, + a truncated form of the copula. This would be, therefore, related to the form of the inflected deictic copula that is found in dialects on the Mosul plain, e.g., C. Qaraqosh *k-ilə*.

16.1.4 Perfect with a past stem inflected by direct suffixes

16.1.4.1

Perfective (tr. and intr.):	**Past Stem + Oblique L-suffix**
Perfect (tr. and intr.):	**Past Stem + Direct D-suffix**

(23) C. Bohtan (Fox 2009: 56–57)

Past perfective (tr. and intr.):	*qṭəl-le* kill.PST-OBL.3SG.M 'He killed.'
Perfect (tr. and intr.):	*qṭīl-∅* kill.PST-3SG.M 'He has killed.'

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(24) C. Hertevin (Jastrow 1988)

Past perfective (tr. and intr.):	*qṭəl-le*
	kill.PST-OBL.3SG.M
	'He killed.'
Perfect (tr. and intr.):	*qṭəl-∅*
	kill.PST-3SG.M
	'He has killed.'

In C. Hertevin the *qṭəl* form in transitive verbs can also express a passive (Jastrow 1988: 58).

In some Jewish Trans-Zab dialects on the north-eastern periphery of NENA, the past stem with direct suffixes is used to express the perfect of intransitive verbs, whereas other constructions are used for the perfect of transitive verbs.

16.1.4.2

Perfective (tr. and intr.):	**Past Stem + Oblique L-suffix**
Perfect (tr.):	**resultative participle + Copula**
Perfect (intr.):	**Past Stem + Direct D-Suffix**

(25) J. Urmi (Khan 2008b: 79–83)

Past perfective (tr. and intr.):	*qṭəl-le*
	kill.PST-OBL.3SG.M
	'He killed.'
Perfect (tr.):	*⁺qtil-e*
	kill.PTCP.SG.M-COP.3SG.M
	'He has killed.'
Perfect (intr.):	*qim-∅*
	rise.PST-3SG.M
	'He has arisen.'

In J. Urmi, the copula in the transitive perfect has become phonetically contracted and bonded to the participle as a stressed affix rather than a clitic, which is the normal prosody of copulas (Khan 2008b: 79-80).

(26) J. Koy Sanjak

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J. Koy Sanjak has the same distribution of forms as J. Urmi, except that the resultative participle + copula construction is used as an alternative to the Past Stem + Direct D-suffix construction in the intransitive perfect (Mutzafi 2004a: 104-105):

Past perfective (tr. and intr.):	*qṭəl-le* kill.PST-OBL.3SG.M 'He killed.'
Perfect (tr.):	*qṭila=le* kill.PTCP.SG.M=COP.3SG.M 'He has killed.'
Perfect (intr.):	(i) *qima=le* rise.PTCP.SG.M=COP.3SG.M (ii) *qim-∅* rise.PST-3SG.M 'He has arisen.'

16.1.4.3

Perfective (tr. and intr.):	**Past Stem + Oblique L-suffix**
Perfect (tr.):	**Particle + Past Stem + Oblique L-Suffix**
Perfect (intr.)	**Particle + Past Stem + Direct Suffix**

(27) J. Rustaqa (Khan 2002b: 403)

Past perfective (tr. and intr.):	*qṭəl-le* kill.PST-OBL.3SG.M 'He killed.'
Perfect (tr.):	*lā-qṭəl-le* PTCL-kill.PST-OBL.3SG.M 'He has killed.'
Perfect (intr.)	*lā-qim-∅* PTCL-rise.PST-3SG.M 'He has risen.'

16.1.4.4

Perfective (tr. and intr.):	**Past Stem + Oblique L-suffix**
Perfect (tr.):	**Resultative participle + Copula**
Perfect (intr.)	**Past Stem + Direct Suffix**

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In some Jewish Trans-Zab dialects, perfects formed from the past stem inflected by D-suffixes are attested only in a subset of verbs with stative lexical aspect. This is the case, for example, in the J. Arbel dialect, in which it is attested only with the verb *p-y-š* 'to remain', e.g.,

(28) J. Arbel (Khan 1999a: 284–285)
piš-Ø
remain.PST-3SG.M
'He has remained.'

16.1.5 Geographical distribution of perfect forms

Perfect constructions combining an inflected copula with a resultative participle are found across a wide range of NENA dialects. They are concentrated, in particular, across the Mosul plain, the northern sector, and on the south-eastern periphery. The use of deictic copulas or preposed non-deictic inflected copulas in the construction is characteristic of dialects in the northern sector.

Perfects formed by preposed uninflected particles are found in mainly dialects of the central sector of NENA in the Arbil and Sulemaniyya provinces. The combination of an uninflected particle with a past-stem inflected verb is found predominantly in Trans-Zab Jewish dialects in Iraq. It is also found in the C. Sulemaniyya dialect and the closely related C. Sanandaj dialect.

The expression of the perfect by past stems inflected by direct D-suffixes is found on the north-western periphery (e.g., C. Bohtan, C. Hertevin) and also in intransitive perfects on the north-eastern periphery of the Jewish Trans-Zab dialect area (e.g., J. Urmi, J. Rustaqa).

16.1.6 Negation of the perfect

16.1.6.1 Perfect with an inflected copula

Perfects that are formed from inflected deictic copulas or preposed non-deictic copulas in the northern sector of NENA are negated by the preposed negative copula, e.g.,

(29) C. Qaraqosh (Khan 2002a)
a. *k-ilə* *qṭila*
DEIC-COP.3SG.M kill.PTCP.SG.M
'He has killed.'

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b. *lelə* *qṭila*
NEG.COP.3SG.M kill.PTCP.SG.M
'He has not killed.'

(30) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a)

a. *hole* *qṭila*
DEIC.COP.3SG.M kill.PTCP.SG.M
'He has killed.'

b. *lɛle* *qṭila*
NEG.COP.3SG.M kill.PTCP.SG.M
'He has not killed.'

(31) J. Betanure (Mutzafi 2008a: 56)

a. *ʾile* *qṭila*
COP.3SG.M kill.PTCP.SG.M
'He has killed.'

b. *lewe* *qṭila*
NEG.COP.3SG.M kill.PTCP.SG.M
'He has not killed.'

In Trans-Zab Jewish dialects that form perfects only with enclitic copulas, the construction is negated by preposing the negative particle *la* and keeping the enclitic copula in place. This can be interpreted as reflecting a greater degree of morphological bonding of the copula to the participle than in dialects that negate the perfect with the negative copula, e.g.,

(32) J. Urmi (Khan 2008b: 85)

a. *+qtil-e*
kill.PTCP-COP.3SG.M
'He has killed.'

b. *la* *+qtil-e*
NEG kill.PTCP-COP.3SG.M
'He has not killed.'

(33) J. Sanandaj (Khan 2009: 97)

a. *qəṭla=y*
kill.TR.PTCP=COP.3SG.M
'He has killed.'

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b. *la qəṭla=y*
NEG kill.TR.PTCP=COP.3SG.M
'He has not killed.'

16.1.6.2 Perfect with an uninflected particle

Perfects formed from uninflected particles exhibit various strategies of negation.

Some dialects that combine an uninflected particle with the a resultative participle replace the particle by an inflected form of the negative copula, e.g.,

(34) C. Ankawa (Khan, fieldnotes)

a. *di-ʾəθya*
PTCL-come.PTCP.SG.M
'He has come.'

b. *di-ʾəθye=wət*
PTCL-come.PTCP.SG.M=COP.2SG.M
'You (sg.m) have come.'

c. *leye ʾəθya*
NEG.COP.3SG.M come.PTCP.SG.M
'He has not come.'

d. *leyət ʾəθya*
NEG.COP.2SG.M come.PTCP.SG.M
'You (sg.m) have not come.'

(35) C. Bədyal (Khan, fieldnotes)

a. *lā xiša*
PTCL go.PTCP.SG.M
'He has gone.'

b. *lā xiše=wət*
PTCL go.PTCP.SG.M=COP.2SG.M
'You (sg.m)have gone.'

c. *liwe xiša*
NEG.COP.3SG.M go.PTCP.SG.M
'He has not gone.'

d. *liwət xiša*
NEG.COP.2SG.M go.PTCP.SG.M
'You (sg.m) have not gone.'

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Some dialects replace the particle by an uninflected truncated form of the negative copula in third person forms and negate with the inflected form of the negative copula in first and second person forms, e.g.,

(36) C. Shawwa (Baz) (Khan, fieldnotes)

a. *ha zila*
PTCL go.PTCP.SG.M
'He has gone.'

b. *ha zile=wut*
PTCL go.PTCP.SG.M=COP.2SG.M
'You (sg.m) have gone.'

c. *lə̆ zila*
NEG.COP go.PTCP.SG.M
'He has not gone.' (full form of negative copula: *lele*)

d. *lə̆wut zila*
NEG.COP.2SG.M go.PTCP.SG.M
'You (sg.m) have not gone.'

(37) C. Armota/Koy Sanjank (Khan, fieldnotes)

a. *lā ʾətya*
PTCL come.PTCP.SG.M
'He has come.'

b. *lā ʾətye=yət*
PTCL come.PTCP.SG.M=COP.2SG.M
'You (sg.m) have come.'

c. *le ʾətya*
NEG.COP go.PTCP.SG.M
'He has not gone.' (full form of negative copula: *leye*)

d. *leyət ʾətya*
NEG.COP.2SG.M come.PTCP.SG.M
'You (sg.m) have not come.'

In the C. Shaqlawa dialect, perfect constructions with the particle *na* are negated by placing the negative copula after the *na*. As remarked above, however, the particle *na* in Shaqlawa has a specific function of expressing contrastive epistemic focus (cf. 18), e.g.,

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(38) C. Shaqlawa (Khan 2022b: 219)

a. *npile=le*
fall.PTCP.SG.M=COP.3SG.M
'He has fallen.'

b. *na lewe npila*
PTCL NEG.COP.3SG.M fall.PTCP.SG.M
'He has not fallen (contrary to your belief).'

In some dialects that form perfects by placing an uninflected copula particle before a past-stem verb, this is negated by placing the negative particle *la* after the copula particle, e.g.,

(39) J. Arbel (Khan 1999a: 115)

a. *lā ʾəlye-le*
PTCL come.PST-OBL.3SG.M
'He has come.'

b. *lā la ʾəlye-le*
PTCL NEG come.PST-OBL.3SG.M
'He has not come..'

(40) J. Dobe (Khan, fieldnotes)

a. *nā ʾəlye-le*
PTCL come.PST-OBL.3SG.M
'He has come.'

b. *nā la ʾəlye-le*
PTCL NEG come.PST-OBL.3SG.M
'He has not come..'

In C. Sulemaniyya and C. Sanandaj, which form the perfect by combining the truncated deictic copula *gi-* with a past-stem verb, this is negated by placing the negator before the *gi-*, e.g.,

(41) C. Sulemaniyya (Khan, fieldnotes)

a. *gi-ʾise-le*
PTCL-come.PST-OBL.3SG.M
'He has come.'

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b. *la gi-ʾise-le*
NEG PTCL-come.PST-OBL.3SG.M
'He has not come.'

Mutzafi Mutzafi (2002a: 60) reports that in the dialect of J. Barzan the perfect formed by combining the uninflected deictic copula *ʾale* with a past-stem verb is restricted to positive clauses. The negative is expressed by a negative copula combined with the resultative participle, e.g.,

(42) J. Barzan (Mutzafi 2002a: 60)

a. *ʾale he-le*
PTCL come.PST-OBL.3SG.M
'He has come.'

b. *lewe hiya.*
NEG.COP.3SG.M come.PPART.SG.M
'He has not come..'

16.1.6.3 Perfect with a past stem inflected by direct suffixes

Perfect constructions formed from past stems with direct suffixes are negated by the negator particle *la*, e.g.,

(43) C. Bohtan (Fox 2002: 56)

a. *riq-Ø*
flee.PST-3SG.M
'He has fled.'

b. *la riq-Ø*
NEG flee.PST-3SG.M
'He has not fled.'

(44) J. Urmi (Khan 2008b: 79–83)

a. *qim-Ø*
rise.PST-3SG.M
'He has risen.'

b. *la qim-Ø*
NEG rise.PST-3SG.M
'He has not risen.'

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In J. Rustaqa, in which intransitive perfects are expressed by the past-stem inflected with direct suffixes and preceded by the particle *lā*, the particle *lā* is omitted when the construction is negated, e.g.,

(45) J. Rustaqa (Khan 2002b: 404)

a. *lā qim-Ø*
PTCL rise.PST-3SG.M
'He has risen.'

b. *la qim-Ø*
NEG rise.PST-3SG.M
'He has not risen.'

16.1.7 Perfect constructions in questions

In many dialects that use deictic copulas in perfect constructions, the deictic copula is replaced by an enclitic copula in questions. The enclitic copula is placed on the participle or on an interrogative constituent, which is a focus in the clause, e.g.,

(46) C. Qaraqosh (Khan 2002a: 341–342)

a. *k-ílə xìla.*|
DEIC-COP.3SG.M eat.PTCP.SG.M
'He has eaten.'

b. *xìle=lə?*|
eat.PTCP.SG.M=COP.3SG.M
'Has he eaten?'

c. *mà=ilə xíla?*|
what=COP.3SG.M eat.PTCP.SG.M
'What has he eaten?'

In some dialects, however, the deictic copula is retained in questions. This is the case, for example, in dialects in the Sapna valley and Aqra region, e.g.,

(47) C. Aqra town (Khan, fieldnotes)

a. *hó-le xìla.*|
DEIC-COP.3SG.M eat.PTCP.SG.M
'He has eaten.'

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b. *hó-le xìla?*|
DEIC-COP.3SG.M eat.PTCP.SG.M
'Has he eaten?'

c. *mà hó-le xíla?*|
what DECI-COP.3SG.M eat.PTCP.SG.M
'What has he eaten?'

In some dialects, however, the deictic copula is retained in questions. This is the case, for example, in dialects in the Sapna valley and Aqra region, e.g.,

In some dialects that form perfects by invariable particles, the particle is omitted in questions, e.g.,

(48) J. Rustaqa (Khan 2002b)

a. *lā-xìl-le.*|
COP-eat.PST-OBL.3SG.M
'He has eaten.'

b. *xìl-le?*|
eat.PST-OBL.3SG.M
'Has he eaten?'

c. *mà xíl-le?*|
what eat.PST-OBL.3SG.M
'What has he eaten?

In some dialects, the invariable particle may be retained in questions, e.g.,

(49) J. Arbel (Khan 1999a: 268)

a. *lā-xìl-le.*|
COP-eat.PST-OBL.3SG.M
'He has eaten.'

b. *lā-xìl-le?*|
COP-eat.PST-OBL.3SG.M
'Has he eaten?'

c. *mà lā-xíl-le?*|
what COP.-eat.PST-OBL.3SG.M
'What has he eaten?

In some dialects, an inflected copula is substituted for an invariable particle in questions, e.g.,

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(50) C. Ankawa (Khan, fieldnotes)

a. *di-šə̀tya.*|
PART-drink.PTCP.SG.M
'He has drunk.'

b. *di-štìθa.*|
PART-drink.PTCP.SG.F
'She has drunk.'

c. *šə̀tye=le?*|
drink.PTCP.SG.M=COP.3SG.M
'Has he drunk?'

d. *štìθe=la?*|
drink.PTCP.SG.F=COP.3SG.F
'Has she drunk?'

e. *mà=ile šə́tya?*|
what=COP.3SG.M drink.PTCP.SG.M
'What has he drunk?

f. *mà=ila štíθa?*|
what=COP.3SG.F drink.PTCP.SG.F
'What has she drunk?

(51) C. Bədyal (Khan, fieldnotes)

a. *lā-šə̀tya.*|
COP-drink.PTCP.SG.M
'He has drunk.'

b. *lā-štìθa.*|
COP-drink.PTCP.SG.F
'She has drunk.'

c. *šə̀tye=le?*|
drink.PTCP.SG.M=COP.3SG.M
'Has he drunk?'

d. *štìθe=la?*|
drink.PTCP.SG.F=COP.3SG.F
'Has she drunk?'

e. *mà=ile šə́tya?*|
what=COP.3SG.M drink.PTCP.SG.M
'What has he drunk?

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f. *mà=ila štíθa?*
what=COP.3SG.F drink.PTCP.SG.F
'What has he drunk?

16.1.8 Agreement patterns of the perfect

In most NENA dialects that have perfect constructions that are formed from a resultative participle and copula the participle and copula agree in number and gender with the subject argument of the clause, both when the verb is transitive and also when it is intransitive, e.g.,

(52) Intransitive: C. Barwar

a. *ʾo-gawṛa qimɛ=le*
DEM.SG.M-man rise.PTCP.SG.M=COP.3SG.M
'The man has risen.'

b. *ʾay-baxta qimtɛ=la*
DEM.SG.F-woman rise.PTCPS.SG.F=COP.3SG.F
'The woman has risen.'

In dialects with such constructions the pronominal direct object of the transitive perfect is expressed by oblique L-suffixes or adnominal dependent suffixes. When there is a definite object argument there is an object agreement pronoun cross-referencing the object:

(53) Transitive: C. Barwar

a. *ʾo-gawṛa xəzyɛ=le=la*
DEM.SG.M-man see.PTCP.SG.M=COP.3SG.M=OBL.3SG.F
'The man has seen her.'

b. *ʾo-gawṛa xəzyɛ=le=la ʾay-baxta*
DEM.SG.M-man see.PTCP.SG.M=COP.3SG.M=OBL.3SG.F DEM.SG.F-woman
'The man has seen the woman.'

c. *ʾay-baxta xzɛθɛ=la=le*
DEM.SG.F see.PTCP.SG.F=COP.3SG.M=OBL.3SG.M
'The woman has seen him.'

d. *ʾay-baxta xzɛθɛ=la=le ʾo-gawṛa*
DEM.SG.F see.PTCP.SG.F=COP.3SG.M=3SG.M DEM.SG.M-man
'The woman has seen the man.'

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In Jewish Trans-Zab dialects on the south-eastern periphery, however, the participle and the copula in transitive clauses agree with the object and not with the subject. This type of agreement only occurs with third person objects. If the object is first or second person, a perfect construction with a past stem is used (Khan 2009: 90-92, 323-326):

(54) J. Sanandaj

a. Intransitive
baxt-ăke *qimta=ya*
woman-DEF rise.PTCP.SG.F=COP.3SG.F
'The woman has risen.'

b. *ʾo-gora* *baxt-ăke* *xita=ya*
DEM.SG.M-man woman-DEF see.PTCP.SG.F=COP.3SG.F
'The man has pulled the woman.'

In transitive perfects in the Jewish Trans-Zab dialect of Sulemaniyya a hybrid type of agreement is found, whereby the participle agrees with the object, but the copula agrees with the subject, e.g.,

(55) J. Sulemaniyya (Khan 2004b: 367)
xzit-aw=ye
see.PTCP.SG.F-3SG.F=COP.3SG.M
'He has seen her.'

In some dialects that form perfect constructions from a past stem, the past stem agrees with the object. In the dialects concerned, the agreement only occurs with the third person objects, e.g.,

(56) J. Arbel (Khan 1999a: 268-217)
lā *xəzy-a-le*
PTCL see.PST-3SG.F-OBL.3SG.M
'He has seen her.'

16.1.9 The function of the NENA past perfective

The NENA past perfective form, which is constructed from the past stem, has a variety of functions. These are illustrated by examples from the C. Urmi dialect.

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16.1.9.1 Recent past events

In conversational discourse a common function of the past perfective form is to express with perfective aspect the occurrence of a time-bound event in the recent past. The margin of the recent past may extend up to the present moment. The form may be used, therefore, when the endpoint of the event is witnessed in the present moment. It is appropriate to translate the form in such contexts by the English perfect of recent past, e.g.

(57) C. Urmi (Khan 2016b: vol.2, 143)
ʰɟór-i tì.lə!|
husband-my come.PST-OBL.3SG.M
'My husband has come! (said when the speaker hears a knock on the door)'

16.1.9.2 Prospective

The temporal proximity to the present of the event expressed by the perfective form is exploited in some cases as a pragmatic strategy to express a prospective function, i.e., an event that is about to happen in the near future, e.g.,

(58) C. Urmi (Khan 2016b: vol.2, 145)
ʾána xə̀š-li.|
I go.PST-OBL.1SG
'I am about to go.'

16.1.9.3 Past narratives

Past perfective forms are used in narratives to narrate a sequence of time-bound events in the past, e.g.,

(59) C. Urmi (Khan 2016b: vol. 2, 148)
ʰtuk̰tə̀k̰-lun| *ʾu-ʰplə̀t̰-li.*| ʾ
know.PST-OBL.3PL and-go.out.PST-OBL.1SG
'They knocked (on the door) and I went out.'

16.1.9.4 Conditional

The past perfect form is used in conditional constructions to express a possible event in the future that is temporally and/or logically anterior to the situation described in the apodosis, e.g.,

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(60) C. Urmi (Khan 2016b: vol. 2, 149)
ʾən-⁺msì-li, | *⁺ʾàv bət-yavvál-la* *ḵát-i.* |
if-can.PST-OBL.1SG he FUT-give.PRS.3SG.M-OBL.3SG.F to-1SG
'If I can (do this), he will give it (f) to me.'

16.1.10 The function of the NENA perfect

Perfect forms in NENA have a variety of functions. In what follows, examples of these are presented mainly from the C. Urmi dialect, in which the perfect is expressed by a participle and copula. Other dialects will be referred to where appropriate. A common denominator of all these functions is that the event associated with the situation expressed by the perfect is in some way cognitively defocalised. For a more detailed treatment, see Khan (2020c).

16.1.10.1 Resultant state

The perfect may be used to express a resultant state. Strictly this applies only to telic verbs whose participles express a durable changed configurational stative property of the subject referent of the clause, e.g.,

(61) C. Urmi
mìtə=lə.|
die.PTCP=COP.3SG.M
'He has died/he is dead.'

A stative usage of the perfect is common in verbs expressing posture, e.g.,

(62) C. Urmi
tìvə=lə|
sit.PTCP=COP.3SG.M
'He is sitting'

16.1.10.2 Anterior

If the participle of a verb does not express a durable changed property of the subject, the perfect does not strictly express a resultant state of the subject but rather a resulting situation in a wider sense. This may be termed an 'anterior' function, in that it implies the occurrence of an event in the past relative to the reference point in the present, e.g.,

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(63) C. Urmi
Yósəp plíxə=lə ḳə̀šya.
Yosəp work.PTCP=COP.3SG.M hard
'Yosəp has worked hard.'

If the speaker witnessed Yosəp enter the house, as he sees him enter he would use the perfective form when speaking to an interlocutor:

(64) C. Urmi
tí-lə Yòsəp.
come.PST-OBL.3SG.M Yosəp
'Yosəp has come.'

16.1.10.3 Existential

The perfect may be used with an existential function (Dahl 1985: 139–140; Kiparsky 2002: 116; Portner 2003: 464) in contexts such as the following:

(65) C. Urmi
ʾána ⁺xíl=əvən ⁺šùrva.
I eat.PTCP=1SG.M stew
'I have eaten stew (on one or more unspecified occasion in an interval in the past extending to the recent past).'

Here the speaker does not assert the existence of a current situation that is the result of a specific event in the past. Rather what is asserted is the attribution of a more diffuse experiential property to the subject of the clause with the implicature that this was the result of at least one unspecified event of eating stew at an unspecified time in the past.

16.1.10.4 Evidential

A perfect may be used with an evidential function (Aikhenvald 2004) to express an event that the speaker has not directly witnessed, but acquires knowledge of only by indirect evidence such as a report, or inference. In such cases the perfect presents the event with perfective aspect, with a specific event time, which may be expressed by a temporal adverbial that is a component of a received report or inference. The event, however, is cognitively defocalised in the mind of the speaker due to this lack of direct witnessing. I shall refer to such perfective uses

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of the perfect as indirect perfectives, which contrast with regular direct perfectives,[1] e.g.,

(66) C. Urmi

a. *⁺xór-i ⁺mṭ́í-lə ḳ́ám xámša dàyḳ́ə.*|
friend-my arrive.PST-OBL.3SG.M before five minutes
'My friend arrived five minutes ago.'

b. *márə=lə ḳ́at-⁺xór-u ⁺mə́ṭ́yə=lə ḳ́ám xámša dàyḳ́ə,*| *ʾáxči ʾána lə̀n xə́zy-u.*|
say.PROG=3SG.M that-friend-his arrive.PTCP=COP.3SG.M before five minutes but I NEG.COP.1SG.M see.PTCP.SG.M-3SG.M
'He says that his friend arrived five minutes ago, but I have not seen him (i.e., I have not witnessed the arrival of his friend).'

In (66a) the speaker witnessed the event of the arrival of the friend and uses the direct perfective form. In (66b) the speaker has only heard a report about this event and the indirect perfective (perfect) is used.

(67) C. Urmi (Khan 2016b: vol. 4, 8)
lá b-⁺xábrət dìyyan| *xə́š-la ⁺ʾal-mèša,*| *⁺tàma,*| *ʾu-díva ⁺xìl-o=lə.*|
NEG by-word.of ours go.PST-OBL.3SG.F to-forest there and-wolf eat.PTCP-3SG.F=COP.3SG.M
'She went to the forest without our permission and there a wolf ate her.'

In (67) the speaker reports the death of a woman. The act of her going to the forest is expressed in the direct perfective form (*xəšla*), since he witnessed this. The act of the wolf eating her, however, is expressed by the indirect perfective (perfect) form (*⁺xilolə*), since he did not witness this event, nor did he witness the direct result. In the story he is shown the bloody garment of the woman. From this he infers that a wolf ate her. Both verbs express a specific event with perfective aspect, bound to a specific event time.

16.1.10.5 Presuppositional

A perfect may be used as an indirect perfective to express a specific event with a specific event time when the event is cognitively defocalised on the information

[1]The term 'indirect perfective' is inspired by Johanson (1996, 2000, 2003), who uses the term 'indirective' for such constructions in Turkic languages.

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structure level due to its being in a presuppositional component of the clause. An example of this is the following. Speaker A is expecting the arrival of his friend Yosəp at the airport. Speaker B goes to the airport to meet Yosəp. When Yosəp arrives, speaker B immediately phones speaker A and reports the arrival with a direct perfective form (68):

(68) C. Urmi
⁺mṭì-lə *Yósəp.*|
arrive.PST-OBL.3SG.M Yosəp
'Yosəp has arrived.'

Speaker A may then ask using an indirect perfective (perfect) (69):

(69) C. Urmi
ʾìman ⁺mə́ṭyə=lə?|
when arrive.PTCP=COP.3SG.M
'When did he arrive?'

In (69) the event of Yosəp arriving at a particular time is part of the presuppositional common ground between the interlocutors and the focus is on the question word, which requests information about the specific time of arrival.

Also of relevance in this section is the distinction between the negation of the perfective and perfect. If a person is waiting for Yosəp but he does not come, he may say to his interlocutors either (70a) or (70b):

(70) C. Urmi

a. *lá* *tì-lə.*|
NEG come.PST-OBL.3SG.M
'He has not come.'

b. *lèlə* *tíyya.*|
NEG.COP.3SG.M come.PTCP.SG.M
'He has not come.'

The negation of the perfective (70a) is used if the speakers wishes the scope of the negation to include the specific event and its event time, expressing the fact that he did not come at the time expected and there is no implicature that he will come later. When the negative perfect construction (70b) is used, on the other hand, the scope of the negation does not include a specific event and its event time but only the speech time ('he has not currently come'), so there is a

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presupposition that he will come. The scope of what is explicitly negated corresponds to what Huddleston & Pullum (2002: 790-799) refer to as the'focus of negation'. We may say, therefore, that the lexical verb of the perfect is defocalised and presuppositional.

16.1.10.6 Remote past

A further function of the perfect is its use to express an event in the remote past. Such past events are presented with perfective aspect with a specific event time, and so should be referred to as indirect perfectives. In such cases, the event may have been witnessed by the speaker, but he/she is separated from it by a long interval of time. The construction may be used, therefore, by speakers to talk in the first person about events that they were involved in. In these uses of the perfect to express the remote past the event may be said to be defocalised due to its distance from present reality. In the framework of mental spaces such as is proposed by Fauconnier (1994) and Dinsmore (1991), one may say that the remote indirect perfective construes the event as occurring in a separate mental space from that of the present and recent past. The reference time of the constructions is the present, which is reflected by the present copula in the morphology of the perfect. This is not necessarily the real present but in narrative it is often the virtual present of the narrator within the world of the narration.

An example from the J. Sulemaniyya dialect is (71). Here the perfect form *mila=y* is used to express the temporal remoteness of the death of one of the brothers in contrast to the more recent death of the other brother, which is expressed by the normal narrative perfective form *mil*:

(71) J. Sulemaniyya (Khan 2004b: 317)
ʾó tre ʾaxóne ruwwè| mìl-i.| xáy-u qáme tre šə́nne
those two brothers big die.PST-3PL one-of.them before two years
mìl-Ø| Mòše.| ʾavál ʾó-xa-xèt| qáme xamšàsar šə́nne
die.PST-3SG.M Moše but that-one-other before fifteen years
bi-zóda milà=y.|
more-increase die.PTCP=COP.3SG.M
'The two older brothers died. One of them, Moše, died two years ago, but the other one died more than fifteen years ago.'

In some NENA dialects, it is common to narrate stories using the perfect. This can be identified as the usage of the indirect perfective perfect to denote the remote past. Such a practice is particularly common in fictitious folktales, and so

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the events are not only distant temporally but also distant epistemically due to their taking place in a fantasy world. As remarked above, however, the present copula makes them prominent for the narrator since it places the reference time at speech time, e.g.,

(72) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a: 669)
qìme=la | *b-lèle* | *ṭrípə=l=la* *Zìne* |
rise.PTCP.PL=COP.3PL at-night seize.PTCP.PL=COP.PL=OBL.3SG.F Zine
ʾu-mùθyə=l=la, | *núblə=l=la*
and-bring.PTCP.PL=COP.3PL=OBL.3SG.F take.PTCP.PL=COP.3PL=OBL.3SG.F
kəs-Mămo. | *núblə=l=la* *kəs-Mămo.* |
to-Mămo take.PTCP.PL=COP.3PL=OBL.3SG.F to-Mămo
dmìxe=la. | *ṛištɛ=la,* |
sleep.PTCP.PL=COP.3PL wake.PTCP.SG.F=COP.3SG.F
zìptə=lle=la | *ṭla-Mămo.* |
push.PTCP.SG.F=OBL.3SG.M=COP.3SG.F OM-Mămo
'At night they went [perfect] and seized [perfect] Zine and brought her [perfect], they took her [perfect] to Mămo. They took her [perfect] to Mămo. They slept [perfect]. She woke up [perfect] and pushed [perfect] Mămo (out of bed).'

In many NENA dialects, the perfect that expresses the remote past is neutral with regard to aspect. It is generally used, as in the examples cited above, to express perfectively a specific event in the remote past, but it may also be used to express habitual activities in the remote past. An example of a habitual activity expressed by the perfect in the C. Urmi dialect is the following:

(73) C. Urmi (Khan 2016b: vol. 2, 176)
ʾína b-x̌ámtət *x̌ámta=da* *hár* *⁺ʾal-ɟaravày dmíxə=na*
but in-before.of before=ADD only on-roofs sleep.PTCP.PL=COP.3PL
⁺x̌eṭa. |
summer.
'But long ago they used to sleep only on roofs during the summer.'

16.2 Perfective and perfect in Kurdish

16.2.1 Past Perfective

The past perfective across Kurdic is expressed by the past stem of the verb and appropriate bound person markers. In Kurdic varieties that have retained tense-

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sensitive alignment, verbal person/number suffixes express S and the clitic pronouns (in CK and Gorani) or the oblique nominals (in NK and Zazaki) express the transitive agent; see Table 16.1 for sample paradigms.

Table 16.1: The past perfective/preterite–sample paradigms

	'fall'		'take'	
NK	*ket-im* [fall.PST-1SG:S]	'I fell'	*min bir* [1SG.OBL took]	'I took (it).'
Zaz.	*kewt-a* [fall.PST-1SG:S]	'I fell'	*mi berd* [1SG.OBL took]	'I took (it).'
CK	*kewt-im* [fall.PST-1SG:S]	'I fell'	*bird=im* [took=1SG:A]	'I took (it).'
Hewr.	*kewt-a* [fall.PST-1SG:S]	'I fell'	*berd=im* [took=1SG:A]	'I took (it).'
SK	*keft-im* [fall.PST-1SG:S]	'I fell'	*bird-im* [took-1SG:A]	'I took (it).'

In varieties that have retained the tense-sensitive alignment, O is expressed by verbal person/number suffixes. This is the case with conservative varieties of NK, Zazaki, Central and northern varieties of CK, and Hewramî. In SK and neighbouring Southern varieties of CK, O is expressed by clitic pronouns (see Table 16.2).

Table 16.2: The past perfective/preterite–sample paradigms

NK	*min tu bir-î*	[1SG.OBL 2SG.DIR take.PST-2SG:O]	'I took you'
Zaz.	*min ti berd-î*	[1SG.OBL 2SG.DIR take.PST-2SG:O]	'I took you'
NCK	*bird=m-î*	[take.PST=1SG:A-2SG:O]	'I took you'
Hewr.	*berd-î=m*	[take.PST-2SG:O=1SG:A]	'I took you'
SCK	*bird=t=im*	[take.PST=2SG:O=1SG:A]	'I took you'
SK	*bird-im=ad*	[take.PST-1SG:A=2SG:O]	'I took you'

The past perfective expresse several function. One common use is expressing time-bounded events at a particular point in the past.

(74) CK Mukri (Öpengin 2016: 46)
jin-e *şam=î* *saz* *kird*
woman-DEF dinner=3SG:A compose do.PST
'The woman prepared the dinner.'

The past perfective may express an extended period of time in the past. In this usage, the starting point of the action and its end point both occur in the past

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time, but the action lasts a long time. In (75), 'raising children' would have lasted several years.

(75) Hewramî (Mohammadirad 2026: 297)
pase *zawlê=şa* *wey* *kerd-ê*
like_this child.PL.DIR=3PL:A raising do.PST-3PL:O
'They raised children in this way.'

The past perfective is also used for the expression of a time-bound event in the immediate past, corresponding to the English perfect of recent past/hot news perfect. In the following example, the narrator witnesses a guest coming through the door and asks whether the recording should continue.

(76) Hewramî (Mohammadirad forthcoming)
dey *ane=yç* ***ama-Ø*** *mêman=a*
DISC.PTCL DEM.DIST.3SG.DIR.M=ADD come.PST-3SG:S guest=COP.3SG:S
çêş *kér-mê*
what do.PRS.SBJV-1SG:A
'Oh, he has arrived. He is guest. What should we do? [Should we keep recording?]' [HR.59]

16.2.2 Perfect

There are mainly two strategies of expressing the perfect in Kurdish. MacKenzie (1961a: 187-189) named these as Perfect Indicative I and II.

16.2.2.1 Perfect Indicative I: Resultative participle + Copular endings

This is formed by the combination of copular person endings with the past participle of the verb.

(77) *min* *tirşik xwar-î=ye*
1SG.OBL stew eat.PST-PTCP=COP.3SG
'I have eaten stew.'

This verb form (i.e., Perfect Indicative I) is used, with slight formal variations, in all Central Kurdish dialects and all Northern Kurdish dialects except in the affirmative clauses in Behdînî (see below).

In Central Kurdish, with intransitive verbs the copular person endings agree with the subject (78), whereas with transitive verbs an invariant and non-agreeing 3SG *=e* ending is used (79).

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(78) Central Kurdish (for full paradigms see Öpengin 2016: 67)

a. *min hat-û=m*
1SG come.PST-PTCP=COP.1SG
'I have come.'

b. *ême hat-û=yn*
WE come.PST-PTCP=COP.1PL
'We have come.'

(79) a. *min kut-û=m=e*
1SG say.PST-PTCP=1SG=COP.3SG
'I have said.'

b. *ême kut-û=man=e*
1PL say.PST-PTCP=1PL=COP.3SG
'We have said.'

Although there can be number agreement with the copula, this is usually not the case in the majority of dialects, as the comparison of the sentences in (80) show:

(80) a. *kitêb-eke=m froşt-ûw=e*
book-DEF=1SG sell.PST-PTCP=COP.3SG
'I have sold the book.'

b. *kitêb-ek-an=it froşt-ûw=e*
book-DEF-PL=2SG sell.PST-PTCP-COP.3SG
'You have sold the books.'

In Northern Kurdish, however, the copular endings agree with the subject and object, both with intransitive (81) and transitive clauses (82). Note that in most Northern Kurdish dialects (with the exception of some Behdînî dialects), the participle suffix *-î* is centralised to an *-i* when it is part of the perfect verb form.

(81) a. *ez hat-i=me*
1SG.DIR come.PST-PTCP=COP.1SG
'I have come'

b. *em hat-i=ne*
1PL.DIR come.PST-PTCP=COP.1PL
'We have come'

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(82) a. *min got-i=ye*
1SG.OBL say.PST-PTCP=COP.3SG
'I have said (that).'

b. *min ew ne-dît-i=ne*
1SG.OBL DEM(.PL).DIR NEG.see.PST-PTCP=COP.3PL:O
'I have not seen them.'

Thus, while the intransitive constructions are identical in both NK and CK, the transitive constructions differ in that copular ending used in the formation of perfect verb forms in CK is a non-agreeing fossilised form while in NK the full paradigm of copular endings are operational and mark the agreement with the object. This is in line with the loss of ergativity in CK. In some conservative CK dialects, when the object is salient(animate), there is sometimes number (but not person) agreement (Öpengin 2013a: 252–254).

A further point of variation in this perfect construction concerns the Zakho dialect of Northern Kurdish (83) and the Qorva transition dialect of Central Kurdish. In both of these dialects, the participle suffix is either omitted or absent.

(83) a. *te boçî xezal-a min kuşt=e?*
2SG.OBL why gazelle-EZ.SG.F my kill.PST=COP.3SG
'Why have you killed my gazelle?' (MacKenzie 1962: 349)

b. *kesê ev qese ne-got=e min*
person DEM.PROX.SG.DIR saying NEG-say.PST=COP.3SG 1SG.OBL
'Nobody has (ever) said such a thing to me.' (MacKenzie 1962: 354)

Note that in Zakho dialect, this verb form (i.e., Perfect Indicative I) is used only with interrogative and negative clauses. Clearly, the dialect does have the regular NK participial verb form, such as *kuşt-î* 'killed', which appears in other constructions such as *mirovê kuştî* 'the killed man, the man who was killed'. The verb form with copular ending being attached to the bare past stem is probably the result of a phonologically conditioned lenition of the participial suffix.

16.2.2.2 Perfect Indicative II: Demonstrative *ezafe* + Past participle

In this construction, a preverbal demonstrative (or pronominal) *ezafe* (*yê*, *ya*, *yêt* and their enclitic forms *=ê =a =êt*) is used with the past participle form of the verb, with no further copular endings. That is, the copular endings used with the Perfect Indicative I as enclitics to the participle verb forms are suppressed in this construction. Instead, the demonstrative forms of *ezafe* are used in conjunction with the participle verb form.

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(84) a. *ez=ê hat-î=m bo mesel-ek-a hutuwe*
1SG.DIR=EZ.M come.PST-PTCP=COP.1SG:S for matter-INDF-EZ.F such
'I have come for such a matter.' (MacKenzie 1961a: 270)

b. *min şîv=a lê-na-y*
1SG.DIR dinner=EZ.F cook.PST-PTCP
'I have prepared supper.' (MacKenzie 1961a)

This construction is used normally only with affirmative clauses, and not in interrogative and negatives. As the clauses in (85) show, the question (85a) is formulated in the Perfect Indicative I form while its declarative response (85b) is in the Perfect Indicative II form.

(85) a. *ev mêz-e kê çê-kir-î=ye?*
DEM.PROX.SG.DIR table-DEM who PV-make.PST-PTCP=COP.3SG
'Who has made this table? (...)

b. *necar-î ya çê kir-î*
carpenter-OBL EZ.F well make.PST-PTCP
'The carpenter has made it.' (MacKenzie 1961a: 210)

The *ezafe* forms express the gender and number features of the subject in intransitive clauses (85a) and of the object in transitive clauses, even when the host noun immediately preceding them does not have these respective functions. In (84b) the feminine singular form of the demonstrative *ezafe* is controlled by the overt object *şîv* 'dinner'; while in (85b), the demonstrative/pronominal *ezafe* carries the gender and number features of the object of the clause, although the latter is only covert in the clause. In (86) the plural object conditions the use of the plural *ezafe*.

(86) *me çêçik vêkra yêt kir-î=n*
1PL.OBL cub together EZ.PL make.PST-PTCP=COP.3PL:O
'We have given birth to cubs together.'

There are two important dimensions of dialectal variation in this construction. First, Duhok-Akre-Hakkari dialects tend to mark additionally the person agreement on the verb (cf. 87, 88) while the more eastern Shamdinan-Barzan dialects do not mark any sort of agreement on the verb:

(87) Akre (with verb agreement)
ez=ê nivist-î=m
1SG.DIR=EZ.M sleep.PST-PTCP=COP.1SG:S
'I have slept.'

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(88) Shamdinan (without verb agreement)
ez=ê *nivist-î*
1SG.DIR=EZ.M sleep.PST-PTCP
'I have slept.'

Secondly, although Shamdinan and similar eastern dialects are consistent in using the distinct plural *ezafe*, the other dialects (Akre, Duhok, Hakkari) are inconsistent in marking the plural *ezafe* when the controller noun phrase is plural. Thus although (86) has the expected plural agreement, (89), likewise with a plural controller noun phrase, has the masculine singular *yê*. The Shamdinan dialect strictly requires the plural *ezafe* in this construction (90).

(89) Akre
direng yê *derket-î=n*
late EZ.M exit.PST-PTCP=COP.3PL:S
'They have set out late.' (MacKenzie 1961a: 362)

(90) Shamdinan
direng yêt *derket-î*
late EZ.PL exit.PST-PTCP
'They have set out late.'

The inconsistency here may be related to verb agreement patterns in the various dialects. The Shamdinan dialect with no verb agreement is systematic in using the plural *ezafe*, whereas the Akre, Duhok, and Hakkari dialects with robust verb agreement tend to use the plural *ezafe* inconsistently. This may reflect a transitional stage in the Akre, Duhok, and Hakkari dialects dialects, where double-marking of plural number (i.e., on the *ezafe* and the verb) is being simplified such that there is one marking of plurality, though, unlike the Shamdinan dialect, by keeping the verb agreement as opposed to the distinct plural *ezafe*.

Finally, there is trace of a similar perfect construction in the Tor dialects of Northern Kurdish. In the Yezidi dialect of Tor, a non-agreeing form *(w)î* (visibly related to the masculine singular *ezafe* of NK) is used with the resultative participle form of the verb (91). The construction is different from the Behdînî perfect (Perfect Indicative II) in two crucial respects: the copular endings are retained in the verb form, and the copular endings agree with the subject and not with the object (thus in opposition to the ergativity requirements of NK).

(91) Yezidi Tor (Mardin)

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pîrek-ê *wan* *î* *hirç* *kuşt-i=ne*
wife-EZ.PL their PTCL bear kill.PST-PTCP=COP.3PL
'Their wives have (actually) killed the bear.' (Bailey 2005: 119)

Bailey (2005) does not provide any examples of intransitive clauses, but she reports that the use of the particle indicates speaker certainty, and accordingly in the absence of such certainty the particle is not used (92).

(92) Yezidi Tor (Mardin)
belkî *wan* *kahrik* *xwar-i=ye*
maybe they kid goat eat.PST-PTCP=COP.3SG
'Maybe they have eaten the kid goat.' (Bailey 2005: 119)

Sahin (2018) presents more data from the Muslim Tor dialect of NK. Here we see that there are distinct *ezafe* forms for gender and number, *wê/ê* for masculine singular, *a* for feminine singular, and *î* for plural. Furthermore, as the examples in (93) show, the *ezafe* particles carry the gender and number features of the subject in intransitive clauses (93a) and those of the object in transitive clauses (93b)–(93c). Finally, the copular personal endings are used on the verb when the controller of the agreement is other than 3SG (cf. 93a vs. 93c). The absence of copular agreement with a 3SG controller, however, may be due to some phonological processes between the participle vowel *-î* and the 3SG copular ending *-e*.

(93) Muslim Tor (Mardin)

a. *ew* *jî* *wê* *ji* *sûrî* *hat-î* *vir*
3SG(.M).DIR also EZ.M from syria come.PST-PTCP here
'He has come here from Syria.' (Sahin 2018: 44)

b. *kurk-ê* *me* *piçek* *ʿerebe* *a* *kir-î*
son-EZ.M our some car EZ.F buy.PST-PTCP
'Our son has bought a little car.'

c. *ga* *(…)* *kew* *î* *kirî=ne*
that partridge EZ.PL buy.PST.PTCP=COP.3PL:O
'He has bought partridges (for five hundred liras).'

According to Sahin (2018: 44), this present perfect construction only occurs with affirmative clauses and no clear semantic and pragmatic factors are observed in its use.

In comparison to the Behdînî *ezafe* perfect construction (Perfect Indicative II), the only clear formal difference here concerns the use of copular personal endings on the verb, such that while in Tor they are used (albeit not in the 3SG), in

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Behdînî copular endings are mutually exclusive with the use of the demonstrative *ezafe*. In terms of function, the pragmatic underspecification found in the Yezidi Tor dialect is not a feature of the constructions in Muslim Tor and Behdînî. The *ezafe* perfect construction is comparatively rare in the Tor dialect, while in Behdînî it is usually the only option available when the clause is affirmative declarative. It is thus safe to conclude that the present perfect construction that incorporates *ezafe* particles is a retention shared by the source variety of both the Behdînî and Tor dialects, rather than being a distinct innovation.

16.2.2.3 Historical evolution

The only study dealing with the evolution of the Perfect II construction (with *ezafe* forms being part of the verbal form) is Haig (2011). He claims that the construction must have developed from a cleft construction, in which the *ezafe* would have had the function of a relative particle. The original meaning of *ez-ê nivist-î-m* 'I have slept' (87), therefore, would have been 'It is I that is one who has slept.' It is indeed very likely that the source construction was a relative clause, but one with a demonstrative pronoun head. The source construction would be *ez ew yê nivist-î* 'I (am) one who has slept.' And it would then have passed through an intermediary stage in which the demonstrative and relativiser *ezafe* coalesced. These stages are illustrated in (94):

(94) Evolution of the demonstrative *ezafe* present perfect tense construction

a. **ez ew yê nivist-î*
1SG.DIR DEM.3SG EZ.SG.M.REL sleep.PST-PTCP

b. **ez ew=ê nivist-î(=m)*
1SG.DIR DEM=EZ.SG.M.REL sleep.PST-PTCP(=COP.1SG:S)

c. *ez yê nivist-î(=m)*
1SG.DIR EZ.M sleep.PST-PTCP(=COP.1SG:S)

In this scenario, with the grammaticalisation of the combination of the demonstrative pronoun (which is also the anaphoric 3SG pronoun) with *ezafe* (e.g., *ew yê*) to mark a cleft type relativiser, the combination was reduced to *ezafe* forms (e.g., *ew yê* > *ew=ê* > *wê/yê*). The traces of the demonstrative base, however, are still visible in the forms of the *ezafe* in various dialects that retain the bilabial sound *w*, as for instance *wê* for masculine singular. This is, indeed, the case in all of the Behdînî dialects, for which MacKenzie (1961a: 162) lists the three *ezafe* inflections both with *y* and *w*, as: *yê/wê* (SG.M), *ya/wa* (SG.F), *yêt/wêt* (PL), for singular masculine and feminine, and, plural respectively. The example (93) is an

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example of this from the Tor dialect, while the sentences (95) and (96) are further illustrations of this variant form in the Behdînî dialects.

(95) Zakho (MacKenzie 1962: 356)
ev pir-a henê ji ber-êt birrî wê hat-î avakirin
this bridge-EZ.F yonder from stone-EZ.PL dressed EZ.M come.PST-PTCP build
'This bridge has been built of dressed stones.'

(96) Shamdinan (fieldnotes)
inşa'ellah aqildar-ê me tiştekî çak wê hizr kir-î
god.willing wise-of our something good EZ.M thought do.PST-PTCP
'God willing, our wise man has planned something good.'

Finally, a more archaic and less used relativiser in the Mukri dialect of CK has a relativiser based on the demonstrative with the form *ewî* (97), which has in all likelihood developed from the combination of the demonstrative base with the *ezafe* forms.

(97) Mukri CK (Öpengin 2016: 104)
brā-eke=m ewī le dē-ye
brother-DEF=1SG REL in village-COP.3SG:S
'my brother who is in the village'

Although the form is analyzed as the oblique form of the demonstrative in the source (Öpengin 2016), it is actually more likely to be a combination of the demonstrative with *ezafe*, since the combination of demonstratives with *ezafe* is a common strategy to form a particular type of relative clauses (i.e., correlatives) throughout Kurdish, both CK and NK, as illustrated in (98):

(98) Mukri CK (Öpengin 2016: 104)
ewe-y tema'=it tê kird-ûw=e
dem-EZ greed=2SG in do.PST-PTCP=COP.3SG
'the one to whom you have shown greed'

16.2.2.4 Functions of perfect

The perfect in Kurdish is mainly used for expressing a past event with relevance to the present situation, like the English anterior perfect (cf. 77). It is also commonly used for expressing stative verbs such as 'to be seated', 'to be standing.' It

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is commonly used also for expressing evidentiality, where the source of information is a report or inference.

The perfect in Kurdish is not normally used as a narrative form to express perfective events in remote cognitive space or remote past in stories. As the following text excerpt shows (99), narratives relating to the remote past are typically expressed by the past indicative (i.e., past perfective).

(99) Akre (MacKenzie 1962)
neql-ek-ê hakim-ek-î sê kur he-bû-n.
time-INDF-OBL.F governor-INDF-OBL.M three son exist-BE.PST-3PL:S
roj-ek-ê kur-êt wî ra-bû-n, çû-n=e
day-INDF-OBL.F son-EZ.PL 3SG.OBL PVB-be.PST-3PL:S go.PST-3PL:S=DRCT
aş-î. ker-ê wa berze bû. (…)
mill-M.SG.OBL donkey-EZ.M 3PL.OBL lost be.PST.3SG:S
'Once a Prince had three sons. One day his sons got up and went to the mill. Their donkey got lost.'

The narration of historical events by elder members of the community is likewise not expressed by the perfect but rather by the past perfetive indicative. The following excerpt is part of an account of local history. The speaker, who was at the time of recording 80 years old, initially clarifies his source of the account as his father, who told it to a crowded audience when the speaker was only eleven years old. The account is about an event that took place in the speaker's home region almost a century before he was born. Despite the extensive time distance and the speaker's source being another narrator, the account is expressed by the past perfective with shifts to the present form, but not by the perfect:

(100) Hakkari NK (fieldnotes)

a. *Melk-ê Tîyarê çû dîwan-a Merşûmîn got=ê*
Malik-of Tiari go.PST courtroom-of PN say.PST=3SG:R
'The Malik of Tiari went to the audience hall of Mar Shimun. (...) He said to him,'

b. *Marşûmîn got, ez dê cab-a melk-ê Tuxûbê rêke-m (…)*
PN say.PST I will call-of Malik-of Tkhuma send-1SG:A
'Mar Shimun said, "I will summon Malik of Tkhum." (...)'

c. *Melik Keje jî deh panzde zelam-an ve çû Koçanisê,*
Malik Kaja too ten fifteen man-PL.OBL with go.PST PN

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rûkarî *êk* *bûn,* *pêk-ne-hat-in*
face-to-face each-other be.PST-3PL:S PVB-NEG-come.PST-3PL:S
'Malik Kaja (i.e., the Malik of Tkhuma) went to Kochanis with ten-fifteen henchmen, they confronted each other, (but) they did not come to an agreement.'

In some stories and anecdotes relating to the remote past (but not in folktales), especially stories of family origins and anecdotes about saints where the source of information is of necessity a report, the events are narrated in the perfect. In the text excerpt below, the narrator is a descendant of the family, and he is relating the history of the family as he has heard it from the elder generation:

(101) Diyana NK (fieldnotes)
li *Beẍda* *em-êt* *hat-î=ye* *Loṛistan-ê*
from Baghdad 1PL-EZ.PL come.PST-PTCP=COP.3SG:S Luristan-F.SG.OBL
'(As far as we know of our family history) we (i.e., the family) went (lit. came) from Baghdad to Loristan.'

Likewise, in the anecdote about a local saint below, the narrator uses the perfect in the narration, indicating that the narrator is relating what he has heard from others about the saint:

(102) Shamdinan NK (fieldnotes)
a. *Pîr* *ʿEbûbekir yê* *çû-y=e* *Basya (…)*
Saint Abubakr EZ.M go.PST-PTCP=COP.3SG:S PN
'Saint Abubakr went (lit. has gone) to Basyan.'
b. *Pîr* *ʿebûbekir wê* *gût-î=yê* *(…)*
Saint Abubakr EZ.M say.PST-PTCP-3SG:R
'Saint Abubakr told (lit. has told) them.'

Certain events in the past are narrated in the perfect when the narrator is separated from the event by a long interval of time, especially if the speaker did not witness the narrated event:

(103) Behdînî NK (fieldnotes)
mam-ê *min-ê* *mezin bîst* *sal* *berê mir-i=ye*
uncle-EZ.M 1SG.OBL-EZ.M big twenty year ago die.PST-PTCP=COP.3SG:S
belê mam-ê *min-ê* *biçûk par* *mir.*
but uncle-EZ.M 1SG.OBL-EZ.M small last.year die.PST.3SG:S
'My elder uncle died 20 years ago but my young uncle died last year.'

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The Present Perfect II, i.e., the demonstrative *ezafe* perfect, in the Tor dialects seems to be related to certain pragmatic readings such as speaker certainty, which also would explain its highly selective and rare usage in those dialects. In Behdînî Kurdish, however, the verb form is more grammaticalised such that it is the only available verb form for expressing the affirmative present perfect.

16.2.3 Perfect in Hewramî

In Hewramî the perfect is formed by combining the resultative participle with copula clitics. The intransitive forms of perfect are shown in (104). The participle inflects for gender and number (SG.M *wəta*, SG.F *wətē*, PL *wətē*) and the copula agrees with the subject, e.g.,

(104) Hewramî Tekht (Khan & Mohammadirad 2024b: 196)

a. *wite=n*
sleep.PST.PTCP.SG.M=COP.3SG.M:S
'He has slept.'

b. *witê=ne*
sleep.PST.PTCP.SG.F=COP.3SG.F:S
'She has slept'

c. *witê=nê*
sleep.PST.PTCP.PL=COP.3PL:S
'They have slept.'

The perfect transitive of Hewramî has ergative alignment whereby both the participle and the copula clitics agree with the direct object. The transitive agentive subject is indexed by clitic agent person markers:

(105) Hewramî Tekht (Khan & Mohammadirad 2024b: 197)

a. *dîye=n=şa*
see.PST.PTCP.SG.M=COP.3SG.M:O=3PL:A
'They have seen him.'

b. *dîyê=ne=şa*
see.PST.PTCP.SG.F=COP.3SG.F:O=3PL:A
'They have seen her.'

c. *dîyê=nê=şa*
see.PST.PTCP.PL=COP.3PL:O=3PL:A
'They have seen them.'

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The perfect in Hewramî has the same range of functions as it does in Kurdish. These include the use of the perfect to narrate actions in the remote past. The aspect of such narrative perfect constructions may be imperfective or perfective, in that the perfect may express habitual events or events at a specific event time. The passage in (106) is an example of the use of the perfect in this way to express habitual events:

(106) Hewramî Tekht (Mohammadirad 2025c: 393)
dey *çêge=îç* *qeyîm* *ʿałif=şa*
DISC.PTCL here=ADD old_time grass.DIR.M=3PL:A
kenne=n=û *ħeywan=şa* *wey*
mow.PST.PTCP.M=COP.3SG.M:O=and animal.DIR.M=3PL:A raising
kerde=n=û *hewar-ê=şa*
do.PST.PTCP.M=COP.3SG.M:O=and summer_habitat.M-PL.DIR=3PL:A
wişkinɛ=nê *î* *dega* *to=ş*
scour.PST.PTCP.PL=COP.3PL:O DEM.PROX village.F 2SG=3SG:O
vîn-î *çoł-e* ***bîyê=ne*** *ħîç*
see.PRS.IND-2SG:A deserted-F be.PST.PTCP.F=COP.3SG.F:S nothing
ne-bîye=n
NEG-be.PST.PTCP.M=COP.3SG.M:S
'In the past, they (people) **mowed** grass. They **raised** animals. They **scoured** the summer habitats [searching for food etc.]. This village, which you see, **was** deserted. There **was** nothing [here].' [JE.1-5]

16.2.4 Perfect in Zazaki

The perfect in Zazaki is constructed like other past tenses, by attaching a suffix to the past stem of verbs. In the perfect, these suffixes coincide with the present copula endings. Thus, the perfect and the perfective (preterite) differ only in the third person singular and in the plural (Table 16.3). The first person plural may also be identical to other plural forms, depending on dialect.

In intransitive verbs the inflectional suffixes agree with the subject, whereas in transitive verbs the suffixes agree in gender, person, and number with the object. Since the perfect and preterite are identical in many instances, without further context sentence like (107a) can be interpreted as either.

(107) Perfect in Zazaki (Paul 2024: 91)

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Table 16.3: Agreement markers in the past perfective and present perfect of Zazaki

	Perfective	Perfect
1SG	*-ane ~-one ~-ûne ~-an*	*~-a ~-o ~-û*
2SG.M	*-î ~-ê*	
2SG.F	*-a*	
3SG.M	*-Ø*	*-o*
3SG.F	*-e*	*-a*
1PL1	*-îme/-î*	
2PL	*-î/y*	*-ê*
3PL	*-î/-y*	*-ê*

a. *ti xeyr ame-yê*
2SG good come.PST-2SG.M:S
'Welcome (lit. you have arrived well).'

b. *bira-yê ma merd-o*
brother-EZ.M 1PL die.PST-3SG.M:S
'Our brother has died.'

c. *to çî-yê dî-yo*
2SG.OBL thing-INDF see.PST-3SG.M:S
'You have seen something.'

d. *wext-o ke to awi şimit-a*
time-EZ.M REL 2SG.OBL water.F drink.PST-3SG.F:S
'When you have drunk the water…'

In Zazaki, the perfect serves three main functions (cf. Selcan 1998: 455–458):

- Perfect anterior: expressing a past event with relevance to the present.
- Evidential/renarrative: expressing events not witnessed by the speaker directly, but reported, inferred, or doubted.
- Narrative: as a stylistic device in traditional folk songs.

The perfect anterior reading is most common in negated sentences and in questions with adverbials such as *hona/hîna* 'yet', *qet/caran* 'never', *heta nika* 'until now', etc. (108a). The perfect is also frequently used with verbs such as 'to be born' and 'to die'.

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(108) Perfect in Zazaki (fieldwork)

a. *mi hona nê-dî-yo*
1SG.OBL yet NEG-see.PST-3SG.M:O
'I haven't seen him yet.'

b. *sima ara xo nê-kerd-a?*
2PL breakfast.F RFLX NEG-do.PST-3SG.F:O
'Haven't you had breakfast [yet]?'

The use of the Zazaki perfect is as an evidential (Paul 2024: 91) is comparable to the Turkish past with the *-mIş* morpheme. In this function, the perfect signals that the speaker did not witness the event but reports it based on hearsay, inference, or assumption. The alternation between preterite and perfect thus serves to mark the epistemic status of the information. The perfect may also be chosen when speakers explicitly distances themselves from the event.

The Zazaki perfect is widely used in folk songs and rhymes to narrate events. This may be related to the traditional function of such songs in narrating events from the distant past that have been not been witnessed by the speaker. Prosodic factors, however, may also play a role.

(109) Perfect in the lament Derê Laçî 'The Laç Brook' (Saltık & Taş 2016: 202-203)

a. *ordî am-o ma ser=de*
army.M come.PST-3SG.M:S 1PL upon=LOC
'The army descended upon us.'

b. *asmên=ra roz vinet-o*
sky=of sun stand.PST-3SG.M:S
'The sun stood still in the sky.'

c. *Hemed Aẍa kot-o ort-ê ordî, qirr ken-o*
Hemed Agha fall.PST-3SG.M middle-EZ.M army, massacre do.PRS-3SG.M
'Hemed Agha plunged into the army, killing [them all].'

d. *ma hêf-ê hawt bedel-u guret-o*
1PL revenge-EZ.M seven generation-PL.OBL take.PST-3SG.M:O
'We avenged seven generations.'

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16.3 Perfective and perfect in Arabic

The past perfective is expressed in all *Qəltu* dialects, according to Jastrow (1978: 307), by the past stem with suffixed person inflections (known as the Suffix Conjugation, SC in the tables below).[2] Generally in *Qəltu* dialects there is a separate strategy to express the present perfect (Jastrow 1978: 307-308). The strategies for the present perfect attested in and around the NENA-speaking region all involve the Suffix Conjugation prefixed by one of the following particles: *kū-*, *kəl-* (*~kə-* *~k-*) or *kən-* (110) (Mosul *kən-* is likely a variant of *kəl*), e.g.,

(110) Āzəx (Jastrow 1978: 307)

a. *kū-ṣər-tu*
PRTL-become.PST-1SG
'I have become.'

b. *kū-jəb-tū-l-kən*
PRTL-bring.PST-1SG-DAT-2PL
'I have brought to you.'

The variant *kū-* is also used in some dialects to form the progressive (see §19.3) and it is assumed here (as in Jastrow 1978: 307) that these homophonous particles have the same origin.

Jastrow (1978: 300), in his discussion of the progressive, derived *kū-* from the 3SG.M 'demonstrative' (deictic) copula *kū(we)* 'he is ... right now', arguing against the suggestion of Sasse (1971: 265-266) that it was borrowed from one of the similar particles in the other regional languages (e.g., Ṭuroyo *ko-*). An alternative internal derivation would be *ykūn*, the 3SG.M Prefix Conjugation of the verb 'to be' (Sasse 1971: 265), which Jastrow actually proposes in a later publication (Jastrow 2013: 112).

Jastrow (1978: 308) tentatively suggests that *kəl-* derives from an extended variant of *kū-*, namely *kət-* (< *kūt-*).[3] Note, however, that some dialects have *kū-* with the Suffix Conjugation, but *kəl-* with the Prefix Conjugation, casting some doubt on the theory that *kū-* and *kəl-* have the same origin (See §19.3).

[2] Jastrow calls it das Präteritum.

[3] See Jastrow (1978: 307-308) for an explanation of the possible path of development between the two. Biţună (2016b: 228, 230) understands *kəl-* to derive from the Suffix Conjugation *kān*, but this is implausible, as *kəl-* does not have any past tense function when used alone.

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Table 16.4: Arabic perfect particles within the NENA area

Mosul (M, C, J)	*kən*-SC (Jastrow 1979: 47-48; Procházka 2019a: 252)
Bəḥzāni (C, Y, M)	*kəl*-SC (Jastrow 1978: 308)
Mērgi (C)	*kəl*-SC (Hassan 2023: 584), but function uncertain
Səndōṛ (J)	*kū*-SC (Jastrow 1991b: 775)
Arbīl and ʿAqra (J)	*kū*-SC (Jastrow 1990a: 66)

Table 16.5: Arabic perfect particles on the periphery of the NENA area

Āzəx (C)	*kū*-SC (Wittrich 2001: 155)
Siirt town (M)	*kəl*-SC (Biţună 2016b: 221)
Tillo (M)	*kəl*-SC (Lahdo 2009: 163–164)

16.4 Perfective and perfect in Armenian

In Armenian, the distinction between perfective past and perfect is articulated by the distinction between the aorist (perfective past) and perfect tenses. This distinction existed in Classical Armenian, and in most dialects, the tense forms used today are diachronically derived from their Classical Armenian equivalents. The two forms may be used interchangeably in many contexts involving completed actions in the past, but there are some differences in the patterns of their usage, which will be discussed in this section.

16.4.1 Aorist

16.4.1.1 Formation

The aorist is a synthetic verb form. In modern Armenian, it is the only synthetic form that is still used in the indicative. It is formed from the perfective (sometimes called aorist) stem of the verb, and endings agreeing in person and number with the subject which are diachronically derived from the Classical Armenian aorist endings. Classical Armenian had different sets of endings for active and passive aorist. Both these types of endings are used for the aorist in modern

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forms of Armenian, although their distribution, and the extent of their link with active and passive meaning, varies between dialects (see Hodgson 2026). In SEA, the link with voice is totally lost, and the different endings are used for different conjugational classes of verbs, with the originally active endings used for simple verbs in *-el* and *-al*, including verbs suffixed with *-v-* (passives, reflexives, reciprocals, anticausatives), and *-cʿr-* (infinitive *-cʿn-*) (causatives), and the originally passive endings used for verbs suffixed with *-en-al* and *-an-al* (many of which are inchoatives derived from nouns and adjectives), *-n-*, and *-čʿ-* (see Dum-Tragut 2009: 229).

(111) Aorist of *sirel* 'to love' in SEA showing "active-type" endings

1SG	*sir-ecʿ-i*
2SG	*sir-ecʿ-ir*
3SG	*sir-ecʿ*
1PL	*sir-ecʿ-inkʿ*
2PL	*sir-ecʿ-ikʿ*
3PL	*sir-ecʿ-in*

(112) Aorist of *lavanal* 'to get better' in SEA showing "passive-type" endings

1SG	*lav-acʿ-a*
2SG	*lav-acʿ-ar*
3SG	*lav-acʿ-av*
1PL	*lav-acʿ-ankʿ*
2PL	*lav-acʿ-akʿ*
3PL	*lav-acʿ-an*

In a very few dialects, notably those of the Agulis-Meghri area, the synthetic aorist has been lost, and its function has been taken over by a complex form which corresponds to the Classical Armenian present perfect (past participle + auxiliary *em* 'to be'), while the present perfect in these dialects is expressed with the resultative participle and the auxiliary. This change was probably the result of paradigmatic pressure to regularise the system so that all indicative tense forms are expressed by participle + auxiliary, a tendency which exists more strongly in Eastern than Western Armenian. It is worth noting that the present perfect > aorist in these dialects has an alternative form, apparently used interchangeably with the full analytic form, which has undergone phonological changes to create a monolectic form parallel to the original aorist (*lsel em* > *ləsem* 'I listened/heard' etc), while the functional perfect with the resultative participle remains transparently analytic (Sargsiancʿ 1883: 116-7), preserving the independence of the auxiliary as a temporal anchoring device. This reflects the fact that, while the perfect is intrinsically anchored to a moment in time, the aorist is not.

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16.4.1.2 Use

The aorist denotes a completed action, usually, but not always, in the past. It is often used with expressions denoting a specific time, such as *ayn žamanak* 'at that time', *žamə vecʿin* 'at 6 o'clock', *mi ōr* 'one day', and is incompatible with adverbs or phrases with non-specific time reference, such as *erbeve* 'ever', *hačax* 'often', etc. (see Dum-Tragut 2009: 231). According to Dum-Tragut (2009: 231), the aorist is the main form used in narration, especially when several actions occur in succession, while perfect is associated with digressions from the main narrative.

As pointed out by Donabédian (2016), the use of the aorist, with its meaning of compact event, often results in an emphasis on the boundaries of the event, either its beginning (inchoative meaning), as seen in examples (113) and (114), or its end, as seen in example 115.

(113) SEA (Donabédian 2016: 20)
mtʿn-ecʿ.
get.dark-AOR.3SG
'It's dark out.' (lit. 'It got dark.')

(114) SEA (Donabédian 2016: 20)
janjra-cʿ-a.
be.bored-AOR-1SG
'I'm fed up.' (lit. 'I got bored.')

In this way, the aorist can be used with any semantic class of verbs (state, activity, accomplishment or achievement in the terminology of Vendler 1957), leading to the recategorisation of the event into an achievement: "no matter what the lexical semantics of the verb, the use of the aorist recategorizes it in order to allow an emphasis on the boundaries" (Donabédian 2016: 22).

The use of the aorist can stress teleology (it's done, I did it), as seen in (115), or qualitative salience (such a thing happened), while the use of the perfect in the same context, as seen in (116), allows only a resultative interpretation (Donabédian 2016: 21-22).

(115) SEA (Donabédian 2016: 21)
hacʿ-d *ker-ar* *prc-ar*
bread-ART2 eat-AOR.2SG finish-AOR.2SG
'That's it, you ate your meal?' ['It's done?']

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(116) SEA (Donabédian 2016: 21)
hacʿ-d ker-el=es
bread-ART2 eat-PST.PTCP=be-PRS.2SG
'You have eaten your meal?' ['You're not hungry? I can clear the table?']

The aorist, with its emphasis on the salience of the occurrence of the event, may be used to give a sense of immediacy, to express something that happened just now, and has been witnessed by the speaker, as stated by Dum-Tragut (2009: 231). This use of the aorist, to express something that has happened immediately prior to the moment of speech, was the meaning most commonly referred to by speakers of Agulis dialect who participated in the study of Hodgson (2022a), when asked to define the difference between the aorist and the perfect.

The usage of the aorist to express an immediately witnessed event creates an evidential dimension to the contrast with the perfect. According to the consultants of Hodgson (2022a), the aorist may not be used when describing events whose occurrence has only been inferred from witnessing the result, such as 'It has rained' uttered on seeing that the ground is wet, which must be expressed with the perfect. Asatryan (2004: 293) describes this evidential contrast (aorist for directly witnessed events, perfect for non-witnessed events) as one of the main differences between the perfect and the aorist in SEA. However, Donabédian (2016: 17) shows that eyewitness meaning is not an essential characteristic of the aorist. Eyewitness meaning is not relevant to the use of the aorist in narrative, and, in discourse, the aorist may be used to create modal effects in which the key feature is emphasis on the assertion, for example, a strong assertion implying that the event is relevant to the argumentation, without necessarily requiring that the speaker has directly witnessed it, as discussed by Donabédian (2016: 18-19), and exemplified by 117.

(117) SEA (Donabédian 2016: 19)
*ənt*ruʿ*yun-ner-i naxōre-i-n kʿałakʿakan iravičak-ə*
election-PL-GEN eve-DAT-DEF political situation-DEF
larv-um=ē. očʿ aynkʿan vałucʿ
be.tense-I.PTCP=be-PRS.3SG. NEG so.much long.ago
*payt*ʿ*ecʿ-v-ecʿ-in jer kusakcʿutʿy-an erku grasenyak-ner-ə.*
blow.up-PASS-AOR-3PL 2PL.GEN party-GEN two office-PL-DEF.
um=ē da jeŕntu?
who-DAT=be-PRS.3SG DEM2 beneficial
'On the eve of the elections, the situation is tense. Not long ago, the two offices of your party were blown up. To the benefit of whom?' (Aravot Daily, 2007.05.10)

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The aorist differs from the perfect tenses in that while the perfect is intrinsically linked to a moment in time (in the present, past, or future, depending on the tense of the auxiliary), the aorist is not (it receives its temporal interpretation from the context). This means that it lacks the resultative, experiential etc. dimension of the present perfect, the use of which implies the relevance of the event for the time of speech. In contexts that block its temporal meaning (e.g., if there are elements in the context implying future reference), the aspectual meaning, which is eventive and compact, remains, giving rise to various modal uses associated with emphasis on the arising of the event, the change involved (gnomic, mirative, in threats etc.).

One such use, exemplified by (118), is described by Dum-Tragut (2009: 232) as ingressive meaning with motion verbs, and corresponds to the label *aoriste d'anticipation* used by Lessan-Pezechki (1998) for Persian.

(118) SEA (Donabédian 2016: 20)
gna-cʿ-inkʿ
go-AOR-1PL
'Let's go!'

This includes prospective meaning (119).

(119) SEA
gna-cʿ-i
go-AOR-1SG
'I am about to go'

This category also includes hypothetical uses in conditionals, as seen in (120), which, according to Donabédian (2016: 34-35), are associated with Eastern rather than Western Armenian, and have parallels in Iranian languages, while they have no parallels in Turkish, the main contact language for Western Armenian.

(120) SEA (Donabédian 2016: 24)
mard-ə or siraharv-ecʿ, hor-n u
person-DEF COMP fall.in.love-AOR.3SG father.DAT-DEF and
mor-ə kə-cax-i.
mother.DAT-DEF PTCL-sell-3SG
'If/when a person falls in love, he will sell his father and mother.'

Dum-Tragut (2009: 224) notes that, while the aorist is preferred for this use in written SEA, in colloquial spoken EA, the perfect is often used for hypothetical

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events in conditionals (see 130). Perhaps it is possible for the perfect to be understood as temporally anchored to a moment in the future, when the apodosis is to be carried out, or perhaps this usage simply reflects the fact that the present perfect and the aorist are to a very large degree interchangeable in colloquial EA.

16.4.2 Perfect

16.4.2.1 Formation

In most dialects, the perfect is diachronically derived from the Classical Armenian perfect, with the participle in < *-eal*, which is referred to here as the past participle in the context of modern Armenian, and the copula/auxiliary *em* (123), which is enclitic in modern Armenian (see §15 for the behaviour of this element), with the present auxiliary used for the present perfect, and the past auxiliary used for the past perfect. In Classical Armenian, the copula was often omitted in perfect constructions: Meyer (2023: 81) states that it is "optional in non-biblical texts". Meyer (2023: 151) suggests that the forms without the copula may reflect the original situation, in particular for third person, as with third person referents, no copula occurs in the Parthian construction which may have served as the model for the Armenian perfect. Note that the 3SG copula is often omitted in the perfect and other complex tense forms in several modern Armenian dialects, including Urmia and Salmast (see examples (121) and (122)). In contrast to the Classical Armenian perfect (for which see §22), the modern Armenian perfect has nominative–accusative alignment, and the copula agrees with the subject in both transitives and intransitives, while in Classical Armenian active transitive perfect constructions, it generally showed default 3SG agreement.

As discussed in sub§16.4.1, the dialects of the Agulis-Meghri area use the form derived from the Classical Armenian perfect for the aorist, while the perfect is expressed by the resultative participle and the copula/auxiliary. Standard Western Armenian and many Western Armenian dialects also use the resultative participle and auxiliary for the unmarked perfect (123), as the form derived from the Classical Armenian perfect has become specialised to express evidential meaning, a development that was probably promoted by contact with Turkish. This does not include Van (Acharyan 1952: 178), Sasun (Petoyan 1954), or, according to (Haneyan 1978: 115), Diyarbakir (Tigranakert); she ascribes the few attested forms with the resultative participle as due to SWA influence. These dialects have only the Classical Armenian-type perfect, as does Eastern Armenian in general, including Urmia. In dialects of the Urmia group, the 3SG copula is often omitted, as seen in (121) and (122).

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(121) Urmia Armenian (Aghnjadzor) (Hodgson field notes)
inʧʰ el-e
what be-PST.PTCP
'What has happened?'

(122) Salmast Armenian (Atayan 1906: 202)
dædæ-n mer-e
father-DEF die-PST.PTCP
'Father has died.'

(123) Present perfect of *sirel* 'to love' in SEA

1SG	*sir-el=em*
2SG	*sir-el=es*
3SG	*sir-el=ē*
1PL	*sir-el=enkʿ*
2PL	*sir-el=ekʿ*
3PL	*sir-el=en*

(124) Present perfect of *sirel* 'to love' with resultative participle

1SG	*sir-ac=em*
2SG	*sir-ac=es*
3SG	*sir-ac=ē*
1PL	*sir-ac=enkʿ*
2PL	*sir-ac=ekʿ*
3PL	*sir-ac=en*

16.4.2.2 Function

Plungian (2018: 236), based on studies by Donabédian (2001), Kozintseva (1988), and Kozintseva (2000), observes that the central value of the perfect in Armenian is connected with some concept of "current relevance", but that it also has an evidential dimension "more or less in keeping with what is observed in a variety of Great Evidential Belt languages (including Iranian, Turkic, Kartvelian and many others)", which is more grammaticalised in Western than Eastern Armenian, probably promoted by contact with Turkish.

According to Dum-Tragut (2009: 222), the main uses of the perfect in SEA are:

i. resultative, typically with telic verbs, referring to the state resulting from an action, which is generally interpreted as being relevant for the time denoted by the auxiliary (125, 126)

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ii. durative/inclusive, typically with atelic verbs, referring to an activity or state whose duration comprises the period from a given moment in the past, up to and including the moment of speech or some other reference point in the past (127)

iii. evidential, referring to unwitnessed events in the past (129), and

iv. narrative, referring to digressions from the main event (129).

v. In colloquial spoken EA, it may also be used for hypothetical events in conditionals (130), while the aorist is preferred for this use in written SEA, as seen in (120).

(125) SEA (Dum-Tragut 2009: 224)
Armen-ə durs=ē ek-el
Armen-DEF out=be.PRS.3SG come-PST.PTCP
'Armen has gone out.' (i.e., he is not here any more)

(126) SEA (Dum-Tragut 2009: 224)
Ani-n gn-el=ē nor mekʿena
Ani-DEF buy-PST.PTCP=be.PRS.3SG new car
'Ani has bought a new car.' (It is in her garage now)

(127) SEA (Dum-Tragut 2009: 225)
erbeve čʿ-i ēl mtac-el or hayrenikʿ-um ēl
ever NEG-be.PRS.3SG ADD think-PST.PTCP COMP fatherland-LOC ADD
karoł=ē antun mn-al
able=be.PRS.3SG homeless stay-INF
'He has never even thought that he could stay homeless also in the fatherland.'

(128) SEA (Dum-Tragut 2009: 225)
Vahan-ə yerevi haskacʿ-el=ē namak-d
Vahan-DEF probably understand-PST.PTCP=be.PRS.3SG letter-ART2
'Vahan has probably understood your letter.'

(129) SEA (Dum-Tragut 2009: 225)
haykakan aybuben-ə stełc-v-el=ē hingerord
Armenian alphabet-DEF create-PASS-PST.PTCP=be.PRS.3SG fifth
dar-um
century-LOC
'The Armenian alphabet was created in the 5th century.'

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(130) SEA (Dum-Tragut 2009: 226)
etʿe tes-el=em nran kʿez k-as-em
if see-PST.PTCP=be.PRS.1SG DEM3.DAT 2SG.DAT FUT-say-1SG
'If I see him, I will tell you.'

According to Acharyan (1961: 224), in Istanbul (Polis) dialect, where, as in SWA, there is a contrast between the neutral perfect in *-ac* and the evidential perfect in *-er* < *-eal*, the two perfect tenses also differ as regards time reference, with the *-ac* perfect in example (131) interpreted as referring to an event that happened a long time ago, i.e., remote past, while the equivalent sentence with the *-er* perfect (132) is interpreted as referring to something that happened just now, or recently.

(131) Istanbul Armenian (Acharyan 1961: 224)
ays ban-ə sovorutʿyun=ē darj-ac Pols-i meǰ
DEM1 thing-DEF custom=be.PRS.3SG become-RES.PTCP Istanbul-GEN in
'This thing became a custom in Istanbul [a long time ago].'

(132) Istanbul Armenian (Acharyan 1961: 224)
ays ban-ə sovorutʿyun=ē darj-er Pols-i meǰ
DEM1 thing-DEF custom=be.PRS.3SG become-PST.PTCP Istanbul-GEN in
'This thing has become a custom in Istanbul [now, lately].'

16.5 Perfective and perfect in Turkic

Azeri distinguishes between a perfective past tense (henceforth: preterite) and a perfect. Given the close connection between evidentiality and the perfect, this section will also address evidential marking.

16.5.1 The preterite

The Azeri preterite is an old tense, whose morphosyntactic parallels are attested in all known Turkic languages and which is effectively reconstructed for Proto-Turkic (Kormušin 1988: 376). The verb stem (e.g., *bax-* 'look', *de-* 'say') takes the stressed (except when followed by the plural suffix *-lAr*)[4] preterite suffix *-dX*, followed by a person-and-number agreement marker from the short series. In the negative, the negative suffix *-mA* precedes the preterite suffix, with stress placed on the syllable preceding *-mA*. The Standard Azeri paradigm is as follows:

[4]For the notation of Turkic vowels see §7.5.

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Table 16.6: Preterite affirmative *bax-* 'look'

Person	Singular	Plural
1	*bax-dı-m*	*bax-dı-q*
	[bɑχˈtɯm]	[bɑχˈtɯχ]
	'I looked'	'we looked'
2	*bax-dı-n*	*bax-dı-nız*
	[bɑχˈtɯn]	[bɑχˈtɯz]
	'you (sg) looked'	'you (pl) looked'
3	*bax-dı-∅*	*bax-dı-∅(-lar)*
	[bɑχˈtɯ]	[bɑχtɯ(ˈlɑr)]
	's/he looked'	'they looked'

Table 16.7: Preterite negative *bax-* 'look'

Person	Singular	Plural
1	*bax-ma-dı-m*	*bax-ma-dı-q*
	[ˈbɑχmɑdɯm]	[ˈbɑχmɑdɯχ]
	'I did not look'	'we did not look'
2	*bax-ma-dı-n*	*bax-ma-dı-nız*
	[ˈbɑχmɑdɯn]	[ˈbɑχmɑdɯz]
	'you (sg) did not look'	'you (pl) did not look'
3	*bax-ma-dı-∅*	*bax-ma-dı-∅(-lar)*
	[ˈbɑχmɑdɯ]	[ˈbɑχmɑdɯ̆(lɑr)]
	's/he did not look'	'they did not look'

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Table 16.8: Preterite affirmative *de-* 'say'

Person	Singular	Plural
1	*de-di-m*	*de-di-k*
	[deˈdim]	[deˈdiç]
	'I said'	'we said
2	*de-di-n*	*de-di-niz*
	[deˈdin]	[deˈdiz]
	'you (sg) said'	'you (pl) said'
3	*de-di-∅*	*de-di-∅(-lər)*
	[deˈdi]	[dediˈlær)]
	's/he said'	'they said'

Table 16.9: Preterite negative *de-* 'say'

Person	Singular	Plural
1	*de-mə-di-m*	*de-mə-di-k*
	[ˈdemædim]	[ˈdemædiç]
	'I did not say'	'we did not say'
2	*de-mə-di-n*	*de-mə-di-niz*
	[ˈdemædin]	[ˈdemædiz]
	'you (sg) did not say'	'you (pl) did not say'
3	de-mə-di-∅	*de-mə-di-∅(-lər)*
	[ˈdemædi]	[ˈdemædĭ(lær)]
	's/he did not say'	'they did not say'

In Urmia Azeri, the forms of the preterite are largely identical to those of Standard Azeri. In the first-person plural, one may occasionally observe vowel disharmony (Doğan 2010: 163) favouring a back realisation (e.g., /dedɯχ/ vs. Standard Azeri /dediç/ 'we said') or delabialisation (e.g., /gojdɯχ/ vs. Standard Azeri /gojduχ/ 'we put'), as is often the case in this variety with vowels preceding a suffixal dorsal.

Johanson (Johanson 2021: 661), who terms this category "terminal", characterises the preterite as the most "anaspectual" category in the TAM system of Turkic languages in that it presents the event "directly and as a whole", rather than highlighting the point at which it reaches its actional boundary. In most

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Turkic languages, the preterite is also the only indicative category that is not formed by means of a periphrastic construction involving a non-finite verb form and an auxiliary.

The preterite denotes an action completed at a specific point in the past. This temporal reference may be expressed by an adverbial or inferred from the context:

(133) Urmia Azeri (Doğan 2010: 277)
urus gəl-əndə bırdan qaş-dı-x geceynən.
Russian come-CVB here.ABL run-PST-1PL by.night
'When the Russians came, we fled by night.'

It can also have resultative functions (while retaining its regular function of marking a completed, single event) when the result of an event directly precedes the utterance and is verifiable:

(134) Urmia Azeri (Doğan 2010: 440)
('I picked [some herbs] and tied them up. I have a daughter [living at home with me]; she started an argument with me and said')
onnaı niyə bağla-dı-n?
they.ACC why tie-PST-2SG
'Why did you tie them up?'

The preterite is often used as a narrative tense in folk tales or narratives:

(135) Urmia Azeri (Doğan 2010: 380)
bu get-di qapı-nı çal-dı.
this go-PST.3 door-ACC whisk-PST.3
'[The Big Bad Wolf] went and knocked on the door.'

As in Persian, the preterite acquires special future-like semantics when it is accompanied by the adverbs conveying epistemic modality:

(136) Urmia Azeri (Doğan 2010: 406)
biz bəlkə gəl-di-x türkiyə-yə dolan-mağ-a.
we perhaps come-PST-1PL Turkey-DAT revolve-INF-DAT
'Perhaps we'll come to Turkey for a visit.'

The preterite is sometimes used in finite temporal clauses denoting sequence, in which case the predicate is typically preceded by the subordinator ki. This usage is especially common in procedural texts:

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(137) Urmia Azeri (Doğan 2010: 375)
uşax ki ol-du, iki gün üş gün onnan soya biy dilxoşluğ
child SUB be-PST.3 two day three day that.ABL after one fun
eləlləy.
do.EVT.3PL
'Once the child is born, a party is thrown two or three days later.'

16.5.2 The perfect

Across the NENA contact area (and beyond it), the Turkic perfect shows mixed paradigms. These ultimately derive from periphrastic constructions involving a non-finite verb form combined with an auxiliary. Synchronically, the perfect consists of the verb stem, the stressed aspectual suffix (*-mXş* or *-Xb*) and a person-and-number agreement marker from the long series. In the negative, the negative suffix *-mA* precedes the perfect suffix, with stress falling on the syllable preceding *-mA*. The Standard Azeri paradigm is seen in Table 16.10 and 16.11 (note the contracted *-mXş* form in the second person):

Table 16.10: Affirmative perfect *bax-* 'look'

Person	Singular	Plural
1	*bax-mış-am* [bɑχˈmɯʃɑm] 'I have looked'	*bax-mış-ıq* [bɑχˈmɯʃɯχ] 'we have looked'
2	*bax-mısan* [bɑχˈmɯsɑn] (*bax-mış-san* is an alternative form typical of written Azeri) or *bax-ıb-san* [bɑˈχɯpsɑn] 'you (sg) have looked'	*bax-mısınız* [bɑχˈtɯz] (*bax-mış-san* is an alternative form typical of written Azeri) or *bax-ıb-sınız* [bɑˈχɯpsɯz] 'you (pl) have looked'
3	*bax-ıb-∅(-dır)* [bɑˈχɯp(tɨ)]	*bax-ıb-∅(-lar)* [bɑˈχɯp(lɑr)]

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Person	Singular	Plural
	(*bax-mış-dır* is an alternative form typical of written Azeri) 's/he has looked'	(*bax-mış-lar* is an alternative form typical of written Azeri) 'they have looked'

Table 16.11: Negative perfect *bax-* 'look'

Person	Singular	Plural
1	*bax-ma-mış-am* ['bɑχmɑmɯ̆ʃɑm] 'I have not looked'	*bax-ma-mış-ıq* ['bɑχmɑmɯ̆ʃɯχ] 'we have not looked'
2	*bax-ma-mısan* ['bɑχmɑmɯ̆sɑn] (*bax-ma-mış-san* is an alternative form typical of written Azeri) or *bax-ma-yıb-san* ['bɑχmɪjɯpsɑn] 'you (sg) have not looked'	*bax-ma-mısınız* ['bɑχmɑmɯ̆sɯz] (*bax-ma-mış-sınız* is an alternative form typical of written Azeri) or *bax-ma-yıb-sınız* ['bɑχmɪjɯpsɯz] 'you (pl) have not looked'
3	*bax-ma-yıb-∅(-dır)* ['bɑχmɪjɯp(tɯ)] (*bax-ma-mış-dır* is an alternative form typical of written Azeri) 's/he has not looked'	*bax-ma-yıb-∅(-lar)* ['bɑχmɪjɯp(lɑr)] (*bax-ma-mış-lar* is an alternative form typical of written Azeri) 'they have not looked'

The suffix *-mXş* is of uncertain origin but is reconstructed for Proto-Turkic and attested in predicate position in the earliest Turkic texts, where it appears both as a non-finite resultative participle and as a finite mirative verb form (Erdal 2004: 294). Today, *-mXş* forms a dynamic TAM category only in Oghuz Turkic (with the exception of Turkmen and Chorasmian Uzbek) as well as in Khalaj and Yakut

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(Johanson 2021: 653–654). Elsewhere, it has been preserved as an unproductive participial or nominal suffix or as a semi-productive marginal modal suffix.

The grammaticalisation of *-Xb* as an aspectual perfect marker most likely began in the third person, in the form of *-Xb-dXr*, a contraction of the earlier periphrastic form <verb-*Xb* + *dur-ur*>, where *-Xb* attached to the lexical verb to form a converb while *dur-ur* <stand-PRS.3> functioned as an auxiliary (hence *bax-ıb(-dır)* 's/he has looked' < **bax-ıb dur-ur* lit. 's/he stands looking'). Once grammaticalised, this construction gave rise to a new paradigm, formed by structural analogy with the other originally periphrastic TAM categories, and began to compete semantically with the *-mXş* paradigm. This competition, in turn, has yielded mixed perfect paradigms, with various combinations, while some forms have become marginal or even obsolete as a result (most present-day Azeri speakers consider first-person *-Xb* perfect forms ungrammatical).

Mixed perfect paradigms in the Turkic varieties of Western Iran are already attested in the sixteenth century (Stein 2014b: 222–224). Almost all known varieties today prefer *-mXş* in the first person, while most varieties prefer *-Xb* (with or without *-dXr* in the singular) in the third. In the second person, both suffixes are represented more or less equally. Some varieties even allow the use of either suffix for the same conjugated form (Bulut 2014: 50–51).

In Urmia Azeri, *-mXş* is used consistently in the first person while *-Xb* consistently in the third. In the second person, both suffixes are encountered depending on the sub-variety, though there seems to be a slight preference for *-Xb* (Doğan 2010: 164–169).

Johanson (2021: 625) defines a typical Turkic perfect, which he terms "postterminal", as a category envisaging "an event at a vantage point where its relevant limit has already passed. This limit depends on the phase structure of the actional phrase."

Likely due to contact with Iranian languages, the perfect in modern Azeri (and related varieties) is hardly evidential and is characterised mainly by resultative and experiential semantics (following Comrie 1976: 55, 60). This sets it apart from closely related Oghuz languages, notably Standard Turkish, where a structurally parallel TAM category is primarily associated with evidentiality. The type of perfect in which evidential distinctions are weakly (if at all) expressed is characteristic of a large area encompassing Eastern Anatolia as far west as Diyarbakır, as well as Iraq, the Caucasus and all of Western Iran, extending as far as Isfahan and the Qashqai-speaking area (Bulut 2014: 50–51).

The perfect in the NENA contact area is used to describe a past event whose current relevance lies in the present state or in the result produced by the event,

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while the course of the event itself is either not observable or not relevant at the time of utterance ("resultative perfect"):

(138) Urmia Azeri (Doğan 2010: 300)
de-mağ ol-ar zərtüşt zaman-ı bu kət ġur-ul-up.
say-INF be-EVT.3 PN time-POSS.3 this village set-PASS-PRF.3
'It can be said that this village was founded at the time of Zoroaster.'

It is also used to refer to events that have occurred at least once (or have never occurred) in the speaker's experience, without reference to the exact time of occurrence ("experiential perfect"):

(139) Urmia Azeri (Doğan 2010: 426)

a. *bu.cür məsāil tārix boyu bizim kət-dən ol-up.*
such.PROX issues history along we.GEN village-ABL be-PRF.3
'Such occurrences have taken place in our village throughout history.'

b. *öz-üm də heş mərz-i gör-mə-miş-əm.*
REFL-POSS.1SG ADD at.all border-ACC see-NEG-PRF-1SG
'As for me, I have not even seen the border.'

In addition, the perfect is used to express biographical information:

(140) Urmia Azeri (Doğan 2010: 352)
min-üş-yüz-atmış-döt-də də xıtmət-dən ġutul-muş-am.
thousand-three-hundred-sixty-four-LOC ADD service-ABL end-PRF-1SG
'And in 1364, I was discharged from military service.'

Finally, with a set of stative and posture verbs (e.g. *otur-* 'sit down', *yat-* 'sleep', *uzan-* 'lie down', etc.), it can convey a progressive reading:

(141) Urmia Azeri (Doğan 2010: 427)
büyünnəi siz qardaş-nan otumuş-ux, söhbət elir-ix.
today you.pl brother-COM/INS sit.PRF-1PL conversation do.IPFV-1PL
'Today, we are sitting down with you, brother, and having a conversation.'

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16.5.3 Evidentiality

Evidentiality, as a grammaticalised category, constitutes a systemic feature across nearly all attested historical and contemporary Turkic varieties. Furthermore, the development of grammaticalised evidential constructions (usually involving a form of the perfect tense) in the languages of Eurasia is, according to Aikhenvald (2004: 279), largely due to contact with Turkic languages. Aikhenvald reconstructs the grammaticalisation path of perfect-derived evidential forms as follows: result of an action or state (or an action or state viewed as relevant at the moment of speech) is interpreted as an inference based on visible traces, assumption or hearsay, which subsequently comes to cover the full range of non-firsthand meanings.

In the same manner way that the indicative identification copulae (present and past) have combined with non-finite verb bases to form periphrastic constructions that later grammaticalised into TAM categories, the evidential copula has given rise to similar constructions based on the same non-finite forms. However, whereas the identification copulae maintain a present–past distinction (crucial for distinguishing, for example, the present from the imperfect or the perfect from the pluperfect), the tense-neutral evidential makes no such distinction. As a result, evidential TAM categories are distinguished only in terms of aspect and mood, not tense. As in the indicative, the evidential copula cannot combine with the preterite.

It is important to distinguish between the perfect suffix *-mXş*, which originally formed participles and synchronically functions as an aspectual suffix occupying the aspect–modal slot in an inflected verb form structure, and the evidential suffix *-mXş*, which is a cliticised and grammaticalised form of the evidential copula occupying the temporal slot (hence in the perfect evidential, the two may co-occur; see below).

Table 16.12: Affirmative evidential imperfective and perfect *bax-* 'look'

Person	Imperfective	Perfect
1	*bax-ır-mış-am* 'apparently I look / am looking / was looking'	*bax-mış-mış-am* *bax-ıb-mış-am* 'apparently I have / had looked'
2	*bax-ır-mış-san*	*bax-mış-mış-san*

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Person	Imperfective	Perfect
	‘apparently you look / are looking / were looking’	*bax-ıb-mış-san* ‘apparently you have / had looked’
3	*bax-ır-mış-∅* ‘apparently s/he looks / is looking / was looking’	*bax-mış-mış-∅* *bax-ıb-mış-∅* ‘apparently s/he has / had looked’

Table 16.13: Affirmative evidential eventual and prospective *bax-* ‘look’

Person	Eventual	Prospective
1	*bax-ar-mış-am* ‘apparently I will / would look’	*bax-acaq-mış-am* ‘apparently I am / was going to look’
2	*bax-ar-mış-san* ‘apparently you will / would look’	*bax-acaq-mış-san* ‘apparently you are / were going to look’
3	*bax-ar-mış-∅* ‘apparently s/he will / would look’	*bax-acaq-mış-∅* ‘apparently s/he is / was going to look’

Table 16.14: Negative evidential imperfective and perfect *bax-* ‘look’

Person	Imperfective	Perfect
1	*bax-m-ır-mış-am* ‘apparently I do not look / am not looking / was not looking’	*bax-ma-mış-mış-am* *bax-ma-yıb-mış-am* ‘apparently I have not / had not looked’

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Person	Imperfective	Perfect
2	*bax-m-ır-mış-san* ‘apparently you do not look / are not looking / were not looking’	*bax-ma-mış-mış-san* *bax-ma-yıb-mış-san* ‘apparently you have not / had not looked’
3	*bax-m-ır-mış-∅* ‘apparently s/he does not look / is not looking / was not looking’	*bax-ma-mış-mış-∅* *bax-ma-yıb-mış-∅* ‘apparently s/he has not / had not looked’

Table 16.15: Negative evidential eventual and prospective *bax-* ‘look’

Person	Eventual	Prospective
1	*bax-m-az-mış-am* ‘apparently I will not / would not look’	*bax-ma-yacaq-mış-am* ‘apparently I am not / was not going to look’
2	*bax-m-az-mış-san* ‘apparently you will not / would not look’	*bax-ma-yacaq-mış-san* ‘apparently you are not / were not going to look’
3	*bax-m-az-mış-∅* ‘apparently s/he will not / would not look’	*bax-ma-yacaq-mış-∅* ‘apparently s/he is not / was not going to look’

(142) Urmia Azeri (Doğan 2010: 426, 437)

a. *bi məjmə gətir-ər-miş, yığış-ar-mış-la, biy.yerdə ğəza*
one tray bring-EVT-EVID.3 gather-EVT-EVID.3-PL together food
ye-ər-miş-lər.
eat-EVT-EVID.3-PL
‘They would (apparently) bring a tray, gather around and eat together.’

b. *üş döt yer-i də qaz-mış-la, bədən-i-n*
three four place-ACC ADD dig-PRF.3-PL body-POSS.3-ACC

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axtar-ır-mış-la.
search-IPFV-EVID.3-PL
'They have dug up three or four spots; apparently, they were searching for his body.'

(143) Ardabil Azeri (Karini 2009: 424)
bu div bı-lar-ın kənd-i-nin əhali-si-nnən üş
this ogre this-PL-GEN village-POSS.3-GEN population-POSS.3-ABL three
dört yüz nəfər ye-miş-imiş ya öldür-müş-ümüş.
four hundred individual eat-PRF-EVID.3 or kill-PRF-EVID.3
'(They say) the ogre devoured or killed three or four hundred people from their village's population.'

Evidential TAM categories are resistant to loss even in areas where Turkic varieties are dominated by Iranian languages that do not have dedicated evidential paradigms. They are attested in Middle Azeri (Stein 2014b: 224) and are employed today, with very few exceptions, in the Turkic varieties of Eastern Anatolia, the Caucasus, and Western Iran as far south as Hamadan (Bekbabayi 2024: 80) and the Qashqai-speaking area (Dolatkhah 2019: 122–125). They are also found in Iraqi Turkic (Bayatlı 1996: 400–403).

16.6 Discussion

In all NENA dialects the past perfective is expressed by forms based on the past stem *qṭil-*. This is historically a passive/resultative participle and constructions based on it would have originally had a present perfect meaning. It has now, however, shifted in meaning to past perfective and the present perfect is expressed by innovative constructions. Many NENA dialects express the perfect by a passive/resultative participle combined with the copula. This participle was different in form from the participle that came to form the past perfective base, in that it has the nominal ending *-a*:

(144)

Past stem	Perfect stem
qṭil-	*qṭila*

This matches Iranian languages of the area, in which the past stem of the past perfect is a passive/resultative participle in origin and the participle of the perfect is an extended form of this.

In the Mosul plain and the northern sector of NENA the copula is preposed before the participle in the perfect, in the form of a deictic copula (145a, 145b) with

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a presentative element or in its basic form (145c). In some dialects it is cliticised to a preposed subject (145d), e.g.,

(145) a. C. Qaraqosh
k-ilə ʾəθya.
DEIC-COP.3SG.M come.PTCP.SG.M
'He has come.'

b. C. Barwar
ho-le ʾəθya.
DEIC-COP.3SG.M come.PTCP.SG.M
'He has come.'

c. C. Telkepe
ʾile ʾəθya.
COP.3SG.M come.PTCP.SG.M
'He has come.'

d. J. Amedia
bab-ux=ile ʾəθya.
father-your=COP.3SG.M come.PTCP.SG.M
'Your father has come.'

This type of structure matches perfect constructions in Behdînî varieties of Northern Kurdish in which the *ezafe* copula is preposed before a participle, either as an independent prosodic word or as an enclitic on a preceding subject argument (§16.2.2.2). In its independent inflected forms the *ezafe* begins with a /*y*/, viz. *yê* (sg.m), *ya* (sg.f), *yêt* (pl) and this, indeed, matches the phonetic shape of the NENA copula, the stem of which is *i* (*i-le* 3SG.M). The Kurdish *ezafe* copula and *ezafe* perfect constructions are likely to have originated as relative particles in a non-contrastive cleft constructions which had a thetic function ('It is John who has come'), and this could apply also to the evolution of the NENA construction.

In many NENA dialects such perfect constructions with preposed copulas are only used in affirmative clauses and the enclitic copula is used in interrogative clauses (46). The same applies to *ezafe* perfects in Kurdish, which are restricted to affirmative clauses (85a). This phenomenon is compatible with the thetic profile of such perfect constructions in Kurdish and NENA, since a question is not thetic. In some NENA dialects, however, through internal analogical extension, preposed deictic copulas are used in perfect constructions also in questions (47). Such an analogical extension does not have a parallel in Kurdish.

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There are further differences between the NENA perfect constructions with preposed copulas and the Kurdish *ezafe* perfect. In Kurdish, the *ezafe* particles inflect for number and gender, but not for person, whereas in NENA the preposed copula inflections also for person. There are differences in alignment, in that transitive clauses in Kurdish have ergative alignment and the *ezafe* copula agrees with the object argument, whereas in NENA the copula agrees with the subject argument in both intransitive and transitive clauses. Likewise when NENA dialects in the northern sector use enclitic copulas in the perfect in, for example, non-assertive clauses or in assertive clauses that are not thetic, then the copula agrees with the subject in all cases. By contrast, in Northern Kurdish dialects that express the perfect by enclitic copulas and in Zazaki, these agree with the object in transitive clauses (see 82). One internal factor that may have conditioned the nominative–accusative alignment of the NENA constructions may have been analogy with the nominative –accusative alignment of present-stem constructions. A possible external factor may have been that the corresponding perfect construction in Modern Eastern Armenian dialects has nominative–accusative alignment and the copula agrees with the subject in both intransitive and transitive clauses (§16.4.2.1). This may have induced or at least reinforced the nominative–accusative alignment in NENA perfect constructions. Similar nominative–accusative alignment of the copula in transitive perfects are found in some Kurdish dialects on the periphery of NENA, such as the Yezidi dialect of Tor (91).

A feature of many NENA dialects in the Central Kurdish area, in particular in the Arbīl and Sulemaniyya provinces of Iraq, is the use of an invariable preposed particle in perfect constructions. These are in some dialects combined with participles and in other dialects combined with the past perfective form. In Central Kurdish dialects the copula agrees with the subject in intransitive clauses but in transitive clauses an invariable 3SG form of the copula is used irrespective of the person or number of the object (79). The existence of this invariable copula in the Central Kurdish transitive perfect may have been a conditioning factor for the development of the invariable particles in the NENA dialects of the area. Most of these particles are, indeed, fossilised forms of the copula. A further factor is likely to have been convergence with the pattern of the deictic copulas of Central Kurdish and Gorani with the stems *ha* and *îna* respectively (see p.521).

It should be noted, however, that the use of perfect constructions consisting of an invariable particle before a participle is attested also in some dialects in the Hakkari region, such as the Baz dialects, e.g., C. Shawwa (36): *ha zila* ‘he has gone.’ Such dialects were in contact with Behdînî Kurdish, so the model would have been the *ezafe* type of perfect. As noted, the *ezafe* particle only inflected

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for gender and, in some dialects, also for number, but never for person. It is not clear, therefore, whether the perfect constructions with invariable particles in NENA dialects in the Arbīl and Sulemaniyya provinces have arisen through convergence with Behdînî, Central Kurdish or Gorani. In principle all three have features that could have induced the development of such constructions.

Perfect constructions consisting of an invariable particle and past perfective form (39, 40, 41), e.g., J. Arbel *lā ʾəlyele*, correspond in structure to perfect constructions in *Qəltu* Arabic dialects (§16.3), in which an invariable particle, possibly a fossilised form of the deictic copula, is placed before the past perfective form, e.g., *kū-ṣər-tu* 'I have become.' These constructions are attested in NENA dialects in the Arbīl and Sulemaniyya provinces of Iraq. Arabic dialects with this type of perfect have been documented in Arbīl province, e.g., Jastrow (1990a), and presumably those NENA dialects of Sulemaniyya province, e.g., C. Sulemaniyya (41) that exhibit the feature were also in contact with such *Qəltu* Arabic dialects at some point in their history.

The Jewish NENA dialects in south-western Iran differ from other NENA dialects in that the perfect construction has an inflected copula that agrees with the object in transitive constructions. This appears to have developed by convergence with Gorani rather than Kurdish. Gorani in this region, e.g., Hewremî, has ergative perfect constructions with an inflected copula agreeing with the object (§16.2.3). There is no such agreement in the Kurdish dialects of the region, in which ergativity has decayed (Khan & Mohammadirad 2024b: 198).

The NENA perfect construction formed from the past stem inflected with direct suffixes (§16.1.6.3) may have been an internal development in such dialects, whereby the direct suffixes that are the inflection of the present stem have been extended to the past stem to express a present perfect. This development may, however, have been reinforced by matching *Qəltu* Arabic perfects in which the pivot of the construction is the past stem verbal form. Another reinforcing factor may have been the elimination of a structural distinction between the participle and the past stem in some Kurdish dialects in the area of the north-western sector of NENA (83) and in Zazaki (§16.2.4). The NENA constructions in questions are indeed attested in dialects of north-western periphery, such as C. Bohtan, C. Hertevin. It is also, however, attested in intransitive perfects on the north-eastern periphery of the Jewish Trans-Zab dialect area (e.g., J. Urmi, J. Rustaqa), which were not in contact with the aforementioned varieties of Iranian.

The functions of the NENA perfective and perfect correspond broadly to those of other languages of the area, in so far as can be established from the current state of documentation and description. The evidential function of the perfect that has been documented in NENA, Iranian and Armenian in the region parallels

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the evidential category in Azeri Turkish, which, although historically related to the perfect, forms a separate paradigm from the perfect (§16.5.2).

It appears that some NENA dialects use perfects more extensively in narratives than is attested in other languages. In Kurdish the perfect is used in narrations of historical events but not folktales. In Zazaki narrative perfects are only used in folksongs. The Armenian perfect is used in narratives only in digressions. In Azeri Turkic the evidential form is sporadically used in narratives for expressing the narrative background (§45). In some NENA dialects, by contrast, the perfect is regularly used as the main narrative verbal form in folktales.

One feature of the NENA narrative perfect is that in 3SG forms the copula is often omitted (Khan 2008c: 669). This has a parallel in the frequent omission of the 3SG copula in the perfect in several modern Armenian dialects, including Urmia and Salmast. It is also a feature of the Azeri Turkic 3sg perfect (§16.5.2).

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17 The expresssion of the future

17.1 NENA future

17.1.1 *bəd* prefix

17.1.1.1 Morphology

Dialects in the northern sector of the NENA dialect area and in the Mosul plain have a future construction that is derived historically from the deontic verb 'to want' and a subordinate complement. It is found in Christian and Jewish dialects. The Jewish dialects include those from the *Lišana Deni* subgroup and also dialects in the northern area of the Trans-Zab subgroup, such as J. Dobe, J. Urmi. For a map of the geographical distribution of the future particle, see Figure 17.1

The particle *bəd* is derived historically from the verb 'to want':

(1) **bāʿē* *d-qāṭel*
want.PRS.3SG.M SBRD-kill.PRS.3SG.M
'He wants to kill.'

The deontic verb has undergone morphological reduction and bonding through grammaticalisation. In the dialect of C. Barwar, for example, the basic form of the construction in slow careful speech is as follows with devoicing of the final */d/* of *bəd*:

(2) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a)
bət-qaṭəl
FUT-kill.PRS.3SG.M
'He will kill.'

The verb has been phonetically contracted and the subordinating complementiser has been affixed to the deontic form and devoiced. In some dialects there is no devoicing, e.g.,

(3) C. Qaraqosh (Khan 2002a)

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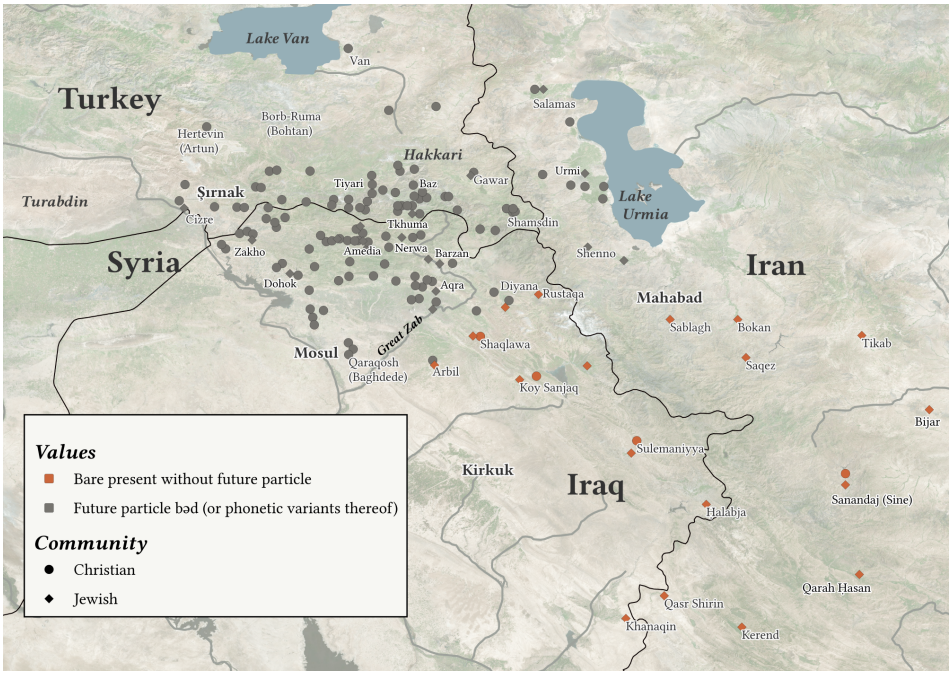

Figure 17.1: Distribution of the future particle *bəd* across NENA dialects

bəd-qaṭəl
FUT-kill.PRS.3SG.M
'He will kill.'

The process of grammaticalisation has reduced person distinctions in the deontic verb and the particle *bəd* is used before verbs of all persons:

(4) C. Barwar

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3SG.M	*bət-qaṭəl*	'he will kill'
3SG.F	*bət-qaṭla*	'she will kill'
3PL	*bət-qaṭli*	'they will kill'
2SG.M	*bət-qaṭlət*	'you (sg.m) will kill'
2SG.F	*bət-qaṭlət*	'you (sg.f) will kill'
2PL	*bət-qaṭlitu*	'you (pl) will kill'
1SG.M	*bət-qaṭlən*	'I (m) shall kill'
1SG.F	*bət-qaṭlən*	'I (f) shall kill'
1PL	*bət-qaṭləx*	'we (m) shall kill'

In normal fast speech, moreover, the particle undergoes further phonetic reduction, resulting in the following allomorphs:

(5) C. Barwar

b-garəš	'he will pull'
p-šate	'he will drink'
p̂ṯ-azəl	'he will go'
ṯ-azəl	'he will go'
t-yawənnax	'I shall give you'

Some dialects exhibit other phonetic shapes of the particle. In dialects on the Mosul plain, for example, it is sometimes reduced to *d-* before vowels, e.g., C. Qaraqosh *d-aθe* 'they will come' (Khan 2002a: 98). In J. Urmi it is reduced to the form *ba-* (Khan 2008b: 76).

For ease of reference, all such forms will be referred to as exemplars of the *bəd-qaṭəl* form.

In Jewish dialects in the Urmi region, the future may be expressed by the uncontracted 3SG.M present form of the verb 'to want', viz. *g-be* (DEIC-want.PRS.3SG.M), as well as the the contracted prefixes *b-* and *ba-*, e.g.,

(6) C. Urmi (Khan 2008b: 76)

a. *b-garəš*
FUT-pull.PRS.3SG.M
'He will pull.'

b. *ba-garəš*
FUT-pull.PRS.3SG.M
'He will pull.'

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c. *g-be* *garəš*
DEIC-want.PRS.3SG.M pull.PRS.3SG.M
'He will pull.'

d. *g-be* *garš-en*
DEIC-want.PRS.3SG.M pull.PRS-1SG.M
'I shall pull.'

The *bəd-qaṭəl* construction can be shifted into the past to express a future in the past by attaching the past-shifting affix *-wa*:

(7) C. Barwar (Khan 2008c)
bət-qaṭəl-wa
FUT-kill.PRS.3SG.M-PST
'He would kill.'

17.1.1.2 Function

17.1.1.2.19 Deontic

When the verb has an agentive 1SG subject the *bəd-qaṭəl* form generally has a sense expressing deontic intention, e.g.,

(8) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a: 599)
b-ṣàly-ən| *b-tápq-ən* *bìy-e.*|
FUT-pray.PRS-1SG.M FUT-meet.PRS-1SG.M on-him
'I shall go down, I shall meet him.'

The intention is typically to perform the action in the immediate future without hesitation, as shown by examples such as (9) and (10) with an adverbial or particle expressing immediacy:

(9) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a: 600)
hadíya b-zadr-án-na *gàn-i.*|
now FUT-shake.PRS-1SG.F-OBL.3SG.F self-my
'Now I am going to shake myself.'

(10) J. Barzan (Mutzafi 2002a: 59)
ha-b-xaz-ən-e
now-FUT-see.PRS-1SG.M-OBL.3SG.M
'Now I shall see him/I'll certainly see him immediately.'

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When the verb has an agentive 1PL subject, the form often has a cohortative sense ('Let's ...'), e.g.,

(11) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a: 600)
bas ṯ-áz-exi ṭalb-ə́x-la m-báb-a dìy-a.
but FUT-go-PRS-1PL ask.PRS-1PL-OBL.3SG.F from-father-her of-her
'But let us go down and ask her father for her hand in marriage.'

The *bəd-qaṭəl* form may express obligation. In such cases the verb generally has an agentive second person subject, e.g.,

(12) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a: 600)
ṯ-az-ítu qam-do-gə̀ppa b-qar-ìtu: ʾó Bə́lbəl Hazə̀r!
FUT-go.PRS-2PL before-OBL.DEM-cave FUT-call.PRS-2PL oh Bəlbəl Hazar
'You should go to the cave. You should cry "Oh Bəlbəl Hazar."'

Occasionally the form expresses obligation also in other persons, e.g.,

(13) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a: 600)
ṯ-ázəl ṭaláb-la m-be-báb-a dìy-a.
FUT-go.PRS.3SG.M ask.PRS.3SG.M-OBL.3SG.F from-house-father-her of-her
'He should go and ask her father's family for her hand.'

17.1.1.2.20 Predictive future

In many cases the construction does not have clear deontic force, but rather expresses a prediction of an eventuality that will happen in the future. This can be regarded as resulting from the grammaticalisation of the deontic construction, parallels to which are found in many languages. The core of this process involves a semantic extension whereby an implicature of the original deontic construction, in particular one with a third person subject, is incorporated into the meaning, e.g. he wants to go to town implies that it is likely that he will go (Bybee 2010: 55).

The predictive future function of the *bət-qaṭəl* construction is generally found where the subject of the verb is third person or where it is a non-agentive first or second person, e.g.,

(14) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a: 598)
b-nayə̀s-li ṯ-axə̀l-li.
FUT-bite.PRS.3SG.M-OBL.1SG FUT-eat.PRS.3SG.M-OBL.1SG
'He will bite me. He will eat me.'

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(15) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a: 1572)
ʾáni b-nɛs-í-le b-màyəθ
they FUT-bite.PRS-3PL-OBL.3SG.M FUT-die.PRS.3SG.M
'They will bite him. He will die.'

The future particle may be used when the event is in the immediate future, on the margin of the speech time. In some cases, indeed, the onset phase of the event may be taking place in the present.

(16) C. Ankawa (Khan, fieldnotes)
dà b-ázəl.
now FUT-go.PRS.3SG.M
'Now he will go (= He is about to go).'

The following construction in the J. Dobe dialect was documented when the referent of the subject had started to leave the room:

(17) J. Dobe (Khan, fieldnotes)
bd-èz.
FUT-go.PRS.3SG.M
'He is going (i.e,. he has started to go and the nuclear phase of the activity is in the immediate future).'

17.1.1.2.21 Conditional constructions

The *bəd-qaṭ̣əl* form is used in the apodosis of conditional sentences. In the majority of cases, it expresses an eventuality that is temporally sequential to a hypothetical situation in the future, e.g.,

(18) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a: 601)
ʾən-kpìn-ni, ṯ-axl-ə̀n-ne.
if-hunger.PST-OBL.1SG FUT-eat.PRS-1SG-OBL.3SG.M
'If am hungry, I shall eat it.'

(19) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a: 1004)
ʾən-ʾamr-ə́n-nux ʾáp-ʾati b-šàn-ət.
if-say.PRS-1SG.M-OBL.2SG.M also-you FUT-faint.PRS-2SG.M
'If I tell you, you will faint.'

In some cases, it expresses a future eventuality that follows logically from a given, real situation in the present denoted by the protasis clause, e.g.,

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(20) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a: 1008)
ʾən=íle xwarzày-i,| *ṯ-áθe*
if=COP.3SG.M nephew-my FUT-come.PRS.3SG.M
t-yăðé-la ʾánna mòdi=la.|
FUT-know.PRS.3SG.M-OBL.3PL what=COP.3PL
'If he is my nephew, he will come and he will know what these are.'

The form consisting of *bəd-* + present stem + past-shifting suffix *-wa* (represented here as *bəd-qaṭəlwa*), which expresses a 'future in the past' is typically used in the apodosis of conditional sentences that refer to a hypothetical condition in the past that was not fulfilled, e.g.,

(21) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a: 605)
ʾən-mbaqr-ət-wa,| *t-yaw-án-wa-lux zùze.*|
if-ask.PRS-2SG.M-PST FUT-give.PRS-1SG-PST-OBL.2SG.M money
'If you had asked, I would have given you money.'

17.1.1.2.22 Performative

In some NENA dialects the *bəd-qaṭəl* form is used with a performative function. This is found in the C. Qaraqosh dialect, e.g.,

(22) C. Qaraqosh (Khan 2002a: 315)
ʾána bəd-qár-ən šə́mm-ux Tòma.|
I FUT-call.PRS-1SG.M name-your Toma
'I (hereby) call your name Toma.'

(23) C. Qaraqosh (Khan 2002a: 315)
ʾána bəd-šóq-ən d-palṭ-ìtu.|
I FUT-allow.PRS-1SG.M SBRD-leave.PRS-2PL
'I (hereby) allow you to leave.'

In such constructions the *bəd-* prefix expresses the wish of the speaker to carry out the act but the reference time of the event coincides with speech time rather than being posterior to speech time, i.e., 'I wish to call your name Toma and am hereby doing so.'

17.1.1.2.23 Indefinite future

A deontic or predictive future expressed by the *bəd* prefix typically expresses a definite event time shortly after speech time. In some dialects, the construction

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can be modified to express an indefinite event by adding an suffix augment. The future forms in (24b) and (24d), for example, make a prediction that the event will take place at some unspecified time in the future:

(24) C. Mawana (Khan, fieldnotes)

a. *ṯ-azəl.*
FUT-go.PRS.3SG.M
'He will go (now).'

b. *ṯ-azəl-ni*
FUT-go.PRS.3SG.M-AUG
'He will go (at some point).'

c. *ṯ-az-ət.*
FUT-go-2SG.M
'You will go (now).'

d. *ṯ-az-et-ən*
FUT-go-2SG.M-AUG
'You will go (at some point).'

17.1.1.3 Negation of forms with *bəd-*

The negative particle *la* is, in principle, not used with the *bəd-qaṭəl* and *bəd-qaṭəlwa* forms. The negative of these future constructions is, rather, expressed by combining the negative particle with the habitual form. The habitual form has the prefix *k-* or *ʾi-* (see §18.1), e.g.,

(25) J. Dohok (Molin 2024: 187-188)

a. *b-šaqəl.*
FUT-take.PRS.3SG.M
'He will take.'

b. *k-šaqəl.*
DEIC-take.PRS.3SG.M
'He takes (habitually).'

c. *la k-šaqəl.*
NEG DEIC-take.PRS.3SG.M
'He does not take (habitually)/He will not take.'

(26) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a: 196)

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a. *ṯ-axl-ən.*
FUT-eat.PRS-1SG.M
'I shall eat.'

b. *y-axl-ən.*
COP-eat.PRS-1SG.M
'I eat (habitually).'

c. *la y-axl-ən.*
NEG COP-eat.PRS-1SG.M
'I do not eat (habitually)/I shall not eat.'

d. *b-šaqəl.*
FUT-take.PRS.3SG.M
'He will take.'

e. *ʾi-šaqəl.*
COP-take.PRS.3SG.M
'He takes (habitually).'

f. *la y-šaqəl.*
NEG COP-take.PRS.3SG.M
'He does not take (habitually)/He will not take.'

The */a/* vowel of the negative particle and the *ʾi-* prefix frequently coalesce, resulting in the raising of the */a/* and, in many cases, also contraction of the two vowels, e.g.,

(27) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a: 604)
le-y-axl-ena.
NEG-COP-eat.PRS-1SG.M
'I do not eat (habitually)/I shall not eat.'

(28) C. Meze (Khan, fieldnotes)

a. *bd-axəl.*
FUT-eat.PRS.3SG.M
'He will eat.'

b. *ʾi-d-axəl.*
COP-SBRD-eat.PRS.3SG.M
'He eats (habitually).'

c. *le-d-axəl.*
NEG-SBRD-eat.PRS.3SG.M
'He does not eat (habitually)/He will not eat.'

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17.1.1.4 Future expressed by realis forms with habitual prefix

Dialects spoken outside of the areas of the Mosul plain and the northern sector of NENA do not use the *bəd* future particle (or its phonetic variants). The functions of deontic and predictive future that are expressed by *bəd* constructions are rather expressed by the habitual form. In all dialects of this category the habitual is expressed by the *k-* prefix (or phonetic variants thereof), e.g.,

(29) J. Arbel (Khan 1999a: 250)

a. *g-ez-en.*
DEIC-go.PRS-1SG.M
'I go (habitually)/I shall go.'

b. *k-e.*
DEIC-come.PRS.3SG.M
'He comes (habitually)/he will come.'

c. *la g-ez-en.*
NEG DEIC-go.PRS-1SG.M
'I do not come (habitually)/I shall not come.'

d. *la k-e.*
NEG DEIC-come.PRS.3SG.M
'He does not come (habitually)/he will not come.'

(30) C. Shaqlawa (Khan, fieldnotes)

a. *k-at-ən.*
DEIC-come.PRS-1SG.M
'I come (habitually)/I shall come.'

b. *k-ate.*
DEIC-come.PRS.3SG.M
'He comes (habitually)/he will come.'

c. *la k-at-ən.*
NEG DEIC-go.PRS-1SG.M
'I do not come (habitually)/I shall not come.'

d. *la k-ate.*
NEG DEIC-come.PRS.3SG.M
'He does not come (habitually)/he will not come.'

The habitual form is used also with second and third person forms to express the will of the speaker, e.g.,

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(31) J. Arbel (Khan 1999a: 250)
geb-ì *k-awé-t.*
with-me DEIC-be.PRS-2SG.M
'You will be with me!' (= I want you to be with me.)

(32) J. Sulemaniyya (Khan 2004b: 286)
k-w-át-tu *xalè.*
DEIC-give.PRS-2SG.F-OBL.3PL food
'You will give them food.' (= I want you to give them food.)

In dialects that express the future by the habitual form, the first person form may be used to express the performative, e.g.,

(33) J. Sanandaj (Khan 2009: 277)
ʾaná *daʿwát* *k-ó-n-ox* *lelé* *pătiré* *hal*
I invitation DEIC-do.PRS-1SG.M-OBL.2SG.M night Passover come.IMP
lăxa.
here
'I (hereby) invite you to come here on the eve of Passover.'

17.1.1.5 Hybrid system *bəd* and habitual forms

The J. Urmi dialect exhibits a hybrid system in which the future can be expressed (i) by the future particle *b-/ba-*, which is a contraction of **bāʿē d-*, (ii) the uncontracted uninflected 3SG.M form of the verb 'to want' *g-be* placed before the verb, and (iii) a habitual form with, where phonotactically possible, a habitual prefix. There is a functional difference between these forms. A future with *b-/ba-* or *gbe* is more assertive than a future with a habitual particle. When using the constructions with *b-/ba-* or *gbe*, the speaker commits themselves fully to the truth of the assertion, whereas there is a lesser degree of commitment when using the latter form, e.g.,

(34) J. Urmi (Khan 2008b: 257)
a. *b-adé* *baqattà.*
FUT-come.PRS.3SG.M tomorrow
'He will (certainly) come tomorrow.'
b. *g-bé* *adé* *baqattà.*
DEIC-want.3SG.M come.PRS.3SG.M tomorrow
'He will (certainly) come tomorrow.'

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c. *g-dé* *baqattà.*|
DEIC-come.PRS.3SG.M tomorrow
'He will come tomorrow (as far as I know).'

In J. Urmi all of these types of future can be negated. The future particle *b-/ba-* and *g-be* are placed before the negator. The negative forms express the same range of degrees of assertiveness as the positive forms, e.g.,

(35) J. Urmi (Khan 2008b: 257)

a. *b-là* *adé.*|
FUT-NEG come.PRS.3SG.M
'He will certainly not come!'

b. *g-bé* *là* *adé.*|
DEIC-want.PRS-3SG.M NEG come.PRS.3SG.M
'He will certainly not come!'

c. *là* *g-dé.*|
NEG DEIC-come.PRS.3SG.M
'He will not come (as far as I know).'

17.1.1.6 Future expressed by irrealis forms with no marking

In all dialects, a deontic or predictive future may be expressed by the irrealis construction formed from the present stem without any prefix. There is not a complete overlap in function with the future forms expressed by the *bəd* particle or by habitual forms. In general, futures expressed by the irrealis form express an event that is further removed from speech time or certain reality than constructions with *bəd* or habitual forms.

First and second person deontic forms express a less immediate future, e.g.,

(36) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a: 574)

a. *ʾaz-ən.*
go.PRS-1SG.M
'I shall go.'

b. *ṯ-az-ən.*
FUT-go.PRS-1SG.M
'I shall go (immediately).'

(37) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a: 575)

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a. *ʾaz-ət.*
go.PRS-2SG.M
'You should go.'

b. *ṯ-az-ət.*
FUT-go.PRS-2SG.M
'You should go (immediately).'

When third person forms of the irrealis construction are used to express the predictive future, it is restricted to predictions that the speaker is not completely certain about and that he is not guaranteeing will be fulfilled, e.g.,

(38) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a: 577)
bálki ʾàθy-a.
perhaps come.PRS-3SG.F
'Perhaps she will come.'

In the J. Urmi dialect, in which a future form with a habitual particle expresses a lesser degree of assertion than a future form with a *bəd* particle (see 34), the irrealis form expresses a further reduction in commitment to the truth of the prediction, e.g.,

(39) J. Urmi (Khan 2008b: 257)

a. *bálki adé baqattà.*
perhaps come.PRS.3SG.M tomorrow
'Perhaps he will come tomorrow.'

b. *lá hamon-én adé baqattà.*
NEG believe.PROG-1SG.M come.PRS.3SG.M tomorrow
'I do not believe he will come tomorrow.'

When future constructions with the irrealis form are negated, they express less immediacy or less certainty than the corresponding negated forms of the *bəd* futures and futures formed from the habitual (both of which have the form of negated habituals, see §17.1.1.3).

(40) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a: 604-605)

a. *là ʾáxl-ən.*
NEG eat.PRS-1SG.M
'I shall not eat.'

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b. *lá y-áxl-ən.*
NEG COP-eat.PRS-1SG.M
'I shall not eat (now)'.

(41) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a: 604-605)
bálki là ʾáxl-ən.
perhaps NEG eat.PRS-1SG.M
'Perhaps I shall not eat.'

(42) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a: 578)
málla ṯ-axə̀l-la ʾaw-lá-ʾaxəl čú-mdi
mullah FUT-eat.PRS.3SG.M-OLB.3SG.F he-NEG-eat.PRS.3SG.M no-thing
sab-rùtɛ=la.
because-Friday=COP.3SG.F
'The mullah will eat it (now), he (the priest) will not eat (during the interval of the whole day) since it is Friday.'

17.1.2 Planned future

17.1.2.1 Active participle

In several NENA dialects in the northern sector and on the Mosul plain a construction consisting of a nominal active participle form and a copula is used to express a future event. These express a future event that is planned or in its preparatory phase and that the speaker is certain will occur.

In some dialects in which this construction is used, it is restricted to a small set of lexical verbs, which generally includes verbs of movement, such as 'to go', 'to come', 'to return' and the verb 'to remain'. This is the case, for example, in C. Urmi. In this dialect the construction is used with this restricted set of verbs to express an event that the speaker is expecting will occur at some unspecified time in the future and that the agent of the action is planning to or preparing to initiate. The construction is assertive in that the speaker is fully committed to the truth of the occurrence of the event, since, if the subject is first person the speaker is planning to undertake the action or if the subject is second or third person the speaker knows that the agent is planning to undertake the action. There is no commitment, however, to the time in which the event will happen, e.g.,

(43) C. Urmi (Khan 2016b: vol. 2, 228)

Proofreading version. Do not quote. Final version available from http://www.langsci-press.org

a. *ʾazànə=lə.*
go.APRT.SG.M=COP.3SG.M
'He is planning to/preparing to go (at some unspecified time in the future).'

b. *ʾatyànə=lə.*
come.APRT.SG.M=COP.3SG.M
'He is planning to/preparing to come (at some unspecified time in the future).'

c. *ʾána ⁺deránə=vən.*
I return.APRT.SG.M=COP.1SG.M
'I am planning to/preparing to return (at some unspecified time in the future).'

In C. Urmi, which has this construction, if the specific time is scheduled or if the event will take place immediately, then the *bəd-qaṭəl* form is used, e.g.,

(44) C. Urmi (Khan 2016b: vol. 2, 228)

a. *tíyyə=na ʾína ṭ-áz-i b-⁺saʾat ⁺ṭla.*
come.PPRT.PL=COP.3PL but FUT-go.PRS-3PL at-hour three
'They have come but they will go at three o'clock.'

b. *b-⁺der-ən.*
FUT-return.PRS-1SG.M
'I shall return (now).'

In J. Urmi the active participle is used in future constructions productively with a wider set of verbs, but only in negated futures. It expresses that the subject referent is not planning to initiate the event at any time in the future, e.g.,

(45) J. Urmi (Khan 2008b: 296)
ána xén ⁺mədráš ezána lèwen.
I again school go.APRT.SG.M NEG.COP.1SG.M
'I shall not go to school again. (= I am not planning to go/am not prepared to go, and so certainly will not go.)'

In (46) the construction is used in the protasis of a conditional construction to express a real situation:

(46) J. Urmi (Khan 2008b: 296)

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ăgár la-maqyantá hawy-á +šultána reš-àn
if NEG-speak.APRT.SG.F be.PRS-3SG.F king head-our
+b-qaté-le.|
FUT-cut.PRS.3SG.M-OBL.3SG.M
'If she will not speak, the king will cut off our head. (= Given that she is not planning to/prepared to speak, the king will cut off our head.)'

In some dialects, the future construction based on the active participle is used fully productively with a wide range of lexical verbs in both positive and negative clauses. This applies to some dialects on the Mosul plain, such C. Qaraqosh, C. Barəṭle and C. Telkepe (Coghill 2010b: 370-371; Coghill 2018: 260). In these dialects, as in the Urmi dialects, active participles are used to express an expected future action that is being planned and prepared for by the agent. It typically refers to an event that is expected and planned to take place in the near future at an unspecified point in time, e.g.,

(47) C. Qaraqosh (Khan, fieldnotes)

a. *k-ílə palàṭa.*|
DEIC-COP.3SG.M leave.APRT.SG.M
'He will (= he is planning to) go out.'

If it is combined with a punctual time adverbial, such as *daha* 'now', this refers to the time deixis of the preparatory phase of the event rather than the event time, e.g.,

(48) C. Qaraqosh (Khan, fieldnotes)
k-ílə paláṭa dàha.|
DEIC-COP.3SG.M leave.APRT.SG.M
'He is leaving now (= He is now in the preparatory phase of leaving but has not yet left).'

The construction may be used with transitive and ditransitive verbs, e.g.,

(49) C. Qaraqosh (Khan, fieldnotes)

a. *k-ílə paθáxa d-tăra.*|
DEIC-COP.3SG.M open.APRT.SG.M SBRD-door
'He is preparing to/about to open the door.'

b. *k-ílə paθáx-əḥ.*|
DEIC-COP.3SG.M open.APRT.SG.M-3SG.M
'He is preparing/about to to open it.'

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c. *k-ílə* *hawála* *d-pə́lsə* *da-bàxt-əḥ.*|
DEIC-COP.3SG.M give.APRT.SG.M SBRD-money to-wife-his
'He is preparing to/about to give money to his wife.'

d. *k-ílə* *hawál-ux* *d-kθàwa.*|
DEIC-COP.3SG.M give.APRT.SG.M-2SG.M SBRD-book
'He is preparing to/about to give you a book.'

The construction is negated by the negative copula, e.g.,

(50) C. Qaraqosh (Khan, fieldnotes)
lélə *palàṭa.*|
NEG.COP.3SG.M leave.APRT.SG.M
'He is not leaving. (= He is not preparing to leave).'

The participle may be combined with a past or future copula, e.g.,

(51) C. Qaraqosh (Khan, fieldnotes)

a. *ʾə́mma θí-li* *k-íwa* *palàṭa.*|
when come.PST-OBL.1SG DEIC-COP.PST.3SG.M leave.APRT.SG.M
'When I came, he was preparing to leave.'

b. *ʾə́mma bəd-ʾáθ-ən* *bəd-háwə* *palàṭa.*|
when FUT-come.PRS-1SG.M FUT-be.PRS.3SG.M leave.APRT.SG.M
'When I come, he will be preparing to leave.'

In the case of the verbs of movement 'to go' (*ʾ-z-l*) and 'to come' (*ʾ-θ-y*) there are two types of active participles, one used specifically for a planned future, viz. *ʾazala* and *ʾaθaya* (the normal pattern of active participles), and the other for the progressive, viz. *ʾazola* and *ʾaθoya*, e.g.,

(52) C. Qaraqosh (Khan, fieldnotes)

a. *k-ílə* *ʾazàla.*|
DEIC-COP.3SG.M go.APRT.SG.M
'He will (= he is planning to/preparing to) go.'

b. *k-ílə* *ʾazòla..*|
DEIC-COP.3SG.M go.APRT.SG.M
'He is going (now).'

c. *k-ílə* *ʾaθàya.*|
DEIC-COP.3SG.M come.APRT.SG.M
'He will (= he is planning to/preparing to) come.'

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d. *k-ílə* *ʾaθòya.*|
DEIC-COP.3SG.M come.APRT.SG.M
'He is coming (now).'

17.1.2.2 Progressive constructions

In some NENA dialects, constructions that normally have a progressive function are used to express planned events that the speaker is certain will take place, e.g.,

(53) C. Urmi (Khan 2016b: vol. 2, 189)
ʾà-šabta| *màlca*| *⁺pə́llan* *yùma,*| *⁺pə́llan* *⁺dàna,*|
this-week king such-and-such day such-and-such time
⁺pə́llan *⁺sàʾat*| *⁺plàṭə=lə*| *⁺ʾal-dà* *ʾúrxa.*|
such-and-such hour leave.PROG=COP.3SG.M to-OBL.DEIC.PROX road
'This week, the king, on such-and-such a day, at such-and-such a time, at such-and-such an hour, is going out on this journey.'

(54) J. Arbel (Khan 1999a: 267)
ʾəd-lel *lŭ-hulaʾè lā-qaṭl-í-lu.*|
this-night OM-Jews COP-kill.PRS-3PL-OBL.3PL
'Tonight they will (= are planning to) kill the Jews.'

(55) J. Arbel (Khan 1999a: 267)
lā-qaṭl-ə́x-xu.|
COP-kill.PRS-1PL-OBL.3PL
'We shall (= are planning to) kill them.'

17.1.3 Prospective

17.1.3.1 Past Form

In NENA dialects, the *qṭil-le* form (i.e., past stem + oblique subject marker) is prototypically used to express the past perfective. It may also express an event that has just taken place, on the margin of speech time, and witnessed by the speaker, e.g.,

(56) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a: 660)
dìya θé-le.|
now come.PST-OBL.3SG.M
'He has just now come.'

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This 'perfect of recent past' function of the *qṭil-le* presents a state that results from an immediately preceding event. Occasionally, the form is exploited to denote an event that the speaker is certain is about to take place in the immediate future by presenting the event as if the event, or at least the onset phase, has already happened. It can be regarded as the mirror image of the 'perfect of recent past', since it denotes a state that relates to an immediately future event rather than an immediately past event. This is referred to as prospective aspect (Comrie 1976: 64-65). It presents a future for which there is already evidence that it is going to happen (due to the occurrence of its onset phase), e.g.,

(57) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a: 616)
mít-li *m-kəpna.*
die.PST-OBL.3SG.M from-hunger
'I am about to die of hunger.' (= I am in a state of having completed the onset phase of dying.)

(58) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a: 616)
ʾána zìl-li *kəs-báb-i.*
I go.PST-OBL.1SG to-father-my
'I am about to go to my father.' (= I am in a state of having completed the onset phase of going.)

(59) C. Urmi (Khan 2016b: vol. 2, 146)
xáčča péš-a *ʾána puráḵ-li* *ctàva.*
little remain.PRS-3SG.F I finish.PST-OBL.1SG book
'I have almost finished the book.'

In dialects of the northern Mosul plain (Telkepe, Baṭnaya, Baqopa, Tisqopa, Alqosh) and in Karimlesh, lying to the south-east of Mosul, the prospective use of the past form of the verb 'to go' has become grammaticalised into an uninflected prefix before present-stem verb forms expressing prospective aspect (Coghill 2010b). In the C. Telkepe dialect, for example, the past form of the verb 'to go' can be used with prospective aspect in its independent form (60a), as an auxiliary inflected verb before an irrealis present-stem verb (60b) or it can be reduced to an uninflected prefix with the same meaning (60c):

(60) C. Telkepe (Coghill 2010b: 364)

a. *zi-lɒ* *l-šuqɒ.*
go.PST-OBL.3SG.F to-market
'She is about to go to the market.'

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b. *zi-lɒ* *napl-ɒ.*
go.PST-OBL.3SG.F fall.PST–3SG.F
'She is going to fall.'

c. *zi-napl-ɒ.*
PRSP-fall.PST–3SG.F
'She is going to fall.'

This prospective auxiliary can be used with a following past irrealis verb, which shifts the prospective aspect into the past, e.g.,

(61) C. Telkepe (Coghill 2010b: 369)
zi-lə *ʾaθe-wɒ* *la-wəllebə.*
go.PST-OBL.3SG.M come.PRS.3SG.M-PST NEG-he.was.able
'He was going to come, but he was not able.'

17.1.3.2 *qam*

In NENA dialects in the Cudi area of south-eastern Turkey, the prospective aspect is expressed by the preverbal particle *qam*. This is a fossilised, uninflected present stem form of the verb *q-y-m* 'to rise'. It is placed before an irrealis present stem verb, e.g.,

(62) C. Harbole (Khan, fieldnotes)
qam-ʾazəl.
rise.PRS-go.PRS.3SG.M
'He is about to go.'

In origin, this would have meant 'he is getting up to go,' i.e., he is in the onset phase of going, indicating that there is evidence that he will go in the immediate future. This was then extended to denote the prospective when there is no act of rising, e.g.,

(63) C. Harbole (Khan, fieldnotes)

a. *qam-ʾate.*
rise.PRS-come.PRS.3SG.M
'He is about to come (he is on the road and nearly here).'

b. *qam-napəl.*
rise.PRS-fall.PRS.3SG.M
'He is about to fall (by accident, without his agency).'

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The construction with *qam* can be used also to express the perfect of immediate past, which is the mirror image of the original prospective meaning, e.g.,

(64) C. Harbole (Khan, fieldnotes)
qam-max-ən-ne.
rise.PRS-hit.PRS-1SG.M-OBL.3SG.M
'I am about to hit him/I have just hit him.'

A verb with prospective *qam* may be used with past time reference by combining the verb with the past-shifting suffix *-wa*, e.g.,

(65) C. Harbole (Khan, fieldnotes)
qam-ʾat-ə̀x-wa,| *bál là té-lan.*|
rise.PRS-come.PRS-1PL-PST but NEG comePST-OBL.1PL
'We were about to come (we were expected to come), but we did not come.'

17.1.3.3 Inflected form of the verb 'to want'

In some dialects that do not use the *bəd* particle to express the future, an inflected form of the verb 'to want' may be used to express an event that is about to happen. This usage appears to be restricted to non-agentive subjects, as shown in the following examples. In (66a) and (67a), in which the main verb is non-agentive, the construction has a prospective meaning, whereas in (66b) and (67b), in which the main verb is agentive, the construction is deontic:

(66) C. Shaqlawa (Khan, fieldnotes)

a. *k-ə̆be* *nàpəl.*|
DEIC-want.PRS.3SG.M fall.PRS.3SG.M
'He is about to fall.'

b. *k-ə̆be* *ʾàxəl.*|
DEIC-want.PRS.3SG.M eat.PRS.3SG.M
'He wants to eat.'

(67) J. Rustaqa (Khan 2002b: 407)

a. *lā-ʾaboʾé=la* *yadl-à.*|
COP-want.PROG-COP.3SG.F give.birth.PRS-3SG.F
'She is about to give birth.'

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b. *lā-ʾaboʾé=la ʾaxl-à.*
COP-want.PROG-COP.3SG.F eat.PRS-3SG.F
'She wants to eat.'

17.1.3.4 Temporal particles

Across the NENA dialects a variety of particles that are temporal adverbials in origin are combined with a verb to express the prospective. These include particles such as *da* (68) and *di* (69), both of which mean, or originally meant, 'now':

(68) C. Ankawa (Khan, fieldnotes)
da-bd-azəl.
now-FUT-go.PRS.3SG.M
'He is about to go.'

(69) C. Alqosh (Coghill 2010b: 371)
di-za-lə.
now-FUT-go.PRS-OBL.3SG.M
'He is about to go.'

C. Barwar and Lower Ṭyare dialects prefix the particle *ga* (< **gaya* 'time'), e.g.,

(70) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a: 583)
ga-t-maṭ-əx.
time-SBRD-arrive.PRS-1PL
'(It is) the time that we shall arrive.' (= We are about to arrive.)

17.1.3.5 Contrastive epistemic particle

The C. Shaqlawa dialect uses the particle *na* with a progressive form to express a prospective. The general function of *na* in the C. Shaqlawa dialect is 'epistemic contrastive focus.' It corrects what the speaker assumes the hearer believes or presupposes to be the case. It reverses the polarity of a proposition that the speaker assumes the hearer holds (Khan 2022b: 212), as shown in (71). In origin, the particle appears to be an invariable, fossilised form of the copula:

(71) C. Shaqlawa (Khan 2022b: 214)

a. *Yáwsəp lèwe bitáya.*
Yawsəp NEG.COP.3SG.M come.PROG
'Yawsəp is not coming.'

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b. *na-bitàye=le.*
COP-come.PROG=COP.3SG.M
'He IS coming (contrary to your belief).'

The construction *na-bitaye=le* can also be used as a prospective with the meaning 'He is about to come.' This appears to be through the use of the particle to express a scalar form of epistemic contrastive focus, 'He IS coming (contrary to your belief) and is even almost here.' See also (72):

(72) C. Shaqlawa (Khan 2022b: 214)
na-bənpàle=le.
COP-fall.PROG=COP.3SG.M
'He is about to fall.'

The particle *na* can also be combined with the prospective construction with the verb 'to want' (§17.1.3.3) to express greater immediacy of the future, e.g.,

(73) C. Shaqlawa (Khan 2022b: 223)

a. *k-ə̌be* *nàpəl.*
DEIC-want.PRS.3SG.M fall.PRS.3SG.M
'He is about to fall.'

b. *na-k-ə̌be* *nàpəl.*
COP-DEIC-want.PRS.3SG.M fall.PRS.3SG.M
'He is just about to fall.'

17.2 Expression of the future in Iranian

Future tense exists as a distinct grammatical category in Northern Kurdish and Zazaki. In both of these, an uninflected and invariable particle is used with the subjunctive form of the verb. This particle is *dê* in Behdînî NK and an enclitic =ê (and its phonological variants *wê* and *yê*) in the rest of NK. Central Kurdish normally uses the indicative present verb form to express the future, though there is an emergent predictive future construction based on the modal use of the verb *wîstin* 'to want'. The use of the present indicative is an option for expressing future in all Kurdish varieties with probably some differences with the distinct future tense expression in terms of modality.

Geographically, thus, a future tense particle exists in all of the NK-speaking locations of Iraq, starting from the immediate east of Rawanduz (i.e., Diyana/Soran)

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to Barzan, Akre through Sheikhan to the Mosul plain, as well as all NK-speaking areas of Iran to the east and north of Urmia and all of the NK dialects in Syria and Turkey. Although a future tense particle does not exist in Harir-Shaqlawa and Erbil, as these are entirely CK-speaking nowadays, it is highly likely that these were NK-speaking areas several centuries ago.

17.2.1 Future in Northern Kurdish

There are two main future tense formations in NK dialects.

17.2.1.1 Behdînî-type *dê* particle

In Behdînî NK, the future tense particle *dê* is used with the subjunctive form of the verb, but the verb is normally without the subjunctive prefix *bi-*.

(74) Zakho (MacKenzie 1962: 202)
gundî jî dê ç-in.
villager also FUT go.PRS-3PL
'The villagers also will go.'

(75) Amadiye (MacKenzie 1962: 322)
tu dê vî heywan-î firoş-î.
you FUT this animal-M.SG.OBL sell.PRS-2SG
'Will you sell this animal?'

This particle is found in all the core Behdînî dialects, as well as throughout Hakkari province. It is thus found from east of Rawanduz and south of Urmia all the way to Duhok and south of Van Lake (cf. , Matras et al. 2016: K-024 Tatvan, S27). However, in the border locations between Behdînî and northern NK dialects, such as Zakho and Tatvan, the *dê* particle alternates with *ê*:

(76) Zakho (MacKenzie 1962: 202)
ez=ê ç-im nêçîr-ê.
I=FUT go.PRS-1SG hunting-F.SG.OBL
'I will go hunting.'

In some dialects such as Tatvan and Gever the consonant of the particle is devoiced to *t*, resulting in the form *tê* (cf. Matras et al. 2016: K-024 Tatvan, S27).

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17.2.1.2 Kurmanji-type *=ê (wê, yê, ew=ê)*

In the rest of NK/Kurmanji, an enclitic *=ê* is used for the future tense with the subjunctive form of the verb, e.g.,

(77) Kurmanji (Bedir Khan & Lescot 1970: 168)
ez=ê bi-şo-m.
I=FUT SBJV-wash.PRS-1SG
'I will wash (it).'

Here too, in Mardin and Zakho dialects the subjunctive prefix is dropped while in the rest of the dialects it is usually present. Even in the Mardin dialect the subjunctive prefix can be present but it is not yet clear if there are any principled reasons behind the alternation:

(78) Ṭur ʿAbdin NK (Ritter 1969: 2)
hemû wê dilop k-in.
all FUT droplet do.PRS-3PL
'(If they do not use the roller on their roofs,) all will leak.'

(79) Ṭur ʿAbdin NK (Ritter 1969: 92)
a. *ez=ê ç-im=e pêşy-a xelk-ê*
I=FUT go.PRS-1SG=DRCT before-of people-F.SG.OBL
'I will go before the people.'
b. *ez=ê xelk-ê bi-kuj-im*
I=FUT people-F.SG.OBL SBJV-kill.PRS-1SG
'I will kill people.'

According to Unger (2024), the future tense particle in NK also contributes a certain modal interpretation to the proposition. Most importantly, the use of the future tense particle implies that the speaker commits to the factuality and plausibility of the future events and situations, even in cases where the event in question is not verifiable. Although Unger claims this only for the Behdînî *dê* particle, it appears that the epistemic commitment to the truth conditions of the proposition is involved in the use of both particles. Accordingly, for instance, adverbs such as *belkî* 'perhaps', which reduce the speaker's certainty, are incompatible with the future tense in Kurdish.

In addition to such adverbs implying uncertainty, the indicative present can also be used to express future events without firm commitment to the truth conditions of the event:

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(80) Shamdinan NK (field notes)

a. *ew sibe t-ê-t.*
he tomorrow IND-come.PRS-3SG
'He comes/will come tomorrow.'

b. *ew dê sibe b-ê-t.*
he FUT tomorrow SBJV-come.PRS-3SG
'He will (I am sure) come tomorrow.'

17.2.1.3 Future in the past

To express a future in the past ('present imperfect', MacKenzie 1961a: 180), Behdînî dialects use another related particle *da* with present tense conjugation of the verb, likewise lacking the subjunctive prefix:

(81) Behdînî NK (MacKenzie 1961a: 190)
da kev-im.
PRT fall.PRS-1SG
'I would fall.'

In Kurmanji, where the *=ê* future is used, the past conditional verb form is used with the invariant *=ê* future tense particle:

(82) Kurmanji (field notes)

a. *ez=ê bi-ket-a-m-a.*
I=PRT SBJV-fall.PST-COND-1SG-PST
'I would fall.'

b. *ez=ê ket-i-ba-m-a.*
I= fall.PST-PTCP-IRR.PST-1SG-PST
'I would fall.'

17.2.1.4 Negation of the future tense

The future tense particle is not used with negation. The negation of the Behdînî future tense with *dê* is expressed by a negated indicative present:

(83) Behdînî NK (MacKenzie 1962: 306-307)
ez qis-a te na-şkîn-im.
I word-EZ.F your NEG-break.PRS-1SG
'I will not go against what you say.'

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According to Bedir Khan & Lescot (1970: 169), the Kurmanji future with the *=ê* particle is, likewise, negated by a negative indicative present, e.g.,

(84) Kurmanji (Bedir Khan & Lescot 1970: 169)

a. *em=ê bi-kev-in.*
we=FUT SBJV-fall.PRS-3PL
'We will fall.'

b. *em na-kev-in.*
we NEG-fall.PRS-3PL
'We will not fall'

Indeed, there are no instances of negative future tense in the existing spoken texts in Kurmanji (e.g., Ritter 1976, Sträuli 2021) that we have been able to identify. Instead, the present indicative is used for expressing negation in future tense:

(85) Ṭur ʿAbdin NK (Ritter 1976: 8)
ez suwar na-b-im.
I mount NEG-be.PRS-1SG
'I will not mount (the donkey).'

Nowadays, however, it is very common to use the negation with the future tense particle, especially in the written language, e.g.,

(86) Kurmanji (CCKT Corpus)
wê tu car ne-gih-ê miraz û meqsed-an.
FUT any time NEG-reach.PRS-3SG desire and purpose-PL.OBL
'He will never reach his aims.'

17.2.1.5 Grammaticalization of the future tense particle in NK

There are no studies dealing with the origin and grammaticalisation of the future tense particles *dê* and *=ê* in Kurdish. One possible source for the *dê* form is the modal usage of the verb *viyan* 'to want, to need'. Its present tense stem is *vê-* while its past tense stem is *viya-*:

(87) Behdînî NK
min xanî-yek di-vê-t di-viya
I house-INDF IND-want.PRS-3SG IMPF-want.PST.3SG
'I want a house / I wanted a house'

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The form *dê* in this case would be a contracted and reduced form of *divêt*, also attested in the form *divê*. As the modal usage of the verb is only inflected for 3SG, the process of its grammaticalization into a future tense particle does not require any further reduction of person marking.

One fact that supports this hypothesis is that there is a modal particle *da* in Behdînî dialects that is used in analogous functions in the past domain (Haig & Öpengin 2018: 204). This particle would then be the contracted form of the past conjugation of the verb *viyan* 'want, need'.

The enclitic form *=ê* of Kurmanji, in this case, would be the reduced form of *dê*. In fact, as MacKenzie (1961b: 180) noted, both the *dê* and *da* forms are reduced in western Behdînî dialects of Zakho and Gulli to *=ê* and *=a* and this is also attested in Hakkari dialects.

There are several caveats with this analysis, though. First, as a typical sensory verb, *viyan* 'to need, to want, to love' requires an experiencer in the oblique case in all tenses (i.e., it forms a so-called non-canonical construction), whereas the future tense particle *dê* does not have such requirements. This may be a regularisation as a result of its grammaticalisation. Second, if the verb *viyan* was the source, it would be expected to be able to take the complementiser *ku*, since such matrix verbs and modal verbs require complement clauses that may or may not be linked with the complementiser. Again, the lack of complementiser may be the result of grammaticalisation.

Another possible source could be the verb *hatin* 'to come', with its present stem *hê-* and past stem *hat-*, though this is in need of elaboration (see below).

17.2.2 Future tense in Central Kurdish

The usual way to express the future in all dialects of Central Kurdish is by the present tense without a dedicated future particle, as illustrated for the affirmative and negative in (88):

(88) Sulemaniyya CK (MacKenzie 1962: 14-15)

a. *sibeynê hazir b-e, e-ç-în bo raw./*
tomorrow ready be.PRS-IMP IND-go.PRS-1PL to hunting
'Be ready tomorrow, we shall go hunting.'

b. *car-êk-î ke min na-bîn-in-ewe.*
time-INDF-EZ other I NEG-see.PRS-2PL-ASP
'You will not see me again.'

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17.2.3 Emergent future with 'want'

In some Central Kurdish dialects a conjugated form of the verb *wîstin* 'to want' is sometimes used as a modal to express a particular type of future. In (89a), the speaker utters the sentence after looking at the sky and inferring that it is likely to rain. The sentence (89b) can be interpreted both as a desire or a decision, in the latter case the verb would be expressing future.

(89) Mukri CK (Öpengin 2016: 83)

a. *de=y-hewê* *bi-bar-ê.*
IND=3SG-want.PRS.3SG SBJV-rain.PRS-3SG
'It will rain.'

b. *de=m-hewê* *dewr-î* *êran-ê* *lê-de-m.*
IND=1SG-want.PRS around-EZ Iran-OBL PVB-give.PRS-1SG
'I will/want to go for a tour around Iran (for one whole year).'

17.2.4 Other expressions of future in Kurdish

17.2.4.1 Prospective

Kurdish dialects have a wide range of strategies for expressing the prospective aspect, that is to express the sense of 'about to'.

17.2.4.1.24 *Wext* 'time'

Most common are constructions with the Arabic loanword *wext* 'time'. CK and NK dialects combine *wext* with the present or past copula:

(90) NK & CK (field notes)
wext-e *bi-mir-im.*
time-COP.3SG SBJV-die.PRS-1SG
'I am about to die.'

(91) Shamdinan NK
wext bû *bi-kev-ît.*
time be.PST.3SG SBJV-fall.PRS-3SG
'He was about to fall.'

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17.2.4.1.25 *Hatin* 'to come'

In some Behdînî dialects, such as Shamdinan, the verb *hatin* 'to come' in past imperfective can express the prospective aspect 'about to' (see Kuteva et al. 2019 for more on this path of grammaticalisation):

(92) Shamdinan NK (field notes)
ez di-hat-im bi-peq-im ji kerb-a.
I IND-come.PRS-1SG SBJV-explode.PRS-1SG from anger-obl.pl
'I was about to explode out of anger.' (lit. I was coming to explode out of anger.)

17.2.4.1.26 *Kirin* 'to do'

In more central and western NK dialects (but not in Behdînî dialects), the prospective is expressed by the verb *kirin* 'to do' used as a modal verb combining with a subjunctive verb. It also expresses 'having intention', e.g.,

(93) NK (field notes)
di-k-e ji mal der-kev-e.
IND-do.PRS.3SG from home PVB-fall.PRS-3SG
'He is about to leave home.'

(94) NK (popular song)
di-k-im her-im xerîbi-yê
IND-do.PRS-1SG go.SBJV-1SG foreign-F.SG.OBL
'I am intending to leave for foreign lands.'

In the south-western dialects of Suruc-Kobani-Afrin, this modal verb has been reduced and further grammaticalised into an invariable, uninflected form *kê* (sometimes *ekê* or *ikê*), which is used more generally for expressing future.

(95) Suruc-Afrin NK (field notes)
ez kê her-im gund.
I FUT go.SBJV-1SG village
'I will go to village.'

17.2.4.1.27 Demonstrative

Both NK and CK employ the singular demonstrative pronoun, *eve* in NK and *(e)wa* in CK, to form prospective aspect:

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(96) Behdînî NK (field notes)
eve *ez hat-im.*
DEM.PROX I come.go.PST-1SG
'I am coming right now.'

(97) Central Kurdish
wa *d-ê-m.*
DEM IND-come.PRS-1SG
'It is about to fall.'

17.2.5 Suffix augment *-in*

In the present conjugation of verbs in the future tense, present indicative and subjunctive, a 3SG verb ending with *-t* can have an augment suffix with the form *-in*, e.g.,

(98) Behdînî NK
a. *ev* *şev-e* *dê* *ç-ît*
this night-PROX FUT go.PRS-3SG
'(When will he go?) Tonight he will go.'
b. *dê* *ç-ît-in.*
FUT go.PRS-3SG-AUG
'(What will he do?) He will go.'

The exact semantic contribution of this suffix is unclear, but it seems to be adding some distance to the event or reducing the certainty, thus epistemically implying lack of commitment to the proposition or to the event time. It is used mostly at the end of prosodic units and is generally not used in the verb of the first clause in a coordinated sequence of verbs. The augment, therefore, also marks the prosodic unit boundary.

(99) Barwar NK (MacKenzie 1961a: 205)
eve *kafir-ek-î* *t-ê-t-in*
DEM.PROX infidel-INDF-EZ IND-come.PRS-3SG-AUG
'Look a monster is coming.'

This augment is found in the CK dialects of Erbil and the Behdînî dialects of NK from Zakho through Amadiye and Akre to Shamdinan and southern Urmia (including Targavar).

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17.2.6 Expression of the future in Zazaki

In many dialects of Zazaki, the simple present is used to express the future. Some dialects, however, preserve a dedicated future tense, formed by one of two strategies.

17.2.6.1 Subject-bound copula + subjunctive verb

The copula attaches to the subject, just as in the progressive, while the verb appears in the present subjunctive. This strategy is attested only in some Northern dialects, and even there is limited, since the future is typically expressed with the present stem, e.g.,

(100) Future in Northern Zazaki (Keskin 2008: 82)
emser ez=o şêr-î.
this.year 1SG=COP.1SG go.SBJV-1SG
'This year, I will go.'

17.2.6.2 Second-position clitic + subjunctive verb

A future particle occurs in second position, followed by the verb in the subjunctive. This construction is characteristic of Central and Southern Zazaki. The particle has the form *do* in Southern dialects and *ko*, *go* or *ro* in Central dialects, e.g.,

(101) Future in Central and Southern Zazaki

a. (CZ, Paul 2024: 180)
Hesen ko bêr-o.
Hasan FUT come.SBJV-3SG.M
'Hasan will come.'

b. (SZ, Paul 2024: 128)
ez do şêx ba.
1SG FUT sheikh be.SBJV.1SG
'I will be a Sheikh.'

17.2.6.3 Future in the past

The future particle can also combine with the past subjunctive, especially in conditional contexts, to express irrealis.

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(102) Conditional with the future particle (SZ, Paul 2024: 156)
eke şans-ê ma bi-bîya-yê, pî-yê ma do genc
if chance-EZ.M 1PL SBJV-be.PST-IPFV father-EZ.M 1PL FUT young
nê-merd-ê.
NEG-die.PST-IPFV
'If we had had luck, our father would not have died young.'

17.2.6.4 Prospective

Similar to Kurmancî, Zazaki employs the verb *kerdene* 'to do' as a modal auxiliary, followed by a verb in the subjunctive, to indicate prospective actions or intentions. Often, the subordinator particle *ke* is inserted between the modal and the lexical verb.

(103) Prospectives with 'to do' (fieldwork)
o ken-o ke şêr-o
3SG do.PRS-3SG.M SBRD go.SBJV-3SG.M
'He intends to go/He is about to go.'

17.3 Expression of the future in Arabic

Most *Qəltu* Arabic dialects, including the ones in and around the NENA-speaking region, express the future with the Prefix Conjugation preceded by a particle apparently derived from Old Arabic *ḥattā* 'so that' (Jastrow 1978: 302), namely *ta-* or *tə-*. A variant, *də-*, found in Siirt dialects, may also have the same origin. In and around Mosul, a form derived from the active participle of the verb 'to go' (**rāyiḥ*) is used, as also in all three Baghdad dialects (Blanc 1964, 117–118) and in Levantine dialects. For documented forms see Tables 17.1 and 17.2

Table 17.1: Arabic future particles within the NENA area

Mosul	*ġayyəḥ* (Procházka 2019b: 252) < active participle of verb 'to go', *də-kawi* (*də-*) (Jastrow 1979: 47)
Bəḥzāni (C, Y, M)	*tə-* (Jastrow 1978: 302)
Mērgi (C)	*ġāḥ*, *tə-* (Hassan 2023: 583)
Səndōṛ (J)	*tə-* (Jastrow 1991b: 775)
Arbīl and ʿAqra (J)	*tə-* (Jastrow 1990a: 65)

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Table 17.2: Arabic future particles on the periphery of the NENA area

Āzəx (C)	*tə-* (Wittrich 2001: 73)
Siirt town (M)	*də-* (Biţună 2016b: 227)
Tillo (M)	*ta- ~tə- ~da- ~də-* (Lahdo 2009: 166-167)

17.4 Expression of the future in Armenian

17.4.1 Future with 'want'

After the loss of the Classical Armenian future, in Middle Armenian the verb *kamim* 'I want' was used with the infinitive of the lexical verb to form future periphrases (Acharyan 1961: 131). The infinitive could either follow or precede *kamim*, as seen in (104).

(104) Middle Armenian (Acharyan 1961: 131)
sir-el *kam-im*
love-INF want-PRS.1SG
'I will love.'

(105) Middle Armenian (Acharyan 1961: 131)
kam-im *sir-el*
want-PRS.1SG love-INF
'I will love.'

This construction has left few traces in the modern dialects. Hamshen dialect has a form *kmer t^{h}ə* < *kamer t'e* (3SG imperfect of *kamim* + conjunction), a type of future past, but it is uncertain whether this represents a continuation of the Middle Armenian form (Acharyan 1961: 131). Hamshen dialect also has a form *gomoŕ* < CA *kamer*, which is used with the future particle *bidi* < *piti* (see §17.4.3) to mean that something almost happened (106).

(106) Hamshen Armenian (Acharyan 1961: 141)
gomoŕ g^{h}əl-eji *bidi*
PTCL slip-IPF.SBJV.1SG FUT
'I almost slipped.' (lit. 'It wanted that I would slip.')

Future forms with the verb *uzel* 'want' have arisen, presumably independently, in a few modern Armenian dialects. In Nor Jugha (New Julfa, the Armenian

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quarter of Isfahan), we find the future form *mam xaɣam* 'I will play', past *mi xaɣi* 'I would play', etc. (Acharyan 1961: 147)). This is derived from the present and imperfect tenses of the verb 'to want' plus the present or past subjunctive of the lexical verb (107), and was synchronically perceived as such, as explained by Acharyan's 11-year-old consultant. Acharyan (1961: 147) compares these to Persian future forms such as *xāham xôrd* etc.

(107) Nor Jugha Armenian (Acharyan 1961: 147)
mam xaɣ-am < uz-um=am xaɣ-am.
FUT.1SG play-1SG < want-I.PTCP=be.1SG.PRS play-PRS.SBJV.1SG
'I will play.'

(108) Nor Jugha Armenian (Acharyan 1961: 147)
mi xaɣ-i < uzum=i xaɣ-i.
FUT.PST.1SG play-1SG < want-I.PTCP=be.PST.1SG play-IPF.SBJV.1SG
'I would play.'

In Marash dialect, the usual future is derived from *piti* (see §17.4.3), but there is also an "immediate future" formed with the verb *izil* 'want' (109).

(109) Marash Armenian (Acharyan 1961: 147)
g-iz-im biɾ-i
PTCL-want-PRS.1SG bring-?PTCP
'I will bring immediately.'

In Suceava dialect, there is a form with *uzel* 'want' + subjunctive (110), which is now only used for past future (the general future form is derived from *piti* + conjunction *or*, see §17.4.3), but Acharyan (1961: 143) suggests that it may once have had general (future) use in this dialect. Note that futures formed with 'want' + subjunctive are considered to be one of the characteristics of the Balkan Sprachbund.

(110) Suceava Armenian (Acharyan 1961: 143)
g-uz-ei dzedz-im.
PTCL-want-IPF.1SG beat-PRS.SBJV.1SG
'I would beat.'

17.4.2 *kə*-forms as future

The forms with the particle *ku* + subjunctive (< CA present) that developed in Middle Armenian (see §18.6) were used for future as well as present (Acharyan

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1961: 131). Most modern Armenian dialects have developed new present and/or future forms so that it is possible to distinguish between present and future. In general, in Western Armenian dialects, the *kə-* < *ku* forms are used for present tense, while for future tense, forms derived from *piti* are used (see §17.4.3), while in Eastern Armenian, new present tense forms have been created, and the main use of the *kə*-forms is future/conditional (111).

(111) SEA
k-as-em.
PTCL-say-PRS.1SG
'I will say.'

(112) SEA
k-as-ei
PTCL-say-IPF.1SG
'I would say.'

However, in some Eastern dialects, the *kə*-forms may be used for present in certain circumstances (in particular, narrative and/or habitual, see sections 20.6, 18.6), and in some Western dialects, including Mush (Baghdasaryan-Tapaltsyan 1958: 120), they may be used to express future as well as present meanings.

As discussed in §18.6 (Habitual), the *kə*-prefix is not used for negative forms. Instead, a different periphrasis is used, derived from the Classical Armenian locative of the infinitive (preposition *i* + accusative (zero) ending) plus the negative auxiliary (113). In a group of dialects that can be said to occupy a "central" position in geographical terms (Ararat including SEA, Mush, Van, Urmia), the preposition *i* has been lost, the lexical verb has lost the final *-l* of the infinitive, and the thematic vowel *e* > *i*, creating an innovative "negative participle'' (113).

(113) Middle Armenian
čʿ-em *i* *as-el.*
NEG-be.PRS.1SG LOC say-INF
'I do not/will not say.'

(114) SEA
čʿem *as-i*
NEG-be.PRS.1SG say-NEG.PTCP
'I will not say.'

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In Agulis and Meghri dialects, the *-l* of the infinitive is retained (115), and a parallel form is used for the affirmative (116), instead of the *kə*-forms, thus in these dialects, future is expressed by a participle that is, for consonant-initial verbs, identical to the infinitive + auxiliary. The preposition *i* is lost, but in Agulis, a prefix *n-*, assumed to be of locative origin (Acharyan 1935: 263, Sargsianc‘ 1883: 113-4),[1] is added to vowel-initial verbs, distinguishing this participle from the true infinitive. Thus the participle used in the Agulis equivalent of the *kə*-forms can be analysed as the infinitive plus a locative element.

(115) Agulis Armenian (Sargsianc‘ 1883: 119)
n-ah-il=əm.
LOC-say-INF=be.1SG
‘I will say.’

(116) Agulis Armenian
n-ah-il *ʧʰ-im.*
LOC-say-INF NEG-be.1SG
‘I will not say.’

17.4.3 Future with *piti*

The main future form in Western Armenian dialects is derived from *piti*, originally an impersonal verb meaning ‘there is need to’ (see §12.4). In the many Western dialects, including SWA, which have voicing of the CA voiceless unaspirated stops and affricates, it is pronounced *bidi*.

(117) SWA (Sakayan 2012: 197)
t‘atron piti ert‘-ank‘
theatre FUT go-PRS.SBJV.1PL
‘We will go to the theatre.’

In many of the dialects where *piti* has become an invariable particle, it has become phonetically reduced. Acharyan (1961: 146) notes that it has the form *ti*

[1] Acharyan (1935: 263) and Sargsianc‘ (1883: 113-4) link it with the root *ner-* ‘in, under’ used by the Hellenophile grammarians as a locative preposition or prefix in imitation of Greek *εν*. This root is also found in modern dialects as an adposition, adverb, or preverb, which has the form *ni* in some dialects, including Karabagh, Ararat, Tbilisi, and Hamshen. Although it does not seem to be productive in Agulis itself, it appears as a preverb in two expressions given by Zak‘aryan (2008), implying that it may once have been: *ni gyl* ‘to hurt (tr.), upset (lit. in/under come)’, *ni tol* ‘to eat greedily (lit. in/under give)’.

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from Ghazakh (in northern Azerbaijan, near Tovuz) to Akn (south-east of Sebastia), and *bi* from Sebastia to Hungary. In the dialects of Moks, Vozmi, and Shatakh, which Jahukyan (1972) places in the Van dialect group, it has been reduced to *tə* or *t* (Acharyan 1961: 146, Muradyan 1962). In Urmia (Asatryan 1962) and Salmast (Vaux 2022) we find the form *ti*, as well as *tikʲi, təkʲi, tikʲə*.[2] None of these authors discuss any differences in use between *ti* and *tikʲi* etc. The fact that Urmia Armenian *ti* seems to be the same type of extremely reduced form that we find in dialects of the Van area implies that here, too, it may have functioned as a future particle. This is supported by evidence from a native speaker consultant, who, when asked for examples of how she would use the form (*kətə* in the Karaglukh subdialect), produced sentences describing future plans, as seen in (118).

(118) Urmia Armenian (Karaglukh) (Hodgson field notes)
Amar-ə kətə etʰ-am Tsaxkadzoɾ.
summer-DEF PTCL go-PRS.1SG Tsaghkadzor (well-known tourist resort)
'In the summer I will go to Tsaghkadzor.'

However, all the examples of *ti* in the texts of Asatryan (1962) are in a text translated from SEA, and they all translate *petkʿ ē* 'there is need'. The examples of *təkʲi* in non-translated texts (there are no examples of *ti*) also seem to express deontic modality, as usual in Eastern dialects, rather than simple future (119), while future is generally expressed by the *kə*-forms. This pattern of usage is possibly due to influence from SEA or local dialects on speakers whose ancestors migrated to Armenia from the Urmia area in 1828.

(119) Urmia Armenian (Asatryan 1962: 157)
sapʰoɾ-kʰʲeɾ-a tærtækʰʲ=i, ʧyɾ təkʲi peɾ-enkʰʲ
jar-PL-DEF empty=be.3SG water PTCL bring-SBJV.1PL
'the jars are empty, we need to bring water.'

In a number of unrelated Western dialects, including Suceava (Acharyan 1961: 143) and Svedia (Acharyan 1961: 145), *piti* combines with the conjunction *(v)oɾ* to give *bidoɾ, bdoɾ, bədəɾ, bəɾ* (Acharyan 1961: 133).

17.4.4 Complex future

There is a third major type of future tense in modern Armenian, which is formed with the future participle < genitive of the infinitive and the enclitic

[2] Acharyan Acharyan (1961: 139) compares the latter with Maragha *kipta*, concluding that these forms are derived from *petkʿ ē* 'there is need', rather than *piti*.

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copula/auxiliary *em*. The infinitive with the ending *-oy*, which appears to be the genitive singular case ending, was used as an adjective in Classical Armenian, as seen in (120).

(120) Classical Armenian (Acharyan 1961: 232)
anasun ut-el-oy
animal eat-INF-GEN
'edible animal/animal to be eaten'

This usage was also found in Middle Armenian, but the infinitive + *-oy* was also used with the auxiliary as a participle, as seen in (121).

(121) Middle Armenian (Acharyan 1961: 232)
z-ayl deł-er-n or ał-al-oy ē
ACC-other medicine-PL-DEF which grind-INF-GEN be.3SG.PRS
'the other medicines which are to be ground/one will grind'

This became the modern Armenian future participle in *-lu* (this spelling is also found in Middle Armenian, see Acharyan 1961: 232). The meaning of the *-lu* forms is different in Western and Eastern Armenian. In Eastern dialects, it is simple future, while in Western dialects, it expresses deontic modality, meaning 'I should V', like *piti* in Eastern Armenian. According to Acharyan (1961: 235), this meaning is an innovation, which could have arisen through some of its adjectival uses, possibly promoted by the influence of the Turkish obligative forms in *-mA-lI*: in Efkere dialect spoken near Kesaria [Kayseri] in Turkey, the participle in question actually ends in *-li*, rather than *-lu* (Acharyan 1961: 234).

Another type of complex future is found in Hamshen dialect, formed of the subject participle and the auxiliary (122), which has a meaning of "uncertain future", contrasting with the general future < *piti*.

(122) Hamshen Armenian (Acharyan 1961: 140)
Eft-oγ=im.
go-S.PTCP=be.1SG.PRS
'I will go (uncertain).'

This type of future construction has a wider distribution, being also found in Lori (Alaverdi region, near the border with Georgia), although it is not certain whether it also has "uncertain future'' meaning in this dialect (Markosyan 1989: 145).

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17.4.5 Different future meanings

According to Acharyan (1961: 236), in SEA there is a difference between the meaning of the *kə*-future, which is uncertain, i.e., it is not known whether the action will really take place, and the complex future with the *-lu* participle, which expresses certainty that the event will take place.

As seen in (122), Hamshen dialect has a different dedicated form for "uncertain future'', which Acharyan (1961: 140) translates into SEA with the *kə*-forms, and which contrasts with the general future, which in this dialect, as in most Western dialects, is derived from *piti*. As we have seen, in SEA and most Eastern dialects, the *piti* forms express deontic modality, and cannot be described as genuine future tense forms.

Another meaning distinction among future tenses is that between immediate and non-immediate future. The only example known to us of an Armenian dialect with a dedicated immediate future form is Marash, which, in addition to the general future derived from *piti*, also has an "immediate future" formed with the verb *izil* 'want', as seen in (123).

(123) Marash Armenian (Acharyan 1961: 147)
g-iz-im *bir-i*
PTCL-want-PRS.1SG bring-?PTCP
'I will bring immediately.'

17.5 Expression of the future in Turkic

The Turkic aorist originally encoded future semantics, traces of which persist in varying degrees across most Turkic languages. In addition to this inherited category, many Turkic languages have innovated new periphrastic future constructions. These typically combine a non-finite verb form (most frequently a participle or a verbal noun) with an auxiliary. Furthermore, language contact has given rise to additional periphrastic forms, some of which are surveyed below for Azeri.

17.5.1 The prospective

The term "prospective" is defined by Comrie (1976: 64) as describing "a state related to some subsequent situation" and, more recently, by Johanson (2017: 29) as "a perspective on events foreseen to occur subsequent to some temporal orientation point".

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The prospective in Azeri consists of the verb stem, the stressed modal suffix *-AcAQ*,[3] of uncertain origin, and a person-and-number agreement marker from the long series, e.g., *bax-acaq-* 'be going to look'. In the negative, the negative suffix *-mA* precedes the prospective suffix, with stress falling on the syllable preceding *-mA*, e.g., *bax-ma-yacaq-* 'not be going to look'. The thematic base goes back to a necessitative participial form, whose combination with the identification copula had grammaticalised into a finite TAM category in Western Oghuz by the fifteenth century (Johanson 2021: 713).

The paradigm is not always morphologically transparent: in many spoken varieties, first-person singular forms undergo contraction, e.g., *bax-ac-am* 'I am going to look' < *bax-acağ-am*. In other cases, forms disregard vowel harmony or consonant assimilation, e.g., Baku Azeri *vır-ıceg-əm* and Urmia Azeri *vur-acay-əm* 'I am going to hit' (cf. Standard Azeri *vur-acağ-am*).

Some varieties (Gəncə, Qazax, Şəki, Naxçıvan, Ordubad) have a competing or alternative paradigm involving the participial form *-AsI*, e.g. *bax-ası-yam* 'I am going to look'. It is strictly non-finite (cf. negative *bax-ası deyil-əm*) and primarily conveys a necessitative meaning in other varieties where it occurs ('I am supposed to look'). This variation may result in a mixed paradigm, combining forms in *-AcAQ* and *-AsI* (Dybo & Levitskaja 2002: 178).

Sub-varieties of Urmia Azeri closely resemble most other Azeri varieties in exhibiting both contracted and non-contracted forms, e.g. *vır-acay-am* / *vur-acay-əm* / *vur-ac-am* 'I am going to hit' (Doğan 2010: 170). Forms in *-AsI* are unattested.

Turkic prospectives, according to Johanson (2021: 712), present non-realised events as foreseen—"wanted, planned, scheduled, preordained, destined, supposed, expected". In Azeri, the *-AcAQ* future thus signals a prediction or an event whose expected occurrence leaves little room for doubt.

(124) Urmia Azeri (Doğan 2010: 261, 426, 387)

a. *məsələn bugün gəl-əcəy-ıx bu saat-də.*
for.example today come-PROSP-1PL this hour-LOC
'For example, today we are going to arrive at this hour.'

b. *gə bu gediş gessə, kətdəəmiz xarab qal-acax.*
if this going go.COND.3 village.PL.POSS.1PL ruined stay-PROSP.3
'If things continue like this, our villages will be left derelict.'

c. *oynıyacax-san ya bi.belə cərīmə ver-əcə-sən ya bu*
play.PROSP-2SG or this.much fine give-PROSP-2SG or this

[3]For the notation of Turkic vowels see §7.5.

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iş-i *gör-əcə-sən.*
work-ACC see-PROSP-2SG
'You shall dance, or else you shall pay a fine or perform (such-and-such) chore.'

17.5.2 The eventual

Beyond its roles in expressing habituality, gnomic statements and a range of commissive and epistemic modal meanings, the eventual may also encode future semantics (for its morphological forms, see §18.7). In this function, it most frequently appears in the apodoses of potential conditionals, paralleling the prospective aspect:

(125) Urmia Azeri (Doğan 2010: 465, 382)

a. *əgər qal-sa* *gəlin-in* *qəynana-sı,* *xoş*
if stay-COND:3 bride-GEN mother.in.law-POSS.3 pleasant
gəl-di-n *di-yər* *bilə-si-nə.*
come-PST-2SG say-EVT.3 REFL-POSS.3-DAT
'If the bride's mother-in-law is present, she'll welcome her.'

b. *adam* *işlə-mə-sə,* *heş.vəxt dişlə-m-əz.*
person work-NEG-COND.3 never bite-NEG-EVT.3
'If a person doesn't work, s/he'll never eat.'

Apodoses in the eventual express less probability that those in the prospective.

17.5.3 The progressive

As in many languages of the region and beyond, phase verbs and verbs of movement in the progressive aspect can encode future actions:

(126) Ardabil Azeri (Karini 2009: 484)
qız, mən ged-ir-əm *emmiz-ə,* *dədə-m-i*
girl I go-IPFV.PRS-1SG house.POSS.1PL-DAT dad-POSS.1SG-ACC
yolluyacām *elçilig-ə.*
send.PROSP.1SG marriage.proposal-DAT
'Girl, I'm going to go home and send my father to propose on my behalf.'

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17.5.4 Periphrastic prospectives with 'want' and 'go'

Rafiei (2017: 256-257, transcription and gloss adapted), describing prospective forms in Azeri as spoken in Iran (the author does not specify the regional origin of his consultants), provides examples of two periphrastic prospective constructions, both involving an auxiliary—either *istə-* 'want' or *get-* 'go'—followed by the lexical verb in the optative:

(127) a. *daş istiyir tüş-ə.*
stone want.IPFV.PRS.3 fall-OPT.3
'The stone is going to fall.'

b. *hava ged-ir yağ-a.*
air go-IPFV.PRS.3 precipitate-OPT.3
'It is going to rain.'

Originally complex sentences featuring complement clauses such as lit. 'The stone wants to fall', 'The air is moving to precipitate' have undergone grammaticalisation, influenced by structurally analogous forms in Persian.

17.6 Discussion

The NENA future construction with the prefixed particle *bəd* (and phonetic variants) in the northern sector of the dialect area matches the future constructions with preverbal particles in Northern Kurdish. The geographical distribution of future preverbal particles in NENA and Kurdish coincides. In NENA dialects in the southern sector the preverbal future particle is not used and this coincides with the lack of a preverbal future particles in Central Kurdish and Gorani.

The closest match for the NENA preverbal particle is the particle *dê* in Behdînî Kurdish. In the rest of Northern Kurdish the future particle *=ê* is cliticised to a preceding clausal argument. These particles appear to be fosslised, uninflected forms of the present of the verb 'to want' *viyan* and are followed by the subjunctive. This would be a direct match to the NENA future particle *bəd*, which is a fossilised form of the present of the NENA verb 'to want' followed by the subordinating particle *d*.

The NENA future particle, however, appears to be more grammaticalised than the Kurdish particle, since the Kurdish particle can be separated from the verb by other clause constituents (see examples in §17.2.1.1 and §17.2.1.2), whereas in NENA it is regularly prefixed to the verb. Also, in Kurdish the future in the past is expressed by a distinct form of the future particle, derived from the past form

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of the verb 'to want' (*da-*, whereas in NENA the future particle deriving from the present form of the verb 'to want' has been extended also to expressions of the future in the past. Furthermore, the NENA particle typically undergoes phonetic reduction. It is relevant to note that such phonetic reduction produces in some cases a phonetic shape that is closer to that of the Kurdish particle. In some NENA dialects, for example, the particle is reduced to *d-*, e.g., C. Qaraqosh *d-aθe* 'they will come' (Khan 2002a: 98). The realisation of the NENA particle as a devoiced *ṯ-*, e.g., C. Barwar *ṯ-azəl* 'he will go' (5) may be compared to the devoicing of the *d-* in Behdînî *dê* to *tê* in some dialects, such as Tatvan and Gever. It is also relevant to note that in many Armenian dialects the particle *piti* 'there is a need to', which can have a future-marking function, is pronounced *bidi* in some dialects, such as Mush. Furthermore, this particle is reduced to unaspirated *t* (with initial devoicing) in many Armenian dialects including Van and Urmia (§17.4.3), which would match the phonetic shape of the NENA future particle before vowels in NENA dialects in the northern sector, e.g., C. Barwar *ṯ-azəl* 'he will go' (5). In Arabic *Qəltu* dialects of the area the future is expressed by similar-sounding preverbal particles, e.g., *tə-* and *də-*, although their origin is from the Arabic subordinator *ḥattā* 'so that' (§17.3).

The NENA future particle *bəd* is incompatible with negation (§17.1.1.3), except in some marginal cases, and this matches Northern Kurdish, in which, likewise, the future particles cannot be combined with negator particles.

A further parallel between NENA future constructions with *bəd* and Northern Kurdish future constructions with *dê* is that in both cases the future particle is used when the speaker has a high commitment to the truth of the prediction and when, typically, the event will happen in the immediate future (§17.1.1.6, §80).

As remarked, the lack of future particles in NENA dialects in the southern sector, coinciding with the geographical area of Central Kurdish and Gorani, matches the lack of future particles in the latter Iranian varieties. In NENA and Iranian in this area the indicative present is used to express the future.

There are some parallels between Kurdish dialects and NENA with regard to more marginal future constructions. The use of an inflected form of the verb 'to want' in some NENA dialects to express a prospective (§17.1.3.3) may be compared with the use in some Central Kurdish dialects of an inflected form of the verb *wîstin* 'to want', some of the examples of which could have a prospective interpretation (§89). There are parallels to this also in the Azeri spoken in Iran (§17.5.4), though the model for this is likely to be the Persian future auxiliary *xāstan* 'to want'.

In NENA dialects in the northern sector augment suffixes with the form *-ni* or *-ən* added to future forms are used to express an indefinite future (24b) and (24d).

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Augments with a similar phonetic shape are attested in Behdînî Kurdish dialects and the resulting forms can be interpreted, likewise, as expressing an indefinite future (§98).

The use of the word for time *ga* in prospective construcitons in some NENA dialects (70) matches Kurdish prospective constructions with the word *wext* 'time' (§17.2.4.1.24).

The use of the auxiliary verb 'to do' followed by the main verb in the subjunctive in western Northern Kurdish (§17.2.4.1.26) and Zazaki (§17.2.6.4), e.g., 'to do to go', i.e., 'to initiate the onset phase of the event' may have facilitated the development of prospective forms with the invariable auxiliary *qam* + subjunctive 'to rise to do' in NENA dialects in the north-western sector, e.g., C. Harbole *qam-ʾazəl* 'He is about to go' (lit. 'he is rising to go') (62).

The use of active participles in NENA dialects in the northern sector and Mosul plain to express a planned, certain future (§17.1.2.1) may be compared to the use of participles to express a certain event in Armenian (§17.4.4). They may, therefore, have been matched perceptually in a language contact situation. Furthermore, the use of constructions with a participle in Armenian to express a negative future (e.g., 114) resembles negative constructions with active participles in some NENA dialects in the northern sector (45, 46). It should be pointed out, however, that the prospective construction with a participle is used more productively in NENA dialects in the Mosul plain, a long way from the the Armenian speech zone, than in dialects such as C. Urmi, which are spoken adjacent to the Armenian speech zone. There is, furthermore, a typological parallel to the Azeri Turkic prospective construction, which consists of a stem that is derived historically from a "necessitative participial form" (§17.5.1). Again, however, this is unlikely to have been the model for the prospective use of the participle in the western sector of NENA.

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18 The expression of the habitual

18.1 NENA habitual

18.1.1 Preliminary remarks

A habitual verbal form expresses a set of an unspecified number of events that occur at unspecified points of time. The speaker does not have in mind specific events bound to specific points in time. It rather expresses a property or disposition of the subject. The term property here is used to refer to an aspect of the inherent nature of the subject and the term disposition refers to incidental qualities independent of the subject (Chafe 2012).

Habitual forms cross-linguistically frequently have their historical origin in progressive forms (Bybee et al. 1994, Deo 2015), and this appears to be the case also in NENA. A progressive expresses a single specific event that is not bounded in time. The habitual does, nevertheless, have a family relationship with the progressive, in that the progressive, like the habitual, can be interpreted as a property of the subject. The difference is that a progressive expresses a property that is contingent to a particular time interval whereas the habitual expresses a more time-stable property. The historical process of development from progressive to habitual involves the extension of the function of the form from denoting a specific contingent property to denoting a more time-stable property. As in many languages, when this extension has taken place in NENA, new forms have been brought into the verbal system in order to express the progressive (see chapter 19).

The habitual is expressed in most NENA dialects by the combination of a preverbal particle with the present stem. The particle has the form *k-* or *ʾi-*, or phonetic variants of these, e.g., *c-*, *č-*, *g-*, *y-*. In some dialects, the particle is a combination of these elements, e.g., C. Urmi *ci-* < *k* + *i*.

The *k-* appears to have its origin in a presentative particle **kā-*. Bar-Hebraeus, writing in the 13th century, states that this particle occurred in his day in Eastern Aramaic vernacular speech. He gives the examples *kā ʾāxel* 'he is eating', *kā ʾāzel* 'he is going' (Heinrichs 2002: 249). This *kā-* is likely to be the origin also of the Ṭuroyo preverbal habitual particle *ko-* and possibly the preverbal particle *x-* in

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Mlaḥso (Jastrow 1994a: 38). The *kā-* may have been a deictic particle; cf. Syriac *kā*, *hā-ḵā* 'here':

(1) C. Qaraqosh (Khan 2002a)
k-paθəx
DEIC-open.PRS.3SG.M
'He opens' < '(See) he opens.'

The *ʾi-* particle is likely to be an uninflected form of the copula. In paradigms of the copula in NENA dialects *ʾi-* is widely used as the stem to which inflections are added. When acting as a preverbal particle, this copula element would have originally taken the verb as its sentential subject, e.g.,

(2) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a: 174-175)
ʾi-paθəx
be-open.PRS.3SG.M
'He opens' < '(That) he opens is.'

Evidence for this is the fact that in some dialects the *ʾi* particle is connected to the verb by a subordinating particle *d*. This is attested when the verbal root has an initial laryngeal *ʾ*, e.g.,

(3) C. Mez (Khan, fieldnotes)
ʾi-d-aθe.
be-SBRD-come.PRS.3SG.M
'He comes.'

This can be interpreted as being, in origin, a non-contrastive thetic cleft (Sasse 1987, Khan 2012), which presents a progressive action: 'It is he who is coming.' The construction would have had a presentative function similar to that of the construction formed by the particle *kā*, i.e., 'Look, he is coming.'

In some dialects the *ʾi* particle is occasionally cliticised to the preceding word, e.g.,

(4) C. Mawana (Khan, fieldnotes)
ʾáxči xa̋na cű́lle mə́ndi ⁺házər=i ʾɔd-í-wa-le
but FILLER every thing reading=COP do.PRS-3PL-PST-OBL.3SG.M
ḵa-sə̀twa.
for-winter
'But they would prepare everything for the winter.'

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This original presentative function of the *k-* and *ʾi-* particles would have been more appropriate to express a progressive activity rather than a habitual. So, as remarked, it is likely that the constructions with the particles originally expressed the progressive and this was subsequently extended to the habitual.

18.1.2 Geographical distribution of *k-* and *ʾi-* prefixes

The particle *k-* or phonetic variants thereof are widely distributed across the NENA area. They are attested in all Jewish dialects, including those in northern areas such a J. Zakho, J. Dohok, J. Amedia, J. Betanure, J. Nerwa, J. Gzira (Nakano 1973) and J. Challa (Fassberg 2010). The only exceptions are Jewish dialects in the Barzan area (Mutzafi 2002a), including J. Bedyel and J. Shahe, which have *i-* in positive habituals, though they use *k-* in negative habituals (see 23). In Christian dialects the *k-* prefix is found in dialects from the Mosul plain up to the north-western periphery in Peshabur (Coghill 2013) and Haṣṣan (Jastrow 1994b), and those across the central NENA sector, e.g., C. Ankawa, C. Shaqlawa, C. Koy Sanjak, and the south-east, e.g., C. Sulemaniyya, C. Sanandaj. In the north-eastern periphery of NENA it is attested in Christian dialects of the Urmi region, e.g., C. Urmi, C. Salamas, C. Gawilan, though it is combined with the *ʾi* prefix, resulting in the form *c-i-* (in this area **k* has been fronted to palatal /c/.

The *ʾi-* prefix is attested in Christian dialects across the northern sector of NENA from the north-west, e.g., C. Bohtan, C. Haṣṣan, C. Harbole across the Hakkari and the bordering regions of Iraq, e.g., C. Barwar, C. Bebede, C. Txuma, C. Qočanəṣ, C. Van, C. Baz, C. Jilu, and in the Tergawar region of north-western Iran, e.g., C. Mawana.

As already remarked, the Christian dialects in the Urmi region use a hybrid form of prefix consisting of a *k-* element (palatalised to /c/) and an *ʾi* element, e.g.,

(5) C. Urmi (Khan 2016b)
c-i-patəx.
DEIC-COP-open.PRS.3SG.M
'He opens.'

For a map of the distribution of NENA habitual particles see Figure 18.1.

18.1.3 Attrition and historical layers of the particles

Most dialects exhibit some attrition of the particles, in that they do not occur with all habitual forms.

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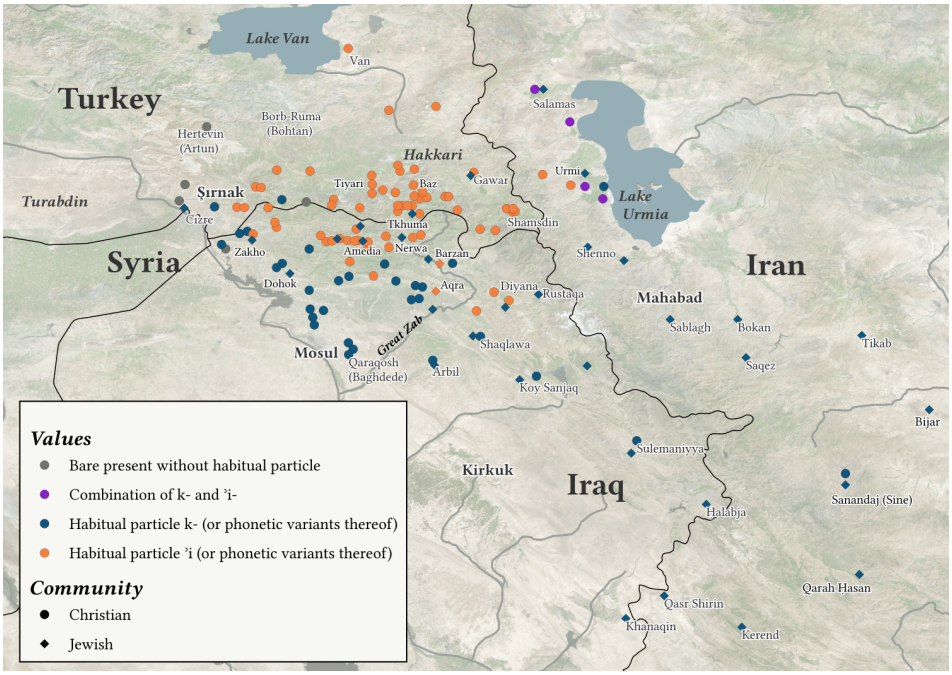

Figure 18.1: Distribution of habitual particles across NENA dialects

In Trans-Zab Jewish dialects and in Christian dialects in the south-eastern sector, including C. Sulemaniyya and C. Sanandaj, the *k-* prefix has been preserved only before verbs with initial weak consonants, e.g.,

(6) J. Arbel (Khan 2000)

a. *šăte.*
drink.PRS.3SG.M
'He drinks.'

b. *k-xəl.*
DEIC-eat.PRS.3SG.M
'He eats (root: *ʾ-x-l*).'

(7) C. Sulemaniyya (Khan 2000)

a. *šate.*
drink.PRS.3SG.M
'He drinks.'

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b. *k-ase.*
DEIC-come.PRS.3SG.M
'He comes (root: *ʾ-s-y*).'

In some dialects on the northern periphery, habitual particles are systematically omitted before all habitual verbs, including those from roots with weak initial consonants, e.g.,

(8) C. Hertevin (Jastrow 1988: 54), C. Umra (Hobrack 2000: 82)

a. *šate.*
drink.PRS.3SG.M
'He drinks.'

b. *ʾate.*
DEIC-come.PRS.3SG.M
'He comes.'

In these dialects, however, the *k-* particle has been preserved in the verb 'to want' (< **b-ʿ-y*), e.g.,

(9) C. Hertevin (Jastrow 1988: 39)
ke-pʾe.
DEIC-want.PRS.3SG.M
'He wants.'

(10) C. Umra (Hobrack 2000: 63)
gə̆-be.
DEIC-want.PRS.3SG.M
'He wants.'

This isolated preservation of *k-* was no doubt due to the fact it became entrenched as a lexically specific feature due to the high frequency of this verb. Its existence suggests that *k-* was originally more generally used in these dialects.

In some Christian from the Lower Ṭyare region in south-eastern Turkey, including C. Ashitha (Borghero 2005: 122), C. Mne Matha, C. Mne Belatha, C. Bne Lagəppa, C. Zawitha, the attrition is complete and no verb has a habitual prefix, e.g.,

(11) C. Ashitha (Borghero 2005: 122, 159)

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a. *šate.*
drink.PRS.3SG.M
'He drinks.'

b. *ʾaθe.*
come.PRS.3SG.M
'He comes.'

c. *bă̈ye.*
want.PRS.3SG.M
'He wants.'

In several dialects, the habitual prefix is regularly preserved before verbs beginning with a weak consonant but only irregularly used before those beginning with a strong consonant. One factor that often motivates the preservation of a prefix before a strong consonant is the discourse prominence of the verbal form. Consider the following example from C. Barwar:

(12) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a: 592)
ʾáni xə̀ṭṭe huwèdi sáma zóda| ***ʾi-zăr-í-la*** *t-là*
they wheat huwedi part more COP-cultivate.PRS-3SPL-OBL.3SG.F REL-NEG
maštóye,| *y-amr-ə̀x-xa* *dèmi.*| *ʾáni* ***zăr-i***
irrigate.INF COP-say.PRS-1PL-OBL.3SG.F unirrigated they cultivate.PRS-3PL
gu-ṭùra.|
in-mountain
'The *huwedi* wheat they generally sow without irrigation, they call it "unirrigated." They sow it in the mountains.'

In (12) the main point the speaker is making is that *huwedi* wheat is cultivated without irrigation. The statement that they sow it in the mountains is an elaboration to this central point.

It is likely that the *k-* prefix was originally used across the whole of NENA. This prefix, which, as remarked, has its origin in the presentative particle **kā*, is also the background of the corresponding preverbal prefix *ko-* in Ṭuroyo. This would have subsequently been replaced by the *ʾi-* prefix. Evidence for this is that in some dialects that generally use the prefix *ʾi-* before habitual verbs, there are fossilised vestiges of *k-*, or phonetic variants of this, in some specific lexical verbs. In most cases these have come to be interpreted as the initial consonant of the verbal root, e.g., the verb 'to want' in some dialects in the Sapna valley that otherwise have *i-*:

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(13) C. Dawudiya (Khan, fieldnotes)

a. *y-azəl*
COP-go.PRS.3SG.M
'He goes (habitually).'

b. *kə̌-be.*
DEIC-want.PRS.3SG.M
'He wants.'

In some Upper Ṭyare dialects and some dialects along the border of Turkey in northern Iraq that use *i-* before habitual verbs, there are some verbs that preserve *k-* in the form of *č-* as the initial radical of the root, e.g.,

(14) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a)

a. *y-azəl.*
COP-go.PRS.3SG.M
'He goes (habitually).'

b. *č-ayəd.*
DEIC-invite.PRS.3SG.M
'He invites.' (< **k-ʿayəd*)

(15) C. Upper Ṭyare (Talay 2008b: 55)

a. *y-amər*
COP-say.PRS.3SG.M
'He says.'

b. *č-azəl.*
DEIC-go.PRS.3SG.M
'He goes.' (< **k-ʾazəl*)

18.1.4 Past forms of the habitual

Most NENA dialects express the past habitual by adding the past-shifting suffix *-wa* to the present form with the habitual prefix, where this occurs in the present, e.g.,

(16) J. Arbel (Khan 1999a)

a. *k-xəl.*
DEIC-eat.PRS.3SG.M
'He eats.'

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b. *k-xəl-wa.*
DEIC-eat.PRS.3SG.M-PST
'He used to eat.'

(17) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a)

a. *y-axəl.*
COP-eat.PRS.3SG.M
'He eats.'

b. *y-axəl-wa.*
COP-eat.PRS.3SG.M-PST
'He used to eat.'

In some dialects, however, the habitual prefix is restricted to the present and is not used when the verb has a past-shifting suffix, e.g.,

(18) C. Alqosh (Coghill 2003: 139)

a. *k-axəl.*
DEIC-eat.PRS.3SG.M
'He eats.'

b. *ʾaxəl-wa*
eat.PRS.3SG.M-PST
'He used to eat.'

(19) C. Shaqlawa (Khan, fieldnotes)

a. *k-ate.*
DEIC-come.PRS.3SG.M
'He comes.'

b. *ʾate-wa.*
come.PRS.3SG.M-PST
'He used to come.'

This is likely to be an archaism reflecting the origin of the prefixes to draw attention to an ongoing event in the present in progressive constructions. In other dialects, the prefixes were extended to the past habitual forms by analogy.

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18.1.5 Negation of habitual forms

In most dialects, a habitual form is negated by placing the negative particle *la* before the positive habitual form, e.g.,

(20) C. Qaraqosh (Khan 2002a: 100)

a. *k-paθəx.*
DEIC-open.PRS.3SG.M
'He opens.'

b. *la k-paθəx.*
NEG DEIC-open.PRS.3SG.M
'He does not open.'

When the habitual prefix in the positive form is *ʾi-*, this often coalesces with the /a/ vowel of the preceding negative particle or causes it to be raised to a higher vowel quality, e.g.,

(21) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a: 194-195)

a. *y-axəl.*
COP-eat.PRS.3SG.M
'He eats.'

b. *la y-axəl.*
NEG COP-eat.PRS.3SG.M
'He does not eat.'

c. *ʾi-palәṭ.*
COP-go.out.PRS.3SG.M
'He goes out.'

d. *lɛ-palәṭ.*
NEG.COP-go.out.PRS.3SG.M
'He does not go out.'

e. *ʾi-šate.*
COP-drink.PRS.3SG.M
'He drinks.'

f. *leɣ-šate.*
NEG.COP-drink.PRS.3SG.M
'He does not drink.'

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In some dialects, however, there is an asymmetry between the positive and the negative form of the habitual.

In Christian dialects of the Urmi region that have a habitual prefix *c-i-* in the positive habitual, the *c-* (< **k-*) element is elided after the negative particle and the */i/* coalesces with the vowel of the negative particle, resulting in the form *le-*, e.g.,

(22) C. Urmi (Khan 2016b: vol. 1, 286)

a. *c-i-patəx.*
DEIC-COP-open.PRS.3SG.M
'He opens.'

b. *le patəx.*
NEG.COP open.PRS.3SG.M
'He does not open.'

This phenomenon can be explained as being the result of phonetic attrition of the /c/ in this context.

In the Jewish dialects of Barzan described by Mutzafi (2002a), conversely, positive habitual forms have the prefix *ʾi-* but after the negator this is sometimes replaced by *k-*, e.g.,

(23) J. Barzan (Mutzafi 2002a: 60)

a. *ʾi-šate.*
COP-drink.PRS.3SG.M
'He drinks.'

b. *la k-šate.*
NEG DEIC-drink.PRS.3SG.M
'He does not drink.'

This could be explained by the hypothesis that that the negative construction preserves the more archaic form with *k-*, which, as remarked above, is likely to have been originally used throughout NENA dialects. Further evidence for this is the fact that the *k-* prefix is preserved in the positive form of verbs with an initial weak radical, to which a *ʾi-* prefix is added, resulting in the hybrid prefix *ʾi-k-*, e.g.,

(24) J. Barzan (Mutzafi 2002a: 62)
ʾi-k-exəl.
COP-DEIC-eat.PRS.3SG.M
'He eats.'

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Also in the C. Sulemaniyya and C. Sanandaj dialects on the south-eastern periphery of NENA, there is some asymmetry between positive and negative habitual forms. As remarked above, in these dialects the *k-* prefix is preserved in positive habitual forms only on verbs with a weak initial radical. It is preserved, however, before verbs beginning with a strong consonant when this is preceded by the negator, e.g.,

(25) C. Sanandaj, C. Sulemaniyya (Khan, fieldnotes)

a. *šate.*
drink.PRS.3SG.M
'He drinks.'

b. *la k-šate.*
NEG DEIC-drink.PRS.3SG.M
'He does not drink.'

An alternative negation strategy is available in C. Sanandaj whereby the positive form is preceded by a negator with the form *ley*, which appears to be fossilised form of the negative copula (cf. forms of the negative copula: *leye* 3SG.M, *leya* 3SG.F, *leyu* 3PL). In such cases, the original *k-* is not preserved before verbs beginning with a strong consonant, e.g.,

(26) C. Sanandaj (Khan, fieldnotes)

a. *šate.*
drink.PRS.3SG.M
'He drinks.'

b. *ley šate.*
NEG.COP drink.PRS.3SG.M
'He does not drink.'

c. *k-axəl.*
DEIC-eat.PRS.3SG.M
'He eats.'

d. *ley k-axəl.*
NEG.COP DEIC-eat.PRS.3SG.M
'He does not eat.'

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18.1.6 Discourse-dependent habitual

In dialects that express the future by the prefixed particle *bəd-* or its phonetic variants (e.g., *b-*, *p-*, *t-*, *ṭ-*), verbal forms with this particle are used to express habitual forms that are sequential to or in some way dependent on the preceding discourse (for the future functions of this particle see chapter 17). The discourse-dependent habitual use appears to have developed from the use of the future form in apodoses of conditional constructions (Khan 2021: 149-154). In apodoses, the form *bət-* + present stem (represented here as *bət-qaṭəl*) may express an eventuality that is temporally sequential to a hypothetical situation in the future, e.g.,

(27) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a: 601)
ʾən kpìn-ni,| *ṭ-axl-ən-ne.*|
if hunger.PST-OBL.1SG FUT-eat.PRS-1SG-OBL.3SG.M
'If am hungry, I shall eat it.'

The form consisting of *bət-* + present stem + past-shifting suffix *-wa* (represented here as *bət-qaṭəlwa*), which expresses a 'future in the past' is typically used in the apodosis of conditional sentences that refer to a counterfactual condition in the past that was not fulfilled, e.g.,

(28) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a: 605)
ʾən-mbaqr-ə̀t-wa,| *t-yaw-án-wa-lux* *zùze.*|
if-ask.PRS-2SG.M-PST FUT-give.PRS-1SG-PST-OBL.2SG.M money
'If you had asked, I would have given you money.'

In conditional constructions such as (27) and (28), the apodoses with the *bət-qaṭəl* and *bət-qaṭəlwa* forms are dependent syntactically on the preceding protasis. Discourse-dependent *bət-qaṭəl* and *bət-qaṭəlwa* forms are more loosely dependent on the preceding discourse and would have developed from the apodosis of conditional constructions by a process of insubordination. Various types of discourse dependency are attested. In some cases, the forms express events that are temporally sequential to what precedes, e.g.,

(29) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a: 518)
báθər ʾéða gòṛa| *ʾìθena*| *ʾéðət* *sulàqa.*| *xàrθa*|
after festival big EXIST festival.of ascension afterwards
ṭ-áθe *xá-ʾeða* *xréna zòra,*| *y-amr-í-le*
FUT-come.PRS.3SG.M one-festival other small COP-say.PRS-3PL-OBL.3SG.M

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ʾéðət musàrde.|
festival.of musarde
'After the Great Festival, the festival of Ascension takes place. Afterwards **comes** a small festival, which is called musarde.'

(30) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a: 607)
čɛrx-ì-wa-la máθa| *xáṣə dawère.*| *ʾa*
take.round.PRS-3PL.A-PST-2SG.F.P village back.of mules she
ṯ-aθy-à-wa,| ***ṯ-or-à-wa,***|
FUT-come.PRS-3SG.F-PST FUT-enter.PRS-3SG.F-PST
*ʾu-**ṯ-oðá-wa** ṣlìwa,*| *məšxa,*| *gu-tắrət qàṣra.*|
and-FUT-make.PRS.3SG.F-PST cross oil in-door.of house
'They used to take her (the bride) round the village on the back of mules. (Then) **she would come back**, **enter** (the house) and **make** (the sign of) the cross in oil on the door of the house.'

In some cases the *bət-qaṭəl* and *bət-qaṭəlwa* forms do not express temporal sequentiality but only some kind of relevance to a preceding clause, typically elaboration, e.g.,

(31) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a: 603)
báwθə Ninwàye| *ʾáp-ʾay ʾìt-wa.*| *ṣɛm-ì-la.*|
petition.of Ninevites also-it.F EXIST-PST fast.PRS-3PL-OBL.3SG.F
ṯ-ámr-i *díge=u kθàye*| *ʾáp ʾan-zóre xtàye.*|
FUT-say.PRS-3PL cocks=and chickens also those-small lower
'The Rogation of the Ninevites was also observed (in our community). They would fast during it. **They say**, "The cocks and the chickens, and also the small lowly creatures (should observe the fast)."'

(32) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a: 607)
qam-ṣàwma ʾíθ xošébə bnàθa.| *bnáθa kúlla **p̂ṯ-az-í-wa***
before-fast EXIST Sunday.of girls girls all FUT-go-.PRS-3PL-PST
bèθa,| ***b-šaql-í-wa*** *ʾixála mən-dáwwa dáwwa dàwwa,*|
home FUT-take.PRS-3PL-PST food from-this.OBL this.OBL this.OBL
ṯ-az-í-wa *gu-xa-ṭùra,*| ***ṯ-atw-ì-wa,***|
FUT-eat.PRS-3PL-PST in-one-mountain FUT-sit.PRS-3PL-PST
ṯ-axl-ì-wa,| ***b-šat-ì-wa.***|
FUT-eat.PRS-3PL-PST FUT-drink.PRS-3PL-PST
'Before the fast (of Lent) was Girls' Sunday. All the girls **used to go** home,

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would take food from here and from there, then **would go** to the mountains, they **would sit**, **would eat** and **would drink**.'

The habitual meaning of the discourse dependent *bət-qaṭəl* and *bət-qaṭəlwa* forms can be explained as the consequence of their origin in conditional constructions. As remarked, a habitual verbal form expresses an unspecified number of events that occur at unspecified points of time. A hypothetical protasis typically does not express a specific event bound to a specific time, but rather an unspecified number of possible events that occur at unspecified points of time. Indeed, the value of the unspecified number may be zero and for that reason the occurrence of the event is only possible and not certain. The consequent in the apodosis would, therefore, have the same underspecified profile. When the apodosis *bət-qaṭəl* was extended to discourse dependent main clauses, therefore, this underspecified profile gave rise to its habitual meaning.

The use of *bət-qaṭəl* and *bət-qaṭəlwa* forms to express discourse-dependent habituals has been documented in many NENA dialects across the northern sector of NENA, where these forms are used to express also the future, from the north-western periphery (e.g., C. Harbole) to the north-eastern periphery (e.g., C. Urmi).

In the dialect of the Chaldean Christians of Dohok this discourse-dependent habitual construction has become the default habitual construction, which is used in all contexts and replaced habituals with other prefixed particles, e.g.,

(33) c. Dohok (Khan, fieldnotes)
kúd-yom b-àθe.
every-day FUT-come.PRS.3SG.M
'Every day he comes.'

18.2 Kurdish Habitual

The Kurdish imperfective affixes have their likely roots in a progressive periphrasis that became a general imperfective, including the habitual characterising function in addition to the progressive (Bybee et al. 1994, Deo 2015, Karim 2024). Many Kurdish varieties have since developed innovative progressive marking to specify an act-in-progress reading. They all have the status of Deo's (2015) "emergent progressive" and are not fully grammaticalised (See Chapter §19.2).

The habitual in Kurdish is expressed, in the present tense, with prefixes in all varieties, although they have undergone phonological erosion and loss in some

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phonological contexts in many varieties. These prefixes take the forms *d(i)-*,[1] *t(i)-*, *de*, and *ʾe-*, and a few varieties also have a preposed enclitic *=y* (see Fattah 2000: 372).

These forms all seem to have their origin in the locative **de* (< PIr. **antara* 'in'). The form underwent regular phonological changes, resulting in the variation observed:

- *d-* occurs in varieties that underwent pretonic shortening of the vowel **e*: e.g., SK Wermizyar *dikwişt* 's/he used to kill' < *dekwíst; the full vowel remains in the negative where the stress occurs in the negation particle, e.g., *nyekwişt* < *nídekwişt 's/he didn't ussed to kill.'
  - **d-* devoiced to *t-*[2] before voiceless consonants, and this sandhi form was leveled in some varieties that had **d-*, e.g., NK Amadi *tkeft* 's/he used ot fall' < *d(i)keft < *dekeft-.
  - in the presence of a vowel-final preverbal element, initial **d-* lenited to *=y*, becoming a preposed enclitic, e.g., SK Beyrey *xorma=y xwem* (Fattah 2000: 372) < *xorma *dxwem < *xorma *dexwem
- *e-* is a sandhi form that occurred in the presence of stress-attracting prefixes (see Karim 2024), SK Dinewar *e-kirdim* ~ *ney-e-kirdim* 'I used to do' ~ 'I didn't used to do' < *d-kirdim ~ *ney-e-kirdim* < *de-kirdim ~ *ne-de-kirdim.

The prefix attaches to the present stem of the verb.

(34) Mukri CK (Öpengin 2016: 47)
hemû sał-ê xêzan=im mindał-êk=î de-b-ê.
all year-INDF wife=1SG child-INDF=3SG IND-be.PRS-3SG
'Each year my wife gives birth to a child.'

This morpheme is generally repeated in each occurrence of verbs in a chain:

(35) Shamdinan NK (Matras et al. 2016: K-078 Semdinli)

[1]Note that the vowel *i* is used as an epenthetic vowel to break up illegal consonant clusters. Its phonemic status in the Iranian languages of the region is questionable at best.

[2]The devoiced prefix *t-* in the Behdînî dialects of North Iraq, Gever, Shamdinan, as well as south of the Lake Van area, was already observed in an 18th-century text from Amadiya (Mohammadirad & Öpengin 2025).

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Em di-çû-n=e liwê, me xo-l awê di-da, hinde
we IPFV-go.PST-3PL=DRCT there we self-in water IPFV-give.PST.3SG some
ca me masî di-girt-in, me derê-d-xist-in, me
time we fish IPFV-hold.PST-3PL we PVB-IPFV-drop.PST-3PL we
ewek-id kir-in (…) me di-xar-in.
FILLER-IPFV do.PST-3PL we IPFV-eat.PST-3PL
'We would go there, we would swim; sometimes we would catch fish, we would take them out, we would do whatsit, we would eat them.'

The morpheme is, however, sometimes encliticized on the preceding word, e.g., *ewek-id kir-in* (see 35). This enclisis may have contributed to another particularity of this morpheme in these varieties that is not typical of affixes. The marker occurs separated from the stem by the inherited directional preverbal particles, such as *ra-, hel-*, etc. Thus, although in (35) the verb form *derê-d xist-in* has the adverbial element preceding the *di-*, in (36) the morpheme is separated from the stem by an adverbial preverb, e.g., *di-ra-b-î*.

(36) *tu herro se'et çendê di-ra-b-î?*
you everyday hour how.much IND-PVB-be.PRS-2SG
'What time do you wake up everyday?'

18.2.1 Geographical Distribution of *d-, t-, de-,* and *e-* Prefixes

The *d*-form prefixes are widely attested across the Kurdish region, spanning all three groups, Northern, Central, and Southern Kurdish. Pretonic shortening that led to *d-* and *t-* only occurred in Northern and Southern Kurdish, and so those forms are absent from Central Kurdish. The sandhi form *'e-* is absent from Northern Kurdish. There are further varieties of Southern Kurdish that do not have any prefix (see §18.2.2). The distribution of these forms can be seen in Figure 18.2 for the present-tense forms of most verbs.

18.2.2 Attrition and historical layers of the prefixes

Most dialects exhibit some attrition of the prefixes, in that they do not occur with all habitual forms.

In Kurdish dialects that have generally lost the *d*-form prefix, it is preserved before the *h*-initial verb 'to come' (common Kurdish **hê-*). In dialects that cannot have intervening affixes between the morpheme and the verbal stem (i.e., Southern Kurdish), the *d*-form is preserved before all *h*-initial verbs.

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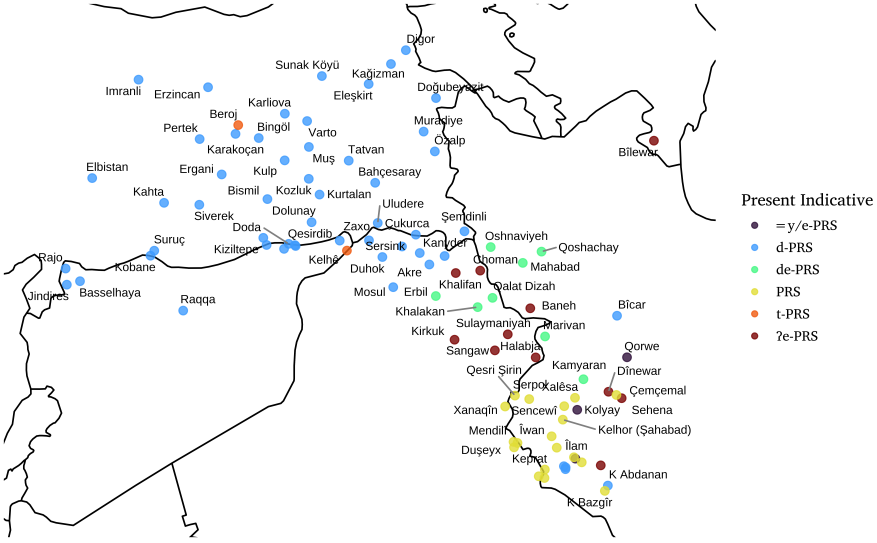

Figure 18.2: Geographical distribution of *d-*, *t-*, *de-*, and *e-* prefixes on present tense verbs

(37) SK Qesri Şîrîn (Fattah 2000)

a. *heł=gerdin-in.*
PV=return.PRS-3PL
'They return.'

b. *der=t-ye-n.*
PV=IND-come.PRS-3PL
'They come.'

In dialects that have generally replaced the *d*-form prefix with the sandhi variant *e-*, it is preserved in the same context indicated above.

(38) CK Kerkuk

a. *e-řo-n.*
IND-go.PRS-3PL
'They go.'

b. *d-ê-n.*
IND-come.PRS-3PL
'They come.'

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In some of these dialects, the relationship between the remnant *d*-form and the imperfective, progressive, and habitual has been lost. Younger generations of speakers have begun to regularise the *e-* prefix in these contexts, creating what is etymologically double marking:

(39) SK Şerwan Zürî (Fattah 2000)
e-ke-n
IND-make.PRS-3PL
'They make.'
a. *e-t-yer-in*
IND-IND-bring.PRS-3PL
'They bring.'

In other dialects, the word-initial **d* is affected by sandhi, becoming *y*. This is analogical in nature and did not necessarily occur in all words in the language. However, verbs with preverbs were particularly susceptible, e.g., CK Slêmanî: *ya-* 'gave' (< **da-*) and *yê-* 'come' (< **dê-* < **dehê*).

The distribution of these forms can be observed in Figure 18.3 for the present-tense forms of **hê-* 'to come.' This distribution differs significantly from that in Figure 18.2, showing a ubiquitous distribution of dental formatives.

18.2.3 Past Forms of the Habitual

Across Kurdish, the past habitual is expressed with the past imperfective, as shown in (40). For the vast majority of Kurdish dialects, the same prefixes that are used in the present tense are combined with the past-tense stem to form the past imperfective (40).

The prefix attaches to the past stem of the verb:

(40) NK Shamdinan (Öpengin fieldnotes)
em di-çû-yn=e *liwê*
we IPFV-go.PST-1PL=DRCT there
'We used to go there.'

Some dialects, however, form the imperfective stem by attaching the suffix *-(y)a* to the past-tense stem, probably also from a locative marker following Karim (2024). These appear to be mostly confined to the Southern Kurdish zone (41). At least with *î/y*-final past tense forms, the imperfective equals the present plus the suffix *-ya*, offering an alternative to the parsing in (41.b): *biř-ya-n* [tear-IPFV-3PL].

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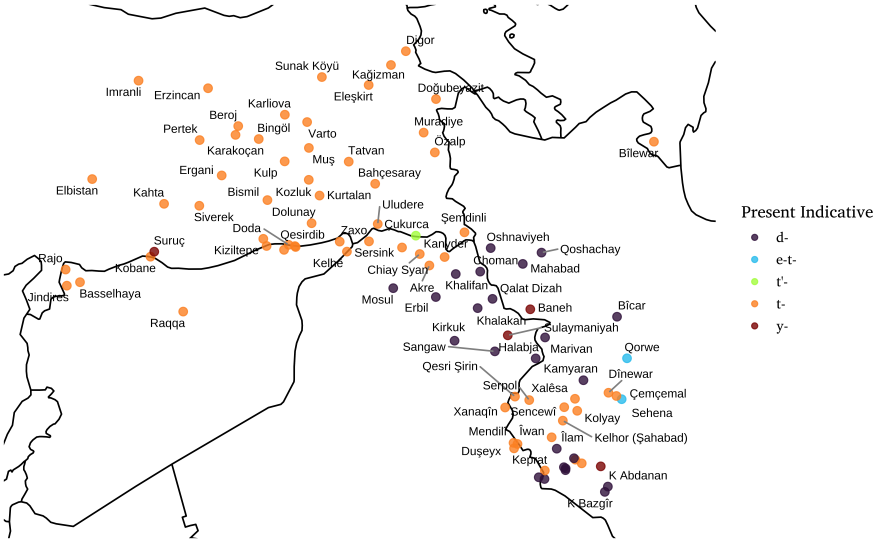

Figure 18.3: Geographical distribution of *d-*, *t-*, *de-*, and *ʾe-* prefixes on h-initial verbs

(41) SK Kirmanşa (Fattah 2000)

a. *biř-in*
tear.PRS.-3PL
'They tear.'

b. *biřy-a-n*
tear-PST.IPFV-3PL
'They used to tear.'

c. *bü-a-n*
be.PST-IPFV-3PL
'They used to be.'

Some dialects have this suffix only where it merged with *î/ü*-final stems, e.g., SK Qesre Şîrîn *bya-n* [be.PST.IPFV-3PL], Bîlewar *e-ẅa-n* [IPFV-be.PST.IPFV-3PL], Bîcar *d-ûat-in* [IPFV-be.PST.IPFV-3PL], etc. There are possible remnants of this construction in other branches of Kurdish; see the Northern Kurdish example produced by one of Christiane Bulut's consultants (42). It is unclear where the speaker was from or how to interpret the form exactly.

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(42) Northern Kurdish (Bulut 2000: 158)
mişk nan-ê me di-xwar-a
mouse bread-EZ 1PL.OBL IPFV-eat.PST.3SG-IPFV
'The mouse [was eating] our bread.'

In Southern Kurdish dialects, the past conditional is the past imperfective stem with the *-(y)a* suffix combined with the subjunctive prefix *b-*, e.g., Sencewî *bi-kird-ya-n* [SBJV-make.PST-IPFV-3PL]. The form of the past conditional persists in all Kurdish varieties, despite the use of other imperfective strategies. This suggests a once larger distribution of this construction.

18.2.4 Negation of habitual forms

There is significant variation across Kurdish dialects in the forms of negation markers. As is the case for most Western Iranic languages that have imperfective prefixes, the negator precedes the prefix. The lenition of **d* in post-vocalic position causes fusional forms, e.g., most Southern Kurdish *nye-* (< **ni-de-*), SK Bîcar nî- (< **ni-d-*), and *na-* (< **ne-de-*). Note that these etymologies are clear from Southern Kurdish. However, Geoffrey Haig, in his 2023 conference presentation at *the Sixth International Conference on Kurdish Linguistics*, suggested that the negative imperfective *na-* that occurs in all of Northern Central and Southern Kurdish may not be a unimorphated affix. He argued that because *di-* was originally a progressive marker, it may not have been compatible with negation in the first place. There is a well-known typological tendency that progressives do not readily lend themselves to negation. In fact, innovative progressives in NK Behdînî and Zazaki are clear instances of this tendency; they are also only used in affirmative declarative sentences (§19.2.1.2, §19.2.2).

In most Southern Kurdish dialects, the negator of the present indicative and the past imperfective is the same (43).

(43) a. SK Kolyay (Fattah 2000)
na-tan-in
NEG.IND-be.able.PRS-3PL
'They cannot.'

b. *na-tan-ist-in*
NEG.IPFV-be.able-PST-3PL
'They used not to be able.'

(44) SK Şerwan K

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a. *nye-ke-n*
NEG.IND-make.PRS-3PL
'They do not make.'

b. *nye-kird-in*
NEG.IPFV-make.PST-3PL
'They used not to make.'

In contrast to Southern Kurdish, Northern and Central Kurdish have different negation strategies in the past and present tenses. In the present tense, all dialects use the negative prefix *na-*, which can never co-occur with the imperfective prefix (*d-*, *t-*, *de-*, or *e-*). According to Karim (2024), this is likely due to the fact that *na-* is the expected outcome of *ne-de-. In other words, *na-* is a contracted form with the reflexes of both the negative and imperfective markers. In contrast with the present-tense forms, before past forms both Northern and Central Kurdish show an agglutinative construction with a negative prefix, either the unimorphated negator *na-* (< *ne-de-) or the regular negator *ne-* and the imperfective prefix, *d-*, *t-*, *de-*, or *e-*, depending on the dialect. The latter type of construction results in negative past imperfective forms like the CK Merîwan *ne-de-kird-* [NEG-IPFV-do.PST-], NK Tatvan *ne-di-kir-* [NEG-IPFV-do.PST-], CK Slemani *ne-[ʾ]e-kird-* [NEG-IPFV-do.PST-], CK Helebce *na-[ʾ]e-kird-* [NEG.IPFV-IPFV-do.PST-] (examples from Matras et al. 2016). These forms do not feature the expected post-vocalic lenition of *d*, pointing to its recent innovation, i.e., it developed after the lenition of *d* had past from active phonology into diachrony. Both prefixes *ne-* and *de-* are available analogical exemplars from other parts of the paradigm, e.g., *ne-kird-* [NEG-do.PST-] and *de-kird-* [IPFV-do.PST-]. In dialects where the regular imperfective marker is *e-*, the past negative imperfective is *ne-[ʾ]e-kird-* [NEG-IPFV-do.PST-] (Kerkûk, Slêmanî, etc.). The imperfective prefix *[ʾ]e-* occurs with a glottal stop, a prosthetic consonant added to vowel-initial words. There are no native word-medial sources for glottal stops in Central Kurdish. This form, once again, reflects recent innovation after the lenition of **d* and the extension of the *e-* allomorph to all contexts.

18.2.5 Discourse-dependent habitual

In Northern Kurdish, it is possible to use the future tense for expressing present habitual actions. This is particularly seen in the colloquial Behdînî NK dialects of Erbil, Duhok, and Shamdinan areas. In the following excerpt, the speaker describes the routine of the chicken that she is taking care of. All verbs are in the future tense form (i.e., *dê* + present stem):

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(45) Shamdinan NK (fieldnotes)

a. *spêdê em dê der-i lê ke-yn=ewe.*
at.morning we FUT door-M.SG.OBL from.it do.PRS-1PL=COMPL
In the morning, we open the door (of the hencoop).

b. *dê bela b-ê-n=e wan der-a=we, dê*
FUT dispersed SBJV-come.PRS-3PL=DRCT those place-PL=POST FUT
ke-n=e qireqir.
do.PRS-3PL=DRCT scream
'They disperse around, they scream.'

c. *dê keyf-a wan xoş b-ît, dê bo xo*
FUT joy-EZ.F their pleasant be.IRR-3SG FUT for self
gerr-iyê-n
roam-MPASS.PRS-3PL
'They rejoice, they walk around.'

Likewise, another narrator refers to a young person in his village who everyday goes out with his old father to take some air:

(46) Shamdinan NK (fieldnotes)
hemî rojê dê bab-ê xo da-nê-t=e di erebanê da
all day FUT father-EZ.M REFL PVB-put.PRS-3SG=DRCT in wheelchair in
û dê în-ît gêrr-ît
and FUT bring.PRS-3SG roam.PRS.CAUS-3SG
'Everyday he puts his father in the wheelchair and brings (up) and makes him wander around.'

As seen in the final verb in (46), the future tense particle can have scope over more than one verb in sequence. An example of a longer sequence of verbs following the particle is (47):

(47) Shamdinan NK (fieldnotes)
heke berhela b-in, dê bo xo ç-in,
if released be.PRS.SBJV-3pl FUT for REFL go.PRS.SBJV-3PL
çer-in, hêwar-iş hê-n
graze.PRS.SBJV-3PL evening-ADD come.PRS.SBJV-3PL
ç-in=e di kulît-î da
go.PRS.SBJV-3PL=DRCT in hencoop-M.SG.OBL in
'If they are free (i.e., not in a fenced ground), they go, graze, and in the evening they come and enter into the hencoop.'

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In (47), the future particle expressing the habitual is used in an apodosis of a conditional clause. This is very common. A further example, with an extended apodosis, is (48):

(48) Shamdinan NK (fieldnotes)
heke berdayî b-in, dê pîyaz-a kol-in=ewe,
if free be.PRS.SBJV-3PL FUT onion-PL.OBL dig.PRS.SBJV-3PL=COMPL
dê maydanoz-ê kol-in=ewe, dê hê-n=e di
FUT parsley-F.SG.OBL dig.PRS-3PL=COMPL FUT come.PRS.SBJV-3PL=DRCT in
xanî da, hemi tişt-a dê ke-n, dê mizurri-ya
house in all thing-PL.OBL FUT do.PRS.SBJV-3PL FUT naughtiness-PL.OBL
ke-n, dê hewd-ê xirab ke-n
do.PRS.SBJV-3PL FUT patch-F.SG.OBL bad do.PRS.SBJV-3PL
'If they are released (and not kept in a fenced area), they dig up the onions, they dig up parsley, they enter into the house, they do everything, they do naughty things, they spoil the patch.'

The use of the future form to express a discourse-dependent habitual is characteristic of the Behdînî dialects of Northern Kurdish. There are, however, some such uses in the recorded texts from the Mardin region, as in the passage below, where the follow-up actions are expressed by future forms.

(49) Mardin Tor NK (Ritter 1969: 5)
ehl-ê Kerboran hemû rûniştin-a li-ser ʿerd-ê,
people-EZ.PL PN all sit-INF-EZ.F.SG on-top ground-F.SG.OBL
çêtir ji ya ser text û qeryol-a ti-hebên-in, ji
better than EZ.DEM.F.SG on bed and sofa-PL.OBL IPFV-prefer.PST-3PL from
ber kû timudaim li-ser ʿerd-ê di-rûn-in. Wextê ş
before REL always on-top ground-F.SG.OBL IND-sit.PRS-3PL When from
şuxul-ek-î ew ji derekî
work-INDF-M.SG.OBL DEM.DIST.DIR from outside-INDF-M.SG.OBL
t-ê-n=e mal, wê li dor-a xwe
IND-come.PRS-3PL=DRCT home FUT at around-EZ.F.SG REFL
meyzên-in, heke tişt-ek dît-in, yanî cil-ek
look.PRS.SBJV-3PL if thingINDF.DIR see.PST-3PL that.is clothINDF.DIR
û merş-ek, wê di-kşên-in=e bin xwe û wê
and carpet-INDF.DIR FUT IND-find.PRS-3PL=DRCT under REFL and FUT
li-ser rûn-in.
on-top sit.PRS.SBJV-3PL
'The people of Kerboran all prefer sitting on the ground to sitting on

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sofas, as they always sit on the ground. When they come home from work, they look around them, if they find something, such as a cloth or carpet, they pull it under them and they sit on it.'

Behdînî dialects express a discourse-dependent past habitual by the particle *da* combined with a present verb stem:

(50) NK Shamdinan
da her ro li min de-t
HAB.PST every day at me give.PRS-3SG
'He would hit me everyday.'

This *da* past habitual is used when narrating a series of habitual actions that are temporally sequential or closely connected thematically. The following excerpt is one such instance where it is seen that the particle is repeated with each verb in the sequence.

(51) NK Akre (MacKenzie 1962: 242)
mirov-ek hebû, hemû roj-ê da
man-INDF.DIR exist.PST.3SG, all day-INDF.DIR HAB.PST
ç-ît=e çîya-y, da bi xo
go.PRS.SBJV-3SG=DRCT mountain-M.SG.OBL, HAB.PST for REFL
pištî-ek-ê dar-a în-ît=e bajêr-î.
load-INDF-EZ.F.SG wood-PL.OBL bring.PRS.SBJV-3SG=DRCT city-M.SG.OBL
bi xo da firoş-ît, da d-e-t bi nan,
for REFL HAB.PST sell.PRS.SBJV-3SG HAB.PST give.PRS.SBJV-3SG with bread
da be-t=eve bo xo û dayk-a xo
HAB.PST take.PRS.SBJV-3SG=COMPL for REFL and mother-EZ.F.SG REFL
'Once there was a man who used to go every day to the mountains by himself and bring a load of wood to town on his back. He would himself sell it, spend (the proceeds) on food and take it back (home) for himself and his mother.'

In certain contexts the particle combines with a past conditional or a past counterfactual verb form, which has the *-ba* ending, as:

(52) a. *em da çû-ba-yn=e ser rûbar-î.*
we HAB.PST go.PST-IRR.PST-1PL=DRCT on river-M.SG.OBL
'(When we were children), we would go to the river.'

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b. *ez da hat-i-ba-m=e otogar-ê*
1SG HAB.PST come.PST-PTCP-COND.PST-1SG=DRCT station-F.SG.OBL
heta spêdê da li wêrê ma-ba-m.
until morning HAB.PST at there stay.PST-COND.PST-1SG
'I would come to the bus station, and I would stay there until morning.'

The basis of the alternation between a present versus past conditional verb form with the *da* particle is unclear. Native speakers accept both versions and see no difference between them, but they use the present tense verb conjugation much more commonly.

This *da* particle is used exclusively in the Behdînî dialects of NK, thus in such locations as Duhok, Zakho, Barzan, Mergasor, Akre, Amadiya, Hakkari, Gever, Shamdinan, Urmiya. In the outlier Zakho and Hakkari dialects, it is sometimes reduced to its vowel.

In addition to the expression of past habitual, the particle *da* is also used in the expression of a counterfactuals conditionals (e.g., *I would have eaten earlier had I known you are not coming back tonight*).

There is no established etymology and source for the particle *da*, but as is the case with the future tense particle *dê* (§17.2.1), it may have evolved from the past imperfective conjugation of the verb *viyan* 'want, need', viz., *da* < *di-viya*.

In some Northern Kurdish dialects that do not have the *da* particle, in addition to the past imperfective verb form, sometimes a past conditional (counterfactual) verb form with a preceding future particle is used to express sequential actions:

(53) NK Şirnak (field notes)

a. *em-ê sibehê ra-bû-ba-n.*
we-FUT morning PVB-be.PST-COND.PST-1PL
'We would wake up in the morning.'

b. *me yê heywan-ê xwe der-êxist-iba derve.*
we FUT animal-EZ.M.SG self PVB-drop.PAST-COND.PST.3SG outside
'we would take the sheep out'

c. *em-ê çû-ba-n ber wan.*
we-FUT go.PST-COND.PST-1PL in.front.of 3PL.OBL
'We would go to herd them.'

d. *êvar me yê bi-doş-a-n-a.*
evening we FUT SBJV-milk.PST-COND-3PL-COND
'In the evening we would milk them.'

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e. *em-ê çû-ba-n xanîk-ê xwe da.*
we-FUT go.PST-COND.PST-1PL hut-EZ.M.SG self in
'We would (then) go (back) into our hut.'

18.3 Habitual in Gorani

Although the functions of the habitual in Gorani are essentially the same as those of their counterparts in Kurdish, there are a few morphological differences. For instance, Gorani differs from Kurdish in that the prefix forms, usually *me-* or *m-*, only occur in the present tense (54). They differ from most of Kurdish in the formation of the past imperfective, which has the structure: present-tense stem + past converter + person-number suffixes (54).

(54) Gorani Pawe

a. *me-ker-an*
IND-make.PRS-3PL
'They make.'

b. *ker-ên-ê*
make.PRS-IPFV-3PL
'They used to make.'

The Gorani dialect of Gewrecû exhibits a verbal system that is heavily influenced by contact with Southern Kurdish and neighbouring varieties of Central Kurdish. It has replicated the Kurdish past-tense forms based on the past stem and the present-tense imperfective marker (55):

(55) Gorani Gewrecû (Mahmoudveysi et al. 2012)

a. *me-ker-in*
IND-make.PRS-3PL
'They make.'

b. *kerd-in*
make.PST-3PL
'They used to make.'

18.3.1 Geographical distribution of prefixes

There are two different forms of the prefix *me-* and *m-*. Almost all Gorani dialects have the form *me-*, while Hewramî dialects and also the adjacent Qela dialect

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have the form *m-*. This shorter form is caused by historical sound changes that are discussed in §18.3.2.

18.3.2 Attrition and historical layers of the prefixes

The Hewramî core of Gorani exhibits some attrition of prefixes. At an early period, they underwent a pretonic shortening of the vowel **e*, just as in Southern Kurdish, resulting in the prefix *m-*, e.g., Luhon *m-ar-o* [IND-bring.PRS-3SG] 'he brings'. Before stems with the forms C-, CY-, and CCVC- the prefix occurs with the epentetic vowe *i*: *mi-*, e.g., *mi-l-o* [IND-go.PRS-3SG] 's/he goes'. Before stems with the form CVC, however, the prefix has been lost, depending on the initial consonant of the root.

The loss of the *m-* prefix occurred before voiceless-stop-initial CVC- stems in all the core Hewramî dialects. Compare the forms in (56): Goranî Pawe exhibits the inherited form; Qela exhibits the vowel reduction in the prefix; Luhon (Hewramî) exhibits the complete loss of the prefix. Note that in these dialects, the stress on the person marker becomes the only signifier of the imperfective (indicative/habitual), contrasting with the subjunctive *kér-o* [make.PRS.SBJV-3SG].

(56) a. Gorani Pawe
me-ker-ó
IND-make.PRS-3SG
'He makes.'

b. Gorani Qela
mi-ker-ó
IND-make.PRS-3SG
'He makes.'

c. Gorani (Hewramî) Luhon
ker-ó
make.PRS.IND-3SG
'He makes.'

The loss of the *m-* prefix occurred before voiced-stop-initial CVC- stems as well but not in all the core Hewramî varieties. Compare the forms in (57): The form in Luhon has the *m-* prefix, contrasting with the Luhon form in (56). However, the form in Gorani Takht (Hewramî) is lost.

(57) a. Gorani Pawe

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me-zan-ó
IND-know.PRS-3SG
'he knows'

b. Gorani (Hewramî) Luhon
mi-zan-ó
IND-know.PRS-3SG
'he knows'

c. Gorani (Hewramî) Takht
zan-ó
know.PRS.IND-3SG
'he knows'

For a full analysis of the environments that condition the loss of the prefix in Hewramî, see Mohammadirad & Karim (2025).

18.3.3 Past forms of the habitual

The Hewramî past-imperfective is formed from the present stem, the past imperfective suffix *-ê(n)*, and a special set of person-number affixes. These can be understood as the continuation of the present-tense optative found in Western Middle Iranian (Skjærvø 2009: 219). This form is sparsely attested in Western Middle Iranian with various functions: irrealis, wishes, etc., but not habitual. However, the Early New Persian equivalent clitic *=i* is attested with a habitual function.

Compare the Gorani (Hewramî) Takht forms in (58), which use the present-tense stem, perhaps better labelled imperfective stem, with an additional suffix on the past form.

(58) Goranî (Hewramî) Takht

a. *ker-ó*
do.PRS.3SG.M
'He does.'

b. *ker-ḗ*
do.PRS-PST.IPFV.3SG.M
'He used to do.'

18.3.4 Negation of habitual forms

Negation markers in Gorani generally correspond to what is attested in other branches of Western Iranian. The past imperfective, which does not have a pre-

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fix, is negated by the marker *né-*, which is used to negate all past-tense forms and the present subjunctive. The present indicative/imperfective/habitual is negated by the prefix *ní-*, perhaps representing a vowel harmonic effect like New Persian *ne-mī-kon-am* [NEG-IND-do.PRS-1SG] vs. *na-kon-am* [NEG.SBJV-do.PRS-1SG], cf. Shabaki (Gorani) *ní-me-ker-î* [NEG-IND-do.PRS-1SG] vs. *né-ker-î* [NEG.SBJV-do.PRS-1SG].

However, in the core Hewramî dialects, the stress of the negation marker shifts from the weak vowel onto the imperfective prefix **ní-me-* > *nmé-*. When pretonic shortening affects the imperfective affirmative, the contrast becomes *mi-* [IND-] vs *nmé-* [NEG.IND-]. In most Hewramî dialects, the initial **nm* cluster is further reduced to *mé-*, superficially similar to the prohibitive on most verbs (see Karim & Mohammadirad 2026).

18.4 Habitual in Zazaki

In Zazaki, the present habitual is expressed by the simple present without a preverbal particle. The past habitual is expressed by the past imperfective, which is formed by attaching an invariable suffix to the past stem. This suffix does not inflect for person, number, or gender (Table 18.1). In the Southern dialects, the nasal element has largely been lost, resulting in forms that are homophonous with the 3PL perfect. Zazaki

Table 18.1: Invariable past imperfective suffixes in Zazaki

Northern Zazaki	Central Zazaki	Southern Zazaki
-(y)êne ~-(y)êni	*-(y)ên ~-(y)în*	*-(y)ê*

The past imperfective is used not only for past habitual actions, but also for durative situations in the past, including background information in narratives (cf. Paul 2024: 89-90). In addition, the past imperfective serves as the basis of the past subjunctive (irrealis).

(59) NZ (Selcan 1998: 459)
aye her roz kitav wend-êne.
3SG.F.OBL every day book read.PST-IPFV
'She used to read a book every day.'

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(60) CZ (Keskin 2008: 194)
ver, loẍ osta-o viraşt-în.
before stone.roller master-PL.OBL built.PST-IPFV
In the past, masters used to build stone rollers.'

(61) SZ (Paul 2024: 90)
hewa=ra kutik lewa-yê.
air=from dog bark.PST-IPFV
'A dog was barking in the air (background information).'

18.5 Habitual in Arabic

Qəltu Arabic dialects in the NENA area use no preverbal particle for the expression of the general imperfective present (covering habitual aspect and general truths), but use simply the unprefixed Prefix Conjugation (conventionally called the Imperfect) (Jastrow 1978: 299-300).

To express the imperfective past, typically an uninflected particle derived from the past tense of the verb 'to be', *kān* 'he was', is combined with the Prefix Conjugation (Jastrow 1978: 304-305). Originally this would have been inflected, as it still is in many other Arabic dialects. Unusually among the *Qəltu* dialects, the inflected auxiliary is still used in Mosul, Bəḥzāni and Mērgi (Jastrow 1978: 304; 1979: 47; Hassan 2023: 590; Procházka 2019b: 252), e.g.,

(62) *kən-na n-jīb*
be.PST-1PL 1PL-bring.IPFV
'We used to bring.'

18.6 Habitual in Armenian

In Armenian, habitual meaning is generally expressed by the present (present habitual) (63) or imperfect (past habitual) (64) tense. In most forms of Armenian, including the standard languages, the present and imperfect have different sets of endings, both for the copula (glossed as PST) and for synthetic verb forms (see sections 13.4.2, 13.4.1.1). However, in some dialects, including Urmia, the imperfect is formed by adding an invariant particle to the present form, as seen in (65) (present) and 66 (imperfect). In dialects of the Urmia group, this particle is a fossilized form of the 3SG past copula *er* found in other forms of Armenian (see §12.4.4). To our knowledge, this formation is unique within Armenian; in other

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dialects possessing a past particle (Agulis-Meghri and some Karabagh dialects), this is a reduced form of the past (<-*eal*) (67) or resultative (<-*ats*) (68) participle of the verb 'to be'.

(63) SEA (Dum-Tragut 2009: 212)
Amen kiraki or-ə Vardan-ə gn-um=ē Vernisaž.
Every Sunday day-DEF Vardan-DEF go-I.PTCP=be.PRS.3SG Vernissage
'Every Sunday Vardan goes to Vernissage.'

(64) SEA (Dum-Tragut 2009: 212)
Amen kiraki or-ə Vardan-ə gn-um=ēr Vernisaž.
Every Sunday day-DEF Vardan-DEF go-I.PTCP=be.PST.3SG Vernissage
'Vardan used to go to Vernissage very Sunday.'

(65) Urmia Armenian (Asatryan 1962: 104)
kʲiɾ-es=em
write-I.PTCP=be.1SG
'I write.'

(66) Urmia Armenian (Asatryan 1962: 104)
kʲiɾ-es=em=eɾ
write-I.PTCP=be.1SG=PST
'I used to write.'

(67) Agulis (Sargsianc‘ 1883: 117)
n-aham=əm=nel
LOC-say-I.PTCP=be.1SG=PST
'I used to say.'

(68) Karchevan (Muradyan 1960: 238)
min teɣ sœɾyn əpr-ij=in=lets
one place nice live-I.PTCP=be.3PL=PST
'they used to live nicely (together) in one place.'

The standard modern Armenian languages are each generally described as having a single present form, without aspectual distinctions. However, in certain dialects and earlier forms of the language, aspectual distinctions in the present may be expressed. In particular, new progressive forms have been created a number of times in the history of the Armenian language, and there is evidence that

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when this takes place, the older present tense form can become specialised to habitual use.

This issue has been investigated by Avetyan (2021), in the context of the development of the periphrastic present in *-um* (see §12.4.3.1) in Eastern Armenian, which originally had progressive meaning, but is now the general present tense of SEA and most Eastern dialects. Avetyan (2021) observes that in 17th century Eastern Armenian texts, the *-um* forms are rare, and restricted to progressive meaning. The dominant present tense used in these texts is the same form as the present tense of SWA. In the affirmative, this is formed by adding the particle *kə* (or phonetic variants), derived from a periphrasis *kay u* 'stand/exist and', to the Classical Armenian present, which has become the subjunctive of modern Armenian, as seen in example (69). There is a corresponding past imperfective (imperfect) formed from *kə* and the Classical Armenian imperfect (modern Armenian past subjunctive) (70) (see §12.4.2.2 for more details on these forms, which are also likely to have been progressive in origin).

(69) *kə-mna-m.*
PTCL-stay-PRS.1SG
'I stay.'

(70) *kə-mna-yi.*
PTCL-stay-IPF.1SG
'I stayed/used to stay.'

In SEA, the *kə*-forms have been largely replaced by the *-um* present in present-tense contexts, and are generally used as a future/conditional, referred to as "conditional'' mood in traditional Armenian grammar, being used in the apodosis of conditionals (71) in addition to their future function, for which see §17.4.

(71) SEA (Dum-Tragut 2009: 443)
yetʿe aveli lav sovor-es, aveli lav gnahatakan-ner
if more good study-PRS.SBJV.2SG more good mark-PL
k-stan-as.
PTCL-receive-PRS.2SG
'If you study better, you will get better marks.'

The corresponding imperfect *kə*-forms are used in the apodosis of past conditionals (72):

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(72) SEA
yetʿe aveli lav sovor-eir, aveli lav gnahatakan-ner
if more good study-IPF.SBJV.2SG more good mark-PL
k-stan-ayir.
PTCL-receive-IPF.2SG
'If you studied better, you would get better marks.'

However, Avetyan (2021) observes that in some 18th-century Eastern Armenian texts, we find the locative-based present restricted to its original progressive meaning, while the *kə*-forms are used for habitual present (as well as for future). He also notes (Avetyan 2021: 140) that in popular spoken Eastern Armenian (presumably of Yerevan) and in a range of Eastern Armenian dialects, the *kə*-forms may be used for general habitual present, and also for historical/narrative present, as well as for future, but not for progressive present. Dum-Tragut (2009: 254-5) notes that the *kə*- forms may be used in SEA for habitual, and also narrative, function, but that these uses are considered antiquated by some speakers.

This pattern of usage is reflected in texts from Salmast published in Atayan (1906), where the *kə*-forms are used for the main body of the narrative in most of the tales (see §20)[3], and are also used in habitual contexts, as seen in (73), while the locative-based present is generally restricted to progressive contexts (see §19).

(73) Salmast Armenian (Atayan 1906: 206)
hmen or k-et^{h}-an, t^{h}ak^{h}avuəɾ-i xəzin-æ-n k-k^{j}oɣn-an.
every day PTCL-go-3PL king-GEN treasury-ABL-DEF PTCL-steal-3PL
'Every day they go [and] steal from the king's treasury.'

We also find the *kə*- present and imperfect used in habitual contexts by Maryam Grigori, a bilingual speaker of Urmia Armenian and Christian Urmi NENA, who generally uses the locative-based present. Examples (74), (75), and (76) are the only instances in our data where she uses the *kə*- present/imperfect, and all have habitual meaning.

(74) Urmia Armenian (Hodgson field notes)
mezi k-as-en vor menk^{h} gjuɣabaɾbar enk^{h}.
1PL.DAT PTCL-say-3PL COMP 1PL.NOM village.dialect be.PRS.1PL
'They (outsiders) say to us that we are dialect-speakers.'

[3]An exception is the tale of the Sharp-witted Boy (Atayan 1906: 201), where the main body of the narrative is in the aorist, as expected given the discussion of the use of the aorist in §16.

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(75) Urmia Armenian (Hodgson field notes)
əngeɾ-neɾ-ov k-ert^{h}-ank^{h}=eɾ miasin əm... jekeɣets^{h}i.
friend-PL-INS PTCL-go-1PL=PST together (hesitation) church
'We used to go to church together [as a group of] friends.'

(76) Urmia Armenian (Hodgson field notes)
jev əndeɣ uɾax jereko-neɾ-ə k-eln-en=eɾ.
and there happy evening-PL-DEF PTCL-be/happen-3PL=PST
'and happy evenings used to take place there.'

However, in the Urmia dialect texts in Asatryan (1962), produced by speakers whose ancestors migrated to Armenia in 1828, the locative-based present has been generalised to all present uses, including habitual and narrative as well as progressive. The *kə*-forms are mostly used for future and conditional, as in SEA, although in the following example (77) the *kə*-forms are used with habitual meaning.

(77) Urmia Armenian (Asatryan 1962: 155)
aman-ʧ^{h}aman-a ʧ^{h}-i ləv-æ, tur-veɾk^{hj}-æ k^{j}extuət
dishes-DEF NEG-be.PRS.3SG wash-N.PTCP, door-PL-DEF dirty
kə-t^{h}oɣn-i.
PTCL-leave-3SG
'[You'd never think our daughter was old enough to get married,] she doesn't wash the dishes, she leaves the doors dirty.'

18.7 Habitual in Turkic

The earliest habitual TAM category attested in Turkic is traditionally referred to as the aorist—a term that should not be conflated with the homonymous Indo-European category, which denotes a perfective past tense. Throughout its documented history, the Turkic aorist has undergone significant semantic evolution, primarily acquiring modal nuances, yet its reflexes persist in some form across all known Turkic languages (Johanson 2021: 627). In varieties that have developed new present constructions, such as Azeri, the aorist has come to encode general statements, habitual actions and future meanings. This category will be labelled here "eventual", a term adapted from French *éventuel* as proposed by Lazard (1975: 353), who defines it as referring to an action that is not currently occurring, or was not occurring at a specific past moment, but represents a hypothetical or potential event that may materialise under certain conditions. While the semantics

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of French *éventuel* (“possible under certain conditions”) do not fully align with English eventual (“occurring at the end of a process”), the absence of a more precise alternative justifies the adoption of Lazard’s terminology for the present volume.

According to Johanson (2021: 628–629), the thematic base of this TAM category stems from a combination of an old (and currently unproductive) imperfective converb in *-A* (which may have had allomorphs in *-X*)[4] and the auxiliary ‘be’ conjugated in the old present tense. The latter allomorphs of the suffix are not guided simply by vowel harmony but take into account the structure of the lexical base (namely the number of syllables), making them among the rare Turkic suffixes that have not two or four but seven allomorphs: *-Ar*, *-Xr* or *-r*. In modern Azeri, this distribution has become simplified and today is limited to *-Ar* only (thus avoiding confusion with the progressive in *-Xr*), e.g., **bax-a/i ər-ür-* > Standard Azeri *bax-ar-* ‘be looking’, followed by (tense and) agreement markers. In the third-person plural form, the suffixal *r* assimilates to the following lateral, e.g. *bax-ar-lar* [bɑχˈɑlːɑr]. In Standard Azeri, if the lexical base ends in a vowel, it is fully preserved, as is the suffix, and the resulting glide is graphically marked, e.g., *başla-y-ar* ‘s/he will start’ (though the final *a* of vowel-final lexical bases is raised when it is pronounced, e.g., [bɑʃləˈjɑr]).

The origin of the eventual construction as proposed by Johanson (2021) echoes that of the progressive (present imperfective) construction, yet these two grammaticalisation processes occurred centuries apart. The Turkic aorist, which gave rise to the Azeri eventual, is reconstructed to the earliest stages of Proto-Turkic, whereas the progressive did not emerge in Western Oghuz until roughly the fourteenth century, or slightly earlier (Dybo & Levitskaja 2002: 172-176). By the time the progressive emerged, the aorist-eventual had long crystallised as a synthetic form.

Like in the progressive, the negative suffix in the Standard Azeri eventual takes the shape of *-m* (as opposed to *-mA* in most other TAM categories) but, unlike in the progressive, it does not trigger backward stress:

[4]For the notation of Turkic vowels see §7.5.

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Table 18.2: Evenutal and Progressive in Standard Azeri

	Eventual (non-past)	Progressive (present)
Affirmative	*bax-ar-am* [bɑˈχɑɾɑm] 'I will look'	*bax-ır-am* [bɑˈχɯɾɑm] 'I look / am looking'
Negative	*bax-m-ar-am* [bɑχˈmɑɾɑm] 'I will not look'	*bax-m-ır-am* [ˈbɑχmɯɾɑm] 'I do not look / am not looking'

In the second and third persons of the non-past eventual and as well as in all persons in the past eventual, the suffix *-Ar* is replaced by *-Az*, e.g., *bax-ar-san* 'you will look' vs. *bax-m-az-san* 'you will not look'; *bax-ar* 's/he will look' vs. *bax-m-az* 's/he will not look'; *bax-ar-dı-m* 'I would look' vs. *bax-m-az-dı-m* 'I would not look'.

Urmia Azeri for the most part shows the same suffixal distribution. In some verbs with vowel-final bases, the suffix may present the archaic form allomorph *-r* (a form that also surfaces sporadically in literary styles of Standard Azeri), e.g., *elə-r* 's/he will do', *oxu-r* 's/he will read' (cf. Standard Azeri *elə-y-ər*, *oxu-y-ar*). As in many Azeri varieties, the suffixal vowel can drop if the lexical base ends in *r*, e.g. *vurram* 'I will hit' (cf. Standard Azeri *vur-ar-am*), or drop with assimilation of the suffixal consonant when the lexical base ends in *l*, e.g., *allam* 'I will get' (cf. Standard Azeri *al-ar-am*). In some sub-varieties, the first-person negative form may feature *-mAn* where others use *-m-Ar*, another widespread dialectal phenomenon, e.g., *gəlmənəm* 'I will not come' (cf. Standard Azeri *gəl-m-ər-əm*).

The non-past eventual primarily encodes the future in modern Azeri but is still frequently found encoding habitual actions. In this latter function, however, it competes with the progressive, which is increasingly generalising to present-time semantics and consequently relegating the eventual to the modal periphery. This process is particularly advanced in the Caucasus varieties of Azeri, where the habitual uses of the eventual have largely retreated to gnomic, commissive and epistemic modal contexts. The varieties spoken in Iran retain the eventual for expressing habitual actions and states, despite the grammatical acceptability of the progressive present tense in these contexts. Consulted speakers from Urmia and Tabriz, for instance, accept both constructions, though further research is required to determine whether specific contexts may favour one form over the other.

(78) Urmia Azeri (Doğan 2010: 404, 457)

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a. *qış gəl-əndə hər nəmnə-miz-i allıx qoy-ar-ıx yān-mız-a.*
winter come-CVB each what-POSS.1PL-ACC get.EVT.1PL put-EVT-1PL side-POSS.1PL-DAT
'When winter comes, we gather whatever we have and keep it close (to ourselves).'

b. *oruş bayram-ı-n=da çox mōtəbər tut-ar-ıx.*
fasting holiday-POSS.3-ACC=ADD a.lot esteemed size-EVT-1PL
'We also celebrate Eid al-Fitr with great festivity.'

In the following example, habitual semantics are expressed by the progressive (present imperfective):

(79) Urmia Azeri (Doğan 2010: 257)
(On being asked about holidays that are usually celebrated in the village)
nōruz beyram-ı çox gözəl tut-ur-ux, hədyə ver-ir-ix.
PN holiday-POSS.3 a.lot beautiful seize-IPFV.PRS-1PL gift give-IPFV:PRS-1PL
'We celebrate the feast of Novruz beautifully; we give (each other) presents.'

The past eventual expresses a past habitual event or action that is no longer ongoing. Functionally, it aligns with the English constructions 'used to V', 'would V' (in the habitual sense):

(80) Urmia Azeri (Doğan 2010: 471)
su gətir-ər-di-m, hasıl suvar-ar-dı-x.
water bring-EVT-PST-1SG produce water-EVT-PST-1PL
'I would fetch the water, and we would irrigate the crops.'

In all known dialects of Azeri, the habitual aspect can also be expressed using the progressive past (or past imperfective). As with the non-past, however, it is difficult to define precise criteria governing the choice between these two categories in habitual contexts:

(81) Urmia Azeri (Doğan 2010: 400)

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ama qabaxca bu.cür=idi, kət-dər-də dünya-ya
but before this.PROX=COP.PST.3 village-PL-LOC world-DAT
gəl-ir-di uşax, bimāristan-da dünya-ya gəl-m-ir-di.
come-IPFV-PST.3 child hospital-LOC world-DAT come-NEG-IPFV-PST.3
'But in the past, this is how it used to be: children would be born in villages, they would not be born in hospitals.'

The two categories may appear in habitual semantics even within the same sentence:

(82) Urmia Azeri (Doğan 2010: 2709)
ged-ir-di-ĥ dərs oxu-mağ-a, onnan gəl-ir-di-ĥ, bekar
go-IPFV-PST-1PL lesson read-INF-DAT that.ABL come-IPFV-PST-1PL idle
vəx-lər-imiz, gənə otar-a-dı-x davar-ı mal-ı.
time-PL-POSS.1PL again graze-EVT-PST-1PL small.livestock-ACC cattle-ACC
'We would go to school, then return, and in our free time, we would take the animals out to graze again.'

It is noteworthy that in potential constructions, which in Azeri are formed with the auxiliary *bil-* 'know', the choice between the eventual and progressive is semantically marked: the former tends to reflect authority (deontic modality), while the latter capacity (dynamic modality):

(83) Urmia Azeri (Doğan 2010: 377, 364)

a. *necə mən o-nu bātil eli-yə bil-ər-əm?*
how I that-ACC null do-CVB know-evt-1sg
'(This is what the Prophet prescribed.) How can I disregard it?!'

b. *bi-bilə ancax elə əğl-imiz-ə gəl-ir danış-a*
this-much only FOC mind-POSS.1PL-DAT come-IPFV.PRS.3 talk-CVB
bil-ır-ıx.
know-IPFV.PRS-1PL
'Only this comes to our mind, (this is what) we can tell.'

18.8 Discussion

The NENA verbal forms with the prefixes *k-* and *ʾi-* (and variants of these) attached to the present stem that are used to express the habitual originated historically as progressives (§19.1.1). The processes of language contact that are likely to have induced their development have been discussed in §19.6.

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In many NENA dialects innovative progressive constructions subsequently developed and the forms with *k-* and *ʾi-* became restricted to the expression of the habitual. A clear parallel to this is found in Eastern Armenian (§18.6). Armenian present verbs with the particle *kə-* originally expressed the progressive and then were extended to the expression of the habitual. Subsequently the progressive function was taken over by innovative locative forms and the forms with the *kə-* came to be restricted to the habitual and, in many dialects, were eventually supplanted in this function by the locative forms. A further parallel between NENA and Armenian is that the bare present stem without the preverbal particle in both NENA and Armenian came to express the irrealis subjunctive. This differs from the Iranian languages of the area, in which the subjunctive is expressed by a specific subjunctive pre-verbal particle.

Qəltu Arabic dialects exhibit progressive forms with a prefixed presentative *kū* (or phonetic variants), but, unlike NENA or Armenian, this construction was not extended to express the habitual, which is expressed by the present stem without a prefix (§18.5).

The Kurdish particle prefixed to the present stem that matches NENA *k-* and *ʾi-* is *de-* (or phonetic variants). Such Kurdish forms are used to express both the habitual and the progressive. There are a number of phonotactic parallels between the Kurdish particle and the NENA particles. The clearest of these is the tendency in both NENA and Kurdish for these particles to undergo attrition, especially before verbal stems beginning with a consonant (§18.2.2). In Gorani a similar attrition of the corresponding preverbal particle *me-* is particularly advanced (§18.3.2). The advanced degree of attrition of the preverbal particles in NENA dialects in the eastern sector, especially in the Jewish Trans-Zab dialects, indeed, may have been induced by the patterns of attrition in Gorani.

Parallels to the phenomenon of combining preverbal habitual particles that is found in some NENA dialects, e.g., C. Urmi *c-i-patəx* 'he opens', J. Barzan *ʾi-k-exəl* 'he eats' (24) are attested in some Kurdish dialects (39).

In some Kurdish dialects the preverbal particle is sometimes cliticised onto the end of the preceding word (§18.2) and parallels to this can be found in NENA dialects in same area in the north-eastern sector (4).

The past habitual in NENA is expressed by combining the invariable past copula particle *-wa* to the present stem after the person markers. In most NENA dialects the present stem has a preverbal particle, as in the present habitual, e.g.,

(84) C. Qaraqosh

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a. *k-paθəx-wa*
PRTCL-open.3SG.M-PST
'He used to open.'

b. *k-paθx-a-wa*
PRTCL-open-3SG.F-PST
'She used to open.'

c. *k-paθx-i-wa*
PRTCL-open-3PL-PST
'They used to open.'

In some dialects, however, the preverbal particle is absent in the past habitual form (18, 19).

Parallels to the NENA past habitual construction formed from the present stem and a past-shifting suffix (e.g., C. Qaraqosh *paθəx-wa* 'he used to open') are found in Armenian and Gorani. In Armenian the closest documented parallel is with the Armenian dialects of the Urmia region (including Salmast, Khoy, and Maragha), in which the past habitual is formed by adding an invariable fossilised past copula clitic *=er* to an inflected present form (see examples 75, and 76). In Gorani the past habitual is formed from the present stem by adding a past-shifting suffix (18.3.3). Unlike in NENA and Urmia Armenian, however, the person inflection is suffixed to the past-shifting suffix rather than the present stem. Moreover, whereas the past-shifting clitic *=er* in Urmia Armenian is clearly a fossilised past copula, the Gorani past-shifting suffix appears to be an optative marker in origin. In Gorani the past habitual does not have a preverbal particle. This phenomenon is attested in some NENA dialects and could be an archaism, possibly matching Gorani.

The embryonic form of the NENA past habitual construction is found already in earlier layers of Aramaic, e.g., Syriac, in which a past habitual can be expressed by an active particle (the origin of the NENA present stem) + the auxiliary past copula *hwā* (the origin of the NENA past-shifting suffix *wa*) (Nöldeke 1904: 216-218). The person inflection in this Syriac construction, however, is on the auxiliary rather than on the stem. Contact with Armenian and Gorani may have reinforced the use of the form in NENA and, in the case of Armenian, induced the shift of the person markers to the stem and the fossilisation of the past copula.

The past habitual in most Kurdish dialects (§18.2.3) and in Zazaki (§18.4) is formed from the past stem, and so differs typologically from the NENA past habitual.

The negation of habitual forms in NENA often results in the lenition and contraction of the habitual preverbal particle after the negator *la* (§18.1.5). There are

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parallels to this phenomenon in Kurdish, whereby the negative particle coalesces with the preverbal particle (§18.2.4).

The discourse-dependent habitual constructions in NENA are formed by using the future-marking prefix (*bəd* or phonetic variants) (§18.1.6), e.g., C. Barwar *bət-paθəx* 'he opens.' The past discourse-dependent is formed by adding the past-shifting suffix *-wa*, e.g., C. Barwar *bət-paθəx-wa* 'he would open.' This construction is found in NENA dialects in the northern sector. It matches the use of the future form as a discourse-dependent habitual in Behdînî dialects of Northern Kurdish (§18.2.5). This geographical overlap, therefore, suggests that the NENA form has developed under the influence of Behdînî Kurdish. The hypothesis that NENA construction developed by extension of future forms in the apodosis of conditional constructions to a wider sequential usage is supported by the fact that in Behdînî dialects past discourse-dependent habituals can be expressed by a past conditional or a past counterfactual verb form (52). In Behdînî the past discourse-dependent habitual is not formed by adding a past shifting suffix as in NENA, but rather by using a different future preverbal particle, viz. *dê* (present) vs *da* (past). The NENA construction, therefore, is the result of only partial convergence with the Behdînî Kurdish model. It should be noted, however, that both Kurdish *dê* and *da* appear to be derived from the verb 'to want', as is the case with the NENA future prefix *bət*. It is worthy noting that the Turkic "eventual" form that expresses the habitual (§18.7) is also used as a modal future form. This may have reinforced the use of the NENA future form for the habitual in dialects in contact with Turkic in the Urmi area.

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19 The expression of the progressive

19.1 Progressive in NENA

19.1.1 Preliminary remarks

Progressive aspect views an event as ongoing without temporal boundaries. The reference time may be speech time, in which case the progressive expresses an event that overlaps with speech time. Progressive forms are also used with a reference time that is anterior or posterior to speech time. Constructions that are used to express progressive dynamic activities are widely used in NENA dialects also to express ongoing states.

Various constructions are used in NENA dialects to express the progressive. In some dialects the same form is used to express the progressive and the habitual (see example 3). In most dialects, however, a specific innovative form has developed to express the progressive. In many dialects, the innovative construction that is used for the progressive is also used to express the habitual aspect. This reflects a common typological pathway of extension of the use of progressive forms to express also habitual activities (Deo 2015). In most dialects, however, there is a restriction on the use of a progressive form for the habitual. In some dialects the use of a progressive form to express a habitual is restricted to habitual activity within a delimited interval of time (see examples 80 and 81). Another tendency found in various dialects is for the habitual use of progressive forms to express discourse prominence (see example 51).

Various dialects have more than one progressive construction. In some dialects these are in free variation. In a number of dialects, however, their distribution is conditioned by polarity, in that different forms are used for positive and negated progressive respectively (§19.1.5), or by discourse pragmatic factors (§19.1.6).

In some dialects a progressive construction is restricted to the present, whereas in others distinctions in the tense and, in some cases, also the mood of the progressive can be made by appropriate auxiliaries (§19.1.7).

In earlier Aramaic, the progressive was expressed by the active particle *qāṭel*. In NENA dialects the reflex of this form serves as the present stem in the verbal system. In some dialects the present stem continues to be used to express

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the progressive. In most such cases, constructions with the present stem that express the progressive include additional elements. These additional elements can historically, at least, be classified as deictic particles and copulas. In some cases, deictic particles and copula elements are combined. These additional elements were added in historical cycles. In the first cycle, prefix elements with the forms *ʾi-* (after vowels *y-*) and *k-* (or phonetic variants thereof) were added, e.g., *ʾi-qaṭəl*, *k-qaṭəl*. The element *ʾi-* is a shortened form of the copula and *k-* appears to be a deictic element derived historically from the locative adverbial **kā* 'here'. These forms are likely to have originally expressed only the progressive, but now their most common function is the expression of the habitual (see chapter 18). Progressive forms tend to be expressed by the addition of a second cycle of copula and deictic elements, e.g.,

(1) C. Qaraqosh
   a. *k-paθəx.*
      DEIC-open.PRS.3SG.M
      'He opens (habitual).'
   b. *k-ilə* *k-paθəx.*
      DEIC-COP.3SG.M DEIC-open.PRS.3SG.M
      'He is opening (progressive).'

The added elements to form progressives in this second cycle in some dialects, such as C. Qaraqosh, include copula elements that are inflected for number, gender, person, and in some cases also tense, aspect and mood. In a variety of dialects, however, the second cycle copula element is an uninflected, and often reduced, form of the copula.

In a wide range of NENA dialects, an innovative form of progressive has developed consisting of an infinitive and the locative preposition *bə*. This is combined with a copula, a deictic element or a combination of the two. By way of illustration, see example (2) below from C. Urmi, which exhibits constructions both with the enclitic copula and also with the deictic copula, e.g.,

(2) C. Urmi
   a. *bə-ptaxə=lə.*
      in-open.INF=COP.3SG.M
      'He is opening.'
   b. *du=lə* *bə-ptaxa.*
      DEIC=COP.3SG.M in-open.INF
      'He is opening.'

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19.1.2 Progressive forms based on the present stem

Dialects with progressive constructions based on the present stem *qaṭəl* are found predominantly in the north-western and south-eastern sectors of NENA.

In a few dialects a single form based on the present stem is used for both the progressive and the habitual. One such dialect is Bohtan in the north-western sector of NENA.

(3) C. Bohtan (Fox 2009 and Khan, fieldnotes)

a. *gorəš.*
pull.PRS.3SG.M
'He pulls (habitual)/is pulling (progressive).'

b. *y-oxəl.*
COP-eat.PRS.3SG.M
'He eats (habitual)/is eating (progressive).'

In C. Bohtan, the progressive/habitual form has a *y-* prefix before verbal roots with a weak initial consonant. This is a reduced form of the copula. It is elided before roots beginning with a strong consonant. As remarked above, this represents the first historical cycle of copula or deictic elements added to the present stem.

In most dialects with progressive constructions based on the present base, a specific progressive construction has developed with a second cycle of augment elements consisting of a deictic element, copula, or a combination of the two. The present stem form without the progressive augment can typically express both the habitual and the progressive, but the marked progressive form with the augment is the normal progressive form.

In some cases the second cycle of augments consists of inflected copulas, as we have seen above in C. Qaraqosh. This is found in dialects of the northern sector, in which the copula augment is typically a preposed deictic copula, and in some dialects of the south-eastern sector of NENA, in which the copula element is a clitic, e.g.,

(4) C. Barəṭle (al-Saka 2024: 1063-1065)

a. *k-ilə* *k-paθəx.*
DEIC-COP.3SG.M DEIC-open.PRS.3SG.M
'He is opening (progressive).'

b. *k-iyət* *k-paθx-ət.*
DEIC-COP.2SG.M DEIC-open.PRS-2SG.M
'You (sg.m) are opening (progressive).'

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(5) C. Aqra (town) (Coghill 2008: 102–104; Khan, fieldnotes)

a. *ho-le k-šate.*
DEIC-COP.3SG.M DEIC-drink.PRS.3SG.M
'He is drinking (progressive).'

b. *ho-la k-šatya.*
DEIC-COP.3SG.F DEIC-drink.PRS-3SG.F
'She is drinking (progressive).'

c. *ho-na k-šati.*
DEIC-COP.3PL DEIC-drink.PRS-3PL
'They are drinking (progressive).'

(6) C. Sanandaj (Panoussi 1990: 118)

a. *bašəl=ile.*
cook.PRS.3SG.M=COP.3SG.M
'He is cooking.'

b. *k-axəl=ile.*
DEIC-eat.PRS.3SG.M=COP.3SG.M
'He is eating.'

c. *bašl-en=yen.*
cook.PRS-1SG.M=COP.1SG.M
'I am cooking.'

d. *k-axl-ən=yen.*
DEIC-eat.PRS-1SG.M=COP.1SG.M
'I am eating.'

In many dialects, the copula augment is fossilised and has a 3sg inflection throughout the paradigm of the verb. This is the case in some dialects in the north-western periphery of NENA, in which the 3sg.m deictic copula *hole* is combined with verbs of all persons, e.g.,

(7) C. Haṣṣan

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3SG.M	*hole k-šate*	'He is drinking.'
3SG.F	*hole k-šatya*	'She is drinking.'
3PL	*hole k-šata*	'They are drinking.'
2SG.M	*hole k-šatət*	'You (sg.m) are drinking.'
2SG.F	*hole k-šatyat*	'You (sg.f) are drinking.'
2PL	*hole k-šatütən*	'You (pl) are drinking.'
1SG.M	*hole k-šatən*	'I (sg.m) am drinking.'
1SG.F	*hole k-šatyan*	'I (sg.f) am drinking.'
1PL	*hole k-šatux*	'We are drinking.'

Some dialects on the north-western periphery, of NENA use an invariable deictic copula form before a verb derived from the present stem without a first cycle augment (*k-* or *y-*), even when the root begins with a weak consonant, e.g.,

(8) C. Hertevin (Jastrow 1988: 64)

3SG.M	*hole ʾate*	'He is coming.'
3SG.F	*hole ʾatya*	'She is coming.'
3PL	*hole ʾate*	'They are coming.'
2SG.M	*hole ʾatət*	'You (sg.m) are coming.'
2SG.F	*hole ʾatyat*	'You (sg.f) are coming.'
2PL	*hole ʾateton*	'You (pl) are coming.'
1SG.M	*hole ʾatən*	'I (sg.m) am coming.'
1SG.F	*hole ʾatyan*	'I (sg.f) am coming.'
1PL	*hole ʾataḥ*	'We are coming.'

(9) C. Umra (Hobrack 2000: 82)

3SG.M	*wəl ʾate*	'He is coming.'
3SG.F	*wəl ʾatya*	'She is coming.'
3PL	*wəl ʾata*	'They are coming.'

In the C. Sulemaniyya dialect on the south-eastern periphery the progressive has a second cycle augment of an enclitic copula that is inflected for person only on third person verbs. On first and second person verbs a fossilised form of the 3sg.m copula is used:

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(10) C. Sulemaniyya (Khan, fieldnotes)

3SG.M	*k-axəl=ile*	'He is eating.'
3SG.F	*k-əxla=ila*	'She is eating.'
3PL	*k-əxli=ilu*	'They are eating.'
2SG.M	*k-əxlət=ile*	'You (sg.m) are eating.'
2SG.F	*k-əxlat=ile*	'You (sg.f) are eating.'
2PL	*k-əxlitun=ile*	'You (pl) are eating.'
1SG.M	*k-əxlən=ile*	'I (sg.m) am eating.'
1SG.F	*k-əxlan=ile*	'I (sg.f) am eating.'
1PL	*k-əxlux=ile*	'We are eating.'

In various dialects, especially in the Arbīl and Sulemaniyya provinces, progressive constructions based on the present stem are augmented by second cycle preposed uninflected particles, many of which appear to be fossilised forms of the copula in origin.

In several dialects in this region progressives based the present base are expressed by the preposed augment *lā*, which is likely to be a reduced form of the 3sg.f copula *ila*, e.g.,

(11) J. Arbel (Khan 1999a)

3SG.M	*lā k-xəl*	'He is eating.'
3SG.F	*lā k-əxla*	'She is eating.'
3PL	*lā k-əxli*	'They are eating.'

(12) C. Koy Sanjak/Armota (Khan, fieldnotes)

3SG.M	*lā k-axəl*	'He is eating.'
3SG.F	*lā k-əxla*	'She is eating.'
3PL	*lā k-əxli*	'They are eating.'

Several dialects use variant forms of the preposed augment *lā* with an initial */n/*, *nā*, e.g.,

(13) J. Dobe (Khan, fieldnotes)

3SG.M	*nā k-xəl*	'He is eating.'
3SG.F	*nā k-əxla*	'She is eating.'
3PL	*nā k-əxli*	'They are eating.'

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(14) C. Nargəzine, C. Xarjawa, C. Shosh-u-Sharmin, C. Iṣṣin (Aqra region) (Coghill 2008)

3SG.M	*nə k-šaqəl*	'He is taking.'
3SG.F	*nə k-šaqla*	'She is taking.'
3PL	*nə k-šaqli*	'They are taking.'

In the C. Xərpa dialect spoken in the region of Aqra, the invariable progressive augment is *ho-*, which is a shortened form the deictic copula *hole*:

(15) C. Xərpa (Aqra region) (Coghill 2008)

3SG.M	*ho k-šaqəl*	'He is taking.'
3SG.F	*ho k-šaqla*	'She is taking.'
3PL	*ho k-šaqli*	'They are taking.'

The J. Barzan dialect uses an invariable particle with the form *ʾale*, which is likely to derived historically from a combination of a presentative particle *ʾa* + 3sg.m copula, e.g.,

(16) J. Barzan (Mutzafi 2004b)

3SG.M	*ʾale ʾi-šate*	'He is drinking.'
3SG.F	*ʾale ʾi-šatya*	'She is drinking.'
3PL	*ʾale ʾi-šate*	'They are drinking.'

In J. Zakho a progressive may be formed by combining the present stem form with the particle *wal*, which is likely also to be derived from a presentative element + copula, e.g.,

(17) J. Zakho (Cohen 2012: 261, 441)

3SG.M	*wal k-šaqəl*	'He is taking.'
3SG.F	*wal k-šaqla*	'She is taking.'
3PL	*wal k-šaqli*	'They are taking.'

In the J. Sanandaj dialect on the south-eastern periphery, the presentative paritcle *wa* can be combined with a present-stem verb to express the progressive, e.g.,

(18) J. Sanandaj (Khan 2009: 244)

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3SG.M	*wa ʾo răxəš*	'Look he is walking.'
3SG.F	*wa ʾo raxša*	'Look she is walking.'
3PL	*wa ʾoni raxši*	'Look they are walking.'

In the C. Ankawa dialect, the particle *də-* is preposed before a present stem form. This particle may be related to the *d-* element in deictic copulas of the form *dole* (C. Mawana), *dulə* (C. Urmi):

(19) C. Ankawa (Borghero 2015)

3SG.M	*də k-šaqəl*	'He is taking.'
3SG.F	*də k-šaqla*	'She is taking.'
3PL	*də k-šaqli*	'They are taking.'

Alternatively, this may be related to the temporal adverbial *da* 'now', which is used to express immediacy and draw attention. This adverbial is used in some dialects in constructions with progressive meaning, e.g.,

(20) C. Sulemaniyya (Khan, fieldnotes)

a. *da garəš.*
now pull.PRS.3SG.M
'Now he is pulling.'/'Look he is pulling.'

b. *da k-ase.*
now DEIC-come.PRS.3SG.M
'Now he is coming.'/'Look he is coming.'

In the C. Bədyal dialect in region of Barzan, progressives are formed by combining a form derived from the present stem with the preposed augment particle *ma*. This may be a phonetic variant of *lā/nā*. Alternatively, its origin may be **qema*, the 3sg.f present form of the verb *q-y-m* 'to rise'/'to stand':

(21) C. Bədyal (Khan, fieldnotes)

3SG.M	*ma k-šate*	'He is drinking.'
3SG.F	*ma k-šatya*	'She is drinking.'
3PL	*ma k-šati*	'They are drinking.'

The possibility of the progressive particle *ma* in C. Bədyal being derived historically from a form of the verb *q-y-m* 'to rise'/'to stand' is supported by the fact that in the Jewish dialect of the same village, the progressive is formed with the augment *qam*, which is clearly a fossilised particle derived from the verb *q-y-m*, e.g.,

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(22) J. Bədyal (Mutzafi 2002a)
qam-šate.
rise-drink.PRS.3SG.M
'He is drinking.'

There is, however, a syntactic difference between C. Bədyal *ma-k-šate* and J. Bədyal *qam-šate*. The former combines the particle *ma* with the present stem augmented by the deictic particle *k-*, viz., *k-šate*, which without the *ma* expresses the indicative habitual. In the J. Bədyal construction *qam-šate*, however, the form *šate* does not have the indicative habitual augment and is the subjunctive form.

Jewish dialects on the south-western periphery exhibit different strategies for marking the progressive function of verbal forms derived from the present stem. In J. Sanandaj and J. Kerend in western Iran, present-stem indicative verbs may be used to express both the habitual or the progressive, e.g.,

(23) J. Sanandaj (Khan 2009: 275-276)
a. *k-xəl.*
DEIC-eat.PRS.3SG.M
'He is eating (progressive).'
'He eats.' (habitual)
b. *băxe.*
weep.PRS.3SG.M
'He is weeping (progressive).'
'He weeps.' (habitual)

In J. Sanandaj, the progressive function of such forms may be specifically marked by combining it with an infinitive form of the verb. In verbs with an initial weak radical, the deictic *k-* element is added both to the verb and to the infinitive e.g.,

(24) J. Sanandaj (Khan 2009: 332)
a. *šatoe šăte.*
drink.INF drink.PRS.3SG.M
'He is drinking (progressive).'
b. *k-xole k-xəl.*
DEIC-eat.INF DEIC-eat.PRS.3SG.M
'He is eating (progressive).'

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In the J. Kerend dialect, the progressive function of a present-stem verb is specifically marked by combining them with a possessive phrase, e.g.,

(25) J. Kerend (Khan, fieldnotes)

a. *hit-e* *k-xəl.*
EXIST-OBL.3SG.M DEIC-eat.PRS.3SG.M
'He is eating (progressive).'

b. *hit-i* *k-xən-na.*
EXIST-OBL.1SG DEIC-eat.PRS-1SG.M
'I am eating (progressive).'

c. *hit-e* *šăte.*
EXIST-OBL.3SG.M drink.PRS.3SG.M
'He is drinking.'

For a map of the distribution of locative progressive constructions formed from the infinitive in NENA dialects see Figure 19.1.

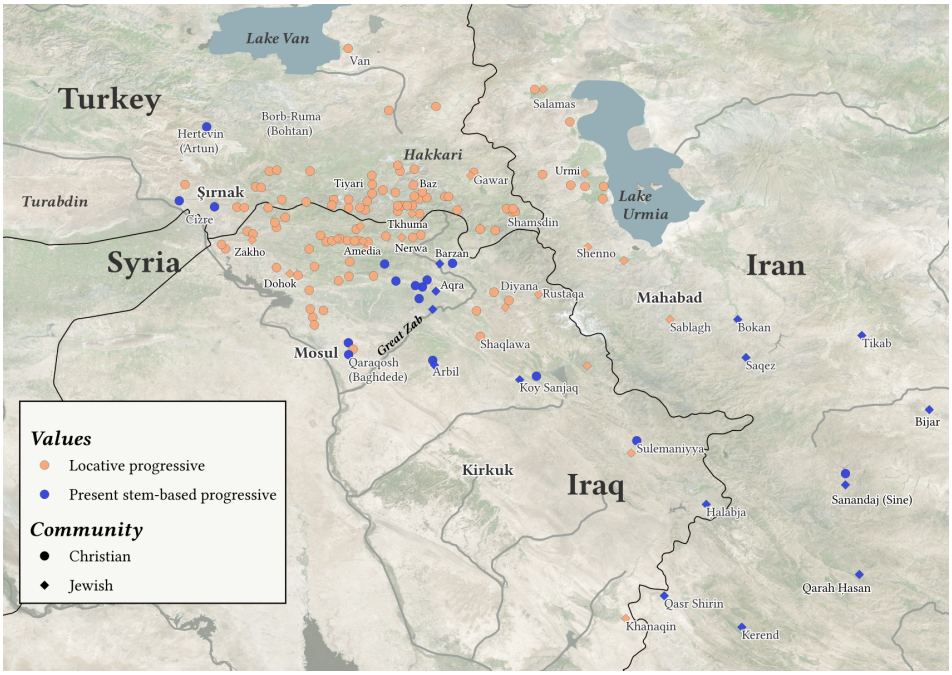

Figure 19.1: Distribution of progressive constructions across NENA dialects

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19.1.3 Progressive forms based on the infinitive

Progressive forms based on the infinitive with the locative particle *b-* 'in' are found across a wide area of NENA concentrated in the northern and north-eastern sectors of NENA.

In many dialects, the locative particle on the infinitive stem of this construction has been elided, e.g.,

(26) C. Urmi
du=lə *b-itaya.*
DEIC=COP.3SG.M in-come.INF
'He is coming.'

(27) C. Barwar
ho=le *θaya.*
DEIC=COP.3SG.M come.INF
'He is coming.'

Even in dialects such as C. Urmi, in which the *b-* has been preserved, there are grounds for considering that it has become bonded to the infinitive and is no longer analysed as preposition, but rather is part of the infinitive stem (Khan 2016b: vol. 1, 216-217).

In many dialects the progressive infinitive base is combined with an inflected deictic copula placed before it, as in the constructions in (26) and (27). Further examples:

(28) C. Karamlesh (Borghero 2008: 82-82)
k-ilə *bəštaya.*
DEIC=COP.3SG.M in-drink.INF
'He is drinking.'

(29) C. Alqosh (Coghill 2003)
wo-le *bəštaya.*
DEIC=COP.3SG.M in-drink.INF
'He is drinking.'

(30) C. Harbole (Khan, fieldnotes)
ho-le *bəštaya.*
DEIC=COP.3SG.M in-drinking
'He is drinking.'

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(31) C. Bebede (Khan, fieldnotes)
ho-le *štaya.*
DEIC=COP.3SG.M drink.INF
'He is drinking.'

(32) J. Zakho (Cohen 2012: 261, 441)
we-le *bəštaya.*
DEIC=COP.3SG.M in-drink.INF
'He is drinking.'

(33) C. Baz Argab (Khan, fieldnotes)
haydo-le *bə-štaya.*
DEIC=COP.3SG.M in-drink.INF
'He is drinking.'

Some dialects have distinct proximal and distal deictic copulas. This is the case, for example, in C. Urmi:

(34) C. Urmi (Khan 2016b: vol. 1, 253)

a. *du=lə* *b-itaya.*
PROX.DEIC=COP.3SG.M in-come.INF
'He (here) is coming.'

b. *ve=lə* *b-itaya.*
DISTAL.DEIC=COP.3SG.M in-come.INF
'He (there) is coming.'

In some dialects in the northern sector of NENA, the basic form of the copula without a deictic element is placed before the infinitive, e.g.,

(35) C. Telkepe (Coghill 2018)
ʾile *b-ixalɒ.*
COP.3SG.M in-eat.INF
'He is eating.'

In some dialects, the copula is optionally abbreviated in form, e.g.,

(36) J. Betanure (Mutzafi 2008a: 63-64)

a. *ʾile* *bə-štaya.*
COP.3SG.M in-drink.INF
'He is drinking.'

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b. *le* *bə-štaya.*
COP.3SG.M in-drink.INF
'He is drinking.'

In some dialects the copula is enclitic to a preceding subject argument, e.g.,

(37) C. Mez (Khan, fieldnotes)

a. *báb-an=ile* *štàya.*|
father-our=COP.3SG.M drink.INF
'Our father is drinking.'

b. *ʾáxni=wəx* *štàya.*|
we=COP.1PL drink.INF
'We are drinking.'

(38) J. Amedia (Greenblatt 2011: 243-244)
kθéθe=la *b-izála* *gu-gə̀nθa.*|
chicken=in-COP.3SG.F in-go.INF in-garden
'The chicken is going about in the garden.'

As can be seen in (36) and (37), the nuclear stress of the intonation group, which is represented by a grave accent sign, falls at the end of the clause. So, the subject constituent, on which the copula is cliticised, is not in narrow focus. Rather these appear to be reduced non-contrastive cleft constructions that are used with a thetic function to present a situation (Sasse 1987, Khan 2012), i.e., 'It is our father (who) is drinking.'.

Many of the dialects that have a preposed copula such as those described above also allow the copula to be cliticised to the infinitive in some pragmatic situations (see §19.1.8). In some Jewish dialects on the eastern periphery of NENA, cliticisation of the copula on the infinitive in progressive constructions is the norm, e.g.,

(39) J. Koy Sanjak (Mutzafi 2004a: 112-113)

a. *štaye=le.*
drink.INF=COP.3SG.M
'He is drinking.'

b. *štaya=wat.*
drink.INF=COP.2SG.F
'You (sg.f) are drinking.'

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(40) J. Sulemaniyya (Khan 2004b: 100)

a. *garoša=y.*
pull.INF=COP.3SG.M
'He is pulling.'

b. *garoša=yat.*
pull.INF=COP.2SG.F
'You (sg.f) are pulling.'

In J. Urmi and other Jewish dialects in the Urmi region, the enclitic copula has been contracted and in most of the paradigm has become identical to the inflection of present-stem verbs:

(41) J. Urmi

	Progressive		Copula
3sg.m	*garoš-e*	'He is pulling'	*=ile*
3sg.f	*garoš-a*	'She is pulling'	*=ila*
3pl	*garoš-u*	'They are pulling'	*=ilu*
2sg.m	*garoš-et*	'You (sg.m) are pulling'	*=ilet*
2sg.f	*garoš-at*	'You (sg.f) are pulling'	*=ilat*
2pl	*garoš-etun*	'You (pl) are pulling'	*=iletun*
1sg.m	*garoš-en*	'I (sg.m) am pulling'	*=ilen*
1sg.f	*garoš-an*	'I (sg.f) am pulling'	*=ilan*
1pl	*garoš-ex*	'We are pulling'	*=ilex*

In some dialects, the progressive infinitive stem is preceded by an uninflected particle, which is a deictic particle or fossilised copula. In such constructions, the person distinctions are expressed by inflected enclitic copulas, but in many cases the inflected copulas are omitted for the 3sg.m form and in some case for all third person forms, e.g.,

(42) J. Rustaqa (Khan 2002b: 407)

Proofreading version. Do not quote. Final version available from http://www.langsci-press.org

3SG.M	*lā šatoʾa*	‘He is drinking.’
3SG.F	*lā šatoʾe=la*	‘She is drinking.’
3PL	*lā šatoʾe=lu*	‘They are drinking.’
2SG.M	*lā šatoʾe=wet*	‘You (sg.m) are drinking.’
2SG.F	*lā šatoʾe=wat*	‘You (sg.f) are drinking.’
2PL	*lā šatoʾe=wetu*	‘You (pl) are drinking.’
1SG.M	*lā šatoʾe=wena*	‘I (sg.m) am drinking.’
1SG.F	*lā šatoʾe=wan*	‘I (sg.f) am drinking.’
1PL	*lā šatoʾe=wex*	‘We are drinking.’

(43) C. Shaqlawa (Khan 2022b: 213)

3SG.M	*na bə-štaya*	‘He is drinking.’
3SG.F	*na bə-štaya*	‘She is drinking.’
3PL	*na bə-štaya*	‘They are drinking.’
2SG.M	*na bə-štaye=wət*	‘You (sg.m) are drinking.’
2SG.F	*na bə-štaye=wat*	‘You (sg.f) are drinking.’
2PL	*na bə-štaye=witun*	‘You (pl) are drinking.’
1SG.M	*na bə-štaye=wən*	‘I (sg.m) am drinking.’
1SG.F	*na bə-štaye=wan*	‘I (sg.f) am drinking.’
1PL	*na bə-štaye=wəx*	‘We are drinking.’

In some dialects in the Hakkari, the third person progressive infinitive forms are introduced by an uninflected deictic particle *ha* without any person inflection, whereas the first and second person forms are preceded by an inflected deictic copula, e.g.,

(44) C. Sat (Khan, fieldnotes)

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3SG.M	*ha bə-štaya*	'He is drinking.'
3SG.F	*ha bə-štaya*	'She is drinking.'
3PL	*ha bə-štaya*	'They are drinking.'
2SG.M	*dowət bə-štaya*	'You (sg.m) are drinking.'
2SG.F	*dowat bə-štaya*	'You (sg.f) are drinking.'
2PL	*dowetun bə-štaya*	'You (pl) are drinking.'
1SG.M	*dowən bə-štaya*	'I (sg.m) am drinking.'
1SG.F	*dowan bə-štaya*	'I (sg.f) am drinking.'
1PL	*dowəx bə-štaya*	'We are drinking.'

In the C. Hawdiyan dialect (northern Iraq), the third person forms are preceded by a reduced form of the copula. This reduced copula has lost a distinction of gender in the 3sg (*le* 3sg.c). Its 3pl form is *ne*, which has developed from **ina* by partial assimilation to the form of the 3sg. The first and second person forms are preceded by a fully inflected deictic copula:

(45) C. Hawdiyan (Napiorkowska, fieldnotes)

3SG.M	*le bə-štaya*	'He is drinking.'
3SG.F	*le bə-štaya*	'She is drinking.'
3PL	*ne bə-štaya*	'They are drinking.'
2SG.M	*duwət bə-štaya*	'You (sg.m) are drinking.'
2SG.F	*duwat bə-štaya*	'You (sg.f) are drinking.'
2PL	*duwitun bə-štaya*	'You (pl) are drinking.'
1SG.M	*duwən bə-štaya*	'I (sg.m) am drinking.'
1SG.F	*duwan bə-štaya*	'I (sg.f) am drinking.'
1PL	*duwəx bə-štaya*	'We are drinking.'

19.1.4 Dynamic and stative

In some NENA dialects, progressive constructions are mainly used with verbs denoting dynamic actions and tend to be used less frequently with verbs with a stative type of lexical aspect, especially verbs of perception or verbs denoting mental states, e.g.,

(46) C. Qaraqosh (Khan 2002a: 120-121)

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a. *k-ilə* *k-šate.*
DEIC-COP.3SG.M DEIC-drink.PRS.3SG.M
'He is drinking.'

b. *k-yaðəʾ.*
know.DEIC-know.PRS.3SG.M
'He knows (at this moment).'

c. *g-biʾə*
want.DEIC-want.PRS.3SG.M
'He wants (at this moment).'

(47) C. Barwar (Khan 2004b: 100)

a. *ho-le* *štaya.*
DEIC-COP.3SG.M drink.INF
'He is drinking.'

b. *yăðe.*
know.PRS.3SG.M
'He knows (at this moment).'

c. *băye*
want.PRS.3SG.M
'He wants (at this moment).'

(48) C. Ankawa (Khan, fieldnotes)

a. *də-k-šate.*
DEIC-DEIC-drink.PRS.3SG.M
'He is drinking.'

b. *č-ade.*
DEIC-know.PRS.3SG.M
'He knows (at this moment).'

c. *k-əbe*
DEIC-want.PRS.3SG.M
'He wants (at this moment).'

(49) J. Arbel (Khan 1999a)

a. *lā* *šăte.*
COP drink.PRS.3SG.M
'He is drinking.'

Proofreading version. Do not quote. Final version available from http://www.langsci-press.org

b. *č-əl.*
DEIC-know.PRS.3SG.M
'He knows (at this moment).'

c. *g-be.*
DEIC-want.COP.3SG.M
'He wants (at this moment).'

(50) C. Urmi (Khan 2016b: vol. 2, 185-186)

a. *du-lə* *bə-štaya.*
DEIC-COP.3SG.M in-drink.INF
'He is drinking.'

b. *⁺yaṯṯə*
know.PRS.3SG.M
'He knows (at this moment).'

c. *⁺bayyə.*
want.COP.3SG.M
'He wants (at this moment).'

The progressive construction may, however, be used in such dialects in stative verbs in marked pragmatic circumstances where the speaker wishes to draw particular attention to the state. Likewise, the progressive construction in such dialects may be used to express the habitual to draw particular attention to a habitual activity or state that is relevant to the present speech situation.

Dialects that use a deictic copula in progressive constructions with dynamic verbs, typically use the enclitic copula when the progressive construction is used for discourse prominent stative or habitual verbs, e.g.,

(51) C. Urmi (Khan 2016b: vol. 2, 185-186)

a. *du-lə* *bə-štaya.*
DEIC-COP.3SG.M in-drink.INF
'He is drinking.'

b. *⁺bə-ddayə=lə.*
in-know.INF=COP.3SG.M
'He knows (at this moment).'

c. *⁺byayə=lə.*
want.INF=COP.3SG.M
'He wants (at this moment).'

Proofreading version. Do not quote. Final version available from http://www.langsci-press.org

d. *bə-štayə=lə.*
in-want.INF=COP.3SG.M
'He drinks (habitually).'

In some dialects, however, progressive constructions are used more frequently with stative verbs. Such dialects are concentrated in the north-eastern sector of NENA. It is most frequently used in Jewish dialects in the Urmi region, e.g.,

(52) J. Urmi (Khan 2008b: 274-275)

a. *garoš-e.*
pull.INF-COP.3SG.M
'He is pulling.'

b. *ayol-e.*
know.INF-COP.3SG.M
'He knows (at this moment).'

c. *abul-e.*
want.INF-COP.3SG.M
'He wants (at this moment).'

The most advanced dialect in this respect is J. Salmas, in which the progressive form is the normal form for progressive dynamic, progressive stative and habitual verbs:

(53) J. Salmas (Khan, fieldnotes)

a. *garoš-e.*
pull.INF-COP.3SG.M
'He is pulling/he pulls (habitually).'

b. *ayol-e.*
know.INF-COP.3SG.M
'He knows (at this moment or habitually).'

c. *abul-e.*
want.INF-COP.3SG.M
'He wants (at this moment or habitually).'

19.1.5 Negation of progressive constructions

In many dialects that use an inflected copula in progressive construction, the construction is negated by the negative copula, e.g.,

Proofreading version. Do not quote. Final version available from http://www.langsci-press.org

(54) C. Qaraqosh

a. *k-ilə* *k-šate.*
DEIC-COP.3SG.M DEIC-drink.PRS.3SG.M
'He is drinking.'

b. *lelə* *k-šate.*
NEG.COP.3SG.M DEIC-drink.PRS.3SG.M
'He is not drinking.'

(55) C. Barwar

a. *ho=le* *štaya.*
DEIC=COP.3SG.M drink.INF
'He is drinking.'

b. *lɛle* *štaya.*
NEG.COP.3SG.M drink.INF
'He is not drinking.'

(56) C. Urmi

a. *du=le* *bə-štaya.*
DEIC=COP.3SG.M in-drink.INF
'He is drinking.'

b. *lelə* *bə-štaya.*
NEG.COP.3SG.M in-drink.INF
'He is not drinking.'

(57) C. Baz Argab (Khan, fieldnotes)

a. *haydo=le* *bə-štaya.*
DEIC=COP.3SG.M in-drink.INF
'He is drinking.'

b. *lele* *bə-štaya.*
NEG.COP.3SG.M in-drink.INF
'He is not drinking.'

(58) C. Telkepe (Coghill 2018)

a. *ʾile* *b-ixalɒ.*
COP.3SG.M in-eat.INF
'He is eating"

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b. *lele* *b-ixalɒ.*
NEG.COP.3SG.M in-eat.INF
'He is not eating'

(59) J. Koy Sanjak (Mutzafi 2004a: 112-113)

a. *štaye=le.*
eat.INF=COP.3SG.M
'He is drinking.'

b. *lewe* *štaya.*
NEG.COP.3SG.M drink.INF
'He is not drinking.'

In the C. Baz Aruntus, dialect a truncated form of the negative copula is used in progressive constructions in the third person, viz., *lə*, the full forms being *ləle* (3sg.m), *ləla* (3sg.f), *ləna* (3pl), e.g.,

(60) C. Baz Aruntus (Khan, fieldnotes)

a. *do=le* *bəšta.*
DEIC=COP.3SG.M in-drink.INF
'He is drinking.'

b. *lə* *bəšta.*
NEG.COP in-drink.INF
'He is not drinking.'

In the C. Sanandaj dialect on the south-eastern periphery of NENA, which expresses the progressive by an inflected enclitic copula, the negative is expressed by the particle *ley* placed before the verb. This can be analysed as an invariable form of the negative copula, the full forms being *leye* (3sg.m), *leya* (3sg.f), *leyu* (3pl), e.g.,

(61) C. Sanandaj (Khan, fieldnotes)

a. *k-axəl=ile.*
DEIC-eat.PRS.3SG.M=COP.3SG.M
'He is eating.'

b. *ley* *k-axəl=ile.*
NEG.COP DEIC-eat.PRS-1SG.F=COP.1SG.F
'I am not eating.'

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In some dialects on the eastern periphery of NENA that have inflected copulas, the construction is negated by placing the negative particle *la* before the verbal form rather than replacing the enclitic copula with the negative copula, e.g.,

(62) J. Sulemaniyya (Khan 2004b: 100)

a. *garoša=y.*
pull.INF=COP.3SG.M
'He is pulling.'

b. *la garoša=y.*
NEG pull.INF=COP.3SG.M
'He is not pulling.'

The same applies to the C. Sulemaniyya dialect, in which the copula is inflected only in the third person but has the fossilised 3sg.m form in the first and second persons:

(63) C. Sulemaniyya (Khan, fieldnotes)

3SG.M	*la k-axəl=ile*	'He is not eating.'
3SG.F	*la k-əxla=ila*	'She is not eating.'
3PL	*la k-əxli=ilu*	'They are not eating.'
2SG.M	*la k-əxlət=ile*	'You (sg.m) are not eating.'
2SG.F	*la k-əxlat=ile*	'You (sg.f) are not eating.'
2PL	*la k-əxlitun=ile*	'You (pl) are not eating.'
1SG.M	*la k-əxlən=ile*	'I (sg.m) am not eating.'
1SG.F	*la k-əxlan=ile*	'I (sg.f) am not eating.'
1PL	*la k-əxlux=ile*	'We are not eating.'

The same applies to Jewish dialects in the Urmi region in which the enclitic copula has been contracted, e.g.,

(64) J. Urmi, J. Shəno, J. Salmas (Khan 2008b; Khan, fieldnotes)

	Progressive		Copula
3SG.M	*la garoš-e*	'He is not pulling'	*=ile*
3SG.F	*la garoš-a*	'She is not pulling'	*=ila*
3PL	*la garoš-u*	'They are not pulling'	*=ilu*

Proofreading version. Do not quote. Final version available from http://www.langsci-press.org

Dialects that place an uninflected particle before the verbal form in progressive constructions exhibit various negation strategies.

Some dialects place the negator particle *la* after the uninflected particle. As can be seen in (65, 67, 66), in which the prosody is marked, the uninflected particle typically takes the nuclear stress of the intonation group rather than the negator:

(65) J. Arbel (Khan 1999a)

a. *lá̋ šătè.*|
COP drink.PRS.3SG.M
'He is drinking.'

b. *là la-šăté.*|
COP NEG drink.PRS.3SG.M
'He is not drinking.'

(66) C. Koy Sanjak/Armota (Khan, fieldnotes)

a. *lá̋ k-šàte.*|
COP drink.PRS.3SG.M
'He is drinking.'

b. *là la-šáte.*|
COP NEG drink.PRS.3SG.M
'He is not drinking.'

(67) J. Dobe (Khan, fieldnotes)

a. *ná̋ šătè.*|
COP drink.PRS.3SG.M
'He is drinking.'

b. *nà la-šăté.*|
COP NEG drink.PRS.3SG.M
'He is not drinking.'

In the C. Bədyal dialect positive progressive constructions have the uninflected particle *ma* whereas in negated constructions the particle has the form *lā* and is followed by the negative particle, as in other dialects, e.g.,

(68) C. Bədyal (Khan, fieldnotes)

a. *má k-šàte.*|
COP DEIC-drink.PRS.3SG.M
'He is drinking.'

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b. *là lá k-šáte.*
COP NEG DEIC-drink.PRS.3SG.M
'He is not drinking.'

In the J. Ruwanduz dialect, the uninflected particle *lā* is replaced by an inflected negative copula and there is no enclitic copula marking the person in the paradigm, e.g.,

(69) J. Ruwanduz (Khan, fieldnotes)

a. *lā garoša.*
COP pull.INF
'He is pulling.'

b. *lewe garoša.*
NEG.COP.3SG.M pull.INF
'He is not pulling.'

c. *lā garoše=la.*
COP pull.INF=COP.3SG.F
'She is pulling.'

d. *lewa garoša.*
NEG.COP.3SG.F pull.INF
'She is not pulling.'

e. *lā garoše=lu.*
COP pull.INF=COP.3PL
'They are pulling.'

f. *lewu garoša.*
NEG.COP.3PL pull.INF
'They are not pulling.'

In the J. Rustaqa dialect, a reduced invariable form of the negative copula *le* replaces the invariable particle *lā* of the positive progressive and, apart from the 3sg.m, person in the paradigm is indicated by an inflected enclitic copula, e.g.,

(70) J. Rustaqa (Khan 2002b: 407)

a. *lā garoša.*
COP pull.INF
'He is pulling.'

Proofreading version. Do not quote. Final version available from http://www.langsci-press.org

b. *le garoša.*
NEG.COP pull.INF
'He is not pulling.'

c. *lā garoše=la.*
COP pull.INF=COP.3SG.F
'She is pulling.'

d. *le garoše=la.*
NEG.COP pull.INF=COP.3SG.F
'She is not pulling.'

e. *lā garoše=lu.*
COP pull.INF=COP.3PL
'They are pulling.'

f. *le garoše=lu.*
NEG.COP pull.INF=COP.3PL
'They are not pulling.'

Similarly, in C. Ankawa an uninfected truncated form of the negative copula *ley* replaces the deictic particle *də* of positive progressive constructions, e.g.,

(71) C. Ankawa (Khan, fieldnotes)

a. *də k-šate.*
DEIC DEIC-drink.PRS.3SG.M
'He is drinking.'

b. *ley k-šate.*
NEG.COP DEIC-drink.PRS.3SG.M
'He is not drinking.'

In the C. Sat dialect, in which third person progressive constructions are introduced by the uninflected deictic particle *ha*, this is replaced by the truncated negative copula *lə*. In first and second person forms the fully inflected form of the negative copula is used, e.g.,

(72) C. Sat (Khan, fieldnotes)

a. *wo naša ha b-izala.*
that man DEIC in-go.INF
'That man is going.'

Proofreading version. Do not quote. Final version available from http://www.langsci-press.org

b. *wo naša lə b-izala.*
that man NEG.COP in-go.INF
'That man is not going.'

c. *yo baxta ha b-izala.*
that woman DEIC in-go.INF
'That woman is going.'

d. *yo baxta lə b-izala.*
that man NEG.COP in-go.INF
'That woman is not going.'

e. *ne naše ha b-izala.*
those people DEIC in-go.INF
'Those people are going.'

f. *ne naše lə b-izala.*
those people NEG.COP in-go.INF
'Those people are not going.'

g. *do=wən b-izala.*
DEIC=COP.1SG.M in-go.INF
'I am going.'

h. *lewən b-izala.*
NEG.COP.1SG.M in-go.INF
'I am not going.'

In dialects in the Aqra region that use the uninflected progressive part *nə*, this is replaced by the negative particle *la*

(73) C. Nargəzine/Xarjawa/Shosh-u-Sharmin (Aqra region) (Coghill 2008: 102-104)

a. *nə k-šate.*
COP DEIC-drink.PRS.3SG.M
'He is drinking.'

b. *la k-šate.*
NEG DEIC-drink.PRS.3SG.M
'He is not drinking.'

In the C. Shaqlawa dialect, which uses the uninflected particle *na* in progressive constructions, the negative is expressed by an inflected negative copula after the particle *na*, e.g.,

Proofreading version. Do not quote. Final version available from http://www.langsci-press.org

(74) C. Shaqlawa (Khan 2022b: 212-229)

a. *ná bə-štàya.*
COP in-drink.INF
'He is drinking.'

b. *bə-štàye=le.*
in-drink.INF=COP.3SG.M
'He is drinking.'

c. *ná lèle bəštáya.*
COP NEG drink.PRS.3SG.M
'He is not drinking.'

In the C. Shaqlawa dialect the particle *na* has the specific attention-drawing function of what may be termed 'epistemic contrastive focus'. It is used to correct what the speaker assumes the hearer believes or presupposes to be the case (Khan 2022b: 212-229). A negative construction such as (74c) would be used, therefore, in response to a statement by the interlocutor reflecting a belief that the referent of the subject is drinking. Likewise, the positive construction (74a) would be naturally used to draw attention to the fact that the referent of the subject is indeed drinking contrary to the assumed belief of the interlocutor that he is not drinking. So, the negative construction (74c) would be a more natural response to an unmarked statement such as (74b) without *na*. We see, therefore, that the pragmatics of the particle *na* in C. Shaqlawa are somewhat different or, at least, more specific, than the uninflected particles *lā* and *na* in other dialects cited.

19.1.6 Effects of focus constructions

In some dialects narrow focus can induce the use of a different type of progressive construction from that normally used when the focus is broad. This is found in dialects that use both progressive constructions based on the present stem and also progressive constructions based on the infinitive. The form based on the present stem is used for broad focus whereas the form based on the infinitive is used when there is some kind of strong narrow focus on a negator or interrogative particle, e.g.,

(75) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a: 707)

a. *yǎð-ən.*
know.PRS-1SG.M
'I know'

Proofreading version. Do not quote. Final version available from http://www.langsci-press.org

b. *là yǎðən.*|
NEG know.PRS.1SG.M
'I do not know (broad focus).'

c. *làn ðá'a.*|
NEG.COP.1SG.M know.INF
'I do NOT know (strong denial).'

(76) C. Koy Sanjak/Armota (Khan, fieldnotes)

a. *lā́ k-šàte.*|
COP DEIC-drink.PRS-3SG.M
'He is drinking.'

b. *lǎ̀ lá k-šáte.*|
COP NEG DEIC-drink.PRS.3SG.M
'He is not drinking (broad focus).'

c. *lè bə-štáya.*|
NEG.COP.3C in-drink.INF
'He is NOT drinking (strong denial).'

(77) C. Bədyal (Khan, fieldnotes)

a. *má k-ìtə.*|
COP DEIC-come.PRS-3SG.M
'He is coming.'

b. *lǎ̄ lá k-ítə.*|
COP NEG DEIC-come.PRS.3SG.M
'He is not coming (broad focus).'

c. *lìwə b-tā́.*|
NEG.COP.3SG.M in-comeINF
'He is NOT coming (strong denial).'

(78) C. Ankawa (Khan, fieldnotes)

a. *má də-k-šàte?*|
what DEIC DEIC-drink.PRS-3SG.M
'What is he drinking? (broad focus).'

b. *mà=yle bəštáya?*|
what=COP.3SG.M in-drink.INF
'What (on earth) is he drinking?! (narrow focus)'

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(79) J. Dohok (Molin 2024: 211–213)

a. *ʾána wə́l gə-mbàšl-an.*|
I DEIC DEIC-cook.PRS-1SG.F
'Look, I am cooking.'

b. *lèwe bəṭṛasa.*|
NEG.COP.3SG.M heal.PROG
'He is not getting better.'

In some of these dialects that use both progressive forms based on the present stem and also progressive forms based on the infinitive, the form based on the infinitive may also be used as a habitual form, especially when denoting a habitual activity in a limited time interval intersecting with the present, e.g.,

(80) C. Ankawa (Khan, fieldnotes)

a. *k-áxəl gèb-an.*|
DEIC-eat.PRS-3SG.M with-us
'He eats with us (habitually, on a permanent basis).'

b. *ʾay-šábta b-ixále=le gèb-an.*|
this-week in-eat.INF=COP.3SG.M with-us
'This week he is eating with us (limited time interval).'

(81) C. Koy Sanjak/Armota (Khan, fieldnotes)

a. *k-áxəl làt-an.*|
DEIC-eat.PRS-3SG.M with-us
'He eats with us (habitually, on a permanent basis).'

b. *ʾay-šábta b-ixále=le làt-an.*|
this-week in-eat.INF=COP.3SG.M with-us
'This week he is eating with us (limited time interval).'

The generalisation that can be made is that in such dialects the progressive form based on the infinitive is less salient than the progressive form based on the present stem. It loses its salience by being defocalised relative to a strong narrow focus elsewhere in the clause or by being extended to express habitual activity rather than expressing a focus on an ongoing activity in the present.[1]

[1]Typological parallels to such sensitivity of verbal morphology to focus are found in particular in Chadic languages, see, for example, Hartmann (2006) and Hyman & Watters (1984).

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19.1.7 Non-present progressive constructions

Some dialects that form progressive constructions with an inflected copula generally can express other tenses and moods by using the appropriate form of the copula, e.g.,

(82) C. Urmi (Khan 2016b: vol. 2, 185-227)

a. *du=lə* *bə-ptaxa.*
DEIC-COP.3SG.M in-open.INF
'He is opening.'

b. *bə-ptaxə=va.*
in-open.INF=COP.PST.3SG.M
'He was opening.'

c. *ʾavə* *bə-ptaxa.*
be.PRS.3SG.M in-open.INF
'He may be opening.'

d. *bət-ʾavə* *bə-ptaxa.*
FUT-be.PRS.3SG.M in-open.INF
'He will be opening.'

In some dialects, however, the TAM inflection of the copula is restricted to the present indicative, e.g.,

(83) J. Koy Sanjak (Mutzafi 2004a: 112-113)

a. *štaye=le.*
drink.INF=COP.3SG.M
'He is drinking.'

b. *šăte-wa.*
drink.PRS.3SG.M-PST
'He was drinking.'

This restriction of TAM inflection applies to some progressive forms that are expressed by uninflected particles (fossilised copulas or deictic particles). The form that has a default present temporal reference, however, can acquire a past temporal deixis in past contexts, e.g.,

(84) J. Arbel (Khan 1999a: 265-268)

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a. *lā šăte.*
COP drinkPRS.3SG.M
'He is drinking.'

b. *bab-í lā-géz ṣlolà,*
father-my COP-go.PRS.3SG.M synagogue
dwíq-le-ll-eu.
seize.PST-OBL.3SG.M-OBJ-3SG.M
'While my father was going to the synagoue, he seized him.'

In some dialects, however, the uninflected particle is used both in the present progressive and also in forms inflected for past time reference, e.g.,

(85) C. Bədyal (Khan, fieldnotes)

a. *ma-k-šăte.*
PART-drink.PRS.3SG.M
'He is drinking.'

b. *ma-k-šăte-wa.*
PART-drink.PRS.3SG.M-PST
'He was drinking.'

In some dialects that use both progressive forms derived from the present stem and progressive forms derived from the infinitive, forms derived from the present base are used for the present indicative progressive, whereas forms derived from the infinitive are typically used to express non-present, non-indicative TAM, e.g.,

(86) C. Ankawa (Khan, fieldnotes)

a. *də-k-šate.*
DEIC-DEIC-drink.PRS.3SG.M
'He is drinking.'

b. *bə-štaya=wewa.*
in-drink.INF=COP.PST.3SG.M
'He was drinking.'

c. *b-awe bə-štaya.*
FUT-be.PRS.3SG.M in-drink.INF
'He will be drinking.'

(87) C. Nargəzine/Xarjawa/Shosh-u-Sharmin (Aqra region) (Coghill 2008; Khan, field notes)

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a. *nə k-šate.*
COP DEIC-drink.PRS.3SG.M
'He is drinking.'

b. *we-le bə-štaya.*
be.PST-OBL.3SG.M in-drink.INF
'He was drinking.'

c. *d-awe bə-štaya.*
FUT-be.PRS.3SG.M in-drink.INF
'He will be drinking.'

d. *balki ho=le bə-štaya.*
perhas DEIC-COP.3SG.M in-drink.INF
'Perhaps he is drinking.'

In some Jewish Trans-Zab dialects the past progressive is formed by combining the Kurdish imperfective preverbal prefix *da* with an inflected form of the past stem, e.g.,

(88) J. Koy Sanjak ((Mutzafi 2004a)
da-rxiš-le
IPFV-walk.PST-OBL.3SG:S
'He was walking.'

(89) J. Arbel (Khan 1999a: 190)
da-fit-lu
IPFV-pass.PST-OBL.3PL
'(The children) were passing.'

19.1.8 Progressive constructions in questions

In some dialects that use a deictic copula in progressive constructions, an enclitic copula is used instead when interrogative, e.g.,

(90) C. Qaraqosh (Khan 2002a: 120-121, 332)

a. *k-ilə k-šatə.*
DEIC-COP.3SG.M DEIC-drink.PRS.3SG.M
'He is drinking.'

b. *k-šate=lə?*
DEIC-drink.PRS.3SG.M=COP.3SG.M
'Is he drinking?'

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c. *ma=ilə* *k-šatə?*
what=COP.3SG DEIC-drink.PRS.3SG.M=COP.3SG.M
'What is he drinking?'

(91) C. Harbole (Khan, fieldnotes)

a. *hole* *bə-štaya.*
DEIC-COP.3SG.M in-drink.INF
'He is drinking.'

b. *bə-štayɛ=le?*
in-drink.INF=COP.3SG.M
'Is he drinking?'

c. *ma=ile* *bə-štaya?*
what=COP.3SG in-drink.INF
'What is he drinking?'

(92) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a: 705)

a. *hole* *štaya.*
DEIC-COP.3SG.M drink.INF
'He is drinking.'

b. *štayɛ=le?*
drink.INF=COP.3SG.M
'Is he drinking?'

c. *ma=ile* *štaya?*
what=COP.3SG drink.INF
'What is he drinking?'

In some dialects, however, the deictic copula is used also in questions. This reflects a further degree of grammaticalisation through which the deictic copula has lost spatial deixis and denotes only temporal contingency, e.g.,

(93) C. Bersive (Khan, fieldnotes)

a. *hole* *bə-štaya.*
DEIC-COP.3SG.M in-drink.INF
'He is drinking.'

b. *hole* *bə-štaya?*
DEIC-COP.3SG.M in-drink.INF
'Is he drinking?'

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(94) C. Bebede, C. Mez (Khan, fieldnotes)

a. *hole štaya.*
DEIC-COP.3SG.M drink.INF
'He is drinking.'

b. *hole štaya?*
DEIC-COP.3SG.M drink.INF
'Is he drinking?'

(95) C. Telkepe (Coghill, fieldnotes)

a. *ʾile b-ixalɒ.*
COP.3SG.M in-eat.INF
'He is eating.'

b. *ʾile b-ixalɒ?*
COP.3SG.M in-eat.INF
'Is he eating?'

Many dialects that have invariable preposed particles in progressive constructions retain these particles in questions, e.g.,

(96) C. Koy Sanjak (Khan, fieldnotes)

a. *lā k-šăte.*
COP DEIC-drink.PRS.3SG.M
'He is drinking.'

b. *lā k-šăte?*
COP DEIC-drink.PRS.3SG.M
'Is he drinking?'

(97) C. Ankawa (Khan, fieldnotes)

a. *də-k-šate.*
DEIC-DEIC-drink.PRS.3SG.M
'He is drinking.'

b. *də-k-šate?*
DEIC-DEIC-drink.PRS.3SG.M
'Is he drinking?'

(98) C. Nargəzine/Xarjawa/Shosh-u-Sharmin (Aqra region) (Coghill 2008)

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a. *nə-k-šate.*
COP-DEIC-drink.PRS.3SG.M
'He is drinking.'

b. *nə-k-šate?*
COP-DEIC-drink.PRS.3SG.M
'Is he drinking?'

(99) C. Bədyal (Khan, fieldnotes)

a. *ma-k-šate.*
COP-DEIC-drink.PRS.3SG.M
'He is drinking.'

b. *ma-k-šate?*
COP-DEIC-drink.PRS.3SG.M
'Is he drinking?'

In some dialects, however, such particles are not used in questions, e.g.,

(100) C. Xərpa (Khan, fieldnotes)

a. *nə-k-šate.*
COP-DEIC-drink.PRS.3SG.M
'He is drinking.'

b. *k-šate?*
DEIC-drink.PRS.3SG.M
'Are you drinking?'

(101) J. Rustaqa (Khan 2002b: 406-407) (Khan, fieldnotes)

a. *lā qyama=wet.*
COP rise.INF=COP.2SG.M
'You are getting up.'

b. *tama qyama=wet?*
why rise.INF=COP.2SG.M
'Why are you getting up?'

In C. Shaqlawa, as remarked, the invariable particle *na* that draws attention to an ongoing action has a contrastive epistemic focus function. It can be used in questions with a positive desiderative bias, to which the speaker wants the answer to be 'yes'. These are to be translated into English most idiomatically by negative questions, which typically have such bias, e.g.,

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(102) C. Shaqlawa (Khan 2022b: 216-217)
na-psaye=wəx?
DEIC-go.INF=COP.1PL
'Aren't we going? (Surely we are going!)'

19.2 Progressive in Iranian

19.2.1 Progressive forms in Kurdish

In general, the progressive is not grammaticalised in Kurdish varieties. Instead, indicative present and past imperfective forms are used, usually alongside relevant adverbs or by relying on the context, to express the sense of continuity and progressive, as in (103).

(103) a. *em niha di-ç-in mal-ê/*
we now IND-go.PRS-PL home-OBL
'We are now going home.'
b. *em hingê di-çû-n mal-ê*
we then IPFV-go.PST-1PL home-OBL
'We are at that time going home.'

Bedir Khan & Lescot (1970: 144) give present and past progressive verb forms consisting of the combination of an *-e* suffix with the present indicative and past imperfective verb forms, such as *ez di-ç-im-e* 'I am going (now)' and *ez di-çû-m-e* 'I was going (at that time)'. This present progressive verb form is restricted to the Botan and Siirt dialects. The past progressive form is not attested either in spoken language or in written texts. In fact the authors note that these progressive tenses no longer used (p.162).

There are nevertheless several grammatical expressions of progressive in Behdînî Northern Kurdish, in Central Kurdish and Southern Kurdish.

19.2.1.1 Behdînî Northern Kurdish *ezafe* progressive

In Behdînî NK, the demonstrative (or independent, pronominal) *ezafe* forms are used with the indicative present forms of the verbs to express the progressive (cf. MacKenzie 1961a: 205). It thus lacks a past tense form. In Behdînî, as in the rest of Kurdish, the past imperfective verb form expresses a past continuous action.

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(104) a. *dest-ê* *min=ê* *t-êş-ît.*
hand-EZ.M my=EZ.M:PROG IND-hurt.PRS-3SG
'My hand is aching.' (MacKenzie 1962: 205)

b. *ez=a* *t-bîn-im.*
I=EZ.F:PROG IND-see.PRS-1SG
'I (female) can see.'

c. *ez=ê* *nan-î* *t-xo-m*
I=EZ.M:PROG food-M.SG.OBL IND-eat.PRS-1SG
'I am eating.'

The *ezafe* forms in Kurdish are found as nominal affixes and as pronominal/demonstrative forms that are either independent words or their encliticised forms (see Table 19.1). The *ezafe* forms used in the progressive construction are the pronominal/demonstrative *ezafe* forms, used either independently or as enclitics, and not the nominal linker *ezafe*s.

Table 19.1: Forms of demonstrative *ezafe*, enclitic and independent forms

	Enclitic	Independent
SG.M	*=ê*	*yê/wê*
SG.F	*=a*	*ya/wa*
PL	*=êt*	*yêt/wêt*

As the examples in (104) show, the *ezafe* appears immediately after the subject of the clause. When the subject is singular, the *ezafe* agrees with it in gender. The *ezafe* used with plural subjects, however, is not the expected plural *ezafe* *=êt/yêt* but the form *=ê/yê*, which is homophonous with the masculine singular form:

(105) *em=ê* *t-bîn-în.*
we=EZ.M:PROG IND-see.PRS-1PL:A
'We can see.' (MacKenzie 1962: 205)

The explanation may be that the indicative prefix (i.e., *t-*), which adjacent to the *ezafe* would lead to ambiguity (e.g., *-êt* + *t* > *=êt*). The ambiguity would not be involved, however, when the predicative *ezafe* is separated from the verb by intervening elements. In (106) below it is clear that the predicative *ezafe* used for a plural subject is *=ê* and not the expected plural form *=êt*.

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(106) *em=ê* *nan-î* *t-xo-yn.*
we=EZ.M:PROG food-M.SG.OBL IND-eat.PRS-1PL
'We are eating.'

19.2.1.2 Negation and interrogative clauses with *ezafe* progressive

Ezafe progressive normally does not lend itself to negation and interrogative clauses. In such contexts the indicative present is used instead:

(107) Shamdinan NK (fieldnotes)

a. *tu=ya* *nan-î* *di-pêj-î.*
you=EZ.F:PROG bread-OBL IND-bake.PRS-2SG
'You are baking bread.'

b. *tu* *nan-î* *na-pêj-î*
you bread-OBL NEG-bake.PRS-2SG
'You are not baking bread.'

c. *tu* *vê* *gav-ê* *nan-î* *di-pêj-î*
you this moment-OBL bread-OBL IND-bake.PRS-2SG
'Are you baking bread at the moment?'

Haig (2011) notes that interrogative and negative clauses are not possible at all with *ezafe* progressive, but in fact the construction is used to a limited degree in negative sentences where the implication is one of insistence or repetitiveness:

(108) Akre NK (MacKenzie 1961a: 206)
em=ê *çêçik-êt* *xo* *na-nas-în=eve.*
we=EZ.M:PROG cub-EZ.PL self NEG.IND-recognize.PRS-1PL=COMPL
'(Now) we do not recognise our own cubs.'

(109) Shamdinan NK (fieldnotes)
yê *na-êş-ît*
EZ.M:PROG NEG.IND-hurt.PRS-3SG
'It (e.g., my tooth) does not hurt at the moment.'

The restrictions on the use of *ezafe* progressive in negative and interrogatives as well as its absence in the past domain indicates that it is an innovation unique to Behdînî Kurdish and that it has not been fully grammaticalised in the language.

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19.2.1.3 Periphrastic progressive constructions

There are several emerging periphrastic progressive constructions in various Kurdish varieties.

19.2.1.3.28 *Xerîk* + copula progressive

The combination of the nominal element *xerîk* 'busy, immersed' and copular endings with a complement clause in indicative or subjunctive form expresses prospective and progressive aspects, depending on the given context:

(110) CK literary standard
êsta xerîk=im xo=m fêr-î ew
now busy=COP.1SG REFL=1SG accustomed-EZ DEM
ziman-an-e de-ke-m
language-PL-DEM.PROX IND-do.PRS-1SG
'I am currently learning those languages.'

(111) CK Mukri (fieldnotes)
xerîk=im le birs-an de-mir-im
busy=COP.1SG FROM hunger-PL IND-die.PRS-1SG
'I am starving (lit. I am about die of hunger).'

19.2.1.3.29 Progressive with demonstrative

The demonstrative pronoun, in some varieties combining with a third person singular copula, namely *wa* in CK, *eve* in Behdînî NK, and *vaye* in central NK dialects, is also used sometimes to express a progressive or prospective sense:

(112) CK Sulemaniyya (fieldnotes)
wa de-řo-m
DEM:PROG IND-go.PRS-1SG
'I am leaving.'/'I am about to leave.'

(113) NK central-southern dialects (popular song)
va=ye ez t-ê-m
DEM=COP.3SG 1SG IND-come.PRS-1SG
'Here I come.'/'I am coming.'

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The deictic meaning is always present in this construction. Accordingly, the demonstrative construction can be used alongside other progressive constructions, such as the *ezafe* progressive in Behdînî NK and the *xerîk+copula* progressive construction in CK:

(114) CK literary standard
wa *xerîk=e* *xwên=tan* *be-fîṛo* *de-ç-êt*
DEM:PROG busy=COP.3SG blood=2PL in-vain IND-go.PRS-3SG
'Your blood is being wasted (lit. is going in vain).'

The demonstrative is thus an attention-drawing device. In all Kurdish varieties it is also used with simple past constructions with a prospective function, implying immediacy and drawing attention to the speech situation:

(115) a. Behdînî NK (fieldnotes)
eve *ez* *hat-im=e* *te*
DEM.PROX 1SG.DIR come.PST-1SG=DRCT 2SG.OBL
'Here I come to you (threatening).'

b. Muş NK (p.c., Songül Gundoğdu)
hava *ez* *hat-im* *te*
DEM.PROX 1SG.DIR come.PST-1SG 2SG.OBL
'Here I come to you (threatening).'

19.2.1.3.30 Demonstrative as contrastive epistemic focus

The demonstrative in NK and CK can be used to denote that the situation is contrary to the speaker's expectation:

(116) CK colloquial (fieldnotes)
ewe *çi* *de-ke-y*
DEM what IND-do.PRS-2SG
'What are you doing?!'

In a similar way, in response to a statement that is counter to the actual situation, the use of the demonstrative can serve as corrective. With special lengthening of the stressed final syllable, the following sentence can be interpreted in this way:

(117) CK Sulemaniyya (fieldnotes)

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wa *de-řo-m*
DEM:PROG IND-go.PRS-1SG
'See, I am leaving (contrary to what you claim!)'

The negative question in (118) with the demonstrative element expressing that the speaker believes that the hearer does not expect to go:

(118) CK colloquial (fieldnotes)
ewe *na-řo-yn?*
DEM:PROG NEG-go.PRS-1PL
'Aren't we going?

19.2.1.3.31 CK adpositional progressive

In the CK of Sulemaniyya, there is a periphrastic progressive construction consisting of the locative circumposition *le=…=da* combined with the infinitive, e.g., *hatin* 'to come,' and the inflected copula. See (119):

(119) *le=řoyştin=a=în*
in=go.INF=in=COP.1PL
'We are going.' (McCarus 2009: 619)

Note that the form in (119) is an emergent progressive construction and is not obligatory when describing an act in progress.

19.2.2 Progressive forms in Zazaki

To express the progressive aspect, Zazaki employs three dialect-dependent strategies (Table 19.2).

i. The copula attaches directly to the subject of an indicative sentence

ii. The copula attaches to a deictic particle *na* (proximal) or *ha* (distal)

iii. A contracted form of the deictic particle *ha* and the copula is used

It should be noted that progressives do not occur in negated clauses.

In Northern Zazaki, the progressive may be formed by attaching the copula to the subject, often a pronoun. In this construction, the first person frequently defaults to either the 3SG or 3PL form. Keskin (2008: 81) reports one dialect where the 1SG copula is maintained, but this is not widespread. The use of the copula in this way, especially after pronouns, is attested for both Northern and Southern Zazaki.

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Table 19.2: Progressive strategies in Zazaki

	COP	DEIC + COP	DEIC *ha*
1SG	*=o/-a*	*na=wo/ha=wo*	*ha*
2SG.M	*=ê*	—	*hê*
2SG.F	*=a*	*na=wa/ha=wa*	*ha/hay*
3SG.M	*=o*	*na=wo/ha=wo*	*ho*
3SG.F	*=a*	*na=wa/ha=wa*	*ha*
1PL	*=o/-ê*	*na=wo/na=yê/ha=wo/ha=yê*	*hê*
2PL	*=ê*	*na=yê/ha=yê*	*hê*
3PL	*=ê*	*na=yê/ha=yê*	*hê*

(120) Present progressive forms using the copula

a. (NZ, Selcan 1998: 530)
ez=o *goçerî=yo,* *son-o.*
1SG=COP.1SG nomad=COP.1SG go.PRS-1SG
'I am on the move, going (now).'

b. (SZ, Paul 2024: 85)
ti=yê *se* *ken-ê?*
2SG=COP.2SG.M what do.PRS-2SG.M
'What are you doing (right now)?'

It is relevant to note in Zazaki, the forms of the Zazaki direct-case *ezafe* and the copula are identical the third person forms of the copula. The *ezafe* inflects for number and gender but not person.

Table 19.3: Zazaki *ezafe* and copula

Ezafe (direct)		Copula	
SG.M	*-o*	3SG.M	*-o*
PL.M	*-ê*	3PL.M	*-ê*
SG.F	*-a*	3SG.F	*-a*
PL.M	*-ê*	3PL.M	*-ê*

(121) Present progressive forms using a deictic particle and the copula

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a. (NZ, Paul 2024: 192)
ez na=wo son.
1SG DEIC=COP.1SG go.PRS.1SG
'I am going.'

b. (NZ, Selcan 1998: 531)
ha=yê verva dey yen-ê.
DEIC=COP.3PL towards 3SG.M.OBL come.PRS-3PL
'They are coming towards him.'

In Central Zazaki, the deictic particle *ha* has contracted with the copula into a monosyllabic unit (Paul 2024: 202; Baluken 2021: 109–111).

(122) Present progressive forms using only a deictic particle

a. (CZ, Baluken 2021: 62)
ti h=ê şîn ça?
2SG DEIC=COP.2SG.M go.PRS.2SG where
'Where are you going?'

b. (CZ, Paul 2024: 179)
mûra h=a berqên-a
pearl.F DEIC=COP.2SG.F shine.PRS-2SG.F
'The pearl is shining.'

The progressive construction is also used in past indicative contexts, primarily with the simple past (preterite), but occasionally also with the perfect. In many such cases, the progressive does not primarily mark an ongoing action, but highlights the speaker's attitude, i.e., adding emphasis, emotion, or a sense of immediacy (cf. Selcan 1998: 530–532).

(123) Progressive forms in past tenses (NZ, Selcan 1998: 531–532)

a. *na=wo cor=de am-e.*
DEIC=COP.3SG.M above=at come.PST-3SG
'He was coming from above.'

b. *ha=wo bî-yo çar roz-î.*
DEIC=COP.3SG.M be.PST-3SG for day-PL
'It has been four days now.'

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19.2.3 Progressive forms in Goranî

19.2.3.1 Hewramî reduplicated progressive

The core Gorani varieties known as Hewramî form their progressive with a reduplicated construction. This construction begins with a full reduplication of the verbal stem with a thematic extension *-ay* for forms based on the present stem, e.g., present indicative and past imperfective, and *-î* for forms based on the past stem, e.g., perfective. See (124).

(124) Hewramî Takht (Mohammadirad 2026)

a. *wer-ay* *wer-ó*
REDUP-NMLZ eat.PRS.IND-3SG:A
'S/he is eating.' ()

b. *wer-ay* *wer-ê*
REDUP-NMLZ eat.PRS.IND-PST.IPFV.3SG:A
'S/he was eating.'

c. *wit-î* *wit-e=n-a*
REDUP-NMLZ sleep.PST-PCPL.M.SG-COP-1SG:S
'I have been sleeping.'

19.2.3.2 Gorani periphrastic progressive

Like CK, many Gorani varieties outside of the core Hewramî zone including Paweyane have a periphrastic progressive employing the nominal element *xerîk* 'busy.' This can combine with the copular endings and a complement clause in indicative progressive aspect; see (125a). It can also occur with the genitival *ezafe* and the infinitive; see (125b).

(125) Paweyane (author's fieldnotes)

a. *emin xerîk-in-an* *m-ûs-û.*
1SG busy-COP-1SG:S IND-sleep.PRS-1SG:S
'I am sleeping.'

b. *emin xerîk-û* *wit-ey-in-an.*
1SG busy-EZ.GEN sleep-INF-COP-1SG:S
'I am sleeping.'

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In the more peripheral varieties of Gorani, such as Gawraju and Kandule, the existential particle *hê*[2] , inflected by enclitic pronouns, combines with the inflected present-stem verb to express the progressive.

(126) a. Gawraju (Bailey 2018: 397)
min hê=m nan m-wer-im.
I EXIST=1SG food IND-eat.PRS-1SG:A
'I am now eating food.' [H:79]

b. *ême hê=man me-gerd-am*
1PL EXIST=1PL IND-walk.PRS-1SG
'We are now walking (around).' [H:96]

19.3 Progressive in Arabic

Known as the 'aktuelles Präsens' in German language sources, the progressive is expressed in most *Qəltu* dialects by means of a particle attached to the Prefix Conjugation (Jastrow 1978: 300). Four different particles can be identified in the dialects in and around the NENA region: most commonly, *kū-*, but also *qa(d)-*, *kē-* and *k(ə)-*. Bəḥzāni and Mērgi *k(ə)-* may derive from *kū-*: there is evidence in other dialects for *kū-* reducing to *kə-* (J. Arbīl, Jastrow 1990a: 63) or *k-* (Daragözü, Jastrow 1978: 302). C. Mosul *kē-*, however, seems less likely to derive from *kū-*, as a shift of a back rounded */ū/* to front unrounded */ē/* is unexpected. Given that there are instances of **q* > */k/* in cases of grammaticalisation in the region, an origin in *qa(d)-* is also plausible for *kē-* and *k(ə)-*.

The particle *qa(d)-* is derived from *qāʿid*, the 3SG.M active participle of 'to sit' (Jastrow 1978: 302; Camilleri & Sadler 2017). This participle and derivatives of it are attested in other dialects of Mesopotamia, including the three dialects of Baghdad (Blanc 1964a: 115-116).

The particle *kū-* appears to be the same as the homophonous particle used by some dialects in combination with the Suffix Conjugation to express the present perfect. Its etymology from either a deictic copula or a copular verb *ykūn* is discussed in §16.3. Some dialects (J. Səndōṛ, J. Arbīl, J. ʿAqra and C. Āzəx) use *kū-* with both Prefix and Suffix Conjugations, while Siirt town and Tillo use *kū-* with the Prefix Conjugation and *kəl-* with the Suffix Conjugation (see §16.3).

[2]Bailey (2018) glosses *hê* as 'currently'. However, the fact that the same particle is used in predicative possessive constructions, e.g., *min ye bira=m hê* [1SG one brother=1SG:NC EXIST] 'I have a brother', suggests that it is an existential particle.

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Table 19.4: Progressive particles within the NENA area

Mosul (M, C, J)	M. *qa(d)-*, C. *kē-* Procházka 2019b: 252; Jastrow 1979: 47), J. *qa-* (Jastrow 2001: 67)
Bəḥzāni (C, Y, M)	*k(ə)-* (Jastrow 1978: 302)
Mērgi (C)	*kə-* with imperfective function (Hassan 2023: 584)
Səndōṛ (J)	*kū-* (Jastrow 1991b: 775)
Arbīl (J)	*kū- ~ku- ~kə-* (Jastrow 1990a: 63)
ʿAqra (J)	*kū- ~ku-* (Jastrow 1990a: 63)
Khānaqīn (J)	*qa-* (Bar-Moshe 2024: 113)

Table 19.5: Progressive particles on the periphery of the NENA area

Āzəx (C)	*kū-* (Wittrich 2001: 71, 152)
Siirt town (M)	*ku-* (Biţună 2016b: 226)
Tillo (M)	*kū-* (Lahdo 2009: 166)
Kirkūk (J), Tūz Khurmātu (J)	*qa-* (Bar-Moshe 2024: 113)

19.4 Progressive in Armenian

Neither of the standard Armenian languages has dedicated progressive verb forms distinct from the general present tense, which is formed with the particle *kə* and phonetic variants plus the subjunctive (present for present tense 127, imperfect for imperfect tense 128) in Western Armenian, and with the copula/auxiliary (present for present tense 129, past for imperfect tense 130) and an imperfective participle containing a locative element in Eastern Armenian (for details of the various Eastern Armenian imperfective participles and their historical development, see §12.4.3.1).

(127) SWA
kə sir-im
PTCL love-PRS.SBJV.1SG
'I love/am loving.'

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(128) SWA
kə sir-ei
PTCL love-IPF.SBJV.1SG
'I loved/was loving.'

(129) SEA
sir-um=em
love-I.PTCP=be.PRS.1SG
'I love/am loving.'

(130) SEA
sir-um=ei
love-I.PTCP=be.PST.1SG
'I loved/was loving.'

Both these constructions are thought to have originated as progressives, although in the case of the *kə*-forms this is less certain, as by the time the construction is attested in the first Middle Armenian texts, it has already become established as a general present (and future) tense (see §18 and §17). The present tense with the imperfective participle is known to have originated as a progressive, and subsequently spread to cover all present and imperfect contexts in SEA and many Eastern dialects. A trace of its progressive origin that is still visible in SEA is the fact that, like the *kə*-forms in many dialects (see §12.4.2.2), it is not used with certain stative verbs, which form the present tense as in CA, i.e., with the same form as the present subjunctive (*un-em* 'I have', *git-em* 'I know', *ka-m* 'I exist', colloquial EA *kar-am* 'I can'). In early modern EA texts, and some dialects, tense forms with the imperfective participle are still associated with progressive meaning (see Avetyan 2021).

Avetyan (2021) presents evidence from early modern Eastern Armenian texts that the locative-based present was originally confined to progressive contexts, while the *kə*-forms continued to be used for non-progressive present. Such a situation appears to obtain in the dialect of Salmast as represented in the texts in Atayan (1906), as seen in (131), where the verbs expressing the main events of the narrative, such as *k-kʰyæʃ-i* 'pulls', *k-as-i* 'says', are in the *kə*-present, while the locative-based present is associated with progressive contexts, such as *et intʃʰ es an-eləi* 'what is this you're doing?'.

(131) Salmast Armenian (Atayan 1906: 204)

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ets-u *æng^{j}ʧ-en* *k-k^{hj}æʃ-i* *t^{h}ex* *tus.* *ʧ^{h}uəræg^{j}ʧ^{h}i-n*
goat-GEN ear-ABL PTCL-pull-3SG towards out baker-DEF
k-as-i, *et* *inʧ^{h}=es* *an-eləi,* *ax* *ets-ə'* *im-n*
PTCL-say-3SG DEM2 what=be.2SG do-I.PTCP PTCL goat-DEF 1SG.GEN-DEF
i
be.3SG
'He drags the goat out [lit. towards out] by its ear. The baker says, "What is this you're doing, the goat is mine."'

Many Western Armenian dialects have developed dedicated progressive forms, generally formed with an invariant particle that follows the present tense verb, as in (132) from colloquial Istanbul (Polis) Armenian. Acharyan (1961: 97) believes their development was promoted by influence from Turkish, which has dedicated progressive forms (e.g. *-(I)yor*) distinct from the regular present; compare Turkish *gel-ir-Ø* [come-PRS-3SG] ~ *gel-iyor-Ø* [come-PROG-3SG].

(132) Colloquial Istanbul Armenian (Acharyan 1961: 98)
g-ert^{h}-am *gor*
PTCL-go-PRS.1SG PROG
'I am going.'

As discussed by Acharyan (1961: 97), such forms are absent not only from the Caucasus and Iran, but also from the eastern part of Anatolia extending from the Persian border up to and including Erzurum, Kharberd (near Elazığ), and Diyarbakir. They cover an area that extends west from Bayburt and Malatya all the way to Rodosto (Thrace). The particle *gor*, seen in (132), is used in Sebastia (Sivas), Evdokia (Tokat), and Rodosto, as well as in colloquial Istanbul Armenian and colloquial WA in general. It is analysed by Vaux (1995: 136) as a combination either of the Middle Armenian particle *ku* (pronounced *gu* in most Western dialects) or the verb *ga* 'exist.PRS.3SG' and the conjunction *or*, so that it could be translated as 'there exists that'.

As discussed by Vaux (2016) with reference to the data of Acharyan (1961: 97-8), in some of these formations, the progressive particle appears to be related to the deictic element *ha*, which could be roughly translated as 'there it is' (like *ecco* in Italian or *na* in Greek). These include Malatya *a* (133), Aslanbeg *haye* (< *ha* + 3SG copula *e*) (134), and presumably Adapazar *haygag*, although the origin of the second part of this element is unclear.

(133) Malatya Armenian (Acharyan 1961: 98)

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g-erɾ^{h}-am a
PTCL-go-PRS.1SG PROG
'I am going.'

(134) Aslanbeg Armenian (Acharyan 1961: 98)
kə siɾ-im haye
PTCL love-PRS.1SG PROG
'I am loving.'

In the texts in the Salmast dialect given by Atayan (1906), we find examples of stressed *ha* preposed to the present tense form for emphasis. In examples such as (135), this could be interpreted as emphasizing duration, potentially giving rise to a progressive interpretation.

(135) Salmast Armenian (Atayan 1906: 198)
ha k-ut-en, ha k-ut-en
PTCL PTCL-eat-PRS.3PL, PTCL PTCL-eat-PRS.3PL
'They eat/are eating (for such a long time).'

Hamshen dialect has progressive tenses formed with the subjunctive (present or imperfect) of the lexical verb plus the 3SG present form of the verb 'to have', as seen in (136) (present progressive) and (137) (past progressive).

(136) Hamshen Armenian (Vaux 2007: 263)
b^{h}er-im g-un-i
carry-PRS.SBJV.1SG PTCL-have-PRS.3SG
'I am carrying.'

(137) Hamshen Armenian (Vaux 2007: 263)
b^{h}er-eyi g-un-i
carry-PST.SBJV.1SG PTCL-have-PRS.3SG
'I was carrying.'

19.5 Progressive in Turkic

The vast majority of Turkic varieties exhibit progressives or general presents evolved out of old progressive constructions. They are predominantly grammaticalised combinations of non-finite verb forms with auxiliaries (Johanson 2021: 638).

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The origin of the progressive construction according to Johanson (2021) bears striking parallels to that of the aorist-eventual construction. However, it is important to recognise that these two grammaticalisation processes occurred centuries apart. While the aorist is reconstructed to the earliest stages of Proto-Turkic, the progressive emerged in Western Oghuz only around the fourteenth century, or possibly slightly earlier (Dybo & Levitskaja 2002: 172–176). By this time, the aorist had already evolved into a fully synthetic construction.

The progressive thematic base varies in form across the dialects but is generally highly fusional throughout the area. The periphrastic origin of the construction is visible in Middle Azeri, where forms like *sal-eir-* 'be dropping' (cf. Modern Azeri *sal-ır-*) are attested (Johanson 2021: 638), as well as in Eastern Anatolian and North-western varieties, which feature a long (or even diphthongised) suffixal vowel that does not undergo vowel harmony, e.g., *al-īr-*, *al-ēr-*, *al-eyr-* 'be taking'.

Urmia Azeri possesses all the allomorphs found in Standard Azeri, e.g., *bax-ır-am* 'I am looking' (Doğan 2010: 416). Occasionally, the suffixal *r* may drop, especially when it is not followed by a vowel, e.g., *gəli-sən* 'you are coming', *qoy-u* 's/he puts' (Doğan 2010: 159–160). In the present progressive, the third-person form may feature an idiosyncratic agreement marker *-i*, e.g., *ged-ir-i* 's/he is going' (Doğan 2010: 160). In addition, when a lexical base ends in a vowel, it is often deleted when followed by a progressive suffix, e.g., *başla-* > *başl-ıl-la* 'they start / are starting' (Doğan 2010: 450).

(138) a. Urmia Azeri (Doğan 2010: 279, 280)
indi elə o zaman-nan sürücü iş-i-nə bax-ır-ıx.
now FOC that time-ABL driver work-POSS.3-DAT look-IPFV.PRS-1PL
'And from that point on, we have been (lit. are) taking care of the driving.'

b. (Describing a one-time trip to Turkey)
ordan bura boyax gətir-ir-di-ĥ
there.ABL here.DAT paint bring-IPFV-PST-1PL
'We were bringing back some paints.'

In most Azeri dialects, the progressive has encroached significantly on the habitual domain and is no longer restricted to an ongoing action:

(139) Urmia Azeri (Doğan 2010: 257, 400)

a. (On being asked about holidays that are usually celebrated in the village)

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nōruz beyram-ı çox gözəl tut-ur-ux, hədyə
PN holiday-POSS.3 a.lot beautiful seize-IPFV.PRS-1PL gift
ver-ir-ix.
give-IPFV.PRS-1PL
'We celebrate the feast of Novruz beautifully; we give (each other) presents.'

b. *ama qabaxca bu.cür=idi, kət-dər-də dünya-ya*
but before this.PROX=COP.PST.3 village-PL-LOC world-DAT
gəl-ir-di uşax, bimāristan-da dünya-ya
come-IPFV-PST.3 child hospital-LOC world-DAT
gəl-m-ir-di.
come-NEG-IPFV-PST.3
'But in the past, this is how it used to be: children would be born in villages, they would not be born in hospitals.'

Contrary to Persian and several other languages of the region, most Azeri dialects—and related Turkic varieties—have not innovated a new progressive construction following the expansion of the old progressive into the habitual domain. A notable exception is Qashqai and Bakhtiari Turkic, which have calqued the Modern Persian 'have'-based progressive using the existential copula *var* (Johanson 2021: 649; Schreiber et al. 2021: 221). The infinitive-based progressive in Azeri, e.g., *bax-maq-da-yam* (look-INF-LOC-1SG) 'I am (in the process of) looking', which has been misidentified as the source of the areal diffusion of infinitive-based progressives across the Northern Iran–Caucasus region (Schulze 2000: 47), remains a marginal, predominantly written TAM category, rarely attested before the mid-twentieth century and likely a recent copy from Istanbul Turkish. While Azeri could theoretically have been responsible for such diffusion, given that most languages with infinitive-based progressives are in contact with it, the phenomenon is more plausibly analysed as combinational copying: in the contact languages whose original grammatical systems did not possess converbs, the infinitive has assumed functions typically associated with the converb and thus served as the progressive base, modelling the Turkic construction.

19.6 Discussion

In NENA dialects the progressive is formed either from the present verbal stem or from a stem consisting of an infinitive and locative preposition (§19.1.1). Progressives based on the present stem are found across the NENA area, including the

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north-western periphery (e.g., C. Bohtan, C. Haṣṣan, C. Hertevin), on the southern Mosul plain (C. Qaraqosh, C. Barəṭle), the southern sector (e.g., J. Arbel, C. Armota, C. Sulemaniyya, J. Sanandaj). Progressives formed from the locative infinitive stem are found predominantly in dialects in the northern sector.

Progressives formed from a present stem are found in the Iranian languages of the region (Kurdish, Gorani and Zazaki) and also in the *Qəltu* Arabic dialects. The NENA present stem *qaṭəl* derives historically from an active participle, which had a progressive function in earlier Aramaic. The use of progressives in Iranian and Arabic formed from a present stem would, therefore, have reinforced the continuation of the construction in Aramaic. There is no clear historical precedent of the NENA progressive construction formed from a locative infinitive within Aramaic. The clearest model for this is Eastern Armenian, in which the progressive is expressed by a locative construction. The stem of this may be an imperfective participle (§19.4) or, in some dialects, an infinitive. The locative infinitive construction appears to have deep historical roots in earlier Armenian (for details see §12.4.3.1). The hypothesis that the NENA locative infinitive progressive developed by matching Eastern Armenian is supported by the fact that the majority of NENA dialects with progressives based on a locative infinitive are in the northern sector. These innovative progressive constructions may have originated in NENA dialects on the northern periphery in contact with Eastern Armenian and then spread southward to dialects outside of the Armenian-NENA contact area. They are found on the Mosul plain, for example, in NENA dialects as far south as C. Telkepe. The NENA construction matches most clearly the Armenian locative infinitive construction, though the use of an infinitive in the construction could also have arisen, or been reinforced, by perceptually matching it with an Armenian locative participle construction.

In eastern Iraq progressive constructions based on the infinitive are found as far south as the dialect of J. Sulemaniyya (40). In this case, however, it is likely that the model was the Central Kurdish dialect of Sulemaniyya, which, unlike the rest of Kurdish, has has an analogous progressive construction, which consists of the locative circumposition *le=…=da* combined with the infinitive (§19.2.1.3.31).

Another possible model for NENA progressive constructions based on the infinitive is the Azeri Turkic progressive, which has developed from a stem consisting of a converb combined with the verb ‘to be’ (19.5). In Azeri there is also progressive construction with an infinitive and a locative particle, e.g., *bax-maq-da-yam* (look-INF-LOC-1SG) ‘I am (in the process of) looking’. This, however, is largely restricted to the literary language and is likely to be influenced by Istanbul Turkish. So, the Armenian model for the NENA dialects in the northern region seems the most likely.

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In the far north-eastern periphery of NENA there is an increasing extension of the construction with a locative infinitive to express the habitual. This may have been induced by sustained contact down to modern times with Eastern Armenian, in which the locative progressive construction is now a general present. Since NENA dialects in this region were in contact also with Azeri Turkish, it also possible that the extension of the Azeri progressive to the expression of the habitual (19.5) also had an impact on NENA in this respect.

The NENA present stem *qaṭəl* has prefixed augments *k-* or *ʾi-/y-* when it expresses the indicative. These augments are derived historically from a presentative particle (*k-* < *kā*) and the copula (*ʾi*). In some dialects they are combined, e.g., C. Urmi *c-i-*. The present stem with these augments originally expressed the progressive and its function still includes the progressive in some dialects. Parallels to the combination of presentative or/and copula elements with the present stem are found in many languages of the region. There are clear parallels in Zazaki, which expresses the progressive with a construction consisting of the present stem combined with the copula, which is in some cases preceded by a presentative particle (§19.2.2). Also in some *Qəltu* Arabic dialects, the progressive is expressed by a prefix beginning with *k-* that seems to be a deictic copula in origin (§19.3). Western Armenian has an augment to the present with the form a *kə-* prefix, which is likely to have originally expressed the progressive and have been used at an earlier period also in the Eastern Armenian area. It is derived from a periphrasis *kay u* 'stand/exist and' > *ku* > *kə* (§12.4.2.2). The prefixes with *k-* in Arabic and Armenian also resemble the phonetic shape of the NENA prefix *k-*. The Kurdish preverbal particle *de-* (and phonetic variants), which is used with present stem verbs to express a general imperfective (progressive and habitual), is likely also to have originated as a progressive. The particle may be derived historically from a locative particle (§18.2). Alternatively, it may be connected etymologically with the attention-drawing particle *de* that is used in Kurdish directives, e.g., *de were* 'come!'

The *ʾi-/y-* prefix of the present stem of NENA dialects could also have matched the pronominal *ezafe* particle in Behdînî Northern Kurdish progressives formed with the *ezafe* (§19.2.1.1). The initial *y-* of the independent form of the *ezafe* (sg.m *yê*) matches the phonetic shape of the NENA *ʾi-/y-* prefix. It is important to note that the NENA *ʾi/y-* prefix is used in the northern sector of NENA, largely coinciding with the Behdînî area. Another parallel to the *ʾi-/y-* NENA prefix is the invariable copula suffix *-e* of present stem verbs that is attested in Botan and Siirt dialects of Northern Kurdish with a progressive-marking function (see p.716). Alternatively, it may have been induced, or reinforced, by matching the NENA copula with the Armenian preverbal particle *kə-*, which is derived from

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a periphrasis *kay u* 'stand/exist and' > *ku* > *kə* (§12.4.2.2). This, indeed, would explain why NENA verbal forms with the *ʾi-* particle appear to have a greater historical depth than the Behdînî *ezafe* construction, since the NENA construction has been extended to express the habitual whereas this is not the case with the Behdînî construction.

The same strategies for the expression of the progressive in the languages in contact with NENA appear to have induced a second cycle of augments on the NENA present stem, which developed when the original NENA progressive was extended to express the habitual. This second cycle of augments was applied also to NENA progressive constructions formed from locative infinitives, indicating that this second cycle of augments took place after the innovative locative infinitive progressive constructions had been introduced into NENA.

A second cycle of preposing of copula elements in NENA progressives formed from the present stem and locative infinitive is found in dialects in the northern sector. This is less grammaticalised than the first cycle of preposing of the copula and typically consists of inflected deictic copulas, e.g., (4), (5), (26), (27).

A parallel to the inflection of the copula element for gender, number and person is found in Zazaki progressive constructions. As in many NENA dialects in the northern sector, the preposed copula element in Zazaki is combined with a deictic element. A further model for such NENA constructions is likely to have been the *ezafe* progressives of Behdînî Kurdish, which has been in contact with NENA dialects in the northern sector of the NENA area down to modern times. If Zazaki acted as a model for the NENA constructions, this must have been at an earlier period, when, one would have to assume, NENA and Zazaki were in contact. The form of the Zazaki third person copula coincides with that of the *ezafe* (Table 19.3). The identity of copula and ezafe in Zazaki may have facilitated the development of the copula-like functions of the *ezafe* in Behdînî Kurdish by a matching of the two forms (see 15.2.3).

As remarked, Zazaki uses a deictic copula in progressives with the structure deictic + copula, e.g., *ha-wo* (DEIC-COP.3SG.M), which, in some varieties, contracts to *ho*. This has the same structure as the deictic copula *k-ilə* (DEIC-COP.3SG.M) of the NENA dialects on the Mosul plain. It also resembles the phonetic shape of the deictic copula *ho=le* that is used in progressive constructions in many NENA dialects in the northern sector. Moreover, some Zazaki dialects distinguish between near and distal deixis in progressives, which would parallel the distinction that is found in the progressives of some NENA dialects, e.g.,

(140) C. Urmi

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a. *du=lə* *bəptaxa.*
NEAR.DEIC=COP.3SG.M open.PROG
'He (here) is opening.'

b. *ve=lə* *bəptaxa.*
FAR.DEIC=COP.3SG.M open.PROG
'He (there) is opening.'

The form *ho=le* appears to be derived historically from *ha* + *ʾaw* + *ile* (DEIC + DEM + COP.3SG.M). The same applies to deictic copula with an initial *d-* element that is used in progressive constructions in some NENA dialects, e.g., C. Urmi *du=lə* (DEIC + DEM + COP.3SG.M). This parallels the use of demonstratives with copulas in some Northern Kurdish varieties, e.g., (113).

In Zazaki progressives the copula is sometimes cliticised to the subject argument (§19.2.2). Likewise the *ezafe* element in Behdînî Kurdish progressives frequently cliticises to the subject (§19.2.1.1). Parallels to this structure are found in progressive constructions in some NENA dialects of the northern sector, in which the copula is cliticised to the subject (37, 38).

In some contact languages, the preposed copula element is uninflected. Such structures are found in *Qəltu* Arabic and in some Northern Kurdish varieties, such as Botan and Siirt (716). The *ezafe* particle of Behdînî Kurdish, moreover, is only inflected for gender, not number or person (§19.2.1.1). This is matched by uninflected copulas preposed before present stem verbs in the progressive constructions of NENA dialects in the north-western periphery (see. p.685ff.) and in the Arbīl and Sulemaniyya provinces (see p.686ff.). In the Arbīl and Sulemaniyya provinces, in addition to contact with Arabic another model that may have induced the use of an uninflected particle in NENA progressives may have been progressive Kurdish constructions with initial demonstrative pronouns. In the Central Kurdish area these are typically fossilised forms without inflection and without a copula, e.g., (112). These demonstratives can be used with a contrastive epistemic function (116, 117, 118) and this is matched by the contrastive epistemic function of the uninflected copula particle in some NENA dialects (74).

In NENA dialects in the northern sector and Mosul plain that use deictic copulas in progressive constructions, the copula is cliticised to the verbal stem (i.e., the present stem or the locative infinitive stem) when the construction is not used deictically, as, for example, in questions. This may be an internal development within the NENA dialects. There are some models for this strutcure, however, in contact languages in the northern sector of NENA. In Eastern Armenian the copula is by default placed after the locative progressive stem (129, 130). The use

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of enclitic copulas in progressive constructions in NENA dialects in the south-eastern sector (6, 40, 63) does not have a clear parallel in contact languages of region. The locative infinitive progressive construction in the Central Kurdish dialect of Sulemaniyya (119), may have been a factor, since the copula in this construction is encltic. This, however, is unlikely to have been the model for all the NENA dialects in the south-eastern sector. Moreover, this progressive construction in the Kurdish of Sulemaniyya is only emergent and not obligatory. It is more likely that the use of enclitic copulas is a continuation of the use of copulas in progressive constructions in the NENA dialects of the northern sector. The fact that they are enclitic is because the NENA dialects of the south-eastern sector do not have fully functional paradigms of deictic copulas.

In the Jewish dialects in western Iran, progressive constructions are used that appear to be modelled on Gorani. The expression of the progressive in J. Sanandaj by combining the present verbal stem with preposed infinitive (24) is likely to have been modelled on Gorani progressives formed by preposing to the present stem a reduplication of the verbal stem with an uninflected suffix (124). The reduplication of the stem in Gorani is not an infinitive form, but the NENA dialect has matched this with the NENA uninflected infinitive form, which was perceived to be the nearest equivalent (cf. the remarks above concerning the matching of the Armenian progressive participle with the NENA infinitive.

The expression of the progressive in J. Kerend by combining the present stem with a possessive phrase (25) has a parallel in Gorani, in which progressives are expressed by an equivalent possessive phrase (126) and also in Qashqai Turkic (19.5), spoken in western Iran.

The expression of the past progressive in Jewish Trans-Zab dialects by combining the Kurdish imperfective preverbal prefix *da* with an inflected form of the past stem (88, 89) is a replication of the common Kurdish construction for expressing the past imperfective, including the borrowing of the Kurdish particle (§18.2). It should be noted, however, that in NENA, as far as can be established, the form is used only for the past progressive, whereas in Kurdish it is used for the past habitual and the past progressive. In the NENA dialects in question, there is no other dedicate construction for the past progressive, so the replication of the Kurdish construction had the motivation to fill this specific gap.

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20 Verbal forms used in narrative

20.1 Narrative verbal forms in NENA

20.1.1 *Qṭille* past perfective

NENA has a perfective past verbal form that is widely used across the dialects to narrate past time-bound events. The stem of this form, which is known as the past stem, is derived historically from the resultative passive participle in the absolute state, viz. **qṭīl*. In most dialects this is inflected by oblique pronominal suffixes consisting historically of the preposition *l-* and a pronominal suffix, e.g., C. Barwar *qṭil-le* 'he killed', *qṭil-la* 'she killed'; *qim-le* 'he arose', *qim-la* 'she arose'. In a small subset of dialects intransitive verbs formed from this stem are inflected by direct nominative pronominal suffixes, e.g., J. Sanandaj *qim-a* 'she arose'. The oblique suffixes reflect an association of this construction with ergative syntax (see §22.2 for more details). This form, which will be designated henceforth as the *qṭille* form, refers to a specific event at a specific event time in the past. It is the default form in NENA dialects to express the past perfective. An example of its use in narrative is (1):

(1) C. Barwar (Khan 2008c: 616)
θé-le *xa-náša* *swarìyya*| *rakàwa.*|
come.PST-OBL.3SG.M one-man horseman rider
ṣlé-le *rəš-xa-ʾèna.*| *tìw-le,*|
come.down.PST-OBL.3SG.M on-one-spring sit.PST-OBL.3SG.M
xíl-le *màndi,*| *šté-le* *mìya.*|
eat.PST-OBL.3SG.M thing drink.PST-OBL.3SG.M water
'A horseman, a rider came. He alighted at a spring. He sat down, ate something and drank some water.'

The temporal sequence and coherence of the events expressed by a series of past perfective forms is an implicature of the linear sequence of the verbs. This is an iconic mapping, in which the order of clauses mirrors the order of events. NENA dialects, however, use a variety of other verbal forms in narrative, in addition to the past perfective, to express the sequence and coherence of time-bound

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events. These forms are used with what may be termed a dependent narrative function. Unlike the past perfective *qṭille* form, the primary meaning of these other forms is not the expression of a time-bound specific event at a specific event time in the past. This meaning is imposed on the primary meaning of the forms by the narrative context.

20.1.2 Present habitual forms

In a wide range of NENA dialects the habitual is expressed by a verb consisting of the present stem (*qaṭəl*), deriving historically from an active participle, combined with a preverbal prefix. The prefix varies in shape across the dialects, including *ʾi-*, derived from the copula, (e.g., C. Barwar), *k-*, most likely derived from a deictic particle, (e.g., C. Shaqlawa), or a combination of both (e.g., C. Urmi *c-i-*) (see §18.1 for further details).

A habitual form such as C. Barwar *ʾi-qaṭəl* does not express a specific eventuality or a specific time reference, but rather a set of an unspecified number of eventualities that occur at unspecified points of time. This lack of specification allows a habitual form to express a single specific event at a specific point in time in narrative. In such cases the narrative context specifies the variables of number and time location, coercing its interpretation as a narrative form expressing a single specific event. The semantics of the habitual form itself, as remarked, contains only unspecified variables.

Since the tense and value of the variable number of events of a habitual in narrative constructions are specified by the context, one of the effects of the use of the habitual is to express dependency on and cohesion with the preceding discourse. Typically the narrative habitual forms in NENA follow past perfective *qṭille* forms in the onset of a narrative or narrative section. The perfective form and the ensuing narrative-dependent habitual forms can be interpreted as sequential phases of a single overall event. Temporal sequence is a feature of the foreground of a narrative, and for this reason the narrative-dependent forms typically express foreground events. This is because the narrative habitual forms are dependent on the preceding past perfective forms for their specification.

In some dialects narrative habitual forms are restricted to a subset of verbs. In the C. Barwar dialect, for example, it is attested only in the quotative verb *ʾ-m-r* ‘to say’ (2).

(2) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a: 594)

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plíṭ-la *šamála šắve* *lhàya.*| *y-ámər*
come.out.PST-OBL.3SG.F candle night burn.INF COP-say.PRS.3SG.M
bàb-i,| *bràt-i,*| *ʾáyya dūs=ila.*|
dear-my daughter-my this.F true=COP.3SG.F
'She came out glowing like a night candle. He says, "My dear, my girl, it is true."'

In several dialects, however, there is no such lexical restriction. This applies, for example, to the C. Shaqlawa dialect. Example (3) illustrates the narrative use of the habitual form in a sequential chain of verbs:

(3) C. Shaqlawa (Khan, fieldnotes)
k-ətʏ-a| *léša* *k-ud-à-le.*| *wáxtət*
DEIC-come.PRS-3SG.F dough DEIC-do.PRS-3SG.F-OBL.3SG.M time.of
ʾitày-u *k-áwe*| *tănúre g-mašxən-à-le,*|
come.INF-his DEIC-be.PRS.3SG.M oven DEIC-heat.PRS-3SG.F-OBL.3SG.M
ka-tănùre *qə-mašxən-á-le,*| *zwàta*| *zutyáta*
when-oven PST-heat.PST-3SG.F-OBL.3SG.M flat.bread flat.breads
gə-mṭapy-à-lu *gawət-tănúre.*|
DEIC-stick.PRS-3SG.F-OBL.3PL in-oven
'She comes and makes the dough. It becomes the time of his coming (back). She heats the oven. When she had heated the oven, she sticks flat bread, flat breads inside the oven.'

These narrative forms of the verb are translated above by English simple present verbs. They should not, however, be regarded as present tense forms. The NENA narrative forms *ʾi-qaṭəl* and *k-qaṭəl* can be used as present habituals, but when used in narrative, their tense and aspect are determined by the context and they should not be analysed as 'historical presents'. As we have described already, the variables of event and time inherent in the habitual form are specified by the narrative context and they narrate perfective events in the past.

Habitual narrative forms in NENA dialects in the northern sector are occasionally discourse-dependent habitual forms. As discussed in §18.1.6, these have the future preverbal particle *bəd-* and express temporal or thematic sequence to what precedes. They are most frequently used to expressed habitual events, i.e., events that occur an unspecified number of occasions at unspecified points in time, but may be used in narrative to express single events. As with other narrative habitual forms, here also the narrative context coerces the interpretation of the form as expressing a single event, e.g.,

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(4) C. Barwar (Khan 2008c: 602)
b-lèle | *qím-la* *šáry-a* *bănúd-a* *dìya,* |
at-night rise.PST-OBL.3SG.F untie.PRS-3SG.F bands-3SG.F GEN.3SG.F
ṯ-àz-a, | *pθíx-la* *tắra* *qðìla.* |
FUT-go.PRS-3SG.F open.PST-OBL.3SG.F door key
'At night she got up, untied her bands, then went and opened the door with a key.'

20.1.3 Progressive Forms

There are some NENA dialects that use a progressive construction in narratives. These forms consist of a progressive stem and a copula. The progressive stem is formed from a locative preposition and the infinitive. Dialects that use this narrative strategy include C. Urmi, in which the progressive form is frequently used by speakers as a narrative form in folktales, e.g.,

(5) C. Urmi (Khan 2016b: vol. 2, 186)
bəšk̭álə=lə *ʾo-náša,* *⁺bək̭ṯàl-u=lə.* |
take.PROG=COP.3SG.M that-man kill.PROG-3SG.M=COP.3SG.M
labúl-u=lə *k̭a-màlca.* |
take.PROG-3SG.M=COP.3SG.M to-king
'He takes that man and kills him. He carries him (i.e., his body) to the king.'

Prima facie this indeed could be interpeted as a historical present that is presenting the events as unfolding virtually in speech time. It is more likely, however, that also these forms are narrative-dependent forms the temporal and aspectual specification of which are determined by the preceding narrative context. As is the case with the narrative habitual forms *ʾi-qaṭəl* and *k-qaṭəl* in C. Barwar and C. Shaqlawa, the construction is typically not used at the beginning of a narrative, but continues it after the temporal setting of the narrative has been established by past perfect forms. It is important to note that although this locative construction originally denoted a progressive aspect, its usage in C. Urmi has been extended to the expression of the habitual in addition to the progressive. When it is used as a habitual, it tends to denote a habitual activity that is salient, in that it is not permanent, but rather is temporally delimited and is characteristic of the present and immediately adjacent periods of time, e.g.,

(6) C. Urmi (Khan 2016b: vol. 2, 187)

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lɛ́t *⁺bixàla,*| *lɛ́t* *bəštàya,*| *ʾáslan*
NEG.COP.2SG.M eat.PROG NEG.COP.2SG.M drink.PROG completely
dŭt *šuxlə̀ppa.*|
DEIC.COP.2SG.M change.PPRT.SG.M
'You are (now) not eating, you are not drinking, you have completely changed.'

Similarly, *prima facie* progressive forms are attested in narratives in other NENA dialects. In C. Qaraqosh on the Mosul plain, for example, the progressive form with a preverbal deictic copula *k-ilə k-qaṭəl* is occasionally used to express a perfective event in narrative. These are attested at salient transition points in a narrative (7) and at salient endpoints in a chain of events (8):

(7) C. Qaraqosh (Khan 2002a: 335)
ʾAbū Šabíb k-íl *k-àmər*|
ʾAbū Šabíb DEIC-COP.3SG.M DEIC-SAY.PRS.3SG.M
'ʾAbū Šabíb says ...'

(8) C. Qaraqosh (Khan 2002a: 336)
fa-ʾánə *ʾáwwal ma-d-θì-hə*| *m-áwwal* *yòma*|
so-they first REL-SBRD-come.PST-OBL.3PL from-first day
mʿalf-ì-hə *da-susawàθa,*| *k-moxl-ì-hə=w*|
feed.PRS-3PL-OBL.3PL OM-horses DEIC-feed.PRS-3PL-OBL.3PL=and
k-ína *k-mast-è-hɔ.*|
DEIC-COP.3PL DEIC-give.drink.PRS-3PL-OBL.3PL
'So, as soon as they came, on the first day, they feed the horses, give them food and give them drink.'

Similarly, the *prima facie* progressive form *lā qăṭəl* in J. Arbel with a preverbal invariable deictic copula particle *lā* is occasionally used in narratives to express salient events, e.g.,

(9) J. Arbel (Khan 1999a: 267)
bqátta *qìm-lu,*| *lā-xér-i* *lā-mél-i*
morning rise.PST-OBL.3PL DEIC.COP-see.PRS-3PL DEIC.COP-die.PRS-3PL
mi-zdúl-u *k-én-i* *qaṭl-ì-lu.*|
from-fear-3PL DEIC-come.PRS-3PL kill.PRS-3PL-OBL.3PL
'They got up in the morning. They see this and die of fear that they would come to kill them'.

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In both C. Qaraqosh and J. Arbel the forms in question elsewhere do not only express progressive, but may be used also to express salient habitual events (Khan 2002a: 334; Khan 1999a: 263-264). The use of the forms in narrative, therefore, could be interpreted as salient habitual forms that are coerced by the narrative context to express perfective events. Indeed, as seen, they are used at salient points in the narrative.

20.1.4 Perfect Forms

In some NENA dialects perfect verbal forms are used in folktales to narrate the foreground events. This applies, for example, to the C. Barwar dialect. In this dialect, as in many NENA dialects, the perfect is formed by a combination of the resultative passive particle (*qṭila*) and copula (see §16.1). An example of the narrative use of the perfect is as follows:

(10) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a: 669)
qìme=la| *b-lèle*| *ṭríp=əl-la* *Zîne*|
rise.PPRT.PL=COP.3PL at-night seize.PPRT.PL=COP.3PL-OBL.3SG.F Zine
ʾu-mùθy=əl-la,| *núbl=əl-la*
and-bring.PPRT.PL=COP.3PL-OBL.3SG.F take.PPRT.PL-COP.3PL-OBL.3SG.F
kəs-Mămo.| *núbl=əl-la* *kəs-Mămo.*|
to-Mămo take.PPRT.PL-COP.3PL-OBL.3SG.F to-Mămo
dmìxe=la.| *ṛìštɛ=la,*|
sleep.PPRT.PL=COP.3PL wake.PPRT.SG.F=COP.3SG.F
zìpt=əlle=la| *ṭla-Mămo.*|
push.PPRT.SG.F=OBL.3SG.M=COP.3SG.F to-Mămo
'At night they went and seized Zine and brought her, they took her to Mămo. They took her to Mămo. They slept. She woke up and pushed Mămo (out of bed)'.

As shown in §16.1.10, outside of narrative the NENA perfect may have a resultative, anterior or existential function. These various perfect functions have in common an under-specification of the event component. In the case of the resultative and the anterior perfects, the event is referentially specific, i.e., one specific event is involved, but the time reference of this event is left unspecified. In the case of the existential perfect, the event component is a set of an unspecified number of events that occurred at unspecified points of time. It may have been one or more events. This is similar to the underspecification of events in habitual constructions.

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When the perfect is used in narrative, this underspecification of the event component is specified by the narrative context, as is the case with narrative habituals. The narrative perfects, therefore, express a specific event bound to a specific event time in the past, just like past perfective verbs.

As with the habitual narrative forms, the specification of the underspecified components of the narrative perfect by the prior context causes the forms to be interpreted as cohering with what precedes, typically in a sequential relationship, and so to be part of the foreground narrative line.

In addition to the expression of coherence, there is a further motivation for the use of perfects in narrative. Outside of folktales, the perfect is used in several NENA dialects with an evidential function to express specific perfective events in reports of events that the speaker has not witnessed (see §16.1.10.4 for further details). The perfect is also used to narrate events in the remote past. In such cases the event may have been witnessed by the speaker, but he/she is separated from it by a long interval of time. The construction may be used, therefore, by speakers to talk in the first person about events that they were involved in in the remote past. (see §16.1.10.6 for further details). The perfective use of the perfect in folktale narratives has a function that is similar to these functions of narrating unwitnessed events or events in the remote past, since the events of a fictional tale are, likewise, remote from present reality.

A similar use of the perfect in the narration of legends and folktales has been documented in the Jewish dialects of western Iran, such as J. Sanandaj (Khan 2009: 297).

In Jewish dialects in the Urmi area the perfect is used in narrative somewhat differently to set the scene and supply background to a following narrative of events, e.g.,

(11) J. Urmi (Khan 2008b: 270)
ayné kull-ù| g-šátət ày| əmmà-w| arbassàr,| +hal əmmá-w
these all-3PL in-year.of GEN hundred-and fourteen until hundred-and
əsrì| ayné ətfaqé lóka pir-ì.|
twenty these events there took.place.PPRT-3PL
'All these events (that I am about to narrate) took place there in the years (19)14 to (19)20.'

20.1.5 Subjunctive

In NENA dialects in the northern sector the bare present stem *qaṭəl* functions as a subjunctive. This is used in a variety of irrealis contexts, including jussive main clauses, irrealis subordinate clauses and conditional clauses.

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In the C. Barwar dialect, for example, the *qaṭəl* subjunctive form is often used in narratives as a perfective sequential form. It typically continues an event or events that are expressed by a narrative past perfective forms, e.g.,

(12) C. Barwar (Khan 2008a: 913)
ʾáp ʾaw-lɛ́le xéna qìm-la,| sáʾət ṭḷáθa b-lɛ̀le,|
also that-night other rise.PST-OBL.3SG.F hour.of three at-night
šáry-a bănúda dìya,| ʾu-ʾáz-a ʾáxl-a xá-brona
untie.PRS-3SG.F bands.her of.her an-go.PRS-3SG.F eat.PRS-3SG.F one-son
xéna ʾu-dɛ̀r-a,| dàmx-a.| páθx-a tắra,|
other and-return.PRS-3SG.F sleep.PRS-3SG.F open.PRS-3SG.F door
dámx-a gu-dudìya.|
sleep.PRS-3SG.F in cradle
'Also the next night she got up, at three o'clock in the morning, untied her bands, went and ate another child, then returned and went to sleep. She opened the door and went to sleep in the cradle.'

The subjunctive narrative *qaṭəl* form has been extended from its use in subordinate clauses, in particular purpose clauses. In NENA dialects, purpose clauses may be linked to the preceding clause asyndetically without a subordinating particle, e.g.,

(13) C. Barwar (Khan 2008c: 732)
ʾána θíθ=ən mpalṭ-án-nux
I come.PPRT.SG.M=COP.1SG.M take.out.PRS.SBJV-1SG.F-OBL.2SG.M
m-gu-sə̀jən.|
from-in-prison
'I have come to bring you out of the prison.'

Purpose clause constructions are also used to express the final outcome or result of a preceding action, whereby the speaker presents the chain of events from the viewpoint of this outcome. Such result clauses appear to have developed from the common implicature of purpose clauses that the event took place, especially after verbs of movement, e.g., I went to buy some bread has the implicature that I did in fact buy bread (Schmidtke-Bode 2009: 178). This conventionalization of an implicature as the expression of a real event that is reflected in result clauses is likely to have been the pathway of development also of dependent narrative *qaṭəl* forms (Khan 2016b: vol. 2, 121-123; 2024b).

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20.1.6 Imperative

In a few cases the imperative is used in narrative as a substitute for a perfective narrative verbal form. These are addressed to the person performing the action and are typically used when there is a transition between spatial locations that involves a verb of movement. The clause containing the imperative may open with a third person subject pronoun as in (14):

(14) C. Barwar (Khan 2008c: 744)
qáyəm yawə́l-le ʾálpa dáwe xène.| *ʾáw*
rise.PRS.3SG give.PRS.3SG-OBL.3SG thousand gold.pieces other he
xá-reša m-táma qú-si l-bɛ̀θa.| *ʾáp*
one-head from-there rise.IMP.SG-go.IMP.SG to-house also
ʾan-tre-ʾálpe dáwe xéne mɛ̀θi-la.| *ʾu-háyyo*
those-two-thousands gold.pieces other bring.IMP-OBL.3PL and-go.IMP.SG
šláma-llux xón-i xùwwe!|
greetings-obl.2sg brother-my snake
'He gives him another thousand gold pieces. He got up directly from there and went home. He brought back also those two thousand pieces of gold and came back "Greetings my brother snake! Peace and blessings!"'

20.2 Narrative verbal forms in Iranian

The use of verbal forms in Kurdish narratives depends on the kind of narrative and on the narrator's own preferences. For the narration of sequential events, however, the most common verbal forms that are used are the past and the present. In some cases the perfect is used. The following discussion focuses on Northern and Central Kurdish dialects.

20.2.1 Past forms

The main form used in narration is the past tense (including past imperfective if the event implies duration). Past tense is the dominant and normal narrative tense in most of the text collections illustrating various NK and CK dialects such as MacKenzie (1962) for Akre, Amadia, Erbil, Sulaimania, Öpengin (2016) for the Mukri dialect of CK, MacKenzie & Öpengin (2026) for Shamdinan, and ALHOME data for Hakkari dialects.

The use of the past tense as narrative tense is most clearly visible in folktales, which are largely stabilized in terms of their contents and narrative styles. The following examples from folktales illustrate this:

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(15) Sulemaniyya CK (MacKenzie 1962: 4-5)
wezîr danîşt le cêga-y paşa paşa dest-ê cil-î
vizier sit.PST.3SG in place-EZ king king hand-EZ cloth-EZ
derwêşî=y leber kird rû=y kird=e şax û
dervishhood=3SG on do.PST face=3SG do.PST=DRCT mountain and
kêw.
mountain
'The vizier sat in the king's place and the king put on a suit of dervish clothes and set off for the mountains.'

(16) Akre NK (MacKenzie 1962: 242-243)
roj-ek-ê çû çiya-y ṭeyr-ek-ê zêṛ
day-INDF-OBL.F go.PST.3SG mountain-M.SG.OBL bird-INDF-EZ.M gold
girt îna=ve p xo bir=e bajer-î da
catch.PST bring.PST=COMPL for self take.PST=DRCT town-M.SG.OBL CONJ
firoş-ît-in
sell.PRS-3SG-AUG
'One day he went to the mountains and captured a gold bird, he brought it back and took it into the town to sell it.'

Past tense is also used when the narrator tells a story or anecdote that they have not witnessed but rather heard from someone else. The example (17) is from a story that the narrator heard from the person who experienced the events.

(17) CK Mukri (Öpengin 2016: 268-269)
kabra kut=î roj-êk-î lêre bar-e rejî=m bird bo
man say.PST=3SG day-INDF-OBL here load-EZ.CMPD coal=1SG take.PST to
serdeşt-ê (...) kut=î kuř-êk-î ciĥêł tûş=im
PN-F.SG.OBL say.PST=3SG boy-INDF-EZ young NVP.encounter=1SG
bû.
be.PST.3SG
'The fellow said: One day, I took the load of coal (from) here to Sardasht. (...) He said: A young man came up to me.'

Example (18) is from the narrative of a battle that took place in the region of the narrator around a century before his birth. He heard the narrative when he was very young from his grandfather, who himself had heard it from his own uncle who was alive during the time of the battle:

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(18) Hakkari NK (narrator, male 80 years old, fieldnotes)
hat gehişt=e nav şer-î wext-ê
come.PST.3SG arrive.PST.3SG=DRCT inside battle-M.SG.OBL time-EZ.M
gehişt=e nav şer-î hucûm-ek da wext-ê
arrive.PST=DRCT inside battle-M.SG.OBL attack-INDF give.PST time-EZ.M
êriş da pêkve ra-bû-n=e şer-î şer
attack give.PST together PVB-be.PST-3PL=DRCT battle-M.SG.OBL battle
çêbû kuştin çêbû (…) heta di-bê-n (…)
happen.PST.3SG killing happen.PST.3SG even IND-say.PRS-3PL
heştê cenaze keft-in.
eighty corps fall.PST-3PL
'(The chief of Marufan clan) came, arrived in the battle(ground). When he arrived in the battle(ground), he led an attack. When he attacked, they together started fighting. A battle took place, killing took place. It is even said that eighty corpses fell (on the ground).'

Similarly, even more obvious instances of hearsay, such as the narratives of family origins, are sometimes narrated in the past tense. In (19) the narrator tells about how his Jewish grandfather converted to Islam and migrated to their current village. He heard the story from his father:

(19) NK Hakkari (fieldnotes)
mesel-ek çêbû, bapîr-ê me ḥej
incident-INDF happen.PST.3SG grandfather-EZ.M our enjoyment
jink-ek-ê kir (…) jink-ê got-ê tu
woman-INDF-OBL.F do.PST woman-F.SG.OBL say.PST-3SG:IO 2SG
bi-b-e bisilman ez dê şü bi te ke-m
SBJV-be.PRS-IMP muslim 1SG FUT husband with 2SG.OBL do.PST-1SG
çû xwast, piştî busulman bû-y, şert-ê
go.PST.3SG want.PST after muslim be.PST-PTCP condition-EZ.M
busulmanî-yê hemî îna cih.
muslimhood-F.SG.OBL all bring.PST place
'An incident occurred, our grandfather loved a woman. The woman told him, convert to Islam then I will marry you. He asked for her hand in marriage, after he had converted to Islam, he met all the conditions of Islam.'

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20.2.2 Present forms

In Kurdish it is very common for a narrative of past events or stories to be expressed by a present indicative verb form. This can be used to lay the background to the narrative but also to narrate a series of events.

(20) Sulemaniyya CK (MacKenzie 1962: 4-5)
paşa-yek e-b-ê le memleket-êk-î wekû beẍa-zemîn-da em
king-INDF IND-be.PRS-3SG in country-INDF-EZ like PN-land-POSTP DEM
paşa=ye wecax=î kör e-b-ê muddet-êk-î zor
king=DEM.PROX hearth=3SG blind IND-be.PRS-3SG time-INDF-EZ much
nöj û itaʿet-î xwa-y xo=y e-ka le-paş
prayer and worship-EZ god-EZ REFL=3SG:PSR IND-do.PRS.3SG after
muddetewdwa bang-î wezîr-î desterast=î e-ka,
a_while_later call-EZ vizier-EZ right.hand=3SG:PSR IND-do.PRS.3SG
e-łê
IND-say.PRS.3SG
'There is a king in a country like the land of Baghdad. This king has no children. For a long time, he prays and worships his god. After some time he calls his right-hand vizier and says (…)'

20.2.3 Perfect forms

Perfect forms are used in various Northern Kurdish dialects for narrating what is often heard from others. In (21) the narrator speaks about his family history as he heard it from the elderly members of his family.

(21) NK Diyana (fieldnotes)
em=ê l beẍda bû-y, (…) li ḥîcaz-ê yêt
1PL.DIR=EZ.M in PN be.PST-PTCP from PN-OBL.F EZ.PL
hat-i (…) li beẍda em=êt hat-î=ye loṛistan-ê.
come.PST-PTCP from PN we=EZ.PL come.PST-PTCP=DRCT PN-OBL.F
(…) li loṛistan-ê yêt hat-i=ye colemêrg-ê (…) li
from PN-OBL.F EZ.PL come.PST-PTCP=DRCT PN-OBL.F in
colemêrg-ê camîʿ-ek=a hebû-y p naw-ê wan
PN-OBL.F mosque-INDF=EZ.F exist.PST-PTCP with name-EZ.M 3PL.OBL
(…) ḥukmet-a ʿusmanlî fikr=êt lê kir-i (…)
government-EZ.F Ottoman thought=EZ.PL at.it do.PST-PTCP
mesîḥî=yêt hebû-y li colemêrg-ê mesîḥî dibindawe yêt
Christian=EZ.PL exist.PST-PTCP in PN Christian secretly EZ.PL

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tîxtîx-da-y *sîlaḥ=êt* *dbinda* *da-y-ê*
encouragement-give.PST-PTCP ARM=EZ.PL secretly give.PST-PTCP-IO
berʿeleyha xanewad-a me *(…)*
against family-EZ.F 1SG.OBL
'We (i.e., the family/clan) were in Baghdad, had come there from Hijaz (...) From Baghdad we came to Lorestan (...), from Lorestan we came to Colemerg (Hakkari) (...) In Colemerg there was a mosque bearing their name (...). (Seeing their growing importance,) the Ottoman government devised some plans (lit. made some thoughts) against them (...). There happened to be Christians in Colemerg. They (the Ottoman government) incited the Christians secretly, they gave them weapons against our family.'

Similarly, the local anecdotes about saints and humorous tales are often narrated in the perfect in various NK dialects:

(22) NK Shamdinan (fieldnotes)
mirûw-ek-ê *laz wê* *çû-y=e* *rêk-ek-ê* *yê* *rast*
man-INDF-EZ.M laz EZ.M go.PST-PTCP=DRCT road-INDF-OBL.M EZ.M right
baxçe-yek-ê *hat-i* *(…)* *wê* *li* *wê* *derê* *derbas*
garden-INDF-OBL.M come.PST-PTCP EZ.M in 3SG.OBL.F place pass
bî-y *wê* *gehişt-î=ye* *bin-ek-e* *gûz-ê*
be.PST-PTCP EZ.M arrive.PST-PTCP=DRCT QNTF-INDF-EZ.F walnut-F.SG.OBL
(…) *di-bêj-in* *gûz-ek=a* *weṛisya-y=ewe* *li*
IND-say.PRS-3PL walnut-INDF=EZ.F release.PST-PTCP=COMPL in
çaw-ê *wi* *kewt-i* *(…)* *hû* *dest-ê* *xû* *yê* *bi*
eye-EZ.M 3SG.OBL.M drop.PST-PTCP thus hand-EZ.M self EZ.M with
çaw-ê *xû* *we* *na-y,* *(…)* *yê* *gût-i* *(…)*
eye-EZ.M self with put.PST-PTCP EZ.M say.PST-PTCP
'A Laz man walked on a path. He came across a garden. He passed by there, he arrived at a walnut tree. They say that a walnut was released and hit his eye. He covered his eye with his hand, and said (…)'

20.3 Narrative verbal forms in Gorani

In Gorani, perfect is the main tense for expressing habitual events in the far tense.

(23) Hewramî Tekht (Mohammadirad 2025c: 393)

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dey *çêge=îç* *qeyîm* *ʿałif=şa*
DISC.PTCL here=ADD old_time grass.DIR.M=3PL:A
kenne=n=û *ħeywan=şa* *wey*
mow.PST.PTCP.M=COP.3SG.M:O=and animal.DIR.M=3PL:A raising
kerde=n=û *hewar-ê=şa*
do.PST.PTCP.M=COP.3SG.M:O=and summer_habitat.M-PL.DIR=3PL:A
wişkinɛ=nê *î* *dega* *to=ş*
scour.PST.PTCP.PL=COP.3PL:O DEM.PROX village.F 2SG=3SG:O
vîn-î *çoł-e* ***bîyê=ne*** *ħîç*
see.PRS.IND-2SG:A deserted-F be.PST.PTCP.F=COP.3SG.F:S nothing
ne-bîye=n
NEG-be.PST.PTCP.M=COP.3SG.M:S
'In the past, they (people) **mowed** grass. They **raised** animals. They **scoured** the summer habitats [searching for food etc.]. This village, which you see, **was** deserted. There **was** nothing [here].'

One of the storytelling strategies is to use the the present tense as a narrative tense for narrating stories. The use of narrative present sometimes has the effect of setting the background.

(24) Hewramî Takht (Mohammadirad 2025c: 320)

a. *ħukm-û* *a* *wext-î* *mi-l-o*
ruler.M-EZ.GEN DEM.DIST time.M-SG.OBL IND-go.PRS-3SG:S
keş=ene
mountain.M=POST
'According to her,[1] the king of that time went to a mountain.'

b. *mi-l-o* *ser-û* *han(e)-êwe* *esłehe=ş*
IND-go.PRS-3SG:S on-EZ.GEN water_spring.M-INDF gun.M=3SG:NC
pene b-o
with be.PRS.IND-3SG:S
'He went to the edge of a spring. He had a gun with him.'

In narratives, the perfective (simple past) tense can be used alternatively with the present tense. In the following excerpt from the same story as (24), the narrator switches to the perfective to describe the foreground events.

(25) Hewramî Takht (Mohammadirad 2025c: 322)

[1]Lit. She said.

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ađ=îç *hukm=iş* ***da-Ø*** ***wat=iş***
3SG.M.DIR=ADD rule.M=3SG:A give.PST-3SG.M:O say.PST=3SG:A
jen(î)-ê *lemepeř-e* *me-b-o* *b-o*
woman.F-INDF pregnant-F NEG.IND-be.PRS-3SG:S be.PRS.SBJV-3SG:S
'He (the king) **issued an order** [and] **said**, "No pregnant women should stay alive!"'

20.4 Narrative verbal forms in Zazaki

Zazaki patterns closely with Northern Kurdish narrative techniques. The default verbal forms for narrating sequential, foregrounded events is the simple past (preterite) or the present. The present is often found in folktales, stories, jokes, etc. Background events that are habitual or progressive in aspect are usually expressed by the imperfect.

(26) Present narrative (Güntaş Aldatmaz 2016: 42)

a. *pasa-yê-de* *barzingan ve* *cînî-ya* *xo=ra*
pasha-EZ.M-INDEF merchant with wife-EZ.F REFL=POST
ben-ê
become.PRS-3PL
'There are a merchant pasha and his wife.'

b. *roz-ê,* *can-ê* *cînî-ya* *pasa-y* *gost-ê*
day-INDF soul-EZ.M wife-EZ.F pasha-M.SG.OBL meat-EZ.M
sayd-î *wazen-o*
hunt-M.SG.OBL want.PRS-3SG.M
'One day, the wife of the pasha desires game meat.' (lit. 'One day, the soul of the pasha's wife wants game meat.)'

A notable difference from Northern Kurdish concerns classical folk songs, especially laments of historical events, in which Zazaki frequently uses the perfect. This may be due to the distant character of the event, or it may be prosodically motivated: the perfect morphology adds one additional stressed syllable, which can support metre and rhyme. Outside this genre, the perfect can also have evidential/reportative functions (see §16.2.4). To express events prior to another past event, speakers use the past perfect (pluperfect) in oral narration by attaching the past tense copula to the past stem of the verb. Example (27) is an oral historical account of the 1938 Dêrsim genocide, in which an eyewitness narrates mostly in the simple past, resorting to the past perfect to locate earlier events

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relative to the main line, and to the perfect in instances of indirect or hearsay reporting.

(27) Eyewitness interview (Sakine S.)

a. *şî çê daye, a uca=ra xo =rê xevere*
go.PST.3SG home 3SG.F.OBL 3SG.F there=from REFL to news
day-bî jümînî, pêrune pîya guret-Ø xo =rê
give.PST-COP.PST each.other all.OBL together take.PST-3SG.M REFL =to
rema-y şî ve= ko
flee.PST-PL go.PST.PL to= mountain
'He goes to her house, from there they had (already) informed each other, they all took off together, [and] escaped into the mountains.'

b. *wa-a mi va ke: "ma şî-me uca, na hêga-y*
sister-EZ.F 1SG say.PST REL 1PL go.PST-1PL there DEM field-PL
vêsn-ê, sare-y xo =rê ard-ê kerd-ê
burn.PST-3PL wheat.ear-PL REFL =to bring.PST-3PL do.PST-3PL
ti-ra […]
PRON-from
'My sister told me: We went there, they have burned the fields, they have gathered the wheat ears, have taken them, [and] have separated them.'

20.5 Narrative forms in Arabic

Jastrow's (1978) survey of the *Qəltu* dialects makes no mention of verbal forms other than the Suffix Conjugation ('Perfect') being used in narrative. Among the published sources, the only mention found was in Wittrich (2001: 152) for C. Āzəx. Wittrich finds both the bare Prefix Conjugation (the general present) and the prefix conjugation with the particle *kū-* (the present progressive) being used to narrate the narrative mainline in stories. Examples of these two verbal forms can also be found in narrative mainlines in collections of texts from other dialects in and around the NENA region. Some examples are given below.[2]

(28) M. Mosul (Jastrow 1979: 56–57, 58-59)

[2]The English translations of the following excerpts from the works of Otto Jastrow were made made by Eleanor Coghill on the basis of the original German.

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a. *yəji hal-ʿənda hal-mā ʿənda yāxáḏ-u,*
come.PC.3SG.M this-she.has this-not she.has take.PC.3SG.M-OBJ.3SG.M
w yġōḥ. ətġīd də-təṣláḥ-u
and go.PC.3SG.M want.PC.3SG.F SBRD-fix.PC.3SG.F-OBJ.3SG.M
l-hāḍa l-walad mā ṭṭīq.
DEF-this.SG.M DEF-boy not can.PC.3SG.F
'He came, took away what she had, and went on. She wanted to fix this lad, but couldn't.'

b. *də-yəhrəb mən əl-qatəl, ybūs īd-a.*
SBRD-escape.PC.3SG.M from DEF-beating kiss.PC.3SG.M hand-3SG.F
'In order to escape being beaten up, he kissed her hand.'

(29) J. Səndōṛ (Jastrow 1990a: 776-777, 778–779)

a. *əṣ-ṣəbḥ k-īqūm, aš yqūm*
DEF-morning PROG-get.up.PC.3SG.M what get.up.PC.3SG.M
yəṛa l-kalb? mayyət!
see.PC.3SG.M DEF-dog dead.M.SG
'In the morning he got up, what did he go and see (instead of) the dog? A dead person!'

b. *k-īji l-bayt má-tənzəl mən*
PROG-come.PC.3SG.M DEF-house not-get.down.PC.3SG.F from
ḏahr-u.
back-3SG.M
'He came home and she did not get down from his back.'

(30) J. ʿAqra (Jastrow 1990a: 134-135)

a. *jā k-īḍḥak. k-īqūl aš*
come.SC.3SG.M PROG-laugh.PC.3SG.M PROG-say.PC.3SG.M what
kū-ʿəməltəm? sāḥ-na ana w əxt-i.
PRS.PRF-do.SC.2PL call.SC.3SG.M-OBJ.1PL 1SG and sister-1SG
'He came and laughed. He said, "What have you done?" He called us, me and my sister.'

b. *az maṛḥūm abū-yi k-īqūl məšītu, qāl*
so late father-1SG PROG-say.PC.3SG.M go.SC.1SG say.SC.3SG.M
qal-l-i, tāl t-aqəl-l-ək.
say.SC.3SG.M-to-1SG come.IMP.SG.M FUT-say.PC.1SG-to-2SG.M
'So, my late father said, "I went (to him)", he said to me, "Come, I'll tell you."'

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Whole texts in the M. Tillo dialect published by Lahdo (2009) (texts 1–4) are narrated with the bare Prefix Conjugation. It may be of significance that these texts are all fictional stories. The two true stories, 5 and 6, are narrated with the Suffix Conjugation and a mixture of Suffix and Prefix Conjugations respectively. Below is a short excerpt from Text 4 showing the use of the Prefix Conjugation:[3]

(31) M. Tillo (Lahdo 2009: 32–33)
uwwe am əyʾəl-l-u: xa-ysīr. əyqūm
he also say.PC.3SG.M-to-3SG.M OPT-happen.PC.3SG.M get.up.PC.3SG.M
yrō. ṭabi šəġl-u yətʿawwaq ąwnaḳ. mō
go.PC.3SG.M of.course work-3SG.M be.delayed.PC.3SG.M there NEG
ytēq tə-yəjī, sane, sant-ayn, fēfe, xamse, ʿašra.
can.PC.3SG.M SBRD-come.PC.3SG.M year year-DU three five ten
'And the friend answers: Let it be so. So he leaves [lit. gets up goes]. But of course, his commitments are delayed there. He could not return for one year, two years, three years, five years, ten years.'

20.6 Narrative forms in Armenian

As discussed in §16.4, according to Dum-Tragut (2009: 231), the aorist is the main form used in narration in SEA. The aorist is also used for the main body of the narrative in some dialect folktales, for example, the Sharp-Witted Boy (Sramit tɣan) (Atayan 1906: 201) from Salmast, as seen in (32):[4]

(32) Salmast Armenian (Atayan 1906: 201)
marth-əʾ sarakʲ pŕn-etsʰ, kʲnætsʰ-in art-əʾ kʰaɣ-en
man-DEF labourer take-AOR.3SG go-AOR.3PL field-DEF reap-PRS.SBJV.3PL
'The man took a labourer and went to reap the field.'

However, in many dialect folktales, including all the other tales in Atayan (1906), the main body of the narrative is in the present tense, not the aorist. In general, this involves forms with the particle *kə-* in Western dialects, such as Van, as seen in (33), and forms composed of a locative-based imperfective

[3]Note, however, that the very first verb of this narrative is in the form of the future tense, the Prefix Conjugation prefixed with *t(ə)-*: *yawm wēḥəd ẓaḷaṃe t-əyqūm yrō mən awne* ... [day one.M man FUT-get.up.PC.3SG.M go.PC.3SG.M from here] 'One day a man wanted to leave [lit. 'will get up, go'] here ...'

[4]The sound rendered by *əʾ* is a central vowel of uncertain quality, "between *ə*, *a*, and *e*" (Atayan 1906: 3).

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participle and the copula/auxiliary in Eastern dialects, as seen in (34). Note that this includes the use of inflected forms of the verb *linel* 'to be' (glossed by Dum-Tragut (2009) and Kozintseva (1988) as 'to be repeatedly', as distinct from the copula *em*) in the first sentence of the narrative, as seen in (33) and (34). In dialects which make use of both types of present tense (both the *kə*-forms and the forms with the imperfective participle), such as that of Salmast presented in Atayan (1906), it is the *kə*-forms that are used for the main body of the narrative, while the imperfective participle-based forms are generally associated with progressive meaning (see §19.4). Dum-Tragut (2009: 254) notes that the *kə*- forms may be used for narrative, and also habitual, function in SEA too, but that these uses are considered antiquated by some speakers. This is consistent with the proposal of Avetyan (2021) that the locative-based present of Eastern Armenian originated as a progressive, and gradually spread to other present contexts, including narrative and habitual.

(33) Van Armenian (Acharyan 1952: 222)
k-eln-i *ɣ^{h}-eln-e* *mej* *mart^{h}* *knik*
PTCL-be-PRS.3SG NEG-be-N.PTCP one man woman
'Once upon a time there was a man and wife.' (lit. '[There] is, [there] is not one man woman.')

(34) Urmia Armenian (Aygezard, Ararat province) (Asatryan 1962: 180)
əl-eli *ɣ^{h}i* *əl-eli* *mi* *mart^{h}* *me* *kənəik^{j}=i* *əl-eli*
be-I.PTCP NEG.be.3SG be-I.PTCP one man one woman=be.3SG be-I.PTCP
'Once upon a time there was a man and wife.' (lit. '[There] is, [there] is not, [there] is one man one woman.')

While speakers of Urmia dialect whose ancestors migrated to Armenia in 1828-9 appear to have generalised the locative-based present to all present contexts, including narrative, as seen in (34), in the texts from Salmast in Atayan (1906), we find that the locative-based present is relatively rare, being associated with progressive contexts, such as 'What is this you're doing?' in (35). The main body of the narrative is expressed by the *kə*-forms, as seen in the verbs *k-k^{hj}æʃ-i* 'drags', *k-as-i* 'says' in the same example, as well as in the formula used to introduce the story, given in (36) (compare similar formulae with the *kə*-present in Van 33 and the locative-based present used by speakers of Urmia dialect from Armenia 34).

(35) Salmast Armenian (Atayan 1906: 204)

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ets-u *ængʲʧ-en* *k-kʰʲæʃ-i* *tʰex* *tus.* *ʧʰuərægʲʧʰi-n*
goat-GEN ear-ABL PTCL-pull-3SG towards out baker-DEF
k-as-i, *et* *inʧʰ=es* *an-elәi,* *ax* *ets-ә'* *im-n*
PTCL-say-3SG DEM2 what=be.2SG do-I.PTCP PTCL goat-DEF 1SG.GEN-DEF
i
be.3SG
'He drags the goat out [lit. towards out] by its ear. The baker says, What is this you're doing, the goat is mine.'

(36) Salmast Armenian (Atayan 1906: 204)
k-l-i *ʧ-l-i,* *me* *marʏʰ* *k-l-i,* *me* *knikʲ*
PTCL-be-3SG NEG-be-N.PTCP one man PTCL-be-3SG, one woman
k-l-i
PTCL-be-3SG
'Once upon a time there was a man and wife.' (lit. '[There] is, [there] isn't, [there] is a man, [there] is a woman.')

Avetyan (2021: 140) notes that in popular spoken Eastern Armenian and in a range of Eastern Armenian dialects, where the locative-based present is used for progressive and in some cases has spread to other present contexts, historical/narrative present is one of the present tense contexts where the *kə*-forms may still be used.

While in folktales, the main body of the narrative is usually expressed in either the present or the aorist, the perfect may be used for narration when the speaker is recounting events that they have not personally witnessed, as in (37). This should probably be interpreted in terms of the evidential function of the perfect tense (see §16.4.2.2).

(37) Agulis Armenian (Tsghna) (Hodgson 2022a)
næn-i-s *mama-n* *... nemka=ja*
grandmother-GEN-ART1 mother-DEF ... German.woman=be.3SG
el-ats *... popi-s* *teh-ats=a*
be-RES.PTCP ... grandfather-AGR1 see-RES.PTCP=be.3SG
siʁaharv-ats, *keɣæh-æts=a* *taʁ-ats* *Tʰiflis*
fall.in.love-RES.PTCP steal-RES.PTCP=be.3SG take-RES.PTCP Tbilisi
'My grandmother's mother ... was a German woman ... my [great] grandfather saw [her], fell in love, kidnapped [her] [and] took [her] to Tbilisi.'

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In texts from Salmast (38) and Van (39, 40), we find examples of the present subjunctive used in narrative, to express a realis event that is sequential to a preceding action, which is expressed by the *k*-present (morphologically, the present subjunctive is identical to the *k*-forms without the particle *k*-).

(38) Salmast Armenian (Atayan 1906: 198)
me mart^{h} k^{h}utʃ^{h}a-jen k-ənsn-i, iʃk-a, et
one person street-ABL PTCL-pass-PRS.3SG see-PRS.SBJV.3SG DEM2
jeɾ-en me dhol-i tsen=i ik^{j}-æli
place-ABL one dhol-GEN voice=be.PRS.3SG come-I.PTCP
'A person passes by in the street, [and] sees [that] the sound of a dhol (type of drum) is coming from that place.'

(39) Van Armenian (Ghaziyan 2009: 12)
kə t^{h}oyn-en, p^{h}axn-en
PTCL leave-PRS.3PL flee-SBJV.PRS.3PL
'They leave [and] run away.'

(40) Van Armenian (Ghaziyan 2009: 14)
k-ejln-i avel k-arn-i dzer, paʃla-ji
PTCL-get.up-PRS.1PL broom PTCL-take-PRS.3SG hand, start-SBJV.PRS.3SG
avel an-el
broom do-INF
'She gets up, takes the broom in her hand, [and] starts to sweep.'

It is possible that the usage of the subjunctive in narrative began with asyndetic purpose clauses with the verb in the subjunctive. (40 could also perhaps be interpreted as 'She gets up [and] takes the broom in her hand in order to start to sweep'). Another example of an asyndetic subjunctive purpose clause can be seen in 41.

(41) Van Armenian (Gevorgyan 1999: 15)
æmr aɾa, jes eɾt^{h}-am tyn-^{j}en kan
order do.IMP 1SG.NOM go-SBJV.PRS.1SG house-ABL search.PVB
g^{j}-æm
come-SBJV.PRS.1SG
'Give an order so that I [can] leave [lit. go from] the house and search.'

In Van, we also find some examples where the subjunctive is used from the beginning of a sentence, rather than following a form with *k*- or an imperative, as seen in 42.

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(42) Van Armenian (Gevorgyan 1999: 18)
Dʒəbo-n eln-i in-i itev, ɛrt^{h}-æ
Jbo-DEF get.up-SBJV.PRS.3SG fall-SBJV.PRS.3SG after, go-SBJV.PRS.3SG
ʧ^{hj}um parv-u tun.
until old.woman-GEN house.
'Jbo goes after [her], [he] goes as far as the old woman's house.'

20.7 Narrative forms in Turkic

Azeri lacks a dedicated narrative tense. Instead, the choice of TAM categories in narration varies according to dialect, narrative genre and discourse context.

Folktales are most commonly narrated in either the past—using the preterite for perfective actions and the imperfect for ongoing or habitual events—or the present. An example of the past is the following:

(43) Urmia Azeri (Doğan 2010: 380)
bu get-di qapı-nı çal-dı.
this go-PST.3 door-ACC whisk-PST.3
'(The Big Bad Wolf) went and knocked on the door.'

These TAM categories can even coexist within a single folktale: the past often grounds the story in its initial setting, while the present (i.e., the form that is otherwise used as a progressive) takes over as the plot unfolds. The only form that betrays the narrative nature of the present is the verb 'be', which does not take the form of the copula, as it would in the case of a real-time state, but of the conjugated finite form of the verb *ol-* 'be', which in non-narrative contexts describes a habitual state:

(44) Ardabil Azeri (Karini 2009: 434)
bir.günnəri bı-nın iki dənə oğlu ol-ur.
one.day this-GEN two QNTF son.POSS.3 be-IPFV.PRS.3
'One day, two sons are born to him.'

Narrative TAM categories can receive evidential marking, seemingly for backgrounding purposes (Larsson Taghizadeh 2023: 54):

(45) Ardabil Azeri (Karini 2009: 439)

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bi dənə cəngəlistan yer-də bi dənə köhül var=ımış,
one QNTF woodland place-LOC one QNTF cave EXIST.COP=EVID.COP.3
apar-ır bu qardaş-ı-n ötür-ür ora.
carry-IPFV.PRS.3 this brother-POSS.3-ACC escort-IPFV.PRS.3 there.DAT
'There is/was a cave in the woods; he takes his brother there.'

Folk beliefs (particularly those describing recurring or supernatural phenomena) are often narrated in the eventual and, in rare cases, this also occurs in folktales:

(46) Tabriz Azeri (Məmmədli 2008: 197)
(A stork had four chicks.)
tülki de-yər hacləhləh qox-ar, ağlıya.ağlıya bala-lar-ı-nnan
fox say-EVT.3 stork fear-EVT.3 cry.CVB baby-PL-POSS.3-ABL
pis-i-n sal-ar.
bad-POSS.3-ACC drop-EVT.3
'(One day) a fox says: ("Push one of your chicks out of the nest, or I shall cut down this tree.") The stork, frightened, cries out and pushes the weakest of its chicks out of the nest.'

Normally reserved for habitual, gnomic or hypothetical future contexts, the use of the eventual in narratives is thinly distributed across a vast geographical area (e.g. Derbent, Tabriz, Meghri, Masallı; see Suleymanov 2023). This patchy distribution suggests that its use in storytelling may not be a recent innovation but rather a relic of an earlier stage, when the eventual still functioned as the least marked present-tense form, rather than a product of regional or contact-induced change.

In certain Eastern Anatolian varieties, the eventual anchors the exposition of a narrative and serves as a diagnostic marker of timeless or backgrounded information. As the story transitions to the dynamic sequence of events, however, a progressive form emerges to carry the action forward (Dybo & Levitskaja 2002: 160).

Personal narratives, by contrast, default to the past (preterite and imperfect, as described above), though speakers may shift to the present tense to highlight the trigger event—the moment that disrupts the status quo. Events presented as real but unwitnessed by the speaker, including in personal narratives, are typically relayed in the perfect. Particularly focal points of such narratives can even feature verbs in the imperative, whose subject is not necessarily in the second person:

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(47) Standard Azeri (Orxan Saffari, "Telefon oğrusu şair", *Ədalət*, no. 38 (5870), 10 April 2021, p. 15.)
(I'd passed out drunk, and my fifth-grade grandson took Barat's phone, which I had with me, and showed it to my wife. She thought I'd bought it for another woman and got angry; first she wanted to smash it, then she told my grandson to go and sell it.])
O=da götür apar telefon mağaza-sı-na, format
that=ADD take.IMP.2SG carry.IMP.2SG telephone shop-POSS.3-DAT format
elə, sat get-sin. Amma qaytar-dı-m. Axşam
do.IMP.2SG sell.IMP.2SG go-JUS.3 but return-PST-1SG evening
Barat=la görüş-dü-k, ver-di-m öz-ü-nə.
PN=COM/INS meet-PST-1PL give-PST-1SG REFL-POSS.3-DAT
'So he took it, brought it to a phone shop, had it formatted, and sold it on the spot. But I got it back. In the evening, I met Barat and gave it back to him.'

20.8 Discussion

The various verbal forms that are used in NENA dialects to narrate sequences of events all have parallels in narrative strategies of the languages of the region. The distribution of these various types of verbal form differs across the NENA dialects and, moreover, their distribution in contact languages in a particular geographical area sometimes differs from what is found in the NENA dialects of the area.

The use of the past perfective for narrating stories, which is found across all NENA dialects (§20.1.1), is found in all languages of the region. The same applies to the use of the present form. In §20.1.2 it was argued that the NENA present-stem forms with preverbal particles *k-qaṭəl*/*ʾi-qaṭəl* that are used in NENA narratives are not historical presents but rather habitual forms expressing underspecified events that have been coerced by the narrative context to express a specific event in the past. The same analysis can be applied to the use of corresponding present forms in Iranian and Armenian and the Prefix Conjugation in *Qəltu* Arabic narratives. One of the arguments for the interpretation of the NENA *k-qaṭəl*/*ʾi-qaṭəl* narrative form as a habitual is that in many NENA dialects the form is not a general present form but is restricted to habitual and narrative, the progressive being expressed by another, innovative, form. The same argument can be applied to several Eastern Armenian dialects, in which the present stem with a *kə-* prefix is, likewise, restricted to habitual and narratives (see p.755). In

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Turkic, moreover, it was shown that a present form of a copula in a narrative is in its habitual form rather than in its normal present form (44) and that folktales are sometimes narrated using the Turkic evenutal form, which is used in other contexts as a habitual (20.7).

In NENA dialects that use the habitual form in narratives, stories typically establish the past time reference by opening with past forms and then shift to habitual forms. In documented Iranian, Armenian and Turkic narratives, however, a story may begin from the outset with present-stem habitual forms. This reflects a somewhat different distribution of the form within the narrative. Such forms could still be interpreted as habitual forms with underspecified events. They are not specified as single perfective events, however, by explicit preceding past perfective verbs, but rather by the general frame of the story, which prototypically would be presupposed to consist of sequential events in the past.

In the discussion of the use of NENA progressive forms in narratives (§20.1.3), it was argued that these, in fact, are extensions of the use of such forms to express salient habitual events. In some NENA dialects, such as C. Qaraqosh and J. Arbel, they are used to express salient events in a narrative. The same interpretation could be applied to the use of apparent progressive forms with the *kū-* prefix in *Qəltu* Arabic dialects (§20.5). In the C. Urmi dialect on the north-eastern periphery, on the other hand, progressive forms derived from a locative infinitive are the normal forms used in narratives. A possible external factor for this generalised used of the form may be the fact that in most Eastern Armenian dialects the present based on a locative infinitive/participle has become a general present form (expressing habitual and progressive), and, crucially, is frequently used as the main narrative verbal form in folktale narratives, as in C. Urmi (§20.6). It is also relevant to note that in Azeri Turkic in the Urmi region the present progressive form is commonly used to narrate events in stories (44, 47).

The use of the perfect in NENA narratives has parallels in Northern Kurdish (§20.2.3). This would be a geographical match, since the narrative perfect is most extensively attested in NENA dialects in the northern sector, especially in the dialects of the Ṭyare region and adjacent areas. In addition to use in reports, where it has an evidential function, the perfect is used in Northern Kurdish in local anecdotes about saints and humorous tales (e.g., 22). It is not, however, the predominant verbal form used in traditional folktales, as it is in the NENA dialects of the Ṭyare region. The wider distribution in NENA, therefore, appears to be an internal development within NENA. In Armenian, the perfect is only used in narrative as an evidential strategy in reports, and so its distribution is even more restricted. In Azeri Turkic, evidiential verbal forms, which are historically related to the perfect, are occasionally used in narratives, especially to set

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the background of a following sequence of events (45). There is a direct parallel to this use of the perfect in narratives in J. Urmi, which was in intense contact with Azeri (11).

The use of the subjunctive in narratives (§20.1.5) in NENA dialects of the northern sector has a parallel in Armenian narratives. There are documented cases of narrative subjunctive forms in the Armenian dialects of Salmast and Van (38, 39, 40). This would coincide geographically with attested narrative subjunctives in NENA dialects of the northern sector.

Finally, the use of imperative forms in narrative, which are occasionally attested in NENA dialects (14), has also been documented in Azeri (47).

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21 The syntax of case and verbal agreement

21.1 Introduction

In discussing the syntax of case and agreement, we draw on concepts and distinctions that are widely used in the literature on the syntactic typology of case and agreement. First, we make a core distinction between case and agreement as the case-marking morphology on the NP and the cross-referencing morphology on the verb, respectively (e.g., Andrews 2007). Further details on NP-marking can be found in Chapter 9 on case morphology and adpositional marking, and further details on cross-referencing morphology in Chapter 13 on verbal person marking and participial agreement. Nichols (1992) distinguishes between dependent-marking and head-marking, and more recent typological literature, such as Malchukov (2009), distinguishes between flagging and indexing. Here, we loosely adopt the following terminology to differentiate between coding strategies:

- "Case-marking" or "flagging": morphemes that directly modify the NP, including case declension and adpositions, which includes full NPs as well as free person markers/pronouns;
- "Agreement" or "indexing": cross-referencing person, gender and/or number marking morphemes that modify the verb, including affixes and clitics. This includes verb endings and bound person markers/pronouns; the latter can also be verbal person marking clitics that attach to an NP in the clause.

These coding strategies may be independent of each other or interdependent. This can depend on the grammatical system in a given variety of the relevant language or on particular constructions within that system.

Following (Comrie 1978, Comrie 1989) and Andrews (2007), we distinguish grammatical functions that express the syntactic-semantic "primitive" roles S, A, and P, which are defined on the basis of the semantic, syntactic, and morphological properties of primary transitive verbs. Following Kittilä (2006), we distinguish

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between three main determining factors that regulate coding strategies. In strategies determined by a grammatical relation, the syntax is based on an opposition between grammatical relations, for example, subjects vs. direct objects. In role-based strategies, the coding is determined on the basis of a syntactic-semantic role that is assigned to the argument, such as agent, patient, theme, recipient, etc. The third strategy is salience-based, in which case the coding is determined on the basis of the properties of the referent, such as animacy, topicality, etc.

Role-based or salience-based strategies are not always relevant for the languages in question. On certain higher levels of abstraction, it is helpful to speak in terms of grammatical relations such as "subject'' and "direct object'', cf. Andrews (2007), who distinguishes syntactic roles as grammatical functions (S, A, P etc.) from grammatical relations ("subject", "direct object", etc.). Certain morphological and syntactic behavioral properties seem to apply only to S and A, in which case it makes sense to speak of a grammatical relation "subject" that subsumes both. When it comes to Iranian and Aramaic, however, more fine-grained grammatical functions are necessary, and the syntax may reflect transitivity-dependence or transitivity-sensitivity. The syntax of the core arguments of transitive clauses may then show peculiarities that do not apply to the single argument of intransitive clauses. This certainly holds true for languages such as Armenian, Turkic, and Arabic, considered here.

Similarly, "objecthood" may be sufficient to capture the similar treatment of the patient argument of a monotransitive verb and the theme and recipient arguments of a ditransitive verb in opposition to "subject". In most languages of the area, however, the salience of the referent needs to be considered.

Furthemore, the phenomenon called "co-argument sensitivity" (Witzlack-Makarevich et al. 2016) may at times also be relevant. Co-argument sensitivity is a term used to capture interdependent coding strategies of the arguments in clauses with multiple arguments. This applies when the coding strategy of an argument is (partly) conditioned by the properties of another argument present in the clause.

Finally, the distinct treatment of transitive clauses may be further complicated by the TAM-sensitive morphological splits found in Iranian and Aramaic. Iranian and Aramaic have undergone a range of developments, most notably in clauses with past stem verbal forms. Some rules for case and agreement, then, do not apply to the system as a whole, but are confined to a subsystem of clauses that constitute particular TAM constructions, such as present vs. past tense clauses, imperfective vs. perfective aspect, and realis vs. irrealis mood.

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21.2 Flagging and indexing in NENA

21.2.1 Introduction

Generally, NENA can be subsumed under what is commonly known as a "pro-drop" language. The verbal agreement system could thus be characterised as one of cross-indexing in Haspelmath's (Haspelmath (2013)) terminology. There are different conditions for the obligatory, optional, and impossible coding of subjects (S and A) and objects, which correlate with both the properties of the argument and the properties of the clause. Throughout its history, the flagging and/or indexing of direct objects in Aramaic has been conditioned by the salience of the object NP, and this also holds true for NENA. Even where direct object markers are innovated, their syntax reflects differential object coding. The details with respect to the coding strategies and specific conditions under which a direct object NP is indexed, flagged, or both are ultimately indicative of dialect-specific microvariation. Figure 21.1 shows the distribution and possible combinations of the various differential coding strategies as well as the prepositions used for flagging. In NENA, DOF always exists alongside DOI, with the exception of personal pronouns in the past perfective in the northern sector in particular. Table 21.2.1 summarises the options that occur in NENA dialects.

By contrast, the case-marking and indexing of subjects (S and A) and obliques is largely unconditioned and obligatory across all NENA dialects. Where there is optionality or impossibility, this mainly depends on the construction type rather than simply the properties of the argument. There is in this respect a distinction between transitive agents (A) and intransitive subjects (S). The syntax of intransitive subjects (S) remains largely independent of clausal properties. Intransitive subjects are incompatible with flagging, but obligatorily indexed throughout the verbal system in all NENA dialects, with the possible exception of the copula in copula-based verbal constructions. Contrary to the syntax of other syntactic roles, the syntax of A shows peculiarities in certain verbal constructions, notably those constructions that ultimately go back to a resultative participle (*qṭil-*. Under specific conditions, the indexing of A may be omitted, and the A may be optionally flagged. In general, transitive past perfective clauses with indexing of both the agent and the object may have dedicated constructions. There is also a more general distinction between flagging and indexing. Flagging is typically role-based for grammatical relations other than direct objects, such as obliques. Indexing, in turn, more closely correlates with topicality, and is less common for obliques.

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Table 21.1: Differential object flagging (DOF) and diffential object indexing (DOI) possibilities in Neo-Aramaic

DOF	DOI	Combinability	Dialect distribution
Yes	Yes	Optional	Jewish dialects of Iranian Azerbaijan and eastern Iraqi Kurdistan and several Christian dialects in the northern sector (Hakkari, Van, Iranian Azerbaijan)
Yes	Yes	Impossible	Jewish dialects of western Iran
Yes	Yes	Obligatory	Christian dialects of the Mosul Plain that have DOF
No	Yes	N/A	The majority of NENA dialects
Yes	No	N/A	Not in NENA, but in Mlahso Neo-Aramaic and Western Neo-Aramaic
No	No (Sporadic)	N/A	NENA dialect of Qaraqosh, and Turoyo Neo-Aramaic

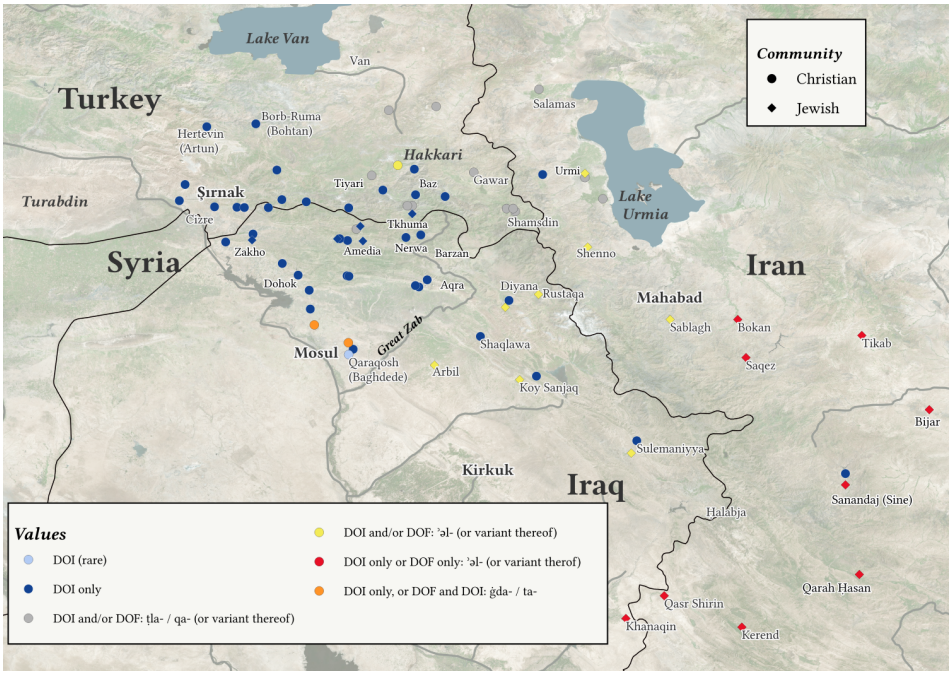

Figure 21.1: Distribution of differential object indexing and/or differential object flagging across NENA dialects)

21.2.2 Argument indexing in NENA

As a cross-linguistic tendency (see Haig & Schnell 2016), the indexing of subjects (S and A) is almost always unconditional and obligatory in NENA, while the indexing of direct object NPs is always conditioned by the properties of the argument and may be optional. This thus reflects a general opposition between subjects and direct objects; for direct objects, in contrast to subjects, the indexing remains salience-based throughout. Across NENA dialects, there are several constructions that are impossible with additional indexing of the direct object NP. This applies to certain verbal forms that cannot be inflected for objects, notably

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the past perfective *qṭil*-stem verbs. Conversely, other verbal forms are incompatible with S arguments.

21.2.2.1 Differential object indexing across verbal clauses

In all NENA dialects, differential object indexing DOI) is conditioned by the salience of the argument, involving a close relationship between DOI and the status of the respective NP in the discourse. What triggers DOI in a certain clause is the result of a highly complex interaction of semantic factors (e.g., referentiality, identifiability, specificity), information structural factors (e.g., given vs. new information, topic vs. focus), and discourse-pragmatic factors (e.g., topic (dis)continuity, discourse organisation), alongside prosody (e.g., accentuation) and syntax (e.g., word order). In the literature, the salience of the direct object in differential object marking is generally determined by local parameters pertaining to the inherent properties of the argument, such as animacy and referentiality, or by global parameters that involve its (topical) status in the discourse (e.g., Mardale 2008: 450). In NENA, the salience of the direct object NP is primarily determined on a contextual basis, and not on the basis of inherent properties of the NP, such as animacy or definiteness. Where inherent properties do seem to play a role, this concerns definiteness/specificity, and not animacy; both of these inherent properties do seem to play a role in DOF. DOI should therefore be mainly understood in terms of the global cognitive status of the referring NP. At face value, the factors that determine DOI seem to confirm the well-established relationship between topic continuity and objects as secondary topics (Givón 1984a), and the incompatibility of focus and person marking ((Siewierska 2004)). As expected, DOI typically reflects the topic continuity of a referent that is given in the discourse, linking the content with the preceding discourse unit. Thus, direct object NPs that add new content to the discourse typically do not trigger DOI, but once new content is introduced, this is continued with DOI in the subsequent discourse, as (1) – (5) illustrate.

(1) J. Betanure ((Mutzafi 2008a: XVI.7: 394))
zwən-na *xa* *nuniθa.* *ʾe* *nuniθa*
buy.PST-OBL.3SG.F:A one fish.F.SG the fish.F.SG
muty-a-la *ṣlix-a-la*
bring.PST-3SG.F:P-OBL.3SG.F:A slit.PST-3SG.F:P-OBL.3SG.F:A
'She bought a fish. She brought the fish [and] slit it.'

(2) C. Aradhin ((Krotkoff 1982: 94.82))

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kəsl-in *i-yap-i* *laxma* *b-bɛθa.* *u* *kul* *bɛθa*
side-1PL IND-bake.-3PL:A bread.M.SG in-house.M.SG and every house.M.SG
yāpe-Ø-le *laxm-e* *diye*
IND.bake-3SG.M:A-OBL.3SG.M:P bread.M.SG-POSS.3SG.M GEN.3SG.M
b-gyan-e.
in-self-3SG.M
'In our community, people bake bread at home. And every household bakes their own bread by themselves.'

(3) C. Dohok (Noorlander 2021a: §115)
k-im, *"maθi* *səkθa."* *gəm-šaqəl-Ø-la*
IND-say.3SG.M:A bring.IMP.M.SG stake.F.SG PST-take-3SG.M:A-OBL.3SG.F:P
səkθa.
stake.F.SG
'He said, "Bring a stake." They took the stake.'

(4) C. Urmi (Khan 2016b: A3:78-79)
"xa-dana *⁺x̌aṭu* *duk̲un."* *⁺x̌aṭu*
one-time cat.F.SG take.IMP.PL:A cat.F.SG
bədvak̲-o=na.
take.PROG-POSS.3SG.F:P=COP.3PL:A
"'Take a cat!" They take the cat.'

(5) C. Qaraqosh (Khan 2002a: 599.151)
basim-a *k-awi-Ø-wa* *pəsra* *kwiš-a.* *pəsra*
delicious-M.SG IND-be-3SG.M-PST meat.M.SG preserved-M.SG meat.M.SG
dare-wa-lə *b-anə* *maya.*
put.3PL:A-PST-OBL.3SG.M:P in-DEM.PL water.PL
'Preserved meat was delicious. They would put the meat in this (salty) water.'

Prima facie, the instances of DOI in the examples above would seem to be triggered simply by definiteness. However, "topicality" would be a better characterisation than definiteness, given that DOI is characteristic of topic maintenance and expresses a link between sentences on the level of the discourse. This is confirmed by the fact that definite direct object NPs that are part of the focus domain seem to be incompatible with DOI (Khan 2008c: 777; Coghill 2014: 350-351; Coghill 2018: 304). For instance, this holds true for direct object NPs that occur in narrow focus configurations, which can express various types of narrow focus such as (6) mirative, (7) exhaustive and (8) contrastive focus.

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(6) C. Nerwa (Noorlander field notes)
măni=t mara măni=ley ʿzim-e
who=COP.2SG.M:A say.PROG who=COP.3PL:A invite.RES.PTCP-PL:A
*(-*əll-e)? Maryam=iley ʿzim-e (-*əll-a)?*
(-OBJ-3SG.M) Maryam=COP.3PL:A invite.RES.PTCP-PL:A (-OBJ-3SG.F)
'Who do you say they have invited? Have they invited *Maryam*?' Narrow focus (mirative)

(7) J. Zakho (Sabar n.d.: 117.3)
ʾana ʾo besa g-əb-ena.
I DEM.M.SG house.M.SG IND-want-1SG.M
'I want *this house* (and no other).' Narrow focus (exhaustive)

(8) J. Sanandaj (Khan 2009: 446.29)
ʾo k-e-wa-lan Ø-axl-ex. hič
DEM.M.SG IND-be.able-PST-OBL.1PL:A-IND-eat-1PL:A no thing
məndix xet la k-əxl-ex-wa.
other NEG IND-eat-1PL:A PST
'This we could eat. We did not eat anything else.' Narrow focus (contrastive)

This also holds true for direct object NPs that occur in broad focus configurations, as (9) – (10) illustrate.

(9) C. Marga (Noorlander 2023b: 31.2)
Context: One evening the she-goat came back home and looked:
hole xa dewa xil-a gəzy-aw.
DEIC.COP.3SG.M:A one wolf.M.SG eat.RES.PTCP-M.SG:A kid.PL-POSS.3SG.F
'Look! A wolf has eaten her kids.' Broad focus

(10) C. Barwar (Khan 2008c: 1900.2)
Context: In the old days it was not the practice to ask the girl.
bab-ət brata xaze-Ø-wa yəmm-ət brata
father.M.SG-CSTR girl.F.SG see-3SG.M:A-PST mother.F.SG-CSTR girl.F.SG
'The father of the bride would see the mother of the bride.' Broad focus

The role of establishing or linking to the general discourse domain is thus key to the presence of DOI, irrespective of whether the direct object NP is definite or not. Hence, topic reactivation of an indefinite NP in the object function, such as *pəsra* 'meat' given in (11), typically goes hand in hand with DOI, in which case a discourse topic is simply resumed.

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(11) C. Qaraqosh ((Khan 2002a: 599.147-148))
g-naxr-i-wa pəsra... ʾaxni pəsra
IND-slaughter-3PL:A-PST meat.M.SG we meat.M.SG
g-naxr-i-wa-lə...
IND-slaughter-3PL:A-PST-OBL.3SG.M:P
'They slaughtered meat ... In our community, people would slaughter meat...'

Also, contrastive topics as exemplified in (12) and (13) are perfectly compatible with DOI.

(12) C. Urmi (Noorlander fieldnotes)
Context: There are two doors.
ʾana tarra qamay-a patx-ən-ne, ʾat tarra
1SG door.M.SG front--M.SG open-1SG.M:A-3SG.M:P 2SG.M door.m.sg
də-tre (patx-ət-le).
REL-two (open-2SG.M:A-3SG.M:P)
'We open the front door; you open the second door.'

(13) J. Dohok (Molin field notes)
Context: In Iraq, we, the Jews, used to have good relations with Muslims. Then a war broke out in Jerusalem. Refugees went to Baghdad. And they tell them:
ʾaxni qam-qaṭl-i-lan ʾu batane d-eni
1PL TR.PST.PFV-kill-3PL:A-OBL.1PL:P and house.PL GEN-1PL
qam-šaql-i-lu.
TR.PST.PFV-take-3PL:A-OBL.3PL:P
'They have killed us and they have taken away our homes.'

Even *wh*-elements can be optionally indexed when they are referential and thereby linked to the established domain of the discourse, as the *wh*-objects in (14) and (15) indicate.

(14) C. Nerwa (Noorlander field notes)
Context: Your family has many books.
xon-ux kul-dana ʾemən kθawe ʾi-qaɻe-∅-ley
brother-POSS.2SG.M all-time when book.PL IND-read-3SG.M:A-OBL.3PL:P
'Which books does your brother read all the time?' (Noorlander field notes)

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(15) C. Urmi

a. Context: Your mother is a writer. I see there are a lot of books in her room.
yəmm-ax *ʾəm* *ktava*
mother.F.SG-POSS.2SG.F which book.M.SG
ktəv-t-u=la
write.RES.PTCP-F.SG:A-POSS.3PL:P=COP.3SG.F:A
'Which book (i.e., which one of these books) has your mother written?' (Noorlander field notes)

b. Context: The vizier has been charged with murder. His wife and the crowds demand that the king hang him. He asks the king who it is they think he has killed and why.
ʾana mut +yaṯṯ-an *mān +ḵṯil-u=t*
I how know-1SG.F who kill.RES.PTCP-POSS.3SG.M:P=COP.2SG:A
'How should I know whom (i.e., which one of our people) you have killed?' (Khan 2016b: 204.19)

The same holds true for referring quantifiers such as 'all', 'each' and 'many', as illustrated in (16) – (18).

(16) C. Dohok (Noorlander 2021a: §121)
Context: There were forty monsters. Mirza Muhammad killed them.
xà xa kull-ay gəm-qaṭəl-∅-lay
one one all-3PL TR.PST.PFV-kill-3SG.M:A-OBL.3PL:P
'He killed each of them one by one.'

(17) C. Nerwa (Noorlander field notes)
ʾət-wa-lan *qəṣṣətyaða. ṛaba l-* *əð-ən-ney.*
EXIST-PST-OBL.1PL story.pl many NEG- know-1SG.M:A-OBL.3SG.M:P
'We used to have stories. I do not know many (of them).'

(18) C. Barwar (Khan 2008c: 2078.64)
Context: They would put in the large pans the food that they were cooking, whether xumṣa or duxwa.
kul-xalta *bašl-i-wa-la*
each-food.F.SG cook-3PL:A-PST-OBL.3F.SG:P
'Each (type of) food they would cook.'

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Apart from topicality at the level of discourse, the topical status of the NP at the level of the clause can be sufficient for DOI. As such, DOI is near-obligatory with the verb *ʾmr* in the sense of 'to call X Y', as (19) – (20) illustrate.

(19) J. Urmi (Khan 2008b: §176)
hudae k-əmr-i-wa-lu loka jhud
Jew.PL IND-say-3PL:A-PST-OBL.3PL:R there jhud
'They used to call the Jews there *jhud*.'

(20) J. Dohok (Molin field notes)
Dŏhok k-ṣarx-í-wa-la maθa.
Dohok.F.SG IND-call-3PL:A-PST-OBL.3SG.F:R town.F.SG
'They used to call Dohok a town.'

The direct object NP that is assigned topical status does not have to be a specific referent that the speaker has in mind, or a referent that is predictable to the listener on the basis of context, as (21 and (22) demonstrate. Instead, the object is introduced as a new topic that the sentence is about.

(21) J. Dohok (Molin field notes)
flān qam-qaṭl-i-le. mă ʾoð-ax?
such-and-such TR.PST.PFV-kill-3PL:A-OBL.3PL:P what do-2SG.F
'They killed someone. What shall we do?'

(22) C. Urmi (Khan 2016b: B5:3)
+pəllan-cas ɟruš-lə ḵamayə
such-and-such pull.IMP.SG:A-3SG.M:P forward
'Take such-and-such to the front.'

Other important contributing factors that determine DOI are, in turn, better characterised as inherent semantic parameters, namely referentiality, identifability, and specificity. There are thus certain types of direct object NPs that are expected to be incompatible with DOI, not because they are nontopical per se, but also or maybe even primarily because they are nonreferential, nonspecific, and/or not uniquely identifiable. *Wh*-elements such as 'who' and 'what', indefinite negative polarity items such as 'not anything', and generic NPs that constitute new information are diagnostic examples of such direct objects. The examples in (23) below illustrate that these, indeed, never seem to trigger DOI.

(23) C. Nerwa (Noorlander field notes)

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a. *naše ma y-ʾaxl-i-wa (*-le) ʾeða*
person.PL what IND-eat-3PL:A-PST (-OBL.3SG.M:P) festival.M.SG
goṛ-a
big-M.SG
'What did people eat at Easter?' *Wh*-pronoun

b. *naše le maṣ-i-wa ʾaxl-i-wa (*-le) ču-məndi*
person.PL NEG can-3PL:A-PST eat-3PL:A-PST (-OBL.3SG.M:P) no-thing
'People could not eat anything.' Polarity item

c. *ʾi-ʾaxl-əx-wa (-*le) ləxma=u šāt-əx-wa*
IND-eat-1PL:A-PST (-OBL.3SG.M:P) bread=and drink-1PL:A-PST
(-ley) miyya*
(-OBL.3PL:P) water.PL
'We would eat bread and drink water.' Generic indefinite referent

Indefinite direct object NPs, therefore, generally do not trigger DOI, especially when they are nonspecific and nontopical. In some cases, an indefinite direct object is contextually specific enough to trigger DOI. In such cases, DOI is arguably simply conditioned by specificity; that is, the direct object NP can be a specific referent that is inferable from a restricted set in the established discourse domain or in the speaker's mind. This is a sufficient condition for the indefinite direct objects to be indexed, as (24) – (26) illustrate.

(24) C. Halmun (Talay 2009: 80.64)
holi gu Ḥalab gwir-a=ll-a
DEIC.COP.1SG:A in Aleppo marry.RES.PTCP-M.SG:A=OBJ-3SG.F
ða-baxta xe-ta
one-woman.F.SG other-F.SG
'I have taken another woman in marriage in Aleppo.'

(25) J. Koy Sanjak (Mutzafi 2004a: 203.29)
b-ṛez, xa-brona wāl-ew=ilu baq-əd
in-row one-boy.SG.M give.PROG-POSS.3SG.M:P=COP.3PL:A to-CSTR
did-ew korbān
GEN-3SG.M sacrifice
'They sacrifice one boy to him in turn, in a row.'

(26) J. Arbel (Khan 1999a: 464.331)

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məndixane zabn-ən-wa baq-eu ... dabi xa-məndəx
thing.PL sell-1SG.M:A-PST to-3SG.M ... must one-thing.M.SG
haw-ən-ne
give.SBJV-1SG.M:A-OBL.3SG.M:P
'I would sell him many things ... I had to give him something.'

However, the exact determining factors of DOI across NENA dialects are not yet fully understood, and the extent to which it is obligatory or optional seems to vary across dialects and individual speakers. Differential object indexing as such remains largely optional, as the following minimal pairs in (27) – (29) indicate (see also corpus-based statistics below).

(27) J. Betanure

a. *lel maġalla... dəmməd matxar-i-wā-le*
night.CSTR Purim when mention-3PL:A-PST-OBL.3MS:P
šəmm-əd Haman,
name-CSTR Haman
'At Purim eve ... when they mentioned Haman's name,' (Mutzafi 2008a: 182.152)

b. *maġalla, dəmm-əd matxar-i-wā šəmm-əd Haman,*
Purim when-CSTR mention-3PL:A-PST name-CSTR Haman
'At Purim, when they mentioned Haman's name,' (Mutzafi 2008a: 182.153)

(28) J. Betanure

a. *ṭalobaye, b-āz-i-wa*
bride_price_mediator.PL FUT-go-3PL:A-PST
ša'š-í-wā-la ʾið-əd babəd
kiss-3PL:A-PST-OBL.3SG.F:P hand.F.SG-CSTR father.M.SG.CSTR
kalo.
bride.F.SG
'The bride-price mediators, they would go kiss the hand of the bride's father.' (Mutzafi 2008a: 196.199)

b. *yəmm-ed kalo, baxtaθa b-āz-i-wa*
mother.F.SG-CSTR bride.F.SG woman.PL fut-go-3PL:A-PST
b-ša'š-i-wa ʾið-əd yəmməd kalo.
FUT-kiss-3PL:A-PST hand.F.SG-CSTR mother.F.SG.CSTR bride.F.SG
'And as for the bride's mother, the wives (of the bride-price mediators) would go kiss the hand of the bride's mother'. (Mutzafi 2008a: 196.199)

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(29) C. Urmi

a. *ʾaxun-i* *xol-ux*
brother.M.SG-POSS.1SG rope.M.SG-POSS.2SG.M
šadər-re!
send.IMP.SG:A-OBL.3SG.M:P
'Brother, send your rope.' (Khan 2016b: A39:15)

b. *ʾaxun-i* *xol-ux* *šadər!*
brother.M.SG-POSS.1SG rope.M.SG-POSS.2SG.M send.IMP.SG:A
'Brother, send your rope.' (Khan 2016b: A39:16)

Thus, even verbs such as *ʾmr* 'to call X Y' that regularly go hand in hand with DOI do not come with it obligatorily, as (30) demonstrates.

(30) J. Sanandaj (Khan 2009: 448.30)
ʾoa-sawzì-jad *k-əmr-i-wa* *gilaxa.*
DEM.SG-mixed_herbs IND-say-3PL:A-PST gilaxa
'The mixed herbs they called *gilaxa*.' Aboutness topic

Conversely, there are numerous exceptions where direct objects are part of the focal domain of the sentence and yet trigger DOI because of their semantic and/or discourse-pragmatic properties. Thus, the direct objects *ya brata* 'this girl' in (31) and *ʾawwa* 'this' in (32) are specific and linked to the established discourse, but they are in narrow focus in terms of information structure. In (33), the direct object NPs *xa yoma* 'one day' and *ʾəṣra yomaθa* 'ten days' are nonspecific and focalised, but they are anchored in the general discourse.

(31) J. Urmi (Garbell 1965b: 155)
Context: Her parents wept when they heard this matter, that the boy was demanding their daughter. But he insisted, saying:
g-b-ən-na *ya* *brata!*
IND-want-1SG.M:A-OBL.3SG.F:P DEM.SG girl.F.SG
'I want this girl! (and not any other)' Exhaustive focus

(32) C. Nerwa (Noorlander field notes
šqul *laxma!* *ʾawwa* *pt-axl-ət-le,* *la* *xa*
take.IMP.SG:A bread.M.SG DEM.SG FUT-eat-2SG.M:A-OBL.3SG.M:P NEG some
məndi xe-na.
thing other-M.SG
'Take some bread! Only this you shall eat, nothing else.' Contrastive focus

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(33) C. Dohok (Noorlander 2021a: §139)
Context: Mirza Muhammad had met an old woman who could use a ball to make day or night. He had requested her to turn one day into night, but she refused. He tied her up to ensure it remained night for one whole day, so he could kill forty monsters. Upon his return, he released her. She says:
la xà yoma b-awð-án-wa-le layle, ʾəlla ʾəṣrà
not one day FUT-do-1SG.F:A-PST-OBL.3SG.M:P night.F.SG but ten
yomaθa b-awð-án-wa-lay ṭal-ux layle.
days FUT-do-1SG.F:A-PST-OBL.3PL:P for-2SG.M night.F.SG
'I would have turned not only one day into night, but I would have turned (even) ten days into night for you.' Scalar focus

21.2.2.2 Corpus-based statistics of DOI

Corpus-based studies (Noorlander 2025a) help determine the frequency at which definite direct object NPs are indexed on the verb. A summary of the results are given in Table 21.2.2.2 for a wide range of NENA dialects. As explained in the previous section, definiteness is not a sufficient or a necessary condition for object indexing to occur. Nevertheless, definite referents have been selected as a heuristic for convenience's sake, as they are relatively easy to identify and were tagged separately from indefinite objects on the basis the guidelines of the projects in which these corpus-based studies took place (see Haig et al. 2024). The previous subsection outlined how there could be many reasons for why a definite direct object NP fails to instantiate indexing on the verb, and subsequent subsections will also provide further details for restrictions in construction-specific contexts. Moreover, the number of tokens is overall low, and further corpus-based research may reveal more robust tendencies. These corpus-based statistics should therefore be taken on an all else being equal basis. Furthermore, in the actual counts, a number of clause types were ignored, such as those where the verbal object index is morphologically zero, and thereby ambivalent. This would apply to past stem verbal forms where the morphological exponent of the 3SG.M object can be zero (e.g., *qṭəl-Ø-le* 'he killed him'. Bearing these caveats in mind, the results indicate that the average frequency of definite object NP indexing across NENA dialects is 75%. Table 21.2.2.2 also shows the relative frequency of definite NPs among object NPs in order to indicate how comparable the corpora are in terms of the distribution of definite as opposed to indefinite direct object NPs, of which the average across the corpora is 50%. By comparison, we added statistics for the Midyat variety of Ṭuroyo Neo-Aramaic, which is closely related to NENA. This

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variety has practically lost differential object indexing of definite NPs, occuring only in a handful of cases (7%). The corpora that show a relatively high rate of object indexing belong to dialects that are located in the south-eastern periphery (C. Shaqlawa, C. Sanandaj) or in the northern sector (J. Urmi, C. Urmi). In all these cases, this could be an effect of the selected corpus sample in question, but it may possibly also be an effect of an ongoing word order shift from VO to OV (see further below for the effect of word order and Chapter 23.1). However, a noteworthy outlier is C. Qaraqosh located on the Mosul Plain, showing significantly lower rate of DOI, but not as low as Ṭuroyo Neo-Aramaic. The rates of DOI in C. Qaraqosh and Ṭuroyo Neo-Aramaci are comparable to local Arabic dialects and most likely the result of contact with them (see §21.3 for more details regarding these Arabic varieties).

Table 21.2: Distribution of definites among direct object NPs and distribution of differential object indexing among definite direct object NPs across corpora of NENA dialects

Dialect	Definite direct object NPs		Direct object NPs	
	Raw total	% of which indexed	Raw total	% of which definite
Ṭuroyo Midyat CNA	107*	7%	237	57%
C. Qaraqosh NENA	66	24%	177	37%
C. Barwar NENA	121	58%	313	47%
C. Hertevin NENA	61	62%	96	64%
J. Barzan NENA	25	64%	52	48%
J. Arbel NENA	67	66%	146	46%
J. Dohok NENA	62	74%	210	35%
J. Betanure NENA	90	75%	205	43%
NENA Average:		**75%**		**50%**
J. Sanandaj NENA	86	76%	330	32%
C. Bohtan NENA	57	86%	93	63%
J. Urmi NENA	87	87%	152	57%
C. Urmi NENA	138	88%	202	76%
C. Shaqlawa NENA	49	94%	94	60%
C. Sanandaj NENA	19	95%	45	47%

At face value, in NENA dialects where word order seems to be relatively free, DOI occurs or does not occur irrespective of whether the direct object NP is in preverbal or postverbal position, as the following minimal pairs demonstrate.

(34) J. Betanure

a. *xmarta* *wið-a-lox* *qutte!*
she.ass.f.sg make.pst-3sg.f:P-obl.2sg.m:A tailless.f.sg
'You made the she-ass tailless!' (Mutzafi 2008a: XVI.7:482)

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b. *wið-a-lox* *xmarta* *qutte!*
make.PST-3SG.F:P-OBL.2SG.M:A she.ass.F.SG tailless.F.SG
'You made the she-ass tailless!' (Mutzafi 2008a: XVI.7:483)

(35) J. Betanure

a. *dahola ʾu ẓuṛna māxe-∅-wa*
drum and oboe strike-3PL-PST
'They played the drum and oboe.' (Mutzafi 2008a: XII.1: 216)

b. *māxe-∅-wa dahola ʾu ẓuṛna*
strike-3PL-PST drum and oboe
'They played the drum and oboe.' (Mutzafi 2008a: XII.1: 217)

On closer inspection, however, corpus-based statistics for word order distributions among NENA dialects do indicate an enhanced potential for DOI in the preverbal position (Noorlander 2025a). Across NENA dialects, there is a high rate of indexing among definite object NPs in preverbal position. For example, in C. Qaraqosh, 91% of definite object NPs in preverbal position are indexed, against only 15% of those in postverbal position. Yet not all NENA dialects are the same in their treatment of indexed definite object NPs, as some show a similar distribution in postverbal position. For example, in C. Barwar, the rate of indexing is 79% among preverbal definite object NPs as against a rate of indexing of 58% among postverbal definite object NPs. In C. Urmi, 91% of definite object NPs in preverbal position are indexed, as against only 50% of those in postverbal position. Examining the data from another angle allows us to take into account this microvaration, counting how often definite object NPs that trigger DOI (for whatever reason) are preverbal in contrast to definite object NPs that do not (for whatever reason). Table 21.3 shows the results for NENA dialects with a reasonably flexible word order. As the results demonstrate, there is a robust tendency among NENA dialects for a definite object NP that triggers indexing to be more likely to be placed in preverbal position than a definite object NP that fails to trigger DOI. This tendency is irrespective of the statistically dominant word order, although, of course, higher rates of direct object NPs in preverbal position will be found in those dialects that favour OV order more generally, and vice versa. Thus, in dialects with dominant VO order, the postverbal position is preferred for definite object NPs overall, but not necessarily for those that are indexed, as in C. Qaraqosh and J. Betanure, where it is mostly 50/50. Similarly, in NENA dialects where OV is statistically dominant, such as C. Urmi and J. Arbel, the preverbal position is preferred for definite object NPs overall, but the extent to which this is preferred is not the same for indexed and non-indexed definite object NPs.

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Table 21.3: Percentage of preverbal position among indexed and non-indexed definite object NPs alongside the raw total number of definite object NPs

Dialect	Definite Object NP Indexed % preverbal	Definite Object NP Not indexed % preverbal	Definite Object NP Raw total
C. Qaraqosh (VO)	55%	2%	66
J. Betanure (VO)	50%	11%	77
J. Dohok (VO)	35%	6%	62
C. Barwar (VO)	38%	17%	121
J. Barzan (VO?)	38%	11%	25
C. Bohtan (OV)	78%	88%	57
C. Urmi (OV)	96%	71%	138
J. Arbel (OV)	70%	43%	67

21.2.2.3 Object indexing in clauses based on past stem verbs

In the majority of NENA dialects, the past perfective verbal forms based on *qṭil-* are incompatible with any object indexes and can therefore only combine with direct object NPs that do not trigger indexing. The transitive syntax is therefore compatible with full NPs where only the A is indexed, but not with full NPs where both would be indexed. In all NENA dialects, a *qṭil-stem* verb can combine with a full NP. In a conservative dialect like C. Marga, the *qṭil*-stem verb can take an additional object index, as illustrated in the following example.

(36) C. Marga (Noorlander fieldnotes)

a. *xawr-i* *xəl-le* *beta*
friend-1SG.POSS eat.PST-OBL.3SG.M:A egg.SG.F
'My friend ate an egg.' Full object NP

b. *xawr-i* *xil-a-le*
friend-1SG.POSS eat.PST-3SG.F:P-OBL.3SG.M:A
'My friend ate it (the egg).' Object index possible

In the majority of NENA dialects, however, this is not possible, as the following example demonstrates for C. Nerwa.

(37) C. Nerwa (Noorlander fieldnotes)

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a. *xoɻ-i* *xəl-le* *beta*
friend-1SG.POSS eat.PST-OBL.3SG.M:A egg
'My friend ate an egg.' Full object NP

b. *xoɻ-i* *xil(*-a)-le*
friend-1SG.POSS eat.PST(*-3SG.F:P)-OBL.3SG.M:A
'My friend ate it (the egg).' Object index impossible

In the majority of NENA dialects, in the presence of an indexed object NP, the verb form changes to match the transitivity coding of present imperfective, i.e., *qaṭəl*-based) clauses. Since the past perfective *qṭəlle* cannot simply take a direct object suffix in these dialects, a lexically transitive verb must occur in the so-called *qam*-perfective construction when the object NP is indexed in the past perfective. Thus, special indexing of A by means of the D-suffixes is required when the direct object NP is indexed as well. When the direct object NP triggers no indexing, the A argument is indexed by an oblique L-suffix as usual. This is shown by the following alternation between the two transitive clauses using the same lexical transitive verb 'to let go out'. The difference between the choice of construction depends on the status of the direct object, being either indefinite nonspecific or definite specific.

(38) C. Nerwa

a. Past stem verb, indexing of A only
xað-i *mpuləṭ-la* *xakma qaṭ-e* *mən beða*
sister-1SG.POSS let_out.TR.PST-OBL.3SG.F:A some cat-PL from house
'My sister let a couple of cats go out of the house.'

b. *Qam*-construction, indexing of A and P
xað-i qəm-palṭ-a-ley qaṭ-ey
sister-1SG.POSS TR.PST.PFV-let_out-3SG.F:A-OBL.3PL:P
mən *beða*
cat.PL-POSS.3PL from house
'My sister let their cats go out of the house.'

While the past *qṭil*-formation is compatible with all verbs, including intransitive verbs, the past *qam*-formation is not compatible with lexically intransitive verbs, as the following alternation demonstrates.

(39) C. Nerwa

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a. Past stem verb compatible with S-indexing
pləṭ-ley *qaṭ-ey* *mən beða*
go_out.PST-OBL.3PL:S cat.PL-POSS.3PL from house
'Their cats went out of the house.'

b. *Qam*-construction incompatibile with S-indexing
**qəm-palṭ-i* *qaṭ-ey* *mən beða*
PST.PFV-go_out-3PL:S cat.PL-POSS.3PL from house
Intended: 'Their cats went out of the house.'

This is a syntactic constraint that is determined by the presence of a direct object index, which can be a pronominal index or a cross-index of a salient object NP. This constraint applies irrespective of whether the direct object bears a patient, theme, or recipient role. In the majority of NENA dialects, the *qam*-perfective construction functions similarly to an applicative voice construction in that the nonsubject argument has to be promoted to the status of direct object. Hence, past perfective clauses with direct object indexing are treated differently from clauses with oblique arguments. Consider, for instance, the following alternation between the partitive patient as an oblique argument and the patient as a direct object.

(40) C. Nerwa

a. *xaðwað-i xəl-ley* *(mən* *xabuša)*
sister.PL-my eat.PST-OBL.3PL:S (from apple.M.SG)
'My sisters ate (from the/an apple).' S with oblique argument

b. *xaðwað-i qəm-ʾaxl-i-le xabuša*
sister.PL-my TR.PST-eat-3PL:A-3SG.M:P apple.M.SG
'My sisters ate the apple.' A with P argument

The same holds true for dative alternations in which the pronominal recipient alternates between a dative prepositional argument and a direct object on the verb, as the following example illustrates for the verb 'to say'.

(41) C. Nerwa

a. *xað-i məɻ-a* *qa* *d-ani*
sister.F.SG-my say.PST-OBL.3SG.F:A to GEN-3PL
'My sister said (something) to them.' A with indirect object

b. *xað-i qəm-ʾamɻ-a-ley*
sister.F.SG-my TR.PST-say-3SG.F:A-OBL.3PL:P
'My sister told them.' A with direct object

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However, in a few NENA dialects, such as J. Dohok, past stem verb forms are compatible with the indexing of a topicalised recipient, but not with a topicalised theme (or patient). In J. Dohok, for instance, a secondary L-suffix can be attached to a past stem verb form to resume a fronted topical recipient argument, but it cannot do so with a fronted topical theme argument.

(42) J. Dohok

a. Past stem verb, indexing of A and R possible
xaθ-i *hul-lu-la* *baṭane*
sister.F.SG-my give.PST-3PL:A-OBL.3SG.F:R blanket.PL
'My sister, they gave her blankets.'

b. Past stem verb, indexing of A and T impossible)
ʾan-baṭane *hul-lu* *(*-lu)* *ta xaθ-i*
DEM-blanket.PL give.PST-3PL:A (*-OBL.3PL.T) to sister.F.SG-my
Intended: 'These blankets, they gave them to my sister.'

In the western periphery, the construction in (42a) is possible with all endpoint roles, including themes, and has been integrated into the argument indexing system, so that the secondary L-suffix can freely cross-reference a theme argument, as the following example demonstrates.

(43) C. Hertevin (Noorlander field notes)
anhi=ssi hu-le-lehən *l-ḥat-i*
DEM.PL=also give.PST-OBL.3SG.M:A-OBL.3PL.T to-sister-my
'These, too, he gave to my sister.'

The presence of an indexed P argument, however, may also obligatorily change the coding of the A argument in the past perfective. In C. Hertevin, this only applies to non-third person agents, and, in C. Umra, C. Jinnet and C. Derabün, only to second person singular agents. Thus, when P is indefinite nonspecific, the regularly expected past stem verb form occurs, as (44) illustrates.

(44) C. Hertevin
ana ḥze-li (-le)* *ḥmara*
I see.PST-1SG:A (*-3SG.M:P) donkey.M.SG
'I found a donkey.' Cross-indexing of only A possible

For the verbal form to be inflected with the regular oblique L-suffix in C. Hertevin, such as *-li* OBL.1SG, the direct object must be indefinite and nonspecific, or omitted entirely, so that examples of the following kind cannot occur:

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(45) C. Hertevin
ana ḥze(-li)-le ḥmar-i*
I see.PST(*-1SG:A)-3SG.M:P donkey.M.SG-my
Intended for: 'I found (lit. him) my donkey.'

Instead, when the P is definite specifc and triggers cross-indexing on the verb, the agent must be expressed with an ergative set of person markers, as (46) illustrates.

(46) C. Hertevin
ana ḥze(-lən) *(-ne) ḥmar-i*
I see.PST-ERG.1SG.M:A *(-OBL.3SG.M:P) donkey.M.SG-my
'I found my donkey.' Cross-indexing of A and P obligatory

Past verb forms like those in (46), however, cannot occur on their own, so that the examples of following kind cannot occur:

(47) C. Hertevin
ana ḥze(-lən) ḥmara*
I see.PST(*-ERG.1SG:A) donkey.M.SG
Intended for: 'I found a donkey.'

In C. Hertevin, the A-past indices such as *-li* and *-lən* for the first person, therefore, are complementary and each occur in a different context depending on the syntactic transitivity and status of the object NP.

21.2.2.4 Optional and impossible indexing of A in clauses based on past stem verbs

In the majority of NENA dialects, the indexing of S and A arguments is obligatory. In some conservative NENA dialects, however, oblique A-past indices may optionally omitted (see Gutman 2009, Noorlander 2021a). This is typically but not exclusively possible when the following three conditions are met: a) the presence of an additional object index on the verb, b) the A argument is contextually presupposed and thereby expected in the established discourse and c) there is another subject (S/A) index present on another verb in the immediate context. Contrast example (48a) reflecting a present stem verbal form that takes obligatory A-indexing with (48b) showing a past stem verbal form that drops the A-indexing on the second verb. The agent index can only be omitted in clauses based on a past stem verb. Omission of the A-index of past stem verbs is also compatible with an overt agent NP, as (48c) illustrates.

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(48) C. Marga

a. *matt*(-i)$_i$-la* *l-xaṣ-ət* *daware*
put.IPFV-3PL:A-OBL.3SG.F:P on-back-of mule.PL
ʾu-nabl(-i)$_i$-la*
and-take.IPFV-3PL:A-OBL.3SG.F:P
'They place her on a mule's back and take her along.' (Noorlander 2023b: 29)

b. *mot-a-wa-ney$_i$* *l-xaṣ-ət* *dăware*
put.PST-3SG.F:P-PST-OBL.3PL:A on-back-CSTR mule.PL
ʾu-nubl-a-wa *(-∅$_i$)*
and-took.PST-3SG.F:P-PST (-3PL)
'They placed her on a mule's back and took her along.' (Noorlander 2023b: 29)

c. *bas* *mbúrx-an(-∅$_i$)=u* *qaša$_i$* *xəš-le*
only bless.PST-1SG.F:P(-3SG.M:A)=and priest.M.SG go.PST-OBL.3SG.M:S
'The priest only wed me and left.' (Noorlander 2021a: 241)

This notwithstanding, it is possible for both A-past and P-past indices to be omitted. Such a truncated past stem verb form seems to be only possible when both the A and P arguments are nonspecific, as illustrated in (49). Clauses of this type are rare, are only compatible with primary transitive verbs, and are generally only used in generic statements, such as customs in the past, though presented as an undivided whole in terms of event structure.

(49) C. Barwar (Khan 2008c: 749-750)

a. *baxta* *qṭil*
woman.SG.F kill.PST
'A woman was killed.' / 'They killed a woman.'

b. *prim* *ʾərwe*
slaugheter.PST sheep.PL
'Sheep were slaughtered. / 'They slaughtered sheep.'

When the A-indexing is absent, the topical nonsubject argument can also belong to a class different from P, as (50) demonstrates.

(50) J. Nerwa (Noorlander 2018: 214)
Awraham *mir* *ʾəbb-e*
Abraham.M.SG say.PST about-3SG.M
'It was said concerning Abraham:' / 'People said concerning Abraham:'

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21.2.2.5 Optional and impossible indexing in clauses based on complex verbs

The argument indexing in clauses based on complex verb forms is generally the same as that discussed in §21.2.2.1. The agreement pattern of the complex perfect is also disccused in §13.2.5.7 and §16.1.8. In the majority of NENA dialects, the copula expresses the subject (S/A), and the resultative participle used to form the perfect agrees with the subject. In Christian dialects in the western periphery, in varieties such as C. Jinnet and C. Hassan, any form of indexing of object NPs is impossible in complex verb construcitons. The participle and the copula agree with a subject (S and A) only and the transitive verb form cannot take additiona object affixes, as seen in the following example.

(51) C. Jinnet (Noorlander fieldnotes)
čoy$_i$ didi ʾaḥun-i=lə šətya? ʾe,
tea.F.SG 1SG.GEN brother.M.SG-my=COP.3SG.M:A drink.RES.PTCP.M.SG:A yes
holə šətya ∅$_i$
DEIC.COP.3SG.M:A drink.RES.PTCP.M.SG:A 3SG.F:P
'Has my brother drunk my tea? Yes, he has drunk it.'

In several NENA dialects, the copula expressing either S or A can be omitted when the argument they refer to is contextually retrievable, as (52 illustrates.

(52) C. Nerwa (Noorlander, fieldnotes)
xəš-ta=u xzi-t=əlley xonawaða
go.RES.PTCP-F.SG:S=and see.RES.PTCP-F.SG:A=3PL:P brother.PL
diyy-a
GEN-POSS.3SG.F
'She went and saw her brothers.'

The omission of the copula in example in (52 is entirely optional, and is compatible with the overt presence of a copula. This is indeed the more common form, as the following example illustrates.

(53) C. Nerwa (Noorlander, fieldnotes)
xəš-t=ela=u hola
go.RES.PTCP-F.SG:S=COP.3SG.F:S=and DEIC.COP.3SG.F:A
xzi-t=əlley xonawaða diyy-a
see.RES.PTCP-F.SG:A=3PL:P brother.PL GEN-POSS.3SG.F
'She went and saw her brothers.'

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By contrast, in SE Trans-Zab Jewish dialects, it is impossible to have any form of indexing of an agent NP in realis complex perfects; the agent remains obligatorily unmarked and nonindexed. The participle and the copula do not agree with A, but instead agree with S and P. In this case, the agreement with P is only expressed when the argument is salient, as (54) shows.

(54) J. Saqiz (Yisraeli 1998: 103)
brat-ev *axonawal-av* *la* *xəzy-e=n*
daughter.F.SG-his brotherM.PL-her NEG see.RES.PTCP-PL:P=COP.3PL:P
'His daughter has not seen her brothers.'

When the P argument is not salient, an invariant, nonreferential 3MSG. form is used, as seen in the following example. Here, therefore, the invariant 3MSG. copula cannot be dropped.

(55) J. Saqiz (Yisraeli 1998: 103)
šulṭana *šinda* *xəzy-a*(=y)*
king.M.SG dream.F.SG see.RES.PTCP-3SG.M=COP.3SG.M
'The kign saw a dream.'

In the irreals complex perfect in these dialects, however, the oblique L-suffixes serve as obligatory agent indices in the inflection as they do for past stem verb forms. The participle and the copula still agree with a salient object NP only, as given in the following example.

(56) J. Saqiz (Yisraeli 1998: 163)
brat-ake *xzi-t=awy-a*(-li)*
daughter.F.SG-DEF see.RES.PTCP-F.SG:P=SBJV.be-3SG.F:P*(-1SG:A)
'I saw the girl.'

21.2.2.6 Indexing of themes, recipients and obliques

Generally, that which applies to the P argument of monotransitive clauses also applies to the theme argument of ditransitive clauses. However, in virtually all NENA dialects, when the R argument is pronominal and is expressed by a direct object suffix attached to the verb, the theme argument cannot be indexed as well, e.g.,

(57) C. Marga (Khan and Noorlander field notes)

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a. *ʾana b-yaw-ən-ne ʾaya brata*
1SG FUT-give-1SG:A-OBL.3SG.M:R this girl.F.SG
'I shall give him this girl (in marriage).'

b. *ʾana b-yaw-ən-na ʾaya brata ṭal-eu*
1SG FUT-give-1SG:A-OBL.3SG.F.T this girl.F.SG to-3SG.M
'I shall give this girl to him (in marriage).'

For a salient theme argument to be indexed on the verb, the pronominal recipient must be expressed independently, e.g.,

(58) J. Betanure ((Mutzafi 2008a: 204.228))

a. *hu-lū-le margəlta*
give-OBL.3PL:A-OBL.3SG.M:R cauldron.F.SG
'They gave him a cauldron.'

b. *ʾu yəmm-əd kalo g-maxəzy-a-le*
and mother.F.SG-CSTR bride.F.SG IND-show-3SG.F:A-OBL.3SG.T
ʾó-julla ʾəl-baxtaθa
DEM-cloth.SG.M to-woman.PL
'The bride's mother shows that piece of fabric to the women.'

For further details regarding argument indexing in ditransitive clauses, see (Coghill 2010a), (Noorlander 2021a).

Sporadically, however, we do find more than one nonsubject index on a verb. In these cases, a pronominal object index can be attached to the verb alongside a differential object index that cross-references a salient theme argument. The examples below demonstrate that this is indeed possible across dialects, but it is by no means common.

(59) C. Marga (Khan and Noorlander field notes)
ʾaya brata, ṭlib-a-lay-le
this girl.F.SG betroth.PST-3SG.F.T-OBL.3PL:A-OBL.3SG.M:R
'This girl, they betrothed her to him.'

(60) C. Halmun (Talay 2009: 76.44)

a. *maxzaw-le-li xone d-aw*
show.IMP.PL-OBL.3SG.M.T-OBL.1SG:R brother.M.SG GEN-DEM.M.SG
naša
man.M.SG
'Show me this man's brother!'

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b. *ʾaql-ux* *č-čappe*
foot.F.SG-POSS.2SG.M GEN-left_hand.PL
máxzi-la-li
show.IMP.SG.M-OBL.3SG.F.T-OBL.1SG:R
'Show me your left foot!'

The R argument, however, can also be differentially indexed like a direct object, even when a full nominal theme is present. The R argument thus occurs as the most topical argument in a double object construction, as the following examples show. This, however, is not the most common construction type.

(61) C. Hertevin (Jastrow 1988: §437)
yăw-á-lehən *ʾan* *čičoke* *beʾe*
give-3SG.F:A-OBL.3PL:R DEM.PL chick.PL egg.PL
'She would give these chicks eggs.'

(62) C. Txuma (Talay 2009: 148.4)
yaw-i-wa-lɛ *kud naša* *xa* *tuman*
give-3PL:A-PST-OBL.3PL:R each person one toman
'They gave each one of them a toman.'

(63) C. Jilu (Talay 2009: 626.8)
mlay-əll-e *xurjən* *pušange*
fill.PROG-COP.3:A.OBJ-3SG.M:R saddlebag.M.SG bullet.PL
'He is filling the saddlebag with ammunition.'

(64) C. Urmi (Polotsky 1979: 218)
hallun-la *šəmma* *haqyat-oxun*
give.IMP.PL-OBL.3PL:R name.M.SG story.F.SG-POSS.2PL
'Give your story a name.'

In most cases, however, this type of P-like indexing of the R argument only occurs when it is fronted to clause-initial topic position (see also Givón 1976).

(65) J. Amedia (Greenblatt 2011: 8.3)
kud ʾarba naše *g-yaw-i-wa-lu* *xa laxma*
every four person.PL IND-give-3PL:A-PST-OBL.3PL:R one bread.M.SG
'Every four people they would give one loaf of bread.'

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Finally, differential indexing of obliques rarely occurs. In some conservative dialects, such as the dialect of Hertevin, the oblique L-suffixes and B-suffixes can be used to index unflagged oblique arguments that would otherwise correspond to the allative/dative preposition *l-* 'to' and the locative/instrumental preposition *b-* 'at; in; by' respectively, e.g.,

(66) C. Hertevin

a. *ḥakmå ṭuråne ʾåte-Ø-le*
some mountain.PL come-3PL:S-to_them
'They came to some mountains.' (Jastrow 1988: 118.130)

b. *qdəm-le-be sănampăreze*
move_forward.PST-OBL.3PL:S-at_him idol.M.SG
'They came forward to approach the idol.'

21.2.3 Argument flagging in NENA

In NENA, flagging is, apart from obliques, generally reserved for direct objects, but may also be a coding strategy applied to agents. With obliques, this type of marking is role-based, i.e., the selection of the particular preposition is primarily based on a particular role associated with the lexical semantics of the verb, such as location, goal, recipient, addressee etc. When the direct object is marked, this is always based on the salience of the argument. Marking of the direct object is never simply due to the object function per se; the properties of the argument trigger overt marking with different degrees of obligatoriness/optionality. While the relevant contexts and degrees of optionality can be dialect-specific, as a system-wide coding strategy, this type of marking shall be subsumed under differential object flagging (DOF). The marking of agents, in turn, is optional, but specific to particular constructions, as well as being conditioned by contextual factors. For agents, an alternative construction with an unmarked agent with the same meaning is always available. NENA dialects can be contrast with Turoyo Neo-Aramaic, where flagging of direct objects is hardly used (Waltisberg 2016, Noorlander 2021a), except in a few varieties, and the verbal object suffixes primarily serve a pronominal indices and do not combine with a co-nominal. In Ṭuroyo Neo-Aramaic, in turn, flagging of A argument is fairly common, obligatorily combined with additional indexing of A. This construction has hitherto not been attested in NENA.

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21.2.3.1 Differential object flagging: Innovated object markers

In NENA dialects without differential object flagging (DOF), the unmarked citation form of full NPs can be used to express several syntactic functions, including both the subject and the direct object. In such dialects, case-marking is used exclusively for indirect objects and obliques, and also, rarely, for agents of clauses based on past stem verbs. This can be contrasted with the NENA dialects that have a direct object marker as part of their differential object marking system. Christian dialects in the northern sector (Hakkari, Van, Urmia) developed novel direct object markers *qa-* or *ṭla*, which are derived from a dative preposition. The following examples illustrate the alternations between DOI and DOF on their own across Christian NENA dialects.

(67) C. Barwar

a. *ʾana hon qṭil=əll-e Dewa Zar*
I DEIC.COP.1SG:S kill.RES.PTCP.M.SG:A=OBJ-3SG.M Dewa Zar.M.SG
'I have killed Dewa Zar.' (Khan 2008c: 1764.22)

b. *ʾawwa xuwwe ĥ-awe-∅-wa qṭil-a ṭla bron-i*
DEM.M.SG snake.M.SG SBJV-be-3SG.M:S-PST kill.RES.PTCP-M.SG:A DOM son.M.SG-my
'That snake would have killed my son.' (Khan 2008c: A9:6)

(68) C. Lewen

a. *baye-∅ ∅-šaqəl-∅-la w ∅-qaṭəl-∅-le Mallək-Loko*
want-3SG.M:A SBJV-take-3SG.M:A-OBL.3SG.M:P and SBJV-kill-3SG.M:A-OBL.3SG.M:P Mallək-Loko.M.SG
'He wants to take the gun and kill Mallik Loko.' (Talay 2009: 98.7)

b. *baye-∅ ∅-qaṭəl-∅-wa qa Mallək-Loko*
want-3SG.M:A SBJV-kill-3SG.M:A-PST DOM Mallək-Loko.M,SG
'He wanted to kill Mallik Loko.' (Talay 2009: 98.7)

(69) C. Txuma

a. *qṭil-ə=bb-ɛ bnon-an w ərw-an*
kill.RES.PTCP-M.SG:A=OBJ-3PL son.PL-POSS.1PL and sheep-POSS.1PL
'He has killed our sons and cattle.' (Talay 2009: 170.43)

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b. *qṭəl-le* *ṭla* *Hawəl*
kill.PST-OBL.3SG.M:A DOM Abel.M.SG
'He killed Abel.' (Talay 2009: 448.6)

DOF by means of *qa-* features prominently in the literary koine used, for instance, in Bible translations (see Murre-van den Berg 1999). In the spoken vernacular of these Christian dialects, however, DOF appears to be used only sporadically (cf. (Khan 2016b: 256-257)). Christian dialects on the Mosul Plain, in turn, innovated a direct object marker *ġda*/*ta*, also derived from a dative preposition, which is always combined with differential object indexing (see next subsection). On rare occasions, we find these, as well as similar object markers, in other dialects; this usage may possibly be the result of imposition or borrowing from the literary language.

The Trans-Zab Jewish dialects, as exemplified below, regularly employ the object marker *(ʾə)l-*. For most dialects, DOF is conditioned by a combination of the inherent and contextual properties of the argument, especially the combination of humanness and discourse-givenness (see also (Khan 1999a: 289-290), (Khan 2009: 319-320), Coghill 2019). While a strong correlation between DOF and human referents can be established (see further below for corpus-based statistics), the exact conditions for each individual dialect are still not entirely understood. Generally, human referents can optionally be case-marked, but they have to be accessible to both speaker and hearer. Most frequently, therefore, a case-marked object NP will be a human referent that is contextually expected or uniquely identifiable. The human object NPs in the following examples are case-marked, because they are discourse-given and maintain discourse reference.

(70) J. Arbel
Context: The man went outside. His neighbour was malevalent towards the owner of the house.
ʾəl-iyya *kābra* *dwiq-le*
DOM-this man.M.SG seize.PST-OBL.3SG.M:A
'He seized this man.' (Khan 1999a: 428.91

(71) J. Sanandaj
Context: My mother came to Tehran and said to me 'You must go back and marry this girl.' I said 'Fine. Whatever you say, I am willing to do. I agree to do whatever you say.' Then my mother went and sent somebody to tell the girl's brother that

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ʾay-brona *həl-* *d-ay* *brata* *g-be-Ø*
DEM.SG-boy.M.SG DOM- GEN-DEM.SG girl.F.SG IND-love-3SG.M:A
'The boy loves the girl.' (Khan 2009: A:18)

Nonhuman animate NPs that are discourse-given can also be case-marked, as the following examples demonstrate.

(72) J. Koy Sanjak (Mutzafi 2004a: 189.15)
xa *ʿaqubra* *ʾəlye-le* *... šer-ake*
one mouse.M.SG come.PST-OBL.3SG.M:S ... lion.M.SG-DEF
dwiq-le *l-ʿaqubr-ake*
hold.PST-OBL.3SG.M:A DOM-mouse.M.SG-DEF
'A mouse came... The lion caught hold of the mouse.'

(73) C. Shamsdin Iyyel (Talay 2009: 448.6)
xzi-la *xuwwe...* *qṭəl-le* *qa* *xuwwe,*
see.PST-OBL.3SG.F:A snake.M.SG kill.PST-OBL.3SG.M:A DOM snake.M.SG
qaṭo *diyy-an*
cat.F.SG GEN-1PL
'It saw a snake... it killed the snake, our cat.'

It is far less common for discourse-given inanimate referents to appear only with case-marking in a NENA dialect, and to what extent this is possible requires further investigation. This seems to occur only regularly in J. Salmas, as shown in (74). This has a direct parallel in Mlaḥso, a Central Neo-Aramaic variety, which relies on the strategy of flagging on its own. This is used on a contextual basis, incorporating both human uniquely identifiable referents and inanimate uniquely identifiable referents (see Jastrow 1994a, Noorlander 2021a).

(74) J. Salmas (Duval 1883 120–121.19, 134.32, transcription modified)
a. *...aya* *brūna* *kudyöm* *lexma* *méndē-Ø-va*
...DEM.SG boy.M.SG every_day bread.M.SG throw-3SG.M:A-PST
'...the boy would throw bread (at the fish) every day.'
b. *ya* *maṣíta* *xel-la* *al-at* *aya* *lexma*
DEM.SG fish.F.SG eat.PST-3SG.F:A DOM-CSTR DEM.SG bread.M.SG
'The fish ate that bread.'

No examples of DOF on its own with specific indefinite referents are known to us. Thus, there seems to be a less strong correlation between DOF and specificity

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than there is between specificity and DOI on its own and between specificity and DOI in combination with DOF.

Unlike indexing, however, DOF can generally not be assigned to an NP that is in clause-initial topic position. Thus, when fronted to initial position to establish the topic of the clause, as shown in (75b), the direct object NP is resumed by an index on the verb, but it is not assigned an overt case marker, which can be contrasted with its 'default' position immediately before the verb, as seen in (75a).

(75) J. Sulemaniyya

a. *bron-i ʾəl-brat-ăxun* *g-be-∅*
son.M.SG-1SG.POSS DOM-daughter.F.SG-2PL.POSS

IND-love-3SG.M:A
'My son loves your daughter.' (Khan 2004b: R:29)

b. *aya brata at g-be gor-ət-ta*
DEM.SG girl.F.SG 2SG.NOM IND-need marry-2SG.M:A-OBL.3SG.F:P
'As for this girl, you need to marry her.' (Khan 2004b: R:§9)

Moreover, human objects that are part of the information that the speaker wishes to highlight as unexpected or important in the discourse are generally not case-marked, even when they are uniquely identifiable (see also Coghill 2010a). The following human object NPs are not case-marked, because they are drawn to the foreground by the speaker.

(76) J. Sanandaj (Khan 2009: A:20))
mani g-b-et
who IND-want-2SG.M:A
'Whom do you want?'

(77) J. Arbel (Khan 1999a: 462.321)
Context: He said, 'Tell me, why have you beaten him?' I said to him, 'He threw three or four stones. Look at the window. Do you see that? Hasn't he broken it? I said to him "Go away, my boy, go away, leave me alone, go away, leave me alone". He did not listen. I ran after him and beat him. So, what do you want? If you want to kill me, kill me, I said. In the end they went away. He went away, he said,
šoq-mun ʾiyya hulaʾa
leave-IMP.PL DEM.SG Jew.M.SG
'Leave that Jew!'

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Differential object flagging is thus assigned on a highly contextual basis, similarly to DOI. However, sporadically, there are instances where DOF seems to be triggered by the inherent properties of the NP. The case-marked direct object can be a human referent within the focal domain. The flagged object NP can thus be human and focal, but uniquely identifiable, such as the specific human referent 'Hitler' in (79),

(78) J. Arbel (Khan 1999a: 444.117)
Ø-ʾam-etune ʾəl-Hitler qaṭəl-Ø-lan?
SBJV-bring-2PL:A DOM-Hitler.M.SG kill-3SG.M:A-OBL.1PL:P
'Would you bring *Hitler* to kill us?'

The flagged object can also be human and *wh*-focal, but not uniquely identifiable, as (79) demonstrates.

(79) J. Saqiz (Israeli 1998: 214)
aḥmad əl-mani g-be-et
Ahmad DOM-who IND-want-2SG.M:A
'Ahmad, whom do you want?'

Moreover, the case-marking of speech act participants is virtually obligatory in some dialects when they are prosodically prominent and in narrow focus. Speech act participants are regularly expressed in the verbal inflection by bound person markers without prosodic prominence. The independent heavy coding of a speech act participant is iconic of the speaker's intention to draw attention to it in the discourse. In the majority of NENA dialects, free unmarked pronouns can serve both as subject and direct object, as (80) shows.

(80) C. Barwar (Khan 2008c: 1716.31)
ʾana ʾati bắy-ən
1SG.NOM 2SG.NOM want-1SG.M:A
'I want *you*.'

This can be contrasted with the NENA dialects that developed a direct object marker, where the free unmarked pronoun expresses the subject and the case-marked pronoun expresses the direct object, as illustrated in (81) – (83). When expressed independently as such, the speech act participants are brought to the foreground in the discourse either because of contrast or narrow focus equivalent to accentuated pronouns in English. This type of DOM can therefore be considered inherent and not contextual.

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(81) J. Solduz (Talay 2009: 192)
ana *əll-ux* *šqəl-li*
1SG.NOM DOM-2SG.M take.PST-OBL.1SG:A
'I bought *you*.'

(82) J. Koy Sanjak (Mutzafi 2004a: 176)
mato ʾati *ʾəll-i* *ṃaṣ-et* *maxəḷṣ-et?*
how 2SG.NOM DOM-1SG can-2SG.M.SG:S save-2SG.M:A
'How will you be able to save *me*?'

(83) C. Urmi
ʾatən *ka* *diyy-i* *bət-katl-ət*
2SG.NOM DOM GEN-1SG FUT-kill-2SG.M:A
'You will kill *me*.'

(84) C. Sara (Talay 2009: 382.17)
ana *y-bayy-ən* *qal-ux*
1SG.NOM IND-want-1SG.M:S DOM-2SG.M.POSS
'I like *you*.'

21.2.3.2 Combination of differential object flagging and indexing

As a general tendency, the NENA dialects that have DOF on its own also optionally have DOI, or a combination of the two, but not the other way around.

First, concerning the Jewish dialects of NENA, those located in Iranian Azerbaijan and eastern Iraqi Kurdistan optionally combine both DOF and DOI. This strategy can also freely occur with inanimate referents that are identifiable to the listener. Moreover, in these dialects, the combination of DOF and DOI is found across the entire verbal system, as shown in (85).

(85) J. Urmi

a. *əl-* *d-ay* *qṭul-le*
DOM- GEN-DEM.SG kill.IMP.SG-OBL.3SG.M:P
'Kill him!' Imperative (Garbell 1965b: 150)

b. *əl-* *d-o* *g-od-ən-ne*
DOM- GEN-DEM.SG IND-do-3SG.M:A-OBL.1SG:P
'That I will do.' Present indicative (Garbell 1965b: 106)

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c. *brat-ox* *əl-* *d-o* *brona*
daughter.F.SG-2SG.M.POSS DOM- GEN-DEM.SG boy.M.SG
abu=la=ll-e
want.PROG=COP.3SG.F:A=OBJ-3SG.M
'Your daughter loves this boy.' Present progressive (Garbell 1965b: 127)

d. *ʾəl-* *d-o* *baxt-éw* *šəwq-a-le*
DOM- GEN-DEM.SG wife-3SG.M.POSS leave.PST-3SG.F:P-OBL.3SG.M:A
ədye-le *g-olk-ət* *noš-ew*
come.PST-OBL.3SG.M:S in-city-CSTR self-3SG.M.POSS
'He left his wife and came to his own city.' Past perfective (Garbell 1965b: 157)

It is not known to what extent specific indefinite NPs can occur with this combination. In rare cases, at least in the dialects of Iranian Azerbaijan, these, too, can be both flagged and indexed, as seen in (86).

(86) J. Urmi (Garbell 1965b: 396.1)
ʾagar ʾəl- *xá-danka bron-ət* *ay-+šultanawe ya juwe* *brona,*
if DOM- one-CLF son.M.SG.-CSTR DEM-king.PL or another boy.M.SG
+taluba=š *∅-hawe-∅* *abu=lat-te,*
beggar.M.SG=ADD SBJV-be-3SG.M:S love.PROG=COP.2SG.F-OBL.3SG.M:P,
la-nxup!
NEG-be_ashamed.IMP.SG
'If you love a son of kings or another boy, even if he be a beggar, do not be ashamed!'

When pronominal direct objects are expressed with flagged independent pronouns, they are in narrow focus. Differential object indexing typically does not occur with direct object NPs in narrow focus. In the Jewish dialects of Iranian Azebaijan and eastern Iraqi Kurdistan, direct object pronouns can, however, be both flagged and indexed, as (87) and (88) demonstrate.

(87) J. Urmi (Garbell 1965b: 155)
əll-a *g-b-ən-na!*
DOM-3SG.F IND-want-3SG.M:A-OBL.3SG.F:P
'Her I want!' (and no other) Exhaustive focus

(88) J. Arbel (Khan 1999a: 440.65)

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dwaʾe k-e-ni ʾəll-an qaṭl-i-lan!
afterwards IND-come-3PL:S DOM-1PL kill-3PL:A-OBL.1PL
'Afterwards they will come to kill us (also).' Additive focus

By contrast, in the Jewish dialects of Iranian Kurdistan, the combination of DOF and DOI is impossible, and the two strategies are mutually exclusive. The two mutually exclusive strategies are illustrated in (89)–(90).

(89) J. Saqiz

a. *əl- d-o k-ol-i-wa (∗-le)*
DOM- GEN-DEM.SG IND-do-3PL:A-PST -OBL.3SG.M:P
'They used to do that.' (Israeli 1998: 199)

b. *bron-an (∗ʾəl-)brat-óx*
son.M.SG-our DOM-daughter.F.SG-2SG.M.POSS
g-be-∅-la
IND-love-3SG.M:A-OBL.3SG.F:P
'Our son loves your daughter.' (Israeli 1998: 176)

(90) J. Sanandaj

a. *(∗həl- d-) ea k-ol-i-wa-le xa ṭaʿim*
DOM- GEN- DEM.SG IND-do-3PL:A-PST -OBL.3SG.M:P one tasty
'They used to make this into something tasty.' (Khan 2009: B:42)

b. *ʾay-brona həl- d-ay brata*
DEM.SG-boy.M.SG DOM- GEN-DEM.SG girl.F.SG
g-be-∅ (∗-la)
IND-love-3SG.M:A-OBL.3SG.F:P
'The boy loves the girl.' (Khan 2009: 319)

Turning to the Christian dialects with DOF, here, sporadically, differential object flagging can optionally be combined with differential object indexing, especially with animate direct object NPs, as (91) illustrates.

(91) C. Lewen (Talay 2009: 108.14)
qṭil-∅-u=l qa tanina
kill.RES.PTCP-M.SG:A-3SG.M:P=COP.3SG.M:A DOM dragon.M.SG
'He killed the dragon.'

In several dialects on the Mosul Plain, when DOF occurs, as given for C. Telkepe in (92), this is obligatorily combined with indexing on the verb (Coghill 2014).

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(92) C. Telkepe (Coghill 2014: 344, glossing adapted)
la- g-be-lə ta xor-e
NEG- IND-love.3SG.M:A-OBL.3SG.M:P DOM friend.M.SG-his
'He does not love his friend.'

In C. Telkepe, recipient and theme NPs cannot be assigned the same (differential) case marker, nor can they both be indexed (see Coghill 2010a). Thus, indexing is reserved for only one of the two arguments, while the recipient argument is always flagged, as demonstrated in (93).

(93) C. Telkepe (Noorlander and Molin field notes)

a. *k-əb-ən ∅-yaw-ən-nə ta Toma (*ta) Ranya*
IND-want-1SG.M:A SBJV-GIVE-1SG.M:A-OBL.3SG.M:R DOM Thomas DOM Ranya
'I want to give Thomas Ranya.' (Lit. 'I want to give him to Thomas Ranya.')

b. *∅-nabl-ax-la ta Rita gəbb-ət Toma*
SBJV-TAKE-1PL:A-OBL.3SG.T DOM Rita.F.SG LOC-CSTR Thomas
'Let's take Rita to Thomas.' (Lit. 'We take her to Rita at Thomas.')

c. *k-əb-ən ∅-yaw-ən-na (*ta) Ranya ta Toma*
IND-want-1SG.M:A SBJV-GIVE-1SG.M:A-OBL.3SG.F.T DOM Ranya DOM Thomas
'I want to give Ranya to Thomas.' (Lit. 'I want to give her Ranya to Thomas.')

In C. Qaraqosh (Khan 2002a: 371), where DOF does not occur with patient NPs, recepients and addressees are typically flagged without any differential treatment, but they can also control DOI, when there is no other nonsubject argument present that is a potential controller of DOI, as the addressees in (94) indicate.

(94) C. Qaraqosh (Khan 2002a: 371)

a. *ʾu-km-amir-∅-a da sot-i*
AND-TR.PST.PFV-say-3SG.M:A-OBL.3SG.F:R DOM grandmother.SG.F-my
'And he said to my grandmother.

b. *da Majid Ḥamad kəm-amir-∅-ə*
DOM Majid Hamad TR.PST.PFV-say-3SG.M:A-OBL.3SG.M:R
'He said to Majid Hamad.'

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By contrast, in the Jewish dialects of Iranian Azerbaijan, the recipient and theme can be assigned the same case marker, but the verb will only index the theme argument, as observed in (95).

(95) J. Urmi (Garbell 1965b: 155)
əl- d-ay +kalo məspy-a-lu +əl-
DOM GEN-DEM.SG bride.F.SG hand_over.PST-3SG.F.T-3PL:A DOM-
hatan
groom.M.SG
'They handed the bride over to the bridegroom.'

21.2.3.3 Corpus-based statistics of DOF

Corpus-based statistics ((Noorlander 2025a)) can give insight into the extent of the optionality of flagging of direct object NPs. A summary of the results are given in Table 21.4 for a small sample of NENA dialects. Definite object NPs are taken as a heuristic, and these are further subdivided into human and nonhuman referents. The results display the number of instances of DOF, irrespective of whether there is an additional index on the verb or not. In comparison to the distribution of indexing, which shows an average of ca. 75% across NENA dialects, flagging is less frequent, with an average of ca. 20%, and least frequent in J. Sanandaj, where only 8% of all definite object NPs are flagged. As expected, these findings suggest a strong correlation between DOF and human definite referents, although it is still highly optional.

Table 21.4: Distribution of flagging among human and nonhuman definite object NPs across a sample of NENA dialects

	Human definite NP % of which flagged	**Nonhuman definite NP % of which flagged**	**Total definite NP % of which flagged**
J. Arbel NENA	15/36 (42%)	2/31 (6%)	17/67 (25%)
J. Sanandaj NENA	9/38 (24%)	0/74 (0%)	9/112 (8%)
J. Urmi NENA	25/44 (57%)	5/62 (8%)	30/106 (28%)

21.2.3.4 Case-marking of A in clauses based on past stem verbs

Generally speaking, the marking of the agent by the 'oblique' preposition *l-* is conditioned by the verb form that is historically derived from a resultative, i.e.,

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either the past stem or the resultative participle, and it is compatible with both active and passive readings. In the majority of NENA dialects, S and A remain in the unmarked case, i.e., they take the default bare form without any adpositional marking. In several conservative NENA dialects, however, the A argument may be flagged by the 'oblique' preposition *l-* under the following conditions: a) the A argument is in narrow or *wh*-focus, b) the presence of a topical P argument (see Noorlander 2021b: 242-243). Flagging of A arguments is incompatible with additional A-indexing and may also occur under verb elipsis, as the following example illustrates. This type of construction, if still productively used in a NENA dialect, is generally no longer productively used by the younger generation of speakers.

(96) C. Marga (Noorlander and Khan field notes)
Mam=u *Zine* *l-măni* *muqəṭl-i(-*le)?*
Mam.M.SG=and Zine.F.SG OBL-who kill.CAUS-3PL:P(-3SG.M:A)
l-Băko *ʿĂwala!*
OBL-Bako.M.SG Awale
'Who had Mam and Zine killed? (It was) Bako Awale (who had them killed)!'

However, the more common construction with the same information structural configuration is shown in (97), where A-past is unmarked and obligatorily indexed on the past stem verb by an oblique L-suffix.

(97) C. Marga (Noorlander and Khan field notes)
Mam=u *Zine* *măni* *muqəṭl-i*(-le)?* *Băko*
Mam.M.SG=and Zine.F.SG who kill.CAUS-3PL:P-3SG.M:A OBL-Bako.M.SG
ʿĂwala!
Awale
'Who had Mam and Zine killed? (It was) Bako Awale (who had them killed)!'

It is worthwhile contrasting this syntactic pattern shown in (96) with a similar phenomenon in Ṭuroyo Neo-Aramaic, a separate group of dialects closely related to NENA. Here, the A-past argument can be optionally flagged by the 'oblique' preposition *l-*. If A-past appears in the oblique case, then it must also be indexed on the past stem verb form by an oblique L-suffix, as illustrated by the following minimal pair.

(98) Ṭuroyo Neo-Aramaic (Noorlander 2021a: 323)

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a. *u-šŭlṭono* *məḷ-ḷe-le*
DEF.M.SG-sultan.M.SG say.PST-OBL.3SG.M:A-OBL.3SG.M:R
l-u-wazir-ayðe
OBL-DEF.M.SG vizier.M.SG-POSS.3SG.M
'The sultan said to his vizier.'

b. *l-u-šŭlṭono* *məḷ-ḷe-le*
OBL-DEF.M.SG-sultan.M.SG say.PST-OBL.3SG.M:A-OBL.3SG.M:R
l-u-waziro
OBL-DEF.M.SG vizier.M.SG
'The sultan said to the vizier.'

Finally, in several NENA dialects, agents can also appear in the 'oblique' case in constructions based on the resultative participle. Such marked agents do occur in texts and can be elicited from speakers in a transitive complex perfect equivalent to the perfective past in 96, shown in (99) and (100), but it is unclear to what extent they are used in everyday language. Agents of an intransitive passive construction also sporadically appear in this 'oblique' case, as illustrated in (101).

(99) C. Aradhin (Noorlander 2026a: 190)
ʾăya *xmarta* *l-măni=la* *qṭəl-ta?*
DEM.F.SG donkey.F.SG OBL-who=COP.3SG.F kill.RES.PTCP-F.SG
'Who has killed this donkey?'

(100) C. Aradhin (Krotkoff 1982: 34)
ʾəll-i=le *wið-a*
OBL-1SG=COP.3SG.M do.RES.PTCP-M.SG
'I (am the one who) did it.'

(101) C. Ṭal (Noorlander 2026a: 179)
la- *payš-a* *šqil-ta* *l-miṛa*
NEG- become.SBJV-3SG.F:S take.RES.PTCP-F.SG:S OBL-emir.M.SG
'that she should not be taken by the emir.'

21.2.3.5 Case-marking of recipient, goal and place complements

Oblique arguments are typically marked by prepositions, which can be optionally omitted. First, recipients of ditransitive verbs such as 'to give' and especially addressees of ditranistive verbs such as 'to say' are typically introduced with a dative preposition, as illustrated in (99)–(101).

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(102) J. Betanure (Mutzafi 2008a: 248.371)
Nəmṛod mər-re ta ʾAvraham
Nimrod.M.SG say.PST-OBL.3SG.M:A to Abraham.M.SG
'Nimrod said to Abraham.'

(103) J. Urmi (Garbell 1965b: 119)
baxta mir-a ba +šultana
woman.F.SG say.PST-OBL.3SG.F:A to king.M.SG
'The woman said to the king.'

(104) C. Diz (Talay 2009: 596.139)
malka mər-re qa bne-biyya diyye
king.M.SG say.PST-OBL.3SG.M:A to son.PL.CSTR-house.M.SG 3SG.M.GEN
'The king said to his family members.'

Such human endpoint arguments can be unmarked and treated like direct objects, but addressees of 'to say' are nearly always case-marked.

Goal arguments of verbs of motion are typically marked by a preposition. When they are unmarked, this is optional and the NP must be inanimate. Their most frequent position is after the verb, as seen in (105)–(107).

(105) J. Zakho (Fassberg 2003: 179)
ʾaxnan g-əb-ax ∅-az-ax ʾəl- ʾEreṣ ʾƏsraʾel.
1PL.NOM IND-want-1PL:A SBJV-go-1PL:S to- land.F.SG.CSTR Israel.F.SG
maṭo b-az-ət ∅ ʾEreṣ ʾƏsraʾel?
how FUT-go-2SG.M:S to land.F.SG.CSTR Israel.F.SG
"'We want to go to the land of Israel." "When will you go to the land of Israel?"'

(106) J. Shəno

a. *zəl-le ∅ šuqa*
go.PST-OBL.3SG.M:S to market.M.SG
'He went to the market.' (Garbell 1965b: 228)

b. *zəl-le g-šuqa*
go.PST-OBL.3SG.M:S to-market.M.SG
'He went to the market.' (Garbell 1965b: 221)

(107) C. Urmi

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a. *xəš-lə* ∅ *+bazar*
go.PST-OBL.3SG.M:S to market.M.SG
'He went to the market.' (Khan 2016b: A28:1)

b. *xúš* *+ʾal +bazar!*
go.IMP.SG to market.M.SG
'Go the the market!' (Khan 2016b: A43:19)

Inanimate place complements are typically marked by a preposition, but, rarely, they can also be optionally left unmarked, as shown in (108)–(109).

(108) J. Urmi (Garbell 1965b: 150)
gor-i ∅ *bela* *lewe*
man.M.SG-POSS.1SG at house.M.SG NEG.PRES.COP.3M.SG
'My husband is not at home.'

(109) C. Urmi (Khan 2016b: A18:2)
+malla *lelə* ∅ *beta*
mullah.M.SG NEG.PRES.COP.3M.SG at house.M.SG
'The mullah is not at home.'

Human goal and place arguments are typically marked by a dedicated preposition, as (110)–(113) illustrate.

(110) C. Umra d-Shish (Noorlander 2025a: 801)
∅-za-la *lwat* *qaddiša*
SBJV-go-OBL.3SG.M:S towards saint.M.SG.
'that she should go to the saint.'

(111) J. Dohok (Molin field notes
zəl-le *kəs-ḥakoma*
go.PST-OBL.3SG.M:S at-king.M.SG
'He went to the king.'

(112) C. Urmi (Khan 2016b: A1:§3)
ʾó-yuma *ʾá* *čačala* *xəš-lə* *cəs...*
DEM.M.SG-day.M.SG DEM.SG baldhead.M.SG go.PST-OBL.3SG.M:S at
+tajər
merchant.M.SG
'On that day the bald man went to the merchant.'

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(113) J. Shəno
zəl-le *geb da-ew*
go.PST-OBL.3SG.M:S at mother.F.SG-3SG.M
'He went to his mother.' (Garbell 1965b: 228)

By contrast, the result outcome of a change-of-state or factitive verb is usually unmarked, as seen in (114a).

(114) a. J. Solduz (Garbell 1965b: 209)
pra *xdər-e* ***dehwé***
earth.SG.M become.PST-OBL.3SG.M:S gold.PL
'The earth turned into pieces of gold.'

b. J. Solduz (Garbell 1965b: 231)
tunnu xurjine *ˁməly-i-la* *dehwe*
both saddle.bag.PL fill.PST-3PL:T-3SG.F:A gold.PL
'She filled both saddle bags (with) pieces of gold.'

The marking of such arguments with the preposition *ba-* among Jewish dialects of western Iran was borrowed from Kurdic, as illustrated in (115).

(115) a. J. Sanandaj (Khan 2009: D:§1)
xir-Ø *ba xá* *broná*
become.PST-3SG.M:S to INDF boy.M.SG
'He became a boy.'

b. J. Sanandaj (Khan 2009: B:§41)
kol-i-wa-le *ba lešà*
make-A.3PL-PST-3SG.M.T to dough.SG.M
'They made it into dough.'

21.3 Flagging and indexing in Arabic

Similarly to NENA dialects, the differential treatment of objects in Mesopotamian Arabic dialects involves differential object indexing (DOI) on its own or differential object flagging (DOF) with a dative preposition (DOF) combined with differential object indexing. The following examples illustrate these two common patterns found across *Qəltu*-Arabic dialects.

(116) J. Arbīl *Qəltu* Arabic (Jastrow 1990a: 72)

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abū-yi *yəštaṛīy-a* *l-ḥənṭa*
father-1SG buy.3SG.M-3SG.F:P DEF-wheat.F.SG
'My father buys the wheat.' Indexing on its own

(117) M. Mosul *Qəltu* Arabic (Jastrow 1979: 49)
ġabb-ə́t-u *lə-l-walad*
raised-3SG.F.A-3SG.M:P DOM-DEF-boy.M.SG
'She raised the boy.' Indexing and flagging combined

In Arabic, differential treatment of salient object NPs, similar to that found in some NENA dialects, is well-documented for a number of Mesopotamian (*Qəltu* and *Gələt*) dialects, for instance the Jewish, Christian and Muslim dialects of Baghdad (Blanc 1964b: 128–130) and the Muslim *Qəltu* dialect of Tikrit (Johnstone 1975: 107–108). It is also well-documented in Levantine Arabic, e.g., in Damascus, Beirut and Galilee dialects (Feghali 1918: 84–85; Brustad 2000: 354–358; Levi 1987) as well as in Levantine Arabic spoken in Turkey (Procházka 2002). For both Levantine and Mesopotamian Arabic, it is generally thought likely to be a substrate feature from Aramaic (e.g., Feghali 1918: 84-85, Diem 1979: 47-49, Coghill 2014, Souag 2017), but see (Pat-El & Stokes 2022) for a contrary view. Where the conditioning of these constructions is discussed, it is usually said to involve definiteness (e.g., Blanc 1964a: 128; Erwin 2004: 334; Jastrow 1990c: 72; Khan 1997: 93), although additional factors are also cited for the better-researched Levantine dialects, such as reactivation of a topic (Brustad 2000: 354), human objects (Cowell 1964: 435) and expression of an emotional attitude (Levi 1987). There is unfortunately no information about differential object flagging or indexing in Jastrow's (1978) survey of the *Qəltu* dialects, or in most grammatical descriptions of the Arabic dialects covered here. Of the dialects spoken in the NENA-speaking region, there is only information for Mosul Arabic, which combines indexing with flagging (Jastrow 1979: 49), and the Jewish dialects of Arbīl and ʿAqra, which have indexing alone (Jastrow 1990a: 72). On the periphery of the NENA region, indexing and flagging appear to be used in the Muslim dialect of Tillo (Lahdo 2009: 157).

Furthermore, corpus-based studies (Noorlander 2023a; Noorlander 2024a; Noorlander 2025a) reveal considerable microvariation across the Arabic dialects. For control groups, we have taken several Arabic varieties located outside the area of the Neo-Aramaic dialects discussed in this volume, namely Mesopotamian Arabic dialects of Khuzestan and Baghdad, as well as Syrian Arabic and Cilician Arabic, which are forms of Levantine Arabic, and Central Asian Arabic, a highly peripheral dialect spoken in Afghanistan. They differ greatly

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as regards the extent to which they make use of direct object flagging and/or indexing. Definite direct object NPs have been taken as a heuristic here. The final column in Table 21.3 shows the comparability of the corpora of spoken narratives in terms of the distribution of definite direct object NPs, with an average of 54%. The second and third columns in Table 21.3 demonstrate the rate at which definite direct object NPs are indexed in respective corpora. At the lowest end, we find Syrian Arabic, with only sporadic occurences of indexing among definite direct object NPs. At the high end, we find the Jewish *Qəltu* Arabic varieties of Iraqi Kurdistan, together with Central Asian Arabic, followed by two other *Qəltu* Arabic dialects, one being that of the Jews of Baghdad, and the other spoken by Muslims of Daragözü in Kozluk in Anatolia.

Table 21.5: Distribution of definites among direct object NPs and distribution of differential object indexing among definite direct object NPs across corpora of Levantine, Mesopotamian and Central Asian Arabic varieties

Dialect	Definite direct object NPs		Direct object NPs	
	Raw total	% of which indexed	Raw total	% of which definite
Syrian Arabic (Levantine)	117	9%	199	66%
Khuzestani Arabic	100	16%	306	35%
Mardini *Qəltu* Arabic	123	21%	232	47%
Diyarbakir *Qəltu* Arabic	144	25%	241	66%
Cilician Arabic (Levantine)	89	31%	172	61%
J. Baghdadi *Qəltu* Arabic	54	50%	163	34%
Kozluk *Qəltu* Arabic	74	53%	160	55%
Central Asian Arabic (Afghanistan)	59	75%	87	68%
J. Kurdistani *Qəltu* Arabic	109	79%	226	52%

21.4 Flagging and indexing in Iranian

21.4.1 Argument indexing

21.4.1.1 Optional and impossible indexing of A in clauses based on past stem verbs

A widespread phenomenon in Iranian languages involves the use of oblique clitics to cross-index the A argument in past transitive constructions (A-past). Generally, four distinct tendencies can be identified within Kurdic (see Figure 21.2 for an overview):

I. In Northern Kurdish and Zazaki, indexing of A-past is impossible, with the exception of third person arguments, which can be indexed by affixal person markers among some Northern Kurdish speakers (see Dorleijn 1996; Haig 2008).

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II. In conservative dialects of Gorani and Kurdish varieties located at the transition between Central and Northern Kurdish, the oblique clitics serve as A-past pronominal indices, and are in complementary distribution with full NPs marked with the oblique case;

III. In Central Kurdish and peripheral Gorani varieties, oblique clitics are obligatory, serving as cross-indexing morphemes, i.e., they can occur with and without a co-nominal.

IV. In Bajalani varieties of Gorani, oblique clitics serve to cross-index both A-past and S-past arguments (see §13.3.4.4);

V. In Southern Kurdish, S-past and A-past are never indexed by means of oblique clitics. Instead, they are indexed by affixal person markers exactly like their counterparts in clauses based on present stem verb forms (see §13.3.4.2).

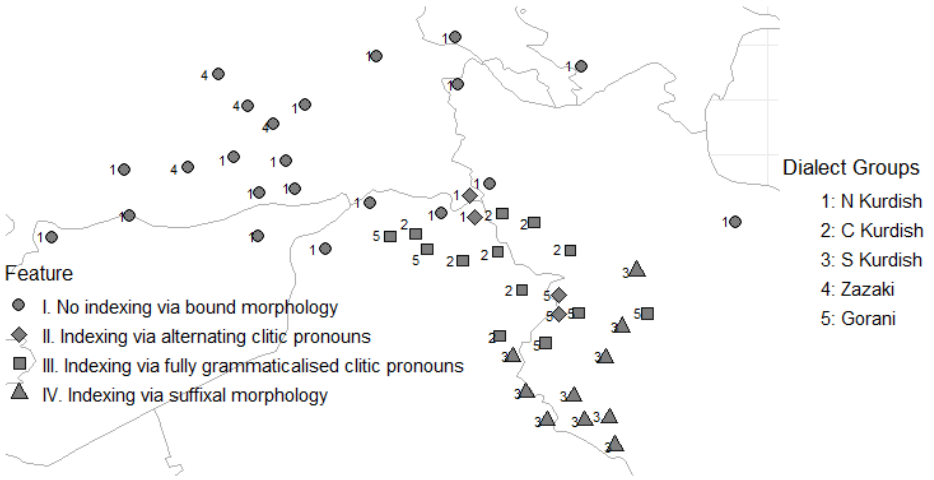

Figure 21.2: Indexation of past tense transitive subjects within Kurdish

The Kurdic languages in Group II employ oblique clitics as agent indices, but unlike Group III, this is not obligatory. In Hewramî, various factors contribute to the inhibition of indexing, including the focality of the A argument, animacy, and clause type (see Mohammadirad & Haig 2026 for a recent overview). Typical

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examples of focused A arguments include focused arguments in constituent (wh-) questions and polar questions (118), and clauses featuring contrastive focus (119)

(118) Hewramî Tekht (Mohammadirad forthcoming)
m-aç-o *miłk ehmeđ î* *dijmen-ê-m=e*
IND-say.PRS-3SG:A PN PN DEM.PROX enemy-DIR.PL=OBL.1SG=DEM
kê *kuştê=nê* ***tò*** *kuştê=nê*
who kill.PST.PTCP.PL=COP.3PL:P 2SG kill.PST.PTCP.PL=COP.3PL:P
'He (the king) said, Oh Milk Ahmad! **Who** has killed my enemies? Have **YOU** killed them?' [ME.150]

(119) Hewramî Tekht (Mohammadirad forthcoming)
kuř-û *min* ***řozgary-a*** *ne-kuşte=n* ***xwa-y***
son-EZ.GEN 1SG PN-OBL.PL kill.PST.PTCP.M=COP.3SG.M:P God-OBL.M
kuşte=n
kill.PST.PTCP.M=COP.3SG.M:P
'**The Rozgaris** did not kill my son, **God** killed him.' [HM.08]

In the Kurdish varieties that are located in a transitional area between the Northern and Central Kurdish dialect groups, the agent index is incompatible with the presence of a co-nominal (Öpengin & Mohammadirad 2022), and thus the oblique clitic serves as a pro-index rather than a cross-index (Haspelmath 2013).

(120) Surçi NK (MacKenzie 1962: 228)

a. *min* *le_bo xo* *rencber-ek* *girt,*
1SG.OBL for REFLX labourer-INDF keep.PST.3SG
'I hired a labourer,'

b. *hinar=im-e* *cot,* *şiwan-ek=iş=im*
send.PST=OBL.1SG:A=DRCT plough shepherd-INDF=ADD=OBL.1SG:A
girt
keep.KEEP.PST
'I sent him to the plough, (then) I also hired a shepherd.'

This is essentially the same system as Shaqlawa CK, e.g.,

(121) CK Shaqlawa

a. *şey* *xo* *şard=ewe* *le pişt* *dar-î*
dog-M.SG.OBL REFLX hid.PST=COMPL in behind tree-M.OBL
'The dog hid behind the tree.' (Khan et al. 2022b: 194)

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b. *be xwa xwa-y da*
by God God-M.OBL give.PST
'By God, God granted [it to me].' (Mohammadirad, fieldnote)

21.4.1.2 Object indexing in clauses based on past stem verbs

In the Iranian dialects discussed here, the indexing of direct object NPs only occurs in clauses that contain a past stem verbal form. As discussed in §13.3, different sets of person markers can serve as object indices. In past transitive constructions, a direct object NP may be cross-indexed with an affixal person marker attached to the past stem verb in conservative varieties of Northern Kurdish and in conservative varieties of Gorani. In Behdînî NK, the indexing of direct objects is obligatory, and there appears to be no semantic-referential restriction on object indexing. The indexing is solely conditioned by the usage of a past stem verbal form. In perfect constructions, as shown in (122b), the ezafe copula expresses the number of the P argument, while the affixal person marker indexes the person of the P argument.

(122) NK Behdînî

a. *me hirç kuşt-in*
1PL.OBL bear.PL.DIR kill.PST-3PL:P
'We killed bears.'

b. *me hirç yêt kuştî-n*
1PL.OBL bear.PL.DIR EZ.PL kill.PST.PTCP-3PL:P
'We have killed bears.'

In Hewramî, a recent corpus-based study by Mohammadirad (2025a) reveals that 82% of past transitive clauses with overt object NPs contain an object index on the verb, thus illustrating a high proportion of object indexing within the context of Iranian languages. The differential indexing of direct objects is triggered by a multitude of factors including the person of the direct object, animacy, and whether the object NP is modified. Among these factors, the object NP being third person plural is a strong predictor of object indexing. Consider the difference between the following examples:

(123) Hewramî Tekht (Mohammadirad 2025a)

a. ***yerê hêłê**=ş ard-ê*
three egg.DIR.PL=3SG:A take.PST-**3PL:P**
'She took three eggs.' [HS.82]

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b. ***penc*** *çemç(e)-ê=şa*
five spoon.M-DIR.PL=OBL.3PL:A
*nîya=**n**=re*
put.PST.PTCP.**M=COP.3SG.M:P**=POVB
'They (my family) had set [the cloth with] five spoons.' [JE.46]

There appears to be no correlation between constituent order and the presence of object indexing. When the object NP is fronted to a topic position, i.e., in OAV clauses, it is regularly indexed on the verb as verbal person suffix in past transitive clauses, but this is not a primary conditioning factor, e.g.,

(124) Hewramî Tekht (Mohammadirad 2026)

a. *î* *dijmen-ê=m=e* *kê*
DEM.PROX enemy-PL.DIR=OBL.1SG:PSR=DEM who
kuştê=nê
kill.PST.PTCP.PL=COP.3PL:P
'Who killed my enemies?' [ME.150]

b. *werês(e)-ekê* *mìn* *warđê=ne*
rope-DEF.F.SG 1SG eat.PST.PTCP.F=COP.3SG.F:P
'[The lion said], 'I have eaten the rope.' [ÇH.85]

In central and northern varieties of CK, object indexing is incompatible with a co-nominal in the same local domain; instead, the index occurs as a substitute for an NP, and thus it always serves as a pro-index rather than a cross-index, following Haspelmath (2013).

(125) Central Kurdish (Haig 2018a: 803)
dena ***ewan**$_i$=î* *de-kuşt/*-**in**$_i$*
otherwise them.P=OBL.3SG:A IPFV-kill.PST-3PL:P
'Otherwise he would kill them.'

21.4.2 Argument flagging

21.4.2.1 Case marking of A in clauses based on past stem verbs

Case marking of past transitive agents depends on various factors. Among the Iranian languages of the region, it is found in Hewramî, NK, and Zazaki, and–to a much lesser extent–northern varieties of CK. In the Tekht variety of Hewramî, oblique case marking appears on 86% of past transitive agents in the study of Mohammadirad (2024a). In Hewramî, case distinction has been lost for speech

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act pronouns. For third person pronouns and lexical nouns, oblique case marking on the agent is available for non-human referents, including inanimate agents (126a), non-human animate (126b), and human referents (126c).

(126) Hewramî Tekht (Mohammadirad 2026)

a. *îse cawê kerdêne çêro.*
*îse caw(e)-**ê** kerdê=ne çêr=o*
now road-OBL.F do.PST.PTCP.F=COP.3SG.F:P under=POST
'Now, the stone is laid under the road.' [ZP.53]

b. *mar-êw-î gest-a*
*mar-êw-**î** gest-**a***
snake-INDF-OBL.M bite.PST-1SG:P
'A snake bit me.' [MP.09]

c. *padşay desûriş dan be minû.*
*padşa-**î** desûr=iş da=n be*
king.M-SG.OBL order.M=OBL.3SG:A give.PST.PTCP.M=COP.3SG.M:P to
min=û
1SG=and
'The king has ordered me [to do this].' [JP.209]

By contrast, in Hewramî Luhon, oblique case marking is only available for inanimate agents (MacKenzie 1966: 51). It is only possible when the A NP is focused (as illustrated in 127). A NPs with human (127b) and non-human animate (127c) referents do not receive case marking.

(127) Hewramî Luhon

a. (MacKenzie 1966: 51)
*yex-eke **germa-y** tawna=we*
ice-DEF heat-M.OBL melt.PST=COMPL
'The heat melted the ice.'

b. (MacKenzie 1966: 68)
padşa wat=iş
king.M.DIR say.PST=OBL.3SG:A
'The king said.'

c. (MacKenzie 1966: 68)
mar-eke wat=iş
snake-DEF.M.DIR say.PST=OBL.3SG:A
'The snake said.'

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Therefore, the two Hewramî varieties differ in the extent of oblique marking with agent NPs. Unlike Luhon, Hewramî Tekht has retained oblique marking for all past agent referents irrespective of animacy (except for speech act pronouns, as explained above). Oblique case marking is occasionally absent in Tekht, which can be accounted for, among other factors, by the 'global prominence' of the A referent. According to McGregor's (2006) "Expected Actor Principle", in episodes of discourse with an expected Actor, the actor can be left unmarked after its introduction. Any deviation from the expected actor is marked in the ergative case. Similarly, in Hewramî, a topic that is continued in discourse may lose the oblique case, appearing instead in the direct case. In the following excerpt, the established direct-marked topic of the intransitive clause in (128a) is repeated in the following transitive clause (128b), even though the oblique form *ađîşa* is expected (see Mohammadirad 2024a for a detailed discussion).

(128) Hewramî Tekht

a. *tenya ađê luwɛnê.*
tenya ***ađê*** *luwɛ=nê*
only 3PL.DIR go.PST.PTCP.PL=COP.3PL:S
'Only they (Baba Khwada, Hama the Invisible, and Little Hama) went [to Iraq].'

b. *êtir ađê watenşa, 'ême diruwê meyeymê.*
êtir ***ađê*** *wate=n=şa* *ême*
DISC.PTCL 3PL.DIR say.PST.PTCP.M=COP.3SG.M.P=OBL.3PL:A 1PL
diruwê me-de-ymê
lie.F NEG.IND-give.PRS-1PL:A
'They said, 'We are not going to lie." [BP.116-BP.117]

Within NK, oblique case marking of agent NPs is most robust in the Behdînî group. In the Northern varieties, e.g., Muş, the case distinction is lost on A NPs that are nouns, but retained on pronouns.

IN CK, case marking is generally absent on agent NPs. The following examples can be considered remnants of an earlier stage of CK which possessed oblique case marking on agents.

(129) CK Shaqlawa

a. *şey* *xo* *şard=ewe* *le pişt* *dar-î*
dog-M.SG.OBL REFLX hid.PST=COMPL in behind tree-M.OBL
'The dog hid behind the tree.' (Khan et al. 2022b: 194)

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b. *be xwa xwa-y da*
by God God-M.OBL give.PST
'By God, God granted [it to me].' (Khan et al. 2022b: 124)

21.4.2.2 Case marking of direct object

Case marking of direct object arguments may be sensitive to salience in the Kurdish languages. In standard descriptions of Central and Northern Kurdish, there is no report of differential object marking (see Öpengin 2016, Haig 2018b, among others). Therefore, for example, in Behdînî NK, direct object arguments are case marked regardless of salience and animacy distinctions. The case-marked direct object is non-specific in (130a), specific in (130b), and definite in (130c).

(130) NK Duhok (Khan et al. 2022b)

a. ***gul-a*** *têda t-çîn-îtin*
flower-PL.OBL in_it IND-plant.PRS-3SG:A
'She plants some flowers in it.'

b. *kes-ek şi wane* ***hêk-ek-ê*** *şikên-îtin*
person-INDF from 3PL.OBL egg-INDF-OBL.F break.PRS-3SG:A
'One of them cracked an egg.'

c. ***cilk-a*** *t-şo-tin*
clothes-PL.OBL IND-wash.PRS-3SG:A
'She washes the clothes.'

Similarly, in northern dialects of Central Kurdish, the oblique case is used for direct objects in present-tense constructions regardless of salience and animacy. The case-marked O argument is non-specific in (131a), specific in (131b), and definite in (131c).

(131) CK Shaqlawa

a. ***dan-î*** *e-xo-n*
seed-M.SG.OBL IND-eat.PRS-3PL
'They were eating seed(s).' (Khan et al. 2022b: 124)

b. ***kurît-ek-î*** *lo xo durust de-ka*
shed-INDF-OBL for REFLX right IND-do.PRS.3SG:A
'She makes a shed for herself.'

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c. ***qanûn-eke-y*** *cê* *be cê* *ke-yn*
rule-DEF-OBL place by place do.PRS.SBJV-1PL:A
'[Let us] perform the rule that we established.' (Khan et al. 2022b: 128)

On the other hand, case marking on direct objects in Hewramî exhibits some traces of differential object marking. The most important factor conditioning DOM is the definiteness status of P referents in discourse (Mohammadirad in review). In both (132a) and (132b), *pîya* 'man' is plural and the direct object of a present-tense verb. The direct marking in (132a) is due to the fact that 'men' has non-specific reference, as opposed to the oblique marking in (132b), where it has definite reference.

(132) Hewramî Tekht (Mohammadirad 2026)

a. ***pîyɛ*** *ber-a*
man.PL.DIR take.PRS.IND-3PL:A
'They are taking men [to service].' [JF.18]

b. *î* ***pîya-ya*** *to* *zan-î* *kamê=nê*
DEM.PROX man-PL.OBL 2SG know.PRS.IND-2SG which.PL=COP.3PL:S
'These men, you know who they are.' [HM.39]

Similarly, non-human entities with non-specific reference are not case-marked, as illustrated in (133).

(133) *toîç nan werî.*
to=îç ***nan*** *wer-î*
2SG=ADD bread.DIR.M eat.PRS.IND-2SG:A
'[and] you will eat [a] meal.' [HB.41]

21.4.2.3 Case marking of recipient, goal and place complements

Differential case marking on non-core arguments, such as recipients, locatives, instruments, addressees, and goals, depends on several factors within Iranian. The topic has been researched within Kurdish in Zazaki (Dogan 2022) and Hewramî (Mohammadirad 2025b). In Zazaki, differential case marking on non-core arguments can be triggered by definiteness (as illustrated in (134a)-(134b)).

(134) Zazaki (Dogan 2022: 53)

a. *ez* *nî* ***astar-î=rê*** *ju şare* *von*
1SG DEM star-OBL=to a song say.PRS.1SG
'[…] I sing a song to **that star**' (PU_m3: Q32)

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b. *milet roc=rê duay ken-o, hama* ***astari=rê*** *duay*
people sun-Ø=to prayer do.PRS-3SG.M but star.DIR=to prayer
nê-ken-o
NEG-do.PRS-3SG.M
'One does pray to the sun, but not to the stars (lit. **a star**)' (PU_m3: Q22)

Animacy may also trigger differential case marking in Zazaki. It may work in conjunction with definiteness, as seen in the comparison between the following pairs.

(135) Zazaki (Dogan 2022)

a. ***her bira-y=rê*** *ju woe lazim=a*
INDF brother-OBL=to a sister need=COP.3SGF
'Every brother needs a sister.' (PU_m3: Q14)

b. *Na motor* ***eve dü*** *gureen-o*
DEM engine with smoke.DIR work.PRS-3SG.M
'This engine works with smoke.' (MA_m3: Q82)

In Hewramî, the presence of oblique case marking on non-core arguments depends on a combination of different factors. The most important predictor for oblique case marking is the type of flagging: while prepositional and circumpositional flagging trigger oblique marking, postpositional flagging and the non-core argument being bare (i.e. not flagged with an adposition) trigger direct case marking of the argument.

(136) Hewramî (Mohammadirad 2025b)

a. *ber-o=we* ***pey şar-î***
take.PRS.IND-3SG:A=POST to town-M.SG.OBL
'He took (him) into town.' [PW.41]

b. *gêł=o* ***şar-eke-ne***
wander.PRS.IND-3SG:S town.M-DEF.SG.DIR-POST
'He wandered in town.' [BP.148]

c. *luwa* ***şar***
go.PST.3SG.M:S town.DIR
'He went into town.' [BB.27]

Another factor triggering differential case marking on non-core arguments is whether the non-core argument is possessed. Here, there is a strong tendency

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against oblique case marking on the possessed argument, which is due to the incompatibility of case marking and ezafe marking in the same slot. The only exception is when the possessed argument is marked in the plural oblique.

(137) Hewramî Tekht (Mohammadirad 2025b)

a. *luwa pey* ***dos****-û jenê*
go.PST.3SG:S to friend-EZ.GEN woman.F.SG.OBL
'He went to the woman's lover.'

b. *lo-dê la* ***dos-eka*** *wê=m*
go.PRS.IMP-2PL:S to friend-DEF.PL.OBL REFLX=OBL.1SG
'Go to my friends.'

Role is reported to be another important factor in the oblique case marking of non-core arguments in Hewramî. Here, arguments expressing human roles, e.g., recipient, addressee, are more likely to be case marked than arguments expressing non-human semantics. In the following examples, the non-core arguments are all bare. However, only those expressing human referents are case-marked.

(138) Hewramî (Mohammadirad 2025b)

a. *xeber=şa da patşa-y*
news=3PL:A give.PST king.M.SG.OBL
'They passed the news to the king.' [DB.310]

b. *xepl(e)-êwe=şa da-b-ê*
bread-INDF=OBL.3PL:A give.PST.PTCP.M-be.PRS-AUG.3SG:P
řosem-î
PN-M.SG.OBL
'They had given a loaf of bread to Rosem.'

c. *to=yç ber-a yane*
2SG=ADD take.PRS.IND-3PL:A house.M.DIR
'They will take you to the house.' [HB.38]

d. *îna-∅ yane=ta*
DEIC-3SG.M:S house.M=OBL.2PL
'He is in your house.' [KŞ.51]

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21.5 Flagging and indexing in Armenian

21.5.1 Argument indexing

21.5.1.1 Obligatory indexing of subjects

In general, throughout the history of the Armenian language, there has been agreement in person and number with the subject relation (S and A) of finite verbs, as seen in (139), (140), (141).

(139) Classical Armenian (Kim & Kölligan 2020: 25)
ew gay-in aṙ na berē-in andamaloyc mi
and come-IPF.3PL PRP 3SG.ACC bring-IPF.3PL lame one
'And they came to him [and] brought a paralytic.' (Mark 2.3)

(140) SEA (*Bible: New Etchmiadzin* 2020)
ek-an nra mot, ber-el-ov mi andamaluyc-i
come-AOR.3PL DEM3.GEN CLOSE bring-INF-INS one lame-dat
'And they came to him, bringing a paralytic.' (Mark 2.3)

(141) SWA (https://asdvadzashunch.blogspot.com/2019/05/margos.html#two)
iren čʿors mard-ov vercʿ-u-ac andamaloyc mə
3SG.DAT four man-INS take-PASS-RES.PTCP lame one
ber-in.
bring-AOR.3PL
'They brought to him a paralytic carried by four men.' (Mark 2.3)

The only exception concerns the Classical Armenian perfect tense. This tense is formed of the participle and an optional copula, which, while it generally shows agreement with intransitive subjects, in transitive constructions, where the subject takes genitive case and the object accusative case, agrees with neither subject or object, showing default 3SG agreement (see e.g., Meyer 2023: 138-9), as seen in (142).

(142) Classical Armenian (Meyer 2023: 139)
ew gitem tʿē lseal ē z=xorhurds mer
and know-PRS.1SG CONJ hear-PTCP be.PRS.3SG ACC-plan-ACC.PL 1PL.GEN
Parskacʿ kapen z=na ew vštacʿucʿanen
Persian.GEN.PL bind-PRS.3SG ACC-3SG and torment-PRS.3PL
'I know that [if] the Persians have heard our plans, they [will] imprison him and torment [him].'

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To our knowledge, this system has not survived in any form of modern Armenian.

21.5.1.2 Pronominal indices for direct objects

In general, Armenian does not have object agreement. Cognitively accessible objects are usually expressed by zero anaphora, as seen in (143).

(143) Colloquial Yerevan Armenian (Hodgson et al. 2024: 361)
dəra hamaɾ=a nəviɾ-um
DEM2.GEN for=be.3SG.PRS give-I.PTCP
'He gives **it to her** because of that.'

However, in some dialects spoken in Iran, including Urmia, Khoy, and Tehran Armenian, the "possessive articles" (see §11.4.2) have expanded their functionality to resemble that of the so-called "Set 2" clitics (see Stilo & Noorlander 2015) found in NENA and other languages of the area, which, as well as expressing possessors, also function as person markers on verbs, expressing direct object agreement on transitive verbs, as well as agents of past transitives in NENA and some Iranian languages. In the Armenian dialects in question, they may be used to express first and second person direct objects of transitive verbs (144, 145), as well as addressees and beneficiaries, as discussed in §21.5.1.3 (see Asatryan 1962: 136, Dolatian et al. 2023: 171ff.). In the dialect described by Dolatian et al. (2023), this strategy is only available for second person referents.

(144) Urmia Armenian (Asatryan 1962: 136)
əmnoɾ t^{h}əp^{h}el=i=s
every.day beat.I.PTCP=be.3SG.PRS=ART1
's/he beats me every day.'

(145) Urmia Armenian (Asatryan 1962: 136)
oroxkets^{h}=əs yɾes tun-ə
send.3SG.AOR=ART1 3PL.GEN house-DEF
's/he sent me to their house.'

21.5.1.3 Pronominal indices for recipient-like arguments

In general, Armenian does not have any form of verb agreement with obliques. However, in those dialects spoken in Iran where the "possessive articles" have taken on some of the other functions of the multi-purpose "Set 2" clitics found

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in NENA and some other languages of the area (see §13), these may attach to the verb and express referents with certain oblique roles, notably addressee 146 and beneficiary 147, in addition to direct object as discussed in §21.5.1.2.

(146) Colloquial Iranian Armenian (Dolatian et al. 2023: 176)
me ban as-em=ət
one thing tell-PRS.SBJV.1SG=art2
'Let me tell you something.'

(147) Urmia Armenian (Acharyan 1911: 284)
me tsi pərn-enk^h=t
one horse catch-PRS.SBJV.1PL=ART2
'Let's catch a horse for you.'

21.5.2 Argument flagging

21.5.2.1 Case-marking of subjects

In general, subjects (S and A) of finite verbs, including the copula, in Classical and modern Armenian are unmarked for case.

An exception concerns the Classical Armenian perfect, where subjects of transitive verbs, and some agentive subjects of intransitive verbs, are marked with genitive case, as seen in (148).

(148) Classical Armenian (Vaux 2005: 1)
nora ē gorc-eal
3SG.GEN be.PRS.3SG do-PTCP
'(s)he has done/accomplished (it)'

Benveniste (1952) shows that this construction is modelled on possessive expressions such as (149), which can be literally translated as 'of him there is a dress'.

(149) Classical Armenian (Hewson & Bubenik 1997: 75)
nora ē handerj
3SG.GEN be.PRS.3SG dress
'(s)he has a dress'

According to Meyer (2023), the development of this construction was influenced by Iranian, in particular Parthian, models.

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Some modern Armenian dialects, notably Karabagh and Agulis, have dative subjects not only for predicative possession (150), but also for the subject of the verb *unenal* 'to have' (151, 152) (see §24 for more details on these constructions).

(150) Agulis Armenian (Tanakert) (Hodgson 2022a)
ændz el-æts=æ ɨrik^{h} axpaɾ
1SG.DAT=be-RES.PTCP be.3SG.PRS three brother
'I had three brothers.'

(151) Agulis Armenian (Tsghna) (Hodgson 2022a)
yræn nəkaɾ-neɾ on-i nel
3SG.DAT picture-PL have-3SG PST
'He had pictures.'

(152) Karabagh Armenian (Martirosyan 2019: 92)
ʃinæts^{h}i Sɨrk^{j}is-i-n Maɾal ənəm-av min kov uneɾ
villager Sargis-DAT-DEF Maral name-INS one cow have-PRS.3SG
'The villager Sargis had a cow called Maral.'

In Hamshen dialect, there is a progressive construction in which the subject can appear in genitive case (153). Vaux (2005: 3) considers that this construction, too, is probably of possessive origin, as Hamshen dialect has an alternative progressive with the verb 'to have' (154). In both cases, the main verb has default 3SG agreement.

(153) Hamshen Armenian (Acharyan 1947: 140-1)
im-s eg-uʃ=æ
1SG.GEN-ART1 come-INF=be.PRS.3SG
'I am coming'

(154) Hamshen Armenian (Acharyan 1947: 140-1)
b^{h}eɾ-im g-un-i
bring-PRS.SBJV.1SG PTCL-have-PRS.3SG
'I am bringing'

21.5.2.2 Case marking of objects

In Classical Armenian, most direct objects were unmarked for case, but there was a form of differential object flagging by which only definite/specific direct objects (the precise semantic properties associated with this element have been

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the subject of some discussion, see e.g., Danon-Boileau & Donabédian 1995) were marked with the preposition *z-*, as seen in 142. This system has survived in some modern dialects, notably Mush, as seen in (155), and most of the dialects placed by Jahukyan (1972) in the Van group, with the exception of Van city itself, as well as some dialects of Syria, that of Ordu on the Black Sea coast, and Suceava and Kuti in the Balkans (Jahukyan 1972).

(155) Mush Armenian (Baghdasaryan-Tapaltsyan 1958: 200)
g-eln-an *kʰur-eɾ,* *kə-təglozts*^{h}*-un* *z-aɣ-en*
PTCL-get.up-PRS.3PL sister-PL PTCL-strip.naked-PRS.3PL ACC-agha-DEF
'The sisters get up and strip the agha naked.'

Baghdasaryan-Tapaltsyan (1958: 80) states that in Mush dialect, the accusative preposition is used on objects that have "definite meaning". Unlike the dative-based DOM found in other modern Armenian dialects, it is not sensitive to animacy, appearing on objects that are definite but inanimate, as seen in (156).

(156) Mush Armenian (Baghdasaryan-Tapaltsyan 1958: 200)
k-ar-in *z-oske-stan*
PTCL-take-PRS.3PL ACC-gold-PL
'They take the gold pieces.'

Many more modern dialects, including SEA and essentially all Eastern dialects, including Urmia, but also Van and a few other Western dialects (Khotorjur, Erzurum, the dialects spoken around Rostov-on-Don) (Jahukyan 1972), use an innovative system whereby animate direct objects receive dative case marking if they are definite 157, and may do if they are specific indefinite 158. Non-specific indefinite animate DOs do not receive case-marking 159, nor do inanimate DOs, even if they are definite 160. Donabédian (p.c.) notes that this system is also used by some speakers in colloquial registers of SWA.

(157) SEA (Hodgson 2022b: 142)
ostikan-i-n=em *pʿntr-um*
policeman-DAT-DEF=be.PRS.1SG look.for-I.PTCP
'I am looking for the policeman.'

(158) SEA (Hodgson 2022b: 142)
mi *ostikan-i=em* *pʿntr-um,* *vor-i* *anun-ə*
one policeman-DAT=be.PRS.1SG look.for-I.PTCP, which-GEN name-DEF
Połos=ē
Poghos=be.PRS.3SG
'I am looking for a (specific) policeman, whose name is Poghos.'

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(159) SEA (Hodgson 2022b: 142)
ostikan=em *pʿntr-um,* *baycʿ čʿ-em* *karoł*
policeman=be.PRS.1SG look.for-I.PTCP, but NEG-be.PRS.1SG find-INF
gtn-el

'I am looking for a (non-specific) policeman, but I can't find one.'

(160) SEA (Dum-Tragut 2009: 62)
es *vard-ə* *gt-a*
1SG.NOM rose-DEF find-AOR.1SG
'I found the rose.'

In SEA, DOM appears to be directly linked to the presence of the definite article, so that an animate object that is semantically indefinite but receives the definite article will receive DOM. This can be seen in examples with negative pronouns (161), and also with interrogatives with *vor* 'which' (162), which requires the definite article on the noun it modifies, thus the nouns receive DOM even though they are not semantically definite.

(161) SEA (Dum-Tragut 2009: 143)
ays *kʿałakʿ-um očʿ* *mek-i-n* *čʿ-em* *čanačʿ-um*
DEM1 town-LOC NEG one-DAT-DEF NEG-be.PRS.1SG know-I.PTCP
'In this town I know nobody.'

(162) SEA
vor *ałčʿk-a-n=es* *uz-um*
Which girl-DAT-DEF=be.PRS.3SG want-I.PTCP
'Which girl do you want?'

However, in Urmia dialect, if an animate object is semantically indefinite, it does not always receive DOM even if the definite article is present, as seen in example (162), which corresponds to the SEA example (161) with interrogative *vor* and the definite article on the noun, but has no DOM.

(163) Urmia Armenian (Asatryan 1962: 156)
vir *axtʃʰiy-n=es* *yzeli*
Which girl-DEF=be.PRS.3SG want-I.PTCP
'Which girl do you want?'

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Aside from its interaction with definiteness, DOM in SEA does not seem to be directly affected by information structure: both objects with narrow focus, which attract the enclitic copula (164), and fronted topical objects (165) generally receive DOM if they are animate and definite.

(164) SEA (Tamrazian 1994: 36)
Siran-ə *Surik-i-n=ē* *sir-um*
Siran-DEF Surik-DAT-DEF=be.PRS.3SG love-I.PTCP
'Siran loves SURIK'

(165) SEA (Tamrazian 1994: 8)
Surik-i-n *Siran-ə* *čanačʿ-um=ē*
Surik-DAT-DEF Siran-DEF know-I.PTCP=be.PRS.3SG
'Siran knows Surik'

Formal SWA has accusative forms only of some pronouns (see 9.13); non-pronominal objects are unmarked for case, regardless of definiteness, animacy etc., as seen in 166.

(166) SWA (Sakayan 2012: 54)
Aram-ə *kə* *sir-ē* *ir* *ənker-ə*
Aram-DEF PTCL love-PRS.3SG 3SG.GEN friend-DEF
'Aram likes his friend.'

21.5.2.3 Case-marking of recipient, goal and place complements

Obliques of various kinds may receive dative (recipient, some goals, some time and place expressions), ablative (starting point in place or time, some stimulus objects, passive agents, partitives), instrumental (entity by which or with which something takes place, time expressions of duration, place expressions of passing through), or locative (static location) case. However, under some circumstances, oblique arguments may be unmarked for case.

Goal arguments of verbs of motion are generally unmarked for case when they are inanimate, as seen in (167).

(167) SEA Hodgson (2019b: 20)
Vardan-ə *gn-um=ē* *Erevan*
Vardan-DEF go-I.PTCP=be.PRS.3SG Yerevan
'Vardan is going to Yerevan.'

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The goals of certain verbs, e.g., *motenal* 'to approach', *kpčʿel* 'to touch', take dative case, whether they are animate, as in (168), or inanimate (169), (171).

(168) Colloquial EA (EANC ArmFilmNarr)
moten-um=a *Gevorg-i-n*
approach-I.PTCP=be.PRS.3SG Gevorg-DAT-DEF
'He approaches Gevorg.'

(169) Colloquial EA (EANC ArmFilmNarr)
moten-um=a *... ed* *sərah-i-n*
approach-I.PTCP=be.PRS.3SG ... DEM2 hall-DAT-DEF
'He approaches that hall.'

(170) SEA https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=R4wtA9qXIyk
erexa-yi-n=ē *kpel*
child-DAT-DEF=be.PRS.3SG touch-PST.PTCP
'He touched the child.'

(171) SEA https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=op85WrDk73I
kʿitʿ-ə *kpel=ē* *getn-i-n*
nose-ART3 touch-PST.PTCP=be.PRS.3SG ground-DAT-DEF
'His nose touched the ground.'

Body parts as goals generally take dative case, as in (172).

(172) SEA https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=HTytoe3mNoo
otkʿ-ə *drel=ē* *glx-i-n*
foot-ART3 put-PST.PTCP=be.PRS.3SG head-DAT-ART3
'He put his foot on her head.'

Human goals can also take dative case, as in (173) but they are more usually expressed with adpositions (in SEA, typically the postposition *mot* 'close'), as seen in (174).

(173) Agulis Armenian (Paraka) (Hodgson 2021)
taɾ-ejk *as* *intʃʰ* *tʰakʰavoɾ-i-n*
take-IMP.2PL DEM1 what king-DAT-DEF
'Take (it) to this (lit. this what) king.'

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(174) SEA https://www.facebook.com/100055208264497
u nranc‘ tan-um=en t‘agavor-i mot
and 3PL.DAT take-I.PTCP=be.PRS.3PL king-GEN close
‘And they take them to the king.’

Locative complements, if inanimate, are usually expressed with locative case in those dialects that possess it (most Eastern dialects, with the exception of the Urmia area and Bayazet), as seen in (175). In SEA, locative case cannot be used with animate referents. In other Eastern dialects, such as Agulis, the rule is not absolute, but even here, locative case is rarely used for human and body part referents.

(175) Colloquial EA (EANC ArmFilmNarr)
u tents^{h} bant-um=a lin-um
and so prison-LOC=be.PRS.3SG be-I.PTCP
‘And so he is in prison.’

Body parts as locations generally take dative case, as seen in (176).

(176) Colloquial EA (EANC ArmFilmNarr)
u koka kola=ya lin-um dzer-i-n
and coca cola=be.PRS.3SG be-I.PTCP hand-DAT-DEF
‘And there is (a cup of) coca cola in his hand.’

Humans as locations are usually expressed with postpositions (*mot* ‘close’, as in (177), or *kołk‘ə / kołk‘in* ‘(by) side’, as in (178)).

(177) SEA https://hayeli.am/?p=40441&l=am
mez mot deŕ hayeren xos-el nuynisk
1PL.DAT close still Armenian speak-INF even
patgamavor-ner č‘-git-en
member.of.parliament-PL NEG-know-PRS.3PL
‘In our country (lit. close to us), even members of parliament still don’t know how to speak Armenian.’

(178) Colloquial EA (EANC ArmFilmNarr)
ty^{h}ə-k-a hima im koxk^{h}in
NEG-exist-PRS.3SG now 1SG.GEN side
‘He isn’t at my side (i.e., where I am) now.’

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In dialects which lack locative case, such as SWA and Urmia, the postposition *meǰ* (and phonetic variants) '(in)side' may be used to express static location, as in (179).

(179) Urmia Armenian ((Asatryan 1962: 174))
yres tæʃt-ə meǰʰ-ə kʰʲən-iɾ=ə
3PL.GEN field-GEN in-DEF sleep-PST.PTCP=be.PRS.3SG
'He went to sleep in their field.'

Locative complements can also be unmarked, especially, but not only, in dialects that lack locative case, as seen in (180). This is most common with nouns denoting places, whose role is predictable from their semantics (see Comrie 1986, Aristar 1997, Haspelmath 2020 for the general association of zero case marking with frequent role-reference combinations). A similar phenomenon is observed with time expressions, which are generally marked for case (dative for time of occurrence, instrumental for some expressions denoting length of time), but may be non-case-marked if they involve certain nouns explicitly denoting time (*or* 'day', names of days of the week, *tari* 'year'), as seen in (181), (182).

(180) SEA (Hodgson 2019b: 20)
Vardan-ə Erevan=ē
Vardan-DEF Yerevan=be.PRS.3SG
'Vardan is in Yerevan.'

(181) SEA (Hodgson 2019b: 20)
Vardan-ə erkušabti ōr-n=ē gnacʿ-el
Vardan-DEF Monday day=be.PRS.3SG go-PST.PTCP
'Vardan went on Monday.'

(182) SEA (Hodgson 2019b: 20)
Vardan-ə erku ōr ē mnacʿ-el
Vardan-DEF two day be.PRS.3SG stay-PST.PTCP
'Vardan stayed for two days.'

The result outcome of a factitive verb is unmarked for case, as seen in (183).

(183) SEA (Hodgson field notes)
Astvats nəran xoz=e sarkʰ-um
God DEM3.DAT pig=be.PRS.3SG make-I.PTCP
'God turns him into a pig.'

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21.6 Discussion

In terms of case-marking and agreement, all NENA dialects belong to the language types with optional salience-based object coding. There is thus first of all a major typological distinction to be considered here, namely between languages with differential treatment of objects and those without, which can be manifested either through flagging (DOF) or indexing (DOI). In "non-DOF languages", either all direct object NPs remain bare, or they are all marked in the same way. In "DOF languages", only some objects are overtly marked conditioned by inherent and/or contextual properties of the NP based on an NP hierarchy. A similar distinction can be made for indexing (DOI): in "non-DOI languages", indexing of the direct object is either virtually nonexistent or virtually obligatory. The latter is cross-linguistically rare (see Haig 2018a). In "DOI languages", object indexing is dependent on a combination of semantic and pragmatic factors not necessarily equivalent to, but at least similar to DOF. As regards differential object flagging, Aramaic has been a "DOF language" from its beginnings around the first millennium BC, similarly to other North-west Semitic languages that were recorded around the same time. Outside of NENA, DOF on its own occurs in Mlaḥso Neo-Aramaic, Western Neo-Aramaic, and Neo-Mandaic. Most non-Semitic languages in the NENA-speaking region can also be considered "DOF languages", such as Eastern Armenian, Persian, and Turkic. The notable exception is Kurdish and Gorani, where differential treatment of the direct object is virtually nonexistent, with a few possible exceptions. Even in Zazaki and some conservative dialects of Gorani such as Hewramî of Luhon ((MacKenzie 1966)), the distribution of DOF is limited to clauses with present stem verbal forms.

(184) Gorani Luhon (MacKenzie 1966: 15-16, 70)

a. *kitêb-∅* *bar-e*
book.-DIR.M.SG bring.IMPV-2SG
'Bring a book!' Nonsalient direct object

b. *kitêb-ekey* *bare*
book.-OBL.DEF.M.SG bring.IMPV-2SG
'Bring the book!' Salient direct object flagged

c. *kilewan-eke=š* *awird-o*
ring.-DIR.DEF.M.SG bring.PST-BACK
'He brought back the ring.' No flagging of P-past

The lack of DOF in Kurdish is also noteworthy from an Iranian perspective, since DOF is an otherwise widespread phenomenon in North-Western Iranian

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languages. In North-Western Iranian languages with tense-sensitive morphological splits similar to Northern and Central Kurdish, the differential treatment of the direct object occurs across such splits, as it does in NENA. The example below illustrates this for Vafsi (Stilo 1971), a Tati language of North-Western Iranian, where animate definite P arguments in the past tense also enjoy DOF just as they do in the present tense.

(185) Vafsi (Stilo personal communication, see Stilo 2004)

a. *xorus-i* *kærg-æ=s* *bæværdæ*
rooster-OBL.M.SG hen-DIR.F.SG=OBL.3SG:A carry.PST
'The rooster carried off a hen.' Nonsalient direct object

b. *xorus-i* *kærg-e=s* *bæværdæ*
rooster-OBL.M.SG hen-OBL.F.SG=OBL.3SG:A carry.PST
'The rooster carried off the hen.' Salient direct object flagged

Overall, the argument flagging and indexing systems in NENA dialects seem to be more complex than those found in neighbouring languages, although some measure of simplification may also be observed in NENA (see further below). Flagging has a more limited communal and geographic distribution among NENA dialects, and has a highly variable relationship with indexing, its combination with indexing being either optional, obligatory or impossible, depending on the dialect group. In NENA, DOF occurs most prominently among Trans-Zab Jewish dialects, as well as a few Christian dialects in the northern sector (Van, Hakkari, Iranian Azerbaijan) and in the south on the Mosul Plain. Where DOF occurs in the other languages of the region, there is a strong association with humanness and definiteness and the use of flagging by means of a dative case marker. In Neo-Aramaic, this association between flagging by means of a dative case marker and human definite referents can also be established, but the conditions for DOF in NENA remain predominantly contextual, not inherent. This stands in stark contrast with the simpler systems of DOM found in, for instance, Persian and Standard Eastern Armenian that have inherent, rather than contextual DOF. In Persian and SEA, DOF is generally determined by the inherent properties of the referent, such as animacy and specificity, and the context in which it occurs is of little importance. An exception to this would be the Armenian dialects of the Urmia region, in which DOF is dependent on context to some extent. This could point to contact between Armenian speakers and NENA speakers in the northern sector. Moreover, even from an Aramaic-internal perspective, the NENA dialects stand out, as the DOF system found in pre-modern

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Aramaic literary varieties, such as Classical Syriac (Noorlander 2025b), seems to be closer to the inherent DOF found in Persian and SEA.

In terms of differential object indexing as opposed to differential object flagging, the prevalence of DOI on its own or in combination with DOF seems to have been primarily a trait of the Semitic languages in the region. There is, for instance, a general tendency in the neighbouring Neo-Iranian languages to avoid cross-indexing, i.e., for object indices not to co-occur with an overt object NP, especially when the oblique clitics are used as pronominal object indices. A possible exception would be Colloquial Persian (Rasekh 2014), where DOI may be combined with DOF, e.g., (186).

(186) Colloquial Persian

a. *man bečče-rā gāz gereft-am=eš*
1SG child.SGDOM BITE take.PST-1SG:A=OBL.3SG:P
'I bit the child.'

b. *man ʾu-rā did-am=eš*
1SG 3SG-DOM see.PST-1SG:A=OBL.3SG:P
'I saw him/her.'

Even in Behdînî Northern Kurdish, Zazaki, and conservative Gorani dialects, where object cross-indexing does occur, this is restricted to past stem verbal constructions (with "direct" affixes rather than 'oblique' clitics). And yet, here, too, there is nothing that comes close to an object indexing system as complex as that in the majority of NENA dialects. Generally, the co-nominal object must also be bare in Iranian for it to be indexed on the verb, so that flagged objects do not combine with additional indexing. Patterns that deviate from this in Northern Kurdish primarily concern third person objects, which can be both flagged and indexed, as recorded by (Dorleijn 1996 among Turkish-Kurdish bilinguals. Apparently, object indexing does co-occur optionally with definite direct objects in the Bajalani variety of Gorani near Mosul documented by Mackenzie MacKenzie 1956; otherwise, the P-present argument may be optionally flagged by itself, e.g.,

(187) Gorani Bajalani, Mosul

a. *amin ī qāqat-a mugō bu-wān-ī=š*
1SG DEM paperSG-DEM FUT SBJV-read.PRS-1SG:A=OBL.3SG:P
'I shall read this paper.' (MacKenzie 1956: 428)

b. *mugō ēdī bu-kš-ī=š*
FUT DEM.SG SBJV-kill.PRS-1SG:A=OBL.3SG:P
'I shall kill him.' (MacKenzie 1956: 431)

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c. *amin ina-y* *mu-kš-ī*
1SG DEM.SG-OBL SBJV-kill.PRS-1SG:A
'I shall kill him.' (MacKenzie 1956: 431)

With respect to the optional indexing of P in Bajalani, it may well be the case that we are dealing here with imposition from local Arabic or NENA on the Gorani syntax.

This stands in stark contrast to the Semitic languages in the area more widely, where the object co-nominal can be flagged as well as indexed across all tense formations. Indeed, with the exception of Syriac, the combination of DOI with DOF was the norm in the literary Aramaic varieties of Mesopatamia, such as Jewish Babylonian Aramaic and presumably Classical Mandaic (Morgenstern 2011). The preponderence of DOI in NENA has even led to the inclusion of formerly independent, flagged object pronouns, such as the LL-series, to be fully integrated as object indices into the differential object indexing system.

In spoken Arabic varieties, DOI and DOF are not necessarily prominent features. For both Levantine and Mesopotamian Arabic dialects, DOF and DOI are generally thought likely to be a substrate feature from Aramaic (e.g., Feghali 1918: 84–85; Diem 1979: 47–49; Coghill 2014; Souag 2017), but see Pat-El & Stokes (2022) for a contrary view. The overall distribution of differential object indexing in the Jewish dialects of NENA in Iraqi Kurdistan and the local Jewish dialects of Qəltu Arabic in the same region is strikingly similar, and goes against the trend among other dialects of Arabic in the region. This most likely points to an Aramaic substrate for these dialects located in the core of the NENA speaking region. Indeed, NENA dialects are profuse with differential object indexing, and the loss or decrease in DOI can be attributed to contact with neighbouring languages. In case of the loss of DOI in Ṭuroyo Neo-Aramaic and the marginalisation of DOI in some NENA dialects on the Mosul Plain, such as C. Qaraqosh, this would most likely result from Arabic-Aramaic bilingualism. In Mlaḥso Neo-Aramaic, cognitively accessible objects tend to be dropped altogether, which would parallel the situation in Armenian. In Ṭuroyo Neo-Aramaic, the verbal person indices are primarly pronominal indices, i.e., pro-indexes in the sense of (Haspelmath 2013, where they function as substitutes or alternants for full NPs or free pronouns. The situation in Central Kurdish is in this respect strikingly similar to Neo-Aramaic. Original direct object indexing in the past tense was downgraded to pronominal indices so that a co-nominal has become impossible in Central Kurdish (see Haig 2018a). In Ṭuroyo Neo-Aramaic, object indexing practically only occurs when a definite object is fronted. Thus, in a corpus-based study (Noorlander 2025a), object indexing was only found with fronted definite object NPs and free pronouns.

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This can be contrasted with the indexing system in NENA dialects, where most definite objects are indexed on the verb (75% of all definite objects). In a corpus-based study of Central Kurdish, co-nominals with object indexes were simply not attested, even when the object NP was fronted (Haig & Schnell 2016). One can thus contrast the indexing system in Central Kurdish with Hewramî, where most overt object NPs are indexed on the verb (82% of all overt objects) (Mohammadirad 2025a),

(188) Central Kurdish (Haig 2018a: 803, glossing modified, emphasis original)

a. *dena* *de=y-kuşt/-**in**$_i$*
otherwise IND=3SG.OBL:A-kill.PST-3PL:P
'Otherwise he would kill them.' Most common

b. *dena* ***ewan**=î* *de-kuşt*
otherwise 3PL=OBL.3SG:A IPFV-kill.PST-3PL:P
'Otherwise he would kill them.' Free pronominal object rare

c. *dena* ***ewan**$_i$=î* *de-kuşt/(*-**in**)$_i$*
otherwise 3PL=OBL.3SG:A IPFV-kill.PST-3PL:P
'Otherwise he would kill them.' Cross-indexing impossible

(189) Ṭuroyo Neo-Aramaic (Noorlander field notes)

a. *qṭil-i-le*
kill.PST-3PL:P-OBL.3SG.M:A
'He killed them.' Most common

b. *aḥun-on-i* *qṭil-i-le*
brother.M-PL-MY kill.PST-3PL:P-OBL.3SG.M:A
'He killed my brothers.' Rare

c. *qṭil-le aḥunonayði*

'He killed my brothers.' Most common

A related phenomeon is the loss and decay of object indices in the inflection of past stem verbs in the majority of NENA dialects. Here, originally, either the D-suffixes or L-suffixes could be attached to the past stem verbal form, as has been recorded for several NENA dialects. In the majority of dialects, however, past-stem verbs can no longer take additional object indices. Thus, in such dialects, past perfective clauses based on past stem verbal forms that are semantically transitive can arguably be considered morphosyntactically intransitive. The verbal morphology requires a derivation from the present stem by means of the

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preverbal TAM-marker *qam-* to add object indices and perform DOI. This *qam-* perfective construction is reminiscent of an applicative voice construction, where a patient is promoted to direct object function. Thus, verbal constructions based on this are incompatible with indirect objects, and must express the nonsubject argument as a direct object, e.g.,

(190) C. Nerwa (Noorlander field notes)

a. *pləṭ-ley(*-ley)* *ʾərwe*
go_outINTR.PST-OBL.3PL:S(*-OBL.3PL:P) sheep.F.PL
'Some sheep went out. Subject NP only, object indexing impossible

b. *mpuləṭ-ley(*-ley)* *ʾərwe*
go_outCAUS.PST-OBL.3PL:A(*-OBL.3PL:P) sheep.F.PL
'They let some sheep go out. Agent NP only, object indexing impossible

c. *qə-m-palṭ-i*(-ley)*
PST.PFV-TRZ-go_out-3PL:A-OBL.3PL:P
'They let them go out.' Pronominal object index obligatory

d. *qə-m-palṭ-i-ley* *ʾərw-ey*
PST.PFV-TRZ-go_out-3PL:A-OBL.3PL:P sheep.F.PL-THEIR
'They let their sheep go out.' Cross-indexing of specific object NP

e. *ʾana* *qə-m-yaw-i-li* *ʾərwe*
1SG.NOM PST.PFV-TRZ-go_out-3PL:A-OBL.1SG:R sheep.F.PL-THEIR
'They gave me sheep.' Left-dislocation of topical recipient argument

In C. Qaraqosh, a NENA veriety which is, like Ṭuroyo Neo-Aramaic, in close contact with local Arabic vernaculars, verbal constructions *without* any object indexing are statistically dominant, similarly to the situation in some Qəltu Arabic dialects. Thus, in C. Qaraqosh, the applicative-like past perfective construction primarily fulfils the function of expressing a pronominal object index, rather than the cross-index of a salient co-nominal.

Turning to the flagging and indexing of the A argument, there is a close correspondence between some conservative NENA varieties and conservative varieties of Gorani, as well as transitional varieties of Kurdish. In both Neo-Aramaic and Neo-Iranian, the flagging of A arguments and possible optionality in the indexing of A only occur in clauses based on past stem verbs. Here, there is considerable diversity within Northern and Central Kurdish as well as among Gorani dialects. By way of simplification, one can conclude that, overall, flagging of A-past arguments is obligatory and indexing of A-past is impossible in Zazaki and

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Northern Kurdish. By contrast, generally speaking, cross-indexing of A-past arguments is obligatory but flagging of A-past is impossible in most dialects of Central Kurdish and most dialects of Gorani (Mahmoudveysi et al. 2012, Mahmoudveysi & Bailey 2013, 2019). There is microvariation that deviates from this, but this is the general dialectal division. In Hewramî of Tekht (Mohammadirad 2026), in turn, A-past can be be both flagged and indexed, but there is a complex system with some optionality in this respect (see Mohammadirad & Haig 2026). In transitional varieties of Kurdish (Öpengin & Mohammadirad 2022) as well as in the Hewramî dialect of Luhon ((MacKenzie 1966: 51)), there is either flagging or indexing of A-past, e.g.,

(191) Hewramî Luhon (MacKenzie 1966: 51)

a. *yex-eke* ***germa-y*** *tawna=we*
ice-DIR.DEF.M.SG. heat-M.SG.OBL melt.PST=COMPL
'The heat melted the ice.'

b. (MacKenzie 1966: 68)
germa-∅ *kere-kê=š* *tawna=we*
heat.M-DIR butter-DIR.DEF.F.SG=OBL.3SG:A melt.PST=COMPL
'The heat melted the butter.'

Only this latter system, where flagging and indexing of A are mutually exclusive, approximates what is attested for a few conservative NENA dialects that have flagging of A-past as an option. In such NENA dialects, when the A-past argument is flagged, it cannot be additionally indexed, e.g.,

(192) C. Marga (Noorlander field notes)

a. *xmart-i* *ʾəl-măni* *qṭil-a* *(*-le)*
donkey.F.SG-POSS.1SG OBL-who kill.PST-3SG.F:P-OBL.3SG.M:A
'Who killed my she-ass?'

b. *xmart-i* *(*ʾəl)-măni qṭil-a* **(-le)*
donkey.F.SG-POSS.1SG OBL-who kill.PST-3SG.F:P-OBL.3SG.M:A
'Who killed my she-ass?'

In the Hewramî dialect of Luhon ((MacKenzie 1966: 51)), however, flagging is only possible with inanimate A arguments. In NENA, clauses with and without flagging of A can be semantically equivalent. The semantically equivalent construction without flagging, however, is far more frequent, in which case the A is nearly always indexed. The flagging and indexing of A-past are thereby mutually exclusive in NENA, although both can be, strictly speaking, optional in some

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conservative varieties. The semantic conditions in NENA under which the indexing of A-past is blocked and the A argument is flagged are strikingly similar to what has been observed for the blocking of A-indexing in conservative Gorani dialects such as Hewramî of Tekht (see Mohammadirad & Haig 2026 for a recent overview), where A arguments in *wh*-focus or narrow focus are generally incompatible with A-indexing, e.g.,

(193) Herwamî Tekht (Mohammadirad field notes)
a maher-ê min(=im) koşt-e*
DEM donkey.DIR.F.SG-DEM OBL.1SG=(**=obl.1sg.a) kill.PST-.3SG.F:P
'This donkey I killed.'

This morphological and syntactic pattern in itself is reminiscent of that found in the Behdînî dialects of Northern Kurdish, where oblique case is assigned to the A argument, but the past stem verb agrees with the P argument, e.g.,

(194) Behdînî NK (Öpengin field notes)
ev ker=e min kuşt-in
DEM donkey.DIR.F.SG-DEM OBL.1SG kill.PST-PL
'These donkeys I killed.'

However, the oblique indices of A-past can optionally be omitted in some conservative NENA dialects when the A argument is contextually retrievable. The conditions under which this occurs parallel co-referential agent deletion in Behdînî dialects of Northern Kurdish. When the A argument is omitted, it depends on the context whether it can still be recovered as an instance of co-referential agent deletion (see Haig 2008: 263–264). Agreement with the object NP is retained in such constructions, e.g.,

(195) Behdînî Kurdish (adapted from Haig 2008: 264)

a. *me ew her sê diz bir-in*
OBL.1PL DEM all three thief.DIR.M take.PFV-O.PL
'we took those three thieves'

b. *∅ ew her sê diz bir-in=e lalî*
3:A DEM all three thief.DIR.M take.PFV-O.PL= DIREC before
'those three thieves were taken before (him) (by somebody)'

The agentless past perfective construction in NENA is a direct parallel of this, but, here, the agent argument is marked with an oblique L-suffix on the verb, e.g.,

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(196) C. Marga (Noorlander field notes)

a. *ʾan ṭḷa ganawe nubl-i-lan*
DEM three thief.PL take.PST.-3PL:P-OBL.1PL:A
'we took those three thieves'

b. *ʾan ṭḷa ganawe nubl-i-∅*
DEM three thief.PL take.PST-3PL:P-A.3
'those three thieves were taken (by somebody)'

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22 Alignment typology

22.1 Introduction

In this chapter, we offer a succinct taxonomy of the alignment types identified in Neo-Aramaic varieties and the relevant contact languages. Both Neo-Aramaic and Iranian have dialects that are characterised by tense-aspect-sensitive morphological splits. Verbal clauses built on past stem verb forms often have a subsystem of their own that is distinct from that of verbal clauses built on other verb forms, such as present stem verb forms. These subsystems can, at times, result also in an alignment type that is distinct from other verb forms. However, some morphosyntactic properties are not specific to particular TAM values but apply across all subsystems, especially the argument-related factors that condition case and/or agreement. In order to maximally distinguish the various alignment types, we characterize the individual systems according to S (the single argument of an intransitive clause), A (the agent-like argument of a transitive clause;), and P (the patient-like argument of a transitive clause), following Comrie (1981), Croft (2001), Siewierska (2005), Andrews (2007). We focus on the relationship between intransitive and monotransitive clauses, and the way that the arguments are encoded, either through flagging/case-marking (see Chapters 9 and 21), indexing/ agreement (see Chapters 13 and 21.. The coding properties of the arguments that are described in this chapter have also been discussed separately in previous chapters. Following Siewierska (2003), we subdivide indexing into "morphological coding" and "trigger potential and conditionality." We draw here heavily on previous scholarship in Neo-Aramaic and Iranian alignment typology (Khan 2004a, 2007b, 2017c, Haig 2004, 2017a, Mengozzi 2005b, Doron & Khan 2012, Waltisberg 2016, Coghill 2016, Noorlander 2018, 2021a). A more detailed discussion of the convergence and divergence between the verbal person marking system across the NENA dialects and contact languages is given in Chapter 13, in particular §13.5, and further information regarding the conditions of argument flagging and indexing for the individual languages can be found in Chapter 21 (and see also Chapter 9. As pointed out in §13.5, NENA is far more diverse with respect to its verbal person marking than any of the other languages in the area, and the parallels between NENA and Kurdic are particularly strong,

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primarily in the similar treatment of 'oblique' vs. 'direct' argument encoding and their tense-aspect-sensitive inversion (see also §13.2.2.4). The outcome in terms of alignment type, however, does not necessarily converge among NENA and Kurdic dialects, and each dialect, whether it is a dialect of NENA or one of Kurdic, may exhibit microvariation in this respect, indicating that the alignment types of NENA and Kurdic have not been diachronically stable and diverged significantly (see below and see also Haig 2008). As we observed in §21.6, the syntax of NENA dialects diverges more strongly from the non-Semitic languages in the area as well as its closely related kin Ṭuroyo Neo-Aramaic in that it has a rich system of differential object indexing, often alongside differential object flagging.

Here, we broaden our discussion of these systems by analysing them from the perspective of alignment typology. In so doing, we do not have the space to include all microvariation, but highlight the most prominent types. The alignment types that are distinguished here are listed in Table 22.1 and are discussed per language group in the subsequent sections. These include the familiar neutral, accusative and ergative alignment types alongside less common alignment types. In neutral alignment, there is no distinction between S, A and P, most often represented by the absence of any morphology, such as the case-marking of full NPs, such as Dutch, Mandarin and Nahuatl. In tripartite alignment, all three syntactic roles are distinguished, . In horizontal alignment, A and P are expressed alike but differently from S. This fact has led to several other common names, including "double oblique," focussing on the fact that there are two marked arguments in the same clause, and "transitive alignment," focussing on the fact that there is one type of marking for the core arguments of transitive clauses and the single argument of an intransitive clause. Bossong (1985), Arkadiev (2008) have claimed that these horizontal systems are a feature of Iranian languages. Perhaps a better characterization is that horozontal systems are an areal feature of the Western Iranian zone. Finally, semantic alignment, which should also be mentioned here but lies outside the scope of the present chapter, refers to systems where S does not uniformly group with either A or P, also known as split intransitivity. This type of split S-marking can be lexical, in which case a subset of semantically intransitive verbs is subsumed under the class of transitive verbs in the system, and vice versa. This lexical (in)transitivity is the most common pattern across Kurdic and NENA dialects, see Chapter 13, in particular §13.2.4.1. In a handful of NENA dialects, however, semantic alignment can depend on the grammatical context in which an intransitive verb occurs. Thus, the same lexically intransitive verb can reflect different groupings (also known as fluid S-marking) depending on TAM, on which see also Chapter 16 and Chapter 13, especially §13.2.4.1 regarding different subject endings in NENA verbal inflection.

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Table 22.1: Alignment types and their respective groupings

Type	Argument grouping
accusative	{A=S} ≠ P
ergative	A ≠ {S=P}
neutral	{A=S= P}
tripartite	A ≠ S ≠ P
horizontal	{A=P} ≠ S
semantic[a]	{A=S_A} ‖ {S_P=P}

[a]This type is not discussed in this chapter.

22.2 Alignment types across NENA dialects

Verbal person marking does the bulk of the work in the vast majority of NENA dialects by cross-indexing the respective arguments, see §13.2 and §21.2.3, of which the main alignment types in verbal person marking are summarised in Table 22.2.1.2. According to conditionality and trigger potential, the majority of NENA varieties isolate the P argument in treating it differentially, see §21.2.3. Thus, the vast majority of dialects exhibit a concistently accusative indexing and/or flagging system. In this respect, S/A remains unmarked throughout and their cross-indexing is unconditoned. This can be contrasted with P, whose flagging and/or indexing is always conditioned by the properties of the argument.

An additional complicating factor, however, is that, in terms of verbal inflection morphology, NENA dialects exhibit various subsystems for particular TAM categories. Clauses built on a different verbal form, such as past stem verb forms as opposed to present stem verb forms, will have different verbal morphology (different TAM modifiers, or different stem, or distinct sets of person markers, a distinct set of arrangement of verbal suffixes etc., see §13.2). In most cases, these morphological distinctions between verbal tense conjugations (present habitual, past perfective, perfect etc.) do not affect the morphological alignment typology nor do they behave differently with respect to the core syntactic configurations for differential treatment of P summarised in 22.2. However, there are contexts where A is given treatment distinct from that of S in clauses based on past stem verb forms. The same holds true for the properties of P, which can be more restricted in clauses built on the past stem than in clauses based on other verbal forms. We will therefore begin with a discussion of verbal blauses based on verbal forms other than the past perfective. Since the Trans-Zab Jewish dialects of

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NENA constitute a group with several unique features, we will separate these from the discussion of the majority of NENA dialects and dedicate a separate section to them (§22.2.4).

Table 22.2: General accusative conditionality in the differential treatment of P arguments across all clauses in NENA dialects

Argument type	Coding type	A	S	P
Nonsalient referents	Flagging	Null	Null	Null
	Indexing	Overt	Overt	Null
Salient referents	Flagging	Null	Null	Overt
	Indexing	Overt	Overt	Overt

22.2.1 Verbal clauses other than the past perfective in the majority of NENA dialects

22.2.1.1 Neutral flagging and accusative indexing

In terms of case-marking, full NPs and independent pronouns occur in their bare citation form, i.e., nominative case, and follow a neutral pattern. Generally, independent pronouns are optional, and two-argument clauses will seldom have two independent pronouns, unless they are both prominent in the discourse. If independent pronouns do occur, the same set can be used for S, A, and P functions just like bare NPs in the majority of NENA dialects, as observed for present imperfective clauses in (1). Here, S and A are indexed by means of the D-suffixes (see §13.2.2.1). The cross-indexing of P arguments shown in (1) is conditioned on the properties of the argument (see §21.2.3). The oblique L-suffix indexing (see §13.2.2.2)) the P argument in (1) does not occur when the P argument is indefinite nonspecific.

(1) C. Nerwa (Noorlander field notes)

a. *baxt-i* *l-əmṣ-a* *∅-ʾaz-a*
woman.F.SG-POSS.1SG NEG-can-3SG.F:S SBJV-go-3SG.F:S
'My wife cannot go.'

b. *ʾaxni l-əmṣ-əx* *∅-ʾaz-əx*
1PL NEG-can-1PL:S SBJV-go-1PL:S
'We cannot go.'

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c. *ʾaxni bayy-ax ∅-xaz-ax-la baxt-ux*
1PL want-1PL:A SBJV-see-1PL:A-OBL.3SG.F:P woman.F.SG-POSS.2SG.M
'We want want to see (lit. her) your wife.'

d. *baxt-ux bayy-a ʾaxni=ži*
woman.F.SG-POSS.2SG.M want-3F.SG:A 1PL=ADD
∅-xazy-a-lan
SBJV-see-3F.SG:A-OBL.3PL:P
'Your wife wants to see us too (lit. see us we too).'

Complex progressive and perfect constructions usually follow similar alignment patterns to the clauses based on the present stem illustrated in (1). In such constructions, A is indexed by a copula, and the resultative participle used to form the perfect agrees with it (see §13.2.5.1). In such constructions, P-indices may precede A-indices depending on the dialect and coding strategy sued in that dialect, as (2) shows.

(2) C. Diyana (Napiorkowska 2015: 211)

a. *xiš-t =et*
go.RES.PTCP-F.SG:S =COP.2SG.F:S
'You (F.SG) have gone.'

b. *xiš-∅ =en*
go.RES.PTCP-M.SG:S =COP.1SG.M:S
'I (M) have gone.'

c. *šudər-t-i =t*
send.RES.PTCP-F.SG:A-1SG:P =COP.2SG.F:A
'You (F.SG) have sent me.'

d. *šudr-∅-ax =en*
send.RES.PTCP-M.SG:A-2SG.F:P =COP.1SG.M:A
'I (M) have sent you (F.SG).'

In several NENA dialects, the enclitic copula that agrees with S and A in such complex perfects or progressives is mobile. It attaches to the most accented constituent at the left edge of the clause (see §13.5 and Chapter 15). The same enclitic copula can also optionally be omitted, as seen in (3) and (4). Thus, person marking of S and A is not obligatory in the complex perfect and complex progressive (see §13.2.5.7). The omission of the copula thus indicates that

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(3) C. Arbuš (Talay 2009: 348.19)
qím-e=ley$_i$ *šwiq=əlle* $\varnothing_i$ *w*
rise.RES.PTCP-PL:S=COP.3PL:S leave.RES.PTCP.PL:A=3SG.M:P 3PL:A and
diṛ-e $\varnothing_i$ *kəs miṛa*
return.RES.PTCP-PL:S 3PL:S at emir
'They rose, left him behind, and returned to the emir.'

(4) C. Nerwa (Noorlander, fieldnotes)
ʾəðy-e=ley$_i$ *kalbe*$_i$ *xil-e* $_i$
come.RES.PTCP-PL:S=COP.3PL:S dog.PL eat.RES.PTCP-PL:A 3PL:A
bəsṛa=u *qim-e=ley*$_i$ *xiš-e* $\varnothing_i$
meat.M.SG=and rise.RES.PTCP-PL:S=COP.3PL:S go.RES.PTCP-PL:S 3PL:S
b-ʾuɻxa
at-road
'Dogs came, ate some meat, and then up they went on their way.'

22.2.1.2 Accusative flagging combined with accusative indexing

The neutral alignment of independent pronouns shown in (1) contrasts with other NENA dialects that have developed dedicated object pronouns that are used with all verbal constructions (see §9.2); compare the forms in (5).

(5) C. Urmi (Noorlander field notes, see Khan 2016b)

a. *ʾaxni le bayy-ax ḵad-ay xazz-ax*
1PL.NOM NEG want-1PL:A ACC-DEM.F.SG see-1PL:A
'We do not want to see her (lit. that one).'

b. *ʾana ḵadiyyux bədday=ən*
1SG.NOM 2SG.ACC know.PROG=1SG:A
'Do I know you?'

c. *ʾani ḵad-ay ḵṭəl-lun*
3PL.NOM ACC-DEM.F.SG killPST-OBL.3PL:A
'They killed her (lit. that one).'

In a few NENA dialects on the Mosul Plain, i.e., C. Bariṭle and C. Telkepe (see §21.2.3.2), differential object flagging is obligatorily combined with differential object indexing. Accusative flagging thus always occurs alongside accusative indexing in such dialects, even in complex verb forms, such as (6).

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(6) C. Telkepe (Noorlander field notes)
ʾiwat *šqəl-t-e* *ta* *Toma*
PRS.COP.2SG.F take.RES.PTCP-F.SG:A-3SG.M:P ACC Thomas.M.SG
'You (F.SG) have taken Thomas.'

Table 22.3: Types of verbal person marking alignment in the majority of NENA dialects

Constructions	Alignment type	A	S	P
Present	Accusative	D-set	D-set	L-set
Past	Accusative	L-set	L-set	D-set
Past + *qam*-perfective	Ergative	D-set	L-set	L-set
Complex progressive	Accusative	Copula	Copula	Various P-markers
Complex perfect	Accusative	Copula	Copula	Various P-markers

22.2.2 Verbal clauses in the past perfective in the majority of NENA dialects

22.2.2.1 Accusative alignment in past stem verb forms

Generally speaking, argument indexing is accusative throughout, including in constructions based on the past stem. At face value, accusative alignment holds true for past perfective clauses. Past perfective clauses with two full NPs where the verbal inflection is based on the 'past' *qṭil*-stem show accusative verbal person marking, in that both S and A are expressed by means of oblique L-suffixes, as (7) shows.

(7) C. Nerwa (Noorlander field notes)

a. *bɻat-i* *ðe-la* *l-beða* *gu-sətwa*
daughter.F.SG-POSS.1SG come.PST-OBL.3SG.F:S TO-house in-winter
'My daughter came home in winter.'

b. *bɻat-i* *xze-la* *beyye*
daughter.F.SG-1SG.POSS see.PST-OBL.3SG.F:A egg.PL
'My daughter found some eggs.'

In a few dialects, full object NPs and independent pronouns can be indexed by the D-set in past stem verb forms (see §13.2.4.2 on the areal distribution). This type of P-indexing, too, follows a fully accusative pattern, as shown in (8).

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In general, however, the accusative pattern exemplified in (8) is restricted to the third person, and dialects have alternative constructions to express first and second person objects, as discussed in §13.2.4. In the vast majority of dialects, this person restriction is peculiar to clauses based on the past stem, and never applies to other types of clauses. In Trans-Zab Jewish dialects (see §22.2.4 and §13.2.6 in Chapter 13), this person restriction may also hold true for other verb forms.

(8) C. Marga (Noorlander field notes)

a. *bron-an* *se-le* *l-besa*
son.M.SG-1PL.POSS come.PST-OBL.3SG.M:S to-house
'Our son came home.'

b. *ʾaxnan* *se-lan* *laxxa* *təmmal*
1PL.NOM come.PST-OBL.1PL:A hither yesterday
'We came here yesterday.'

c. *nobəl-∅-lan* *bron-an* *l-mədrasa*
take.PST-3SG.M:P-OBL.1PL:A son-1PL.POSS to-school
'We took our son to school.'

d. *ʾaxnan* *nubl-ux-le* *bron-an* *l-besa*
1PL.NOM take.PST-1PL:P-OBL.3SG.M:A son-1PL.POSS to-home
'Our son took us home.'

22.2.2.2 Ergative indexing across the TA-sensitive split in the *qam*-construction

Table 22.4: Ergativity and the *qam*-construction in NENA

	Construction	**S**	
	Past stem construction	L-set	
	Construction	**A**	**P**
Nonsalient P	Past stem construction	L-set	Null
Salient P	*Qam*-construction	D-set	L-set

In the vast majority of NENA dialects, the past perfective forms based on the *qṭil*-stem are incompatible with direct object person indexes. Instead, a so-called transitive *qam*-perfective based on the present stem must be used for clauses with

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both A- and P-indexing. This results in a morphological split between intransitive and transitive clauses for the cross-indexing of definite full NPs and pronouns. The resulting alignment split is a type sui generis, but it should not be considered accusative, since S and A are not grouped together in this system. Examples (9)-10 illustrate this pattern. Here, S and P are indexed by oblique L-suffixes on the verb, while A is expressed by D-suffixes. The stem of the transitive verb form is, however, distinct from that of the intranistive verb. See further Noorlander 2021a on arguments as to why this could be characterised as an ergative subtype in which transitive clauses without differentially treated objects should be considered equivalent to intransitive clauses (see also §13.2.4.3) and §21.2.2.3). Most NENA dialects thus show a split in the past perfective that cannot be characterised as accusative, and would, on the basis of sets of person markers alone, be subsumed under the ergative type, as summarised in Table 22.2.2.2.

(9) C. Nerwa (Noorlander fieldnotes)
qəm-ley *xdəṛ-ṛey* *ʾəll-ey la*
rise.PST-3PL:S look.PST-OBL.3PL:A at-3PL NEG
qəm-xaz-i-ley *beyye*
PST.TRZR-see-3PL:A-OBL.3PL:P egg.PL
'They got up and looked for them (but) they did not find the eggs.'

(10) C. Shaqlawa (Noorlander fieldnotes)

a. *ʾahat=ži* *te-lux* *l-beta*
2SG.NOM=also come.PST-OBL.2SG:S to-home
'You also came home.'

b. *ʾaxni* *ʾahat* *=ži* *qəm-xaz-əx-lux*
1PL.NOM 2SG.NOM =also PST.TRZR-see-1PL:A-OBL.2SG.M:P
'We saw you also.'

This subtype of ergative person marking is conditioned syntactically by the presence of a P-index, which, in turn, is conditioned by the presence of a referential P argument (see §13.2.4.3 and §21.2.2.3. Consequnetly, transitive clauses with an indefinite nonspecific P argument, as seen in (11b), are indistinct from intransitive clauses, cf. (11b and the other examples of intransitive verbs in (10) and (9) above. The indefinite nonspecific P argument in (11b) does not trigger P-indexing. The verb groups S and A by using the oblique L-suffixes to index them, and P remains null. When P is definite, however, and triggers P-indexing, the *qam*-construction must be used, and this results in identical marking of S and P through the oblique L-suffixes, while A is isolated by using the D-suffixes.

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(11) C. Nerwa (Noorlander fieldnotes)

a. *npəl-la baxta*
fall.PST-OBL.3F.SG:S one woman.F.SG
'A woman fell.' (Lit. 'Her fell.')

b. *qṭəl-ley baxta*
kill.PST-OBL.3PL:A woman.F.SG
'They killed a woman.' (Lit. 'Them killed.')

c. *qəm-qaṭl-i-la baxta*
PST.TRZR-kill-3SG.M:A-OBL.3SG.F:P woman.F.SG
'They killed the woman.' (Lit. 'They killed her woman.')

It is possible to consider clauses of the kind in (11b) to be a subtype of intransitive clauses. This can be illustrated by teh following alternation. In (12a), A is indexed on the past stem verb form by means of the expected oblique L-suffixes, and the patient argument is omissiable and can be expressed as oblique, in which case it is not definitively affected. Such a configuration is incompatible with the *qam*-construction, in which case the patient argument must be salient and the clause must be syntactically transitive, resulting in cross-referencing of P. Consequently, hypothetical clauses of the kind in (12c) where the patient is omitted or oblique but S is indexed by means of the D-suffix are impossible.

(12) C. Nerwa

a. *xaðwað-i xəl-ley (mən xabuša)*
sister.PL-my eat.PST-OBL.3PL:S (from apple.M.SG)
'My sisters ate (from the/an apple).' S with optional oblique argument

b. *xaðwað-i qəm-ʾaxl-i*(-le xabuša)*
sister.PL-my TR.PST-eat-3PL:A*(-3SG.M:P apple.M.SG)
'My sisters ate the apple.' A with obligatory P argument

c. **xaðwað-i qəm-ʾaxl-i (mən xabuša)*
sister.PL-my TR.PST-eat-3PL:S (from apple.M.SG)
Intended for: 'My sisters ate (from the apple).' S with optional oblique impossible

In the dialects where P-flagging is always accompanied by P-indexing, the ergative *qam*-perfective construction occurs alongside accusative flagging, as seen in (13).

(13) C. Telkepe (Coghill 2010a: 225, 231)

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a. *npəl-lə* *gora*
fall.PST-OBL.3SG.M:S man.M.SG
'A man fell.' (Lit. 'Him fell.')

b. *qṭil-lə* *gora*
kill.PST-OBL.3SG.M:A man.M.SG
'He killed a man.' (Lit. 'Him killed.')

c. *kəm-qaṭəl-∅-lə* *ta* *gora*
PST.TRZR-kill-3SG.M:A-OBL.3SG.M:P ACC man.M.SG
'He killed the man.'

22.2.2.3 Optional ergative flagging and tripartite indexing

Several conservative varieties of NENA have preserved optional ergative A-flagging under certain conditions, notably narrow focus, see §21.2.3.4) for further discussion. The pattern is summarised in Table 22.2.2.3. The A argument of a past stem verb form can be flagged by the 'oblique' case-marker *l-*. When A is flagged, however, it cannot be indexed by the oblique L-suffixes that normally index S and A in the past. In terms of verbal person marking, however, this alignment is tripartite, since the S is obligatorily indexed by the oblique L-suffixes, as seen in (14a), and morphologically distinct from the P, which is indexed with D-suffixes, as illustrated in (14b), and distinct from the A, which obligatorily lacks indexing. This transitive past perfective construction with ergative flagging by means of the oblique case-marker *l-* can always alternate with the more common transitive perfective past construction that reflects accusative indexing, as illustrated in (14c).

(14) C. Marga (Noorlander fieldnotes)

a. *ʾayya* *brata* *dməx-la*
DEM.SG.F girl.F.SG fall_asleep.PST-OBL.3SG.F:S
'This girl fell asleep.'

b. *ʾayya* *brata* *l-xon-i*
DEM.SG.F girl.F.SG OBL-brother.M.SG-POSS.1SG
šqil-a-(-le)*
take.PST-3SG.F:P-(OBL.3SG.M:A)
'This girl *my brother* took.' (Lit. 'This girl by my brother took her.')

c. *ʾayya* *brata* *xon-i* *šqil-a-le)*
DEM.SG.F girl.F.SG brother.M.SG-POSS.1SG take.PST-3SG.F:P-OBL.3SG.M:A
'This girl *my brother* took.'

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Table 22.5: Ergative flagging alongside tripartite indexing in NENA

	A	S	P
Flagging	*l-*	∅	∅
Indexing	∅	L-set	D-set

In the same dialects, the tripartite indexing is also compatible with clauses where A is neither flagged nor indexed, as (15) illustrates. Here, when A is expected and contextually retrievable, the oblique L-suffix attached to past stem verb can be omitted. When we consider the conditionality and trigger potential of indexing expected and topic-continuous referents, therefore, this system could be characterised as an optional type of ergative indexing. S and P are grouped ergatively in that they are indexed when topic-conintuous, but the indexing of A can be optionally dropped. Purely morphologically speaking, however, S and P are always distinguished by each having their own set of person markers, S being expressed by the oblique L-suffixes but P being expressed by the D-suffixes.

(15) C. Marga (Noorlander fieldnotes)
xon-i *se-le=u* *šqil-a*
brother.M.SG-POSS.1SG come.PST-OBL.3SG.M=and take.PST-3SG.F:P
čant-i
bag.F.SG-POSS.1SG
'My brother came and took my bag.'

22.2.3 P-like markers used as copula in nonverbal clauses

In the majority of NENA dialects, enclitic S-indexing morphemes in copula clauses can be identical to P-indexing morphemes in verbal clauses. This concerns third person subjects of present tense copula clauses, which are inflected by means of 'oblique' L-suffixes, notably *le* and *la* for the 3MSG. and 3FSG.. These S-marking copulas are thereby treated identically to the P-indexing set that occurs in transitive verbal clauses based on present stem verbs, as the following example with *le* illustrates.

(16) J. Dohok (Molin 2024: 171)

a. *tora=le*
bull.M.SG=COP.3SG.M:S
'He is a bull.' (Lit. 'Him a bull.')

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b. *k-tor-a-le*
IND-break-3SG.F:A-OBL.3SG.M:P
'She breaks him.'

Using P-like morphemes for the third person copula forms is not a typical characteristic of nominative-accusative alignment, but is in fact found in some ergative languages (Molin 2024: 171). Still, in the majority of NENA dialects, complex verb forms can be based on this oblique copula for both S and A-indexing, in which case the argument indexing reflects an accusative pattern. This could also be said to parallel the general situation in clauses based on past stem verbs, where S and A are both indexed by oblique L-suffixes in the majority of NENA dialects.

22.2.4 Alignment types in Trans-Zab Jewish dialects

In Trans-Zab Jewish varieties of NENA, the alignment typology can be fairly complex. We will begin our discussion with the accusative types, and then gradually discuss the more restricted and/or more complex patterns that occur in past perfective clauses as well as complex verb forms.

22.2.4.1 Accusative conditioning of coding properties

Table 22.6: Types of verbal person marking alignment in the complex perfect in eastern Trans-Zab Jewish NENA dialects

Constructions	Alignment types	A	S	P
Present	Accusative	D-set	D-set	L-set // LL-set
Past	Ergative / Tripartite	L-set	D-set	D-set / LL-set
Complex realis perfect	Ergative / Tripartite	∅	Copula + Participle	Copula + Participle / LL-set
Complex irrealis perfect	Ergative / Tripartite	L-set	Copula + Participle	Copula + Participle / LL-set

Table 22.7: Ergative indexing and accusative flagging J. Sulemaniyya and Ḥalabja

Coding	Alignment	A	S	P
Indexing	Ergative	L-set	D-set	D-set
Flagging	Accusative	Null	Null	*l-*

First of all, across all Trans-Zab Jewish dialects, the indexing of P arguments is conditional (see Chapter 21). Only salient P arguments are indexed, and this is

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Table 22.8: Participial agreement patterns of realis complex perfects in Trans-Zab Jewish NENA

Dialect	Gender	A	S	P
J. Koy Sanjak	All	Agreement	Agreement	Null
J. Sulemaniyya	Feminine	Agreement	Agreement	Agreement[a]
	Other	Agreement	Agreement	Null
J. Urmi	Feminine	Agreement	Null	Null
	Other	Null	Null	Null
J. Saqiz	All	Null	Agreement	Agreement

[a]Only if third person and also attached to the verb in the form of a possessive suffix

found across all verbal constructions, including present stem and past stem verb forms, as shown in (17).

(17) J. Saqiz

a. *baxt-év* *aburw-év*
wife.F.SG-3SG.M.POSS dignity.M.SG-3SG.M.POSS
labl-a-le
take-3SG.F:A-OBL.3SG.M:P
'His wife takes away his dignity.' Present stem A and P (Israeli 1998: 186)

b. *broná* *šulṭaná* *bratá* *ləbl-a-le*
son.M.SG king.M.SG girl.F.SG take.PST-3SG.F:P-OBL.3SG.M:A
'The king's son took the girl.' Past stem A and P (Israeli 1998: 138)

Secondly, S and A arguments are obligatorily unmarked in this dialect group as a whole. When flagging occurs, this is always accusative and optional (see §21.2.3.1 on differential object flagging). For independent personal pronouns, the flagging is obligatory accusative with dedicated accusative pronouns across the entire verbal system, including clauses based on present stem and past stem verb forms, as the following examples from J. Solduz illustrate. In terms of flagging, therefore, the syntax is accusative throughout in all Trans-Zab Jewish dialects.

(18) J. Solduz

a. *balki* *əllan* *palq-et*
maybe ACC.1PL save-2SG.M:A
'Maybe you can save us.' Present stem A and P (Garbell 1965b: 175)

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b. *əllan pləq-le*
ACC.1PL save.PAST-OBL.3SG.M:A
'He saved us.' Past stem A and P (Garbell 1965b: 173)

22.2.4.2 Verbal clauses based on past stem verb forms

In all of Trans-Zab Jewish NENA, object indexing with the D-set in past perfective clauses is restricted to the third person (see also §13.2.4.2 and §13.2.6). In the northern and western varieties of Trans-Zab Jewish NENA, this results in a person-restricted accusative pattern of person marking morphology, since S is grouped with A by the L-suffixes. In the south-eastern Trans-Zab Jewish varieties, this results in person-restricted ergative alignment, since S is grouped with P by the D-suffixes. The distinction between the dialects in terms of alignment is thus solely based on the intransitive construction. The syntax of the transitive past perfective construction is identical. This contrast between person-restricted accusative and person-restricted ergative inflection can be observed in the following examples. In the Jewish NENA of Solduz 19, the S argument of *idye-lu* and the A argment of *pəlṭ-i-le* are both indexed by oblique L-suffixes, namely *-lu* [-3PL] and *-le* [-3SG.M], respectively. The P argument is indexed by the D-suffix *-i* [3PL]. By contrast, the example from Jewish NENA of Saqiz in 19b shows how S and P are indexed with D-suffixes, namely *-i* [3PL], and only the A argument is indexed by L-suffixes, i.e., *-le* [3SG.M].

(19) Restricted accusative: J. Solduz

a. *kull-u hakim-e idye-lu*
all-3PL doctor.M-PL come.PST-OBL.3PL:S
'All the doctors came.' (Hopkins 1989: 269.33)

b. *kull-u pəlṭ-i-le*
all-3PL move_out.PST.TRZR-3PL:P-OBL.3M.SG:A
'He let all of them go.' (Hopkins 1989: 268.30)

(20) Restricted ergative: J. Saqiz (Israeli 1998: 104)

a. *axon-awal-év pliṭ-i mən belá*
friend.M-PL-3SG.M.POSS move_out.PST.INTR-3PL:S from house
'His friends left the house.'

b. *qatw-év pəlṭ-i-le mən belá*
cat.PL-3SG.M.POSS move_out.PST.TR-3PL:P-OBL.3SG.M:A from house
'He let his cats go out of the house.'

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In the south-eastern Trans-Zab Jewish dialects, the ergative A-past index can occasionally spread to an adjacent S-past verb, as (21a) shows. Conversely, the S-past indexing can also spread to an adjacent P, resulting in rare forms where even first and second person indexes reflect an ergative pattern, as seen in (21b).

(21) J. Sanandaj (Khan 2009)

a. *ʾay =zíl-wa-la mír-wa-la baqa*
DEM.SG.F =GO.PST-PST-OBL.3SG.F:S tell.PST-PST-OBL.3SG.F:A to
Mərza Xănăka
Mirza Khanaka
'She went and told Mirza Khanaka.' (Khan 2009: 472.21)

b. *hiy-ăna ləbl-ăna-nu bimaristán-e Hădasá*
come.PST-1SG.F:S take.PST-1SG.F:P-OBL.3PL:A hospital-EZ Hadasa
'I (F.SG) came (and) they took me to Hadasa hospital.' (Khan 2009: 472.2)

To express first and second person objects, dedicated object pronouns based on the preposition *(h)əll-* are used. In the western sector of Trans-Zab Jewish NENA dialects, the verbal morphology remains accusative for first and second person indexes. S and A arguments are both indexed by L-suffixes, while P is expressed by a separate LL-series (see §13.2.5.4 and §13.2.4.5).

(22) J. Arbel (Khan 1999b)

a. *kwəš-li*
descend.PST-OBL.1SG:S
'I went/came down.'

b. *kwəš-lox*
descend.PST-OBL.2SG.M:S
'You (M.SG) went/came down.'

c. *qṭəl-li =llox* ~ *ʾəllox qṭəl-li*
kill.PST-OBL.1SG:A =ACC.2SG.M:P 2SG.M.ACC kill.PST-OBL.1SG:A
'I killed you (M.SG).'

In the south-eastern Jewish dialects, the inflection of intransitive past stem verbs takes D-suffixes, which is distinct from A (L-suffixes) and distinct from P (LL-series), as the following example illustrates. This is therefore a type of tripartite indexing in terms of morphology. Only S and A are indexed on the verb, but they are indexed by distinct sets of person markers, which, in turn, are

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distinct from P. The only argument that is flagged, however, is P, so that the flagging is accusative.

(23) J. Kerend (Hopkins 2002)

a. *kwiš-na*
go_down.PST-1SG:S
'I (M) went/came down.'

b. *kwiš-et*
go_down.PST-2SG.M:S
'You (M.SG) went/came down.'

c. *ʾəlox* *qṭəl-li*
ACC.2SG.M kill.PST-OBL.1SG:A
'I killed you (M.SG).'

In the Jewish dialects of western Iran, the aforementioned system illustrated for J. Sulemaniyya is found not only in the past perfective, but also in the irrealis perfect. In the Jewish dialects of Rustaqa and Ruwanduz, located in north-east Iraqi Kurdistan, the four aforementioned subsystems co-exist and are further subdivided by tense-aspect. The ergative and tripartite patterns are confined to the realis perfect, while the two accusative systems are restricted to the past perfective (see Khan 2002b, Noorlander 2021a).

The dedicated object pronouns are generally cliticised to the immediately preceding verb (see §13.2.4.5) to express any pronominal object, i.e., *qṭəl-le=llan* 'He killed us' from *qṭəl-le ʾəllan*. Often, the gemination of /ll/ is lost, and this can lead to identical marking of A and P (see §13.5), since the object markers are identical to the L-suffixes. In the Jewish dialects of Iranian Azerbaijan, this leads to a neutral pattern in verbal person marking, where S, A, and P are all expressed by L-suffixes, and this pattern is available for all persons. This is illustrated below for the Jewish dialect of Urmi.

(24) J. Urmi (Garbell 1965c, Khan 2008b)

a. *kwəš-li*
go_down.PST-OBL.1SG:S
'I (M) went/came down.'

b. *kwəš-lox*
go_down.PST-OBL.2SG.M:S
'You (M.SG) went/came down.'

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c. *⁺qṭəl-li-lox* ~ *əll-ox* *qṭəl-li*
kill.PST-OBL.1SG:A-OBL.2SG.M:P 2SG.M.ACC kill.PST-OBL.1SG:A
'I killed you (M.SG).'

Where this gemination is lost in the Jewish dialects of western Iran, the alignment is horizontal for first and second person, marking A and P identically through the L-suffixes, while S is isolated by the D-suffixes, as the following exmaple indicates.

(25) J. Saqiz (Yisraeli 1998)

a. *kwiš-na*
go_down.PST-1SG:S
'I (M) went/came down.'

b. *kwiš-et*
go_down.PST-2SG.M:S
'You (M.SG) went/came down.'

c. *qṭəl-li-lox* ~ *əlox* *qṭəl-li*
kill.PST-OBL.1SG:A-OBL.2SG.M:P ~ 2SG.M.ACC kill.PST-OBL.1SG:A
'I killed you (M.SG).'

When the LL-series or L-series are used as pronominal object clitics in the past perfective, they have become part of the argument indexing system, even though they are historically independent pronouns (see §13.2.5.4). Thus, in the following examples with the verb 'to wash', the P argument is cross-indexed on the verb by means of a clitic from the LL-series or a clitic-like oblique L-suffix, respectively.

(26) J. Arbel (Khan 1999b: 498.83)
xíp-la=lleu *bron-í*
wash.PST-OBL.3SG.F:A=ACC.3SG.M:P son.M.SG-POSS.1SG
'She washed my son.'

(27) J. Urmi (Garbell 1965b: 156)
ʾo=š *xíp-la-le*
3SG=ADD wash.PST-OBL.3SG.F:A-OBL.3SG.M:P
'She washed him too.'

22.2.4.3 Verbal clauses based on complex verb forms

In the complex verb forms that express the perfect and progressive, the same tendencies are observed as with the other types of clauses. There are several

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complexities, however, including participial agreement, which is summarised in Table 22.2.4.1.

In Iraqi Kurdistan, Trans-Zab Jewish dialects make use of possessive suffixes to express P. In J. Koy Sanjak, the copula can express both S and A in the complex perfect and progressive. In the perfect, the participle agrees with S and A, e.g.,

(28) J. Koy Sanjak (Mutzafi 2004a)

a. *dmix* *-te* *=la*
sleep.RES.PTCP -SG.F:S =COP.3SG.F:S
'She is/has fallen asleep.'

b. *dmix* *-e* *=le*
sleep.RES.PTCP -SG.M:S =COP.3SG.M:S
'He is/has fallen asleep.'

c. *nšiq* *-t* *-ew* *=ila*
kiss.RES.PTCP -SG.F:A -POSS.3SG.F:P =COP.3SG.F:A
'She has kissed him.'

d. *nšiq* *-∅* *-aw* *=ile*
kiss.RES.PTCP -3SG.M:A -POSS.3SG.F:P =COP.3SG.M:A
'He has kissed her.'

These P-indexes are available for all persons in J. Koy Sanjak, which is similar to the majority of NENA. However, they can only be used when A is third person (see §13.2.6; Mutzafi 2004a). When A is first or second person, L-suffixes are used instead. When A outranks P on the person hierarchy or vice versa, the coding strategy is distinct, but the morphological alignment remains accusative throughout. Thus, in the following examples, we observe how for an intransitive verb like 'to sleep' the enclitic copula that indexes S binds immediately to the verbal stem. The A indices are identical, but the P indices can be bound to the verbal stem before the enclitic copula only in clauses where the P outranks the A in person, such as 'she has kissed me'. Conversely, in clauses where A outranks P, such as 'I have kissed her', however, the P indices are bound to the copula and cannot bind to the verbal stem.

(29) J. Koy Sanjak (Mutzafi 2004a)

a. *dmix* *-ta* *=wan*
sleep.RES.PTCP -SG.F:S =COP.1SG:S
'I (F) am/have fallen asleep.'

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b. *dmix -ta =la*
sleep.RES.PTCP -SG.M:S =COP.3SG.F:S
'She has fallen asleep.'

c. *nšiq -t -i =la (*-li)*
kiss.RES.PTCP -SG.F:A -POSS.1SG:P =COP.3SG.F:P (*-obl.1sg:P)
'She has kissed me.'

d. *nšiq -t (*-aw) =wan -na*
kiss.RES.PTCP -SG.F:A (*-poss.3sg.f:P) =COP.1SG.F:A -OBL.3SG.F:P
'I (F) have kissed her.'

Further east in Iraqi Kurdistan, namely in J. Sulemaniyya and J. Ḥalabja, however, accusative verbal person marking with the 'possessive' P-indexes is restricted to the third person. Instead of this, these dialects make use of the LL-series to express P, which is available for all persons and must be used for first and second persons. With respect to both object coding strategies, verbal person marking remains accusative. Further north in Iraqi Kurdistan, the LL-series are the only means available to express P. This can be contrasted with the following complex progressive forms in J. Koy Sanjak, J. Sulemaniyya, and J. Rustaqa. In J. Koy Sanjak, the coding of P depends on the person of A, as explained above. In J. Sulemaniyya, the coding of P cannot bind with the verbal stem when it is first or second person. In J. Rustaqa, the coding of P is always external to the verbal stem.

(30) J. Koy Sanjak (Mutzafi 2004a)

a. *graš -ew =ila*
pull.PROG -POSS.3SG.M:P =COP.3SG.F:A
'She is pulling him.'

b. *graš -an =ila*
pull.PROG -POSS.1PL:P =COP.3SG.F:A
'She is pulling us.'

c. *graša =wex -xu*
pull.PROG =COP.1PL:A -OBL.3PL:P
'We are pulling them.'

(31) J. Sulemaniyya (Khan 2004b)

a. *garoš -ew =ya*
pull.PROG -POSS.3SG.F:P =COP.3SG.M:A
'She is pulling him.'

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b. *garoša =ya ʾəllan*
pull.PROG =COP.3SG.F:P 1PL.ACC
'She is pulling us.'

c. *garoš -u =yex*
pull.PROG -POSS.3PL:P =COP.3PL:A
'We are pulling them.'

(32) J. Rustaqa (Khan 2002b)

a. *lā garoše=la ʾəlleu*
PRS.IND pull.PROG=COP.3SG.F:A 3SG.M.ACC
'She is pulling him.'

b. *lā garoše=la ʾəllan*
PRS.IND pull.PROG=COP.3SG.F:A 1PL.ACC
'She is pulling us.'

c. *lā garoša=wex ʾəllu*
PRS.IND pull.PROG=COP.1PL:A 3PL.ACC
'We are pulling them.'

As in the vast majority of NENA dialects, the participle shows an accusative pattern in J. Koy Sanjak, agreeing only with S and A. This generally also holds true for J. Sulemaniyya and J. Ḥalabja. In these dialects, however, participial agreement may also be controlled by P, reflecting a neutral pattern. This only occurs when a P-index is present and attached to the immediately preceding verbal stem. The agreement pattern is thus neutral, treating S, A, and P alike. The agreement is also hierarchical in the sense that it is controlled by the feminine argument, if one is present, irrespective of whether the argument has S, A, or P role. Thus, in the following examples, the feminine argument can control participial agreement for all syntactic roles (S, A, P). In order for it to control agreement with P, however, an additional affix must be bound to the verbal stem, such as *-aw* 'her'. If the feminine P argument is external to verbal form, such as a flagged pronoun like *ʾəllax* ACC.2PL 'you', it does not trigger participial agreement. This contrast with nonfeminine arguments, such as a masculine singular argument, which only shows participial agreement with S and A.

(33) J. Sulemaniyya (Khan 2004b)

a. *smix-Ø-a =yena*
wait.RES.PTCP-M:S-SG:S =COP.1SG.M:S
'I (M) have waited.' Masculine participial agreement with S

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b. *qəṭl-Ø-a* *=yena* *ʾəllax*
kill.RES.PTCP-M:A-SG:A =COP.1SG.M:A 2SG.F.ACC
'I (M) have killed you (F.SG).' Masculine participial agreement with A

c. *smix-t-a* *=ya*
wait.RES.PTCP-F:S-SG:S =COP.3SG.F:S
'She has waited.' Feminine participial agreement with S

d. *qṭəl-t* *-aw* *=ye*
kill.RES.PTCP-F:P -POSS.3SG.F:P =COP.3SG.M:A
'He has killed her.' Feminine participial agreement with P

e. *qṭəl-t* *-ew* *=ya*
kill.RES.PTCP-F:A -POSS.3SG.M:P =COP.3SG.F:A
'She has killed him.' Feminine participial agreement with A

In the Jewish dialects of Iranian Azerbaijan, the LL-series are used for all persons in complex verb forms. In the realis perfect and pluperfect, however, intransitive and transitive clauses each possess morphological peculiarities which incidentally result in the distinct treatment of S, A and P (see Noorlander 2021a). Importantly, in the northern dialects, including J. Urmi, an ergative pattern can be observed in feminine participial agreement. In contrast to the above examples from J. Sulemaniyya, in J. Urmi, overt agreement with the feminine argument is only observed for A, not for S or P. Thus in the following examples showing the expression of the perfect in J. Solduz, the *t*-morpheme that expresses feminine participial agreement only appears with feminine A arguments, not with S nor with P.

(34) J. Solduz (Garbell 1965c, Khan 2008a)

a. *dmix* *-an* *-wa*
sleep.PST -1SG.F:S -PST
'I (F) had fallen asleep.' No participial agreement with S

b. *⁺qtil* ***-t*** *-an* *-wa* *-lox*
kill.PST **-RES.PTCP.F.SG:A** -1SG.F:A -PST -OBL.2SG.M:P
'I (F) have killed you (M.SG).' Feminine participial agreement with A

c. *dmix* *-a* *-wa*
sleep.PST -3SG.F:S -PST
'She had fallen asleep.' No participial agreement with S

d. *⁺qtil* *-é* *-wa* *-la*
kill.PST -RES.PTCP.3SG.M:A -PST -OBL.3SG.F:P
'He had killed her.' No participial agreement with P

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e. *⁺qtil -t -á -wa -le*
kill.PST -RES.PTCP.F.SG:A-3SG.F:A -PST -OBL.3SG.M:P
'She had killed him.' Feminine participial agreement with A

Turning to the Trans-Zab Jewish dialects located in western Iran, alignment in the complex perfect is ergative throughout for the third person. Both the copula and the participle agree only with S and P. In such transitive complex perfects, there is no verbal coding of A, and the A argument remains unmarked. However, P-indexing in this manner is only possible when A and P are both third person, as the following alternation illustrates.

(35) J. Saqiz (Israeli 1998: 229)

a. Copula/participle agree with S
blan-u dmix-e =n
daughter.PL-POSS.3PL fall_asleep.RES.PTCP-PL:S =COP.3PL:S
'Their daughters have fallen asleep.' (Lit. 'Their daughters are fallen asleep.)

b. Copula/participle agree with P only
šulṭana blan-u qəṭl-e =n
king.M.SG daughter.PL-POSS.3PL kill.RES.PTCP-PL:P =COP.3PL:P
'The king has killed their daughters.' (Lit. 'The king are killed their daughters.'

In southeastern Trans-Zab Jewish dialects, the ergative agreement pattern in the complex perfect is incompatible with first and second person arguments, which must be expressed external to the verbal form. For first and second person, therefore, the verb only agrees with S, such as the verb 'to dance' in the example below. First and second person P argument necessarily appear in accusative case, such as *əli* ACC.1SG 'me', as seen in the example below.

(36) J. Kerend (Hopkins 2002: 293–294)

a. *ʾana rqil-a =yena*
1SG.NOM dance.RES.PTCP-M.SG:S =COP.1SG:S
'I (M) have danced.' Copula+participle agree with S

b. *ʾonye rqil-e =n*
3PL.NOM dance.RES.PTCP-PL:S =COP.3PL:S
'They have danced.' Copula+participle agree with S

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c. *onye* *əli* *qəṭla=y*
3PL.NOM ACC.1SG:P kill.RES.PTCP=COP
'They have killed me.' No agreement, P is flagged

When A is first or second person, the complex perfect is impossible, and instead the speakers take recourse to a past verbal form to express a perfect (Hopkins 2002), as the following example illustrates. Consequnetly, first and second person arguments are expressed differently across all syntactic roles.

(37) J. Kerend (Hopkins 2002: 289)

a. *gərš-i-li*
pull.PST-3PL:P-OBL.1SG:A
'I have pulled them.'

b. *əlax* *grəš-li*
2SG.F.ACC pull.PST-OBL.1SG:A
'I have pulled you (F.SG).'

22.2.4.4 Combinations of flagging and indexing

In the Trans-Zab Jewish dialects located in Iranian Azerbaijan and eastern Iraqi Kurdistan, accusative flagging and indexing can occur independently or in combination (see §21.2.3.1 and §21.2.3.2).

In clauses based on past stem verb forms, accusative flagging can also be combined with the argument being indexed by the clitic LL-series or L-series, e.g.,

(38) J. Arbel (Khan 1999b: 498.83)
ġzé-le *=llew* *əl-xalon-əd*
see.PST-OBL.3SG.M:A =ACC.3SG.M:P ACC-uncle.M.SG-CSTR
bab-í
father.M.SG.-POSS.1SG
'He saw the maternal uncle of my father.'

(39) J. Solduz (Garbell 1965b: 150)
∅-šulṭana *əl-bron-ew*
NOM-king.M.SG ACC-son.M.SG-POSS.3SG.M
nšəq-le-le
kiss.PST-OBL.3SG.M:A-OBL.3SG.M:P
'The king kissed his son.'

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Thus, in the Jewish dialects of eastern Iraqi Kurdistan and those of Iranian Azerbaijan, P-indexing can be optionally combined with accusative flagging in complex verb forms too, e.g.,

(40) J. Koy Sanjak (Mutzafi, p.c.)
ʾəl-bron-aw *nšəq-t-ew* *=ila*
ACC-son.M.SG-POSS.3SG.F kiss.PST-SG.F:A-3SG.M:P =COP.3SG.F:A
'She kissed her son.'

(41) J. Urmi (Garbell 1965b: 119)
ʾəl-do *xšəlta* *dehwe* *g-talme*
ACC-GEN.DEM.SG jewel.F.SG gold.PL in-pitcher
dri-t-at-tu
put.RES.PTCP-F.SG:A-2SG.F:A-OBL.3PL:P
'Have you (F.SG) put those jewels (and) pieces of gold into the pitchers?'

The combination of accusative flagging and ergative indexing is not possible in the Trans-Zab Jewish dialects located in western Iran (e.g., Hopkins 2002; Khan 2009: 319). Indeed, the incompatibility of P-flagging and P-indexing prevails throughout the entire system (see §21.2.1 and §21.2.3.2). As a consequence, this incidentally leads to the impossibility of the combination of ergative indexing and accusative flagging in these dialects, e.g.,

(42) J. Saqiz

a. *líma* *∅-xaləst-í* *məṭy-a*
when NOM-sister.F.SG-POSS.1SG arrive.PST-3SG.F:S
bel-óx
house.M.SG-POSS.2SG.M
'When did my sister arrive at your house?' (Israeli 1998: 103)

b. *∅-Aḥmad* *(∗əl-)xalist-év*
NOM-Ahmad.M.SG (ACC-)sister.F.SG-POSS.3SG.M
xəzy-a-le
see.PST-3SG.F:P-OBL.3SG.M:A
'Ahmad saw his sister.' (Israeli 1998: 103)

(43) J. Saqiz

a. *∅-blan-u* *məṭy-e* *=n*
NOM-daughter.PL-POSS.3PL arrive.RES.PTCP-PL:S =COP.3PL:S
'Their daughters have arrived.' (Israeli 1998: 103)

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b. *∅-brat-év* *(∗əl-)axonowal-áv* *la*
NOM-daughter.F.SG.-POSS.3SG.M (ACC-)brother.PL-POSS.3SG.M NEG
xəzy-e *=n*
see.RES.PTCP-PL:P =COP.3PL:P
'His daughter has not seen her brothers.' (Israeli 1998: 103)

Located further to the west, the Jewish dialects of Sulemaniyya and Ḥalabja, however, do allow differential object indexing and flagging to be freely combined. Consequently, ergative indexing is freely combined with accusative flagging. This pattern is illustrated in the example below and summarised in Table 22.2.4.1.

(44) J. Sulemaniyya

a. *∅-yalé* *zil-i* *ta-maktab-i* *hulaye*
NOM-child.PL go.PST-3PL:S to-school-EZ Jew.PL
'The children went to the school of the Jews.' (Khan 2004b: 514.151)

b. *lă-yalé* *ləbl-i-le* *ta-baġdád*
ACC-child.PL take.PST-3PL:P-OBL.3SG.M:A to-baghdad
'He took the children to Baghdad.' (Khan 2004b, 326)

22.3 Alignment types across Iranian languages in the region

Broadly speaking, Kurdic languages (with the exception of Southern Kurdish) exhibit split alignment in indexing, flagging, or both. The alignment patters are split according to tense, with an accusative alignment pattern in clauses based on present stem verb forms, but with various patterns in clauses based on past stem verb forms. In conservative dialects of Iranian languages, these past stem-based clauses show ergative alignment, grouping S and P. The most coherent form of this split can be found in the dialects of Behdînî NK. In Behdînî NK, only one of the two arguments in transitive clauses can be grammatically indexed, so that the conditioning of obligatory S-like indexing of either A or P is also based on the presence of either a present or past stem verb form. S-like indexing also correspond directly to the S-like unmarked case form of the respective full NP or free pronoun. In the majority of Northern Kurdish dialects, however, only S-indexing is obligatory in past stem verb forms, and the unmarked case form is confined to S arguments. In most of Central Kurdish and Gorani, the P-markers function

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as pronominal indices only, while S- and A-indexing are both obligatory, irrespective of tense and irrespective of their morphological alignnment (see Haig 2018a). Thus, the indexing system is accusative in its trigger potential and conditioning in such dialects, even though the morphology can reflect nonaccusative alignment patterns. The dialects with obligatory S- and A-indexing also tend to lack argument flagging, so that full NPs and free pronouns typically appear in their unmarked case form throughout.[1]

22.3.1 Verbal clauses built on present stem verbs

22.3.1.1 Accusative flagging and indexing

Accusative alignment is illustrated by the following example from Northern Kurdish: the 1SG pronoun takes the direct form *ez* while functioning as S and A, but the oblique form *min* when appearing as P. Similarly, the A-indexing aligns with S, and there is no P-indexing, see (45).

(45) a. ***ez*** *t-ê-**m***
1SG.DIR IND-come.PRS-1SG:S
'I (S) come.'

b. ***ez*** *mast* *di-kiř-**im***
1SG.DIR yoghurt IND-buy.PRS-1SG:A
'I am buying yoghurt.'

c. *ew* ***min*** *di-bi-**n***
3PL 1SG.OBL IND-take.PRS-3PL:A
'They take me.'

Accusative alignment is found in all clauses built on present stem verbs, including past imperfective in Goranî (46) and past habitual in Behdînî (47).

(46) Hewramî Tekht (Mohammadirad forthcoming)
zarołe)-ê *bazî* *ker-ên-ê*
child-PL.DIR game.SG.DIR do.PRS-AUG-3PL:A
'The children were playing a game.' [ŞE.09]

(47) NK Akre (MacKenzie 1962: 242)

[1]Note that the unmarked forms of the first- and second-person pronouns reflect historically oblique forms, despite not marking case in the modern varieties. Compare the Northern Kurdish *ez* [1SG.DIR]/*min* [1SG.OBL] with the Central Kurdish *min* [1SG].

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*mirovek hebû, hemû rojê da ç-**ît**=e çîyay,*
man existed, every day HAB.PST go.PRS-3SG.S=DRCT mountain,
*da bi xo pştîekê dara în-**ît**=e bajêrî, bi xo*
HAB.PST for self a.load.of wood bring.PRS-3SG:A=DRCT city, for self
*da firoş-**ît***
HAB.PST sell.PRS-3SG:A
'Once there was a man who used to go every day to the mountains by himself and bring a load of wood to town on his back, (when) he would himself sell it'

In Hewramî, accusative flagging is conditioned by the properties of the P argument (see §21.4.2.2).

22.3.1.2 Neutral alignment of free person markers

There is an effect of person on accusative alignment in Goranî and northern varieties of CK. In Goranî (more specifically, the conservative Hewramî), speech act pronouns have lost their case distinction, rendering the alignment system neutral for these pronouns; see the coding of *min* in (48).

(48) a. ***min** mi-l-û*
1SG IND-go.PRS-1SG:S
'I go.'

b. ***min** ađî wîn-û*
1SG 3SG.M.OBL see.PRS.IND-1SG:A
'I see him.'

c. *ađ **min** wîn-o*
3SG.DIR 1SG.OBL see.PRS-3SG:A
'He sees me.'

In the northern varieties of NK, accusative alignment is restricted to 3SG (Öpengin 2016: 95), rendering the alignment pattern with the rest of the independent pronouns neutral.

22.3.2 Verbal clauses built on past stem verbs

22.3.2.1 Ergative alignment

Prototypical ergative alignment prevails among the Behdînî varieties of NK, where both argument flagging and argument indexing group S and P against A;

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see (49) where S and P arguments are in the direct case and the verb agrees with them, and A is in the oblique case.

(49) NK Behdînî

a. ***tu*** *hat-**î***
2SG.DIR come.PST-2SG:S
'You came.'

b. *min* ***tu*** *dît-**î***
1SG.OBL 2SG.DIR see.PST-2SG:P
'I saw you.'

c. ***te*** *ez* *dît-im*
2SG.OBL 1SG.DIR see.PST-1SG:P
'You saw me.'

In conservative dialects of Gorani, such as Hewramî, ergative alignment is most consistently evident in the pronominal indices, where S and P are grouped through the affixal person markers and only A is expressed with oblique clitics; see (50).

(50) Hewramî

a. *wit-**ê***
sleep.PST-3PL:S
'They slept.'

b. *berd-**ê**=**şa***
take.PST-3PL.P=OBL.3PL:A
'They took them.'

The same ergative pattern of pronominal indices can be seen across the majority of Central Kurdish, e.g.,

(51) CK Mukri

a. *řoyşt-**în***
go.PST-1PL:S
'We went.'

b. *bird=**yan**-**în***
take.PST=OBL.3PL:A-1PL:P
'They took us.'

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22.3.2.2 Optional ergative flagging

Apart from the Behdînî dialects of NK, other Kurdic varieties have retained ergative flagging of the A-past argument only in specific contexts (see §21.4.2.1). For example, in northern vareities of CK, the A-past argument is flagged only when it is in narrow focus, e.g.,

(52) *be xwa xwa-y da*
by God God-M.SG.OBL give.PST
'By God, (it was) *God* (who) granted [it to me].' (Khan et al. 2022b: 124)

22.3.2.3 Accusative alignment

Throughout Central and Southern Kurdish and most of Gorani, the cross-indexing of S and A arguments is obligatory, while P-indexing is chiefly pronominal and does not occur with a co-nominal. In terms of trigger potential and conditionality, the indexing system is, therefore, accusative (see also Haig 2008 for discussion).

(53) Central Kurdish (Haig 2018a: 803)
dena ***ewan***$_i$*=î* *de-kuşt/**-***in***$_i$
otherwise them.P=3SG.OBL:A IPFV-kill.PST-3PL:P
'Otherwise he would kill them.'

In Southern Kurdish, the entire system, including clauses based on past stem verbs, is nominative-accusative, where S and A are obligatorily expressed by affixal person markers, while P is indexed by oblique clitics.

22.3.2.4 Neutral alignment

Neutral alignment in past stem-based constructions is attested in the Bajalani variety of Gorani as recorded in MacKenzie (1956), where the indices for S, A, and P morphologically belong to the same oblique set, with the exception of 3SG. However, the oblique clitics that express S are distinct from those that express A and P in that they occur in a fixed position immediately after the verbal stem, whereas the A and P oblique indices are mobile (see §23).

(54) Bajalani (MacKenzie 1956)

a. *xas hut=****îta***
well sleep.PST=OBL.2PL:S
'Did you sleep well?'

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b. *sêr=**ta*** *ward*
enough=OBL.2PL:A eat.PST
'Have you eaten enough?'

Neutral alignment is seen in patterns of argument flagging in CK and Gorani. As with present tense constructions, neutral alignment is conditioned by the person of the core arguments. In CK, except for 3SG, all the other pronouns have neutral alignment. In Hewramî, speech act pronouns have neutral alignment.

(55) Hewramî

a. ***min*** *wit-a*
1SG sleep.PST-1SG:S
'I slept.'

b. *epase* ***min*** *wat*
as 1SG say.PST
'As I said, '

c. *to* ***min**=it* *quł* *kerđ-a*
2SG 1SG=2SG:A hole do.PST-1SG:P
'You disabled me.'

22.3.2.5 Horizontal alignment

In terms of argument flagging, horizontal alignment occurs in the Northern Kurdish varieties outside the Behdînî region. Here, both A and P arguments appear in the oblique case and remain unindexed, while the S argument appears in the direct case and is obligatorily indexed, e.g.,

(56) NK Muş

a. ***ez*** *hat-im*
1SG.DIR come.PST.1SG:S
'I came.'

b. ***min*** *dît*
1SG.OBL see.PST
'I saw.'

c. *wî* ***min*** *dît*
3SG.OBL 1SG.OBL see.PST
'He saw me.'

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The same analysis can be applied to the pattern of pro-indexing morphology in the southern varieties of CK and peripheral Gorani dialects. Here, A and P are indexed by mobile oblique clitics, while only S is indexed by affixal person markers (see §23).

(57) CK Sanandaj

a. *çû-yn*
go.PST-1PL:S
'We went.'

b. *bird=**man=yan***
take.PST=OBL.1PL.P=OBL.3PL:A
'They took us.'

22.3.2.6 Tripartite alignment

The two aspects of verbal person marking in Central Kurdish have led some scholars (e.g., Haig 2008, Öpengin 2013b) to subsume the system of argument indexing in CK under tripartite alignment, where "S, A and P each determine a distinct, but partially overlapping, type of agreement." (Haig 2008: 302). According to Öpengin (2013b: 271): "A tripartite analysis of the alignment in Mukri and in CK, on the other hand, takes both of these aspects of the issue into account, since while S-past and A-past agreement are differentiated on morphological grounds, S past and P-past agreement are not equated on morphosyntactic grounds." In other words, in clauses with full NPs, S-past, A-past and P-past are all morphologically distinguished, in which case the P-past argument cannot be indexed; se (58) where neither the third-person plural clitic nor affix person marker can co-occur with the patient that it indexes, in this case *marekan* 'snakes'.

(58) Common Central Kurdish

a. *kiçekan* *hat-in*
girl.DEF.PL come.PST -1PL:S
'The girls came.'

b. *kiçeke* *marekan(=∗yan)=î* *kuşt(-∗in)*
girl.DEF.SG snake.DEF.PL(=OBL.3PL:P)=OBL.3SG:A kill.PST(-3PL:P)
'The girl killed the snakes.'

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22.4 Alignment types in Armenian dialects of the region

22.4.1 Accusative alignment

Throughout the recorded history of Armenian, with the exception of the Classical Armenian perfect tense, the language has generally shown nominative-accusative alignment, both in terms of verb agreement and case marking. The verb agrees with S in intransitive clauses and A in transitive clauses, and S and A receive nominative (unmarked) case, as seen in (59), (60) (Classical Armenian), (61) (SEA), and (62) (SEA).

(59) Classical Armenian (Matthew 5.6)
zi nokʿa yag-escʿin
CONJ 3PL.NOM be.satisfied-AOR.SBJV.3PL
'For they shall be satisfied.'

(60) Classical Armenian (Matthew 5.5)
zi nokʿa žaŕang-escʿen z-erkir
CONJ 3PL.NOM inherit-AOR.SBJV.3PL ACC-earth
'For they shall inherit the earth.'

(61) SEA (*Bible: New Etchmiadzin* 2020)
orovhetev nrankʿ k-hagen-an
CONJ 3PL.NOM PTCL-be.satisfied-3PL
'For they shall be satisfied.'

(62) SEA (*Bible: New Etchmiadzin* 2020)
orovhetev nrankʿ yerkir-ə k-žaŕang-en
CONJ 3PL.NOM earth-DEF PTCL-inherit-3PL
'For they shall inherit the earth.'

In Armenian, the verb never agrees with P (although in some dialects spoken in Iran, the "possessive articles" can function as object clitics, as discussed in §21.5.1.2). The case marking of P referents varies across dialects, with most forms of Armenian showing some type of DOM, as discussed in §21.5.2.2.

22.4.2 Tripartite alignment: Classical Armenian perfect tense

The only example of non-accusative alignment in the history of the Armenian language concerns the Classical Armenian perfect tense. This tense was formed

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of an invariant participle, which showed no agreement, and an optional copula, which agreed with the subject in intransitive clauses, as seen in (63), but generally showed default third person singular agreement in transitive clauses, as seen in (64) and discussed by Meyer (2023: 138-9).

(63) CA (Meyer 2023: 138)
ew orpēs etun zroycʿ or-kʿ ənd nma ekeal
and as give.AOR.3PL news which-NOM.PL with 3SG.DAT come.PTCP
ēin
be.PST.3PL
'And as those, who came with him, reported …'

(64) CA (Meyer 2023: 139)
ew git-em tʿē ls-eal ē z-xorhurd-s mer
and know-PRS.1SG CONJ hear-PTCP be.PRS.3SG ACC-plan-ACC.PL 1PL.GEN
Parskacʿ kap-en z-na ew vštacʿucʿan-en
Persian.GEN.PL bind-PRS.3SG ACC-3SG and torment-PRS.3PL
'I know that [if] the Persians have heard our plans, they [will] imprison him and torment [him].'

In intransitive clauses, the subject generally took nominative, i.e., unmarked, case, as seen in (63), while in transitive clauses, the subject took genitive case, and the object showed differential object marking, receiving accusative case if definite/specific, as seen in (64), and being unmarked for case if indefinitenon-specific, as seen in 65 (see §21.5.2.2).

(65) Classical Armenian (Hewson & Bubenik 1997: 76)
gorc gorceal ē nora
work make.PTCP be.PRS.3SG 3SG.GEN
'He has accomplished a work.'

There are some cases where agentive subjects of intransitive verbs receive genitive case, like the subjects of transitive verbs, as seen in (66) (see Vaux 2005: 7-8), so it is possible that this case-marking pattern was sensitive to agentivity, rather than transitivity in itself.

(66) Classical Armenian (Vaux 2005: 8)
očʿ xoseal nocʿa erbekʿ
NEG speak.PTCP 3PL.GEN never
'They have never spoken.'

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22.5 Discussion

The commonalities in tense-aspect-sensitive alignment splits shared by Aramaic and Iranian have received considerable attention in the literature (see Coghill 2016, Khan 2017a and Noorlander 2021a,c for recent overviews, with further references therein). Clauses containing present stem verbs generally remain accusative throughout in both Neo-Aramaic and Neo-Iranian, as do those based on the complex progressive in NENA. Only clauses based on past stem verbs and, in the case of NENA, also those based on complex perfects, show alignment types that deviate from the accusative type. In terms of alignment typology, however, the North-eastern and Central Neo-Aramaic dialects mostly diverge from their neighbouring Iranian languages. While both language groups assign a kind of "oblique" coding to A in the past and perfect, in contradistinction to the present, this does **not** mean that the alignment is also by definition ergative. Alignment types are identified on the basis of groupings of S, A and/or P on some level of morphological or syntactic analysis, not on the basis of one transitive construction.

There are noticeable parallels with respect to transitive past stem constructions in NENA verbal person marking and in the Iranian verbal system, which were addressed in Chapter 13. However, this does not entail that intransitive constructions reflect the same measure of convergence. Indeed, the primary divergence between the two language groups is due to the distinctive treatment of S in perfect and past perfective constructions in the respective languages. In the vast majority of NENA dialects, S is generally expressed like the "oblique" A, instantiating accusative (A = S ≠ **P**) or neutral morphology (A = S = P), while, in the Iranian languages, S is generally not expressed like the "oblique" A, instantiating ergative (S = P ≠ **A**) or horizontal morphology (A = P ≠ **S**). This Iranian-like expression of S like P, yet unlike the "oblique" A, (S = P ≠ **A**) in Neo-Aramaic is generally only found in the south-eastern Trans-Zab Jewish dialects and, outside of the NENA-speaking region, in Ṭuroyo Neo-Aramaic. In both Neo-Aramaic dialect groups, this is limited to the third person, and in Ṭuroyo Neo-Aramaic, it primarily concerns pronominal indices on the verb, rarely the cross-indexing of co-nominals.

A remarkable parallel in Ṭuroyo Neo-Aramaic dialects, however, is the emergence of Iranian-like horizontal alignment, which is necessary for first and second person object indices. This closely converges with the dominant "double oblique" case system in Northern Kurdish (outside of the Behdînî area), as reflected below, which closely parallels Ṭuroyo Neo-Aramaic. In the south-eastern Trans-Zab Jewish dialects of NENA, horizontal verbal person marking is the re-

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sult of lenition of the LL-series that serve as cross-indexes of P, which can end up identical or similar to the "oblique" L-suffixes that cross-index A, e.g.,

(67) Ṭuroyo Neo-Aramaic (Midyat)

a. *ʾaθi-no*
come.PST-1SG.M:S
'I came.'

b. *ʾaθ-at*
come.PST-2SG:S
'You came.'

c. *ḥze-lox-li*
see.PST-OBL.2SG.M:A-OBL.1SG:A
'You saw me.'

(68) NK Muş

a. *ez hat-im*
DIR.1SG come.PST-1SG:S
'I came.'

b. *tu hat-î*
DIR.3SG come.PST-1SG:S
'You came.'

c. *te min dît*
OBL.2SG OBL.1SG see.PST
'You saw me.'

(69) Gorani

a. *ama-î*
come.PST-1SG:S
'I came.'

b. *ama-î*
come.PST-2SG:S
'You came.'

c. *dî=m=it*
see.PST=OBL.1SG:P=OBL.2SG:P
'You saw me.'

(70) J. Saqiz (Yisraeli 1998)

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a. *iye-na*
come.PST-1SG.M:S
'I came.'

b. *iy-et*
come.PST-2SG.M
'You came.'

c. *xze-lox-li* *(< xze-lox əli)*
see.PST-OBL.2SG.M-OBL.1SG
'You saw me.'

Conversely, in the neighbouring Iranian languages, the identical marking of S-past and A-past as in NENA has thus far only been recorded among Bajalani speakers near Mosul, resulting in a system where S, A, and P are all expressed by oblique indices. This shows a striking similarity to the neutral alignment found in some NENA dialects, e.g.,

(71) Gorani Bajalani Mosul (MacKenzie 1956: 423, 432)

a. *āmā* *=yšān*
come.PST =OBL.3PL:S
'They came.'

b. *arnā* *=m* *=iš*
put.PST =OBL.1SG:A =OBL.3SG:P
'I put it down.'

c. *amin dūwa zalām-a=m kušt*
1SG two man-DEM =OBL.1SG:A put.PST
'I killed two men.'

Moreover, one feature that is typical of Neo-Aramaic syntax is tripartite alignment, whereby each syntactic role is treated differently (**A S P**). Overall, in NENA, on the syntactic level of trigger potential and conditioning, the flagging or cross-indexing of P is conditional, while that of S and A is obligatory. This is also arguably a core feature of the syntax in the neighbouring Neo-Iranian languages (with the exception of Behdînî varieties of Northern Kurdish, which have a consistent ergative pattern in past constructions).

In NENA, intransitive constructions and transitive constructions generally have their own syntax and morphology. Thus, many restrictions on alignment are specific to past perfective transitive constructions, resulting in the same person restrictions on accusative as well as ergative types of verbal person marking.

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Moreover, the conditioning factors for P-indexing and/or P-flagging are predominantly coordinated with the differential treatment of direct objects in NENA. In some conservative dialects, A also possesses unique properties that set it apart from S (as well as P). This combination of construction-specific properties as well as the differential coding of P appears largely irrespective of the alignment of the main sets of person markers and/or case-markers in the relevant NENA dialects. For instance, the A argument is generally morphologically distinct from S and P in Central Kurdish and Gorani in that it is expressed by mobile oblique clitics; this is the case irrespective of whether P is expressed like S or like A in such dialects. Thus, even in Bajalani, where all arguments are expressed through the same set, only the A argument shows clitic movement, as (Xc) illustrates, which would incidentally reflect an ergative property even in this dialect. Moreover, while the P argument may be expressed through the same set of person markers as S or A in Central Kurdish and Gorani, agreement with S and A is generally obligatory, in contrast to P. Thus, P-indexing does not generally co-occur with an overt object NP. In the end, therefore, S may share a number of properties with A and/or P, and, yet, on other levels of analysis, A and P seem to each have unique properties of their own that contrast with S.

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23 Word order in verbal clauses

In this chapter, word order patterns of the core constituents of the clause are identified on the basis of frequency dominance in line with (Dryer 2007: 73–78). This concerns the linear ordering and placement of arguments relative to the verb when the arguments are realised as full lexical noun phrases or independent pronouns. For bound pronouns, i.e., bound person markers, pronominal suffixes, or verbal indexes, see Chapter 13. Drawing on the corpus-based methods and word order studies published in (Haig et al. (2024)), among non-subject arguments, we distinguish between indefinite direct object NPs, definite direct object NPs, goals of motion and caused motion verbs such as 'to go' and 'to bring', addressees of verbs such as 'to say', and recipients of ditransitive verbs such as 'to give'. In addition to order, the measure of rigidity or flexibility in positioning the constituents will also be relevant, i.e., whether the word order is relatively fluid or fixed. Overall, the surface syntax of the clause will be discussed rather than pragmatic, formal, or information-structural configurations.

23.1 Word order in NENA

Word order varies significantly across dialects of NENA. In this section, we also draw on comparisons with Central Neo-Aramaic (CNA) languages closely related to NENA, notably Ṭuroyo and Mlaḥso located in south-eastern Turkey, and Western Neo-Aramaic (WNA), notably the dialect of Maaloula, located in south-western Syria. For more information regarding the word order of Ṭuroyo, see Waltisberg (2016: 289–290) on Ṭuroyo. See also Noorlander & Molin (2022) and Noorlander (2024a,b) on NENA.

23.1.1 Position of direct objects

In general, VO is the most common order overall across NENA dialects, with OV order being more prevalent in the eastern and northern sectors. However, there are important exceptions to consider, which are correlated with the identifiability and referentiality of the object.

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Table 23.1: Overview of dominant configurations

Dialect	**VO**	**VGoal**	**VAddr**
C. Barwar	+	+	+
C. Shaqlawa	−	+	+
C. Urmi	−	+	−
C./J. Sanandaj	−	+	+

First of all, we need to distinguish between dialects where the position of direct objects is relatively fixed and dialects where it is relatively free. In the dialects where the order is relatively fixed, corpus-based studies show an overwhelmingly higher rate of either preverbal or postverbal object placement (Noorlander 2025a), as summarised in Table 23.2. In Jewish and Christian Sanandaj, for instance, OV order is rather fixed, which can be contrasted with the relatively fixed VO order of C. Qaraqosh, as well as other Neo-Aramaic languages, such as Ṭuroyo in Turkey and Maaloula in Syria.

Table 23.2: Distribution of postverbal direct objects (nominal NPs) in Neo-Aramaic languages with relatively fixed word order

Dialect	% Postverbal	Dominant order
J. Urmi	1%	OV
C. Sanandaj	2%	OV
J. Sanandaj	5%	OV
Mlaḥso (Diyarbakir, Central Neo-Aramaic)	8%	OV
C. Qaraqosh	93%	VO
Ṭuroyo (Midyat, Central Neo-Aramaic)	92%	VO
Maaloula (Western Neo-Aramaic)	99%	VO

Nevertheless, in the majority of NENA dialects, word order is fluid, as shown in Table 23.3. Direct object NPs can be placed on either side of the verb with greater freedom than in the abovementioned dialects. For example, the examples from C. Hertevin show both VAP (1a) and PVA (1b) word order. The examples from C. Urmi show both APV (2a) and AVP (2b) word order, and the examples from J. Urmi show both PV (3a) and VP (3b) word order, with the pronominal agent ommited.

(1) C. Hertevin

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Table 23.3: Distribution of postverbal direct objects (nominal and pronominal) in Neo-Aramaic languages with fluid word order

Dialect	**N (Total)**	**% of which Postverbal**	Dominant Order
J. Dohok	238	87%	VO
C. Barwar	345	80%	VO
J. Betanure	239	71%	VO
J. Barzan	74	65%	VO (?)
C. Bohtan	101	32%	OV
J. Arbel	172	22%	OV
C. Urmi	258	16%	OV
C. Shaqlawa	108	13%	OV
Mlaḥso, Qamishli, CNA	261	20%	OV

a. VAP
ʾo lele ḥze-le ḥakoma ḥa ḥəlma
DEM.SG night see.PST-OBL.3SG.M:A ruler.M.SG INDF dream.M.SG
'That night the ruler saw a dream.' (Jastrow, 154.477)

b. PVA
ḥa ḥəlma ḥze-le Zăkərya
INDF dream.M.SG see.PST-OBL.3SG.M:A Zechariah.M.SG
'Zechariah saw a dream.' (Jastrow 1988: 166.605)

(2) C. Urmi

a. APV
səppərta biyyə mutti-la
bird.F.SG egg.PL put.PST-OBL.3SG.M:A
'The bird laid eggs.' (Noorlander, elicited; cf. (Khan 2016b))

b. AVP
səppərta mutti-la biyyə
bird.F.SG put.PST-OBL.3SG.M:A egg.PL
'The bird laid eggs.' (Noorlander, elicited; cf. (Khan 2016b))

(3) J. Urmi

a. PV

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əl-šalomo *hammelex* *xzé-le-le*
DOM-Solomon.M.SG king.M.SG.DEF see.PST-OBL.3SG.M:A-OBL.3SG.M:P
'He saw king Solomon.' (Garbell 1965b: 126)

b. VP
xzé-la-le *l-d-ay* *šalomó*
see.PST-OBL.3SG.F:A-OBL.3SG.M:P DOM-OBL-DEM.SG Solomon.M.SG
hammelex
king.M.SG.DEF
'She saw that king Solomon.' (Garbell 1965b: 127)

Corpus-based studies (Noorlander & Molin 2022; Noorlander 2024b,a, 2025a) have shown that in the NENA dialects with relatively free word order, the statistically dominant order can be either VO or OV. In some of the dialects with relatively flexible word order, definite direct objects, and especially independent pronouns, appear in preverbal position significantly more often than indefinite NPs, as shown in Table 23.4.

Table 23.4: Distribution of postverbal direct objects in NENA subdivided by definiteness and lexicality

Dialect	Pronoun		Definite Nominal		Indefinite Nominal	
	N	Post-V	N	Post-V	N	Post-V
C. Qaraqosh	5	0%	66	83%	111	100%
J. Dohok	8	13%	62	73%	148	97%
C. Barwar	12	8%	121	71%	192	81%
J. Betanure	5	0%	90	54%	116	81%
J. Barzan	–	–	25	72%	27	70%
C. Bohtan	1	0%	57	21%	36	47%
J. Arbel	11	0%	67	39%	79	24%
C. Urmi	37	8%	153	8%	49	49%
C. Shaqlawa	7	29%	49	8%	45	13%
Mlaḥso, Qamishli, CNA	36	17%	97	16%	90	28%

23.1.2 Position of other verbal complements

Verbal complements follow the verb in the majority of NENA dialects, as shown in Table 23.5.

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Table 23.5: Rate of post-verbal Goals, Recipients/Beneficiaries and Addressees (nominal and pronominal)

Dialect	Goals		Recipients		Addressees	
	N	Post-V	N	Post-V	N	Post-V
C. Urmi, OV	129	92%	11	73%	37	24%
J. Urmi, OV	59	86%	19	11%	55	33%
C. Sanandaj, OV	44	84%	4	75%	5	80%
J. Sanandaj, OV	207	91%	38	87%	32	72%
C. Shaqlawa, OV	44	91%	28	96%	31	97%
C. Barwar, VO	137	95%	11	81%	6	100%
J. Dohok, VO	112	99%	34	95%	31	100%
Mlaḥso, CNA, OV	152	97%	42	69%	34	50%
Ṭuroyo, Midyat CNA, VO	140	97%	24	96%	25	100%
Maaloula, WNA, VO	52	100%	6	83%	3	100%

23.1.2.1 Goals

Postverbal position is preferred for goal arguments across all dialects, irrespective of the syntax of direct objects, as shown in Table 23.5. This applies to goals of both verbs of motion, such as 'to go' and 'to come', and verbs of caused motion, such as 'to bring' and 'to take'.

23.1.2.2 Recipients of 'to give' and addressees of 'to say'

The same postverbal tendency holds for recipients and addressees in the vast majority of NENA dialects, irrespective of the dominant placement of direct objects, as shown in Table 23.5. However, the tendency for postverbal placement of recipients is somewhat less strong than the tendency for postverbal placement of goals in OV-dominant dialects. This indicates that if a dialect has a relatively fixed position for direct objects, this same degree of rigidity need not equally apply to the position of recipients and addressees.

In the northern sector, however, preverbal position seems to be preferred for addressees. It is significantly more common for addressees than for recipients to occur preverbally in the Christian NENA dialects of Urmi and Sardarid (see Noorlander 2024b), similarly to direct objects, which also show a preference for preverbal placement in these dialects. This is despite the fact that both recipients and addressees are marked by the same preposition, i.e., *qa-*; see (4).

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(4) a. Verb-Recipient
C. Sardarid (Younansardaroud 2001: 17:§10)
ʾaxnan xa ton čapač jarāy Ø-yav-ax ***qa darʿbar***
we a ton sawdust must SBJV-give-1PL to court
'We must give a ton of sawdust **to the court**.'

b. Addressee-Verb
C. Sardarid (Younansardaroud 2001: 15:§3)
ʿŠāh ʿʾAbbās ***qa vazir*** *mār=ələ*
Shah Abbas to vizier GRD.say=COP.3SG.M
'Shah Abbas says **to the vizier**...'

The dominant position of goals, recipients, and addressees in the majority of Trans-Zab Jewish dialects is postverbal. The dialect of J. Urmi described in (Khan 2008b), however, is noteworthy for its tendency to place recipients pre-verbally. The dominant position of recipients and addressees in dialects in the same region documented in Garbell (1965b) and Hopkins (1989) is postverbal, as shown in (5).

(5) a. Object-Verb-Recipient
J. Urmi (Garbell 1965b: 149.18)
əsrá dehwé hwəl-le ***ba d-o*** ***mar***
ten gold.PL gave.PFV-A.3SG.M to GEN-DEM.SG owner.CSTR
xmará
donkey.SG.M
'He gave ten pieces of gold **to the donkey owner**.'

b. Verb-Addressee
J. Urmi (Garbell 1965b: 149.20)
mər-a ***ba d-o*** ***görá***
said.PFV-A.3SFG to GEN-DEM.SG man.SG.M
'He said **to that man**...'

23.1.2.3 Final states of 'to become Y' and 'to turn X into Y'

In contrast to direct objects, but similarly to goals, the final state of change-of-state verbs, such as 'to become,' 'to turn into,' typically follows the predicate (e.g., Khan 2008a: 323), as shown in (6a). In this class one may also subsume the complements of 'to name' and 'to fill,' although, here, the object complement does not represent the final outcome of the primary object, but rather specifies the content of the verb. The complement can also be treated as a recipient in J.

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Urmi and J. Sanandaj and flagged as such (see Noorlander & Molin 2022: 251–252).

(6) a. Become-Complement
J. Solduz (Garbell 1965b: 209)
pra *xdər-e* ***dehwé***
earth.SG.M became.PFV-S.3SG.M gold.PL
'The earth turned **into pieces of gold**.'

b. Object-Verb-Complement
J. Solduz (Garbell 1965b: 231)
tunnú xurjine *ʿməly-i-la* ***dehwé***
both saddle.bag.PL filled.PFV-3PL:P-A.3SG.F gold.PL
'She filled both saddle bags **with pieces of gold**.'

With the verbs 'to say' and 'to make,' the double object construction shifts the semantics to that of 'to name X Y' and 'to make X into Y'. Thus, with the ambivalent verb (C.) *(h)wd* or (J.) *(h)wl* 'to make,' postverbal placement of the object correlates with two-argument valence and the semantics of the resulting condition, i.e., 'to turn into,' rather than the effect of a single argument verb, i.e., 'to make' (Noorlander & Molin 2022: 252–253); contrast *kăbắb* (7a) with (7b) below.

(7) a. Object-Verb
J. Sanandaj (Khan 2009: B:§35)
kăbắb *kol-i-wa*
kebab.SG.M make-A.3PL-PST
'They made **kebab**.'

b. Verb-Complement
J. Sanandaj (Khan 2009: B:§35)
kol-í-wa-le ***kăbắb***
make-A.3PL-PST-3SG.M:P kebab.SG.M
'They made it into **kebab**.'

(8) a. Object-Verb
C. Bohtan (Fox 2009: 55)
xa kaboba *iwad-le*
one kebab.M.SG make.IMPV-3SG.M:P
'Make **a kebab**!'

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b. Verb-Complement
C. Bohtan (Fox 2009: 56)
wəd-lo-le ***kaboba***
made.PFV-A.3SG.F-3SG.M:P kebab.M.SG
'She made it **into a kebab**.'

23.1.3 Object complements of non-finite verbal forms

Generally, the complement of non-finite verbs follows the syntax of the complement of finite verbs (see Khan 1999a, 2004b, 2008b, 2009; Noorlander 2024a,b). Thus, phasal verbs like 'to begin' can combine with a nominal or non-finite form of the verb, such as an infinitive or gerund; see C. Nerwa examples (9), where objects follow both finite and non-finite verbs, and J Koy Sanjak examples (10), where objects precede both finite and non-finite verbs.

(9) C. Nerwa

a. Verb(Non-finite)-Object
mšorre-ley *mzabona* *ʾəɻbe*
begin.PST-OBL.3PL:A sell.INF sheep.PL
'They started selling sheep.'

b. Verb(Finite)-Object
yə-mzabn-i-wa *ʾəɻbe*
IND-sell-3PL:A-PST sheep.PL
'They used to sell sheep.'

(10) J. Koy Sanjak

a. Object-Verb(Non-finite) (Mutzafi 2004a: 119)
bde-lu *bə-ləxma* *wala*
begin.PST-OBL.3PL LOC-bread.M.SG make.INF
'They began making bread.'

b. Object-Verb(Finite) (Mutzafi 2004a: 187.9)
ləxma *g-ol-i-wa*
bread.M.SG IND-make-3PL:A-PST
'They used to make bread.'

In C. Urmi, the placement of object complements is relatively free. This applies to the complements of both finite and non-finite verbal forms; see (11), where the object *ʾərbə* 'sheep' can occur both before and after finite and non-finte verbal forms.

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(11) C. Urmi

a. Verb(Non-finite)
ˀšuri-lun *{ʾərbə}* *bə-zvana* *{ʾərbə}*
beginPST-3PL.OBL:A sheep.PL at-buying.INF sheep.PL
'They started buying sheep.'

b. Verb(Finite)
{ʾərbə} *zvən-nun* *{ʾərbə}*
sheep.PL buy.PST-OBL.3PL:A sheep.PL
'They bought sheep.'

Finally, however, in the dialect of Hertevin, there is a discrepancy. Direct objects of infinitives have shifted to OV, while postverbal position remains dominant for direct objects in clauses with finite verbs; see the C. Hertevin examples (12) and also the C. Bohtan examples 13, where the object follows the non-finite verb in (13a) but precedes the finite verb in (13b).

(12) C. Hertevin (Jastrow 1988: §318-§319)

a. Object-Verb(Non-finite)
b-dar-aḥ *ʾida* ***gəlla*** *člaʾa*
FUT-throw-1PL:A hand.F.SG grass.M.SG mow.INF
'We started mowing **grass**.'

b. Verb(Finte)-Object
čléʾ-laḥ-le ***gəll-an***
mowed.PFV-1PL:A-3SG.M:P grass.M.SG-our
'We mowed our grass.'

(13) C. Bohtan (Fox 2009: §118)

a. Object-Verb(Non-finite)
ani *darəš-i* ***qanyon-e*** *xlowa*
they begin-A.3PL sheep-PL milk.INF
'They started milking **sheep**.'

b. Verb(Finite)-Object
oyün=se xolü-∅ ***qanyon-e***
he=ADD milk-A.3SG.M sheep-PL
'He too was milking sheep.'

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23.2 Word order in Iranian

23.2.1 Position of direct objects

Iranian languages of the region have generally been reported to have fixed OV order. This has been discussed both in descriptive accounts (e.g., McCarus 2009: 613 and Öpengin 2016: 51 for Central Kurdish; Fattah 2000: 672 for Southern Kurdish; Mahmoudveysi & Bailey 2013: 72 for Gorani Zarda), and in quantitative corpus-based accounts (e.g., Asadpour (n.d.), Haig et al. (2024), Mohammadirad (2024b)). The corpus-based overview of word order in Iranian presented in Haig et al. (2024: 25) reveals that Iranian languages of the region show less than 5% postverbal direct objects: CK Sanandaj (1%); SK Bijar (2%); NK Muş (3%); NK Lachin (2%); Zazaki Siwereg (5%); Gorani Gawraju (5%). The following examples illustrate OV order within Iranian.

(14) Gorani Gawraǰu (Mohammadirad 2022a: E, 0920)
tu *min=it* *kušt*
2SG 1SG=2SG:A kill.PST
'You killed me.'

(15) NK Akre (MacKenzie 1962)
min *kiç-a* *xo* *da* *te*
1SG.OBL daughter-EZ.F REFL give.PST.3SG 2SG.OBL
'I have given my daughter to you.'

Despite the overwhelming tendency across Kurdish for preverbal position of direct objects, there is some evidence that certain clauses, including interrogative clauses and prohibitive clauses, may allow postverbal direct objects.

(16) Hewramî Tekht (Mohammadirad 2026)

a. *m-aç-a* *şana=t* *tom-eke*
IND-say.PRS-3PL:A scatter.PST.3SG:O=2SG:A seed-DEF.M.SG.DIR
'They would say, 'Did you plant the seeds?'' [JP.39]

b. *me-koj-dê* *a* *kabra-y*
PROH-kill.PRS-2PL:A DEM.DIST fellow-M.SG.OBL
'Do not kill that man!' [SH.268]

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23.2.2 Position of other verbal complements

23.2.2.1 Goal arguments of verbs of movement

Goal arguments of verbs of movement, including 'go', 'come' (e.g., *I go* ***to the market***.), and of verbs of caused motion, including 'put', 'take' (e.g., *I put the book* ***on the table***,) are associated with a high propensity for postverbal syntax within Kurdish. The following examples illustrate the positioning of goal arguments.

(17) NK Duhok (Haig 2022)

a. *dihî* *ez* *ču-bû-m=e* ***Duhok-ê***
yesterday 1SG.DIR go.PST-PLPRF-1SG=DRCT Duhok-F.OBL
'Yesterday, I went **to Duhok**.'

b. *min* *nan* *kir=e* ***di*** ***firin-ê*** ***da***
1SG.OBL bread do.PST=DRCT ADP oven-F.OBL ADP
'I put the bread **into the oven**.'

(18) CK Sanandaj (Mohammadirad 2022b)

a. *hat* ***bo*** ***la-y*** ***şuwan-eke***
come.PST.3SG:S to next_to-EZ shepherd-DEF
'He came *to the shepherd*.'

b. *hîlke-(e)ke=y* *nîya* *naw* *mişt-î*
egg-DEF=3SG:A put.PST in FIST=3SG:P
'He put the eggs into his fist.'

The tendency within Kurdish for postverbal placement of goals has been reported to be an ancient Aramaic imprint in the region (Haig 2015). This has also been supported by recent empirical corpus-based studies in the volume Haig et al.'s (2024) on post-predicate elements in Western Asia, in the sense that the Kurdish varieties closer to the NENA speech zone, e.g., CK Sanandaj, have a much higher percentage of post-verbal realisation of goals than Kurdish varieties outside the immediate contact zone with NENA, e.g., NK Ankara and NK Lachin, which are in intense contact with Turkic (see Table 23.6).

23.2.2.2 Recipients of 'give'

Unlike direct object arguments, nominal recipient arguments of the verb 'to give' have a strong tendency to appear in postverbal position across the Iranian languages of the region. The following examples illustrate the placement of recipients within Kurdish.

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Table 23.6: Postverbal realisation of goals within Kurdish

Variety	% of post-predicate	Source
Zazaki (Siwereg)	100	Demir & Dogan (2021b)
Kurdish (Southern, Bijar)	97	Mohammadirad (2022c)
Gorani (Gawraju)	96	Mohammadirad (2022a)
Kurdish (Central, Sanandaj)	94	Mohammadirad (2022b)
Zazaki (Çewlig)	91	Demir & Dogan (2021a)
Kurdish (Northern, Muš)	89	Haig (2021)
Kurdish (Northern, Lachin)	81	Stilo (2021)
Kurdish (Northern, Ankara)	59	Iefremenko (2021)

(19) Hewramî Tekht (Mohammadirad 2026)
kinaç(ê)-ekê=t *mi-đe-î* ***p=î***
daughter.F-DEF.F.SG.OBL=2SG:P IND-give.PRS-2SG:A TO=DEM.PROX
kuř-î
boy.M-SG.OBL
'Will you give your daughter to this boy [in marriage]?' [JE.75]

(20) NK Duhok (gloss modified Haig 2022)
min *pare* *da-n=ev* *Majid-î*
1SG.OBL money give.PST.PL=COMPL Majid-M.SG.OBL
'I returned the money to Majid.'

(21) NK Akre (MacKenzie 1962)
min *kiç-a* *xo* *da* *te*
1SG.OBL daughter-EZ.F REFL give.PST.3SG 2SG.OBL
'I have given my daughter to you.'

This tendency within Kurdish, like the parallel tendency with goals, has been argued by Haig (2015) to reflect an 'ancient imprint of Aramaic' on the western-most Iranian languages in the region. It has been argued that the strong tendency for post-predicate realisation of recipients across Kurdish is due to the fact that they share endpoint semantics with goals of verbs of movement (Haig 2022).

23.2.2.3 Addressees of verb 'to say'

There is a large degree of variation within Kurdish with respect to the placement of addressee arguments of the verb 'to say', e.g., *I said* ***to my mother***. This has

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been recognised through a pilot study (Haig 2022) which reveals opposing directionality for the placement of addressees within Northern Kurdish, with the Behdînî group favouring post-predicate realisation of addressees and the rest of NK favouring pre-predicate placement of these arguments. The following examples illustrate variation between varieties in each group regarding the positioning of addressees.

(22) NK Duhok
min got=e wî
1SG.OBL say.PST=DRCT 3SG.OBL
'I said to him.'

(23) NK Mush
min ji wî re got
1SG.OBL ADP 3SG.OBL ADP say.PST
'I said to him.'

(24) CK Sanandaj
wit=î be dayk=î
say.PST=3SG:A TO mother=3SG:P
'He said to his mother.'

(25) CK Mukri
be dayk=î kut=î
TO mother=3SG:P say.PST=3SG:A
'He said to his mother.'

Table 23.7 summarises the placement of addressee arguments across Kurdish based on corpus counts from available sources.

Figure 23.1 represents the areal distribution of the placement of addressee arguments of the verb 'to say' across Kurdish. The following observations can be made: We find opposing directionalities of nominal/free pronoun addressees within and across varieties of Kurdish, with some doculects favouring post-predicate realisation (over 80%), while others strongly favour pre-predicate realisation of addresses (over 90% pre-predicate).

When these two opposing directionalities meet, a compromise is reached, resulting in around 50% post-predicate placement of addressees. The dialects exhibiting these characteristics are CK dialects in the immediate Trans-Zab region and NK dialects in the Ṭur ʿAbdin region.

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Table 23.7: Post-predicate realisation of nominal addressee arguments of the verb 'to say'

L group	variety	tokens	% post-pred	source
NK	Akre	40	100%	MacKenzie (1962: 242-252)
	Zakho	12	100%	MacKenzie (1962: 357-367) Khan et al. (2022b: 95-103))
	Surchi	20	95%	MacKenzie (1962: 228-239))
	Amedia	30	93%	Blau (1975: 98-126)
	Gulli	11	88%	Khan et al. (2022b: 41-59, and 423-433))
	Duhok	30	87%	Khan et al. (2022b: 367-421, and 505-545)
	Kerboran (Ṭur ʿAbdin)	26	58%	Ritter (1969: 2-58))
	Yezidi of Ṭur ʿAbdin	36	50%	Ritter (1976: 2-37)
	Sinjar	16	50%	Blau (1975: 158-175)
	Urfa	14	7%	Mann (2021)
	Mush	14	0%	Haig & Schnell (2023)
	Erzinjan	8	0%	Haig & Schnell (2023)
CK	Sanandaj	13	92%	Mohammadirad (2022b)
	Erbil region	14	50%	MacKenzie (1962: 188-225); Khan et al. (2022b: 359-365)
	Bingird	14	7%	MacKenzie (1962: 136-170)
	Suleimaniya	16	6%	MacKenzie (1962: 7-49)
	Mukri	12	0%	Öpengin (2016)
	Pižḏar	12	0%	Khan et al. (2022b: 170-185)
SK	Bijar	23	0%	Mohammadirad (2022c)
Gor	H. Pawe	11	100%	Christensen & Benedictsen (1921)
	H. Tekht	20	95%	Mohammadirad (2026)
	H. Luhon	9	88%	MacKenzie (1966)
	G. Gawraju	13	46%	Mohammadirad (2022a)

The two blocks strongly favouring post-predicate realisation of nominal/free pronoun addressees within Kurdish are the Behdînî dialects and conservative Gorani dialects. In the case of Gorani, post-predicate placement of addressees has spread through substratum interference to southern dialects of CK, such as Sanandaj (see Mohammadirad 2024b).

23.2.3 Locational complements of copula verbs

Another area of word order showing a high degree of variability within Kurdish is the expression of locational complements of copula verbs, e.g., *He is at home*. The dominant order within Kurdish is for the locational complement to precede the copula. This is common in central and northern varieties of CK, the northernmost varieties of SK, and northern varieties of NK:

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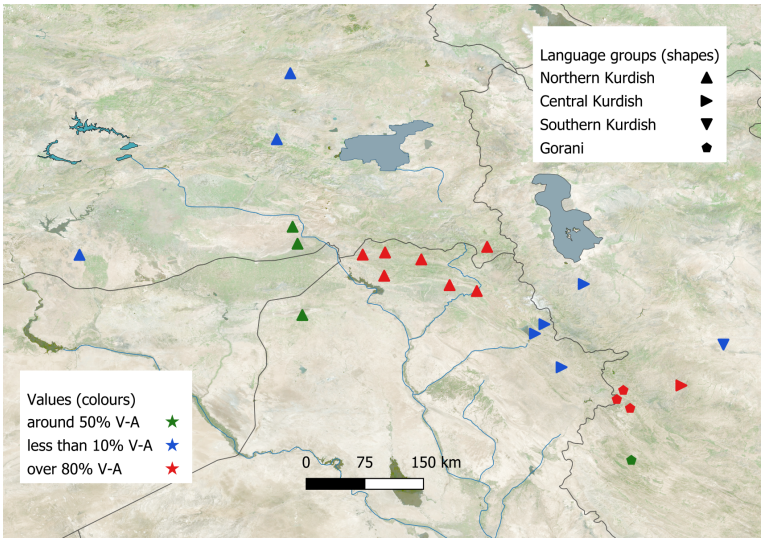

Figure 23.1: The placement of nominal addressees across Kurdish

(26) CK Suleimaniye/Saqiz/Erbil
perwîn le mał-ewe=ye
PN AT house-POST=COP.3SG:S
'Perwin is at home.'

(27) NK Midyat
pervîn li mal-ê=ye
PN at house-F.OBL=COP.3SG:S
'Pervin is at the house.'

(28) SK Bijar (Mohammadirad 2024b: 264)
kênî le pał derya d-û
spring in side sea IND-be.PRS.3SG:S
'The spring is next to the sea.'

The second pattern is seen in Gorani varieties, and has diffused through substratum influence to neighbouring CK and SK varieties (Mohammadirad 2025d). Here, the verbal person affixes attach to a deictic stem of pronominal origin (see §15.2.3), and the locational complement appears in post-predicate position.

(29) Hewramî

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îna-nê *yane-ne*
DEIC-1SG:S home-POST
'I am at home.'

(30) CK Sanandaj
ha=m=e *mał*
DEIC-1SG:S=at home
'I am at home.'

(31) SK Qasr Shirin (Fattah 2000: 255)
ha-n=e *kû*
DEIC-3PL:S=at where
'Where are they?'

In the Behdînî region, the copula is expressed by the inflected form of the ezafe, and the locational complement appears following the copula.

(32) NK Barwar
hesen yê *li mal*
PN EZ.M.SG at home
'Hesen is at home.'

(33) NK Mêrgesûr Barzan
hesen ê *li mał*
PN EZ.M.SG at home
'Hesen is at home.'

In addition, the Behdînî-type ezafe copula may appear as a substrate feature in the neighbouring CK varieties, e.g., Raniya (34).

(34) CK Raniya
hesen a le mał-ê=ye
PN EZ.M.SG at home=COP.3SG:S
'Hesen is at home.'

Overall, five patterns are attested within Kurdish regarding the positioning of locational complements of present tense copula verbs, summarised below:

I. LOC COPULA: The locational complement is realised before the copula (central and northern varieties of CK, northernmost varieties of SK, and northern varieties of NK).

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II. EZ.COP LOC: The locational complement follows the ezafe copula (the Behdînî type).

III. EZ.COP LOC COPULA: the same as type II, except that the copula is also used.

IV. DEICTIC.COPULA LOC: The locational complement follows the inflected deictic copula (the Gorani type).

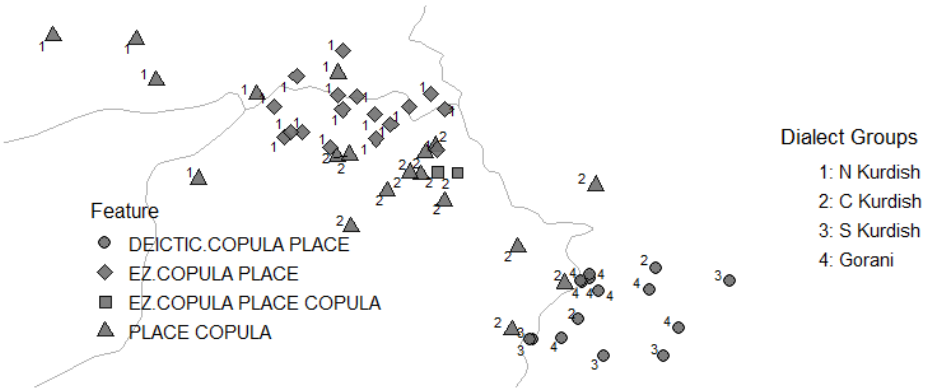

Figure 23.2: The position of locational complements of present tense copula verbs within Kurdish

Therefore, it can be said that types I and III position the locational complement pre-predicatively, while types II and IV exhibit the reverse pattern for locational complements. Figure 23.2 illustrates the distribution of these types. The overall wide distribution of post-predicate locational complements of the the verb 'to be' within Kurdish may indicate Aramaic influence on the Kurdish varieties in question.

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23.3 Word order in Armenian

23.3.1 Position of objects

In Armenian, objects can appear in preverbal or postverbal position. Some dialects show a very clear preference for preverbal position: Stilo (2018) finds that in Erzurum and Stepanakert dialects, 100% of indefinite DOs, and 98% and 91.9% of definite DOs respectively appear in preverbal position. Spoken SWA, too, apparently shows a strong preference for OV order (Donabédian p.c.).

However, studies of SEA and colloquial Yerevan Armenian show a more mixed picture. Stilo (2018) presents data from colloquial Yerevan Armenian that show a general preference for preverbal position, somewhat weaker for definite than for indefinite objects (indefinite DOs are 95% preverbal, definite DOs 86.1% preverbal). The study of SEA in Samvelian et al. (2023) confirms the relevance of definiteness for object position, but shows far higher numbers of postverbal objects: while indefinite DOs still show a preference for preverbal position (74.4% of indefinite DOs with the indefinite article and 75.7% without the indefinite article appear in preverbal position in Experiment 2), definite DOs in fact show a strong preference for postverbal position (82.7% of definite DOs appear in postverbal position in Experiment 1). The study of colloquial Yerevan Armenian in Hodgson et al. (2024) shows results that are intermediate between those of Stilo (2018) and Samvelian et al. (2023). In total, 78.7% of objects appear in preverbal position, 21.3% in postverbal position. The data do not show a significant difference between the behaviour of lexical NP and pronominal objects, with the former showing 21.9% VO, the latter 18.9%.

As in previous studies, definiteness has been shown to play a major role in object position, with only 2.6% of indefinite objects appearing in postverbal position, compared to 32.9% of definite objects. Definiteness is the only one of the factors investigated by Hodgson et al. (2024) that was shown to have a statistically significant effect on object position, although there are marginal effects of weight and animacy, with heavy and animate objects appearing more frequently in postverbal position, as also found by Samvelian et al. (2023).

There is evidence that register plays a role in object position in EA, as has also been proposed for Persian (Rasekh-Mahand et al. 2024). This could explain the difference between the results of Stilo (2018), whose data are from colloquial language, and Samvelian et al. (2023), whose experiment prompts and instructions are in formal SEA. In the corpus used by Hodgson et al. (2024), there is one "outlier" speaker (Speaker 3) who produces 44% postverbal objects, compared to an average of 17.4% for all the other speakers. This speaker uses forms characteristic

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of formal literary SEA that are not used by the other speakers in the study.[1]

Urmia Armenian (texts from Asatryan 1962) shows a very strong preference for OV order with indefinite DOs (98.9% OV), and a weaker, but still fairly strong preference with definite DOs (80.5% OV). In contrast to Yerevan Armenian, in Urmia, there is a major contrast between the position of lexical NP and pronominal objects: there are no examples in the texts from Asatryan (1962) of pronominal DOs in postverbal position, i.e., pronominal DOs are 100% preverbal.

23.3.2 Position of other verbal complements

The study of Hodgson et al. (2024) examines the positional characteristics of other verbal complements (benefactive, goal, ablative, comitative, location, complement of 'become', instrumental, recipient, addressee) as shown in Table 23.8.

Table 23.8: Position of other verbal complements in colloquial Yerevan Armenian (Hodgson et al. 2024)

Other roles	Total	Post-predicate	% Post-predicate
Benefactive	11	8	72.7%
Goal	122	84	68.9%
Ablative	50	20	40%
Comitative	44	13	29.5%
Location	116	30	25.8%
Become	9	2	22.2%
Instrumental	71	15	21.1%
Recipient	11	2	18%
Addressee	6	0	0%
Total other roles	445	178	40%

We observe that while most of these elements show around 20-30% post-predicate position, goals show a marked preference for post-predicate position

[1]For example, she uses the formal medial demonstrative *ayd* as opposed to colloquial *ed/et*), and the formal third person "emphatic" pronoun nominative plural *irenkʜ* as opposed to colloquial *irank^h*.

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(68.9% here, 85% in Hodgson 2021), something that has been found in other languages of the area, and has been proposed to be an areal feature (Haig et al. 2024). Benefactive also shows an apparent preference for postverbal position (72.7%), perhaps because it has "endpoint" semantics similar to goal, but the numbers are too small to be certain. Recipient and addressee, which also have "endpoint" semantics, do not seem to show this preference, but again, the numbers are too small to draw any firm conclusion. The relatively high proportion of post-predicate position for ablative (40%) is surprising, given that it has the semantics of starting-point, directly opposed to endpoint. However, in data from Agulis dialect (Hodgson 2021), ablative shows only 16.7% post-predicate position, and in Urmia dialect (texts from Asatryan 1962) only 6.6% (see Table 23.9), thus we cannot speak of a general tendency for ablatives to appear in post-predicate position in Armenian.

Table 23.9: Position of other verbal complements in Urmia dialect (texts from Asatryan 1962)

Other roles	Total	Post-predicate	% Post-predicate
Benefactive	12	4	33.3%
Goal	144	94	65.2%
Ablative	76	5	6.6%
Comitative	13	2	15.4%
Location	63	11	17.5%
Become	7	4	57.1%
Instrumental	36	2	5.6%
Recipient	8	4	50%
Addressee	10	2	20%
Total other roles	369	128	34.7%

In Urmia dialect, as shown in Table 23.9, the overall pattern is similar to colloquial Yerevan, with most types of complement showing a preference for pre-predicate position (slightly stronger in Urmia than in Yerevan, with an average of 10.6% post-predicate position for roles without "endpoint" semantics), with the notable exception of goals, which are 65.2% post-predicate. However, in Urmia,

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unlike in Yerevan, this tendency for post-predicate position seems to be extended to other types of complement with "endpoint" semantics, namely recipient and complement of 'become', and, to a lesser extent, benefactive and possibly addressee, although the numbers are too small to draw a firm conclusion.

23.4 Discussion

Neo-Aramaic and Neo-Iranian dialects are situated between mainstream Arabic, a prototypical example of a head-initial language, and Turkish, a prototypical example of a head-final language. The Aramaic and Arabic varieties of the region in question exhibit numerous hallmarks that can be characterised against the backdrop of these two spheres of influence. At the same time, these contact-induced typological traits cannot be disentangled from language-internal developments. Iranian languages such as Kurdish, in turn, have a more mixed word order typology, being in several respects rather similar to Semitic, except for the more rigid preverbal object position, the fixed clause-final placement of the copula, and the higher number of postpositions (see §9.6), which exhibit distinctly head-final syntax. While the influence of neighbouring V-final languages – be they Iranian or Turkic – is undeniable, intensive exposure to contact with such languages may not always radically change word order typology. For example, the Arabic and Aramaic varieties – originally – spoken in Iranian Khuzestan are still characterised as VO (Häberl 2011: 735; El Zarka & Ziagos 2020), suggesting, if correct – which is still a matter of debate –, that word order can be remarkably stable. This notwithstanding, local OV languages have doubtless affected the peripheral Anatolian Arabic dialects belonging to the Diyarbakir or Kozluk-Sason-Muş cluster, the Neo-Aramaic dialect of Mlaḥso in Diyarbakir, and that of Bohtan in Siirt. Furthermore, a higher rate of OV can be indicative of greater word order flexibility for pragmatically driven configurations, which need not result from contact, and this is presumably the situation in the majority of NENA dialects. In fact, it is plausible that continuous interaction with the wider Arabic-speaking world reinforced more rigid VO syntax, thereby serving as an anticatalyst against a shift to OV or more flexible word order, although much more comparative data is needed to establish how frequently, for instance, object topicalisation occurs across Arabic dialects. Thus, the rather inflexible VO syntax in Ṭuroyo may well be the result of Arabic influence, and not necessarily an archaic feature. The greatest extent of Arabic influence on NENA, in turn, is observed on the Mosul Plain in northern Iraq (Khan 2002a; Coghill 2020). Several typological features indicate diffusion into eastern Anatolia from the Levant and Mesopotamia, resulting in many parallels between Aramaic and Arabic (see e.g., Weninger 2012 and

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Procházka 2020), and to some extent also Iranian, to name a few: First of all, differential object indexing (also known as clitic doubling) possibly combined with the preposition *l-* is a feature shared by Aramaic (e.g., Coghill 2014; Noorlander 2021a: 290–294, 307–308, 350–370) and Arabic (e.g., Souag 2017); this, however, correlates with preposed objects, especially in Anatolian *qəltu*-Arabic and Ṭuroyo. The correlation between differential object indexing and word order requires further investigation (but see Noorlander 2025a). The data thus suggest that a combination of both the area-specific contact situation and the language-specific syntax of definite objects served to reinforce the dominance of OV order. Historically, the complete syntacticisation of OV as found in Central Asian Arabic (e.g., Seeger 2002; Jastrow 2004b) and in Jewish NENA of Iran (e.g., Khan 2020a; Noorlander & Molin 2022; Noorlander 2024b) is only sporadically observed in Anatolia, and definiteness remains a major factor regulating object placement. While VO is certainly the more archaic order, alternative pragmatically driven configurations were presumably part of Central Semitic syntax as a whole, though perhaps not with equal frequency across the entire subgroup. The shift to OV in Central Asian Arabic is generally explained in terms of the conventionalisation and thus increase in frequency of a former topicalisation strategy, e.g., *That man – I saw him yesterday*, due to intense contact with Uzbek and Tajik (e.g., Versteegh 1984: 452; Ratcliffe 2005; Souag 2017: 56); the same holds for OV in NENA under Kurdish influence (Haig 2015: 410–412). These explanations are consistent with the data as well as with the view of contact-induced word order convergence as a result of the extension of a pre-existing parallel construction (e.g., Silva-Corvalán 1994, 2008; Heine & Kuteva 2010). The convergence towards OV in the Christian NENA varieties of Iranian Azerbaijan, however, is incomplete, as these varieties still maintain a greater degree of flexibility in object placement, and betray features of predicate-initial typology in the ordering of indefinite objects and possessums, and that of light verb complements.

The areal convergence in word order could be merely incidental, for example, in the case of the prevalence of Verb-Goal and Become-Complement, which are common to Semitic and Iranian. The higher rates of OV in the main dialects discussed in this chapter, however, are doubtless due to influence from neighbouring OV languages, and yet the outcome differs according to region and community. For example, the word order profile of the Jewish and Christian dialects of Sanandaj as representative of the dialects of Iranian Kurdistan in many ways matches that of the local Iranian varieties, i.e., Central Kurdish and Gorani (see Mohammadirad 2024b. The fact that these show a similar general tendency for Object-Verb (and Predicate-Copula) order is most likely due to contact with Iranian. However, many configurations are still liable to language-internal develop-

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ments, such as the syntax of objects, which is sensitive to definiteness in dialects like C. Urmi. Moreover, the same syntactic structure is attested in cases where contact with neighbouring OV languages presumably played no direct role, such as AUX-OV order and the preverbal placement of the object of non-finite verbal forms.

Convergence in word order can thus be partly understood as contact-induced reinforcement of pre-existing parallel patterns (e.g., Silva-Corvalán 1994, 2008[2]; Heine & Kuteva 2010: 42–43, 48–49), which presupposes that syntactic OV presumably goes back to an original situation of more fluid order driven by pragmatic configurations.

Areal features are present in all Trans-Zab Jewish varieties, but the effect of contact on Christian varieties seems to be more varied. Doubtless, speakers' attitudes play a crucial role in susceptibility to contact-induced change in NENA dialects (Noorlander 2014), and thus word order shifts. One may think that Christian NENA varieties show considerably higher rates of VO than their Jewish peers. This seems to hold true for the Christian dialects of Iranian Azerbaijan, but it does not seem to apply to the south-easterly dialects such as Christian Shaqlawa, Koy Sanjak, Sulemaniyya and Sanandaj, where OV seems to be as rigid as it can be in Trans-Zab Jewish dialects.

Regional effects, in turn, may also cut across communal differences. Both Jewish and Christian NENA dialects of Iranian Azerbaijan, for instance, show a higher rate of Addressee-Verb order for verbs of speech, which parallels the northernmost dialects of Kurdish (Haig 2022), and Adjective-Noun order for evaluative adjectives, which parallels Azeri. On the other hand, other features are completely unaffected by word order shifts: flagging, for instance, remains prepositional in all NENA dialects, and none of the Neo-Aramaic varieties discussed here have developed a system of postpositions, despite having undergone a shift from VO to OV.

Further research is required on the embedding of the shift from VO to OV in other internally- and externally-caused developments, as well as on its sociohistorical circumstances. Moreover, it is possible that the shift documented for NENA, especially in the east, is ultimately rooted in the spoken varieties of Mesopotamia during the Achaemenid period.[3] Moreover, there is a direct correlation between object and possessum placement in NENA dialects. In locative-exisential possessor constructions, exemplified in (35–36), the possessum can be considered the object-like argument, and hence, not surprisingly, it occupies the

[2]I am indebted to G. Haig for directing my attention to this reference.

[3]See Haig et al. (2023) for a discussion of this from a wider areal and typological perspective.

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same position as object NPs in verbal clauses in the majority of NENA dialects. Possessums (25 out of 38), however, occur postverbally far more often than definite objects in C. Urmi, and are comparable to *in*definite objects (24 out of 49, see §23.2.2.1). It is conceivable that discourse organisation also plays a role in possessum-possessor constructions. Since possessums are generally definite, we would expect to observe the same distribution. Post-predicate possessums occur more frequently still, although this does not reach statistical significance. This higher rate of post-predicate possessums might be due to formulaic language, e.g., opening formulas introducing discourse-new arguments, as illustrated in (35), which would favour post-predicate placement.

(35) Existential-Possessum
C. Urmi (Khan 2016b: A39:§1)
ʾət-va ***xa-malka.*** *ʾaha* *malka* *ʾát-va-le* ***ʿṭla***
EXIST-PST one-king.SG.M DEM.SG.M king.SG.M EXIST-PST-3SG.M three
bnunə
son.PL
'There was **a king**. This king had **three sons**.'

(36) Possessum-Existential
C. Sanandaj (Panoussi 1990: 3:§1–2)
xa gora *k-awe… ay* *gora* *məšulman-a* ***tre išənyase***
one man.SG.M IND-be DEM.SG man.SG.M muslim-SG.M two woman.PL
k-āwe-le
IND-be-3SG.M
'There was (lit. is) **a man**… This Muslim man had (lit. has) **two wives**.'

Furthermore, similarly to indefinite objects, the nominal element of light verb constructions from Kurdish, Persian, and Azeri can occur after the light verb in C. Urmi, e.g., *kullə ʾodilun* ***ʿhazər*** 'they should prepare everything' (Khan 2016b: A3:§70). By contrast, such non-referential nominal elements precede the light verb in J. Urmi, as do all types of objects and possessums (Garbell 1965b: 173), e.g., *ixalé* ***ʿhazər*** *wudun* 'prepare food!' (J. Urmi, Garbell 1965b: 156). Thus light verb constructions, too, are consistent with their usage in neighbouring languages, with the non-referential nominal element preceding the light verb. The object NP, as expected, occurs before the complex verb, e.g., (37). In Christian dialects of north-eastern Iraq, recent Arabic loans also make use of this strategy (Hakeem 2021: 474–475), e.g., (38),

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(37) Noun-Light Verb
C. Sanandaj (Panoussi 1990: 126:§16)
xay-u *ləbas-i* ***ḥazər k-od-i-lu***
one-of.them clothes-my ready IND-make-A.3PL-3PL:P
'One of them **prepares** my clothes.'

(38) Noun-Light Verb
C. Shaqlawa (Khan et al. 2022b: Text 12:§28)
dăbi *ʾana* ***ʾistəraḥat Ø-ʾawd-ən***
must I rest SBJV-do-1SG.M
'I must **rest**.'

Similarly, the non-referential complement of light verb constructions follows the verb where VO predominates, as shown in (39–41).[4]

(39) T. *banyo etmek*
Qəltu-Arabic Mardin (Jastrow 1981b: I.1:§60)
t-a-ğ̆i *a-sawiy-u* *ḇāṇyo*
FUT-S.1SG-come 1SG:A-do-3SG.M:P bathroom
'I shall come to wash him.'

(40) T. *telefon etmek*, K. *telefon kirin*
CNA Midyat, Ṭuroyo (Ritter 1967: 7:§13)
səm-li *talafőn* *l-ú=* *ḥakimo* *d-áḥ=* *ḥəyewən*
did.PFV-1SG:A telephone to-DEF.M.SG= doctor.M.SG GEN-DEF.PL= animal.PL
'I called the vet.'

(41) T. *idare etmek*
NENA Hertevin (Jastrow 1988: 156.§505)
Ø-ʾod-aḥ-be *ʾidara*
SBVJ-do-A.3SG.M-by.it management
'so that we come through it'

The complement regularly precedes the light verb in dialects with a higher rate of OV order:

[4]For more examples, see e.g., Talay (2007: 184); Akkuş (2020: 150); Procházka (2020: 97).

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(42) T. *keyf etmek*, K. *kêf kirin*
Qəltu-Arabic Kaʿbiye (Jastrow 2022: XIII:§4)
kēf saw-ōn
joy did.PFV-A.3PL
'They celebrated.'

(43) K. *kar kirin*
CNA Mlaḥso (Jastrow 1994b: 106.§17)
l-á=ṭay-e *kar* *sim-no*
for-DEF=muslim-PL labour do-1SG.M
'I shall work for the Muslims.'

(44) Russ. *sobraniye*
NENA Bohtan (Fox 2009: 4.2:§2)
sabroni *yawd-i*
meeting do-A.3PL
'They held a meeting.'

Turning to object complements and obliques, in the NENA-speaking area, predicate-final order becomes more prevalent in the east, where, today, varieties of Central Kurdish are dominant.[5] As in Kurdish, a general post-predicate proclivity becomes apparent in object complements (see §23.2.2.3) of verbs of naming and turning something into something else in the Jewish varieties of north-eastern Iraq and Iranian Kurdistan. The Kurdic preposition *ba-* (see Mohammadirad 2024b) has been transferred into these Jewish varieties along with the pattern; see (115).

(45) a. Verb-Complement
J. Sanandaj (Khan 2009: D:§1)
xir-Ø ***ba***-*xá* *broná*
became.PFV-S.3SG.M to-INDEF boy.SG.M
'He became a boy.'

b. Verb-Complement
J. Sanandaj (Khan 2009: B:§41)
kol-i-wa-le ***ba***-*lešà*
make-A.3PL-PST-3SG.M:P to-dough.M.SG
'They made it into dough.'

[5]This corresponds to Stilo's (2005) Buffer Zone 1, bordering a low OV and high OV zone.

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This is, however, not supported by the statistics, as preverbal position, exemplified in (46) below, is far more frequent than in the NENA dialects outside of the relevant area. The rate of post-predicate final states is 22% (4/18) in C. Shaqlawa, 27% (3/11) in J. Urmi, 30% (12/41) in J. Sanandaj, and 62% (8/13) in C. Urmi, which can be contrasted with 90% (18/20) in C. Barwar.

(46) a. Complement-Verb
C. Shaqlawa (Khan et al. 2022a: Text 35:§33)
ʾen-aw ***kor*** *pəš-lu*
eye.PL-his blind became.PFV-S.3SG.M
'His eyes became **blind**.'

b. Complement-Verb
C. Shaqlawa (Khan et al. 2022a: Text 28:§19)
ʾāt *bet-i* ***nura*** *qam-ʾawd-ət-e*
you.SG house.SG.M-my fire.SG.F PST.PFV-make-2SG.M:A-3SG.M:P
'You have turned my home **into a hell**.'

The complement, i.e., a resulting condition, is generally placed before the verb in the NENA dialects of Iranian Azerbaijan studied here, and may even be fronted before the object, as can be observed in (47). This pre-predicate placement matches the word order in Turkic and Persian, rather than the expected order in Kurdish. The same holds true for Recipient-Theme-Verb order in the Jewish Urmi material in Khan (2008b), as exemplified by (20) in §23.2.2.2.

(47) Complement-Object-Verb
C. Sardarid (Younansardaroud 2001: 15:§1)
trə *ʾaxunvatə* *ʿtla* *d-ani* *vəd-li*
two brother.PL three GEN-DEM.PL made.PFV-1SG
'Into two brothers I turned three of them.'

Verb-Goal and Become-Complement order is shared by Semitic and Kurdish more widely (Haig 2015, 2022), more specifically Verb-Addressee placement converges with Behdînî, i.e., south-eastern varieties of Northern Kurdish (Haig 2022: 354–359). In NENA, addressees seem to have shifted in the same predicate-final direction as objects in Iranian Azerbaijan, a tendency which is more prevalent in the north-east. Here, the syntactic organisation is role-specific and area-specific. The split between pre-verbal addresseee and post-verbal goal and recipient in C. Urmi and Sardarid Azerbaijan matches the findings for some varieties of Central Kurdish and northernmost dialects of Northern Kurdish (Haig 2022: 358–359).

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Influence from Azeri and Persian, and also from Armenian, however, cannot be ruled out either. A higher rate of Verb-Goal order, for example, also occurs in local Azeri dialects due to Colloquial Persian influence (Kıral 2001: 75–77). Mlaḥso also converges with Kurdish word order typology. In Mlaḥso the rate of post-predicate addressees is only 56% (18/32), whereas this rate is 100% in Ṭuroyo (Midyat; 26/26). Mlaḥso also shows a higher rate of Beneficiary-Verb order (11/23) as opposed to Verb-Recipient order (16/17). Addressee-Verb and Beneficiary-Verb order as opposed to Verb-Goal order corresponds to the Northern Kurdish word order pattern in the same region (Haig 2022). Imposition from Iranian–rather than Turkish–is thus the most likely explanation for this syntactic split in Mlaḥso. Oblique-Verb order in Mlaḥso could be due to contact with either Iranian or Turkish.

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24 Experiential predicates and predicative possessors

24.1 Introduction

In this chapter, we discuss the syntax of clauses which deviate from the pattern of "canonical" transitive clauses. Here, we confine ourselves to clauses that involve experiencer verbs and predicative possessors. Both types of clauses tend to have noncore arguments that show special marking. We avoid the term "non-canonical subject constructions" here, because of the complexity of the alignment typology in some of the languages in the area, notably Aramaic and Iranian. In some respects, for instance, the argument coding may share characteristics with the agent of a transitive past (perfective) clause (or the subject of an intransitive past perfective clause). "Non-nominative subject" coding is also partially problematic, since, in some languages of the area, the experiencer or possessor undergoes obligatory topicalisation to clause-initial position, in which case it takes the unmarked and therefore nominative case.

Semantically, the two types of clause, i.e., experiential predicates and predicative possession, are, of course, rather distinct from each other. Experiencer verbs entail a human(-like) participant that is indirectly affected by some bodily or mental experience. Predicative possessor constructions concern constructions that imply a locational relation of a human(-like) possessor with respect to an item in its proximity that it exercises control over (Stassen 2009). Grouping these two together is therefore primarily motivated by their shared morphological and syntactic properties in some of the languages in the area. Semantically, they do share some properties, namely, they typically presuppose a highly topical human(-like) participant that might not be as readily conceived of as being as fully agentive as the agent of a transitive clause. This human(-like) participant can be considered to share semantic characteristics with the recipient of a ditransitive verb. Here, for convenience's sake, we primarily consider types of constructions where the less human-like or nonhuman participant, i.e., the possessee or stimulus, if present, is an indefinite NP.

The experiential predicate types we investigate here are:

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- two-place modal verbs that take complement clauses, such as verbs of desire, necessity, and capability, such as 'want', 'need', and 'can;
- one-place sensation predicates denoting physiological states such as 'be thirsty', 'be hungry', 'be cold', 'be hot', 'be sick', 'be well';
- one-place or two-place emotion predicates denoting mental states such as 'be sad', 'be happy', 'be afraid', 'to fear', 'to like', 'to please'.

In general, we prioritise the types of experiential predicate constructions where the experiencer is not coded like a nominative subject:

1. P-like experiencer constructions, where the experiencer is encoded like the P argument ofa transitive clause, such as *me* in *Dogs frighten me*;
2. genitive experiencer constructions, where the experiencer is encoded like an adonominal possessor, such as *his* in *His leg hurts*;
3. possessive experiencer constructions, where the the experiencer is encoded as the possessor in predicative possession, such as *I have* in *I have a headache*;
4. dative experiencer construction where the experiencer is expressed like the recipient of a social transfer like 'to give' or like the goal of motion, such as German *Mir* in *Mir ist bange* 'I am afraid', lit. 'Me is afraid';
5. other non-nominative experiencer constructions

The types of predicative possession constructions (Stassen 2009) relevant here are:

1. HAVE-possessive construction, transitive possessive verb with A-like coding of the possessor and P-like coding of the possessee, such as possessor verbs in European languages;
2. locative, comitative or dative existential possessive construction, like Latin *Mihi est liber* 'There is a book (belonging) to me'.
3. genitive possessor construction, where the possessor is encoded like the adnominal possessor.

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24.2 Experiential predicates and predicative possessors in NENA

In NENA, the coding of experiencers can simply follow the same pattern as that of nominative subjects. In many cases, therefore, the experiencer can be the subject of an intransitive verb, a copula, or a transitive verb, as illustrated in (1), respectively.

(1) C. Qaraqosh (Noorlander fieldnotes, see Khan 2002a)

a. *ʾana šxən-ni*
1SG become_warm.PST-OBL.1SG:S
'I got hot.' Intransitive clause

b. *xor-awaθ-an le-yax kpin-ə*
friend-PL-POSS.1PL NEG-PRS.COP.1PL:S hungry-PL:S
'My friends are not hungry.' Copula clause

c. *ʾəmm-i k-raxm-a-li*
mother.F.SG-POSS.1SG IND-love-3SG.F:A-OBL.1SG:P
'My mother loves me.' Transitive clause

In what follows, we will focus on constructions where the expression of the experiencer or possessor deviates in some respects from the above. In NENA, dedicated possessive constructions are never expressed by a transitive possessor verb such as Persian *dāštan* or Standard Eastern Armenian *unenal*; instead, a predicative possessor construction must be used. In both experiential predicates and predicative possessor constructions, the typically human participant is presented as the sentence topic, which need not be expressed in a separate intonation unit. It is therefore assigned the unmarked (nominative) case, and, as such, identical to the grammatical subject of an intransitive or transitive verbal clause or to the subject of a copula clause. Typically, the predicate obligatorily indexes the possessor or experiencer. This obligatory indexing is similar to the obligatory indexing of the nominative/unmarked subject. The sets of person markers used to express the experiencer or possessor role, however, deviate from those used for agents of transitive verbs or subjects of intransitive verbs; rather, they are typical of the coding of recipients or recipient-like arguments. Apart from this recipient-like indexing of the topical human participant, the verb or verb-like element in these experiencer verb and predicative possessor constructions is typically impersonal. In NENA impersonal constructions, the nonreferential coding can be 3SG.F. or 3SG.M., e.g.,

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(2) C. Nerwa (Noorlander fieldnotes)

a. *pəš-le* *xuy-a*
become.PST-OBL.3SG.M:S dark-M.SG:S
'It became dark.'

b. *pəš-te=la* *qədamta*
become.RES.PTCP-F.SG:S=COP.3SG.F morning.SG.F
'It has become/became morning.'

(3) C. Qaraqosh ((Khan 2002a: 252))

a. *xšək-la*
become_dark.PST-OBL.3SG.F:S
'It has become dark.'

b. *qarθe=la*
cold.F.SG=COP.3SG.F:S
'It is cold.'

24.2.1 Unflagged possessors and experiencers indexed by the oblique L-series or LL-series

In most NENA dialects, the so-called oblique L-suffixes are used to express human endpoint roles, which is a relic of their former usage as free pronouns based on a dative marker *l-* (Coghill 2019: 364–370; Noorlander 2021d). Across dialects, the oblique L-suffixes attach to a past or present verbal form and express the recipient, goal, indirect affectee, or external possessor, as shown in (4). In the past perfective, the L-suffixes also generally express the subject, resulting in verbal forms with two L-suffixes, the first always denoting the subject, the second expressing the nonsubject argument. Both the subject and the nonsubject argument can be overtly expressed as a topicalised NP or free pronoun in clause-initial position. In the examples in (4), the nonsubject argument is given as a topical free pronoun in parentheses, but it can also be a full NP, as shown in (4b).

(4) J. Dohok (Molin fieldnotes)

a. *(ʾaxni) g-yāw-i-wa-lan* *baṭane*
1PL IND-give-3PL:A-PST-OBL.1PL:R blanket.PL
'They used to give us blankets.' Recipient (present stem)

b. *xaθ-i* *hul-lu-la* *baṭane*
sister.F.SG-POSS.1SG give.PST-OBL.3PL:A-OBL.3SG.F:R blanket.PL
'They gave my sister blankets.' Recipient (past stem)

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c. *(ʾana) θe-lu-li* *yalunk-i*
1SG come.PST-OBL.3PL:A-OBL.1SG:R child.PL-POSS.1SG
'My children came to me.' Goal (past stem)

d. *(ʾana) wər-ra-li* *xšuta*
1SG enter.PST-OBL.3SG.F:S-OBL.1SG:R thought.F.SG
b-reš-i
in-head.SG.M-POSS.1SG
'A thought occurred to me in my mind.' Indirect affectee (past stem)

e. *(ʾaxni) mət-lu-lan* *yalunke*
1PL die.PST-OBL.3PL:S-OBL.1PL:R child.PL
'We lost our children.' External possessor (past stem)

For the L-suffixes to serve as its indexes, the recipient-like nonsubject argument has to be unmarked and has to function as sentence topic. If the recipient-like argument is nontopical, for example, if a *wh-constituent* occurs in the recipient function, it is incompatible with the above topicalisation strategy, and must be flagged. If the recipient-like argument is flagged instead, the additional index is not compatible with it, as illsutrated in (5-(24.2.1) (see Sections 21.2.2.6 and 21.2.2.6).

(5) J. Dohok (Molin fieldnotes)

a. *baṭane* *ta-măni* *g-yāw-i-wā-lu*
blanket.PL DAT-who IND-give-3PL:A-PST-OBL.3PL:P
'To whom did they give the blankets?'

b. *θe-lu* *kəsl-i* *yalunk-i*
come.PST-OBL.3PL:S at-1SG child.PL-POSS.1SG
'My children came to me.'

(6) C. Telkepe (Coghill 2019: 369)
l-təlkəpnayə, *məθ-la* *kabirə našə.*
to-Telkpenaye die.PST-OBL.3PL:S many people
'As for the Telkepnaye, they lost many people.'

In the following sections, the experiential predicates and predicative possessor constructions show similarities with topicalised recipient-like arguments, that is, they are clearly derived from the topicalisation structures discussed above. Nevertheless, as we shall see, they have several unique properties that distinguish them from these, showing behaviour like that of a grammatical subject.

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24.2.1.1 Experiential predicates

In experiential predicates, the recipient-like indexing of the experiencer argument is obligatory, while the experiencer NP remains unmarked. The verbs *bsm* and *ʿjb* 'to please, to like' follow this pattern. Generally, the construction is otherwise impersonal, and the stimulus NP remains unflagged, as shown in (7). If the verb does not agree with the stimulus NP, as shown in (7a), the verb takes invariant, nonreferential 3SG.M or 3SG.F inflection. The stimulus optionally controls agreement, as shown in (7b).

(7) C. Marga (Noorlander fieldnotes)

a. *măni basəm-Ø-le xabuše*
who please-3SG.M-OBL.3SG.M:R apple.PL
'Who likes apples?' (Lit. 'Who pleases him apples?')

b. *ʾan-xabuše (ʾana) basm-i-li*
DEM.PL-apple.PL 1SG please-3PL-OBL.3SG.M:R
'These apples I like.' (Lit. 'These apples I please-me.')

c. *(ʾana) le ʿajb-ā-li gyan-i hatxa*
1SG NEG please-3SG.F:A-OBL.1SG:R self.SG.F-POSS.1SG such
'I do not like (seeing) myself in such a situation.'

d. *ʾən basm-a-lux*
if please-3SG.F:A-2SG.M:R
'If you like it / if it pleases you.'

In the past perfective, the first L-suffix represents the impersonal 3SG.M. or 3SG.F. coding, the second L-suffix denotes the recipient-like core argument, e.g.,

(8) C. Marga (Noorlander fieldnotes)
(ʾana) bsəm-le-li xabuše
1SG please.PST-OBL.3SG:A-OBL.1SG:R apple.PL
'I liked apples.'

(9) C. Urmi (Noorlander fieldnotes)
ʾalaha ʾatxa bsəm-lā-li
god.SG.M such please.PST-OBL.3SG.F:A-OBL.1SG:R
'God likes it this way.' or 'It pleased God thus.'

Ocassionally, this oblique coding can spread to the present imperfective as well, e.g., C. Telkepe *k-ʿājəb-le-li* 'I am willing' (Coghill 2019: 39). In Jewish NENA

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dialects of Western Iran, such as J. Saqiz and J. Sanandaj, the 3SG.F. impersonal L-suffix *-la-* has spread to all conjugations and is obligatorily combined with the L-suffix denoting the experiencer. The stimulus, in turn, is flagged using the ablative/source preposition *mən-* 'from', e.g.,[1]

(10) J. Saqiz (Yisraeli 1998: 170)
la basəm-la-li mənn-ev
IND please-OBL.3SG.F-OBL.1SG:R from-3SG.M
'I do not like him.' (Lit. Me it pleases not of him.')

The structures illustrated with 'to like, to please' are also observed with other verbs such as *mly* 'to be enough', *wjj* 'to care' (J. Amədya; Hoberman 1989b: 226), *ṭwy* 'to be worth, to merit', (J. Betanure; Mutzafi 2008a: 88–89), *hny* 'to enjoy', *mṭy* 'deserve, lit. arrive, reach' (J. Zakho; Cohen 2012: 144), *hny* 'to have pity on' (Polotsky 1979: 211), *kšy* 'to find difficult' and *špr* 'to befit' (Yisraeli 1998: 170). The verb *ʾby* 'to want, to need' also has the meaning 'to like, to love' and normally takes agent-like coding of the experiencer. Occasionally, this verb can also take the recipient-like L-suffixes, in which case it conveys a sense of necessity, e.g.,

(11) J. Betanure (Mutzafi 2008a: 89)
gbe-wā-leni ṛaba ṣiwe
want.IND-PST-OBL.3PL:R much wood.PL
'We needed much wood.' (Lit. 'Us need much wood.')

(12) C. Barwar (Khan 2008c: 1752.7)
ʾăwaha... băye-le baxta
DEM.SG want-OBL.3SG.M:R woman.F.SG
'That one... needs a wife.'

When the body part is not expressed, the verb *mrʾ* 'to hurt, to ache, to be in pain' can be used in an impersonal experiencer construction, in which case the verb takes an L-suffix to express the experiencer, e.g.,

(13) C. Nerwa (Noorlander fieldnotes)

a. *ʾana reš-i hole mɻaya*
1SG head.SG.M-POSS.1SG DEIC.COP.3SG.M hurt.INF
'I have a headache.'

[1]Note that the use of the ablative to mark the stimulous is the default in Persian, Kurdish, and Iranian Azeri, e.g., Central Kurdish *ħez=im le ew=e* [like=1SG.R from 3SG=COP.3SG] 'I like him/her.'

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b. *kud-yom kas-i ʾi-maɻe-li*
every-day stomach.F.SG-]POSS.1SG IND-hurt-OBL.1SG:P
'Everyday my stomach hurts (me).'

c. *kud-yom xa-duka ʾi-maɻe-li*
every-day a-place.F.SG IND-hurt-OBL.1SG:P
'Everyday I feel a pain somewhere.'

In a few dialects in the western and southern periphery, the experiencer of cold is coded in a similar way to that seen in the above construction, as illustrated below. The experience of heat is encoded differently, see §24.2.2.2.

(14) C. Hertevin (Noorlander fieldnotes)
qårəš-li
become_cold-OBL.1SG:R
'I am cold.' (Lit. 'It becomes me cold.')

(15) C. Jinnet (Noorlander fieldnotes)
qorəš-li
become_cold-OBL.1SG:R
'I am cold.' (Lit. 'It becomes me cold.')

(16) C. Umra (Noorlander fieldnotes)
qåyər-ri
become_cold-OBL.1SG:R
'I am cold.' (Lit. 'It becomes me cold.')

(17) C. Qaraqosh ((Khan 2002a: 719))
ʾana qayər-ri
become_cold-OBL.1SG:R
'I am cold.' (Lit. 'It becomes me cold.')

The impersonal intransitive expression can also be an idiomatic phrase composed of the verb 'to come' and an NP denoting the experience, where the recipient-like experiencer is indexed by an L-suffix, e.g.,

(18) C. Urmi (Polotsky 1979: 212))
ⁿʔav ti-lə-lə muxabən
3SG come.PST-OBL.3SG.M:S-OBL.3SG.M:R pity
'He felt sorry.' (Lit. 'He, pity came him.')

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24.2.1.2 Locative-exisential constructions and predicative possession

In NENA, predicative possession is generally expressed by an existential construction in which both the possessor and the possessee are unflagged. The possessor is indexed by L-suffixes that are attached to an existential particle *ʾiθ, which may also be marked for past tense by the particle *wa*. The structure is similar to the topicalised recipient-like arguments above. The main difference, however, is that the predicative possessor is obligatorily unmarked, and the possessee cannot be indexed. Moreover, the possessor NP does not need to be topical, nor does the possessee need to be indefinite.

(19) J. Dohok (Molin fieldnotes)

a. *ʾəθ-wā naše*
EXIST-PST person.PL
'There were people.' Existential construction

b. *naše ʾəθ-wā-lu ṣaneʾta*
person.PL EXIST-PST-OBL.3PL craft.F.SG.
'People used to have a craft.' Possessor NP indexed by L-suffixes

c. *măni ʾət-le skina*
who EXIST-OBL.3SG.M knife.SG.M
'Who has the knife?' *Wh*-possessor indexed by L-suffixes

d. *ʾana ʾət-li skina*
1SG EXIST-OBL.1SG knife.SG.M
'I have the knife.' Pronominal possessor indexed by L-suffixes

e. *ʾana ʾət-li*
1SG EXIST-OBL.1SG
'I have it.' Implicit possessee

Generally, the possessee is not treated like a full-fledged direct object. It can, however, acquire full object properties when it is definite (see Noorlander 2021d).

The copula verb 'to be' is generally used instead of the existential particle in irrealis or future tense clauses, in which case it takes the invariant 3SG.M. form, e.g.,

(20) J. Amədya (Greenblatt 2011: 274.33)
quppa lazəm-∅ ∅-hawe-la ṛaba pare
cash_box should-3SG.M SBJV-be-OBL.3SG.F:R much money.PL
'There is supposed to be a lot of money in the cash box.'

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(21) J. Urmi (Khan 2008b: 126)
ana=č *bărux̆awale* *k-we-li*
1SG=ADD friend.PL IND-be-OBL.1SG
'I shall have friends.'

The verb 'to be' can also serve as an existential verb, especially in story-telling, e.g.,

(22) C. Sanandaj (Panoussi 1990: D:6)
xa gora *k-awe... ay* *gora* *məšulman-a tre išənyase*
one man.SG.M IND-be DEM.SG man.M.SG Muslim-M.SG two women.PL
k-āwe-le
IND-be-OBL.3SG.M
'There was (Lit. is) a man... This Muslim man had two wives.'

Predicative possessors can serve as expressions of ability with modal complements in Trans-Zab Jewish varieties (see Khan 2004b: 311)).

A related verb that also denotes enduring existence is 'to remain, to be left'. When used impersonally, it can also take an additional L-suffix denoting a type of possessor. This verb is often used instead of the copula in negated clauses with the connotation of 'no longer, not anymore', e.g.,.

(23) J. Zakho citep[159.1] sabar
u-la *pəš-le-lu* *la* *daxla u-la* *xəṭṭe*
and-NEG remain.PST-OBL.3SG.M-OBL.3PL NEG crop and-NEG wheat.PL
u-la *čə-məndi*
and-NEG any-thing
'They no longer had any crop, wheat, not anything.'

24.2.1.3 The verb 'to beget, to give birth, to be born'

Verbs with the meaning 'to become', 'to happen' and/or 'to be born' can take an additional L-suffix to express the recipient-like argument to whom a child was born or by whom something was acquired, as illustrated below. The intransitive verbs *hwy* and *bry* by themselves can convey the meaning of 'to be born', with the undergoer as subject. The causative counterparts of these verbs denote 'to give birth' and, in turn, take the woman giving birth as their subject. The intransitive verb, however, can also take the woman giving birth or the father begetting as a core recipient-like argument. The reciepient-like argument behaves in a similar way as the experiencer and possessor in the above constructions. Generally, the

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inactive undergoer, i.e., the child, is indefinite, and the verb does not agree with it, taking the 3SG.M. or 3SG.F. as base.

(24) J. Zakho (Fassberg 2003: 203)
brat-ox *hwe-le-la* *brata*
girl.F.SG-POSS.2SG.M become.PST-OBL.3SG.M-OBL.3SG.F:R girl.F.SG.
'Your daughter gave birth to a daughter.'

(25) C. Txuma (Talay 2008a: 220.36)
wi-le-la *brata*
become.PST-OBL.3SG.M-OBL.3SG.F:R daughter.SG.F
'She gave birth to a daughter.'

(26) C. Barwar (Talay 2008a: 516.1)
bab-i *qam-hāwi-wā-le* *brata*
father.SG.M-POSS.1SG PST.PFV-become-PST-OBL.3SG.M:R daughter.F.SG
'My father begot a girl.'

(27) J. Betanure (Mutzafi 2008a: 210.243)
hakan ∅-hāwe-wā-le *brata,*
if SBJV-become-PST-OBL.3SG.M:R daughter.F.SG,
∅-bāre-le *brata...*
SBJV-happen-OBL.3SG.M:R daughter.F.SG
'If he had a daughter, a daughter was born to him...'

(28) J. Arbel (Khan 1999a: 438.37)
yal-e *ġdi-rā-le*
childM-PL become.PST.PFV-OBL.3.SG.F-OBL.3SG.M:R
'Children were born to him.'

Occasionally, however, the verb can also reflect agreement with the undergoer, e.g.,

(29) C. Nočiya (Talay 2008a: 462.6)
bət-hoy-a-laxun *brata*
FUT-become-3SG.F:S-OBL.2PL:R daughter.F.SG
'A daughter shall be born to you.'

(30) C. Aradhin (Krotkoff 1982: 106.120)
qam-hāw-i-le *baxta=u brune*
PST.PFV-become-3PL:S-OBL.3SG.M:R=and son.PL
'He got a wife and sons.'

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(31) J. Dohok (Molin fieldnotes)
hwe-lu-li *yalunke*
become-3PL:S-OBL.1SG:R child.PL
'Children were born to me.'

24.2.1.4 Irregular verbs inflected with L-suffixes

Across NENA dialects, several verbs are irregular and are inflected with L-suffixes in present imperfective clauses. Besides the high frequency motion verb 'to go' with the present base *za-*, this category also includes expressions of ability, such as *qar* < **qadr*, of emotions, such as *ṣad-* 'to fear', which supplements the regular verb *zd-* 'idem', and other relevant expressions such as *qar-* 'to be cold' and *bas-* 'to be enough', e.g.,

(32) C. Jinnet (Noorlander fieldnotes)

a. *le* *zo-li*
NEG go.PRS-OBL.1SG:S
'I'm not going.'

b. *zo-wo-lan*
go.PRS-PST-OBL.1PL:S
'We used to go.'

c. *zəl-li*
go.PST-OBL.1SG:S
'We went.'

(33) C. Jinnet (Noorlander fieldnotes)

a. *qar-i*
be_able-OBL.1SG:R
'I am able.'

b. *qar-wo-li*
be_able-PST-OBL.1SG:R
'I was able.'

(34) J. Betanure (Mutzafi 2008a: 88)

a. *k-ṣad-li*
IND-fear-OBL.1SG:R
'I fear.'

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b. *zdeʾ-li*
fear.PST-OBL.1SG:S
'I feared.'

(35) J. Dohok (Molin fieldnotes)

a. *qar-ri*
become_cold-OBL.1SG:R
'I am cold.'

b. *qar-wā-li*
become_cold-PST-OBL.1SG:R
'I was cold.'

(36) C. Barwar (Khan 2008c)

a. *bass-i*
enough-OBL.1SG:R
'I have enough.'

b. *bas-wā-li*
enough-PST-OBL.1SG:R
'I had enough.'

24.2.2 Genitive possessors and experiencers

Genitive possessive and experiential predicates resemble the structure of the topicalisation of adnominal genitive possessors. The citation form of the argument is used in clause-initial position and resumed by a possessive suffix that is attached to the possessed NP, e.g.,

(37) C. Urmi
ʾana šəmm-i *ʾilə* *Maryam*
1SG name.SG.M-POSS.1SG PRS.COP.3SG.M:S Maryam
'My name is Maryam.'

The possessive suffixes can also serve as object indexes attached to originally nominal forms of the verb in complex verb constructions (see §13.2.5.3). This also holds true for pronominal recipients, which can also be topicalised, e.g.,

(38) C. Urmi (Noorlander fieldnotes)

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a. *ʾana yuvv-i=lə xa ctava xat-a*
1SG give.RES.PTCP-POSS.1SG:R=COP.3SG.M:A one book.M.SG new-M.SG
'He has given me a new book.'

b. *ʾaxnan yav-an=ina xa ctava xata*
1PL give.PROG-POSS.1PL:R=COP.3PL:A one book.M.SG new-M.SG
'They are giving us a new book.'

24.2.2.1 Predicative possessors

In the Christian dialects of NENA of Iranian Azerbaijan, the complex perfect can be used to express possession in the indirective past (see Khan 2016b: 208). The possessor is encoded as a possessive pronominal suffix attached to the resultative participle of the verb *hwy* 'to be'. The accompanying copula is impersonal 3SG.M. and does not agree with the possessee. The structure is therefore similar to the L-suffixes that attach directly to the verb *hwy* to express the predicative possessor, e.g.,

(39) C. Urmi

a. *haccim-ə viyy-an=ilə*
doctor.M-PL be.RES.PTCP.M.SG-POSS.1PL:R=COP.3SG.M
'We had doctors.' (Khan 2016b: 234.9)

b. *may ɟu-ʿʾIran ʿraba bətvatə viyy-u=lə*
who in-Iran many house.PL be.RES.PTCP-POSS.3SG.M=COP.3SG.M
'Who had many houses in Iran?' (Noorlander fieldnotes)

In a few Christian dialects in the western periphery, a genitive possessive construction has been recorded to express predicative possession, for instance, in C. Bohtan, C. Hertevin and C. Marga, as illustrated below. In the genitive possessive, the possessor is expressed as an index attached to the possessee. In general, possession can be freely expressed by nominal annexation (see Gutman 2018; 11.1). The construction is thus similar to a topicalised adnominal possessor with pronominal resumption. Such adnominal possessors can also have free genitive pronouns, which typically occur when both the possessor and possessee are definite. Nevertheless, the genitive possessive construction is different in that the possessor NP is unmarked and indexed by a genitive pronominal attached to the posseessee. The predicative possessor construction in which the unmarked possessor NP is indexed by L-suffixes is, however, far more common.

(40) C. Bohtan (Fox 2009: 118, 116)

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a. *abra ǰambali=wa šəmm-əw*
boy.M.SG Jambali=PST.COP.3 name.M.SG-POSS.3SG.M
'The boy's name was Jambali.' (Lit. 'The boy Jambali was his name)
Topicalised adnominal possessor

b. *ʾowən iwa baxt-əw (u) abr-əw*
3SG.M PST.COP.3 woman.F.SG-POSS.3SG.M and son.M.SG-POSS.3SG.M
'He had a wife and a son.' (Lit. 'He was his wife (and) his son.')
Possessor indexed by genitive suffixes

c. *xuda xa abra ət-wo-le*
only one son.M.SG EXIST-PST-OBL.3SG.M
'He had only one son.' Possessor indexed by L-suffixes

(41) C. Hertevin (Jastrow 1988: 148.419, 110.24, 136.322)

a. *ḥda šəmm-ew Yosep=iwa*
one name.M.SG-POSS.3SG.M Joseph=PST.COP.3
'one was called Joseph.' (Lit. 'One his name was Joseph.') Possessor indexed by genitive suffixes

b. *ʾad hawe-∅ ḥalw-ew gallak,*
DEM.SG be-3SG.M milk.M.SG-POSS.3SG.M much
'whoever has much milk.' (Lit. 'This one his milk might be much.')
Possessor indexed by genitive suffixes

c. *ʾad hawe-∅-le qənyana*
DEM.SG be-3SG.M-OBL.3SG.M cattle.SG.M
'whoever had cattle.' Possessor indexed by L-suffixes

(42) C. Marga (Noorlander and Khan fieldnotes)

a. *ʾawa šəpr-ət flān=ile*
DEM.SG.M property.SG.M-CSTR someone=COP.3SG.M:S
'This is somebody's property.' Genitive possessor

b. *ʾăra ʾəd-diy-ew=ila*
land.F.SG GEN-GEN-POSS.3SG.M=COP.3SG.F:S
'The land is his.' Independent genitive possessor

c. *kutxa ʾăr-ew=ila*
each land.F.SG-POSS.3SG.M=COP.3SG.F
'Each has his own land.' (Lit. 'Each is his own land.') Possessor indexed by genitive suffixes

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d. *kutxa ʾət-wā-le ʾăr-ət gyan-eu*
each EXIST-PST-OBL.3SG.M land.SG.F-CSTR self.F.SG-POSS.3SG.M
'Everyone had their own land.' Possessor indexed by L-suffixes

24.2.2.2 Experiential predicates

In genitive experiencer constructions, the experiencer is encoded as an adnominal possessor on an NP, which generally still controls agreement. The NP can be a relevant body part or a bodily sensation.

In all NENA dialects, the verb *mrʾ* 'to hurt, to ache' typically takes a body part with the adnominal possessor denoting the experiencer. The experience of sleepiness is expressed using the feminine singular NP 'sleep' and the verb 'to come' with the experiencer encoded as an adnominal possessor, e.g.,

(43) J. Dohok (Molin fieldnotes)

a. *baxt-i=ži reš-a g-mareʾ-∅*
woman-POSS.1SG=ADD head.M.SG IND-hurt-3SG.M:S
'My wife, too, has a headache.'

b. *ʾo gora=ži šənθ-e θe-la*
DEM.SG.M man.M.SG=ADD sleep.F.SG-POSS.3SG.M come.PST-OBL.3SG.F:S
'This man, too, got sleepy.'

Across NENA dialects, similarly to the idiom for sleepiness, a genitive experiencer may also be used with the emotive state of enjoyment, in which case the verb 'to come' combines with the feminine singular NP *kef* or *kep* and an adnominal possessor. The experiencer can also be marked as adnominal possessor in the expression for the physiological experiences of heat and cold. In the dialects located further south-east of the NENA speaking area, this construction has been extended to the experiences of hunger and thirst, as given in (46) and (47).

(44) J. Dohok (Molin fieldnotes)
kef-u θe-la
pleasure-POSS.3SG.M come.PST-OBL.3SG.F:S
'They enjoyed it.' (Lit. 'Their pleasure came.')

(45) C. Urmi (Noorlander fieldnotes, see also (Khan 2016b: 354))

a. *(ʾana) cep-i ti-la*
1SG pleasure-POSS.1SG come.PST-OBL.3SG.F:S
'I enjoyed it.' (Lit. 'My pleasure came.')

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b. *(ʾana) xəmm-i =lə*
1SG heat.M.SG-POSS.1SG =PRS.COP.3SG.M:S
'I am hot.' (Lit. 'It is my heat.')

c. *(ʾana) qart-i =la*
1SG cold.F.SG-POSS.1SG =PRS.COP.3SG.M:S
'I am cold.' (Lit. 'It is my cold.')

(46) J. Saqiz (Yisraeli 1998: 170)

a. *brat-i qard-av =ya*
daughter.F.SG-POSS.1SG cold.F.SG =PRS.COP.3SG.F:S
'My daughter is cold.' (Lit. 'My daughter, it is her cold.')

b. *ana kpənt-i =ya*
1SG hungry.F.SG-POSS.1SG =PRS.COP.3SG.F:S
'I am hungry.' (Lit. 'I, it is my hungry.')

(47) C. Koy Sanjak

a. *siṭ-ew =ila*
thirsty.F.SG-POSS.3SG.M =PRS.COP.3SG.F:S
'He is thirsty.' (Lit. 'It is his thirsty.')

b. *pənt-an =ila*
hungry.F.SG-POSS.1PL =PRS.COP.3SG.F:S
'We are hungry.' (Lit. 'It is our hungry.')

In Jewish and Christian dialects of Iranian Azerbaijan, the idiomatic template of a particle or nominal element combined with the verb 'to come' is extended to other emotive experiences (see Khan 2016b), although not to the experiencers of hunger and thirst. In the examples below, the possessive suffixes serve as indexes of the experiencer and attach to the particle or nominal element, much like the pronominal object of a complex predicate or light verb construction. In such expressions, the stimulus can be introduced with the source preposition *mən-*, as shown in (51), or the goal preposition *əll-*, as shown in (52).

(48) J. Solduz (Garbell 1965b: 214)
ana jwexet jur yaxxa xoš-i g-de-∅!
1SG another sort.M.SG collar.M.SG pleasure-POSS.1SG IND-come-3.SG.M:S
'I like (lit. my pleasure came) a different kind of collar!'

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(49) J. Solduz (Garbell 1965b: 170)
ˁšultana jəgr-ew əd̲ye-∅
king.M.SG anger.M.SG-POSS.3SG.M come.PST-3SG.M:S
'The king grew very angry.' (Lit. 'His anger has come.')

(50) J. Solduz (Garbell 1965b: 229)
baxil-aw əd̲ye-la
weeping.F.SG-POSS.3SG.F come.PST-OBL.3SG.F:S
'She felt like weeping.' (Lit. 'Her weeping came.')

(51) J. Solduz (Garbell 1965b: 197)
ba-ma xoš-ox mən-ni le id-a
for-what pleasure-POSS.2SG.M from-1SG NEG come.PST-3SG.F:S
'Why do you not like me?' (Lit. 'Your pleasure has not come from me.')

(52) J. Urmi (Garbell 1965b: 167)
ana rahm-i iday=le əll-ox
1SG pity.M.SG-POSS.1SG come.PROG=COP.3SG.M:S DAT-2SG.M
'I am taking pity on you.' (Lit. 'My pity is coming to you.')

The verb *ʾby byy* 'to like, to please, to love, to want' can also take a nominal form, in which case the experiencer is expressed as the genitive possessor.

(53) J. Shino (Garbell 1965b: 214)
ya ˁsudra ana abyan-t-i lewa!
DEM.SG shirt.F.SG 1SG like.ACT.PTCP-F.SG:S-[POSS.1SG NEG.PRS.COP.3SG.F
'This shirt is not to my liking!'

Depending on the dialect, the genitive experiencer can also be flagged using a genitive marker, as (54) shows for the Christian dialect of Marga. In dialects like J. Saqiz, however, the possessive suffix has grammaticalised to a grammatical index to express subject agreement, as (55) illustrates.

(54) C. Marga (Noorlander fieldnotes)
d-măni=la qarsa
GEN-who=PRS.COP.3SG.F:S cold.F.SG
'Who is cold?' (Lit. 'Whose cold is it?')

(55) J. Saqiz (Yisraeli 1998: 170)
mani sḥit-ev=ya
who thirst.F.SG-POSS.3SG.M=PRS.COP.3SG.F:S
'Who is thirsty?' (Lit. 'Who is his thirsty?')

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24.2.2.3 The verb 'to beget, to give birth, to be born'

As opposed to the varieties in §24.2.1.3 where the L-suffix is used, in the Jewish dialects of Iranian Azerbaijan, the recipient-like entity that begets or gives birth to children can also be expressed as a possessor, which is attached to the possessee NP, e.g.,

(56) J. Urmi (Garbell 1965b: 128)
alpa niš-e ∅-hawe-li, šata alpa
thousand woman.PL SBJV-be-OBL.1SG, year.F.SG son-PL-POSS.1SG
bron-aw-i xadr-i
become-3PL:S
'If I have a thousand wives, a thousand sons will be born to me (lit. my sons will become) yearly.'

(57) J. Salmas (Duval 1883: 105)
la xadr-i-va yal-u
NEG become-3PL-PST child.PL-POSS.3PL
'No children were born to them.' (Lit. 'Their children did not become.')

24.2.3 Dative possessors and experiencers

24.2.4 Parallels in Central Neo-Aramaic

The Central Neo-Aramaic dialects closely parallel the NENA dialects in the syntax of experiential predicates and predicative possessors (see Noorlander 2021d). Predicatve possessors are typically expressed by oblique L-suffixes that attach to an existential construction or the copula, e.g.,

(58) Ṭuroyo Neo-Aramaic

a. *ú-həmmāl-ano kət-way-le əštó-abne*
DEF.M.SG-carrier.M.SG-DEM.M.SG EXIST-PST-OBL.3SG.M six-son.PL.M
'This carrier had six sons.' (Ritter 1967: 63.2)

b. *Baṣuṣ gt-owe-le abro*
Baṣuṣ FUT-be-OBL.3SG.M son.M.SG
'Baṣuṣ will have a son.' Ritter 1967: 115/309

c. *ú-tajər hawi-le barθo*
DEF.SG.M-merchant.M.SG become.PST-OBL.3SG.M daughter.F.SG
'The merchant begot a daughter.' Ritter 1967: 23/4

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Experiencer NPs are mainly expressed by the same recipient-like coding strategy, e.g.,

(59) Ṭuroyo Neo-Aramaic

a. *aḥun-i* *bosam-way-le* *u-dawšo*
brother-POSS.1SG be_pleasant-PST-OBL.3SG.M:R DEF.M.SG-honey.M.SG
'My brother used to like honey.' (Lit.

b. *i-kačke,* *aθi-la* *šanθo*
DEF.F.SG-girl.F.SG come.PST-OBL.3SG.F:R sleep.F.SG
'The girl became sleepy.' (Lit. 'The girl, sleep came her.')

In the expressions of temperature sensations, experiencer NPs can appear as locative complements of copula phrases, or they can be indexed by oblique L-suffixes on verb phrases, e.g.,

(60) Ṭuroyo Neo-Aramaic

a. *ko-šoḥal-lan*
IND-become_hot-OBL.1PL:R
'We are hot.' (Lit. 'It becomes us hot.')

b. *ko-qoraš-lan*
IND-become_cold-OBL.1PL:R
'We are cold. (Lit. 'It becomes us cold.')

(61) Ṭuroyo Neo-Aramaic

a. *ḥemo=yo* *aʿl-i*
heat.M.SG=PRS.COP.3SG:S upon-1SG
'I am hot.' (Lit. 'It is heat upon me.')

b. *quro=yo* *aʿl-i*
cold.M.SG=PRS.COP.3SG:S upon-1SG
'I am cold.' (Lit. 'It is cold upon me.')

The human argument can also be flagged by the dative preposition *l-*, in which case it must be additionally indexed by L-suffixes, e.g.,

(62) Ṭuroyo Neo-Aramaic

a. *ma* *kət-le* *l-ú-malk-ano*
what EXIST-OBL.3SG.M DAT-the-king-DEM.M.SG
'What does the king have?' (Ritter 1967: 58/3, 57/12)

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b. *basəm-le* *l-ú-rŭʿyo*
be_pleasantPST-OBL.3SG.M:R DAT-the-shepherd.SG.M
'The shepherd liked it.' (Prym & Socin 1881: 29.10)

Dative experiencers are typical of expressions of temperature in the NENA dialects in the western sector, as illustrated in (63) .

(63) C. Marga

a. *(ʾana)* *xer-re* *ʾəll-i*
NOM.1SG look.PST-OBL.3SG at-1SG
'He looked at me.'

b. *l-măni* *xer-re*
from-who look.PST-OBL.3SG
'Whom did he look at?'

(64) C. Marga
xəmma=yla/qarta=yla *ʾəl-li*
heat.M.SG=PRS.COP.3SG.M:S/coldness.F.SG=PRS.COP.3SG.F:S DAT-1SG
'I am hot/cold.'

Flagging may occur in (locative-existential) predicative possessive constructions in Trans-Zab Jewish varieties, especially in those located in north-western Iran and especially in the dialect of J. Salamas (Duval 1883), e.g.,

(65) J. Salamas

a. *ve-la* *all-ef* *xa* *dukana* *rab-ta*
be.PST-OBL.3SG.F:S DAT-3SG.M one shop.F.SG big-F.SG
'He owned a big shop.' (Duval 1883: 91)

b. *la* *ve-lu* *all-ev* *bərune ham bəlane*
NEG be.PST-OBL.3PL:S DAT-3SG.M son.PL ADD daughter.PL
'He had neither sons nor daughters.' (Duval 1883: 105)

(66) J. Solduz (Garbell 1965b: 214)
haman jaxxa *əl-ˈsudr-ew* *it*
same collar on-shirt-POSS.3SG.M EXIST
'His shirt had the same collar.'

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24.3 Experiential predicates and predicative possessors in Arabic

In Mesopotamian Arabic dialects in the region, the predicative possessor is expressed by means of a prepositional phrase. This prepositional phrase by itself can cross-index a conominal possessor, e.g.,

(67) Mardin Qəltu-Arabic
eddēv kān le-hu arbaʿīn wălăd
demon.M.SG be.PST DAT-3SG.M forty boy.M.SG
'The demon had forty sons.'

Experiencers can be expressed by means of direct object indices, as in the case of the verb 'to like; to please', e.g

(68) Āzəx Qəltu-Arabic (Jastrow 1981a: 206.12)
hakar mā ʿəğb-ət-ək ənt fə-bayt-ək
if NEG please.PST-3SG.F:A-2SG.M:P 2SG.M in-house.M.SG-POSS.2SG.M
'If you do not like her, you will stay at home.'

The same direct object indices can also be attached as goal-like arguments to intransitive verbs. In this way, they can denote the experiencer in idioms with 'to come', such as in the expression of sleepiness or falling asleep, e.g.,

(69) Iraqi Gələt Arabic (Woodhead & Beene 1967: 82a)
yə-jī-∅-k n-nōm
3M-come-SG:S-OBJ.2SG:R DEF-sleep.M.SG
'You will fall asleep.' (Lit. 'The sleep will come you.')

They can also be expressed by means of dative prepositional indices bound to the verb, e.g.,

(70) Qarṭmīn Qəltu-Arabic (Jastrow 1981a: 148.10)
ana y-rīd-∅=əlli wəḥd-e
1SG 3M-want-SG=DAT.1SG
'I need one (girl).'

(71) Iraqi Gələt Arabic (Woodhead & Beene 1967: 200a)
l-bēt y-rīd-∅=la ṣubuġ
DEF-house.M.SG 3M-want-SG=DAT.3SG.F paint
'The house needs paint.'

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Expressions with 'to come' and an adnominal possessor denoting the experiencer also occur, e.g.,

(72) Kinderib Qəltu-Arabic (Jastrow 2003: 490)
ana baqa ğā kēf-i
1SG MUCH come.PST.3SG.M pleasure.M.SG-POSS.1SG
'I rejoiced.' (Lit. 'I, my pleasure came.')

Further research is required to investigate these type of constructions in Mesopotamian Arabic.

24.4 Experiential predicates and predicative possessors in Iranian

Experiential predicates and predicative possession are associated with a special type of syntax across the Iranian languages within the Neo-Aramaic speaking region. The human agent-like argument in these constructions is treated differently from the indexing and flagging patterns associated with 'canonical' subjects, except for the oblique agent of past stem verb constructions. Hence, in Iranian linguistics, the term "non-canonical subject" has been adopted. Note theat there is a regional split between the nothern varieties Northern Kurdish and Zazaki and the rest of the group. In many/most Iranic varieties (esp. C. Kurdish, etc.) these experiencers are often encoded with pronominal clitic forms, either alone or coindexing the experiencer/possessor nouns. However, NK and Zazaki (as with Caspian languages) are lacking such clitics altogether, including even for adnominal possession, cf. CK *bra-ke=m* [brother-DEF=1SG.POS ~ NK *bra-yê min* [brotherEZ 1SG.OBL] both 'my brother', etc.

Predicative possession within most of Kurdic is expressed by an existential/copula verb and "non-canonical" coding of the possessor, which is a reflex of Old Iranian syntax. By contrast, in most of the Southern Kurdish varieties, possession is expressed by means of the verb *daştin* (PRS: *dêr/dîr*; PST: *daşt*) 'have' (see Mohammadirad 2020a for an overview of predicative possessive constructions within Western Iranian languages.) Unlike locative-existential possessive constructions, the possessor verb 'to have' follows the dominant syntax of the language, thus its subject is treated the same as that of primary transitive verbs, e.g.,

(73) SK Kermanshah

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*mi kitaw dîr-**im***
1SG book have.PRS-1SG:A
'I have (a) book.'

Expression of necessity and wanting is coded differently across Iranian languages of the region. In Zazaki and northern and western varieties of Kurmanji as well as Southern Kurdish, the verb 'to want' expresses necessity, and follows the syntax of primary transitive verbs, e.g.,

(74) a. Zazaki (Paul 2024: 85)
ez a to waz-en-a
1SG.DIR COP.3SG.F 2SG.OBL want-AUG-1SG:A
'I want you.'

b. NK Mardin
ez te di-xwaz-im
1SG.DIR 2SG.OBL IND-want.PRS-1SG:A
'I want you.'

c. SK Kermanshah
mi to xwaz-im
1SG 2SG want.PRS-1SG:A
'I want you.'

In Zazaki, the experiencer of physiological states relating to temperature remains 'canonical' and is expressed by means of a copula construction, as shown below. (In other Iranian languages of the region, this is expressed differently.)

(75) Zazaki
ez serd=a
1SG.DIR cold=COP.1SG:S
'I am cold.'

Other physiological states such as 'hunger' and 'thirst' exhibit variation in the way they are coded within Kurdish. In Zazaki and Northern Kurdish, however, these predicates are expressed through regular copula constructions, as (76a)-(76b) illustrate.

(76) a. Zazaki
ez vêşan=a
1SG.DIR hungry=COP.1SG:S
'I am hungry.'

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b. NK Mardin
ez *birçî=me*
1SG.DIR hungry=COP.1SG:S
'I am hungry.'

In what follows, we shall focus on constructions that deviate from the above.

24.4.1 Unflagged experiencers and possessors indexed by oblique clitic pronouns

24.4.1.1 Predicative possessors

The possessor NP is unflagged but cross-indexed via oblique clitic indices in Central Kurdish and Goranî in an exisential possessive construction, as illustrated in (77)–(78). Here, the possessor is encoded in the same fashion as in adnominal possession, and attaches to the indefinite possessee like a bound genitive pronoun. However, when the possessee NP is not overtly expressed, the possessive index attaches to exisential verb, as shown in (77b) and (77c).

(77) CK

a. *(min)* *bira-yêk=im he-ye*
brother-INDF=OBL.1SG EXIST-3SG:S
'(As for me), I have a brother.' (Lit. 'I, a brother of me/mine there is.')

b. *he=m-e*
EXIST==OBL.1SG--3SG:S
'I have it/them/some.' (Lit. 'There is me/mine.')

c. *nî=man-e*
EXIST==OBL.1PL--3SG:S
'We don't have any.' (Lit. 'There isn't me/mine.')

(78) Hewramî (Mohammadirad 2026)
sîyawehş-î *kuř-êw=**iş*** *bîye=n*
Siyawehsh-M.SG.OBL son-INDF=OBL.3SG be.PST.PTCP.M=COP.3SG.M:S
'Siyawehsh has had a son.' [SK.87]

The construction is thus similar to a topicalised adnominal possessor with pronominal resumption, as (79) illustrates.

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(79) Common Central Kurdish
(min) naw=im *Sara=ye*
1SG name=OBL.1SG SARA=COP.3SG:S
'(As for me,) my name is Sara.'

In the Bijar variety of SK, the genitive possessive construction is conditioned by inalienability (Mohammadirad 2020a). The genitive possessive index with the verb 'to be' encodes inalienable possession (80b), whereas the possessor verb 'to have' with a 'canonical' subject expresses alienable possession (80c).

(80) Bijar SK (Mohammadirad 2020a: 513, glosssing modified)

a. *dot-i* *ewe* *d-û*
daughter-EZ 3SG.OBL IND-be.PRS.3SG:S
'She is her daughter.' Adnominal possessor

b. *dot=**î*** *d-û*
daughter=OBL.3SG IND-be.PRS.3SG:S
'She will have a daughter.' Possessor NP indexed by oblique clitic

c. *îme kewş* *ne-yr-îman*
1PL shoes NEG-have.PRS-1PL:A
'We don't have shoes.' Possessor verb

24.4.1.2 Experiential predicates

Experiencer arguments of experiential predicates can also be indexed by means of oblique clitic pronouns, depending on the semantics and dialect in question. In Central Kurdish, for instance, oblique clitic pronouns express the experiencer argument of 'to want; to need; to be necessary', as (81a)-(81b) show.

(81) a. CK Erbil
to=m *de-wê-y*
2SG=OBL.1SG textscind-be_necessary-2SG:S
'I want you.' (Lit. 'You are wanting to me.')

b. CK Sanandaj
to=m *gerek=e*
2SG=OBL.1SG be_necessary-COP.3SG:S
'I want you.' (Lit. 'You is wanting to me.')

In Central and Southern Kurdish as well as Gorani, the experiencer argument of sensations of temperature and physiological needs such as hunger and thirst are obligatorily indexed by oblique clitics, as shown in (82)-(83).

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(82) a. CK Suleimaniya/ SK
serma=m=e
cold=OBL.1SG=COP.3SG:S
'I am cold.' (Lit. 'It is my cold.')

b. Hewramî
serd=m=a
cold=OBL.1SG=COP.3SG:S
'I am cold.' (Lit. 'It is my cold.')

(83) a. CK Suleimaniya/SK
birsî=m=e
hungry=OBL.1SG=COP.3SG:S
'I am hungry.' (Lit. 'It is my hungry.')

b. Hewramî
awra=m=a
hungry=OBL.1SG=COP.3SG:S
'I am hungry.' (Lit. 'It is my hungry.')

24.4.2 Flagged possessors and experiencers

24.4.2.1 Genitive predicative possessors

In predicative possession, the possessor argument has to appear in the oblique case in Zazaki and Northern Kurdish. The expression of the predicative possessor does not differ from adnominal possession.

(84) Common Northern Kurdish
hêval-ekî *min* *heye*
friend-INDEF.EZ.M.SG 1SG.OBL EXIST.PRS.3SG
'I have a friend.' (Lit. 'A friend of mine there is.')

(85) Zazaki (Mohammadirad 2020a citing Paul 2024: 270)
yew mêşna-y ***mi*** *est-a*
one sheep.F-EZ 1SG.OBL EXIST.PRS.3SG.F:S
'I have a sheep.' (Lit. 'One sheep of mine there is.')

24.4.2.2 Genitive experiencers

Experiencers can also be treated like adnominal possessors, particularly in expressions involving the verb 'to come', as illustrated below, but also in expressions for the sensation of pain located in parts of the body.

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(86) a. Zazaki (Mohammadirad 2020a citing Paul 2024: 270)
hewn-ê *mi* *yen-o*
sleep-EZ.M 1SG.OBL come.PRS.AUG-3SG:S
'I feel sleepy.' (Lit. 'My sleep comes.')

b. Common Northern Kurdish
xew-a *min* *t-ê*
sleep-EZ.F 1SG.OBL IND-come.PRS.3SG:S
'I feel sleepy.' (Lit. 'My sleep comes.')

c. Common Central Kurdish
xew *=im* *d-ê*
sleep =1SG.OBL IND-come.PRS.3SG:S
'I feel sleepy.' (Lit. 'My sleep comes.')

24.4.2.3 Oblique possessor or experiencer subjects

The oblique possessor or experiencer can also occur in initial position, in which case the human argument is not the adnominal genitive possessor, but it is an oblique subject NP, e.g.,

(87) NK Akre (MacKenzie 1962: 308.682)
he-bô *ḥakimek.* *ewî* *ḥakim-î*
EXIST-be.PST ruler.DIR.INDEF.M.SG OBL.DEM.SG.M ruler.OBL.M.SG
habô *kiček* *ô* *kuřek*
EXIST-be.PST girl.DIR.INDEF.F.SG and boy.DIR.INDEF.M.SG
'There was a prince. That prince had a daughter and a son.' (Lit. 'There was belonging to the prince a daughter and a son.')

Experiencer arguments of experiential verbs can also occur in the oblique case, depending on the verb and dialect in question. In Behdînî NK, the verb *viyan* expresses necessity and wanting, and the experiencer argument is expressed in the oblique case. The stimulus, if expressed, is coded in the direct case, and the verb agrees with it.

(88) Behdînî NK

a. *min* *tu* *t-vê-y*
1SG.OBL 2SG.DIR IND-be_necessary.PRS-2SG:S
'I want you.' (Lit. 'Me want you.')

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b. *min* *tu* *vîya-y*
1SG.OBL 2SG.DIR IND-be_necessary.PST-2SG:S
'I wanted you.' (Lit. 'Me wanted you.')

c. *min* *vîya* *bi-ç-im*
1SG.OBL be_necessary.PST SBJV-go.PRS-1SG:S
'I wanted to go.' (Lit. 'Me wanted to go.')

Moreover, the experiencer in expressions of the sensation of temperature is coded in the oblique case in NK, e.g.,

(89) Common Northern Kurdish
min *sar=e*
1SG.OBL cold=COP.3SG:S
'I am cold.' (Lit. 'To me it is cold.')

24.4.3 Flagged experiencers indexed by oblique clitic pronouns

In conservative Gorani varieties, the experiencer of 'to want; to need' is both expressed in the oblique case and indexed by an oblique clitic pronoun, as (90) illustrates.

(90) Hewramî Tekht (Mohammadirad 2026)
a *zařoł(e)-a* ***jenî=şa*** *gerek-e=ne*
DEM.DIST child-PL.OBL wife.SG.F.DIR=3PL.OBL necessary-F =COP.3SG.F:S
'The boys (the princes) want wives.' [ME.13]

24.5 Experiential predicates and predicative possessors in Armenian

Most experiential predicates and predicative possessors have a human argument in the nominative. For instance, Standard Eastern Armenian has inherited the possessor verb 'to have', with a nominative possessor subject (91a). Similarly, experiential predicates denoting temperature sensations are expressed by verbs with nominative subjects (91b), (91c), and physiological needs such as hunger (91d) and thirst (91e) are expressed with regular copula clauses. In what follows, we shall focus on constructions that deviate from this.

(91) SEA

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a. *es* *girkʿ* *unem*
1SG.NOM book have-PRS.1SG
'I have a book.'

b. *es* *šog-um=em*
1SG.NOM be.hot-I.PTCP=be.PRS.1SG
'I am hot.'

c. *es* *mŕs-um=em*
1SG.NOM be.cold-I.PTCP=be.PRS.1SG
'I am cold.'

d. *es* *sovac=em*
1SG.NOM hungry=be.PRS.1SG
'I am hungry.'

e. *es* *carav=em*
1SG.NOM thirsty=be.PRS.1SG
'I am thirsty.'

24.5.1 Genitive possessors and experiencers

24.5.1.1 Genitive possessors

Classical Armenian also had predicative possession constructions with an existential verb, in which the possessor appeared in the genitive, as discussed by, among others, Benveniste (1952) and Hewson & Bubenik (1997) (92).

(92) Classical Armenian (Hewson & Bubenik 1997: 75)
nora *ē* *handerj*
3SG.GEN be.PRS.3SG dress
'S/he has a dress.'

This is paralleled by constructions found in some modern Armenian dialects, where the possessor in a predicative possession construction may be expressed as a "possessive article" (93).

(93) Agulis Armenian (Paraka) (Hodgson 2022a)
ankʰan *hingir-ne-s=a* *el-ats*
so.many friend-PL-ART1=be.3SG be-RES.PTCP
'I had so many friends.'

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24.5.1.2 Genitive experiencers

Furthermore, there are some expressions where experiencers are expressed as adnominal possessors, using a "possessive article" (see 11.4.2), for example (94), (95), (96), (97).

(94) SEA
kʿun-s *tan-um=ē*
sleep-ART1 take.away-I.PTCP=be.PRS.3SG
'I am sleepy.' (Lit. 'My sleep is taking away.')

(95) SEA
mełkʿ-s *gal-is=ē*
sin-ART1 come-I.PTCP=be.PRS.3SG
'I feel pity.' (Lit. 'My sin is coming.')

(96) SEA
haves-s *gal-is=ē*
pleasure-ART1 come-I.PTCP=be.PRS.3SG
'I feel pleasure.' (Lit. 'My pleasure is coming.')

(97) SEA
lacʿ-s *gal-is=ē*
crying-ART1 come-I.PTCP=be.PRS.3SG
'I feel like crying.' (Lit. 'My crying is coming.')

The experiential predicate for 'to like; to please' is also of this type, except that the preverbal element that governs the genitive experiencer is derived from an adjective meaning 'smooth, easy, pleasant', as shown in (94) and (95). This is a preverb that is generally not used independently. In this construction, the stimulus takes nominative case. The genitive experiencer is most often expressed by a "possessive article", as in (98), but can also be expressed by a noun or pronoun in genitive case, as in (99).

(98) SEA
na *dur-s* *gal-is=ē*
3SG.NOM pleasant-ART1 come-I.PTCP=be.PRS.3SG
'I like him/her.' (Lit. 'He is coming my pleasant.')

(99) SEA

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es *kʿo* *dur-ə* *gal-is=em*
1SG.NOM 2SG.GEN pleasant-DEF come-I.PTCP=be.PRS.1SG
'You like me.' (Lit. 'I am coming your pleasant.')

24.5.2 Dative possessors

24.5.2.1 Locative-existential dative possessors

In most (locative-existential) predicative possession constructions found in Armenian dialects, the possessor appears in dative case, as shown in in (100)-(102)).

(100) Salmast Armenian (Atayan 1906: 204)
tænc^{h}ə' *me* *ets* *k-l-i*
DEM2.DAT one goat PTCL-be-PRS.3SG
'They have a goat.' (Lit. 'There is to them a goat.')

(101) Van Armenian (Gyuzak) (Mkrtumyan n.d.)
im *pap-i-n* *me* *kajlon* *k-aɾ*
1SG.GEN grandfather-DAT-DEF one pipe EXIST-PST.3SG
'My grandfather had a pipe.' (Lit. 'There was to my grandfather a pipe.')

(102) Agulis Armenian (Tanakert) (Hodgson 2022a)
ændz *el-æts=æ* *iɾik^{h}* *axpaɾ*
1SG.DAT be.RES.PTCP=be.3SG three brother
'I had three brothers.' (Lit. 'There is been to me three brother.')

24.5.2.2 Dative subjects of the possessor verb

In Karabagh (103) and Agulis (104), and also in Diyarbakir (105), we find constructions where the possessor subject of the verb 'to have' appears in dative case, perhaps through influence of the predicative possession constructions with dative possessors.

(103) Karabagh Armenian (Martirosyan 2019: 92)
ʃinæc^{h}i *Siɾk^{j}is-i-n* *Maral* *ənəm-av* *min* *kov* *uneɾ.*
villager Sargis-DAT-DEF Maral name-INS one cow have-PRS.3SG
'The villager Sargis had a cow called Maral.'

(104) Agulis Armenian (Tsghna) (Hodgson 2022a)
yræn *nəkaɾ-neɾ* *on-i* *nel*
3SG.DAT picture-PL have-3SG PST
'He had pictures.' (Lit. 'Him had pictures.')

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(105) Diyarbakir Armenian (Haneyan 1978: 158)
kʰæʧʰʧʰəl-i-n tʰiɣ unen-æ, iɾ kəlox-e gə-kʰəss-e
bald-DAT-DEF razor have-3SG.PRS.SBJV 3SG.GEN head-DEF PTCL-rub-3SG
'[If] a bald man has a razor, he will rub his head.'

Examples of dative subject constructions have also been reported from a speaker of Urmia Armenian resident in Vayots Dzor region of Armenia, as shown in (106).

(106) Urmia Armenian (Vernashen) (Hodgson fieldnotes)
meɾə ʒamtun el un-ehʲ gjuɣ-i meʧʰə
1PL.DAT church PTCL have-PRS.1PL village-GEN in
'We had a church in the village too.'

There are, however, also examples of the verb 'to have' with nominative subject in the Armenian dialect of Urmia, and such dative subject constructions are not discussed by Asatryan (1962).

24.6 Discussion

In general, Iranian and Aramaic most closely converge in making use of the oblique case or oblique sets of person markers to express experiencer and possessor arguments. This convergence also extends to using the same case or set of person markers for the agent in past stem verb clauses, on which see Chapters 13 and 21. These common usage patterns seem to have a deep history, so that the observable commonalities are not simply the result of recent bilingualism that imposes the pattern from one language on another (but see below). Furthermore, it will prove challenging to trace down to a single source the few idioms shared throughout languages of the area that involve a motion verb and the experiencer expressed as an adnominal possessor of the subject NP, as in the expressions for the experiencer of sleepiness, e.g.,

(107) a. J. Dohok
šənθ-i θe-la
sleep.F.SG-POSS.1SG come.PST-OBL.3SG.F:S
'I got sleepy.'

b. Zazaki (Mohammadirad 2020a citing Paul 2024: 270)
hewn-ê mi yen-o
sleep-EZ.M.SG 1SG.OBL come.PRS.AUG-3SG:S
'I am sleepy.'

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c. Common Northern Kurdish
xew-a *min* *t-ê*
sleep-EZ.F.SG 1SG.OBL IND-come.PRS.3SG:S
'I am sleepy.'

d. Common Central Kurdish
xew *=im* *d-ê*
sleep.SG =OBL.1SG IND-come.PRS.3SG:S
'I am sleepy.'

e. Azeri
yux-um *gəl-di*
sleep.SG-POSS.1SG come-PST.3
'I got sleepy.'

There is some variation in the encoding of the experiencer in this idiom, notably as an oblique argument of the verb, e.g.,

(108) a. Ṭuroyo Neo-Aramaic
aθi-li *šanθo*
come.PST-OBL.1SG:R sleep.F.SG
'I got sleepy.'

b. Iraqi Gələt Arabic (Woodhead & Beene 1967: 82a)
jā-ni *n-nōm*
come.PST-OBJ.1SG:R DEF-sleep.M.SG
'I got sleepy.'

There is also variation in the respective lexical verb, such as 'to take (away)' instead of 'to come', e.g.,

(109) a. SEA
kʿun-s *tan-um=ē*
sleep.SG-ART1 take_away-I.PTCP=be.PRS.3SG:A
'I am sleepy.'

b. Persian
xāb *=am* *mi-barad*
sleep.SG =OBL.1SG IND-take.PRS.3SG.M
'I am sleepy.'

There is some evidence, however, that Neo-Iranian structures have been imposed on NENA dialects. In Iranian languages, the oblique has the additional

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function of marking adnominal possession. In NENA, there are separate possessive suffixes or genitive markers used for this function. Thus, in several NENA dialects, mostly those that have been in contact with Central Kurdish or Persian, the Iranian oblique has clearly been interpreted as a genitive experiencer, and has thereby been imposed as such on the Neo-Aramaic syntax. This holds true in particular of the expression of temperature sensations, as illustrated in (110a)-(110c). The sensations of hunger and thirst are also included in this in the Christian NENA dialects of eastern Iraqi Kurdistan and Iranian Kurdistan as well as the Jewish NENA dialects of Iranian Kurdistan.

(110) a. C. Koy Sanjak
'ana qart-i=la
1SG cold-POSS.1SG=COP.3SG.F:S
'I am cold.'

b. Persian
man sard=am=e
1SG cold=OBL.1SG=COP.3SG:S
'I am cold.'

c. Central Kurdish
min serma=m=e
1SG cold=OBL.1SG=COP.3SG:S
'I am cold.'

This interpretation of the Iranian oblique as an adnominal possessor also seems to apply to the predicative possessive constructions that involve a genitive of some kind in NENA dialects and Armenian dialects in contact with Northern Kurdish. Thus, the Iranian syntax almost certainly served as a model for the sporadic cases of genitive possessive constructions in NENA in the western periphery, in dialects such as C. Bohtan and C. Hertevin, where the predicative possessor is encoded as an adnominal possessor of the possessee NP, as well as the Armenian dialects located in or near north-western Iran.

(111) Common Northern Kurdish
hêval-ekî *min* *heye*
friend-INDEF.EZ.M.SG 1SG.OBL EXIST.PRS.3SG
'I have a friend.'

(112) C. Bohtan (Fox 2009: 116)

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ʾowən iwa baxt-əw (u) abr-əw
3SG.M PST.COP.3 woman.F.SG-POSS.3SG.M and son.M.SG-POSS.3SG.M
'He had a wife and a son.'

(113) Agulis Armenian (Paraka) (Hodgson 2022a)
ank^{h}an hingiɾ-ne-s=a el-ats
so.many friend-PL-ART1=be.3SG be-RES.PTCP
'I had so many friends.'

By contrast, where the human argument appears in the Iranian oblique case this converges with the dative in NENA, Central Neo-Aramaic, and Armenian. For instance, the experiencer argument in the expressions of the sensation of temperature is coded in the oblique case in Northern Kurdish, which converges with the oblique indices, i.e., L-suffixes, and prepositional phrases in dialects of NENA and Ṭuroyo Neo-Aramaic.

(114) Northern Kurdish

a. *min germ =e*
1SG.OBL warm.SG COP.3SG
'I am hot.'

b. *min sar =e*
1SG.OBL cold.SG COP.3SG
'I am cold.'

(115) C. Hertevin (Noorlander field notes)

a. *ḥəmme =le lål-i*
heatM.SG =COP.3SG.M DAT-1SG
'I am hot.'

b. *qåɾəš-li*
IND-become_cold-OBL.1SG:R
'I am cold.'

(116) Ṭuroyo Neo-Aramaic

a. *ḥemo =yo aʿl-i*
heatM.SG =COP.3SG on-1SG
'I am hot.'

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b. *ko-qoraš-li*
IND-become_cold-OBL.1SG:R
'I am cold.'

The dative existential possessor construction in Mlaḥso Neo-Aramaic located in south-eastern Anatolia and the Jewish NENA dialects of Iranian Azerbaijan parallels the syntax of the dative case in Armenian and that of the oblique case in Northern Kurdish, e.g.,

(117) J. Salamas
la ve-lu all-ev bərune ham bəlane
NEG be.PST-OBL.3PL:S DAT-3SG.M son.PL ADD daughter.PL
'He had neither sons nor daughters.'

(118) Salmast Armenian (Atayan 1906: 204)
tænc^{h}ə' me ets k-l-i
DEM2.DAT one goat PTCL-be-PRS.3SG
'They have a goat.'

(119) Mlaḥso Neo-Aramaic (Jastrow 1994a: 76.19)
zʿure el-i lo- ve-len
child.PL DAT-1SG NEG be.PST-OBL.3PL:S
'I did not have children.'

(120) NK Gulli (MacKenzie 1961a: 350)
me biçûk nîn-in
1PL.OBL little NEG.EXIST-3PL:S
'We haven't any children.'

Finally, the Arabic verb *ʿjb* 'to please; to like' was imported into NENA and Ṭuroyo Neo-Aramaic together with the imposition of its Arabic syntax. However, the experiencer is encoded by direct object indices in Arabic, which can also express recipients. In NENA and Ṭuroyo Neo-Aramaic, the oblique L-suffixes serve as corresponding recepient-like experiencer markers, including in the Christian dialects of the Urmi region.

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25 Concluding remarks

25.1 Preliminary remarks

In this concluding chapter we shall bring together and summarise a selection of the themes and processes of language contact that have been examined in detail in the discussion sections of the preceding chapters.

We shall first review the various layers of linguistic contact that have been operative on NENA dialects at various stages of their history. Then we discuss other factors that had a bearing on the outcome of language contact across the NENA dialect area. This is followed by an overview of the features in the contact languages that are matched by NENA dialects and seem to have had an impact on their development in NENA. Then we go on to discuss the typology of the processes that have resulted in the various types of contact-induced change in NENA. Finally, we examine various explanatory models of contact linguistics for the development of the current profile of NENA.

25.2 Contact languages and historical layers of contact

This book has examined correlations between NENA dialects and languages spoken in the region that are or have been historically in contact with NENA. The focus has been on contact-induced change in NENA. This is manifested in structures in NENA shared with languages of the region that are the result of contact rather than inheritance from a common ancestor.

The contact languages that have been taken into consideration include Kurdish, Gorani, Zazaki, Armenian, vernacular Arabic, and, in a few cases, Turkic. It has been shown that all these languages contain, in varying degrees, features in phonology, morphosyntax and syntax that match corresponding features in NENA. Account has not been taken of modern national standard languages, such as Standard Arabic or Standard Persian, which some NENA speakers have come into contact with in recent times, mainly through school education and modern administration. The impact of these on NENA appears to be restricted to the occasional recent borrowing of technical vocabulary, but they have had only a minimal impact on the structure of NENA. Languages of the region that may have

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been historically in contact with the ancestors of the modern NENA dialects but now are extinct and no longer spoken have, likewise, not been taken into account. These include languages such as Akkadian and various earlier Iranian languages, such as Middle Persian and Old Persian.

Aramaic has deep historical roots in the Mesopotamian region, the earliest records of it being datable to the beginning of the first millennium BCE. It is likely that the presence of Armenian had a similar time depth in the region (§1.2.3.1). Iranian-speaking populations are attested on the borders of the Mesopotamian area in the early first millennium BCE in the central and northern Zagros, but did not settle in the heartlands of the Aramaic-speaking populations in Mesopotamia until the Achaemenid period (6th century BCE). The speakers of Kurdish, Gorani and Zazaki were later arrivals in the Aramaic-speaking area, apparently some time in the 1st millennium CE, though there is no certainty about the dates of their migrations. Arabic became prevalent in the region after the Islamic conquests in the 7th century CE. Turkic-speaking peoples settled in western Iran on the periphery of the current NENA area after the Seljuk conquests in the 11th century CE.

Both the modern NENA dialects and the modern Armenian dialects exhibit a marked diversity. This can be interpreted as a reflection of the considerable historical depth of the speakers of the ancestors of these languages in the region. Our study of correlations of NENA dialects with the other languages of the region has shown that, in many features, these latter appear to exhibit a lesser degree of diversity. This may be a reflection of the later arrival of speakers of these languages by migrations from outside of the Mesopotamian region and the shallower time depth of their settlement compared to NENA and Armenian speakers. One must take into account, however, Kurdish dialects have not been documented to the same level of detail as NENA and Armenian dialects. Within NENA itself there are differing degrees of diversity in different sectors of the NENA area, and one factor conditioning this is likely to be different periods of migration. A clear case of this is in the distribution of the Jewish Trans-Zab dialects. The Jewish Trans-Zab dialects in western Iran exhibit considerable uniformity in structure, whereas those in Iraq are more diverse (Khan 2020b). This is likely to reflect a relatively recent wave of migration of Jewish NENA speakers from Iraq to western Iran.

A number of words in the lexicon of modern NENA dialects are of Akkadian origin (Krotkoff 1985; Khan 2017b; Mutzafi 2018). This is evidence that the ancestors of the NENA dialects had contact with Akkadian when it was still a living language in the first millennium BCE. The aforementioned studies have shown that in some cases these Akkadian loanwords have their origin specifically in the

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Assyrian dialect of Akkadian, which was spoken in northern Mesopotamia, coinciding geographically, therefore, with the NENA dialect area. Given the early presence of Armenian speakers in the region, it is likely that contact between Aramaic and Armenian began at about the same period, though, unlike the Akkadian loanwords, there is no direct linguistic evidence embedded within the modern NENA dialects that reflect the antiquity of this contact.

The various languages studied in this volume that exhibit features that correlate with features in NENA were in contact with different sectors of the NENA area at the time when the NENA area was at its full extent in the first half of the twentieth century, before the massive displacements of NENA-speaking communities. Armenian was in contact with NENA dialects in the northern sector in south-eastern Turkey and north-western Iran. Vernacular *Qəltu* Arabic dialects were in contact with NENA dialects mainly on the Mosul plain, the Arbil plain and the north-western sector. The Northern Kurdish subgroup was in contact with NENA dialects in the northern sector of NENA. The Central Kurdish subgroup was in contact with NENA dialects on the southern sector. The Southern Kurdish subgroup was in contact with some dialects on the far south-eastern periphery of the NENA area in western Iran. Turkic was in contact with the north-eastern periphery of NENA in north-western Iran.

The contact between NENA speakers and speakers of Gorani and Zazaki in modern times, however, is less clear. A number of features that NENA dialects share with Gorani and Zazaki, however, indicate that the latter two languages must have been in contact with NENA at an earlier historical period. Several NENA dialects, especially those in the south-eastern sector, exhibit influence from Gorani but these NENA dialects were spoken in the twentieth century in locations where the main contact language was Kurdish. By the twentieth century the areas in which Zazaki dialects were spoken lay outside the NENA area. There were, therefore, historical layers of contact. It would appear that Gorani and Zazaki had different geographical boundaries before the twentieth century that resulted in contact with NENA. This has been shown in Khan and Mohammadirad (2024b) to have been the case in the town of Sanandaj in western Iran, in which Gorani was spoken until the end of the nineteenth century, but most inhabitants subsequently shifted to Kurdish, presumably following a period of bilingualism. Alternatively, it may have been the case that the areas in which NENA was spoken in earlier periods was larger and this faciliated contact with Gorani and Zazaki. Another example of historical layering of contact can be identified in the region of Urmi in north-western Iran. The C. Urmi dialect exhibits influence in structure and lexicon from Kurdish. The dialect spoken today contains numerous loanwords from Turkic and Persian but only minimal influence

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in structure. Furthermore, a large proportion of the Kurdish nouns have been adapted to NENA morphology by the addition of NENA inflectional endings, whereas only a small minority of the Turkic and Persian loanwords have been adapted. This can be interpreted as reflecting that the Kurdish loans represent an older layer of the lexicon, which entered the dialect at an earlier historical period, before the dominance of Turkic and Persian. Nowadays speakers of the C. Urmi dialect in the Urmi region speak Azeri Turkic and Persian but generally not Kurdish (Khan 2016b: vol. 3, 2). Similarly, NENA dialects spoken on the Mosul plain today exhibit influence in structure and lexicon from Kurdish, but now Kurdish is generally not spoken by the NENA speakers in the villages in this area. The main contact language is, rather, Arabic, which has left its mark on the dialects by large numbers of unadapted loanwords and extensive code-switching between NENA and Arabic.

25.3 Factors that had a bearing on the outcome of language contact

As would be expected, in many cases of structural correspondences between NENA and contact languages the corresponding structures are to be found in contact languages in the same geographical area as the NENA dialects in question. For example, certain structures that are characteristic of NENA dialects in the northern sector correspond to those that are found in Northern Kurdish, Armenian, Zazaki or Arabic rather than in Central Kurdish or Gorani.

As remarked, however, this geographical correspondence between NENA structures and those of contact languages can be skewed by historical layering of contact. This has resulted in a situation whereby features of a NENA dialect in one geographical area do not correspond to those of languages in contact with the NENA dialect in modern times. This is the case with Gorani, whereby due to the contraction of the area where Gorani was spoken, the Jewish NENA dialects of western Iran exhibit structural correspondences with Gorani dialects that now are spoken in a different geographical area.

Another way in which geographical correspondences have been skewed is by migrations of NENA-speaking communities. There are typically no historical records of these migrations, but they are reflected in the linguistic structure of some dialects. A clear example is the geographical extent of the Jewish Trans-Zab subgroup in modern times. In the twentieth century dialects of this subgroup were spoken in an area extending east of the Great Zab to the region of Urmi and Salamas in north-western Iran and along the border area between Iraq and Iran

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as far south of Kerend. The Jewish Trans-Zab dialects, however, exhibit some features that appear to have arisen through contact with Gorani, such as the labio-dental realisation of historical **w* (§3.2.3) and features that are areal features of the Zagros region, such as the weakening of **d* to the lateral */l/* by the 'Zagros *d* effect' (§2.6). Moreover, the Jewish Trans-Zab dialects in north-western Iran lack features that have been acquired by Christian NENA dialects of the region due to contact with Northern Kurdish and Armenian, such as unaspirated stop phonemes (§4.5). This suggests that the Jewish Trans-Zab dialects developed originally in the Zagros area and some speakers subsequently migrated north to the region of Urmi and Salamas. Another possible reflection of migration within the Jewish Trans-Zab group is the presence in the dialects of this subgroup in western Iran of lexical borrowings from Bahdini Northern Kurdish, suggesting that the ancestors of the speakers of the dialects migrated from the Northern Kurdish area of Iraq (Khan & Mohammadirad 2024b: 515). A further sign of migration within the Jewish Trans-Zab group is the fact that the dialects of the subgroup across various geographical locations in western Iran all have a very similar structure. This is likely to reflect a relatively recent settlement of these Jewish Trans-Zab communities in this area compared to the Jewish Trans-Zab communities in Iraq. Some cases of migration of NENA-speaking communities that could have skewed geographical correlations are historically documented. The NENA-speaking Christians who originally lived in many villages across the Urmi plain in the course of the twentieth century migrated for the most part to the town of Urmi. This skewed geographical correlations of distinctions between the northern and the southern subgroups of C. Urmi with geographical distinctions between the Kurdish dialects of the region, since speakers of both subgroups of C. Urmi came together in the town of Urmi (Khan 2016b: vol. 1, 28).

It should be taken into account, however, that it is not always clear whether geographical skewing of contact-induced change is due to migration or diffusion. Features may gradually diffuse through social networks without there being migration of groups from one geographical area to another (Milroy 1987; Milroy & Milroy 1992). A possible example of this is the emergence of the expression of the progressive in NENA dialects by an infinitive with a locative preposition. It is likely that this developed by convergence with a construction with a similar structure in Armenian (§19.6). NENA dialects would have come into contact with Armenian in south-eastern Turkey and north-western Iran. Progressive constructions with a locative infinitive, however, are found further south than this region in the northern sector of the NENA area in Iraq, outside of the Armenian speech zone. Rather than assuming mass migrations of NENA-speaking communities from the Armenian speech zone into Iraq, it is more likely that this feature was

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the result of gradual diffusion. We have evidence from pre-modern texts written in NENA dialects that this construction was rarely used in the northern Mosul plain before the twentieth century (Mengozzi 2012: 32), although it is common in the documented modern form of these dialects in this area. This indicates the diffusion took place in the northern Mosul plain in relatively recent times. This, in turn, suggests that the source of the diffusion was in the north-east of the NENA area, in north-western Iran, where locative progressive constructions are well established and have in some dialects, e.g., J. Salamas, become a general indicative present, as in most modern Eastern Armenian dialects.

Diffusion to NENA dialects of a feature that has its origin in a contact language may take place indirectly. This appears to be the case with regards to the presence of unaspirated stops in some NENA dialects (§4.5). Unaspirated stops had their origin in Armenian, from where they diffused to Northern Kurdish and NENA dialects in the northern sector. In the NENA dialects of northern Iraq and south-eastern Turkey unaspirated stops occur only in loanwords from Northern Kurdish, suggesting that their presence in these NENA dialects was not due to direct contact with Armenian. In NENA dialects in the Urmi region in north-western Iran, however, unaspirated stop phonemes are more established in the sound system and are found in words belonging to the native Aramaic lexicon. It is known that in modern times there was direct contact between NENA speakers and Armenian speakers, sometimes in the same family, in the Urmi region and this would have resulted in their more established presence in the sound system of the NENA dialects.

The existence of different social networks of NENA speakers based on religious community rather than on geographical location can result in geographical mismatches and skewing within NENA dialects across the NENA dialect area. The Christians and the Jews spoke distinct NENA dialects. This applied even to locations where Christians and Jews lived in the same location, e.g., in Zakho, Dohok, Shaqlawa, Koy Sanjak, Bədyal, Sulemaniyya and the Barwar region in Iraq, and in Salamas, Urmi and Sanandaj in Iran.

One factor that brought about some of these communal dialect differences in the same location was the different migration histories of the Christian and Jewish communities. This was the case, for example, in the town of Urmi, as discussed above. The Christians moved to the town from the countryside relatively recently whereas the Jews, who had been established in the town for a longer period of time, seem ultimately to have migrated from the south. As a result, the C. Urmi dialect exhibits linguistic changes that have been induced by contact with languages in the Urmi region whereas J. Urmi exhibits some features that were induced ultimately by contact with languages further south.

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The most powerful factor in bringing about the linguistic differences between Christian and Jewish NENA dialects, however, was social. Linguistic change is a spontaneous process which occurs in the period of language acquisition by young children and also during the lifetime of adults. The extent to which change is diffused depends first and foremost on social networks. The extent of the change and the boundaries of its diffusion depends on the tightness of social networks and the group identity of the networks. Linguistic distinctiveness is, indeed, an emblem of distinct communal identities. The fact that the patterns of linguistic change have been so different between the dialects of Christians and the dialects of Jews reflects the fact that these communities constituted two entirely different social networks and identity groups.

These social networks sometimes extended over considerable distances. This is shown by the fact that there were chains of Jewish dialects spread over a large geographical area that were very similar to each other and in the same geographical area there were chains of Christian dialects that were similar to each other but very different from the Jewish dialects in the same region. The linguistic profile of the dialects shows that the social networks incorporate communities that are separated by large geographical spaces. The dialects of the Jews of the towns of Zakho, Dohuk, Amedia and Betanure (Barwar), for example, exhibit many similarities, although some of these communities were separated by several days' journey before the period of modern transport.

What is of particular interest to us are linguistic structures that can be correlated with structures in languages in contact. The presence of different social networks within the same geographical area can result in different outcomes of language contact in NENA dialects spoken within each of these networks. These different outcomes may consist of different degrees of convergence with contact languages in different networks. The Jewish Trans-Zab dialects, for example, exhibit several innovative features that have arisen by convergence with contact languages whereas the Christian dialects in the same area lack these features or exhibit them with a lesser frequency and so are more conservative. The Jewish Trans-Zab dialects, for example, normally place the verb after the object, which is a feature of Iranian and other languages in the same region, whereas this type of word order is less regular in Christian dialects (§23.1). There has been loss of gender distinction in third person singular pronouns in Jewish Trans-Zab dialects, which matches the lack of gender distinction in Kurdish and Turkic dialects in the region, whereas this gender distinction has been preserved in Christian dialects (§10.1). The NENA annexation particle has been lost in the Jewish Trans-Zab dialects of the south-eastern sector through matching the pattern of noun phrases in south Central Kurdish, which lack the *ezafe* particle. In the Christian dialects

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in the same area, however, the NENA annexation particle has been preserved (§11.5). In phonology the Jewish Trans-Zab dialect of Urmi exhibits a greater convergence with Turkic vowel harmony than the Christian dialects of the same area (§7.1.3).

Also diffusion of contact-induced features from a particular area is dependent not only on geography but also, indeed principally, on social networks. An example of this is the diffusion of the progressive construction formed from a locative infinitive, which was discussed above. This appears to have developed through contact with Armenian in the north-eastern periphery of NENA and subsequently diffused into south-eastern Turkey and northern Iraq. It is found in NENA dialects on the Mosul plain as far south as Karamlesh (Borghero 2008: 82-83) but not in the dialects in the geographically adjacent villages of Qaraqosh (Khan 2002a) and Barəṭle (al-Saka 2024). The NENA speakers in Karamlesh belong to the Chaldean Catholic denomination of Christianity, whereas the community of speakers in Qaraqosh are Syrian Catholic and the community in Barəṭle are Syrian orthodox. Other dialects on the Mosul plain to which the locative infinitive progressive construction has diffused are spoken by Chaldean Catholic communities, e.g., Telkepe and Alqosh. The diffusion appears to have taken place within the Chaldean Catholic social network of villages, but did not diffuse outside of this network to Christian communities of Qaraqosh and Barəṭle.

Social networks also had an impact on internal historical change in NENA dialects that were not induced by contact with other languages of the region. This can be seen again by comparing the Christian dialects of Karamlesh, Qaraqosh and Barəṭle on the Mosul plain. In the imperative and infinitive causative derivational pattern (historical *ʾafʿel* C. Karamlesh has an *m-* prefix, which has been extended to these forms analogically from the present stem (historically an active participle) of this derivational pattern. In C. Qaraqosh and C. Barəṭlə, by contrast, the imperative and infinitive of the causative pattern preserve the archaic form with *m-* prefix:

Table 25.1

	C. Karamlesh	C. Qaraqosh	C. Barəṭle
Present:	*maqṭəl*	*maqṭəl*	*maqṭəl*
Imperative:	*maqṭəl*	*ʾaqṭəl*	*ʾaqṭəl*
Infinitive:	*maqṭolə*	*ʾaqṭolə*	*ʾaqṭolə*

The innovative analogical extension of the *m-* of the present stem to the imper-

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ative and infinitive is found in NENA dialects of other Chaldean communities on the Mosul plain and indeed in all other NENA dialects across the NENA area. The diffusion of this feature to C. Karamlesh was facilitated by the fact that the Christian community of Karamlesh was in the social network of the other Chaldean villages on the Mosul plain. The fact that it was not diffused to C. Qaraqosh and C. Barəṭle can be explained by the fact that the Christian communities of Qaraqosh and Barəṭle were in different social networks due to their different church denomination.

The Jewish Trans-Zab dialects exhibit innovative internal analogical changes that have not occurred in Christian dialects in the same area, thus making them more innovative than Christian dialects both through contact-induced change and through internal analogical change. An example that illustrates this is the levelling of historically final *ʿ verb paradigms with those of final /y/ verbs in Jewish Trans-Zab dialects whereas the historical distinction of the paradigms is preserved in Christian dialects of the same area. This is seen by comparing, for example, C. Koy Sanjak and J. Koy Sanjak (Mutzafi 2004a: 11):

Table 25.2: Final *ʿ and final /y/ in Koy Sanjak NENA dialects

	C. Koy Sanjak	J. Koy Sanjak	
3FS final *ʿ	*šăma*	*šamya*	'she hears'
3FS final /y/	*baxya*	*baxya*	'she weeps'

In addition to boundaries between social networks, there were other factors that blocked contact-induced change in a particular geographical area.

One example is a socially-motivated constraint on lexical transfer from contact languages. This is reflected by the almost total exclusion of Armenian loanwords from NENA. Several cases of convergence between the sound systems and verbal systems of NENA and Armenian can be identified. These convergences arose due to close contact between NENA speakers and Armenian speakers in some areas. This contact was particularly close in the Urmi region in north-western Iran, where there were many intermarriages between the Christian NENA-speaking communities and the Armenian-speaking communities. This contact is reflected by borrowing by in the C. Urmi of some features of Armenian phonology and verbal syntax, but there are virtually no Armenian loanwords in the NENA dialects of the Urmi region and no documented codeswitching. This appears to be the result of a deliberate attempt to mark a boundary between the group identity

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of the NENA-speaking community from that of the Armenian-speaking community. The motivation is the need to preserve NENA group identity in a situation of intimate social connection and cultural homogeneity between the two groups, in which the boundaries between group identities are particularly under threat. No such attempt was made to exclude loanwords from socially more distant groups such as those of speakers of Kurdish or Turkic, who do not constitute a threat to the group identity of NENA speakers (Khan 2016b: vol. 3, 1-10). The replication in NENA of Armenian phonological features and syntactic patterns would have been below speakers' "level of awareness" (cf. Silverstein 1981).

Other factors that constrain convergence with contact languages include the size of the language community and the terrain of its geographical location. Some of the most conservative NENA dialects are those that were spoken by the Christian Ṭyare tribes, who, until 1915, lived in a large group of NENA-speaking villages in the Hakkari mountains of south-eastern Turkey (Gaunt 2006, 414; Talay 2008b, 2008a). The dialects of NENA-speaking communities that were smaller in size have typically converged to a greater extent with languages in contact. As has been remarked, some of the dialects that have undergone the most radical contact-induced linguistic changes are the Jewish Trans-Zab dialects spoken by communities of Jews in north-eastern Iraq and western Iran. All of these communities were small tight social networks embedded within villages or towns where the majority of the population spoke other languages. Many were very small communities, in some cases consisting of only a handful of families in a village, e.g., Dobe, Ruwanduz, Rustaqa (Khan 2002b).

As for terrain, the Hakkari region where the Ṭiyare tribes lived was mountainous, which is likely to have contributed to their geographical isolation from contact languages and also made the networks between the Ṭyare villages looser, resulting in their relative conservatism compared to other NENA dialects. This is exhibited, for example, by their preservation of interdental consonsonants (§2.6). A high density of population of NENA speakers in villages on the Urmi plain in north-western Iran (Gaunt 2006: 417), which were less geographically isolated, did not result in such linguistic conservatism, on account of higher exposure to contact and a geography that was more conducive to tighter networks. The linguistic conservatism of the Ṭyare tribes appears to be the result of a combination of their geographical isolation and their large population of loose networks. This would correspond to the theory of socio-linguists that innovations are diffused less easily in large loosely networked communities than in small tightly networked communities (e.g., Nettle 1999, 139; Trudgill 2009, 102).

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25.4 Overview of matched features in the contact languages

25.4.1 Areal features found across languages

Several features that are innovative developments in NENA dialects are areal features that are common to all or most of the languages that have been studied in this volume.

Clear examples of cross-linguistic areal features include some aspects of the encoding of Tense-Aspect-Mood (TAM) in verbal systems. In particular, most languages express the indicative habitual with a preverbal particle and also have complex verb constructions formed from copulas (§12.5). Most languages, moreover, exhibit some analogical extension of person marking based on inflection of the present stem (§13.5).

The existence of an enclitic copula in NENA is a feature that is shared by other languages in the region.

25.4.2 Iranian languages

Some innovative features of NENA have developed through convergence with features that are common to the Iranian languages of the region.

Some phonological features that are characteristic of the sound systems of various Iranian languages of the region have had an impact on NENA dialects. These include the lack of interdental consonants in Iranian languages, which conditioned their loss in NENA (§2.6). Also, the distribution and properties of pharyngeals in Kurdish, including their instability and the emergence of non-etymological pharyngeals associated with flat resonance, were matched by many NENA dialects (§6.6).

Clear parallels are found between NENA and Iranian languages with respect to the verbal stem and the verbal endings expressing the person, number and gender of the subject and/or object (§12.5). The most noteworthy parallel is the 'oblique' encoding of the agent in past perfective clauses in contrast to present imperfective clauses. Iranian and Aramaic also closely converge in making use of the oblique case or oblique sets of person markers to express experiencer and possessor arguments (§24.6).

Several NENA dialects have developed dedicated object pronouns, which could be partly due to influence from Iranian (see §21.6).

The expression of the past progressive in Jewish Trans-Zab dialects by combining the Kurdish imperfective preverbal prefix *da* with an inflected form of the

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past stem (88, 89) is a replication of the common Kurdish construction for expressing the past imperfective, including the borrowing of the Kurdish particle (§18.2.3, §12.5, §19.1.7).

In NENA, head nouns are generally not connected to an adjectival modifier by a linker particle, in contrast to Iranian languages, in which a head noun is connected to an adjectival modifier by *ezafe*. There are, however, some sporadic examples of linker particles before adjectival modifiers in NENA dialects across the Iranian area (§11.5).

Many NENA dialects express the perfect by a passive/resultative participle combined with the copula. This matches Iranian languages of the area, in which the past stem of the past perfect is a passive/resultative participle in origin and the participle of the perfect is an extended form of this. (§16.6)

The ordering of elements in the clause in several NENA dialects in the eastern sector of NENA has converged with Iranian languages. These include object arguments, goal arguments, the nominal components of light verb constructions, and complements of various types (§23).

25.4.2.1 Northern Kurdish

Various innovative features of NENA dialects in the northern sector can be correlated with features of Northern Kurdish dialects of the region.

Some features of the sound system of Northern Kurdish dialects have been matched by NENA dialects in the northern sector of the NENA area. These include the acquisition of unaspirated unvoiced stops , which, although originating in Armenian, have diffused to NENA through loanwords from Northern Kurdish in some regions (§4.5). Some marginal realisations of lenited **b* as [v] in NENA dialects may be due to matching with the lenition process in Northern Kurdish (§3.5). Also, the fronting of */u/* to */ü/* [y] in the Christian NENA dialects of the Targawar and Margawar region and the associated realisation of */w/* as bilabial ([β], [β̟]) are shared by Behdînî dialects of Northern Kurdish (§3.5).

The development of three sets of demonstratives in NENA dialects in the northern sector of NENA matches the system of three sets (near deixis, far deixis and anaphoric) that is found in Behdînî Northern Kurdish. Moreover, the morphological shape of the forms in NENA and Kurdish are strikingly similar due to an innovative analogical levelling in the stems of the NENA demonstrative pronouns and the development of augments that match those of Kurdish (§10.6).

In NENA dialects in the northern sector, the annexation particle has developed into a suffix, which matches the phonotactics of the Northern Kurdish *ezafe* particle, which also has the status of a suffix (§11.2). In NENA dialects in the northern

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sector, the *-ət* annexation suffix can be detached from the head and placed before the dependent noun (21) or placed before a predicative attribute (23). This matches the pronominal use of *ezafe* as an independent particle in Northern Kurdish (§11.2.1.4). Constructions in NENA dialects with a demonstrative pronoun and linker particle before an adjectival modifier are likely to have developed by convergence with Northern Kurdish constructions with a pronominal *ezafe* before the adjective. Oblique demonstratives in NENA dialects in the northern sector have lost their historical compositionality of annexation particle + demonstrative. They appear to have developed by NENA-internal analogy with the paradigm of the genitive pronoun reinforced by the presence of oblique pronouns in Northern Kurdish (§11.5).

The productive expression of the P argument by a verbal affix on a past stem in NENA dialects in the northern sector matches a similar pattern in the verb morphology of Behdînî dialects of Northern Kurdish (13.5). The 'double oblique' of both the subject and object of past-stem transitive verbs that is found in NENA dialects in the northern sector is matched by corresponding constructions in Northern Kurdish (§13.5). The loss of valency-reducing morphology in verbal derivation in most NENA dialects (i.e., the loss of the earlier Aramaic T-stems) corresponds to a similar loss in Northern Kurdish. The NENA dialects, moreover, exhibit parallels to the various innovative detransitivising strategies of Northern Kurdish (§14.4).

The movement of the copula onto constituents in focus is a feature of NENA dialects in the northern sector of the NENA area. Parallels to this phenomenon are found in Eastern Armenian (§15.4.2) and in Behdînî varieties of Northern Kurdish (§15.2.1), which were in contact with the northern NENA dialects. (§15.6)

Some features of the NENA copula may have developed through matching with the *ezafe* copula of Behdînî dialects of Northern Kurdish, such as the *i* stem of the NENA copula and the apparent origin of the form of the NENA copula as a deictic copula (§15.6).

Sentential demonstratives in NENA, consisting of a demonstrative pronoun and an enclitic copula, have direct parallels in Northern Kurdish (§15.6).

Perfect constructions consisting of a deictic copula + participle match perfect constructions in Behdînî varieties of Northern Kurdish in which the *ezafe* copula is preposed before a participle, either as an independent prosodic word or as an enclitic on a preceding subject argument (§16.2.2.2; §16.6).

The *ʾi-/y-* prefix of the present stem of NENA dialects could have matched the pronominal *ezafe* particle in Behdînî Northern Kurdish progressives formed with the *ezafe* (§19.2.1.1, §19.6).

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The NENA future construction with the prefixed particle *bəd* (and phonetic variants) in the northern sector and its incompatibility with negation match the future constructions with preverbal particles in Northern Kurdish (§17.6).

The discourse-dependent habitual construction in NENA that is formed from the future-marking prefix (*bəd* or phonetic variants) (§18.1.6) matches the use of the future form as a discourse-dependent habitual in Behdînî dialects of Northern Kurdish (§18.2.5).

Northern Kurdish syntax almost certainly served as a model for the sporadic cases of genitive possessive constructions in NENA in the western periphery, in dialects such as C. Bohtan and C. Hertevin, where the predicative possessor is encoded as an adnominal possessor of the possessee NP (§24.6).

25.4.2.2 Central Kurdish

Phonological features of Central Kurdish dialects that have had an impact on NENA include the following. The lenition of */d/* in Central Kurdish dialects in the Zagros region, as well as in neighbouring Southern Kurdish and Gorani dialects appear to have conditioned the shift of **d* to the lateral */l/* in Jewish Trans-Zab NENA dialects (§2.6). In the Urmi region, the advancement of the dorsals **k* and ***gto the postalveolar affricates [tʃ] and [dʒ] and the historical postalveolar affricates **tʃ* and **dʒ* to the alveolar affricates [ts] and [dz] in NENA dialects is matched by Central Kurdish dialects spoken south of the town of Urmi. Such affrication is also found in the NENA dialects of C. Koy Sanjak and C. Shaqlawa before high vowels as in Central Kurdish (§5.5).

In NENA dialects in the Central Kurdish region, the phonotactic status of the annexation particle as an enclitic rather than a suffix matches the enclitic status of the *ezafe* particle in Central Kurdish (§11.2, §11.5). The omission of the annexation particle in the Jewish Trans-Zab NENA dialects in the south-eastern sector matches the omission of the *ezafe* particle in noun phrases in southern Central Kurdish dialects of the region (98, 107a). The restriction of the NENA annexation particle to pronominal heads in the Jewish Trans-Zab dialect of Sulemaniyya matches the restrictive distribution of the *ezafe* in the Central Kurdish dialect of Sulemaniyya (§11.5). The substitution of the annexation particle by a preposition in predicative possession constructions in NENA dialects in the south-eastern sector corresponds to the replacement of the *ezafe* by a particle of a similar phonetic shape to the NENA preposition in Central Kurdish of the region (§11.5).

The order of the pronominal argument affixes P-A in NENA past-stem verbs corresponds to the preferred order of these pronominal arguments in southern varieties of Central Kurdish (13.5). The "double oblique" encoding of A and P in

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the past stem verbal forms in Trans-Zab Jewish NENA varieties corresponds to the 'double oblique' clitics found in Central Kurdish dialects of Iranian Kurdistan and peripheral Gorani dialects (13.5).

The complete levelling of inflection of the present copula with verbal inflection that is found in NENA dialects on the eastern periphery of the NENA area, such as J. Sanandaj, matches the profile of the copula in Central Kurdish (§15.6). The lack of movement of the copula in NENA dialects of the southern sector, including Jewish Trans-Zab dialects, corresponds to the lack of its movement in Central Kurdish (§15.6).

The invariable deictic copulas of the NENA dialects of the south-eastern sector are likely to have developed by convergence with the pattern of the deictic copulas of Central Kurdish and Gorani (§15.2.3). A further feature of Central Kurdish that may have stimulated the development of invariable copulas in south-eastern NENA dialects is the use of an invariable form of the 3SG enclitic copula *=e* on perfect verbal constructions (67, 68, 70, §15.6).

The expression of the progressive by a complex structure of an infinitive and copula in J. Sulemaniyya (40) is likely to be based on the model of a progressive construction consisting of the locative circumposition *le=…=da* combined with the infinitive, which is found in the Central Kurdish dialect of Sulemaniyya (§19.2.1.3.31).

25.4.2.3 Gorani

Correlations with features in Gorani have been identified in NENA dialects that were spoken in modern times across a wider geographical area than the current speech zones of Gorani. This applies in particular to the Jewish Trans-Zab dialects.

Features of phonology that match Gorani include the following. The lenition of **d* in the Zagros region, which conditioned the development of **d* > */l/* in Jewish Trans-Zab NENA dialects is a characteristic of Gorani dialects (§2.3). The realisations of */w/* in the Jewish Trans-Zab dialects as a labio-dental is likely to have arisen through matching the sound system of Gorani, which exhibits labio-dental pronunciation of the corresponding phoneme (§3.5).

The presence of a */y/* or */i/* element in the stem of near demonstrative forms in NENA dialects in the south-eastern sector may have been reinforced by contact with Gorani, in which the stem of near deixis demonstratives contains an */i/* element (§10.6).

Use of oblique demonstrative pronouns in the Jewish Trans-Zab dialects in the south-eastern sector is likely to have been conditioned or reinforced by contact

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with Gorani, which preserves oblique third person pronouns, whereas these have been lost in southern Central Kurdish dialects.

There are a number of parallels in the morpho-syntax of the NENA verbal system and that of Gorani. The tense-aspectual inversion of role marking in NENA transitive clauses corresponds closely to what is found in conservative Gorani dialects (§13.5) but differs from Kurdish. The person marking of P in past-stem verbs with zero for the 3SG.M in NENA dialects has parallels in Gorani dialects (§13.5). There are parallels between the distribution of the past converter affix *-wa* that is added to present stems in NENA and the past converter affix *-ên* in Gorani (§12.5). In copula-based transitive perfect verbal constructions, there is a direct correspondence between the copula syntax in south-eastern Trans-Zab Jewish dialects of NENA and that in Gorani (13.5). The 'double oblique' encoding of A and P in the past stem verbal forms in Trans-Zab Jewish NENA varieties corresponds to the 'double oblique' clitics found in peripheral Gorani dialects (13.5). In Gorani dialects outside the Hawraman region, such as Bajalani of the Mosul region and Bajalani of the Qasre-Shirin region, the oblique A-past clitics have been extended to intransitive S-past, which parallels the uniform syntax of 'oblique' L-suffixes as S-past and A-past indexes across NENA dialects. (13.5).

There are structural parallels between the stem and inflection of the NENA copula and those of the Gorani copula (§15.6).

The invariable deictic copulas of the NENA dialects of the south-eastern sector are likely to have developed by convergence with the pattern of the deictic copula in Gorani with the stem *îna* respectively (§15.2.3). The shift of an original *l* to *n* in several such NENA invariable copulas may have arisen by convergence with the phonetic shape of the stem of the Gorani deictic copula *îna* (§15.6).

The advanced degree of attrition of the preverbal particles in NENA dialects in the eastern sector, especially in the Jewish Trans-Zab dialects, may have been induced by the patterns of attrition in Gorani (for a recent study of the development of Gorani pre-verbal particles, see Mohammadirad & Karim 2025). In Gorani the past habitual does not have a preverbal particle. This phenomenon is attested in some NENA dialects and could be an archaism, possibly matching Gorani (§18.8).

In the Jewish Trans-Zab dialects in western Iran, progressive constructions are used that appear to be modelled on Gorani (§19.6).

Some NENA dialects exhibit patterns of flagging of A-past that resemble those of Gorani (§21.6).

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25.4.2.4 Zazaki

A number of features of NENA have close parallels in Zazaki. Several of these are in deictic elements.

The intensifying near deixis augment in NENA dialects on the Mosul plain with form of a */y/* or */i/* element has a parallel in Zazaki (in its variant form */e/* (§10.6).

In NENA dialects of the northern sector, the common form of the deictic copula *hole* (3SG.M) (< **hā-ʾaw* 'look (at) that') may be compared to deictic copulas with the element *ha* in Zazaki, which in the 3SG combine with the enclitic copula *-o*, resulting in the form *ho* (93). The NENA form *hole* may have been originally deictic *ho-* + object L-suffix, but it came to be reanalysed as a merger of *ho* + enclitic copula *ile*. A close parallel to this is found in Zazaki sentential demonstratives, which have the form *ha-wo*/*ho=yo* 'there he is' (95). The Zazaki construction also resembles the phonetic shape of the NENA form.

The prefixed augments of the NENA present stem *qaṭəl* that have the form *k-* or *ʾi-*/*y-* and are derived historically from a presentative particle (*k-* < *kā*) and the copula (*ʾi*) respectively, have parallels in Zazaki, which expresses the progressive with a construction consisting of the present stem combined with the copula, in some cases preceded by a presentative particle (§19.2.2). Moreover, in Zazaki the copula in progressive constructions is inflected as is the copula in innovative 'second cycle' progressive constructions with an inflected deictic copula in NENA dialects in the northern sector. The form of the Zazaki third person copula coincides with that of the *ezafe* (Table 19.3). This may have facilitated the development of the copula-like function of the *ezafe* in Behdînî Kurdish (§19.6).

25.4.3 Armenian

Several innovative phonological features of NENA dialects in the northern sector match features in the sound system of Eastern Armenian dialects. The development of the labio-dental fricative reflex [v] of **w* in the Christian dialects of the Urmi region may have been facilitated by the existence of */v/* in Armenian dialects of the region (§3.5). The acquisition of unaspirated unvoiced stop phonemes by NENA dialects in the Urmi region has taken place by matching the sound system of Armenian (§4.5). The tendency of NENA speakers who migrated to Georgia to pronounce unaspirated stops as glottalised is an areal feature shared by Georgian and Armenian in this region. In the northern portion of the Urmi plain the palatalisation of velar dorsals to palatal stops [c] and [ɟ] is matched by the palatalisation process that is found in Armenian dialects of

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this area (§5.3, §5.5). The fronting of the uvular stop */q/* to unaspirated */q̠/* in the NENA dialects of the north-eastern sector may have been facilitated by contact with Armenian (§8.6).

Systems of demonstrative pronouns with three sets of forms, which are found in NENA dialects in the northern sector, have parallels to three-set systems of demonstratives in some Armenian dialects (§10.6). The higher degree of placement of adjectival modifiers before the head noun in NENA in the north-eastern sector than elsewhere may have been facilitated by contact Armenian (11.5.

There are various parallels between NENA and Armenian in verbal morphosyntax. Armenian present-stem verbs with the preverbal particle *kə-* originally expressed the progressive and then were subsequently extended to the expression of the habitual, as happened in the equivalent construction in NENA. In both NENA and Armenian the bare present stem without the preverbal particle came to express the irrealis subjunctive (§18.8). The clearest model for the expression of the progressive by a locative infintive construction in NENA is Eastern Armenian, in which the progressive is expressed by a locative construction. The stem of this may be an imperfective participle (§19.4) or, in some dialects, an infinitive. Armenian dialects in the Urmia area use a fossilised form of the past 3SG copula as an invariable past converter particle that resembles the distribution of the NENA past converter *-wa*, which is likewise a fossilised past copula (§12.5). In most NENA dialects the complex perfect construction must be agent-oriented when the verb is transitive, which parallels the dominant syntax of such constructons in Eastern Armenian dialects (§13.5, §16.6), but differs from Iranian languages in the region. The copula in Eastern Armenian is mobile and moves to salient constituents in a clause, which parallels the mobility of the copula in NENA dialects in the northern sector. The negated copula in Armenian is placed before the predicate, as it is in most NENA dialects (§13.5, §15.6). The use of dedicated independent pronominal objects in NENA dialects of Iran has parallels in Armenian. (§13.5)

The adaptation of a dative case marker in NENA to differentially mark salient objects has a parallel in Eastern Armenian dialects (§21.6).

The use of active participles in NENA dialects in the northern sector and Mosul plain to express a planned, certain future (§17.1.2.1) may be compared to the use of participles to express a certain event in Armenian (§17.4.4, §17.6).

In the C. Urmi NENA dialect on the north-eastern periphery progressive forms derived from a locative infinitive are the normal forms used in narratives. This may have been facilitated by the fact that in most Eastern Armenian dialects the present based on a locative infinitive/participle has become a general present form (expressing habitual and progressive), and, crucially, is frequently used as

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the main narrative verbal form in folktale narratives 20.6, §20.8). The use of the subjunctive in narratives (§20.1.5) in NENA dialects of the northern sector has a parallel in Armenian narratives, notably those from Van and Salmast (Salamas) (§20.8).

The differential flagging of direct objects that is a feature of NENA dialects is found also in many forms of Armenian (§21.6).

25.4.4 Arabic

Several features of the sound systems of Arabic dialects in the region appear to have had a conservative effect on the sound systems of NENA. These include the preservation of interdentals in NENA dialects in the western sector, where many of the Arabic dialects have interdentals in their sound inventories (2.2). The geographical distribution of pharyngeals in NENA dialects corresponds, broadly speaking, to the geographical areas where Arabic dialects are spoken, all of which have pharyngeals in their sound inventories 6.6. The inherited emphatic (pharyngealised) consonant segments of Aramaic have been retained in NENA dialects in Iraq and the north-western sector in Turkey, together with innovative emphatic sonorants, labials and rhotics. A similar range of emphatic consonants are found in adjacent Arabic dialects (§7.6).

A possible other case of Arabic playing a conservative role is the constraint it is likely to have had on the shift to an Iranian type of verb-final syntax in NENA dialects in contact with Arabic (§23.4).

Some Arabic varieties have three sets of demonstratives, which parallel the three-set systems in NENA dialects in the northern sector (§10.6). The */y/* or */i/* demonstrative element that is attested as an intensifying near deixis augment in NENA dialects on the Mosul plain has a parallel in Arabic dialects in the region (§10.6).

The *Qəltu* Arabic dialects have enclitic pronominal copulas rather than verbal copulas (§15.3). This matches the historical origin of NENA copulas as enclitic pronouns (§15.6).

The form of the deictic copula in NENA dialects on the Mosul plain, consisting of the pre-verbal particle *k-* is closely paralleled by Arabic *Qəltu* dialects, which, likewise, form deictic copulas by combining a *k-* particle with the enclitic copula (§15.6).

NENA perfect constructions consisting of an invariable particle and past perfective correspond in structure to perfect constructions in *Qəltu* Arabic dialects (§16.3), in which an invariable particle, possibly a fossilised form of the deictic copula, is placed before the past perfective form (§16.6).

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Qəltu Arabic dialects exhibit progressive forms with a prefixed presentative *kū* (or phonetic variants), but, unlike NENA, this construction was not extended to express the habitual, which is expressed by the present stem without a prefix (§18.5, §18.8).

The lack of DOI (Differential Object Indexing) in some NENA dialects on the Mosul Plain may be due to convergence with Arabic, where it is also lacking (§21.6).

25.4.5 Turkic

The sound system of Turkic in the Urmi region is likely to have some impact on the NENA dialects in contact with it. The realisation of **w* as */v/* of NENA dialects of the region matches the existence of /v/ in Turkic as well as by Armenian (§3.5). It is possible that the affrication of dorsals in NENA dialects in the sourthern Urmi region was reinforced by contact with Azeri Turkic (§5.5). In some village dialects of southern C. Urmi and also in J. Urmi a front-back harmonic distinction is extended to the */u/* and */o/* vowels, which are noticeably fronted in plain words. This would represent a convergence with Turkic. Contact with Turkic does not, however, seem to have played a central role in inducing the phenomenon of suprasegmental pharyngealisation in NENA dialects of the north-eastern NENA sector (7.6).

The greater frequency of placing adjectival modifiers before the head noun in NENA dialects in the north-eastern sector may have been facilitated by contact with Turkic as well as Armenian, since in Turkic, as in Armenian, the placement of an adjective before the noun is the norm (11.5.

In Azeri Turkic in the Urmi region the progressive form *gedir* ('he is coming') is commonly used to narrate events in folktales. This may have been one of the models for the use in narratives the C. Urmi NENA dialect of the locative infinitive construction, which otherwise normally expresses the progressive (§20.8).

Differential Object Flagging (DOF), which is a feature of many NENA dialects has parallels in Turkic (§21.6).

25.4.6 Comments

One particularly striking fact that emerges from this overview is the deep influence that Armenian and Gorani have had on many central structures of NENA, although in modern times NENA has had only marginal contact with these languages. Also there are a few surprising parallels between innovative NENA features and Zazaki, although in modern times Zazaki has not been in contact with

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NENA. A variety of explanations could be offered for this situation. The areas of overlap of the speech zones of NENA, Armenian, Gorani and Zazaki may have changed diachronically. We know this to be the case for Gorani, which, before the twentieth century, was spoken in a much wider area in the region than it is today (Khan & Mohammadirad 2024b). Features of Armenian and Gorani on the periphery of NENA may have diffused across NENA in areas where there was no direct contact between NENA and these languages. There may have been indirect contact, whereby another language with a different geographical speech zone, overlapped with the source contact language and NENA. This was the case with Northern Kurdish, which in some features, notably unaspirated stops, appears to bridge between Armenian and NENA. Likewise, Northern Kurdish may have been a bridge between Zazaki and NENA. In the southern sector of NENA some features originating in Gorani may have been transmitted to NENA through Central Kurdish, which historically had a Gorani substrate. In such a situation as the latter, however, the historical layering of contact-induced change was complex. This is because NENA dialects that have been in contact with Central Kurdish in modern times exhibit both features that match the Gorani substrate of Central Kurdish and also features that match the Central Kurdish substrate rather than Gorani.

The overview also shows that there are correlations between features of contact-induced change in NENA in particular geographical areas and the geographical areas of contact languages. As has already been discussed, however, this correlation was in some cases skewed by migrations, diffusion and language shifts.

25.5 Processes of contact-induced change

In this section we shall summarise the type of processes that have resulted in contact-induced change in NENA.

25.5.1 Matter borrowing

Matter borrowing (Matras & Sakel 2007; Matras 2009) involves the transfer of lexical, morphological, or phonetic material from external contact languages to NENA. The most common type of matter borrowing is the transfer of lexical items. This volume has not been concerned with loanwords, so our study has not included many cases of matter borrowing. Some of the syntactic constructions that we have investigated, however, involve the matter borrowing of grammatical particles. For example, when the head of a relative clause is a full noun in J.

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Sulemaniyya NENA, an Iranian relative particle *ka/ga* is used (11.5). The Kurdish-Gorani preposition *bo/ba* 'to, for, because of' was borrowed by NENA dialects to form new dative case-markers (§9.6). The past progressive in Jewish Trans-Zab dialects is formed by the borrowing of the Kurdish imperfective preverbal prefix *da*, which is combined with an inflected form of the NENA past stem (88, 89, §12.5, §19.1.7).

25.5.2 Pattern replication

This process involves the replication by NENA dialects of patterns in the external source language(s) with internal morphological material. The vast majority of the processes of contact-induced change that have been discussed in the chapters can be categorised generically as pattern replication. We can identify, however, numerous variations and subtypes of pattern replication.

25.5.2.1 Matching of phonetic shape

In a number of cases NENA dialects replicate the pattern of a structure in a contact language with internal morphological material that matches the phonetic form of a structure in the source language. Although the outcome of this process resembles that of matter borrowing, it should be classified as pattern replication. Examples of this that have been discussed in the previous chapters include the following.

The innovative developments of demonstratives into three sets in NENA dialects in the northern sector of NENA match the system of three sets (near deixis, far deixis and anaphoric) that is found in Behdînî Kurdish. Moreover, there is a striking similarity in the morphological shape of the forms in NENA and Kurdish. The morphological components of the NENA forms are of Aramaic heritage, but have been reshaped to resemble the Kurdish forms (§10.6).

The */y/* or */i/* element in the stem of near demonstrative forms in NENA dialects in the south-eastern sector has an Aramaic etymology but its presence may have been reinforced by imitation of the stem of the near demonstratives of Hewramî, the stem of which contains an */i/* element (see Table 10.5; §10.6).

In several Jewish Trans-Zab dialects, a particle resembling the shape of Iranian *ezafe* particles is used in place of, or in combination with, the regular NENA annexation particle. These are unlikely to be loans of Iranian *ezafe* morphology. Rather, they are original NENA demonstrative elements that have developed by matching the form and syntax of the Iranian *ezafe*.

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In NENA dialects in the south-eastern sector, a predicative possessor is introduced by the preposition *ʾəl* 'to' (or phonetic variants thereof) rather than the annexation particle (104, 116, 122a). In C. Sulemaniyya, the equivalent particle has the form *hən* or *hi* (52). This is phonetically similar to a particle that is used for the same purpose before predicative possessors in Central Kurdish of the region. It is likely that the form of the NENA particle in C. Sulemaniyya is the result of an internal phonetic reshaping based on the model of Kurdish rather than a matter borrowing from Kurdish. (11.5)

The development of the invariable deictic copula in some NENA dialects of the south-eastern sector into a form with initial *n*-with , e.g., *nā* (J. Dobe, J. Hiza), *na* (C. Aqra, C. Shaqlawa), may have developed by convergence with the phonetic shape of the stem of the Gorani deictic copula *îna* (§15.6).

The expression of the future in NENA dialects of the northern sector by the future particle *bəd* replicates the pattern of future constructions in Northern Kurdish with the future particle *dê*. The NENA particle is frequently reduced phonetically to the form *d-* or *t-* and this produces a phonetic shape that is closer to that of the Kurdish particle. The NENA future particle *bəd* is also phonetically very close or identical to that found in many Western Armenian dialects, such as Mush *bidi*. The particle is reduced to *t* (with initial devoicing) in many Armenian dialects including Van and Urmia (§17.6).

The NENA particle *k-* that is prefixed to present-stem verbs has an Aramaic etymology, but it resembles the phonetic shape of the equivalent preverbal particles in Armenian (*kə-*) and *Qəltu* Arabic (*kū*) (§18.8).

The *ʾi-/y-* prefix of the present stem of NENA dialects in the northern sector matches the phonetic shape of the *ezafe* particle in Behdînî Northern Kurdish progressive constructions (§19.6).

The deictic copula *ho=le* that is used in progressive constructions in many NENA dialects in the northern sector resembles the phonetic shape of the corresponding deictic copula that is used in progressive constructions in Zazaki (§19.6).

25.5.2.2 Matching of phonemes

Within the broad category of pattern replication can be included the phenomenon of replication of phonemes. The process involves the perceptual matching by NENA speakers of a phoneme in their language with a phoneme that is perceived to be similar in a contact language, even if not objectively identical. This often results in a NENA sound imperfectly replicating a sound in the contact language or, vice versa, the shift in properties of a sound in a NENA dialect

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to bring it closer to the properties of the perceptually matched sound in the contact language. This process in contact phonology has been described by (Blevins 2017) as the 'perceptual magnet effect'. Some examples of this are as follows.

Lenition of a *d* in Jewish Trans-Zab NENA dialects to */l/* can be identified as the reflection of the areal feature of lenition of *d* in the Zagros region. The weakened *d* in languages in this region is matched perceptually by NENA speakers with the sonorant */l/* in their existing sound inventory. Since the more common reflex of lenition of */d/* in Iranian contact languages in the Zagros region is debuccalisation rather than a sonorant, it is likely that the sonorant reflex */l/* of Jewish Trans-Zab NENA is not a direct replication of Iranian but an imperfect replication using a perceptually similar sound within the NENA sound inventory (§2.6).

The labio-dental fricative reflex [v] in the Christian dialects of the Urmi region is likely to have developed due to contact with Armenian and Azeri Turkic dialects in this region, which have */v/* in their sound inventories. This would have developed by a process of perceptual matching of NENA /w/ with /v/ (§3.5).

Pharyngeal consonants are inherited sounds in the sound systems of NENA dialects and pharyngeals in Iranian languages in the area have their origin in Semitic (Aramaic or Arabic). Pharyngeals in NENA, however, exhibit some innovative properties that have arisen by the perceptual matching of the NENA pharyngeals with the pharyngeals in Iranian together with their properties. For example, variation in the voicing of pharyngeals that is attested across Kurdish dialects (see 6.3.1, is also found in NENA (see example 19). Instability of pharyngeals involving phonetic interchange between etymological pharyngeals and laryngeals, and vice versa, which is a feature of Kurdish, is attested within individual Jewish Trans-Zab dialects of NENA, e.g., examples (25) and (26) (§6.6). Also the occurrence of non-etymological pharyngeals in some NENA dialects reflecting flat resonance has arisen by matching the distribution of pharyngeals in Kurdish, which exhibits the occurrence of non-etymological pharyngeals under such conditions (§7.6).

NENA dialects do not exhibit the same degree of variation of the occurrence of unaspirated consonants in specific lexical items across the dialects as is found in Northern Kurdish (§4.2.1). What does vary across dialects in NENA, however, is the distribution of suprasegmental pharyngealisation in the lexicon (see, e.g., 16). It is possible that this reflects a perceptual matching between the articulatory gestures of suprasegemental pharyngealisation and those of unaspirated stops.

A related process of change within the phonological systems of NENA dialects involves the perceptual matching of NENA phonemes with phonemes in a contact language and the extension in NENA of a property of the matched phoneme

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in the contact language. Examples of this include the following. In some Christian NENA, outside of the area of Kurdish affrication, in Targawar (§5.1.1.2), Baz (§5.1.1.3) and Hakkari (§5.1.1.6 in south-eastern Turkey, there is affrication of dorsals in a specific set of lexical items, which is remarkably stable across these dialects. In the Northern Kurdish dialects of these areas there is no affrication, though dorsals may develop a palatal offglide by a process of palatalisation. It appears that affrication in these NENA dialects is an internal development, catalysed by palatalisation in Northern Kurdish. The process would have involved the perceptual matching of NENA dorsals with palatalised dorsals in Kurdish and the extension of the palatalisation to affrication internally within NENA. The further fronting of unaspirated post-velar /k̟/ in NENA dialects in the Baz region to the unaspirated affricate [ʧ] appears to be an internal development of these NENA dialects, since it does not have a specific parallel in other languages of the region. It may, however, have been indirectly facilitated by the general process of palatalisation of dorsals in Northern Kurdish, in that it was an internal extension of this process, as was the case with the affrication of dorsals in the NENA dialects of this region. There are no clear parallels in Kurdish to the affrication of alveolar *t and *d to /ʧ/ and /ʤ/ before high vowels in the NENA dialect of C. Bədyal (Barzan region). It is likely that this too was an internal development involving an extension of the process of palatalisation of dorsals in Northern Kurdish (5.5).

Another case of this phenomenon is the extension of the distribution of unaspirated stops in NENA dialects compared to their distribution in Northern Kurdish (§4.5).

25.5.2.3 Complete replication of structural patterns

Some cases of replication by NENA of syntactic or morphosyntactic patterns in contact languages can be classified as complete replication, in that the innovative structure in the NENA dialects in question correspond exactly to the pattern of those in the contact language. An example of this is replication of the default verb-final clausal syntax of Iranian by Jewish Trans-Zab NENA dialects and some Christian NENA dialects in the south-eastern sector (§23.4).

25.5.2.4 Incomplete replication of structural patterns

More frequently, however, replication of syntactic or morphosyntactic patterns is incomplete. This is due to various factors, including blocking factors internal to the morphosyntactic system of NENA, a preference for matching of discrete words rather than bound morphemes, imperfect matching and the overlay of

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influences of different contact languages. Such incomplete replication can be explained by the theory of "pivot matching" (cf. Matras & Sakel 2007; Matras 2009), whereby speakers identify a shared feature of a particular construction across the two languages and this facilitates the construction in the two languages being matched. This is similar to Blevin's (2017) theory of matching of phonemes by the "perceptual magnet effect." Incomplete replication can also be regarded as manifestations of "linguistic compromise" and "accommodation", which have been identified as features of contact-induced changed (Friedman & Joseph 2025: 112; Trudgill 1986).

The NENA annexation particle has converged with some aspects of phonotactic and prosodic patterns of the Kurdish *ezafe* linker particle. In most NENA dialects, however, the annexation particle does not completely match the distribution of the *ezafe*, in particular since, with some exceptions, it is not used to link a head noun to an adjective. Moreover, the NENA annexation particle that is suffixed to the head noun does not inflect for gender and number, unlike the *ezafe* in Northern Kurdish, which exhibits such inflection (11.5). Phonotactic and prosodic convergence did not entail a different distribution of the particle from its inherited distribution in Aramaic or a change in its morphological inflection, so this type of convergence was less constrained than convergence in distribution and inflection.

In copula-based transitive perfect constructions, there is a correspondence between the copula syntax in south-eastern Trans-Zab Jewish dialects of NENA and that in Gorani, which parallels the past stem verbal inflection (Khan & Mohammadirad 2024b: 194–202). In both language groups, the perfect is formed on the basis of the copula and a participle, which jointly express S and P. The convergence, however, remains partial in terms of person constraints and agent marking (13.5). In the transitive indicative present perfect, for example, the NENA dialects in question do not have an oblique subject index in the perfect corresponding to the oblique subject clitics of Gorani. The cause of the lack of correspondence in subject indexing is internal to NENA. The use of oblique L-suffixes to mark the subject would have created an inflection identical to the past copula, thus confusing the construction with a past perfect. In order to avoid this ambiguity, the use of the L-suffix subject index has been blocked. This has had the consequence of restricting the transitive perfect construction based on resultative participles to third person subjects. Zero-marking of third person subjects is tolerated but not of first and second person subjects. This, therefore, has resulted in a further difference from the Iranian model, which uses the transitive perfect with subjects of all persons.

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In NENA and Iranian the agent in past perfective clauses is encoded as 'oblique'. The oblique, however, is not in the same position in Iranian (§12.5). In NENA the oblique agent-indexing oblique L-suffix is obligatorily placed immediately after the verbal stem. This arises from the greater prosodic bonding of the A-indexing L-suffix to the verbal stem than the A-indexing oblique Iranian clitics.

In the eastern sector, the 'double oblique' clitics found in Central Kurdish dialects of Iranian Kurdistan and peripheral Gorani dialects correspond to the 'oblique' L-suffixes combined with the phonetically reduced LL-series in the past stem verbal forms in the local Trans-Zab Jewish NENA varieties. The order of A and P, however, are different (13.5). This again has arisen due to the different prosodic status of NENA oblique A-indexing L-suffixes from that of the corresponding Iranian oblique elements.

NENA perfect constructions in dialects in the northern sector with a preposed deictic copula correspond to the pattern of perfect constructions formed from the *ezafe* in Northern Kurdish in the region. There are differences, however, in inflection. In NENA, the deictic copula is inflected for person, number and gender. In Kurdish, however, the *ezafe* particles inflect for number and gender, but not for person. There are also differences in alignment between the NENA and Kurdish constructions (§16.6). This reflects a preference for matching of discrete words rather than bound morphemes, since the slot of the *ezafe* particle in the Kurdish *ezafe* perfect construction is matched by the NENA deictic copula, but not the bound inflectional elements.

Another case of incomplete replication is that of the discourse-dependent habitual construction in NENA that is formed by the future-marking prefix (*bəd*) (§18.1.6). This construction is a replication of the future form that is used as a discourse-dependent habitual in Behdînî dialects of Northern Kurdish (§18.2.5). In NENA, the past form of such discourse-dependent habitual constructions is formed by adding the past converter suffix *-wa* to the verb. In Behdînî, on the other hand, the past discourse-dependent habitual is not formed by adding a past shifting suffix, but rather by using a different future preverbal particle, viz. *dê* (present) vs *da* (past). The NENA construction, therefore, is the result of only partial convergence with the Behdînî Kurdish model (§18.8). Again, this reflects a preference for matching of discrete words rather than bound inflection.

NENA demonstrative systems have undergone change through matching the pattern, and in some cases also the phonetic shape, of Kurdish demonstrative systems. In Kurdish the vocalic ending or augment of the independent forms of demonstrative pronouns is detached from the stem of forms in the adnominal forms and attached to the end of the modified noun. In NENA dialects, by

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contrast, this feature is not replicated. Only the form of the independent demonstrative is replicated and this is used also in an adnominal function (§10.6). The process, therefore, is incomplete replication, whereby only the pattern of the unbound form of the Kurdish demonstratives have been replicated.

Another type of partial replication is seen in the progressive construction k-xole k-xəl 'He is eating' (24). This replicates the pattern of a progressive construction in Gorani in which an inflected realis form is preceded by a form composed of the present stem and the ending *-ay* (§19.2.3). Such a form is not the same form as the infinitive, but its ending resembles that of Gorani infinitives, which end in *-āy* or *-ay*. This can be identified, therefore, as a case of imperfect matching, in that the Iranian form has been matched with the inherited NENA infinitive in the progressive construction. This is similar to the process in contact phonology described by Blevins (2017) as the 1perceptual magnet effect', whereby speakers of a language match a sound in their L1 with a sound that is perceived to be similar, even if not objectively identical.

An example of incomplete replication conditioned by the overlay of influence from more than one contact language is the expression of pronominal objects in past-stem verbs in NENA dialects in the south-eastern sector. The NENA dialects of this region, which were historically in contact with Gorani, match the Gorani pattern of expression of pronominal objects ergatively by direct suffixes on past stem verbs. The Central Kurdish of the region does not express objects ergatively. In the NENA dialects, however, the replication of the Gorani pattern is not complete, since the expression of the object by the direct suffixes is restricted to the third person. In this case the restriction of the replication is likely to have had an external factor, namely the impact of Kurdish overlaying the Gorani pattern. Ergativity has decayed in the Central Kurdish of the region. This has resulted in partial decay in NENA with the marking of the first and second person objects by direct suffixes being eliminated. Another factor in this process, impacting on both Kurdish and NENA, may have been the greater markedness, i.e., difficulty of learning, of first and second person objects expressed by direct suffixes (Khan 2017a: 880; Thomason 2010: 43).

We may include in the category of incomplete replication the replication of a structure but the lack of replication of a typologically associated structure. An example of this is the fact that NENA dialects that replicate verb-final clausal syntax of contact languages have not replicated systems of postpositions that are also found in the contact languages and are typologically associated with verb-final syntax (§23.4).

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25.5.2.5 Differences in distribution of replicated structures

In some cases the distribution of a replicated structure is more restricted than it is in the contact language.

The various verbal forms that are used in NENA dialects to narrate sequences of events all have parallels in narrative strategies of the languages of the region. The distribution of these various types of verbal forms differs across the NENA dialects and, moreover, their distribution in contact languages in a particular geographical area sometimes differs from what is found in the NENA dialects of the area (§20.8).

Differential Object Flagging (DOF) expressed by means of a dative case marker has parallels in Eastern Armenian. The distribution and conditions for DOF in NENA and Eastern Armenian, however, are different. In NENA DOF is contextually motivated whereas in Standard Eastern Armenian it is motivated by the inherent properties of the object argument (§21.6), although in some Armenian dialects, including those of the Urmia area, DOF shows some sensitivity to discourse properties.

Perfect and progressive constructions with preposed deictic copulas in NENA dialects of the northern sector replicate corresponding structures in Northern Kurdish with a preposed *ezafe* copula. In Kurdish such constructions are not used in questions. In some NENA dialects, however, through internal extension, the preposed deictic copulas are used in perfect and progressive constructions also in questions (§16.6).

25.5.2.6 Functional difference of a replicated pattern

In a number of cases the form of a pattern in a contact language is replicated in NENA but the function of the pattern in NENA is different from its function in the source language. Some examples of this are as follows.

NENA dialects of the northern sector replicate the three-set system of demonstratives that is found in Behdînî Kurdish and other contact languages. Despite this structural convergence of the demonstrative systems, the pragmatic function of the various sets of demonstratives across the languages does not coincide exactly with NENA dialects (§10.6).

In Northern Kurdish, the pronominal *ezafe* is the norm after complex noun phrases. This structure is replicated by NENA dialects but in NENA it is used more restrictedly to give focus to the adjective, typically contrastive focus. Non-contrastive adjectives are placed immediately after the head noun. The NENA dialects, therefore, have used the Kurdish model of pronominal *ezafe* after complex

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noun phrases to express an internal functional distinction between contrastive and non-contrastive adjectives (11.5).

The placement of adjectival modifiers before the head noun in NENA to express evaluative attributes or focused attributes is a sporadic feature that is found in dialects of the northern sector (124, 125). It is most common in dialects of the north-eastern sector, such as C. Urmi. This may have been facilitated in NENA in that region due to its contact with Armenian and Turkic, in both of which the placement of an adjective before the noun is the norm (for Armenian see §11.4.1). Again, therefore, NENA may have replicated the form of the construction in contact languages to serve a specific functional purpose within NENA, thus enriching its strategies of expression of pragmatic distinctions. (11.5

The expression of the past progressive in Jewish Trans-Zab dialects by combining the Kurdish imperfective preverbal prefix *da* with an inflected form of the past stem (88, 89) is a replication of the common Kurdish construction for expressing the past imperfective, including the borrowing of the Kurdish particle (§18.2.3). In NENA, however, the construction is used only for the past progressive, since this cannot be expressed by another construction, whereas in Kurdish it is used for the past habitual and the past progressive (§19.1.7).

In some NENA dialects, notably C. Urmi, the placement of the verb after objects, which is the default pattern in contact languages of the region, has resulted in an increased degree of fronting of objects, but the fronting has a marked pragmatic function (§23.4).

25.5.2.7 Two cycles of pattern replication

Pattern replication may be repeated, resulting in two cycles of replication. An example of this is the development of pre-verbal augments in NENA dialects. The patterns of constructions used to express the progressive in the languages in contact with NENA were replicated twice, in two cycles, in the form of preverbal augments in NENA. The older cycle became grammaticalised and the replicated progressive construction was extended to the habitual. A new progressive was subsequently development by applying a second cycle of replication of the progressive construction in the contact language, which was less grammaticalised (§19.6).

25.5.2.8 Pattern replication reflects the interpretation of function

A replication by NENA of a pattern in a contact language reflects the way in which NENA speakers interpreted the grammatical function of the pattern in the

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contact language. This is particularly insightful in cases where the grammatical category of constructions in the contact language is opaque or has undergone change. An example of this is the replication by several Jewish Trans-Zab NENA dialects of the Iranian *ezafe* particle by a NENA demonstrative element (§11.5). Another case is the replication of the Northern Kurdish *ezafe* copula and the *ezafe* in perfect and progressive constructions (§15.2.5, §16.6, §19.6) by the NENA copula, reflecting the interpretation of the *ezafe* in such constructions as a copula rather than as a relative in this construction.

25.5.3 Simplification

Some changes that have been induced by contact have resulted in simplification. Examples of this include various cases where historical distinctions have been lost. These include the loss of interdental consonants in many NENA dialects and their merger with other consonants, thus reducing the consonant inventory and assimilating it to that of a contact language (§2.6), the loss of gender in third person singular pronouns in Jewish Trans-Zab dialects (§10.1), and the loss of valency-reducing morphology in verbal derivation (§14.4).

25.5.4 Enrichment

By contrast, numerous innovative developments induced by contact have enriched the expression of functions in NENA dialects, thereby introducing complexification. Some examples of this are as follows.

The acquisition of unaspirated stop and affricate phonemes in NENA dialects of the north-eastern sector (§4.1) led to an enrichment of their sound systems, in that they were exploited to perform functional purposes such as sound symbolism (Khan 2022a).

The various distinct expressions of the perfect contrasting with the perfective and distinct expressions of the progressive contrasting with the habitual have developed by replication of patterns in contact languages and enriched the expression of TAM distinctions.

The expression of the past progressive in Jewish Trans-Zab dialects by combining the Kurdish imperfective preverbal prefix *da* with an inflected form of the past stem (88, 89) is a replication of the common Kurdish construction for expressing the past imperfective, including the borrowing of the Kurdish particle (§18.2.3). In NENA the form is used only for the past progressive, whereas in Kurdish it is used for the past habitual and the past progressive. In the NENA dialects in question, there is no other dedicated construction for the past progressive, so

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the replication of the Kurdish construction had the motivation to fill this specific gap (§19.6).

25.5.5 Grammaticalisation

In some cases of contact-induced change a NENA construction has undergone grammaticalisation, involving loss of inflection, semantic bleaching and prosodic bonding, tht matches a grammaticalised element in a contact language.

An example of this is the NENA future construction with the prefixed uninflected particle *bəd* (and phonetic variants), which matches preverbal future particles in Northern Kurdish (§17.6). The NENA particle has evolved by a process of grammaticalisation of a finite form of the verb 'to want'. This matches a similar grammaticalisation of the corresponding verb in Kurdish that gave rise to the Kurdish particle. Contact, therefore, has induced grammaticalisation (cf. Heine & Kuteva 2005).

Another case is the grammaticalisation of the copula in the form of the uninflected prefix *ʾi-* in NENA progressive/habitual constructions. This grammaticalisation has been induced by convergence with uninflected particles with similar functions in contact languages (§19.6).

25.5.6 Multiple causation

In some cases contact-induced change in NENA has been conditioned by a variety of different factors. The cumulative result of this, therefore, can be said to have arisen by multiple causation. These multiple factors may be features across a variety of external contact languages or many be a combination of internal and external factors.

An example of multiple external factors is the palatisation and affrication of dorsals in the varieties of C. Urmi NENA. The geographical distribution of palatalisation and affrication in C. Urmi varieties exhibits close parallels to the geographical distribution in Kurdish dialects, in that it is a feature of NENA varieties and Central Kurdish dialects spoken south of the town of Urmi. It appears, however, that the affrication in NENA dialects in the southern Urmi region was reinforced by contact with Azeri. This is because in southern C. Urmi NENA and Azeri the affrication occurs in all phonetic contexts, whereas in Kurdish dialects of the region it seems to be largely restricted to occurrence after front vowels (§5.5).

The development of suprasegmental pharyngealisation in NENA dialects and the suprasegmental opposition between back and front vowels in the north-eastern sector appears to have been induced by convergence with a range of

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features in different contact languages of the region, including suprasegmental pharyngealisation in Kurdish, the matching of pharyngeal segments in Kurdish with flat resonance, word-level harmony of front vowels in Armenian, and the acquisition of the unaspirated stop /t̰/ from Armenian and Northern Kurdish (§7.6).

The fronting of /q/ to /k̰/ in NENA dialects in the north-eastern sector was facilitated by the palatalisation of dorsal stops, which was induced by contact with Kurdish and Turkic varieties in the region. Another facilitating factor, however, is likely to have been that the segment *q has lost its emphatic feature in NENA dialects in this region due to the development of suprasegmental pharyngealisation (8.6).

The development of oblique demonstratives in NENA can be explained as a replication of the morpho-syntax of Iranian demonstrative systems, which distinguish between nominative and oblique case. There was, however, also an internal cause, namely the analogy with the inherited NENA genitive pronoun (*did-*). This internal analogical process was reinforced by contact with Iranian oblique demonstratives (§11.5).

The preverbal future particle *bəd-*, which is found in NENA dialects of the northern sector, matches the Northern Kurdish future particle *dê*. It is possible, however, that a corresponding future particle in Armenian dialects also played a role in the development of *bəd-*. In many Armenian dialects the future particle *piti*, which is pronounced *bidi* in some dialects, such as Mush, is reduced to particles beginning with unaspirated [t] (§17.4.3), which would match the phonetic shape of the NENA future particle before vowels in NENA dialects in the northern sector, e.g., C. Barwar *t̰-azəl* 'he will go' (5). Furthermore, in Arabic *Qəltu* dialects of the area the future is expressed by similar-sounding preverbal particles, e.g., *tə-* and *də-*, although their origin is from the Arabic subordinator *ḥattā* 'so that' (§17.6).

The NENA perfect construction formed from the past stem inflected with direct suffixes (§16.1.6.3) may have been an internal development in such dialects, whereby the direct suffixes that are the inflection of the present stem have been extended to the past stem to express a present perfect. This development may, however, have been reinforced by matching *Qəltu* Arabic perfects in which the pivot of the construction is the past stem verbal form. Another reinforcing factor may have been the elimination of a structural distinction between the participle and the past stem in some Kurdish dialects in the area of the north-western sector of NENA (83) and in Zazaki (§16.2.4). The NENA constructions in questions are indeed attested in dialects of north-western periphery, such as C. Bohtan, C. Hertevin. It is also, however, attested in intransitive perfects on the north-eastern

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periphery of the Jewish Trans-Zab dialect area (e.g., J. Urmi, J. Rustaqa), which were not in contact with the aforementioned varieties of Iranian, so in this case there does not seem to have been external factors (§16.6).

25.5.7 Directionality of replication

NENA dialects have typically undergone historical change by replicating features in contact languages. There are some cases, however, in which another language may have replicated a NENA feature and so the directionality of the replication is the reverse.

One possible example is the uninflected past converter particle in Armenian, which is a fossilised form of the past verb 'to be'. This is restricted to Armenian dialects where NENA was spoken, e.g., the Urmia area. In NENA, by contrast, the past converter is found across all dialects (§12.5).

Another case in Armenian is the contextual conditioning of Differential Object Flagging (DOF) in Armenian dialects of the Urmia region, which contrasts to the conditioning of DOF elsewhere in Armenian by the inherent meaning of the object. Contextual conditioning of DOF is characteristic of NENA dialects, so the exceptional contextual conditioning in the Armenian dialects in the Urmia could have been the result of Armenian replicating the pattern of NENA DOF (§21.6).

Differential Object Indexing (DOI) is only a marginal feature of Gorani, but is found in the Bajalani variety of Gorani near Mosul. This may have developed by replicating the pattern of DOI in NENA dialects in the region (§21.6).

The overall distribution of Differential Object Indexing in the Jewish dialects of NENA in Iraqi Kurdistan and the local Jewish dialects of *Qəltu* Arabic in the same region is strikingly similar, and goes against the trend among other dialects of Arabic in the region. This most likely points to an Aramaic substrate for these Arabic dialects located in the core of the NENA speaking region and the replication of the NENA pattern (§21.6).

25.6 Metatypy and communal identity

We have seen that NENA has undergone extensive influence from the various contact languages of the region. This has resulted in the replication of patterns in much of the morpho-syntax and syntax and the convergence of the phonological system with that of the contact languages. It also has resulted in the incorporation into NENA of numerous loanwords, especially from Iranian, though this aspect of contact-induced change has not been examined in this volume.

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Such massive change has resulted in a shift in typology of NENA, or metatypy, to use a term coined by (Ross 1996; 2001; 2003). NENA dialects can be said to have acquired their dis-tinctness or 'speciation' (according to the terminology of Mufwene 2001; 2007) through language contact. This shift in typological profile has replaced many of the typological features of historical Aramaic. Some historical distinctions were lost, if there was not a corresponding distinction in contact languages, e.g., the loss of gender in third person singular pronouns in Jewish Trans-Zab dialects (§10.1). NENA dialects have, however, also been enriched with a variety of innovative features and distinctions that did not exist in earlier Aramaic but existed in contact languages, such as a series of unvoiced unaspirated stops that are exploited to express semantic distinctions (§4.1), a wider range of types of deixis in the systems of demonstrative pronouns (§10.1), and various TAM distinctions, such as the distinction between past perfective and perfect (§16.1) and the distinction between habitual and progressive (§19.1). This reflects the fact that language contact can bring about both simplification and complexification (Trudgill 2010: 306; 2011).

The Semitic heritage of NENA is, nevertheless, preserved in the morphology and the inherited elements of the lexicon. This retained inventory of inherited morphemes and lexemes is sufficient to make NENA an emblem of community identity (cf. Matras 2010: 76).

The vast number of Iranian loanwords in NENA (Khan 2017b: 262-268; Khan & Mohammadirad 2024b: 483-509) and also Turkic loanwords in NENA dialects on the north-eastern periphery (Khan 2016b: vol. 3, 1-5) indicates there was no attempt at lexical exclusion. This could be regarded as a reflection of the rapprochement of the community identity of the Jews with that of the surrounding Iranian and Turkic communities or even a mixed identity. A relevant comparison is with Alsatian–French bilinguals in Strasbourg who perceive language mixing and code-switching as a reflection of their community identity and so are more tolerant of borrowing. The speakers of French and Dutch in Brussels, on the other hand, mix their languages much less, since they perceive themselves as distinct communities (Treffers-Daller 1994; 1999). Another case is the mixed language of the second-generation Portuguese in France, know as immigrais, which is regarded by young members of the immigrant community as an emblem of their mixed identity (Gardner-Chloros 2010: 193).

Several cases have been documented of a community consciously excluding loanwords from a language in contact for the sake of maintaining a distinct community identity. It was suggested in Khan (2020a: 389) that the absence of Armenian loanwords in the Christian NENA dialect of the Urmi region despite the close contact between NENA and Armenian speakers may have been motivated

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by a desire to keep a clearly distinct identity. A similar phenomenon of conscious lexical exclusion in Amazonia has been identified by Epps et al. (2013: 36), Floyd (2013) and Aikhenvald (2003). We have seen, however, that NENA dialects have replicated several features of Armenian phonology and syntax and there was no attempt to exclude them. This was due to the fact that such features were below speakers' "level of awareness" (cf. Silverstein 1981).

The contrast between the lexical exclusion of Armenian loanwords in NENA and the incorporation of numerous Iranian and Turkic loanwords may have related to the different relationships between the various community identities involved. The Armenian Christians in the Urmi region and the NENA-speaking Christians shared the same religion. Many Armenians, moreover, married NENA-speaking Christians. There would have been a particular need, therefore, to preserve NENA group identity in such a situation of intimate social connection and cultural homogeneity between the two groups, in which the boundaries between group identities were particularly under threat. There was, on the other hand, a clear group demarcation between the Jews and their Muslim Iranian-speaking or Turkic-speaking neighbours in their distinct religions. This religious distinction meant that the boundaries between the two groups was not under threat and there was a lesser need to mark communal distinctions by lexical exclusion. The effect of language contact, therefore, is more closely tied to social ideologies and perception of identity than the nature of the contact itself (cf. Hazen 2000: 126; Fought 2010: 285; Friedman & Joseph 2025: 128-131).

25.7 Theoretical models of language contact

In this section, we shall examine the sociolinguistic and psychological processes by which the deep influence of contact languages on NENA may have taken place.

A key factor that brought about contact-induced change in NENA was bilingualism. Matter borrowing and the replication of patterns of a contact language have their source in the competence of NENA speakers in the contact language concerned and their interaction with speakers of these contact languages. This was, in principle, "productive" bilingualism (Edwards 1994; Romaine 1995) whereby NENA speakers could produce with a high degree of proficiency another language. In some situations NENA speakers were multilingual, which would have facilitated transfer of matter and patterns from more than one contact language. In various areas of northern Iraq NENA speakers have competence in both Kurdish and Arabic. In the Urmi region in north-western Iran

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NENA speakers have competence in Turkic, Persian and, in many cases, also Armenian. In the Kordestan and Kermanshah provinces of western Iran NENA speakers in modern times had competence in Kurdish and Persian. As has been remarked above (§z25.3), there was historical layering in such bilingualism or multilingualism. In the Kordestan province of Iran and the surrounding area, for example, NENA speakers had competence in Gorani at an earlier period. On the Mosul plain NENA speakers must have once had competence in Kurdish, but nowadays many NENA speakers in this region are bilinguals in NENA and Arabic but do not speak Kurdish. Furthermore, Christian NENA-speaking communities in the mountainous Ṭyare region are reported to have been largely monolingual, although their dialects exhibits many features of contact-induced change. It must be assumed in such cases either that the communities were bilingual at an earlier period or that the features of contact-induced change diffused from other areas where NENA speakers were bilingual. Such diffusion aross different NENA dialects can be regarded as a form of "dialect contact" exhibiting the same principles of contact-induced changes as languages in contact (cf. the remarks of Friedman & Joseph 2025: 100 regarding Balkan languages). It should also be pointed out that in some areas of the NENA region bilingual speakers codeswitch between NENA and the contact language, sometimes within the same sentence. For example, code-switching between NENA and Arabic has been observed among speakers of NENA dialect on the Mosul plain.

What was the mechanism of contact-induced change in bilingual speakers?

In much of the theoretical literature on language contact it is claimed that in situations of bilingualism there are two main processes of linguistic influence. One of these has been termed 'borrowing' and the other is generally termed 'interference' or 'imposition' (Thomason & Kaufman 1988: 37; Van Coetsem 1988; 1995; 2000; Winford 2005; 2010). In what follows we shall use the term 'imposition', proposed by Van Coetsem, rather than 'interference' for the second process.

Borrowing is the incorporation by the recipient language (RL) of features from the source language (SL) typically without further changes to the RL beyond these incorporated features. This process involves primarily the acquisition by the RL of vocabulary from the SL without any impact on the structure of syntax or the system of phonology. Imposition, on the other hand, primarily involves the transfer of syntactic patterns and phonological features from the SL to the RL and not vocabulary. The distinction between borrowing and imposition is said to be based, crucially, on which of the languages spoken by a bilingual speaker is the "linguistically dominant" one. This is the language in which the speaker is most proficient and most fluent, though not necessarily the native language

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of the speaker (Van Coetsem 1995: 70). Linguistic dominance should be distinguished from social domnance, which refers to the social or political status of a language. The agency of the influence is rooted in the knowledge by the speaker of the linguistically dominant language. When the process involves borrowing by the RL, the RL is the linguistically dominant language and features of the SL are imported into the RL by the agency of the RL. When the process involves imposition, the SL is the linguistically dominant language and features are transferred to the RL by the agency of the SL.

One common situation in which imposition occurs is where there is a language shift by speakers and speakers of the language that is for them linguistically dominant (i.e., the SL) acquire through imperfect learning a second language (i.e., the RL), which is less dominant. The dominant SL in such situations is termed the substrate language and the less dominant RL the superstrate language. In the process of this imperfect learning syntactic structures and the phonological system of the dominant SL are said to be imposed by speakers on the acquired language, without necessarily a transfer of vocabulary from the SL.

This is not, however, the only situation in which imposition may occur. Imposition may occur through the agency of a linguistically dominant language in a bilingual situation where this dominant language is not a substrate in a language shift to a less dominant language. This is typically the case where the RL is a maintained ancestral language of a small community and the dominant SL that has the agency is an external language of the wider society that exerts cultural pressure on the smaller community. There is a sharing of patterns across the languages in contact. In such cases of imposition it has, indeed, been claimed that bilingual speakers organise their communication in both languages in a single linguistic system (Matras 2010). Such a situation lies behind the development of a linguistic area (Sprachbund), in which two or more languages have become structurally similar, as is the case with the languages in the Balkans (Joseph 1983; 2010; Friedman & Joseph 2025) and the Indo-Aryan and Dravidian languages in India (Emeneau 1956; 1980). Ross (2003: 183) points out that that in almost all case studies of linguistic areas there is a one-sided process whereby one language, in our terms the RL, adopts the structures of another, in our terms the SL. This, therefore, is imposition through SL-agency. Imposition and the development of linguistic areas are facilitated by open and flexible attitudes towards community boundaries and identity (Matras 2010: 72).

We have seen in our study that NENA dialects have acquired a wide range of syntactic and morphosyntactic patterns from contact languages, and also acquired features of the phonological systems of contact languages. Within the model described above, this would be regarded as the result of the imposition

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of features from SLs that are linguistically dominant in a bilingual/multilingual speech situation onto NENA. According to the model described above, one way this situation could have come about would have been through a language shift of speakers of a contact language to NENA, with a period of imperfect learning. There are reports that some Kurdish-speaking Muslims converted to Christianity at earlier periods. Such Kurdish-speaking converts would have learnt to speak Christian NENA dialects (Chyet 1995: 223). It is not clear, however, how many such conversions there were and they are unlikely to have been on a scale that would have brought about the extensive contact-induced changes in syntax and phonology in NENA. Moreover, we are not aware of any reports of Kurdish-speaking Muslims converting to Judaism and learning to speak Jewish NENA dialects. There is evidence, however, of Christian and Jewish NENA speakers converting to Islam and, consequently, shifting to speaking Kurdish (Soane 1912: 186; Chyet 1995: 223). In the region of Urmi in north-western Iran Armenians in some cases married NENA-speaking Christians. This would have entailed the learning of Christian NENA by the Armenian spouses. Again, however, it appears that this was not of sufficient scale to bring about contact-induced change through imperfect learning that would have diffused to the whole NENA-speaking community.

Bilingual speakers of NENA and Kurdish typically had a native or near native competence of Kurdish (Chyet 1995: 229; Khan & Mohammadirad 2024b: 530). This arose from being bilingual from an early age. NENA speakers, therefore, would have acquired Kurdish long before the "critical threshold'' of age for perfect language acquisition (Lenneberg 1967; Labov 1972; Trudgill 2010: 310). Some NENA speakers had similar native levels of competence in other contact languages that had an impact on NENA. If NENA speakers had native-speaker competence in both NENA and a contact language, the linguistic dominance of the contact language would not have been due to it being a substrate in a language shift situation but rather due to the fact that the contact language was the language of the dominant wider society and exerted cultural and social pressure on the smaller NENA-speaking communities. As a result, the linguistically dominant contact language had the agency of change. This would have resulted in the imposition of syntactic and phonological features of the contact language on NENA. This scenario is certainly likely to have applied to the Iranian contact languages in NENA area, viz. Kurdish and Gorani.

A possible complicating issue with regard to this proposed model is the presence of a large number of Iranian loanwords in NENA. As remarked, loanwords are typically transferred to a RL through a process of borrowing in which the

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RL is the linguistically dominant language. Loanwords are not expected in a process of imposition through the agency of a linguistically dominant SL. One way of explaining this may be to regard all Iranian features in NENA to have been transferred by a process of borrowing through RL agency. It would have to be assumed that due to the proficiency of the NENA speakers in Iranian, the borrowing process went beyond the transfer of vocabulary and included also syntax and phonology. An analogous case of an ancestral language undergoing extensive influence in lexicon and grammatical structure from a politically dominant external language that has been studied in the literature is Asia Minor Greek (Dawkins 1916). Thomason & Kaufman (1988: 45, 215) regard this to be a case of borrowing by the Greek dialects, which was so intense that it included all levels of language. Similarly Friedman & Joseph (2025: 125-127) term replication of lexicon and structural patterns from one language to another in the Balkan Sprachbund as borrowing. Winford (2005: 402-9; 2010: 181), on the other hand, argues that such a wholesale transfer of features must have taken place through the process of imposition by Turkish-dominant bilinguals, i.e., by SL agentivity. This would explain, he argues, why the lexical loans include many items of basic vocabulary, which is 'not normally associated with borrowing alone'. Winford (2005: 408), nevertheless, contends that the process that brought about the changes in Asia Minor Greek involved both types of agency with Greek-dominant bilinguals implementing RL agency, and Turkish-dominant bilinguals implementing SL agency. He apparently means that much of the lexical borrowing resulted from RL agency, though he does not state this explicitly.

If we apply Winford's model for Asian Minor Greek to NENA, we would have to assume that the process that brought about the contact-induced changes in NENA involved both NENA-dominant bilinguals implementing RL agency, and Iranian-dominant bilinguals implementing SL agency. This would mean, in effect, that there was a fine balance and tension between the dominance of the two languages within the NENA communities. Such a scenario could perhaps have arisen in a situation in which some components of the communities (e.g., women and children) were dominant in NENA and other components (e.g., adult men) were dominant in Iranian. Another possibility would be to invoke the notion of "reverse interference" (Friedman & Joseph 2025: 101-109), whereby a dominant RL can acquire non-lexical features, in particular phonological features, from a non-dominant SL.

A further complicating factor is the role of Armenian as a source for replicated syntactic structures and phonology in NENA dialects. Unlike Kurdish or Gorani, Armenian was not a politically dominant language that would have exerted social and cultural pressure on NENA. NENA speakers in Armenian-speaking ar-

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eas had competence in Armenian. The motivation for such bilingualism was not the political, social or cultural dominance of Armenian but rather the desire to communicate with Armenian neighbours. It is unlikely, moreover, that the Armenian spoken by NENA speakers would have been more dominant in terms of competence than NENA. A model based on linguistic dominance, therefore, is unsatisfactory to explain the replication of Armenian features in NENA, unless these are regarded as cases of "reverse interference" .

Rather than attributing syntactic or phonological replication in NENA of features in contact languages to the linguistic dominance of the contact languages, or to complicated mixtures of RL and SL dominance within NENA-speaking communities, or to language shift, a more satisfactory model is that of Matras (Matras 2009; 2010), who regards contact-induced change as a result of bilingual speakers treating the two languages as a single system rather than a result of the prestige of the donor language or different levels of dominance the RL and SL. According to Matras, contact-induced change is triggered in bilingual speakers by the language-processing mechanism and the challenge to manage the selection of structures within a complex repertoire of linguistic structures across two languages. This results in the convergence of structures and lexicon to facilitate the management of the bilingual repertoire. Convergence of structures also facilitated illocutionary goals, such as the expression of focus (cf., for example, the preposing of focused adjectives in NENA dialects, see §11.1.8, 125). Such a model could explain not only replication in NENA of patterns from Armenian but also the existence of both replicated patterns and massive loaning of lexicon from other contact languages without having to appeal to complicated mixtures of borrowing and imposition. The case of Armenian, whose lexicon, as we have seen, appears to have been consciously excluded from NENA, indicates that convergence of patterns within a bilingual repertoire of patterns must have been below the "level of awareness". The resulting convergence became entrenched in NENA, since it was a feature of the speech of the majority of speakers in the NENA speech communities. This entrenchment was reinforced by the fact that the contact and convergence existed over many centuries. Since the majority of speakers of Iranian languages or Turkic were not bilingual in NENA, these languages did not, in principle, converge with NENA. The existence of a few NENA loanwords in Kurdish (Chyet 1995) may have been the result of conversions of NENA-speaking Christians and Jews to Islam and their shift to Kurdish.

The apparent convergence of Armenian dialects in the Urmi area with NENA in a few features, may have been due to a large proportion of the Armenian speakers being bilingual in NENA in this region, which would have resulted in the convergence with NENA becoming entrenched in these Armenian dialects.

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It has been observed above (§25.3) that some NENA dialects have converged to a greater degree with contact languages than others. This applies to the Jewish Trans-Zab dialects, which exhibit a more advanced convergence with the contact Iranian languages than is the case with the Christian dialects of the same region. This could be explained by the fact that the Jewish speakers of the Trans-Zab dialects had a more intense contact with Iranian speakers, involving more frequent interaction, than was the case with Christian NENA speakers. The Jews were traditionally small peddlers, who had extensive interaction with Iranian-speaking Muslims. Moreover, until the foundation of large towns such as Sanandaj and Sulemaniyya, they typically lived in small village communities.

The common factor that conditioned convergence of NENA with languages in contact, therefore, was bilingualism or multilingualism motivated by a need of NENA speakers to communicate with their neighbours whilst maintaining their heritage language as an emblem of communal identity, with separate identity-marking codes for Christians and Jews. The linguistic convergence was licenced by the fact that the heritage linguistic code, although highly assimilated in patterns and lexicon to contact languages and so hybrid in form, was maintained as an identity marker. Many other aspects of culture of the NENA-speaking communities also converged with those of the speakers of contact languages, such as clothing, food, marriage customs, songs and folklore (Chyet 1995; Khan et al. 2022b). The key anchors of identity were the maintenance of the core of a distinct heritage language and distinct religion. These distinct markers, however, adapted to the linguistic and cultural environment, by a process of linguistic and cultural ecology (cf. Mufwene 2001) and accommodation (Trudgill 1986). The language adapted in the way we have described. Some aspects of the practice of religion adapted to the environment, e.g., in the adoption of local musical culture and clothing associated with religious rituals. Aside from these anchors of identity, the culture of the NENA-speaking Christians and Jews exhibited extensive assimilation to the environment. This adaptive ecology of language and culture facilitated the survival of these vulnerable minority communities over millennia.

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